

Spanish, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one commute at a time

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This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they
are written.

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Preface

This book teaches Spanish one word at a time — and it teaches each word by taking it apart. A huge fraction of Spanish vocabulary is not arbitrary: it is Latin, lightly worn by a thousand years of use, and English borrowed from the same Latin so often that the two languages are full of hidden cousins. So no word here is a fresh thing to memorize. *gracias* arrives next to *grace*, *gratitude*, *gratuity*, *ingrate*, and *congratulate* — a family you have owned your whole life. The bet is simple and, as far as we can tell, how the brain actually works: you learn the new by welding it to the known.

Three things follow from that, and shape every lesson:

- **One word per lesson, gone deep.** Not “the ten greetings” — *hola* is a lesson, *buenos días* is a lesson. A few minutes each, the size of a single errand or commute.
- **The widest honest web of cousins.** Every word reaches for all the English relatives it can *truthfully* claim — because the more live connections a word has, the more places it sticks. False cousins are flagged, not smuggled in.
- **The reason, not the rule.** Why is it *buenos días*, plural? Because it is the fossil of a blessing, “*may God give you good days.*” We learn the culture and the idiom hiding inside the grammar — the things Spanish 101 skips.

How to use this book

Every numbered section is one word, or one small phrase, and takes a few minutes — the length of a queue, an errand, or the walk to the bus. Read them in order the first time through: each section stands on the ones before it, and nothing is used before it has been taught. After that the book becomes reference, and you can open it anywhere.

Say the Spanish out loud wherever you can. The prompts under *Your turn* are written to be spoken, and saying a word is most of what makes it stay. The questions under *Before you move on* carry their own answers in brackets: cover them, answer from memory, then look.

Nothing here is gated behind pronunciation. Each lesson names the one or two sounds its own word needs, exactly where they are needed. The whole system is gathered in a reference at the back of the book — somewhere to look things up when you are curious, never a chapter to sit through first.

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Chapter 1

Hola and Buenos Días

Modes: 🎧 voice (7) 📞 Hands-free start: all 7 lessons.

***By the end of this chapter:** I can greet someone in Spanish, say how I am, and wish them a good day.*

*A short doorway greeting: **hola**, an answer to how you are, and **buenos días** on the way in.*

1.1 hola — hello

The very first word, and the easiest to say — but there’s already one trap hiding in it, and one small mystery.

Sounds you’ll need

- **silent-h** — the **h** is **silent**. *hola* is said *OH-la*, never *HOH-la*. The letter is written but makes no sound at all. This is true of every Spanish *h* you’ll ever meet. → pronunciation reference
- **vowel-o**, **vowel-a** — two pure vowels: *OH*, *AH*. No glide, no drift.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hola — hello / hi.

This one is a genuine mystery, and honesty matters more than a tidy story: *hola*’s origin is **not settled**. It’s an old interjection — a hailing call — and that’s about as far as the evidence firmly goes. You’ll see it confidently linked to English *hello*, or to Arabic *wallāh* (“by God”), or

to a nautical shout. Treat all of those as **folk etymology**: plausible-sounding, not established.

In particular, the resemblance to English *hello* is a **false friend**.

English *hello* comes from a Germanic hailing root (*hail, holler, hollo*) — a completely different family from anything Spanish. The two words sound alike by pure coincidence, not shared ancestry.

Why flag this so hard? Because the whole method of this book is building on real family resemblances between Spanish and English. A *fake* one is worse than none — it teaches a connection your brain then has to unlearn. So: enjoy *hola*, but don't file it next to *hello* in your head. They're strangers who happen to look alike.

Why it's said this way

hola is **informal**. It's the "hi" you'd say to a friend, a kid, a shopkeeper you know. It carries no time of day and no deference — which is exactly why, in more formal or first-meeting situations, Spanish speakers reach past it for *buenos días* and its siblings (the next lessons). Knowing *when not* to use *hola* is as much the lesson as the word itself.

Note the written form: an exclamation gets an **upside-down mark** at the front — *¡hola!* — so you know the tone before you start reading it aloud.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "hola" — *OH-la*, silent h
- "¡hola!" to an imagined friend — light, informal

Before you move on

Two things to lock in: what sound does the *h* make? (None.) And is *hola* actually related to English *hello*? (No — a coincidence, a false friend.)

1.2 bien — “well,” a whole answer in one word

You have *hola*. Now the word that carries half of everyday small talk: *bien*. It answers “how are you,” it agrees to a plan, it stands completely on its own — and it opens a family of English words you already use.

What to know first

- *hola* — your first word; *bien* is what you say back when someone asks how you are.

Sounds you’ll need

- diphthong-**ie** — **ie** is a quick *YEH*: *bien* is said *byen*, one syllable. → reference
- **v-b** — the **b** is soft, halfway to a *v*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

bien — “well.” Root: Latin **bene** (“well”). That *bene* is the piece hiding in a shelf of English words, every one about something being *good* or *well*:

- **benefit** — literally “to do **well**” (*bene* + *facere*).
- **benevolent** — “wishing **well**” (*bene* + *volens*).
- **benediction** — “speaking **well**,” a blessing (*bene* + *dicere*).
- **benefactor**, **beneficial**, **benign**.

So *bien* is the Spanish member of the *bene*- family you’ve owned in English your whole life.

Using it on its own. This is the useful part: *bien* is a complete answer.

- “¿Cómo estás?” (how are you?) → “**Bien.**” — “Well.” / “I’m good.” Done.
- As agreement, when someone suggests something → “**Bien.**” — “Okay / fine.”

The adjective sibling: *bueno* / *buena*

bien is an **adverb** — it describes *how* something is done (“you speak *well*”). When you want the **adjective** — to describe a *thing* as “good” — Spanish uses **bueno** (for a masculine word) or **buena** (for a feminine word). These come from Latin **bonus** (“good”), *bene*’s sibling: Latin split the idea of “good” into an adverb (*bene*) and an adjective (*bonus*), and Spanish kept both. The Latin-descended English cousins of *bueno* are *bonus*, *bonanza*, and *bounty*.

English does the exact same split: *well* (adverb) vs. *good* (adjective) — “you did *well*” but “a *good* job.” English’s pair happens to be Germanic, not Latin, so *well*/*good* aren’t blood cousins of *bien*/*bueno* — but the *structure* is identical, and that parallel is your handle: **bien = well, bueno/buena = good.**

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “bien” as the answer to “how are you”
- “bueno” then “buena” — the adjective, masculine then feminine

Before you move on

Which is the adverb (“well”) and which is the adjective (“good”) (*bien* / *bueno–buena*.) And name an English *bene-* cousin of *bien*. (benefit, benevolent, benediction...)

1.3 el and la — “the,” and the gender it carries

Before your first noun, meet two of the smallest, most frequent words in Spanish: *el* and *la*. Both mean “the.” Your job here is simply to recognize the pair and connect each form to its label.

What to know first

- *bien* / *bueno* — you saw *bueno* change to *buena*; this lesson explains the gender that made it happen.

Sounds you'll need

- vowel-**e**, vowel-**a** — two clean vowels: *el* (*ehl*), *la* (*lah*). → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el — “the” (masculine). **la** — “the” (feminine). English has one word, “the”; Spanish makes this two-way distinction.

Where they come from. Both are worn-down Latin **demonstratives** — words that meant “**that one (over there)**”:

- **el** ← Latin **ille** (“that one,” masculine).
- **la** ← Latin **illa** (“that one,” feminine).

Over centuries the pointing force faded and the initial *i*- dropped: *ille* → *el*, *illa* → *la*. What began as “that one” softened into a plain “the.” The same *ille/illa* spread across the whole family — French *le/la*, Italian *il/la* — every Romance “the” is eroded Latin “that.”

The twin thread. Those *same* Latin words, *ille/illa*, also became Spanish **él** (“he”) and **ella** (“she”). So the article *el* (“the”) and the pronoun *él* (“he”) are twins from one Latin parent — told apart only by the accent. (English “the,” by contrast, is Germanic and *unrelated* — a shared job, not a shared root.)

What you've built

el and *la* are **articles**: little words that mark “the.” Keep them apart from their accented relatives *él* and *ella*, the pronouns “he” and “she.” The next micro-lesson explains why Spanish needs two article forms.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “el” then “la” — the two “the”s
- which article goes with a masculine noun? with a feminine one?

Before you move on

Which form is labelled masculine? (*el*.) Which is labelled feminine? (*la*.) Both come from Latin words meaning what? (“That one” — *ille* / *illa*.)

1.4 Grammatical gender — the two noun classes behind *el* and *la*

You know that *el* and *la* both mean “the.” Now give their two labels: *el* is masculine; *la* is feminine.

What to know first

- *el* / *la* — the two definite articles.

Grammar Lens: grammatical gender

Every Spanish noun belongs to one of two **grammatical classes**, traditionally called masculine and feminine. This is not a claim about biological sex. It is a matching system: a masculine noun uses *el*; a feminine noun uses *la*.

Latin had masculine, feminine, and neuter classes. Spanish reduced that three-way system to two, with most old neuter nouns joining the masculine class. The word *gender* itself comes through Latin *genus*, “kind” or “class.”

You cannot always predict a noun’s class from its ending. Learn each new noun with its article, as one small unit: *el* + *noun* or *la* + *noun*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the article for a noun labelled masculine
- the article for a noun labelled feminine
- what grammatical gender classifies — nouns, not people

Before you move on

How many noun classes did Latin have? (Three.) How many does Spanish keep? (Two.) What should travel with every new noun you learn? (Its article, *el* or *la*.)

1.5 día — your first noun

You just learned how Spanish tags gender with *el* / *la*. Now put it to work on your very first noun — *día*, “day.”

What to know first

- *el* / *la* — grammatical gender and the two “the”s; *día* is where you apply them.

Sounds you’ll need

- **accent-i** — the accent sits on the **í**: *día* is *DEE-a*, two beats. → reference
- **d-soft** — the **d** between vowels is soft, toward the *th* in *this*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el día — “the day.” Root: Latin **dies** (“day”). The family fans across English, mostly through French:

- **diary**, **diurnal** (“of the day”).
- **journal**, **journey** — French *jour*, “a day” (a *journey* was once “a day’s travel”).
- **quodidian** (“every-day”), **meridian** (“mid-day”), and *dismal* (*dies mali*, “evil days”).

Its two tags: gender and number

You already know gender from the last lesson; here’s how *día* wears it. **Gender.** *día* is **masculine** — *el día* — which is a small surprise, because it ends in *-a*, the ending that usually signals feminine. Why the exception? Because Latin *dies* was masculine, and *día* inherited

that gender whole, spelling be damned. (This is exactly why gender must be learned *with* the word, not guessed from the ending — and it’s the first of several “-a-but-masculine” nouns you’ll meet.)

Number. One rule for now: a noun ending in a vowel adds **-s**. *día* → *días* (“days”). (Consonant endings take *-es* — later.)

Grammar Lens: why the gender matters next

Gender isn’t a passive label — it *forces* the words around the noun to match. The very next lesson, *buenos días*, turns *bueno* (“good”) into *buenos* precisely because *día* is masculine and plural. So the gender you just attached to *día* is about to earn its keep.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “el día” — with its masculine “the”
- “días” — plural, vowel + *-s*
- is *día* masculine or feminine, and why? (masculine — from Latin *dies*, despite the *-a*)

Before you move on

Which “the” goes with *día*, and why? (*el* — masculine, inherited from Latin *dies*, despite the *-a* ending.) How do you make it plural? (*días* — vowel + *-s*.)

1.6 buenos días — the greeting you say before noon

You can already greet someone at any hour with *hola*. Now the one you use in the morning — the greeting everyone knows.

What to know first

- *día* — the word *day*, which you have already met.

Sounds you'll need

- **diphthong-ue** — **ue** is a quick *WEH*: *bueno* is *BWEH-no*.
- **accent-i** — *días* keeps its stress on the *í*: *DEE-as*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

buenos días is, word for word, “**good days**” — plural, and nobody knows quite why the plural stuck. Spanish says it in the plural and always has.

Take it whole. It is one thing you say, not two things you assemble: *buenos días*, said as a single run, the way English says *good morning* without stopping to think about *good* or *morning*.

The shape of it — why *buenos* and not *bueno* — is a real rule, and a useful one. It is also not the rule you need in order to say hello before lunch. It comes later, once you have enough words for it to be worth explaining.

Why it's said this way

So why “good **days**,” plural at all? Because *buenos días* is a **fossil** — the worn-down stub of a blessing: “**Buenos días os dé Dios,**” “*may God give you good days.*” You weren’t wishing one good morning; you were asking heaven for many good days ahead. The plural is the last bone of that prayer — and it’s why *buenos días* feels warm and a little formal, where *hola* is casual. It is, almost literally, a small *benediction* (the *bien* lesson’s word). (*A widely-accepted account; exact history debated.*)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- build it slowly — “bueno” ... “días” ... “buenos días”
- “hola, buenos días” — casual + warm, stacked
- why is it *buenos*, not *bueno*? (out loud, in your own words)

Before you move on

Two things: why is it *buenos* and not *bueno*? (Agreement — *días* is masculine plural.) And what blessing was *buenos días* shortened from? (“May God give you good days.”)

1.7 Practice — hola and buenos días

End of the chapter. No new words — just the four you have, turned over until they’re automatic.

What you’ve built

In four short lessons you went from nothing to two full greetings and the first two rules of Spanish grammar:

- **hola** — the casual “hi.”
- **bien** — “well/good,” a complete answer on its own; and its adjective sibling **bueno** / **buena**.
- **día** → **días** — a noun, and the plural rule (vowel + -s).
- **buenos días** — assembled from *bueno* + *días*, with **agreement** turning *bueno* into *buenos* to match.

Your turn

Say each out loud; don’t just read.

Say these aloud:

- greet a friend casually — *hola*
- greet someone warmly in the morning — *buenos días*
- stack them — *hola, buenos días*
- answer “how are you” with one word — *bien*
- the four shapes of “good” — *bueno, buena, buenos, buenas* — and for each, is it masculine/feminine, singular/plural?

Twice through: Build *buenos días* from scratch, out loud: *bueno* → agree with masculine-plural *días* → *buenos días*. Do it until the “why” feels obvious, not memorized.

Before you move on

You can now greet two ways and give a one-word positive answer. The very next question is the one that opens a real conversation: when *someone else* says *buenos días* to you — **what do you say back?** That’s the whole next chapter, and it’s where these words start turning into an exchange.

Chapter 2

The Rest of the Greetings

Modes: 🗣️ voice (6) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 6 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can greet someone correctly at any hour — morning, afternoon or night — and say why the greeting changes shape.

The same greeting exchange run three times across the day, choosing the right form for each hour.

2.1 tarde — “afternoon,” and the “late” hiding inside it

You built *buenos días*. The afternoon greeting is coming, but first its key word on its own — *tarde* — and it’s secretly a word you already know from English.

What to know first

- buenos días — you’ll pair *tarde* with *buena* the same way you paired *días* with *bueno*.

Sounds you’ll need

- Regular stress: *TAR-de* — ends in a vowel, so the stress falls on the second-to-last syllable. → reference

la tarde (feminine) — “afternoon.” Root: Latin **tardus** — which did *not* mean afternoon. It meant “**slow, late.**” And *that* is the meaning English kept:

- **tardy** — late.
- **retard** — to slow down (literally “to make late”).
- **tardigrade** — “slow-stepper,” the real name of the little water-bear that plods under a microscope.

How did “late” become “afternoon”? Naturally — the afternoon *is* the late part of the day, the day growing old. Spanish took the Latin word for “late” and let it drift to name the lateness itself. Say *tarde* and you’re calling it “the late hours.”

Its gender: *tarde* is **feminine** — *la tarde*, not *el tarde*. (Contrast *el día* from the last lesson: your first masculine and feminine nouns, side by side.) Learn each noun *with* its *el/la*, because gender isn’t reliably guessable — and it will decide the shape of every word that describes the noun, starting next lesson.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “tarde” — *TAR-de*
- “tarde” then English “tardy” — hear the shared root
- “tardes” — plural, add *-s* (vowel ending), just like *día* → *días*

Before you move on

What did Latin *tardus* originally mean, before “afternoon”? (Slow, late — as in *tardy*, *retard*.) And how do you make *tarde* plural? (*tardes* — vowel + *-s*.)

2.2 buenas tardes — assembled, and now the *feminine* side of agreement

Same move as *buenos días*: take “good” and “afternoon” and snap them together. But watch the ending — this time it comes out *buenas*, and that difference teaches you the other half of the agreement rule.

What to know first

- bien / bueno — the adjective *bueno* and its four shapes.
- tarde — the noun *tardes*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

buenas tardes = **buena** (“good”) + **tardes** (“afternoons”) = literally “good afternoons.”

Why it’s said this way

Buenos días in the morning; **buenas tardes** in the afternoon. The ending changes, and there is a reason for it — the same reason that comes later, with the rest of the pattern. For now: two greetings, two shapes, both said whole.

Why it’s said this way

Same fossil blessing as the morning greeting: *buenas tardes* is short for “*Buenas tardes os dé Dios.*” One cultural note on timing — *tardes* runs from after the midday meal until it’s genuinely dark, which in much of the Spanish-speaking world is late. Spanish follows the daylight, not the clock; there’s no fixed “12:00 = afternoon” line.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*buenas tardes*” — *BWEH-nas TAR-des*
- “*buenos días*” then “*buenas tardes*” — hear the *o* flip to *a*
- why *buenas* and not *buenos*? (out loud, your own words)

Before you move on

Why is it *buenas tardes* but *buenos días*? (*tarde* is feminine, *día* is masculine — the adjective agrees with each.)

2.3 noche — “night,” and a Latin sound-change you can now spot

The last time-of-day word before the evening greeting. *noche* — “night” — and it shows off a spelling pattern that will help you decode dozens of Spanish words later.

What to know first

- *tarde* — same build ahead: word first, then *buenas* + it.

Sounds you’ll need

- **soft-c** — the **ch** in *noche* is the *ch* of English *church*: *NO-cheh*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la noche (feminine) — “night / evening.” Root: Latin **nox**, stem **noct-** — which was itself *feminine* in Latin, and *la noche* inherited that gender straight down (just as *el día* inherited its masculine from Latin). That *noct-* runs all through English:

- **nocturnal** — active at night.
- **nocturne** — a piece of night-music.
- **equinox** — *equi* (“equal”) + *nox*, the day when night and day are equal length.

A pattern worth banking: Latin *noctem* → Spanish *noche*. The Latin **-ct-** softened into Spanish **-ch-**. This happened again and again: *factum* → *hecho* (“done”), *lactem* → *leche* (“milk”), *octo* → *ocho* (“eight”). Once you know *-ct-* → *-ch-*, you can often guess the Latin root (and its English cousins) behind a Spanish *-ch-* word on sight.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “noche” — *NO-cheh*
- “noche” then “nocturnal” then “equinox”

- “noches” — plural, vowel + -s

Before you move on

What English word is *equi-* + *noche*’s root? (*Equinox*, “equal night.”) And what Latin sound did the *-ch-* in *noche* come from? (*-ct-*, as in *noctem* → *noche*.)

2.4 buenas noches — good evening *and* good night

The fourth greeting, assembled the way you now expect — and it has one quirk the others don’t: it works both coming and going.

What to know first

- buenas tardes — feminine agreement (*buenas*); *noche* is feminine too, so the same shape applies.
- noche — the noun *noches*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

buenas noches = **buena** (“good”) + **noches** (“nights”). *noche* is **feminine** (*la noche*), plural here, so — exactly like *tardes* — the adjective is **buenas**. No new rule; you’re now just *fluent* in the agreement you learned two lessons ago: masculine *días* → *buenos*, feminine *tardes/noches* → *buenas*.

Why it’s said this way

The same amputated blessing (“*Buenas noches os dé Dios*”) — but with a twist. *buenas noches* is both a **greeting** and a **farewell**:

- Arriving at a dinner at 9pm → *buenas noches* (“good evening”).
- Leaving that same dinner at midnight → *buenas noches* (“goodnight”).

English splits these into two phrases; Spanish uses one and lets context tell you the direction. The blessing doesn’t care which way you’re going — you’re wishing good hours either way.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “buenas noches” arriving somewhere
- “buenas noches” leaving somewhere
- all four times of day — “buenos días, buenas tardes, buenas noches” — and notice which take *buenos* vs *buenas* and why

Before you move on

What’s unusual about when you can use *buenas noches*? (Both hello and goodbye.) And why *buenas*, not *buenos*? (*noche* is feminine.)

2.5 buenos or buenas — the rule you have been using all along

Say all three greetings, in order through the day: *buenos días*, *buenas tardes*, *buenas noches*.

You have been saying them for two chapters without being told why the first one differs. Now it is worth knowing.

What to know first

Two things you already have:

- Every Spanish noun is **masculine or feminine**. *Día* is masculine; *tarde* and *noche* are feminine.
- Adding **-s** makes a noun plural: *días*, *tardes*, *noches*.

Grammar Lens: the describing word copies the noun

In Spanish a describing word **copies** the noun it sits next to — it matches both the masculine-or-feminine and the one-or-many. *Bueno* is the describing word in all three greetings. It copies:

- *días* is masculine and plural, so *bueno* becomes **buenos**.
- *tardes* is feminine and plural, so *bueno* becomes **buenas**.

- *noches* is feminine and plural, so again **buenas**.

That is the whole rule. One word changing its last letter to agree with the word beside it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The **-o** and the **-a** are old. Latin marked masculine with *-us* and feminine with *-a*: *bonus* and *bona*, “good.” Spanish wore *bonus* down to *bueno* and kept *bona* as *buena*, and the two endings have been doing this same job for two thousand years.

English lost this entirely. *Good* is *good*, whatever it sits beside.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “buenos días” — and say why it is *buenos*: *días* is masculine.
- “buenas tardes” — and why *buenas*: *tardes* is feminine.
- all three in order, morning to night.

Before you move on

Why *buenos días* but *buenas tardes*? (*Día* is masculine, *tarde* is feminine, and the describing word copies the noun.) Which Latin endings are hiding in *-o* and *-a*? (*-us* and *-a*.) Does English do this? (No — *good* never changes.)

2.6 Practice — the four greetings

You can now greet at any hour of the day. Let’s make the choice — and the grammar behind it — automatic.

What you’ve built

- **hola** — any time, casual.
- **buenos días** — morning (*días* masculine → *buenos*).
- **buenas tardes** — afternoon (*tarde* feminine → *buenas*).

- **buenas noches** — evening *and* goodnight (*noche* feminine → *buenas*).

The one grammar thread running through all of them: **agreement**. The “good” word copies the gender of the time-of-day word. That’s why it’s *buenos días* but *buenas tardes* and *buenas noches*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- greet for the actual current time of day, correctly
- all three “buenos/buenas” greetings in a row; for each, say whether the noun is masculine or feminine and why the ending fits
- “hola, buenas tardes” — casual + timed, stacked

Twice through: Run morning → afternoon → night, out loud, without hesitating on *buenos* vs *buenas*.

Before you move on

Quick: is it *buenos* or *buenas* noches, and why? (*buenas* — *noche* is feminine.) Next chapter, someone finally greets *you* back — and you learn to say your name and ask for theirs.

Chapter 3

Un and Una — the Other Article

Modes: 🗣️ voice (3) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say a day, an afternoon and a night, choosing the article by the noun's gender.

un is the number one, and English a is the same word worn down.

3.1 un — “a,” and the number hiding in it

How do you say “the day”? (*El día*.) Which word is doing the work of *the*? (*El*.)

Grammar Lens: the other article

El día is **the** day — a particular one, the one we both know about. For **a** day, any day, not one we have settled on, Spanish swaps the article:

un día — *a day*.

That is the second article, and Spanish has only these two kinds. *El* points at something known; **un** does not. Like *el*, it carries the noun's gender — so *un* is the masculine one, and its partner is coming in the next lesson.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Here is the part worth keeping.

Un is the number one. Latin *ūnus*, “one”, and Spanish never really separated the two — *un día* is *a day* and *one day* at once, and context decides which you meant.

English did exactly the same thing and hid it better. Our *a* and *an* are the word **one**, worn down over centuries of being unstressed. That is why *an hour* and *one hour* start with the same sound, and why *a* feels like almost nothing when you say it: it has been eroded from a whole number down to a single vowel. So the two languages made the same move. Spanish just left the seam visible.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “el día” then “un día” — the known one, then any one
- “un día”, and hear the number *one* still sitting in it

Before you move on

How do you say “a day”? (**Un día.**) What is the difference between *el* and *un*? (*El* points at something known; *un* does not.) And what number is *un*? (**One** — and English *a* is the same word.) Next: the feminine partner.

3.2 una — the feminine one

Say “a day.” (*Un día.*) And what is the word for “the afternoon”? (*La tarde.*)

Grammar Lens: the partner

Tarde and *noche* are feminine, so they take the feminine article:

una tarde — *an afternoon*. **una noche** — *a night*.

You now have both, and they behave exactly as *el* and *la* do — the article takes the gender of the noun standing next to it. Nothing new

is being asked of you; the rule you learned for *el* and *la* simply applies again.

	masculine	feminine
the	<i>el</i> día	<i>la</i> tarde
a	un día	una tarde

This table is allowed here because every box in it is something you can already say.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

One detail, because it runs against what you might expect.

Una is not *un* with something added. It is the other way round: Latin had *ūnus* and *ūna*, and **una kept the whole word while un lost a syllable.**

That is the ordinary direction of travel. The forms said most often wear down fastest, and *un* — standing in front of masculine nouns, which are the default for anything unspecified — got said more.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “un día, una tarde, una noche”
- each noun twice — once with *the*, once with *a*

Before you move on

Say “a night.” (**Una noche.**) Which article goes with *día*, and why? (**Un** — *día* is masculine.) And which of the pair is the worn-down one? (**Un** — *una* kept the whole Latin word.)

3.3 Review — the four little words

Nothing new here. Say “the day,” then “a day.”

What you've built

Four words, and they cover every noun you will ever meet in this book:

- **el** · **la** — *the*, pointing at something we both know.
- **un** · **una** — *a*, pointing at no one in particular.

Two jobs, two genders, and the gender is never the article's own — it is borrowed from the noun beside it, exactly as *bueno* borrowed it from *día*.

That is one rule doing all four jobs, and you have now seen it three times: on the greeting, on the definite article, and here.

Your turn

- *Say it*: “el día, un día” · “la tarde, una tarde” · “la noche, una noche”

Twice through: Until the article arrives with the noun rather than after it.

Before you move on

Name all four articles. (*El, la, un, una.*) Which two point at something known? (*El* and *la.*) And where does an article's gender come from? (**The noun beside it** — never from itself.)

Chapter 4

Saying Your Name

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say my own name in Spanish.

Saying Your Name — the chapter run end to end.

4.1 me — your first pronoun, and a *real* English twin

A tiny word doing big work. *me* is your first **pronoun** — and unlike *hola*, its English look-alike is the real thing: a true cousin, not a coincidence.

Sounds you'll need

- vowel-e — one clean syllable, *meh* (the *e* of *bed*).

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

me — “me / myself.” Root: Latin **me** (the object form of *ego*, “I”). Here’s the satisfying part: English **me** is a **genuine cousin**, not a false friend. Spanish *me* comes from Latin *me*; English *me* comes from Proto-Germanic — but both trace back to the *same* ancient ancestor (the Proto-Indo-European root *me-*, “me”). So do English **my** and **mine**. This is the opposite of the *hola/hello* trap you saw earlier: here the resemblance is real, and you can lean on it hard. Spanish *me* = English *me*, all the way down.

Grammar Lens: what a pronoun is

A **pronoun** is a stand-in word that points to a person or thing without naming them — *I, you, he, me, it*. *me* specifically is an **object** pronoun: it marks the person the action lands on (“call *me*”, “give *me*”). In Spanish it usually sits **right before the verb** — you’ll see it next lesson in *me llamo*, literally “myself I-call.” For now, just hold *me* = “me / myself.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “me” — *meh*
- “me” then English “me”, “my”, “mine” — all one family

Before you move on

Is Spanish *me* a true cousin of English *me*, or a coincidence like *hola/hello*? (A true cousin — both from the same ancient root.) What part of speech is it? (A pronoun.)

4.2 llamo — “I call,” from a root that shouts

The verb inside “my name is.” On its own it means “to call” — and its Latin root literally means *to shout*, which is why it echoes through a whole family of English words.

What to know first

- me — you’ll bolt *me* onto *llamo* next lesson.

Sounds you’ll need

- ll-y — ll sounds like English y: *llamo* is *YA-mo*, not *LA-mo*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

llamo — “I call.” The dictionary form (the infinitive) is **llamar**, “to call.” Root: Latin **clamare**, “to cry out, to shout.” That *clam-* shouts all through English:

- **exclaim**, **exclamation** — *ex-* (“out”) + *clamare*: to shout **out**.
- **proclaim**, **proclamation** — *pro-* (“forth”): to call **forth**.
- **acclaim** — *ad-* (“toward”): to shout praise toward.
- **claim**, **reclaim**, **disclaim**; and **clamor**, borrowed whole.

A sound-pattern to bank: Latin *cl-* became Spanish *ll-*. *clamare* → *llamar*. It happened repeatedly: *clavem* → *llave* (“key”), *flamma* → *llama* (“flame”), *plovere* → *llover* (“to rain”). A Spanish word starting *ll-* is very often a Latin *cl-/fl-/pl-* word in disguise — and its English cousin usually kept the original cluster (*clamor*, *flame*, *pluvial*).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “llamo” — *YA-mo*
- “llamo” then “exclaim”, “proclaim”, “clamor” — the shouting root
- “llamar” (to call), “llave” (key) — both from Latin *cl-*

Before you move on

What does the root *clamare* mean? (To shout / cry out.) Latin *cl-* becomes which two letters in Spanish? (*ll-* — *clamare* → *llamar*.)

4.3 me llamo — “I call myself”

Snap the last two lessons together — *me* + *llamo* — and you can introduce yourself. But notice Spanish doesn’t say “my name is” at all.

What to know first

- me · llamo

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

me llamo = **me** (“myself”) + **llamo** (“I call”) = literally “**I call myself.**” Then the name: *Me llamo Susana* — “I call myself Susan.”

Grammar Lens: reflexive verbs

When the action loops back onto the person doing it — you call *yourself* — the verb is **reflexive**, and Spanish marks it with that little pronoun in front: *me* (“myself”). *llamo* alone is “I call [someone else]”; *me llamo* is “I call **myself.**” English can do this (“I call myself Sam”) but usually doesn’t bother, flattening it to “my name is.” Spanish keeps the reflexive loop visible.

This matters because the pronoun **changes with the person**: *me llamo* (I call myself) → *te llamas* (you-informal call yourself) → *se llama* (he/she/you-formal calls himself). You’ll meet *te* and *se* in a few lessons; for now, lock in *me llamo* for yourself.

Why it’s said this way

Spanish presents your name not as a thing you *have* (“my name is”) but as what you *do* — what you call yourself. It’s subtly more active, and it’s the completely standard, neutral way to introduce yourself.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “me llamo” + your own name
- “hola, me llamo ____” — greeting + introduction
- what does *me llamo* literally mean, word for word?

Before you move on

Literally, what is *me llamo*? (“I call myself.”) What makes it reflexive? (The *me* — the action loops back on you.)

4.4 Saying your name — putting it together

Three lessons became one sentence. Say it to a stranger. Nothing new in this lesson — only what you already have.

The exchange

— Hola. **Me llamo** Susana. — Me llamo David.

What you've built

You can now put your own name into Spanish, which is the first thing anyone will ask you for.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the whole exchange, both parts, without stopping
- it again, faster, and let it sound like speech rather than recital

Twice through:

Before you move on

Run it once more from memory. If a word does not come, go back one lesson rather than pushing on — this chapter is short on purpose.

Chapter 5

The Three Words for You

Modes: 🎧 voice (5) 📞 Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can choose between tú and usted, and recognise vos.

The Three Words for You — the chapter run end to end.

5.1 tú and usted — two of the three words Spanish says to one person

English has one word for “you.” Spanish has three for speaking to one person, and today you get two of them — the two you will use yourself. What the choice *means* socially, and the odd grammar *usted* drags along with it, comes next. The third word comes shortly after, and you will only ever need to recognise it.

The two words

tú — “you,” **informal**. For friends, family, children, peers, anyone you are on easy terms with.

Root: Latin **tū**. This is a **true cousin** of English **thou** — the word English used to have for exactly this job, the intimate “you” (*thou/thee/thy*), before it faded out around 400 years ago. Both *tú* and *thou* come straight from the same ancient root (*tu-*). So Spanish still uses, every day, the pronoun English quietly retired.

usted — “you,” **formal**. For strangers, elders, officials, customers, anyone you are showing respect or keeping distance with.

Both are the “doer” word — the one that says who is acting, like *yo* (“I”). Say them enough times that they come out without hunting: *tú*, one syllable with the accent; *usted*, stress on the second, with a very soft final *d*.

Not the whole story, and you should know that now.

Across Argentina, Uruguay, Paraguay, most of Central America and parts of Colombia, the everyday informal “you” is a *third* word — not *tú* at all. That is well over a hundred million people. You are learning *tú* because it is understood everywhere, and you will meet the third word shortly, only to recognise.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*tú*” — for a close friend
- “*usted*” — for someone you’d address respectfully
- “*tú*” then English “thou” — the retired twin

Before you move on

Which is formal, *tú* or *usted*? (*Usted*.) What English pronoun is the lost twin of *tú*, and what happened to it? (*Thou* — it faded out of English around 400 years ago.) How many words does Spanish have for “you,” and how many will you say yourself? (*Three, for one person; two.*) Next: what picking one of them tells your listener.

5.2 *tú or usted* — a choice you have to make every time

You have both words. Now the hard part: Spanish makes you **choose** one every time you speak to someone, and the choice is never neutral.

What to know first

- *tú* / *usted* — the two words themselves.

Why it's said this way

Tú and *usted* do not differ in **meaning** — both are “you,” singular, one person. They differ in **register**: the social distance you are claiming.

you say

tú

usted

you are signalling

closeness, equality, ease

respect, deference, distance

English used to carry this too, with *thou* against *you* — and when *thou* died, English lost the ability to say it at all. One-size-fits-all “you” means an English speaker never has to decide. A Spanish speaker decides every single time, and getting it wrong is not a grammar mistake but a **social** one: *tú* to a stranger can read as presumptuous, *usted* to a friend as cold.

The safe default when you cannot tell: **usted**. Over-formal is recoverable; over-familiar is awkward.

Grammar Lens: *usted* takes he/she forms

One structural surprise, because it shapes every lesson after this: ***usted* takes the *he/she* verb forms, not the informal “you” forms.**

That is why “what’s your name?” formally is *¿cómo se llama usted?* — using the *se llama* you would otherwise use for “he calls himself” — and not *te llamas*. Grammatically, *usted* behaves as though you were talking **about** the person rather than **to** them. That is a fossil of where the word came from, and the next lesson digs it up.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*tú*” and name someone you would use it with
- “*usted*” and name someone you would use it with
- which verb pattern *usted* takes — the he/she one

Before you move on

Do *tú* and *usted* differ in meaning or in register? (**Register** — both mean “you”; they signal closeness versus respect.) Which do you pick when unsure? (**Usted**.) Which verb forms does *usted* take?

(The same forms used with **he** or **she**.)

5.3 vos — the third “you,” and you only have to recognise it

Two words so far. Which one do you use with a friend? (*Tú*.)
Which one keeps a respectful distance? (*Usted*.)

What to know first

vos — “you,” informal. It does the same job as *tú*.

Where it lives, in part: Argentina, Uruguay and Paraguay, and most of Central America. It is also alive in Chile, and in parts of Colombia and Bolivia — this list is not the whole map. Counting only the places named, that is **well over a hundred million people** for whom *vos*, not *tú*, is the ordinary word to a friend.

You are learning *tú* because it is understood everywhere, those places included. But a course that never mentioned *vos* would be teaching you a Spanish nobody speaks in Buenos Aires.

What you owe this word. Recognition, nothing more. Hear **vos**, think *tú*. Its endings differ a little, and you will meet that where you meet the endings themselves — not before.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Vos is Latin **vōs** — and Latin **vōs** was the **plural** “you.” The word Romans used for a group.

How does a plural become the word for one friend? By politeness. Addressing someone as though they were several made them bigger. The courtesy wore off, and across much of the Americas the word slid into *tú*’s place.

English began the same way and ended in the opposite place.

You met *thou* earlier in this chapter. What retired it was **you** — a *plural*, used to one person out of politeness, exactly as Spanish used *vos*. But English’s polite plural won and spread until it was the only word left; standard English now has no separate singular at all. Spanish’s *vos* went the other way — it *lost* the polite job and dropped into the intimate one.

Same start, opposite ends. And what took the polite job away from *vos* is the very next lesson.

Your turn

Recognition only — nothing to produce here.

- [YOU HEAR: “vos”] → think: *tú*. A friend, an equal, someone at ease with you.
- [YOU HEAR: “usted”] → think: distance, or respect.
- [YOU SAY: “tú”] — still your word, everywhere you go.

Before you move on

How many words does Spanish have for “you” when speaking to **one** person? (*Three*.) Which do you say? (*Tú* — and *usted* for distance.) Name a country where *vos* is the everyday word. (*Argentina, Uruguay, Nicaragua...*) What was Latin *vōs* originally? (*The plural “you.”*)

5.4 *vuestra merced* → *usted* — respect compressed into one word

You use *usted* for respectful “you,” and it takes the same verb form as “he” or “she.” That surprising grammar preserves the word’s history.

What to know first

- *tú* / *usted* — the informal and formal choices.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

usted wore down from **vuestra merced**, “your grace” or “your mercy.” *Vuestra* comes from Latin *vestra*, “your.” *Merced* comes from Latin *merces, mercedem*, “wages, reward, favor.” The *merc-* root links **mercy, mercenary, commerce, merchant, and merchandise**. A respectful title was repeated so often that two

words compressed into one pronoun. Its older abbreviation **Vd.** still preserves the *v* of *vuestra*.

Why it's said this way

A title like “your grace” refers to a respected person in the third person. That is why modern *usted* still takes the he/she verb form even while it means “you.” The social history remains visible in the grammar.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the two-word title that became *usted*
- “usted” followed by “mercy” and “merchant” — the *merc-* family
- which verb pattern *usted* takes

Before you move on

What did *vuestra merced* mean? (“Your grace” or “your mercy.”) Why does *usted* take the he/she verb form? (It began as a third-person title.) And the third “you” you met last lesson — which is it, and do you say it or just know it? (*Vos*; you recognise it, and keep saying *tú*.)

5.5 Choosing your “you” — putting it together

Three words, one choice, and it is social rather than grammatical. Nothing new in this lesson — only what you already have.

The exchange

To a friend: **tú**. To a stranger, an elder, an official: **usted**. Heard across the Southern Cone and Central America: **vos** — understand it, keep saying *tú*.

What you've built

You know which word to reach for, and why *usted* takes the shape it does.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the whole exchange, both parts, without stopping
- it again, faster, and let it sound like speech rather than recital

Twice through:

Before you move on

Run it once more from memory. If a word does not come, go back one lesson rather than pushing on — this chapter is short on purpose.

Chapter 6

Asking Someone's Name

Modes:  voice (6)  eyes (1)  pen (1)  Hands-free start: first 1 of 8 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask someone's name in either register and say it was a pleasure.

Asking Someone's Name — the chapter run end to end.

6.1 cómo — “how,” your first question word

To ask someone's name or how they are, you need this word first. *Cómo* — “how” — and hiding inside it is a little Latin word for “manner” that you already own a dozen English versions of.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

cómo — “how.” Root: Latin **quo modo** — not a word but a **two-word phrase**, “in what **manner**.”

The two halves, and their English cousins:

- *modo* (“manner, measure”) → English **mode**, **modal**, **model**, **moderate**, **modify**, commodity.
- *quo* (“in what”) is the Latin question-stem **qu-**, the seed of nearly every Spanish question word.

How the phrase became one word — the wearing-down.

Spanish did not borrow *cómo* ready-made; it **eroded** out of *quo modo*

over centuries of everyday speech. The final *-do* fell off and the middle collapsed:

quomodo → *quomo* → **como**

The *qu-* (a *kw* sound) flattened to a plain *k*, written *c* before *o*. What is left is a whole Latin phrase worn smooth — the way a pebble loses its edges in a river. The same erosion gave Italian *come*, Portuguese *como*, French *comme*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “cómo” — *CÓ-mo*, stress on the first syllable
- “cómo” then English “mode”, “model” — the *modo* root
- the erosion — “quo modo, quomo, como”

Before you move on

What does *cómo* mean? (“How.”) Walk the erosion: *quo modo* → ? → *cómo*. (*Quomo* → *como*.) What did the two Latin halves mean? (*Quo*, “in what”; *modo*, “manner” — the root of English *mode* and *model*.) Next: the two marks Spanish puts on a question.

6.2 ¿cómo? — the two marks that say “this is a question”

You have the word *cómo*. Written down, it wears **two** marks that English has no equivalent for — and neither of them is decoration. Both do a job English leaves to word order and guesswork.

What to know first

- *cómo* — the word itself, and where it came from.

Script — the upside-down opener

Spanish questions open with an upside-down ¿ and close with a normal ?:
¿cómo?

Why? Spanish word order often does not change in a question — *cómo estás* looks the same whether you are asking or reporting. A reader coming to a long sentence would not know to raise their pitch until they hit the mark at the very end, by which time it is too late. The ¿ is a piece of engineering: it tells your voice, in advance, what shape the sentence has. Only the **question part** gets bracketed, not necessarily the whole line.

Grammar Lens: the accent that marks a question

Now watch the accent mark do real work:

written

means

cómo

“how?” — the question word

como

“like / as” — or “I eat”

Same letters, same sound. The written accent is the **only** thing marking the difference:

- ¿*Cómo* estás? — “**How** are you?”
- *Como* tú. — “Like you.” / *Yo como*. — “I eat.”

Every question word you will meet — *qué, dónde, cuándo, quién* — carries this accent for exactly this reason. It is not about stress (the stress is the same either way); it is a flag that says “**asking.**”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “¿cómo?” — with question intonation, opening high
- the pair — “cómo” (how?) then “como” (like / I eat)

Before you move on

Why does Spanish open a question with ¿? (Word order often does not change, so the reader needs the warning **before** the sentence, not after.) What changes when the accent disappears from *cómo*? (It stops being the question word — *como* means “like / as,” or “I

eat.”)

6.3 The *qu-* question family — one ancient pattern, many clues

You traced *cómo* back to Latin *quomodo*. Focus now on its first piece, *qu-*, without trying to use a whole set of new question words yet.

What to know first

- *cómo* — “how,” from Latin *quomodo*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin used a recurring *qu-* stem in questions. Spanish preserves that family, although centuries of sound change gave the modern forms different shapes:

Spanish clue	← Latin	future meaning
<i>qué</i>	<i>quid</i>	what
<i>quién</i>	<i>quem</i>	who
<i>cuál</i>	<i>qualis</i>	which
<i>cuándo</i>	<i>quando</i>	when
<i>cuánto</i>	<i>quantus</i>	how much
cómo	<i>quomodo</i>	how

These are previews, not vocabulary to produce today. For now, use the family only as an etymological clue: a question form beginning *qu-* or *cu-* may continue the same Latin pattern. *Dónde*, “where,” is an exception from Latin *de unde*, “from where.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the Latin source of *cómo*
- the recurring Latin question stem
- whether the table is today’s production list or a preview

Before you move on

Which old stem connects *qué*, *quién*, *cuándo*, and *cómo*? (*qu-*)
Which word in the preview is the exception? (*Dónde*.)

6.4 se llama — the reflexive that fits *usted*

You can say *me llamo* (“I call myself”). To ask someone *else* their name — especially formally, with *usted* — you need the version that loops back on *them*: *se llama*.

What to know first

- *me llamo* — the reflexive “I call myself.”
- *tú* / *usted* — and the key fact that *usted* takes *he/she* verb forms.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

se llama = **se** (“himself / herself / yourself-formal”) + **llama** (“calls”). So *se llama* = “he/she calls himself,” or — because *usted* uses third-person forms — “**you** (formal) call yourself.”

se — the reflexive pronoun for the third person (and for *usted*). Root: Latin *sē* (“himself, herself, itself”). That same *se-* — carrying the sense of “self / apart / aside” — is bolted onto a shelf of English words:

- **secede** — *se* + *cedere* (“go apart”).
- **seclude**, **segregate** (“apart from the flock”), **separate**.
- **seduce** — *se* + *ducere* (“lead aside”).
- **secure** — *se* + *cura* (“free from care”), **secret** (“set apart”).

Every one is something turned in on itself or set apart — the same idea as a reflexive looping the action back on the doer.

Grammar Lens: the reflexive pronoun changes with the person

The verb *llamar* stays, but the little reflexive word in front shifts to match *who* is doing the calling:

- **me** llamo — *I* call myself
- **te** llamas — *you (informal, tú)* call yourself
- **se** llama — *he / she / you (formal, usted)* calls himself/yourself

Three persons, three pronouns: *me / te / se*. That *se* is exactly why the formal “what’s your name?” is *¿cómo se llama usted?* — *usted*, born from “your grace,” politely takes the *he/she* shape.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “se llama” — *seh YA-ma*
- the set — “me llamo, te llamas, se llama”
- “se” then “secede”, “seclude”, “separate” — the set-apart root

Before you move on

Which reflexive goes with *usted* — *te* or *se*? (*se* — because *usted* takes third-person forms.) What’s the “self/apart” root inside *secede* and *separate*? (Latin *se-*.)

6.5 ¿cómo se llama usted? — assembling the question, and answering it

Everything you built this chapter clicks into one sentence: how to ask a stranger their name, and how to answer back. This is your first real two-way exchange.

What to know first

- cómo · se llama · usted

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

¿Cómo se llama usted? = *cómo* (“how”) + *se llama* (“do you-formal call yourself”) + *usted* (“you,” formal).

Literally: “**How do you call yourself?**” Spanish asks *how*, not *what*, for a name — you’re asking by what name a person goes, the manner they’re called.

The informal version, for a friend, swaps the reflexive and drops the formal pronoun: **¿Cómo te llamas?** (*te llamas*, from *tú*). Same question, two registers — exactly the *tú/usted* choice from earlier, now live in a real sentence:

- To a stranger, an elder, a customer → *¿Cómo se llama usted?*
- To a friend, a child, a peer → *¿Cómo te llamas?*

How to answer

You already have the answer from the *me llamo* lesson: **Me llamo _____**.

— *¿Cómo se llama usted?* — **Me llamo David.**

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- ask a stranger their name — *¿cómo se llama usted?*
- ask a friend the same — *¿cómo te llamas?*
- the whole mini-exchange — ask, then answer with *me llamo _____*

Before you move on

Formal vs. informal “what’s your name”? (*¿Cómo se llama usted?* / *¿Cómo te llamas?*) Does Spanish literally ask “what” or “how” is your name? (“How” — *cómo*.)

6.6 mucho — “much,” and a sound-change you’ve already seen

One more word before “pleased to meet you.” *mucho* — “much, a lot” — and it hides the same Latin-to-Spanish sound trick you spotted in *noche*.

Sounds you'll need

- **soft-c** — the **ch** is the *ch* of *church*: *MOO-cho*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

mucho — “much, a lot.” Root: Latin **multus** (“much, many”). The English cousins keep the original *-lt-*:

- **multiple**, **multitude**, **multiply**, **multi-purpose**, **multimedia**.

The sound-change, again: Latin *multum* → Spanish *mucho*. The Latin **-lt-** softened into Spanish **-ch-** — the very same move as *noctem* → *noche* (*-ct-* → *-ch-*, as in the *noche* lesson). Spanish has a habit of melting these consonant clusters into *ch*. So a Spanish *-ch-* word very often points back to a Latin *-ct-* or *-lt-* root — and the English cousin usually preserves it (*nocturnal*, *multiple*).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “mucho” — *MOO-cho*
- “mucho” then “multiple”, “multitude” — the *mult-* family
- “noche” and “mucho” — two words, same *-ch-* from a melted Latin cluster

Before you move on

mucho comes from Latin *multus* — what English words keep the *-lt-*? (multiple, multitude, multiply.) What Latin cluster melted into the *-ch-*? (*-lt-*, like *-ct-* did in *noche*.)

6.7 gusto → mucho gusto — “much pleasure”

The line you say when you shake someone’s hand. First the noun *gusto*, then snap *mucho* onto it, and you’ve got it.

What to know first

- *mucho* — “much,” about to modify *gusto*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el gusto (masculine) — “taste; pleasure, liking.” Root: Latin **gustus** (“a tasting, a taste”). The English cousins:

- **gustatory** — to do with the sense of taste.
- **disgust** — *dis-* (“not, opposite”) + *gust*: literally “**distaste**.”
- **gusto** — borrowed whole into English, meaning zest, relish, enjoyment.

False friend to flag: a *gust* of wind is **not** related — that one’s from Old Norse *gustr*. Same spelling, different root. Resemblance isn’t proof.

mucho gusto = *mucho* (“much”) + *gusto* (“pleasure”) = literally “**much pleasure**” — short for “it’s a great pleasure [to meet you].” *gusto* is masculine (*el gusto*), and *mucho* is in its plain masculine form to match it: another quiet piece of the agreement you’ve been building.

Why it’s said this way

Spanish greets a new acquaintance by naming the *pleasure* of it — “much pleasure” — where English names the *person* (“pleased to meet **you**”). The phrase works by itself, so this first exchange needs no extra reply formula.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “gusto” then “gusto” (English), “disgust”, “gustatory”
- “mucho gusto” — on meeting someone

Before you move on

What does *mucho gusto* literally mean? (“Much pleasure.”) Is *el gusto* masculine or feminine? (Masculine.) And the English cousin of *gusto* built from *dis-*? (*Disgust* — “distaste.”)

6.8 Practice — introducing yourself

Ten lessons of atoms now assemble into a real conversation. No new words — just the exchange, run both formally and informally until the *tú* / *usted* choice is automatic.

The exchange

Formal (a stranger, an elder, a customer):

- Buenos días. Me llamo Susana. **¿Cómo se llama usted?**
- Me llamo David. **Mucho gusto.**

Informal (a friend, a peer): only two words change, and they’re the ones that carry the whole social difference:

- ¡Hola! Me llamo Susana. **¿Cómo te llamas?** — Me llamo David. Mucho gusto.

What you’ve built

- **me llamo** — introduce yourself (“I call myself”).
- **tú** / **usted** — the informal vs. formal “you,” and *why* (the retired *thou*; *usted* from “your grace”).
- **¿cómo te llamas?** / **¿cómo se llama usted?** — ask a name, in either register, the pronoun (*te* / *se*) tracking the choice.
- **mucho gusto** — “much pleasure,” pleased to meet you.

And one from two chapters back, because it is worth keeping warm: *buenos días* but *buenas tardes* — the describing word copies its noun.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the full *formal* exchange, both parts
- the same exchange *informally* — catch yourself on *se llama* → *te llamas*
- for a police officer, then your best friend — which “you” for each, and why?

Twice through: Run the formal version start to finish without stopping.

Before you move on

Which two words change between the formal and informal introduction? (*se llama usted* → *te llamas*.) Next chapter, you will learn how to ask how someone is doing.

Chapter 7

Thank You, Yes, and No

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can thank someone, answer when I am thanked, and say yes or no.

Thanks, the answer to thanks, and the two words that let you accept or decline.

7.1 sí — yes

The smallest useful word — and the accent on it is doing real work.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

sí = **yes**. One syllable, said *see*.

The written accent is not decoration — it is the **whole difference** between two words:

- **sí** (with the accent) = **yes**
- **si** (no accent) = **if**

They sound almost identical, so Spanish uses the mark to tell them apart on the page: *Sí, si quieres* = “Yes, if you want.” Miss the accent and you’ve written “if” where you meant “yes.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

sí is Latin **sīc**, “thus, so” — answering a question with “just so,” exactly the move Latin also made with **ita** (“thus” = yes, from the Latin yes/no lesson). Its Romance cousins kept the same root:

Latin <i>sīc</i>	→
Spanish	sí
Italian	sì
Portuguese	sim

French is the odd one out — it went a completely different way for “yes” (*oui*), which its own lesson tells. But say *sí*, *sì*, *sim* in a row and you hear one Latin word answering across three countries.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “sí” — *see*, and picture the accent
- the pair — “sí” (yes) vs “sì” (if)
- the cousins — “sí, sì, sim” — all from Latin *sīc*

Before you move on

How do you say yes in Spanish? (**sí**.) What is the *only* difference between **sí** “yes” and **si** “if”? (The **written accent**.) What Latin word is *sí* from, and what did it mean? (**sīc** — “thus, so”.)

7.2 no — no / not

The easiest word yet — and it quietly does two jobs Spanish never splits apart.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

no = **no**. Said *noh*, a clean single vowel.

It is Latin **nōn** with almost nothing worn off — just the final consonant gone. Compare the family, all from the same *nōn*:

Latin <i>nōn</i>	→
Spanish	no
Italian	no
French	non

Why it's said this way

Here's the thing English splits and Spanish doesn't. English has “**no**” (the answer) and “**not**” (inside a sentence) — two different words. Spanish uses **no** for **both**:

- as the **answer**. Someone asks you something — anything at all — and this one syllable declines it. You do not need to understand the question to answer it, which is exactly why this word comes early.
- and later, as the word that turns a sentence around — but that needs a sentence first, so it waits until you have one. For now: **no** is how you decline, refuse, and disagree, which is most of what a beginner needs it for.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “no” — *noh*
- “No.” — flat, once, the way you would decline a second coffee
- “Sí.” then “No.” — the two shortest complete answers in Spanish

Before you move on

How do you say no in Spanish? (**no**.) What Latin word is it from? (**nōn**.) Spanish *no* does the work of which **two** English words? (“**no**” the answer, and later the word for “not.”) Where does *no* go to negate a sentence? (**Right before the verb.**)

7.3 **gracias** — “thank you,” and a whole family of English words

You can now introduce yourself. The next exchange is *how are you?* — but every answer ends the same polite way, so we learn the courtesy word first: **gracias**.

Sounds you’ll need

- **vowel-a** — the clean *ah* of *father*, twice.
- **r-tap** — a single flicked *r* (not the English one, and not yet the rolled *rr*): the tongue taps once, like the middle of American *butter*.
- **ci-th-s** — the *ci* is a soft *s* in Latin America (**GRAH-syahs**) and a soft *th* in most of Spain (**GRAH-thyahs**). Either is correct — pick one.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

gracias is the plural of **gracia** (“grace, favour”), from Latin **grātia** — *favour freely given*. Saying *gracias* literally offers someone “graces,” i.e. good will in return for theirs.

That one Latin root **grātia** fans out across English — once you see it, you get a fistful of words for free:

- **grace, gracious, graceful** — the direct borrowings.
- **grateful, gratitude** — being *full of* grātia.
- **gratis, gratuity** — something given as a *favour* (for free, or a tip).
- **congratulate** — literally “to wish grace *together with* someone.”
- Italian **grazie**, French *grâces*, Portuguese *graças* — the whole Romance family kept grātia, even where everyday thanks went elsewhere (French says *merci*, Portuguese *obrigado*).

So *gracias* is not a word to memorize cold: it is **grace**, made plural and handed to another person.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “gracias” — *GRAH-syahs*, one soft tap on the *r*
- “gracias” then English “grace, grateful, gratitude” — one family

Before you move on

What everyday English word is *gracias* the plural of, at the root? (*Grace*.) So when you thank someone in Spanish, you are literally handing them — what? (Graces / favours.) Next: the little reply that closes the exchange, **de nada**.

7.4 de nada — “you’re welcome,” or “it was nothing”

Someone says **gracias**. You need the reply that closes the loop: **de nada** — literally “*of nothing*.” You’re waving the favour off as no trouble at all — the same move English makes with “*it’s nothing*” / “*no problem*.”

Sounds you’ll need

- **d-soft** — the *d* in *nada* is soft, almost the *th* of *this* (**NAH-thah**), not a hard English *d*. Spanish *d* between vowels always softens.
- **vowel-a** — three clean *ah* sounds: *deh NAH-thah*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **de** = “of / from” (Latin **dē**) — the same *de* hiding in English **depart**, **deduct**, **descend**.
- **nada** = “nothing.” And this is the beautiful part.

nada comes from Latin (**rēs**) **nāta** — “(a thing) *born*.” From *nāscī*, “to be born,” the same root as English **native**, **nature**, **natal**, **re-nais-sance** (re-birth). Latin speakers said *nōn est rēs nāta*, “there is not a born thing” — *not a single thing that ever came into being* —

and over centuries the emphatic *nāta* (“born thing”) wore down until **the word for ‘born thing’ became the word for ‘nothing’ itself.** So the reply *de nada* literally says “**of [a] born-thing**” → “of nothing at all.” French did the identical trick with **rien** (“nothing”) — which is Latin **rem**, “a thing.” Two languages, same move: the word for *thing* collapses into the word for *nothing*.

Grammar Lens: the courtesy pair

gracias → *de nada* is a fixed **adjacency pair**: one turn expects the other. Learn them as a unit, the way English glues *thank you* → *you’re welcome*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “gracias” ... “de nada” — the full exchange, both voices
- “de nada” then English “native, nature, natal” — nada’s true family

Before you move on

nada (“nothing”) started life as the Latin word for a *born* — what? (A *thing* — *rēs nāta*, a born thing.) What English words share that “born” root? (Native, nature, natal, renaissance.) Next: the verb the whole “how are you?” question turns on — **estar**.

7.5 Thank you, yes, and no — putting it together

Two words that travel everywhere together. Nothing new in this lesson — only what you already have.

The exchange

— **Gracias.** — **De nada.**

And the two words that let you answer anything at all:

— ¿...? — **Sí.** / — **No.**

What you've built

You can thank someone, answer when you are thanked, and — for the first time — accept or decline. Until you have *sí* and *no*, every question anyone asks you is unanswerable.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the whole exchange, both parts, without stopping
- it again, faster, and let it sound like speech rather than recital

Twice through:

Before you move on

Run it once more from memory. If a word does not come, go back one lesson rather than pushing on — this chapter is short on purpose.

Chapter 8

How Are You

Modes: ⇄ voice (4) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask a stranger how they are.
Greeting plus the question that opens almost every conversation.

8.1 *estar* — “to be,” the *standing* kind

To ask *how are you?* Spanish needs a verb for **being**. Today just the verb itself and where it came from; how to use it, and its two forms, come next.

Sounds you’ll need

- **st-no-e** — Spanish never starts a word with a bare *st-*; it props it up with an *e*: *es-TAR*. (That reflex is why Spanish speakers say *e-Spain*, *e-student* — the same *e* that Latin *stāre* grew to become *estar*.)
- **r-tap** — the final *r* is one soft tap: *es-TAR*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

estar comes straight from Latin **stāre**, “*to stand*.” Hold onto that picture: it is the whole reason this verb behaves the way it does. How you are **standing** at this moment — well, tired, here, there — is a snapshot, not a permanent fact.

That root **stā-/sta-** is one of the most productive in English. *Estar*

hands you a large family for free:

- **stay, stand, stance, station, stable, stationary** — to stand or stay put.
- **state, status, statue, estate** — a way of *standing* (your state is how you stand).
- **constant, circumstance, substance** — “standing with / around / under.”

So *¿cómo estás?* is, at the root, “**how are you standing?**”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “estar” — *es-TAR*, with the little propping *e*
- “estar” then English “stay, state, status, stable” — all *standing*

Before you move on

Which Latin verb is *estar* — “to be” or “to stand”? (To **stand** — *stāre*.) Why does Spanish put an *e* on the front? (It never begins a word with bare *st*.) Name two English cousins. (*Stay, state, status, stable, estate*...) Next: the two forms you will actually ask with.

8.2 estás / está — the two forms, and what they are for

Estar is “to stand.” Now put it to work. Two forms, one job: saying how somebody is **right now**.

What to know first

- *estar* — the verb and its Latin “to stand” root.
- *tú* or *usted* — why *usted* takes he/she forms.

Grammar Lens: state and location use *estar*

Use **estar** for a **current state** or a **location** — the two things that can change without changing what something *is*:

- a state: *estoy bien* — “I’m well” (today; maybe not tomorrow).
- a location: *está aquí* — “it’s here” (for now).

“How are you?” asks about a current state, so it takes *estar*. Spanish has a second be-verb for identity, and it arrives in its own later lesson; keeping it out of today’s drill lets one contrast settle at a time.

Grammar Lens: the two forms you need

you’re addressing	form	reads as
tú (informal)	estás	“you are”
usted (formal)	está	“you are”

Notice that **está** is also “he is / she is.” That is not a coincidence and not something extra to learn — it is the *usted*-takes-he/she-forms rule you already met, showing up for the first time in a real verb.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “estás” ... “está” — the two forms you’ll ask with
- which one goes with *tú*, which with *usted*
- a state, then a location — “estás bien”, “está aquí”

Before you move on

What two kinds of thing does *estar* cover? (**Current state** and **location**.) Which form goes with *tú*, and which with *usted*? (*Estás*; *está*.) Why is *está* also “he/she is”? (Because *usted* takes the **he/she** verb forms.) Next lesson, you finally ask it: **¿cómo está usted?**

8.3 ¿cómo está usted? — “how are you?”

Everything you’ve built this chapter now snaps together into one question. You already met **cómo** (“how”) and the **tú / usted** choice back in when you first met them; you just learned **estar**. Assemble them.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

¿Cómo está usted? = “How are you?” (formal) literally:
“In what manner are you standing?”

- **cómo** = “how / in what manner”
- **está** = “you are” (the *usted*/he-she form of **estar** — state, not identity)
- **usted** = the formal “you”

Note the **¿** — Spanish opens a question with an upside-down mark so you know the melody is coming before you start reading aloud. (We take that mark apart in a dedicated writing lesson.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “¿Cómo está usted?” — formal, for a stranger
- the pieces — “cómo + está + usted”

Before you move on

Which be-verb does “how are you?” use — *ser* or *estar*, and why? (*estar* — it’s about your current state.) What changes between formal and informal? (**The next step changes the ending and pronoun.**) Next: choosing the register.

8.4 How are you — putting the question together

You have a second “to be” and the question it carries. Nothing new here — only what you already have.

The exchange

— Buenos días. **¿Cómo está usted?**

The answer is the next chapter. Asking is this one.

What you've built

You can ask a stranger how they are, which is the question that opens almost every conversation you will ever have in Spanish.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “¿Cómo está usted?” — to someone you have just met
- the greeting and the question together, as one breath

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which “to be” carries how someone is, and why? (*Estar* — a state, not an identity.) Ask the question once more from memory.

Chapter 9

Answering, and Handing It Back

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can answer how I am, choose my register, and return the question.

The answer, the register choice inside it, and handing the question back.

9.1 ¿cómo está usted? / ¿cómo estás? — choose the register

You can already ask a stranger **¿Cómo está usted?** Now change only the relationship: ask the same question of a friend.

Grammar Lens: one question, two relationships

register	question
formal (stranger, elder, customer)	¿Cómo está usted?
informal (friend, peer, child)	¿Cómo estás?
The formal version uses the third-person ending está plus usted . The informal version uses second-person estás and normally omits tú . This is the same relationship contrast you drilled with se llama / te llamas .	

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- to a doctor you just met — “¿Cómo está usted?”
- to your cousin — “¿Cómo estás?”
- swap back and forth — “está usted / estás”

Twice through: Ask both versions until the ending swap is automatic.

Before you move on

Which version fits a stranger? (**¿Cómo está usted?**) Which fits a friend? (**¿Cómo estás?**) What two things change? (**The verb ending and the pronoun.**)

9.2 regular / más o menos — the honest “so-so”

You asked *¿cómo estás?* Now you can answer three ways: great, middling, or a wave of the hand. You already have **bien** (“well”). Today, the *middling* answers — because nobody is *bien* every day.

What to know first

Recall **bien** — “well.” Root? (Latin *bene*, “well” — same as *benefit*, *benevolent*.) So *estoy bien* = “I’m well.” Now the answer for when you’re *not* quite bien.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

regular — as an answer to “how are you?”, it means “**so-so, average, not great.**” (A famous false-friend trap: it does **not** mean English “regular / normal / usual” here.) From Latin **rēgula**, a *straight rod* a builder used to check a line — the **ruler**. So *regular* is “on the rule, on the average line” → middling.

That *rēgula* rod is everywhere in English: **rule, ruler, regulate, regular, regiment**, and even **rail** (a straight rod). All the same straight stick.

más o menos — “more or less,” the shrug-answer:

- **más** = “more,” from Latin **magis** (“more”) — cousin of *major*, *master*, *maximum*.

- **menos** = “less,” from Latin **minus** — the very word English borrowed for *minus*, *minor*, *minimum*, *minuscule*.

So *más o menos* is literally “**more or less**” — the exact phrase, root for root, that English uses for the same shrug.

Grammar Lens: a small answer set

You now have a scale to answer *¿cómo estás?*:

answer	sense
(muy) bien	(very) well
regular	so-so
más o menos	more or less / meh

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “regular” — *reh-goo-LAR*, soft tap on both *r*’s
- “más o menos” — a little shrug in the voice
- answer “¿cómo estás?” three ways — bien / regular / más o menos

Before you move on

As an answer, does *regular* mean “normal” or “so-so”? (So-so — the false-friend trap.) What straight-rod Latin word is it from, and what English “rod” words share it? (*rēgula* → rule, ruler, regulate, rail.) Next: put the whole exchange together.

9.3 y / ¿y tú? — pass the question back

You can ask how someone is and answer. One tiny connector turns that exchange around so the other person gets a turn too.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Y means **and** and sounds like Spanish **i**: *ee*. It continues Latin **et**, also “and.” English borrowed that Latin word intact inside **et cetera**,

literally “and the rest.”

Grammar Lens: the shortest return question

Put **y** before a person you already know:

- **¿Y tú?** — And you? (*informal*)
- **¿Y usted?** — And you? (*formal*)

Nothing else needs repeating. The little question hands the previous topic back to the other person.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Bien. ¿Y tú?” to a friend
- “Regular. ¿Y usted?” to a stranger
- “y” — one clear *ee* sound

Before you move on

What does **y** mean? (**And.**) How do you hand a question back to a friend? (**¿Y tú?**) To a stranger? (**¿Y usted?**) Which Latin word survives inside English **et cetera**? (**Et**, “and.”)

9.4 Asking how someone is — putting it together

Now the question, its answer, and the register choice inside it. Nothing new in this lesson — only what you already have.

The exchange

— **¿Cómo está usted?** — **Bien**, gracias. **¿Y usted?** — **Regular**.

What you've built

You can ask how someone is, formally or not, answer honestly, and hand the question back.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the whole exchange, both parts, without stopping
- it again, faster, and let it sound like speech rather than recital

Twice through:

Before you move on

Run it once more from memory. If a word does not come, go back one lesson rather than pushing on — this chapter is short on purpose.

Chapter 10

The Written Accent

Modes:  voice (1)  pen (2)  Hands-free start: none of the 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can hear where a Spanish word is stressed and see why the accent is written.

The Written Accent — the chapter run end to end.

10.1 á é í ó ú — the acute accent, and the two jobs it does

You’ve been reading accented words since your very first noun — **dí**a, **có**mo, **está**, **má**s. Time to make that little stroke make sense. Spanish uses one mark to write exceptional stress — the *acute* accent, ´, leaning right — and it does two jobs in the words you know. Learn the stress job now; the next lesson adds its grammar-label job.

Script — shape and stroke

A short stroke rising **left-to-right**, sitting on top of a vowel: **á é í ó ú**. (On the *í*, it replaces the dot.) One clean up-stroke — the opposite lean from the French *grave* accent â. Spanish never uses grave or circumflex; if it leans the wrong way, it isn’t Spanish.

Grammar Lens: the mark records exceptional stress

Spanish stress is regular, so most words need **no** mark. The default:

- word ends in a **vowel, -n, or -s** → stress the **second-to-last** syllable (*ho-la*, *lla-mo*, *gus-to*).
- word ends in **any other consonant** → stress the **last** syllable (*us-**ted***, *re-gu-**lar***, *es-**tar***).

The accent appears **only when a word breaks that rule** — it marks the exception. *está* ends in a vowel, so the rule wants *ES-ta*; the accent overrides it to *es-**TÁ***. *cómo* ends in a vowel (rule wants *co-**MO***) but is stressed *CÓ-mo*, so it gets the mark. The accent is a **spoken stress you can see** — it never changes the vowel’s sound, only which syllable you hit.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hola, llamo, gusto” — second-to-last stress
- “usted, regular, estar” — final stress
- “está, cómo” — the accent overrides the default

Before you move on

How many accent marks does Spanish have, and which way does it lean? (One — the acute, ´, rising left-to-right.) Its two jobs? (Mark irregular stress; the next step covers its look-alike job.) When does a word ending in a vowel, **-n**, or **-s** need an accent? (**When its stress breaks the second-to-last default.**)

10.2 el or él? — the accent as a meaning label

You know **el** as the article “the.” Add one acute accent and the same two letters do a different job.

Grammar Lens: one mark, two grammatical jobs

The **tilde diacrítica** separates words that otherwise look alike:

no accent**el** = the**with accent****él** = he

The two words are pronounced alike. Here the accent does not move stress; it labels meaning and grammar. Other pairs will arrive only when you know both words, so this lesson asks you to hold one contrast, not memorize a list.

Your turn

- *Say it:* “el” — the
- *Say it:* “él” — he
- *Write it:* **el** / **él**, adding the meaning-label accent only to the pronoun

Before you move on

What is the accent’s second job? (**Separate look-alike words.**) Which means “the”? (**El**, no accent.) Which means “he”? (**Él**, with the accent.) Does this mark change their stress? (**No — it labels the job.**)

10.3 The written accent — putting it together

Two lessons on one small mark that changes both sound and meaning. Nothing new in this lesson — only what you already have.

The exchange

está is not *esta*. *él* is not *el*.

What you’ve built

You can hear where the stress falls and see why the mark is there.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the whole exchange, both parts, without stopping
- it again, faster, and let it sound like speech rather than recital

Twice through:

Before you move on

Run it once more from memory. If a word does not come, go back one lesson rather than pushing on — this chapter is short on purpose.

Chapter 11

Enye and the Upside-Down Marks

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ✍ pen (4) ⇄ Hands-free start: none of the 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can read and write ñ and the upside-down question and exclamation marks.

Enye and the Upside-Down Marks — the chapter run end to end.

11.1 ñ — the letter that remembers a doubled n

ñ is the one letter English does not have — and it has the best origin story in the alphabet. That wavy hat (~, a *tilde*) is not decoration. It is **a tiny second n, written on top to save space**. Once you know that, you know both how to write it *and* why it sounds as it does.

Sounds you'll need

ñ = the *ny* in “canyon” or “onion” — one squished sound, tongue flat against the roof of the mouth. English *canyon* is, in fact, Spanish **cañón** with the ñ spelled out as *ny*. Say “onion,” freeze on the middle: that is ñ.

Script — how to write it

Write a normal **n**, then a small wavy ~ floating above it. Two strokes, one letter.

Careful: ñ is its own letter, not “n with an accent.” *año* (“year”) and *ano* (a rather different word) are completely different words — the tilde is not an optional flourish, it is a distinct letter of the alphabet, with its own slot in the dictionary.

Why it’s said this way

That wave is a **medieval shorthand**. Scribes copying Latin were forever writing double letters, so they saved a stroke: write the letter **once**, and put a little mark above meaning “...and one more of these.” A bar over a vowel meant a dropped *n* or *m* (Latin *tantum* → *tātum*); a wave over an *n* meant **nn**.

Spanish is full of words where a Latin **-nn-** did exactly this:

- Latin **annus** (“year”) → *anno* → **año**. (That same *annus* gives English **annual**, **anniversary**, bi-**ennial**.)
- Latin **canna** (“reed”) → **caña**; Latin *domina* → *donna* → **doña**.

So the tilde on ñ is a **frozen abbreviation** — a thousand-year-old note saying “there used to be two *n*’s here.” You are writing a scribe’s shortcut.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “año” — *AH-nyo*, one squished *ny*; then English “annual”
- the doubled-n words — “año, caña, doña”

Before you move on

What is the tilde on ñ, really? (A tiny second *n* — a scribe’s shorthand for a doubled *nn*.) What Latin word gives *año*, and what English words share it? (*Annus* → annual, anniversary.) Is ñ a separate letter or an accented *n*? (A **separate letter**.) Next: the two everyday words you will be writing it in.

11.2 mañana, español — the ñ in the words you are about to need

You can write **ñ** and you can say it. Two of the next words in this book carry it, and both are worth a minute on their own — because neither of them got its *ñ* from a doubled *n*.

What to know first

- **ñ** — the letter, the sound, and the scribe’s shorthand.

Script — the two forms

- **mañana** — “tomorrow,” and also “morning.” *ma-NYA-na*: the *ñ* is in the **middle**, and it is the stressed syllable.
- **español** — “Spanish.” *es-pa-NYOL*: the *ñ* is at the **end**, right before the *-ol*.

Now the honest footnote. The scribe’s doubled *nn* is **one** road to *ñ*, the one you met with *año*. These two words took a **different** road: Latin’s **-ni-** before a vowel. *Mañana* traces back through *maneana* to **māne** (“morning” — the root of English **matinée**); *español* comes from **Hispaniolus**, built on **Hispania**. In both, a *ni* sequence squeezed together into the same single palatal sound.

So *ñ* is where **two** separate Latin sequences ended up — *-nn-* and *-ni-*. One letter, one sound, two histories.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “año, mañana, español” — the *ñ* in three positions
- the two roads — “año, from *-nn-*” then “mañana, from *-ni-*”

Before you move on

Where does the *ñ* sit in *mañana*, and where in *español*? (Middle; end.) Did those two get their *ñ* from a doubled *n*? (**No** — from Latin **-ni-** before a vowel, a second road to the same letter.) What was the first road? (**-nn-**, the scribe’s shorthand, as in *año*.)

11.3 ¿ ¡ — the marks that open a question

You’ve been writing them since *¿cómo está usted?* Spanish is the one major language that puts an **upside-down** question or exclamation mark at the **start** of the sentence, as well as the normal one at the end. It looks exotic; the reason is purely practical.

Script — the two opening marks

- ¿ ... ? wraps a question: *¿Cómo estás?*
- ¡ ... ! wraps an exclamation: *¡Hola! ¡Gracias!*

The opening mark is just the closing mark **flipped 180°** — turned upside down *and* left-right. To write ¿, draw a normal ? and rotate it half a turn: the hook ends up at the bottom, the dot on top.

Why it’s said this way

English lets you read most of a sentence before the final ? reveals it was a question — fine, because English usually flags a question early with word order (“Are you...”, “Do you...”). Spanish often **doesn’t reorder words**: *Tienes hambre*. (“You’re hungry.”) and *¿Tienes hambre?* (“Are you hungry?”) are the **same words** — only punctuation and the spoken rising tone tell them apart. So the Spanish Royal Academy, in **1754**, made the opening ¿ official: it warns the reader “*a question is starting — read this with rising intonation from the very first word.*” It’s a **melody cue placed before the melody**, the exact same instinct as the written accent marking stress you can’t otherwise see. For a language read aloud, it’s genuinely useful.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- read “¿Cómo estás?” — start the rising *question* melody from the very first word, the way the ¿ tells you to
- “¡Hola!” — the ¡ warns you to begin with exclamation energy

Before you move on

Why does Spanish open a question with ¿? (Because word order often doesn't change, so the reader needs an early warning to use question intonation.) How do you write it? (A normal ? rotated 180°.) Does it always sit at the sentence's start? (**The next step places it around a question inside a larger sentence.**)

11.4 Where does ¿ begin? — bracket the spoken span

You can open a whole question with ¿. Now place that mark inside a larger sentence, exactly where the questioning voice begins.

Script — bracket the spoken span

The opening mark goes where the **question** begins, even if the sentence started earlier:

Roberto, ¿cómo estás?

The name **Roberto** is outside the question. The marks bracket the words that need question intonation. The same principle works for an exclamation:

Roberto, ¡buenos días!

This is why the opening mark is more than decoration. It tells the reader exactly where to begin and end a change in spoken melody.

Your turn

- *Write it:* “María, ¿cómo estás?”
- *Write it:* “María, ¡buenos días!”
- *Say it:* begin the new melody at ¿ or ¡, not at the first capital

Before you move on

In **Roberto**, ¿cómo estás?, is **Roberto** inside the question? (**No.**) Where does the inverted mark go? (**At the start of the question or exclamation span.**) What does that placement tell a reader? (**Where to change the spoken melody.**)

11.5 Practice — “how are you?”, start to finish

No new words. This chapter’s atoms — *gracias*, *de nada*, *estar*, *¿cómo está?*, *regular* — now assemble into a real exchange, run formally and informally until the register swap is automatic. It picks up right where the introduction left off.

The exchange

Formal (a stranger, an elder, a customer):

— Buenos días. ¿Cómo está usted? — **Bien, gracias.** ¿Y usted? — **Más o menos.** — [reply to a thanks, later in the chat] **De nada.**

Informal (a friend, a peer) — only the verb + pronoun change:

— ¡Hola! ¿Cómo estás? — **Regular.** ¿Y tú? — Bien, gracias.

The glue pattern you just secured is **¿y usted?** / **¿y tú?** — “and you?” It bounces the question back without repeating the whole sentence.

What you’ve built this chapter

- **gracias** — thank you (← *grātia*, “grace”).
- **de nada** — you’re welcome (← “of a born-thing” → “of nothing”).
- **estar** — the state/location be-verb (← *stāre*, “to stand”).
- **¿cómo está usted?** / **¿cómo estás?** — how are you, formal / informal.
- **bien** / **regular** / **más o menos** — well / so-so / more-or-less.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the full *formal* exchange, both voices
- the same exchange *informally* — catch *está* → *estás*, *usted* → *tú*
- chain the two — introduce yourself *and* ask how they are: “Me llamo ... ¿Cómo está usted?”

Twice through: Run the formal exchange, greeting to answer, without stopping.

Before you move on

Which be-verb carries “how are you?” and why? (*estar* — current state.) Two words swap between formal and informal — which? (*está* → *estás*, and *usted* → *tú*.) What does *de nada* literally say? (“Of nothing.”) And if the person answering you says **vos** instead of *tú* — do you switch? (*No. You understand it and keep saying tú.*)
Next chapter: **farewells** — hasta luego, hasta mañana, adiós.

Chapter 12

Goodbye

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can end a conversation, and I know the word every softer goodbye is built from.

Goodbye — the chapter run end to end.

12.1 adiós — “goodbye,” or “to God”

You can greet, introduce yourself, and ask how someone is. Time to leave gracefully. The final, plainest parting is **adiós** — and, like the English *goodbye*, it’s a tiny prayer worn smooth.

Sounds you’ll need

- diphthong-io — the *-íos* is one glide, *ee-OHS*: *ah-DYOHS*, stress on the end (that’s what the accent on *ó* marks — remember the acute-accent lesson).

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

adiós is **a + Dios** — “**to God**.” It’s the front half of an old blessing, *a Dios te encomiendo*, “I commend you **to God**” — said to someone setting off, when a journey was dangerous and you left them in God’s keeping.

Every Romance sister kept the same farewell-prayer:

language	goodbye	literally
Spanish	<i>adiós</i>	“to God”
French	<i>adieu</i>	“to God” (<i>à Dieu</i>)
Italian	<i>addio</i>	“to God”
Portuguese	<i>adeus</i>	“to God”

And English is doing the **exact same thing** without telling you: **goodbye** is a crushed-down “*God be with ye.*” So *adiós* and *goodbye* are, at heart, the same sentence — a blessing for the road.

- **Dios** (“God”) ← Latin **Deus** — the *Deus* of English *deity*, *divine*, *adieu*, and (via Greek *Zeus*, same root) the whole sky-god family.

Grammar Lens: *adiós* is a *final* goodbye

adiós leans toward a **longer** parting — you won’t see them soon, or it’s the end of the day. For “see you later / tomorrow,” Spanish reaches for **hasta ...**, which the rest of this chapter is about — and *hasta* has a surprising origin.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*adiós*” — *ah-DYOHS*, stress the end
- *adiós* / *adieu* / *addio* / *adeus* — four “to God” farewells
- English “goodbye” = “God be with ye” — the same prayer

Before you move on

What two words hide inside *adiós*? (*a* + *Dios* — “to God.”) What English goodbye is built the same way? (*Goodbye* ← “God be with ye.”) Is *adiós* for a quick “see you soon”? (No — it’s the longer/final parting; *hasta ...* comes next.) Next: **hasta**, and a word Spain borrowed from Arabic.

12.2 hasta — “until,” and Spain’s Arabic centuries

Spanish says “see you later” as **hasta luego** — literally “**until** later.” So the key word is **hasta**, “until.” And *hasta* carries the single most important fact about Spanish’s history: **for nearly 800 years, much of Spain spoke Arabic.**

Sounds you’ll need

- **silent-h** — Spanish **h** is always silent: **hasta** = *AHS-tah* (no breath on the *h* at all). Stress the front.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hasta comes from Arabic **ḥattā**, “until, up to.” From **711 CE**, Muslim armies ruled much of the Iberian Peninsula — *al-Andalus* — and Arabic was the language of government, science, and poetry there for **centuries**, until 1492. Spanish absorbed roughly **four thousand** Arabic words in that time — more of its vocabulary than from any source except Latin itself.

Most of those loans are **nouns**, and you can spot a huge number by the frozen Arabic article **al-** (“the”) fused onto the front:

- **almohada** (pillow), **alcázar** (fortress), **alcalde** (mayor), **alfombra** (rug), **aduana** (customs), **álgebra**, **alcohol**.
- **azúcar** (sugar), **aceite** (oil), **naranja** (orange).

But **hasta** is rare and special: it is a **function word** — a preposition, part of the grammatical skeleton. Languages borrow nouns easily and grammar words almost never — so an Arabic *preposition* surviving in everyday Spanish shows how deep, how *intimate*, those centuries of contact were. (Its Latin rival *ad* “to”/*usque* “up to” simply lost.) You say a piece of al-Andalus every time you say goodbye.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hasta” — *AHS-tah*, silent h

- “hasta” then Arabic *ḥattā* — the same word, 1,300 years apart

Before you move on

What language is *hasta* from, and what does it mean? (Arabic *ḥattā* — “until.”) Why is it remarkable that Spanish borrowed it? (It’s a *function word* / preposition — languages almost never borrow those; it shows how deep the Arabic centuries went.) How do you spot many Arabic nouns in Spanish? (The frozen *al-* article: *almohada*, *azúcar*, *álgebra*.)

12.3 hasta aquí / hasta la noche — point to the limit

You know **hasta** means “until” or “up to.” Give that small word one spatial endpoint and one temporal endpoint, using only one new word.

Grammar Lens: endpoints in space and time

Aquí means **here**. Put it after **hasta**:

hasta aquí — up to here

For a time endpoint, reuse **la noche**, “the night,” which you already have:

hasta la noche — until the night / until tonight

The same preposition points to a place or the end of a stretch of time. The next lessons will place new time words after it one at a time.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “aquí” — here
- “hasta aquí” — up to here
- “hasta la noche” — until tonight

Before you move on

What does **hasta** point to? (**An endpoint.**) Give one spatial and one temporal example. (**Hasta aquí; hasta la noche.**) What is the only new lexical item? (**Aquí**, “here.”)

12.4 Leaving — putting it together

One farewell that is final, and one word that opens all the others.
Nothing new in this lesson — only what you already have.

The exchange

Adiós — meant, and a little final. **Hasta** — “until,” and it is waiting for what comes next.

What you’ve built

You can close a conversation, and you have the word every softer goodbye is built from.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the whole exchange, both parts, without stopping
- it again, faster, and let it sound like speech rather than recital

Twice through:

Before you move on

Run it once more from memory. If a word does not come, go back one lesson rather than pushing on — this chapter is short on purpose.

Chapter 13

Until When

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can pick the farewell that matches when I will next see someone.

Until When — the chapter run end to end.

13.1 hasta luego — the everyday “see you later”

This is the goodbye you’ll actually use most — friendly, casual, open-ended. **hasta luego**: “until later.” You already own **hasta** (“until”); today you add **luego** (“later”), and it has a very Latin backstory.

Sounds you’ll need

- diphthong-ue — **luego** = *LWEH-goh*: the *ue* is a *w*-glide, *lweh*-.
- The whole phrase: *AHS-tah LWEH-goh*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hasta luego = “until later” → “see you later.”

- **hasta** = “until” (last lesson — Arabic *ḥattā*).
- **luego** = “later / then / soon,” from Latin **loco**, “at the place / at that point.” The idea slid from *place* → *point in time* → “then, next, soon.” So its cousins in English are all about **place**:

local, locus, location, locate, al-loc-ate. Spanish moved *loco* from *where* to *when*.

A nice contrast: **hasta luego** fuses an **Arabic** word and a **Latin** word in three syllables — the two great layers of Spanish, shaking hands as you leave.

Grammar Lens: the “hasta ...” family

hasta + a time word is Spanish’s whole toolkit of soft goodbyes. You’ll build the other two this chapter:

phrase	“until ...”	when
hasta luego	later	the default “see you”
hasta mañana	tomorrow	leaving for the day
hasta pronto	soon	you expect to meet again shortly

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hasta luego” — *AHS-tah LWEH-goh*
- “luego” then English “local, location” — the *loco* “place” family
- “¡Adiós! ... no — ¡hasta luego!” — feel the difference: final vs. soon

Before you move on

What does *hasta luego* literally mean? (“Until later.”) What did *luego*’s Latin root *loco* first mean, and what English words keep it? (Place — *local, location, locus*.) Which two language layers meet in *hasta luego*? (Arabic *hasta* + Latin *luego*.) Next: **hasta mañana**.

13.2 hasta mañana — “see you tomorrow” (and the ñ returns)

Leaving for the day? **hasta mañana** — “until tomorrow.” It brings back a letter you studied in the writing lessons: the **ñ**. Here it is, living in a word you’ll say every evening.

Sounds you'll need

- enye-ny — **mañana** = *mah-NYAH-nah*: the **ñ** is the squished *ny* of “canyon” (your ñ writing lesson — the tilde is a tiny second *n*, remember). Three soft *ah*’s: *ma-ÑA-na*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hasta mañana = “until tomorrow” → “see you tomorrow.”

- **hasta** = “until” (Arabic *ḥattā*).
- **mañana** = “tomorrow” — **and** “morning.” One word for both, from Latin (**hōra**) **maneana**, “the **early** hour” (from *māne*, “in the morning”). The logic: the next “early hour” you’ll see is *tomorrow morning* → *mañana* came to mean both **morning** and **tomorrow**.

The ñ, in the wild. Recall the writing lesson: *ñ* is a frozen *nn* — a scribe’s shorthand for a doubled *n*. *mañana* comes from Latin *maneana*, whose *n+ea* palatalized (softened) into that single *ñ* sound. So the tilde is a little historical fossil sitting in the middle of “tomorrow.”

Grammar Lens: same word, two meanings — context decides

mañana means “morning” **or** “tomorrow”; the sentence tells you which. Paired with *hasta*, it’s always **tomorrow**: *hasta mañana*, “until tomorrow.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “mañana” — *mah-NYAH-nah*, squished *ñ*
- “hasta mañana” — until tomorrow
- “mañana” once as “morning,” then once as “tomorrow” — context decides

Before you move on

What two meanings does *mañana* carry? (Morning; tomorrow.) With *hasta*, which one? (Tomorrow.) What sound is the *ñ*, and what is its tilde, historically? (The *ny* of “canyon”; a frozen doubled-*n*.) Next: **hasta pronto**.

13.3 hasta pronto — “see you soon”

The last of the “hasta ...” trio: **hasta pronto**, “until soon” — for when you genuinely expect to meet again shortly. One new word, **pronto**, and it’s hiding in plain sight in English.

Sounds you’ll need

- **hasta pronto** = *AHS-tah PRON-toh* — a clean *pr*, a pure *o*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hasta pronto = “until soon” → “see you soon.”

- **hasta** = “until” (Arabic *ḥattā*).
- **pronto** = “soon / quickly / ready,” from Latin **promptus**, “brought forth, ready at hand” (from *prōmere*, “to bring out”). Something *prompt* is brought out **without delay** — so *pronto* slid to “soon.”

You already know its English twin: **prompt** (on time; to bring out a response), plus **prompter**, **promptly**, and the computer **prompt** (the cursor “ready” for input). Italian borrowed *pronto* too — it’s what Italians say when they pick up the phone (“*Pronto!*” = “Ready!”).

Grammar Lens: the “hasta ...” trio, complete

You now have Spanish’s three soft goodbyes, sharpest to vaguest in time:

phrase	until...	nuance
hasta pronto	soon	you'll meet again shortly
hasta luego	later	the neutral default "see you"
hasta mañana	tomorrow	you're parting for the day
...and adiós for the long or final goodbye.		

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hasta pronto” — *AHS-tah PRON-toh*
- “pronto” then English “prompt, promptly” — one family
- the trio — hasta pronto / hasta luego / hasta mañana

Before you move on

What does *hasta pronto* mean, and *pronto*'s English twin? (“Until soon”; *prompt*.) What Latin word is it from, and its literal sense? (*promptus*, “brought forth / ready.”) Order the three *hasta* goodbyes by time. (pronto → luego → mañana.) Next: put the whole farewell set together.

13.4 Practice — saying goodbye

No new words. This chapter's farewells — *adiós* and the three *hasta ...* goodbyes — now close a real conversation, and fold back into the whole arc you've built since *hola*.

Grammar Lens: choosing the right goodbye

The choice is about **when you'll meet again**:

you're...	say
parting for good / a long time	Adiós.
expecting to meet again shortly	Hasta pronto.
just “see you” (neutral default)	Hasta luego.
leaving for the day	Hasta mañana.

The exchange — start to finish

Everything from Chapters 1–5, in one conversation:

— ¡Hola! Buenos días. Me llamo Ana. ¿Cómo se llama usted?
 — Me llamo Luis. Mucho gusto. — ¿Cómo está usted? — Bien,
 gracias. ¿Y usted? — Bien. **Hasta mañana**, Luis. — **Hasta**
mañana, Ana. **¡Adiós!**

What you’ve built this chapter

- **adiós** — the plain/final goodbye (“to God”; twin of *goodbye*).
- **hasta** — “until,” Spain’s everyday Arabic word (← *ḥattā*).
- **hasta luego** / **mañana** / **pronto** — see you later / tomorrow / soon, each an Arabic + Latin handshake.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the full conversation above, both voices — greeting to goodbye
- pick the goodbye — for a friend you’ll see tomorrow? (*hasta mañana*); for someone moving away? (*adiós*)

Twice through: Run the whole exchange, *hola* to *adiós*, without stopping.

Before you move on

Which goodbye for someone you won’t see for a long time? (*Adiós.*)
 Which everyday word for “until” did Spanish take from Arabic? (*hasta.*) You can now open *and* close a conversation in Spanish.
 Next chapter: **por favor** and **gracias**’ partner courtesies, then into

everyday verbs.

Chapter 14

A Coffee, Please

Modes: 🗣️ voice (3) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask for something politely.

A Coffee, Please — the chapter run end to end.

14.1 café — coffee, and a place to drink it

Before you can make a polite request, you need one small thing to request. **Café** gives you a useful noun and lets the written accent do a job you already understand.

Sounds you'll need

Say **ca-FÉ**. A vowel-final word would normally stress the second-to-last syllable, so the acute accent records the unexpected final stress.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish **café** came through Italian **caffè** and Turkish **kahve** from Arabic **qahwah**. English **coffee** reached the same travelling word by a different European route. The drink and the word both crossed languages.



The route from Arabic qahwah through Turkish kahve and Italian caffè to Spanish café

Café can name the drink or the place, just as English **coffee** and **café** divide those jobs. It is masculine: **el café**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “café” — final stress
- “el café”
- the route — “qahwah → kahve → caffè → café”

Before you move on

Where does the stress fall? (**On the final é.**) Why is the accent written? (**It overrides the usual vowel-final stress.**) What route carried the word into Spanish? (**Arabic qahwah → Turkish kahve → Italian caffè → Spanish café.**)

14.2 por favor — “please,” i.e. “for a favour”

You can already thank (*gracias*) and reply (*de nada*). The third courtesy completes the set: **por favor**, “please” — literally “*for [a] favour*.” You’re asking someone to do you a kindness.

Sounds you’ll need

- **r-tap** — one soft tapped *r* in *por* and *favor*.
- **v-b** — Spanish *v* and *b* sound **identical** (a soft *b*): *favor* ≈ *fah-BOR*. (So *favor* and English *favour* look alike *and* the *v* even sounds like the *b* you’d hear in “harbour.”)

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **por** = “for / through / by,” from Latin **prō** (“for, on behalf of”) — the same *pro-* in English **pronoun**, **propose**, **protect**.

- **favor** = “a favour, goodwill,” from Latin **favēre**, “*to be favourable to, to support*.” It’s the very word English borrowed: **favour, favorite, favorable, favouritism**.

So *por favor* literally says “**for a favour**” — [*do this*] as a kindness to me. English **favour, favorite, and favorable** keep the same Latin family visible without asking you to learn another language’s formula.

Grammar Lens: the courtesy set is complete

You now hold the three pillars of politeness:

- **por favor** — please (asking).
- **gracias** — thank you (receiving).
- **de nada** — you’re welcome (replying).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “por favor” — *por fah-BOR*, soft *v/b*
- “Café, por favor” — “Coffee, please”
- “favor” then English “favour, favorite” — one family

Before you move on

What does *por favor* literally mean? (“For a favour.”) What Latin verb is *favor* from, and its English cousins? (*favēre* — favour, favorite, favorable.) Which three-word courtesy loop do you now own? (*Por favor* → *gracias* → *de nada*.) Next: your first regular verb — *hablar*, “to speak.”

14.3 Ordering — putting it together

Your first transaction: a thing you want, and the word that makes it a request. Nothing new in this lesson — only what you already have.

The exchange

— Un **café**, **por favor**. — Gracias.

What you've built

You can ask for something and stay polite doing it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the whole exchange, both parts, without stopping
- it again, faster, and let it sound like speech rather than recital

Twice through:

Before you move on

Run it once more from memory. If a word does not come, go back one lesson rather than pushing on — this chapter is short on purpose.

Chapter 15

When You Don't Understand

Modes: 🗣️ voice (3) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say that I did not understand, and ask for it more slowly.

The two sentences that rescue a conversation, and the thanks that closes it.

15.1 no entiendo — the most useful sentence a beginner owns

Everything so far assumed you understood what was said to you. This chapter is for when you did not.

What to know first

No entiendo. — “I don’t understand.”

Say it whole. You already have **no**; the rest comes with it for now, and the piece you are not yet meant to take apart will come apart later.

This is not an admission of failure. It is the sentence that keeps a conversation alive — the alternative is nodding at something you did not catch.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The word hiding inside *entiendo* comes from Latin **intendere** — literally *to stretch toward*. To understand something was to lean into it. English took the same word and kept it in several places: **intend** (to stretch your mind toward a thing), **intense**, and — through the same

family — **attention**, which is what you are stretching when you listen hard.

So *no entiendo* is, underneath, “I am not managing to stretch that far yet.” Which is exactly true, and much kinder than “I failed.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “No entiendo.” — calmly, not apologetically
- it again, to someone speaking too fast

Before you move on

Say it once from memory. Which English word shares its root?

15.2 más despacio — the request that makes the last sentence solvable

Everything so far assumed you understood what was said to you.
This chapter is for when you did not.

What to know first

Más despacio, por favor. — “More slowly, please.”

No entiendo stops the conversation. This restarts it. Together they are the whole repair kit: say what went wrong, then say what would fix it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Despacio comes from **de spatio** — “of space.” Latin **spatium** is English **space**, and also **spatial**.

Doing something *de spatio* meant doing it with room around it, unhurried. The sense drifted from space into time, which is a journey English made too: we still say we need *space* when we mean we need *time*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Más despacio.” — calmly, not apologetically
- it again, to someone speaking too fast

Before you move on

Say it once from memory. Which English word shares its root?

15.3 When you don’t understand — putting it together

Two sentences. Between them they rescue almost any conversation.

The exchange

— *(something too fast to follow)* — **No entiendo. Más despacio, por favor.** — *(again, slower)* — **Gracias.**

What you’ve built

Until now, a sentence you missed was the end of the conversation. It is not any more. You can say what went wrong and what would fix it, and then thank someone for doing it — which is the difference between speaking a language badly and not speaking it at all.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- both sentences, one after the other, without a pause between them
- them again, then “Gracias.” — the whole repair, start to finish

Twice through:

Before you move on

What do you say when you did not follow? And what do you ask for next? Which English words hide inside *entiendo* and *despacio*? (*Intend, intense, attention* — and *space*.)

Chapter 16

Your First Verb, and the Form That Means I

Modes: ⇄ voice (3) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I do, in one word, with no pronoun at all.

One word, one whole sentence — and why English cannot do the same.

16.1 hablar — “to speak,” which used to mean “to tell tales”

Fixed phrases got you this far. **Hablar** (“to speak”) is the first verb you will take apart and put back together. Today: the word itself. Next lesson: one ending, and it becomes about you.

Sounds you’ll need

- **silent-h** — the **h** is **completely silent**: *hablar* = *ah-BLAR*. (Spanish *h* never makes a sound.)
- **v-b** — the *b* is a soft *b*; *hablo* = *AH-bloh*.

That silent *h* is not an accident of spelling. Latin’s initial **f**- weakened in a whole set of Spanish words and eventually fell silent altogether, but the scribes kept writing a letter where it used to be — and that letter is **h**. You are looking at the gravestone of an *f*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hablar comes from Latin **fābulārī**, “to chat, to tell tales” — from **fābula**, “a story.” So *to speak*, in Spanish, is at root *to tell stories*. Notice Latin had a plainer verb available (*loquī*, “to speak,” which English keeps in **eloquent** and **loquacious**) — and Spanish chose the chattier, more colourful one.

That **fābula** is thoroughly English: **fable**, **fabulous** (“story-like”), **confabulate**, and **ineffable** (“un-speak-able”).

The single path you need today is **fābulārī** → **hablar**; later words will let you test how broadly that *f* → *h*- pattern reaches.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hablar” — *ah-BLAR*, silent *h*
- “hablar” then English “fable, fabulous, ineffable” — the *fābula* root
- the sound law — “fābulārī” then “hablar”

Before you move on

What Latin word is *hablar* from, and what English word shares it? (*Fābulārī* ← *fābula* — **fable**.) What happened to its initial Latin *f*-? (It weakened away, leaving the written but **silent** Spanish *h*-.) Next: swap the *-ar* for one letter, and *hablar* becomes *I speak*.

16.2 hablo — “I speak”

What is the word for “to speak”? (*Hablar*.) Say it once.

What to know first

- *hablar* — the verb, and the *fābula* behind it.

Grammar Lens: change the ending, change who is speaking

Hablar is the naming form — “to speak.” It is not yet about anybody. To make it about **you**, take off the **-ar** and put **-o** in its place:

hablar → **hablo** — *I speak*.

That is the whole operation. One ending, swapped.
And notice what you did not have to do: you did not add a word for *I*.
The **-o** is already carrying it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The **-o** is old and it is nearly untouched. Latin marked “I” on a verb with **-ō**, a long *o*: *amō*, “I love.” Two thousand years later Spanish still marks “I” with exactly that letter.

Most of Latin’s endings wore down on the way to Spanish. This one did not. When you say *hablo*, the last sound in your mouth is the same one a Roman used to say *I*.

Worth noticing. English gave up. *Speak* is *speak* whoever is doing it, which is why English cannot let go of its pronouns. You will meet that difference properly in the very next lesson.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hablo”
- “hablo” again, and hear that the *-o* is the part meaning *I*

Before you move on

How do you turn *hablar* into “I speak”? (Drop **-ar**, add **-o**.) Which Latin ending is that **-o**? (*-ō* — the same one.) Next: why *hablo* is already a complete sentence.

16.3 **hablo** — one word, one whole sentence

Say “I speak” in Spanish. (*Hablo*.) Now count the words you said.

Grammar Lens: the pronoun you never needed

One word. And it is a complete, ordinary, grammatical Spanish sentence.

English needs two — *I* and *speak* — because English's ending is doing no work. Spanish needs one, because the **-o** already said *I* in the previous lesson.

Spanish does have a word for *I*. You will meet it. But putting it in front of *hablo* is a little like saying “**I, I speak**” — the information is already there, and repeating it is something Spanish does only when it wants to make a point.

The habit to build now. When you want to say *I speak*, say **hablo**. Not two words. One.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

This is not Spanish being clever. It is English having lost something. Old English marked its verbs properly — *īc sprece*, *þū sprecest*, *hē spricþ*. Those endings were as distinct as Spanish's are. Then English wore them down until almost nothing was left: today *speak*, *speaks*, *speaking*, *spoke*, *spoken*. Four of the five are identical.

Once the endings stopped telling you who was speaking, the pronoun had to, and English could never put it down again. Spanish kept its endings. So Spanish kept the choice.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hablo” — one word, and stop there
- it as an answer to a real question, as if someone just asked whether you speak

Before you move on

How many words is “I speak”? (**One** — *hablo*.) What is the name for leaving the pronoun out? (**Pro-drop**.) Why can't English do it? (Its endings wore away, so only the pronoun is left to carry the person.) Next chapter: the same verb, aimed at somebody else.

Chapter 17

Talking to a Friend

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what a friend does, using the tu form of an -ar verb.

The -as ending, and the one English ending that survives beside it.

17.1 hablas — “you speak,” to someone you know

Say “I speak.” (*Hablo.*) How many words? (One.)

What to know first

- tú — the “you” for a friend, a peer, someone at ease with you.

Grammar Lens: one more letter, and it is about the other person

Last chapter the ending was **-o**, and it meant *I*.

Swap it for **-as** and the sentence turns around to face the person you are talking to:

hablar → **hablas** — *you speak.*

Same verb. Same operation — drop the **-ar**, add an ending. Only the ending changed, and with it, who the sentence is about.

This is *tú*’s form: a friend, a peer. And as before, you need no separate word for *you*. **Hablas** on its own is the whole sentence.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin marked *you* with **-ās**, and Spanish kept it whole: *hablās* → **hablas**.

Here is the piece worth holding on to. English has almost no verb endings left — but it does have one. **He speaks**. That lonely **-s**, the last ending standing in English, comes from the very same Latin-and-Germanic habit of putting an *s* sound on a verb to mark the person.

English kept one *s* and lost the rest. Spanish kept the whole set. When you learn *hablas*, you are learning the system English is down to its last piece of.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hablas”
- “hablo” then “hablas,” and feel the sentence turn from you to the other person

Before you move on

What is “you speak,” to a friend? (**Hablas**.) Which ending means *I*, and which means *you*? (**-o** and **-as**.) Which English ending is the last survivor of this system? (The **-s** in *he speaks*.) Next chapter: the same verb again, for *usted* — and for *he* and *she*.

Chapter 18

He, She, and the Polite You

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what someone else does, and address someone respectfully, with one form.

One form doing three jobs, and the vuestra merced fossil behind it.

18.1 habla — “he speaks,” and the polite “you speak”

Two forms so far. Which means *I speak*? (*Hablo.*) Which is *you speak*, to a friend? (*Hablas.*)

Grammar Lens: take the -s away again

Drop the **-ar**, add just **-a**:

hablar → **habla** — *he speaks, she speaks.*

That is the third form, and the third ending: **-o**, **-as**, **-a**.

Grammar Lens: the same form does a second job

Back when you met *usted*, you were told it takes the *he/she* form of the verb. Here is the first verb where you can actually see it happen.

usted habla — *you speak*, politely.

The same word, **habla**, covers *he speaks, she speaks*, **and** the respectful

you speak. Nothing extra to learn — it is one form doing three jobs, and that is a gift, not a complication.

Why? Because *usted* was never a word for *you* to begin with. It grew out of *vuestra merced*, “your grace” — and *your grace* is a **thing you talk about**, not a person you talk to. You would say “your grace **speaks**,” not “your grace speak.” The verb form is a fossil of that politeness.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin’s ending here was **-at**: *hablat*, “he speaks.” Spanish let the final **-t** fall away, as it let most final consonants fall away, and the bare **-a** is what was left standing.

French did the same thing and went further — it writes *parle* but the ending is now silent. Italian kept more: *parla*. Three languages, one Latin ending, three degrees of wear.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “habla”
- it for a friend’s brother, then for a stranger you are being polite to — same word both times

Before you move on

What is “he speaks”? (**Habla**.) Which form does *usted* take, and why? (**Habla** — because *usted* began as *vuestra merced*, “your grace,” something you talk *about*.) What did Latin’s **-at** lose? (Its **-t**.) Next chapter is a review — no new words at all.

Chapter 19

Review — The Three Forms Side by Side

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) ↔ Hands-free start: none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can hold all three singular -ar forms at once and choose between them without stopping.

The first paradigm table in the book, arriving only after all three of its cells are owned.

19.1 Review — the three forms, side by side

Nothing new in this chapter. Not one word. Say the three forms you already have, in any order they come.

Grammar Lens: the table you have earned

Three chapters, one form each. Now — and only now — they are worth seeing together:

who	ending	<i>hablar</i> →	meaning
I	-o	hablo	I speak
tú	-as	hablas	you speak (a friend)
él · ella · usted	-a	habla	he/she speaks · you speak (polite)

A table like this one at the *start* would have been three things at once

and you would have memorised it. Arriving here, it is a picture of something you can already do.

This is the whole engine. Every regular **-ar** verb in Spanish — and there are thousands — runs on these three endings. You have not learned one verb. You have learned the pattern that fits all of them.

What you've built

- Say what **you** do — *hablo*.
- Ask or state what a **friend** does — *hablas*.
- Say what **someone else** does, or address someone **politely** — *habla*.
- Do all three **without a pronoun**, because the ending carries it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all three in order — “hablo, hablas, habla”
- them out of order, as prompted: *she · I · a friend · politely*

Twice through: Until the ending arrives before you have to think about it.

Before you move on

Three endings — name them. (**-o, -as, -a.**) How many regular *-ar* verbs does this pattern fit? (**All of them.**) Next chapter you will not learn anything either — you will *use* this to say something you actually mean.

Chapter 20

Trabajar — Work, and the Torture Device Behind It

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I do for work with a second regular -ar verb.

tripalium, a three-stake device, is why work and travail are the same word.

20.1 trabajar — “to work,” and it once meant *torture*

A second **-ar** verb — snap it into the exact template you just learned. And *trabajar* has the darkest, best etymology in this chapter: it began as a word for **torture**, and it’s the secret origin of English **travel**.

Sounds you’ll need

- j-jota — the **j** is a raspy *h*-from-the-throat (the *jota*): *trabajar* = *tra-ba-HAR*.
- r-tap, b-soft — tapped *r*, soft *b*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

trabajar comes from Vulgar Latin **tripaliāre**, “to torture” — from **tripalium**, a Roman instrument of torture made of **three stakes** (*tri-* “three” + *pālus* “stake,” the root of English **pale** and **impale**).

The chain of meaning is grimly logical: *torture* → *torment* / *suffering* → *hard toil* → just **work**. And English took the very same word down a parallel road:

- **travail** — painful, laborious effort (and the pains of childbirth).
- **travel** — yes: journeying was once such an *ordeal* that “travail” (toil) became **travel** (to make a journey). Every time you *travel*, you’re etymologically being *tortured*.

So even plain **trabajo**, “I work,” hides the old idea of toil as torment — a dark little joke inside an everyday verb.

Grammar Lens: same -ar template

Drop **-ar**, add the ending — identical to *hablar*:

person	form	meaning
I (ending carries the subject)	trabajo	I work
tú	trabajas	you work
usted	trabaja	you (formal) work

Notice you didn’t learn a new ending — that’s the point. **One template, every regular -ar verb.**

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “trabajar” — *tra-ba-HAR*, raspy *j*
- “trabajo, trabajas, trabaja” — same endings as *hablo/hablas/habla*
- “trabajar” → travail → travel — torture became a journey

Before you move on

What did *trabajar* originally mean, and from what device? (“To torture,” ← *tripalium*, a three-stake tool.) What two English words come from the same root? (*Travail* and *travel*.) How do you say “I work”? (*Trabajo* — same *-o* ending.) Next: **estudiar**, “to study.”

Chapter 21

Estudiar — Studying Is Being Eager

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I study, with a third regular -ar verb and no new pattern.

studere, to be eager - the root under student, studio and studious.

21.1 estudiar — “to study,” and the eagerness inside it

Your third **-ar** verb. By now the pattern should feel automatic — that’s exactly what we want. *estudiar* also hides a nicer feeling than the classroom suggests: at root it means **eagerness**.

Sounds you’ll need

- **st-no-e** — Spanish props up *st-* with an *e*: **es-tudiar** (the same reflex behind *estar*, *España*, *escuela*). *es-too-DYAR*.
- **diphthong-io** — the *-iar* glides: *es-too-DYAR*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

estudiar comes from Latin **studēre**, “to be eager, to apply oneself zealously.” A *studium* was **zeal, enthusiasm, devotion** — only later “study.” So to *study* is, at heart, to *throw yourself eagerly* at something.

That **studēre** is everywhere in English:

- **student** — literally “one who is *eager*.”
- **studio**, **studious**, **study** — the place, the trait, the act.
- Italian **studio** and the musical *studio* keep the “devoted practice” sense.

So *Estudio español* is “I devote myself eagerly to Spanish” — a nicer picture than mere schoolwork.

Grammar Lens: the template holds

Drop **-ar**, add the ending — for the third time:

person	form	meaning
I (ending carries the subject)	estudio	I study
tú	estudias	you study
usted	estudia	you (formal) study

Three verbs, one pattern: *hablo*, *trabajo*, *estudio*. The singular regular **-ar** present is now reusable rather than memorized verb by verb.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “estudiar” — *es-too-DYAR*
- “estudio, estudias, estudia” — the now-familiar endings
- “estudiar” then English “student, studio” — the *studēre* “eagerness”

Before you move on

What did *studēre* originally mean? (“To be eager / apply oneself.”) Its English cousins? (Student, studio, studious.) Say “I study” — and notice it uses the same *-o* as *hablo* and *trabajo*. (*Estudio*.) Next: put a verb and a noun together into your **first real sentence**.

Chapter 22

Espanol, and Your First Built Sentence

Modes: 🗣️ voice (2) 🗋️ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the language and build a whole sentence from parts I chose myself.

Hispania to espanol, and the first sentence assembled rather than memorised.

22.1 español — the word for the language

You have practised writing this word's ñ. Now find out what is inside it — because *español* is not a Spanish-made word at all.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

español = “Spanish” — both the language and a Spaniard — from **Hispania**, the **Roman** name for the Iberian peninsula. The path *Hispania* → *hispaniolus* → *español* wore the word down, and there is the ñ again, exactly the *-ni-* squeeze you met in the writing lesson (*Hispaniolus* → *españ-ol*). Say it *es-pa-NYOL*.

Two footnotes worth having:

- English **Spanish**, **Hispanic** and **Hispania** are all the same root, so the English and Spanish names for the language are cousins, not translations of each other.
- *Hispania* itself may go back through Latin to a **Phoenician**

name for the coast, often read as “land of hyraxes” (or rabbits) — the Phoenicians having met an unfamiliar animal and reached for the nearest word they had.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “español” — *es-pa-NYOL*
- the path — “Hispania, hispaniolus, español”
- “español” then English “Hispanic” — same root

Before you move on

Where does *español* come from? (**Hispania**, the Roman name for Iberia.) What letter does its ending bring back, and from what Latin sequence? (**ñ**, from **-ni-** in *Hispaniolus*.) Next: put it behind a verb and build your first sentence.

22.2 Hablo español — your first real sentence

This is the moment this book has been building to. You take a **verb** you conjugated yourself and a **noun** you took apart yourself, and make a sentence **nobody handed you pre-assembled**.

What you’ve built — the sentence assembled

Snap two things you already own together:

Hablo (I speak, from *hablar*) + **español** (Spanish) =
Hablo español.

That is a complete, grammatical Spanish sentence, and notice what is **not** in it: no separate subject word. The *-o* of *hablo* already says “I” — the pro-drop you just learned, doing real work in a real sentence. Now swap the pieces and watch it generate:

- **Estudio español.** — “I study Spanish.”

- **Trabajo.** — “I work.”
- **¿Habras español?** — “Do you speak Spanish?” (the *¿ ?* pair opening and closing the question, as in the writing lesson).

Grammar Lens: languages go bare

One more thing missing from *hablo español*: **no “the,” no “a.”** After a verb like *hablar* or *estudiar*, a language name takes **no article** — *hablo español*, never *hablo el español*.

This matters because Spanish otherwise loves its articles far more than English does (*me gusta el café*, “I like coffee”). So this is a genuine exception you have to hold onto, and the rule of thumb is narrow: right after *hablar*, the language goes bare.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Hablo español” — *AH-bloh es-pa-NYOL*
- swap the verb — “Estudio español”, “Trabajo”
- ask it — “¿Habras español?” (raise the pitch; *¿* opens it)

Why it’s said this way

You met **no** long ago as the answer. It has a second job, and now you have a sentence to try it on: put *no* directly in front of the verb and the whole thing flips.

Hablo español → No hablo español.

That is all there is to it. English needs a helper — *do not* — and Spanish needs nothing: one small word, in front, and the sentence means its opposite.

Before you move on

Say “I speak Spanish,” then “I study Spanish.” (*Hablo español; estudio español.*) Why is there no separate subject word? (The *-o* ending carries “I.”) Why no “the” before *español*? (**Languages take no article** after a verb like *hablar*.) You just built a sentence from parts — that is the whole game from here.

Chapter 23

-cion — About Two Thousand Words, At Once

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) 🗉 Hands-free start: none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can turn an English -tion word into Spanish and know its gender without being told.

Complete ES-C56-cion: convert an English -tion word, give the gender, and say why the correspondence is a rule.

23.1 -ción — about two thousand words, at once

You have learned roughly twenty Spanish words so far. This chapter is going to hand you about two thousand more, and it is not a trick.

Sounds you'll need

- **ci-th-s** — *ci* is a soft sound: *th* in most of Spain, *s* across Latin America. *Nación* is *na-SYON* or *na-THYON*, never *na-KYON*.

Grammar Lens: an ending that translates itself

Spanish -ción is English -tion.

Not “often.” Not “sometimes.” As a rule:

nación → nation · *información* → information ·
educación → education *conversación* → conversation ·
nación → nation · *atención* → attention

Read those without the English column and you can still read them. **And every single one is feminine**, without exception — *la nación*, *la información*. One ending, one gender, no decision to make. That alone is worth the chapter: gender is the thing this book will otherwise ask you to learn word by word.

So: take almost any English word ending in *-tion*, swap the ending for *-ción*, and you have said something real. You will be right far more often than you are wrong, and when you are wrong you will still be understood.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The reason this works is not luck, and it is worth knowing so you trust the rule rather than half-trusting it.

Latin had an ending **-tiōnem** that turned a verb into a noun for the act of doing it. Spanish **inherited** it directly, wearing it down to *-ción*. English **borrowed** it — first from French after 1066, then straight from Latin for centuries afterwards — and kept it as *-tion*.

Same ending, two routes, and the routes did not change it much. That is why the correspondence is a rule and not a resemblance: these are not similar words, they are **the same word**, arriving from two directions.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “nación, información, educación” — hear the ending stay put
- an English *-tion* word of your own, converted

Before you move on

English *-tion* becomes? (**-ción.**) What gender? (**Feminine**, always.) And roughly how many words did that just give you? (About **two thousand.**) Next: another ending, and another twelve hundred.

Chapter 24

-dad — Twelve Hundred More

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can read a -dad word I have never met, and say why it looks less like its English partner.

Complete ES-C56-dad: convert university, read realidad unseen, and explain the uneven erosion.

24.1 -dad — twelve hundred more

-ción is -tion. Here is a second ending, and this one is harder to spot because the two languages wore it down by different amounts.

Sounds you'll need

- **d-soft** — the *d* between vowels is soft, close to English *th* in *this*: *ciudad* ends nearer -*dath* than -*dad*.

Grammar Lens: -dad is -ty

Spanish -dad (or -tad) is English -ty.

ciudad → city · *libertad* → liberty · *universidad* → university
realidad → reality · *dificultad* → difficulty · *sociedad* → society

This one does not announce itself the way -ción does. *Ciudad* and *city* do not look alike at a glance — but line the endings up and the rule is exact, and once you have seen it you cannot unsee it.

Feminine again, every time: *la ciudad, la libertad*. That is now two endings that carry their own gender, which between them cover a large slice of the abstract nouns in the language.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **-tātem** made a noun meaning *the quality of being* something. Spanish inherited it and wore it to **-dad**: the *t* softened to *d* between vowels, exactly as it does in the middle of *ciudad* today. English took it through French, where it had already worn much further — *-tātem* to *-té* to **-ty**.

So English is holding a shorter stub of the same ending. That is why this pair looks less alike than *-ción/-tion*: not a different relationship, just more erosion on the English side.

Which gives you a way to read the ones you have not met. See a Spanish word ending in *-dad* and you are looking at an abstract quality, and English almost certainly has the same word with a smaller tail.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ciudad, libertad, universidad” — the same tail three times
- “city, liberty, university” straight after, and hear the shorter tail

Before you move on

English *-ty* becomes? (**-dad**.) Gender? (**Feminine**.) And what does a *-dad* word always name? (**A quality** — the state of being something.) Next: an ending you can put on almost any adjective.

Chapter 25

-mente — With No Upper Limit

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can build an adverb from any adjective, and say why the adjective goes feminine first.

Complete ES-C56-mente: build *rapidamente*, explain the feminine step, and say what the word literally means.

25.1 -mente — with no upper limit

Two endings so far, and each was worth a fixed number of words.

This one has **no number**, because you can make it yourself.

Grammar Lens: -mente is -ly

Spanish *-mente* is English *-ly*.

rápidamente → rapidly · *claramente* → clearly ·
perfectamente → perfectly · *naturalmente* → naturally

And unlike the last two endings, this one is a **machine** rather than a list: take an adjective, put it in its **feminine** form, add *-mente*.

rápido → *rápida* → **rápidamente** *claro* → *clara* →
claramente

That feminine step looks arbitrary and is not — the next section says why. But the practical effect is that every adjective you ever learn comes with a free adverb, which is why this ending has no count attached. Its reach is however many adjectives you end up knowing.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

-mente is not an ending at all, historically. It is the Latin noun **mente**, “with a mind” — and *mente* is **feminine**, which is the whole explanation for that feminine adjective.

Latin said *clārā mente*, “with a clear mind,” and the adjective agreed with the noun because that is what adjectives do. Then the phrase fused, the noun stopped being a noun, and the agreement was left behind as a rule nobody could explain any more.

So *rápidamente* is, at the bottom, “**with a rapid mind.**” Every Spanish adverb in *-mente* is quietly a phrase about somebody’s state of mind.

English does exactly the same thing with a different body part. **-ly** is Old English *-lice*, from *lic*, “body, form” — so *clearly* is “in a clear form.” Two languages, two fused nouns, the same idea.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “rápido, rápida, rápidamente” — watch the feminine step
- “claramente” and hear “with a clear mind” underneath it

Before you move on

English *-ly* becomes? (***-mente***.) What do you do to the adjective first? (Make it **feminine**.) And why? (Because ***mente*** was a **feminine noun** meaning *mind*.) Next: the three of them together.

Chapter 26

Review — Three Endings

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the three endings, their partners, and which give gender for free.

Complete ES-C56-repaso-amigos: give the three pairs and distinguish a decoder from a machine.

26.1 Review — three endings

Nothing new here. Say the three endings and their English partners before you look.

What you've built

Spanish	English	gender	roughly how many
-ción	-tion	feminine	~2,000
-dad / -tad	-ty	feminine	~1,200
-mente	-ly	(adverb)	no limit

Three chapters. Between them they reach further than every vocabulary lesson in this book put together, and they will keep reaching for as long as you keep learning adjectives.

That is worth stating plainly, because it changes what you should expect from the rest of the book. **A Spanish course is not mostly a list of words.** A large part of it is a small number of rules that turn words you already own into words you can use — and you have just

been handed three of the biggest.

Grammar Lens: two kinds of ending

The three are not the same kind of thing, and the difference matters:

- **-ción** and **-dad** are **decoders**. They let you *read* a word you have never met. They have a fixed reach, because there are only so many English words with those endings.
- **-mente** is a **machine**. It lets you *build* a word nobody taught you, from any adjective you hold. Its reach is whatever your adjective vocabulary turns out to be.

Both kinds are worth having, and neither is a substitute for the other. A decoder gets you through a page; a machine gets you through a sentence you have to say yourself.

Your turn

- *Say it*: “nación, ciudad, rápidamente” — one of each

Twice through:

Before you move on

Three endings — name them. (**-ción**, **-dad**, **-mente**.) Which two are always feminine? (**-ción** and **-dad**.) Which one has no upper limit? (**-mente**.) Next: reading a sentence nobody taught you.

Chapter 27

Synthesis — Reading What You Were Never Taught

Modes:  voice (1)  Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can read a sentence containing words no lesson has taught me.

Complete ES-C56-sintesis-leer: read a four-new-word sentence and say what let you read it.

27.1 Synthesis — reading what you were never taught

You are about to read a sentence with four words in it that this book has never shown you. Read it before you read the explanation.

The exchange

*La **universidad** tiene una **reputación internacional**, **naturalmente**.*

Say it aloud. Then say what it means.

The university has an international reputation, naturally.

Now count what you were given. **Four of those words are new**, and you read all four:

- *universidad* — -dad is -ty.

- *reputación* — *-ción* is *-tion*.
- *internacional* — a plain friend; it needed no rule at all.
- *naturalmente* — *-mente* is *-ly*.

Three chapters of endings, and a sentence of adult Spanish came free.

Grammar Lens: what has actually changed

Something is different about this chapter and it is worth naming. Every other lesson so far has taught you a word or a form and then asked you to use it. This one asked you to read words **nobody taught you**, and you could, because a rule reaches further than a word. That is the shape of the rest of your Spanish, and it is worth expecting. You will keep learning individual words — there is no way around *casa* or *comer* — but the reading you can do will run far ahead of the words you were handed, as long as you keep collecting rules alongside them. **A warning that costs nothing.** These endings are reliable, not perfect. A few words wearing a familiar ending have drifted somewhere unexpected, and you will meet them later as **false friends** — memorable precisely because the rule is otherwise so dependable.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the whole sentence, twice
- the four new words alone, and name the rule that gave you each

Twice through:

Before you move on

How many words in that sentence were new? (**Four.**) What let you read them? (**Three endings.**) And what does that tell you about the rest of the book? (That **rules reach further than words** — collect both.)

Chapter 28

F to H — Why the H Says Nothing

Modes:  voice (1)  Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can decode an unfamiliar h- word by putting an f back, and say why the h is silent.

Complete ES-C57-f-a-h: say why the h is silent, name *hablar*'s English friend, and decode *hierro* unseen.

28.1 f → h — why the h says nothing

Since your first chapter you have known that the Spanish *h* is silent. You were told it as a fact. Here is the reason, and it turns the fact into a tool.

Grammar Lens: a letter standing on a grave

Where Spanish has a silent *h*-, Latin very often had an *f*-.

You already hold the proof. *Hablar* comes from Latin **fabulārī** — and English took the same root and kept the *f*: **fable**, **fabulous**.

hablar ← *fabulārī* → **fable**

The sound did not vanish overnight. Latin *f*- weakened to a breathy *h*, the breath faded, and eventually nothing was left — but the spelling had already settled, so Spanish went on writing a letter it had stopped saying. **The silent *h* is a gravestone.** It marks where a sound used to be.

Which makes it a decoder. Meet an unfamiliar Spanish word beginning with *h*-, put an *f* back, and look for the English:

Spanish	put the f back	English friend
<i>hijo</i>	<i>fijo</i> ← <i>filium</i>	filial, affiliate
<i>hierro</i>	<i>fierro</i> ← <i>ferrum</i>	ferrous, ferric
<i>harina</i>	<i>farina</i>	farinaceous
<i>higo</i>	<i>figo</i> ← <i>ficus</i>	fig
<i>hoja</i>	<i>foja</i> ← <i>folia</i>	foliage, portfolio

Not one of those five words has been taught in this book, and you can read all five.

Why it's said this way

Two honest limits, because a decoder you trust too far will mislead you. **Not every *h* is a dead *f*.** *Hola* is not, and *hasta* came from Arabic. **And not every Latin *f* became *h*.** *Fácil*, *fuerte* and *forma* kept theirs; the change left *f* alone before *ue* and *r*.

So this is a **lead**, not a guarantee. Put the *f* back and believe it when an English word appears.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hablar” then “fable” — the same word, one letter apart
- “hijo, hierro, hoja” and put the *f* back on each

Before you move on

Why is the *h* silent? (It stands where an *f* used to be.) What do you do with an unfamiliar *h*- word? (**Put the *f* back** and look for the English.) Is it always right? (**No** — a lead, not a guarantee.)

Chapter 29

Cl-, Pl-, Fl- to Ll-

Modes:  voice (1)  Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can try three Latin clusters on an unfamiliar ll- word and find the English cousin.

Complete ES-C57-ll: name llamar's cousins, give the three clusters, and decode llave.

29.1 cl-, pl-, fl- → ll-

Say “my name is.” (*Me llamo.*) That *ll-* is the second sound law of this book, and you have been using it since your third chapter without being told.

Grammar Lens: three clusters, one destination

Latin *cl-*, *pl-* and *fl-* all became Spanish *ll-*.

Llamar is Latin **clāmāre**, “to cry out.” English took the same root untouched: **claim**, **clamour**, **proclaim**, **exclaim**.

llamar ← *clāmāre* → **claim**, **clamour**

And it happened to all three clusters, which is what makes it a law rather than a one-off:

Spanish	from	English cousin
<i>llamar</i>	<i>clāmāre</i>	claim, clamour
<i>llave</i>	<i>clāvem</i>	clavicle, clef, conclave
<i>llover</i>	<i>plovere</i>	pluvial
<i>lleno</i>	<i>plēnum</i>	plenty, plenary
<i>llano</i>	<i>plānum</i>	plain, plane
<i>llama</i>	<i>flamma</i>	flame, inflammable

Three different starting points arriving at one sound is unusual, and it is useful precisely because it is untidy: an unfamiliar Spanish word in *ll-* has **three** English shapes to try, and one of them is very often right.

Why it's said this way

You now hold three sound laws, and they are not three facts. They are three instances of the same thing.

- *-ct-* → *-ch-* — *noctem* → *noche*, and English kept **nocturnal**.
- *f-* → *h-* — *fabulārī* → *hablar*, and English kept **fable**.
- *cl-, pl-, fl-* → *ll-* — *clāmāre* → *llamar*, and English kept **clamour**.

Every one has the same shape: **Spanish inherited the word and wore it down; English borrowed it later and left it closer to the Latin.** That is why the English cousin so often looks more Latin than the Spanish does, which feels backwards until you see why. So the laws are not trivia about the past. They are a **conversion table** between the Spanish in front of you and the English already in your head, and they will keep working on words no course will ever teach you.

Your turn

- *Say it:* “llamar” then “clamour”; “llave” then “clavicle”; “llama” then “flame”

Before you move on

Which three clusters became *ll*-? (*cl*-, *pl*-, *fl*-.) What is *llamar*'s English cousin? (**Claim.**) And why does the English usually look more Latin? (Spanish **inherited and wore it down**; English **borrowed it later.**)

Chapter 30

Es- — the Vowel Spanish Put in Front

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can strip the *e-* from a Spanish word beginning *es-* plus a consonant and recognise the English word underneath.

*Decode *estacion*, *estudiante* and *espacio* by taking the *e-* off the front.*

30.1 es- + consonant

Say “to be” — the one about how and where. (*Estar*.) Now say “to study.” (*Estudiar*.)

You have known both since your first chapters. Today they explain each other.

Grammar Lens: a word cannot start like that

Latin words beginning *s* + a consonant grew an *e-* in front.

Latin was happy to start a word with *st-*, *sp-* or *sc-*. Spanish was not — the mouth wants a vowel there — so it put one in.

stāre → **estar** · *studēre* → **estudiar**

Nothing was added to the meaning. A vowel was added to the *front*, because the alternative was a beginning Spanish could not say.

English borrowed the very same Latin words and never needed the vowel:

Spanish	from	English kept it bare
<i>estar</i>	<i>stāre</i>	state, stay, status
<i>estudiar</i>	<i>studēre</i>	study, student, studio
<i>escuela</i>	<i>schola</i>	school, scholar
<i>especial</i>	<i>speciālis</i>	special, species
<i>espíritu</i>	<i>spīritus</i>	spirit

So the rule runs in both directions, and the backwards one is the useful one: **take the *e*- off the front, and an English word is often standing there.**

Your turn

Take the *e*- off and say what you see.

Say these aloud:

- *estación* → **stación** → **station**
- *estudiante* → **studiente** → **student**
- *espacio* → **spacio** → **space**

Estación took two rules at once: the *e*- came off the front, and the *-ción* you learned seven chapters ago became *-tion* at the back. That is what these rules are for — they stack.

Why it's said this way

A word you would expect to fit, and it does not.

Español looks like a perfect example. It is not. Its *Es*- is not an added vowel — it is what is left of Latin ***Hispania***, whose *H* was already silent. *España* is *Hispania* with the *h* gone, not *spaña* with an *e* glued on.

So check before you claim one. The rule is about words that *began* with two consonants in Latin. When the *e* was there all along, there is nothing to take off.

Before you move on

Say the rule in your own words.

Then take the *e-* off *estilo* and say the English word you find.

(*Style.*)

Chapter 31

Synthesis — The Decoder

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can decode unfamiliar Spanish with three sound laws and three endings.

Complete ES-C57-sintesis-descifrar: decode hoja and lleno, read a two-ending phrase, and say what a word that resists every rule suggests.

31.1 Synthesis — the decoder

Four sound laws and three endings. Before the practice: what do you do with an unfamiliar word starting *h*-? One starting *ll*-? One starting *es*-?

What you've built

what you see	what to try	example
-ch-	Latin -ct-	noche → nocturnal
h-	put an <i>f</i> back	hijo → filial
ll-	try <i>cl</i> -, <i>pl</i> -, <i>fl</i> -	llave → clavicle
es- + consonant	take the <i>e</i> - off	escuela → school
-ción	-tion	nación → nation
-dad	-ty	ciudad → city
-mente	-ly	claramente → clearly

Seven rules, and between them they will get you through a great deal of written Spanish this book has no room to teach. They also **stack**:

estación gives up both ends at once.

Grammar Lens: what a decoder is not

Be exact about what you have, because overclaiming it will disappoint you at the worst moment. This is a **reading** tool, and mostly a first-guess one: it will not tell you how to say something, will not give you gender or conjugation, and will sometimes point at the wrong English word.

What it does is remove the feeling that an unfamiliar Spanish word is a wall. Usually it is not — it is a word you already know, wearing clothes you have learned to recognise. That change of expectation is worth more than any word in this chapter: it is what lets you read above your level and get most of it.

And when the decoder fails, that is information too. A word that resists every rule is usually from one of Spanish's non-Latin layers — Arabic, Basque, or the Americas — worth noticing precisely because it breaks a rule you hold.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the seven rules, in order
- “hoja, lleno, noche” and name the law behind each

Twice through:

Before you move on

How many rules do you now hold? (**Seven** — four laws and three endings.) What are they for? (**Reading**, mostly first guesses.) And what has really changed? (An unfamiliar word is **no longer a wall**.)

Chapter 32

Synthesis — The Same Conversation, Twice

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can hold one short conversation both warmly and respectfully, changing only the verb ending.

The register choice carried entirely by one letter - and now with something real to say.

32.1 Synthesis — the same conversation, twice

Nothing new in this chapter either. This one is for **using** what you have — because knowing three endings is not the same as choosing the right one while a real person waits for you to finish.

Grammar Lens: what the ending is really saying

You are going to hold one short conversation twice — once with someone your own age, once with someone you want to show respect to. The **words** barely change. What changes is **one letter on the end of one verb**.

That letter is the whole message. *Hablas* says *I am at ease with you*. *Habla* says *I am being careful with you*. English would need a change of tone, or a “sir.” Spanish does it with an **-s**.

The exchange — with a friend

— ¡Hola! Me llamo Ana. — Me llamo David. Mucho gusto. —
 ¿**Hablas** español? — Sí, **hablo** español. ¡Gracias!

The exchange, again — being polite

— Buenos días. Me llamo Ana. — Me llamo David. Mucho
 gusto. — ¿**Habla** usted español? — Sí, **hablo** español. Gracias.

One letter. *Hablas* became *habla*, and the whole exchange changed its temperature. Your own line — *hablo* — never moved, because *you* are still you in both conversations.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- version one, both parts, start to finish
- version two — and catch the single letter that moved

Twice through: Run whichever version is harder.

Before you move on

What is the *only* thing that changed between the two conversations? (**One letter** — *hablas* → *habla*.) Why did *hablo* stay the same? (Because it is about **you**, and you did not change.) What does choosing *habla* over *hablas* actually tell the other person? (That you are being **respectful** — the grammar is carrying the manners.)

Chapter 33

Putting the -ar Verbs to Work

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can use several -ar verbs in real sentences.

The -ar present tense in action across the verbs of the last chapters.

33.1 Practice — making sentences with -ar verbs

A milestone chapter: for the first time you're not reciting fixed phrases, you're **building sentences from a pattern**. Drill the three verbs through the endings until *hablo / hablas / habla* is automatic.

Grammar Lens: conjugate on command

Run each verb through the three singular jobs you know: the ending alone for **I** → **tú** → **usted**:

- **hablar**: hablo · hablas · habla
- **trabajar**: trabajo · trabajas · trabaja
- **estudiar**: estudio · estudias · estudia

Same three endings (**-o** / **-as** / **-a**) every time — that's the whole regular **-ar** present, singular.

The exchange — say something real

— ¿**Hablas** español? — **Hablo** español. — ¿**Estudias** español? — **Estudio** español. — **Café, por favor.** — ¡Gracias!
— De nada.

What you’ve built this chapter

- **por favor** — please (← “for a favour”), completing *gracias* / *de nada* / *por favor*.
- **the singular regular -ar pattern** — drop *-ar*, add **-o** / **-as** / **-a**: the template behind *hablar*, *trabajar*, and *estudiar*.
- **hablar** (← *fābula*, fable; the f→h law), **trabajar** (← *tripalium*, torture → travail/travel), **estudiar** (← *studēre*, eagerness → student).
- **Hablo español** — your first self-assembled sentence (pro-drop, no article).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- conjugate all three verbs for I / tú / usted, without stopping
- answer “¿Hablas español?” and “¿Estudias español?” about yourself
- request “Café, por favor” and run the full *gracias/de nada* loop

Twice through: Ask and answer “¿Hablas español? — Hablo español.”

Before you move on

What are the three singular *-ar* endings? (*-o* / *-as* / *-a*.) Give the “I” form of all three verbs. (*Hablo*, *trabajo*, *estudio*.) Why does *Hablo español* need no separate subject word? (The *-o* carries “I.”) You can now generate sentences — this book stops handing you phrases and starts handing you *rules*. Next chapter adds the *-er/-ir* verb families.

Chapter 34

Comer — the Second Verb Family, One Slot at a Time

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 👁️ eyes (1) 🦋 Hands-free start: first 4 of 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can use all three singular forms of a regular -er verb, having built each one separately.

The -er singular, earned a slot at a time - and the yo ending that never changed.

34.1 comer — “to eat,” and the second verb family

Last chapter you learned the **-ar** verbs. Spanish has two more families — **-er** and **-ir** — and here’s the good news: they’re **almost the same**. Meet **comer** (“to eat”), your first **-er** verb.

Sounds you’ll need

- **r-tap** — one soft tap: *ko-MER*.
- The *c* before *o* is a hard *k*: *comer* = *ko-MER*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

comer derives from Latin **comedere**, “to eat up” — **com-** (intensifier, “completely”) + **edere**, “to eat.” That **edere** is the twin of English **eat** (both from the same ancient root), and it feeds a small English family:

- **edible** — fit to be eaten.
- **comestible** — a fancy word for food (straight from *comedere*).
- English **eat** itself — the Germanic cousin of Latin *edere*.

Grammar Lens: one family over, and one ending already yours

Hablar ended in **-ar**. *Comer* ends in **-er**, and that single letter is what makes it a different family.

Here is the good news, and it is worth having before you meet a single new form: **the *yo* ending does not change**. *Hablar* gave *hablo*.

Comer will give *como*. The ending you already own works untouched. Only two slots in this family behave differently from the one you know, and you will meet them one at a time over the next three chapters — not here.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “comer” — *ko-MER*
- “comer” then English “edible, comestible, eat” — the *edere* family

Before you move on

What Latin verb is *comer* from, and its English cousins? (*Comedere* ← *edere* — edible, eat.) Which ending is the same in both families? (The ***yo*** ending, **-o**.) Next: the *yo* form — and it will cost you nothing.

34.2 como — “I eat,” and you already knew how

How do you say “I speak”? (*Hablo*.) And what is the verb for “to eat”? (*Comer*.)

Grammar Lens: the ending that did not change

Drop the **-er**, add **-o**:

comer → **como** — *I eat*.

That is the same operation and the same ending you used on *hablar*. A new verb family, and the *yo* slot cost you nothing at all. This is worth pausing on, because it is how most of the rest will go. Spanish's three families differ in **two** of their singular slots, never in the first one. Whatever the verb, "I" is **-o**. And as before, one word is the whole sentence: **como**. No pronoun.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

One warning, because this word is busy. **Como** is three things:

- **como** — *I eat*, the form you just built.
- **como** — *like, as*. (*Como tú* — "like you.")
- **cómo**, with the accent — *how?*, which you have used since your first conversations.

Same four letters, three jobs. The accent marks the question word; context sorts the other two. This is not a trap so much as a reminder that the accent in Spanish is doing real work.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "hablo" then "como" — the same ending, twice
- "como" alone, as a complete sentence

Before you move on

How do you say "I eat"? (**Como**.) Which slot never changes between verb families? (The **yo** slot — always **-o**.) What does *cómo* with an accent mean? (**How?**) Next: the slot that *does* change.

34.3 comes — "you eat," and the first real difference

Say "I eat." (*Como*.) Now say "you speak," to a friend. (*Hablas*.)

Grammar Lens: one vowel moves

In the *-ar* family, *tú* took **-as**. Here it takes **-es**:

comer → **comes** — *you eat*.

That is the whole difference. The **-s** that means *you* is still there, doing the same job it does in *hablas*. Only the vowel in front of it has moved from **a** to **e** — and it moved because the verb's own family vowel is **e**. The ending is agreeing with the family it belongs to. So you are not learning a new ending so much as watching a familiar one take on the colour of its surroundings.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin had *amās* for “you love” and *comedis* for “you eat” — different vowels in the ending, exactly as Spanish has now. The split is not a Spanish invention; it is inherited, and it is why the families exist at all. What every one of them kept, across two thousand years, is the **-s**. If a Spanish verb form ends in *-s*, it is talking to *tú*. That single rule will carry you through every tense in this book.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hablas” then “comes” — the same *-s*, a different vowel
- “como” then “comes” — and feel the sentence turn toward the other person

Before you move on

What is “you eat,” to a friend? (**Comes**.) What part of the ending is the same as in *hablas*? (The **-s**.) What changed, and why? (The vowel, to match the verb's own family.) Next: the last of the three.

34.4 come — “he eats,” and the polite “you eat”

Say “you eat,” to a friend. (*Comes*.) And what was the *usted* form of *hablar*? (*Habla*.)

Grammar Lens: take the -s off again

Drop the **-er**, add **-e**:

comer → **come** — *he eats, she eats*, and **usted come**, *you eat*, politely.

The relationship is the one you already know. In the *-ar* family, *hablas* became *habla* by losing its **-s**. Here *comes* becomes *come* the same way. And exactly as before, this one form does three jobs — *he*, *she*, and the respectful *you* — for the same reason it did last time: *usted* began life as *vuestra merced*, a thing you talk **about**.

Three slots, three chapters, and the shape of the family is now yours.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin's form here was *comedit*. Spanish let the final **-t** fall, precisely as it let it fall from *hablat* to give *habla*.

That is the useful part: the two families were not worn down by different forces. The same weather hit both. Which is why, once you know what happened to one, the other holds no surprises.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “habla” then “come” — the same move, one family over
- “come” for a friend's sister, then for a stranger you are being polite to

Before you move on

What is “she eats”? (**Come**.) How did it come from *comes*? (By losing the **-s**, exactly as *hablas* → *habla*.) What did Latin's *comedit* lose? (Its **-t**.) A short review closes this chapter; the third and last family follows.

34.5 Review — the -er family, all three

Nothing new. Say the three forms of *comer* you have built, in any order they come to you.

Grammar Lens: the table you have earned

Three slots, three lessons. Now they are worth seeing beside the family you already had:

who	-ar	-er	
I	-o	-o	<i>hablo</i> · como
tú	-as	-es	<i>hablas</i> · comes
él · ella · usted	-a	-e	<i>habla</i> · come

Read the middle two columns down and the whole *-er* family is one observation: **the *yo* slot is shared, and the other two swap a for e.**

That is the entire cost of a second verb family. Every regular *-er* verb in Spanish runs on it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “como, comes, come” straight through
- “hablo, como” · “hablas, comes” · “habla, come” — the two families in step

Twice through:

Before you move on

Give the three *-er* endings. (**-o, -es, -e.**) Which one matches *-ar* exactly? (The **yo** ending.) How many regular *-er* verbs does this fit? (**All of them.**) Next chapter: the third family, and it is the smallest change yet.

Chapter 35

Vivir — the Family That Costs Nothing

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can use the singular of a regular -ir verb, and say why it asked me to learn no new form.

In the singular the -ir endings ARE the -er endings; the families part company only in the plural.

35.1 vivir — “to live,” and the third family (that’s barely new)

The third and last verb family: **-ir**, and **vivir** (“to live”) is your first. Here’s the punchline — in the present tense, **-ir is almost identical to -er**. You’ve nearly finished learning the whole regular present.

Sounds you’ll need

- **v-b** — Spanish *v* = a soft *b*: *vivir* ≈ *bee-BEER*.
- **r-tap** — one tap on the final *r*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

vivir comes from Latin **vīvere**, “to live” — one of the most alive roots in English:

- **vivid** — “full of life.”
- **survive** (*super-vivere*, “to live beyond”), **revive** (“live again”).
- **vivacious**, **convivial** (“living together” — sociable), **viva!**, **vivarium**. (And *vita*, “life,” gives **vital**, **vitamin**.)

Grammar Lens: the family that costs nothing

The third family is the shortest lesson in this book, and it is short because of a fact rather than a shortcut.

In the singular, the *-ir* endings are the *-er* endings. Not similar. The same three:

vivo · vives · vive — *-o*, *-es*, *-e*, exactly as *como*, *comes*, *come*.

So the third family asks you to learn no new form at all. You already built these three endings one at a time in the last chapter; here they are, doing the same work on a different verb.

The two families do part company later, in the plural — and when they do, you will meet that difference on its own. It is not needed now, and mentioning it here would be borrowing trouble.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “vivir” — *bee-BEER*
- “como, comes, come” then “vivo, vives, vive” — identical endings
- “vivir” then English “vivid, survive, revive” — the *vivere* family

Before you move on

What Latin verb is *vivir* from, and two English cousins? (*vivere* — vivid, survive.) In the singular, how do *-er* and *-ir* endings compare? (They are **identical**: *-o* / *-es* / *-e*.) Say “I live.” (*Vivo*.) Next: a second verb in this family, and two words for asking questions.

Chapter 36

Beber, and Two Ways to Ask

Modes: ⇄ voice (4) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I drink, and ask what and where with *que* and *donde*.

A second -er verb that needs no new pattern, and the two question words that turn the forms outward.

36.1 beber — “to drink,” and the pattern is yours

One more **-er** verb to make the pattern automatic — **beber**, “to drink.” Pair it with *comer* and you can talk about eating and drinking, the heart of any café or restaurant.

Sounds you’ll need

- **v-b** — both *b*’s are the soft Spanish *b*: *be-BER*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

beber comes from Latin **bibere**, “to drink” — a thirsty little root that soaked into English:

- **beverage** — a drink (via Old French *beverage*, from *bibere*).
- **imbibe** — to drink in (*in-* + *bibere*).
- **bibulous** — fond of drinking; **bib** — the cloth that catches drips; even **beer**’s cousins hover nearby.

Grammar Lens: no new grammar — that’s the point

beber is a regular **-er** verb, so it takes the endings you already own:

| yo | **bebo** | I drink |

| tú | **bebes** | you drink |

| él/ella/usted | **bebe** | he/she drinks / you (formal) drink |

Nothing new to learn — you’re just *reusing the machine*. With the word *café* from the previous chapter, you can already say:

Bebo café. — “I drink coffee.”

One new verb, one known noun, one sentence you built yourself.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “beber” — *be-BER*
- “bebo, bebes, bebe” — the familiar *-o/-es/-e*
- “Bebo café” — “I drink coffee”

Before you move on

What Latin verb is *beber* from, and its English cousins? (*bibere* — beverage, imbibe.) Did *beber* need any new endings? (No — it’s a regular *-er* verb.) Say “I drink.” (*Bebo*.) Next: start **asking** — *qué*, “what?”

36.2 qué — “what”, a new question word

You already know the question word *cómo*; now ask about a thing. The new question word is **qué**, “what” — and it puts to work two things from your writing chapter: the **accent** and the *¿* ?.

Sounds you’ll need

- k-hard — **qu** is a plain hard **k** (the *u* is silent): *qué* = *keh*.
- accent-mark — the **accent on é** marks this as the *question*

word (recall the diacrítica: *qué* = “what?”; *que* = “that”).
Question words wear the accent.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

qué comes from Latin **quid**, “*what*” — the neuter of *quis*, “who.” It’s a small function word with a few learned English descendants:

- **quiddity** — the “what-ness,” the essence of a thing.
- **quid pro quo** — “*what* for *what*,” this for that.
- the *qu-* question family it heads in Spanish: *qué*, *quién* (who), *cuál* (which) — Latin’s *qu-* interrogatives, the same *wh-* instinct as English (Latin *qu-* and English *wh-* are ancient cousins).

Grammar Lens: asking with a verb you know

Put **qué** in front of a verb, wrap it in **¿** ?, and you have a real question:

¿Qué comes? — “What are you eating? / What do you eat?”
¿Qué bebes? — “What are you drinking?”

Remember the opening **¿** (from the writing lesson) warns the reader a question is coming; the accent on *qué* marks it as the question word. Answer with the verb you already conjugate and a noun you already know: *Bebo café.* (“I drink coffee.”)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “qué” — *keh*, silent *u*
- “¿Qué comes?” / “¿Qué bebes?” — ask with verbs you know
- “qué” vs “que” — the accent marks the *question*

Before you move on

What Latin word is *qué* from? (*quid* — quiddity, quid pro quo.)
Why does *qué* carry an accent? (It’s the *question* word; *que* without

= “that.”) Ask “what are you eating?” (*¿Qué comes?*) Next: asking **where** — *dónde*.

36.3 dónde — “where?”

One more question word, and one more real question you can build: **dónde**, “where?” Pair it with *vivir* and you can ask the single most common getting-to-know-you question: *where do you live?*

Sounds you’ll need

- **d-soft** — the middle *d* is soft, near the *th* of *this*: *DON-deh*.
- **accent-mark** — like *qué*, the **accent on ó** marks the question word (*dónde* = “where?”; *donde* without = “where,” a relative — “the place *where*”).

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

dónde comes from Latin **de unde**, literally “*from whence*.” *unde* meant “from where,” and Spanish glued *de* onto the front and wore the pair down to *dónde*. (English once had the matching set *whence* / *where* / *whither* — “from where / at where / to where”; Spanish keeps that flavour in *de dónde* “from where”, *dónde* “where”, *adónde* “to where”.)

Grammar Lens: your first getting-to-know-you questions

Two question words + verbs you own = real conversation:

¿Dónde vives? — “Where do you live?” → *Vivo en Madrid*. **¿Dónde trabajas?** — “Where do you work?”
¿Qué estudias? — “What do you study?”

Notice the little **en** (“in,” ← Latin *in*) in the answer — the first preposition, slipping in exactly where you need it. You’re now trading real questions and answers, not fixed phrases.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “dónde” — *DON-deh*, soft *d*
- “¿Dónde vives?” — “Where do you live?”
- answer — “Vivo en ...” with your city

Before you move on

What Latin phrase is *dónde* from, and what did it mean? (*De unde* — “from whence.”) Why the accent? (It marks the *question* word.) Ask “where do you live?” and answer it. (¿*Dónde vives?* — *Vivo en* ...) Next: put the questions and verbs together in practice.

36.4 Practice — asking real questions

You now have all three verb families **and** two question words. This is where it becomes a conversation: you can **ask** and **answer**, not just recite. Drill until the questions come without thinking.

Grammar Lens: three singular patterns

Conjugate *yo* → *tú* → *él/ella* — feel how little differs:

- **-ar** *hablar*: hablo · hablas · habla
- **-er** *comer*: como · comes · come
- **-ir** *vivir*: vivo · vives · vive

Endings: *-ar* → *-o/-as/-a*; *-er* and *-ir* → *-o/-es/-e* in these three singular forms. The plural forms can wait.

The exchange — use only what you know

— ¿**Dónde** vives? — **Vivo** en Sevilla. ¿Y tú? — **Vivo** en México. — ¿**Qué** estudias? — **Estudio** español. ¿**Qué** bebes? — **Bebo** café.

What you've built this chapter

- **comer** / **beber** (-er), **vivir** (-ir) — the two remaining verb families; singular endings **-o** / **-es** / **-e**.
- **qué** (← *quid*) and **dónde** (← *de unde*) — your first question words, each wearing the **accent** and opening with **¿**.
- **Real questions:** *¿Qué comes?* *¿Dónde vives?* *¿Dónde trabajas?* — and the first preposition, **en** (“in”), in the answers.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- conjugate all three families, yo/tú/él, back to back
- ask a friend where they live and what they drink; answer both
- ask what they study; answer “Estudio español”

Twice through: “¿Dónde vives? — Vivo en ... ¿Y tú?”

Before you move on

What are the singular endings for *-er/-ir* verbs? (*-o* / *-es* / *-e*.)
 Give the “I” forms of *comer*, *vivir*, *beber*. (*Como*, *vivo*, *bebo*.) Ask
 “what do you study?” and “where do you live?” (*¿Qué estudias?*
¿Dónde vives?) You can now hold a simple back-and-forth — this
 book is fully in sentence territory. Next: **numbers** (uno, dos, tres)
 and telling someone your age and phone.

Chapter 37

Synthesis — Asking, and Answering

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can hold a short exchange about what someone drinks and where they live, using all three verb families.

Three families and two question words, and every word in the dialogue self-built.

37.1 Synthesis — asking, and answering

Nothing new in this chapter. Say “I eat” and “I live.” (*Como. Vivo.*)

What you’ve built

Something quietly enormous happened over the last four chapters, and it is worth saying out loud before you use it.

Spanish has **three** verb families. You now hold the singular of all three. That is not three facts — it is a machine: hand it any regular verb you meet for the rest of your life, and you can already say what you do with it, what a friend does, and what somebody else does.

Two question words turn that machine outward. **¿Qué?** asks *what*. **¿Dónde?** asks *where*. With them, the forms stop being an exercise and start being a conversation.

The exchange

— ¿**Qué** bebas? — **Bebo** café. ¿Y tú? — Yo también. ¿**Dónde** vives? — **Vivo en** Madrid.

Four lines, and every single word in them is something you built yourself. No new vocabulary was needed to get here — only the endings, one slot at a time.

Notice what the questions cost: nothing. You did not learn a question *form*. You put **¿qué?** or **¿dónde?** in front of a verb you already had.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the exchange above, both parts, without stopping
- it again, swapping in *comes* for *bebas*

Twice through: Run it until the question and the answer arrive together.

Before you move on

How many verb families do you hold? (**Three** — and that is all of them.) What did the question words cost you? (**Nothing** — they sit in front of forms you already had.) Ask where somebody lives. (¿*Dónde vives?*)

Chapter 38

Hablamos — the First Form That Is Not About One Person

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what we do, with the -amos ending.

-mos is Latin's -mus, barely changed in two thousand years.

38.1 hablamos — “we speak”

Say “I speak”, then “you speak” to a friend. (*Hablo. Hablas.*)

Grammar Lens: the first form that is not about one person

Every verb form you have met so far — in every tense — has been about **one** person. That changes here.

Drop the **-ar**, add **-amos**:

hablamos — *we speak*.

One word again, no pronoun, and now it covers you and somebody else. This is the form you will reach for constantly and have not had: *we speak, we work, we study*. Everything you could say about yourself, you can now say about a group you belong to.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The **-mos** is remarkable for how little happened to it.

Latin marked *we* with **-mus**: *amāmus*, “we love”. Spanish says *-mos*.

One vowel changed in two thousand years, and nothing else — no consonant lost, no syllable worn away, no analogy pulling it out of shape.

Compare what became of the third person, which lost its **-t** entirely (*hablat* → *habla*). Endings do not decay at the same rate, and this one barely decayed at all.

And Portuguese and Italian kept it too — *falamos*, *parliamo*. If you ever meet another Romance language, *-mos* or *-mo* will be waiting for you, doing the same job.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hablo” then “hablamos” — one person, then a group
- “hablamos” alone, and notice it is still a whole sentence

Before you move on

How do you say “we speak”? (**Hablamos.**) Which Latin ending is that? (**-mus**, almost unchanged.) How many words? (**One** — still no pronoun.) Next: the form for *them*.

Chapter 39

Hablan — They, and Ustedes

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what they do, and address any group as ustedes.

ustedes is vuestras mercedes - so it takes the they form for the same reason usted takes the he form.

39.1 hablan — “they speak,” and “you all speak”

Say “we speak.” (*Hablamos.*) And what was the form for *he speaks?* (*Habla.*)

Grammar Lens: add the plural -n

Take *habla*, the form for one other person, and add **-n**:

hablan — *they speak.*

That is the whole operation, and it is the same one Spanish uses everywhere: a final **-n** on a verb means the subject is plural and is not you.

Grammar Lens: the form does a second job, exactly as *habla* did

ustedes — *you all.* And it takes **hablan**, the *they* form. You have seen this exact move before. *Usted* takes the *he/she* form because it grew out of *vuestra merced*, “your grace” — a thing you talk

about. Ustedes is simply that phrase made plural, *vuestras mercedes*, “your graces”. Same origin, same consequence.

Where this is the ordinary word. Across all of Latin America, and in the Canary Islands and parts of Andalusia, **ustedes** is how you address *any* group — friends, family, strangers alike. There is no separate familiar plural. For most Spanish speakers alive, this lesson is the complete answer to “how do I talk to more than one person?”

Spain uses a different word for friends, and it has the next chapter to itself.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “habla” then “hablan” — one other person, then several
- “ustedes hablan”, addressing a group you have just met

Before you move on

What is “they speak”? (**Hablan.**) What does a final **-n** on a verb tell you? (The subject is **plural**, and not you.) And who does *ustedes* address in Latin America? (**Any** group at all.) Next: the word Spain uses instead, for friends.

Chapter 40

Habláis — the Form Spain Keeps

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can recognise the *vosotros* form and say where it is used.

vos + otros, added in Spain to keep the plural apart from a singular vos the Americas kept instead.

40.1 habláis — the form Spain keeps

How do you say “you all speak” to a group in Mexico? (*Ustedes hablan.*)

Grammar Lens: a second plural you

In Spain, addressing a group of **friends** uses a different word and a different verb form:

vosotros habláis — *you all speak*, informally.

vosotros — *you all*, familiar. Its ending is **-áis**, and it is the last of the six.

This is not an ornament. In Spain it is the ordinary, everyday way to speak to more than one friend, and a Spaniard hears *ustedes* to a group of friends as oddly formal — roughly as an English speaker hears *sir* from someone they know well.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

You met **vos** long ago: Latin's *plural* you, which drifted into the singular across much of the Americas.

That drift left Spain with a problem. If *vos* was being used for one polite person, what was left for an actual group? Spaniards added a word to disambiguate: **vos + otros**, “you **others**” — hence *vosotros*, and its feminine *vosotras*.

The Americas never needed the repair, because *ustedes* had already taken the plural job. So the split is not a difference of taste. **Two regions solved the same problem in two different ways**, and both solutions are still in use.

What you owe this form. Recognition, at minimum — you will meet it in every book, film and song from Spain. Produce it if you are learning for Spain; otherwise *ustedes* will carry you anywhere.

Your turn

- [YOU HEAR: “habláis”] → a Spaniard, talking to friends.
- *Say it*: “ustedes hablan” then “vosotros habláis” — the same sentence, two continents

Before you move on

What is *vosotros* built from? (**Vos + otros** — “you others”.) Why did Spain need it and the Americas not? (Because *vos* had drifted singular in the Americas, where *ustedes* already covered the plural.) Which will carry you anywhere? (**Ustedes.**)

Chapter 41

Review — the Whole Present Tense

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can produce all six present-tense forms of a regular -ar verb.

The first complete paradigm in the book - withheld for thirty-two chapters until every box in it was earned.

41.1 Review — the whole thing, at last

Nothing new in this chapter. Say “we speak”, then “they speak.”

Grammar Lens: the table this book has been withholding

Six forms. Every one of them built separately, on its own, in its own lesson.

who	<i>hablar</i> →
yo	hablo
tú	hablas
él · ella · usted	habla
nosotros	hablamos
vosotros (<i>Spain</i>)	habláis
ellos · ellas · ustedes	hablan

Most Spanish courses open with this table. This one has spent thirty-two chapters refusing to show it, because a table you cannot yet

fill is a picture of work still to do, and a table you can fill is a picture of ground you hold.

Read it now and there should be no surprises in it. That is the point.

And it is not one verb. Every regular *-ar* verb in Spanish — thousands of them — runs on these six endings, so this table is the present tense of a large part of the language.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all six in order, top to bottom
- them out of order, as prompted: *they · we · I · a friend*

Twice through: Until the whole set runs without a gap in it.

Before you move on

Give all six endings. (**-o, -as, -a, -amos, -áis, -an.**) How many regular *-ar* verbs does this fit? (**All of them.**) And why did the table wait until now? (Because every box in it had to be yours first.)

Chapter 42

Synthesis — the Same Sentence, Two Continents

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can choose between vosotros and ustedes by where I am, and say that neither corrects the other.

The first choice in this book decided by geography rather than meaning.

42.1 Synthesis — the same sentence, two continents

Nothing new here. Say *hablan*, then *habláis*.

Grammar Lens: a choice that is not about grammar

Every other choice this book has asked you to make has been about **meaning**. *Tú* or *usted* — how close are you to this person? *El* or *un* — does your listener already know which one you mean?

This one is different. It is about **where you are**.

— ¿**Habláis** español? — *asked in Madrid, to friends.* —

¿**Hablan** ustedes español? — *asked in Bogotá, to the same friends.*

Identical meaning. Identical register. The speaker chose by geography, and nothing else.

What you've built

This matters more than a regional footnote, because it settles what “correct Spanish” means in this book.

Neither of those sentences is the correction of the other.

Roughly 40 million people use *vosotros* daily; several hundred million have never used it in their lives and never will. A course that taught only *ustedes* would leave you unable to follow a Spanish film. One that taught only *vosotros* would leave you sounding strange in nineteen countries.

So you learn both, and you learn *which is which* — which is exactly what you have just done across four chapters.

If you must pick one to produce: **ustedes**. It is understood everywhere, Spain included, and in the Americas it is the only option.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the Madrid version, then the Bogotá version
- the one you would actually use, and say why

Twice through:

Before you move on

What decides between *habláis* and *hablan*? (**Where you are** — not what you mean.) Which is correct? (**Both.**) And which one will carry you everywhere? (**Ustedes hablan.**)

Chapter 43

Where -er and -ir Part Company

Modes: 🗣️ voice (2) 🗋️ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what we eat and what we live, and explain why the singular hid the difference.

comemos and vivimos: one vowel apart, audible only because the ending is stressed.

43.1 comemos — “we eat”

Say “we speak.” (*Hablamos.*) And “I eat.” (*Como.*)

Grammar Lens: the same -mos, a different vowel

Drop the -er, add -emos:

comemos — *we eat.*

The **-mos** is the one you already have from *hablamos*. Only the vowel in front of it changed, from **a** to **e** — and it changed for the reason it always does: the ending takes the colour of its family.

That is the pattern for every plural ending you will meet. **-mos** and **-n** never change. The vowel before them does.

Something is about to happen that has not happened before. In the singular, -er and -ir were **identical** — *como/comes/come* and *vivo/vives/vive*, the same three endings twice over. That was a genuine saving,

and it is about to stop. The next lesson is where the two families finally part.

Your turn

- *Say it:* “hablamos” then “comemos” — the same *-mos*, a different vowel

Before you move on

What is “we eat”? (**Comemos.**) Which part of a plural ending never changes? (The **-mos.**) And what has been true of *-er* and *-ir* until now? (They were **identical** — which the next lesson ends.)

43.2 vivimos — where the two families part

Say “we eat.” (*Comemos.*) And “I live.” (*Vivo.*)

Grammar Lens: the saving ends here

Drop the **-ir**, add **-imos**:

vivimos — *we live.*

Not *vivemos*. **Vivimos.**

This is the first form in the whole book where *-er* and *-ir* do not match. For every singular form you learned, the two families shared endings exactly — and you were told that saving would end in the plural. This is where.

comemos — we eat. · **vivimos** — we live.

One vowel apart, and it is each family’s own vowel: the **e** of *comer*, the **i** of *vivir*. The families were never really the same; the singular endings simply happened to fall out identically.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Why did the singular hide the difference and the plural expose it? Stress. In *vivo*, *vives*, *vive*, the stress is on the **stem** and the ending is unstressed — and unstressed vowels wear toward each other until they

are indistinguishable. In *vivimos*, the stress lands on the **ending itself**, and a stressed vowel keeps its own quality.

So the families did not diverge here. They were always distinct, and the plural is simply the place where the stress lets you hear it.

Your turn

- *Say it*: “comemos” then “vivimos” — and hear the one vowel that separates them

Before you move on

What is “we live”? (**Vivimos**.) Why was the difference invisible in the singular? (The ending was **unstressed**, so the vowels wore together.) And what makes it audible here? (The **stress** falls on the ending.)

Chapter 44

Comeis and Vivis

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can recognise both *vosotros* forms and say that they are the second and last difference.

Latin's -tis, collapsed two ways: -eis for one family, -is for the other.

44.1 coméis and vivís — the second difference, and the last

Which form goes with *vosotros* for *hablar*? (*Habláis.*) And where is that word used? (*Spain.*)

Grammar Lens: two families, two endings, one lesson

coméis — *you all eat.* · **vivís** — *you all live.*

These two are taught together, and it is worth saying why, because this book has otherwise insisted on one form per lesson.

You already know the fact they demonstrate. The *-er* and *-ir* families differ in exactly **two** slots — *nosotros*, which you met last chapter, and *vosotros*, which is this one. Learning them apart would teach the same single fact twice and hide the pattern that makes it easy.

And after this, the two families agree again. *They eat* and *they live* take the same ending, as every singular form did.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Both descend from Latin's **-tis**: *comeditis*, *vīvitis*. Spanish lost the **-t-** between vowels — as it lost most of them — and what was left collapsed differently in each family. The *-er* line kept two vowels, **-éis**. The *-ir* line kept one, **-ís**.

Same ending, same erosion, two outcomes. That is most of what sound change looks like.

Your turn

- [YOU HEAR: “coméis”, “vivís”] → a Spaniard, addressing friends.
- *Say it*: “comemos, coméis” then “vivimos, vivís” — the two differing slots, side by side

Before you move on

Give both *vosotros* forms. (**Coméis, vivís.**) In how many slots do the two families differ? (**Two** — and you have now met both.) What Latin ending is behind them? (**-tis.**)

Chapter 45

Comen and Viven — Agreeing Again

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what they eat and what they live, with one ending shared by both families.

After two chapters apart the families fall back into step and stay there.

45.1 comen and viven — agreeing again

What is “they speak”? (*Hablan.*) And who else does that form address? (*Ustedes.*)

Grammar Lens: one ending for both

Both families take **-en**:

comen — *they eat, ustedes eat.* **viven** — *they live, ustedes live.*

No split here. After two chapters of divergence the families fall back into step, and they stay there.

That is the shape of the whole system, and it is worth holding as one sentence:

-er and **-ir** are identical in four of the six slots.
They differ only in *nosotros* and *vosotros*.

Two exceptions in a system of twelve forms. You have now met both, and everything else you already knew.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “comen, viven” — one ending, both families
- “ustedes comen”, addressing a group

Before you move on

Give *they eat* and *they live*. (**Comen, viven.**) In how many of the six slots do the two families agree? (**Four.**) Next chapter: all three families, whole.

Chapter 46

Review — the Present Tense, Whole

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) 🔄 Hands-free start: none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can conjugate any regular Spanish verb in the present, in any of the three families.

Eighteen forms, every one built separately before it appeared in the grid.

46.1 Review — the present tense, whole

Nothing new in this chapter. Say “we eat” and “we live.”

Grammar Lens: eighteen forms, and you built each one

who	-ar	-er	-ir
yo	hablo	como	vivo
tú	hablas	comes	vives
él · ella · usted	habla	come	vive
nosotros	hablamos	comemos	vivimos
vosotros	habláis	coméis	vivís
ellos · ustedes	hablan	comen	viven

This is the present tense of the Spanish language. Not a summary of it, not the regular part of it with exceptions pending — every regular verb in Spanish sits in that grid, and there are thousands

of them.

Two things are worth reading off it before you close the chapter:

- **The *yo* row is the same in all three families.** It always was. That is why the second and third families cost so little when they arrived.
- ***-er* and *-ir* differ in exactly two boxes — *nosotros* and *vosotros*. Four of their six forms are identical.**

So the whole grid is really one set of endings with a family vowel, plus two exceptions. That is the shape you have actually learned.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- one column straight down — *hablar*, all six
- one row straight across — *nosotros*, all three families

Twice through: Down a column, then across a row, until neither direction stalls.

Before you move on

How many forms are in the grid? (**Eighteen** — three families, six each.) Which row never varies? (***Yo***.) And how many boxes separate *-er* from *-ir*? (**Two**.)

Chapter 47

Numbers, and How Old You Are

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🗋️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can count from one through ten and use singular forms of *tener* to ask and answer age with a number I know.

*Count from one through ten, move among *tengo*, *tienes*, and *tiene*, then ask and answer age with the number frame taught in the chapter.*

47.1 uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco — counting to five

Numbers are among the most reusable words in any language. Spanish keeps them close enough to Latin that English cousins can help you remember them. This lesson asks for only **five**: **uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco**.

Sounds you'll need

- diphthong-ue — **cuatro** begins *KWA*-.
- r-tap — give *tres* and *cuatro* one light tap, not an English *r*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish	Latin source	English memory hook
uno (1)	<i>ūnus</i>	unit , unique
dos (2)	<i>duo</i>	duo , dual
tres (3)	<i>trēs</i>	trio , triple
cuatro (4)	<i>quattuor</i>	quart , quarter
cinco (5)	<i>quīnque</i>	quintet , quintuplet

The spellings changed, but the family resemblance remains. *Cinco* and *quintet* both descend from *quīnque*; Spanish changed the opening sound while English borrowed a more visibly Latin form.

Grammar Lens: uno becomes un or una

When **uno** stands alone, it means “one.” Before a noun it shortens:

- **un** before a masculine noun: **un café** — one coffee / a coffee.
- **una** before a feminine noun: **una noche** — one night / a night.

This shortening is called **apocope**: the end drops away. Spanish uses the same forms for “one” and “a/an”; context supplies the difference.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco” — once up, once down
- “uno/unit, dos/duo, tres/trio, cuatro/quart, cinco/quintet”
- “un café, una noche” — hear *uno* shorten

Before you move on

Give 1–5 in Spanish. (*Uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco.*) Which English word helps you remember *cinco*? (*Quintet*, through Latin *quīnque*.) What happens to *uno* before a noun? (It becomes **un** or **una**.) Next: **six through ten**.

47.2 seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez — and the calendar's old count

You can count to five. Add one small set and you reach ten: **seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez**. Four English month names will help hold the last four in memory.

Sounds you'll need

- diphthong-*ie* — **siete** begins *SYE*-.
- diphthong-*ue* — **nueve** begins *NWE*-.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish	Latin source	English memory hook
seis (6)	<i>sex</i>	sextet
siete (7)	<i>septem</i>	September , septet
ocho (8)	<i>octō</i>	October , octave
nueve (9)	<i>novem</i>	November
diez (10)	<i>decem</i>	December , decimal

Say the chain aloud: *siete–September, ocho–October, nueve–November, diez–December*. It is a memory path, not a second list to memorize.

Why it's said this way

The month names preserve an old Roman count in which **March was first**: September through December occupied positions seven through ten. When January and February stood before March, those names shifted to positions nine through twelve but kept their old numbers. One tempting story is wrong: July and August were not new months inserted into the middle. The existing months **Quintilis** and **Sextilis** were later **renamed** for Julius Caesar and Augustus. The calendar moved; the numbered names stayed. Numbers above ten belong to a later chapter. For now, stop cleanly at **diez**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- count from *uno* through *diez*
- “siete/September, ocho/October, nueve/November, diez/December”

Before you move on

Give 6–10. (*Seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez.*) Why does *December* carry the old word for ten? (The month names preserve a March-first count.) What happened to Quintilis and Sextilis? (They were renamed July and August.) Next: the verb **tener**, “to have.”

47.3 tener — “to have,” with two visible changes

Regular *comer* gave you *como, comes, come*. The common verb **tener**, “to have,” belongs to the same **-er** family, but its three singular forms change in two places. Learn only those three today.

Sounds you’ll need

- diphthong-**ie** — **ti**enes begins *TYE*-.
- **r-tap** — one light tap at the end of **tener**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

tener descends from Latin **tenēre**, “to hold or keep.” Having is, at root, holding. English borrowed the same root many times:

- **tenant, tenure, tenacious** — holding land, office, or position.
- **contain, retain, maintain, sustain** — holding together, back, in hand, or up.

When you see *-tain* in English, think of Spanish **tener**.

Grammar Lens: the three singular forms

person	regular <i>comer</i>	irregular <i>tener</i>
yo	como	tengo
tú	comes	 tienes
él / ella / usted	come	 tiene

Two small changes do all the work:

1. **yo** adds **g**: *tengo*, not *teno*. 2. The other two singular forms change **e** → **ie**: *tienes*, *tiene*.

Later chapters will expand both patterns. For now, hold only **tengo**, **tienes**, **tiene** — the same three-person frame you already use for regular verbs.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “tener — tengo, tienes, tiene”
- “tener / tenant / retain” — the shared idea is *hold*
- compare “como, comes, come” with “tengo, tienes, tiene”

Before you move on

What did Latin *tenēre* mean? (“To hold.”) Give the three singular forms. (*Tengo, tienes, tiene*.) What are the two changes? (*g* appears in *tengo*; *e* becomes *ie* in *tienes/tiene*.) Next: use them to ask and answer about **age**.

47.4 ¿Cuántos años tienes? — asking age

You now have *tengo, tienes, tiene* and the numbers one through ten. Put them together and you can ask or answer age. Spanish frames age as something you **have**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

¿Cuántos años tienes? “How old are you?” — literally, “How many years do you have?”

- **cuántos** means “how many.” Latin **quantus**, “how much,” also gives English **quantity**, **quantum**, **quantify**.
- **años** means “years.” Latin **annus** also gives **annual** and **anniversary**. Its doubled *nn* became Spanish **ñ**, exactly as your script lesson showed.
- **tienes** is the *tú* form of **tener**.

Keep the marks visible: opening **¿**, the accent in **cuántos**, and the letter **ñ** in **años** each carries information.

Grammar Lens: Spanish “has” years

English says “I **am** ten years old.” Spanish says:

— ¿Cuántos años **tienes**? — **Tengo diez años.**

The reusable frame is **Tengo + number + años**. Use a number you already know: *Tengo ocho años*, *Tengo nueve años*, *Tengo diez años*. Larger numbers wait until their own lesson; the grammar does not change.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “¿Cuántos años tienes?”
- “Tengo ocho años. Tengo nueve años. Tengo diez años.”

Before you move on

What does the question literally ask? (“How many years do you have?”) Which verb carries age? (*Tener*.) How do *cuántos* and *años* connect to English? (*Quantus* → quantity; *annus* → annual.) Next: combine counting, *tener*, and age in one short exchange.

47.5 Practice — counting, having, and age

This checkpoint asks for three small moves: count to ten, choose the right singular form of *tener*, and use the age frame. Every-

thing here has already appeared.

Grammar Lens: count and conjugate

- Count: **uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco, seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez.**
- Change person: **tengo · tienes · tiene.**
- Remember the roots: *quīnque* helps with *cinco*; *decem* helps with *diez*; *tenēre*, “hold,” helps with *tener*.
- Keep the calendar correction: July and August were **renamed**, not inserted.

The exchange — use only what you know

— Hola. ¿Cómo te llamas? — Me llamo Ana. ¿Cuántos años tienes? — Tengo diez años. ¿Y tú? — Tengo nueve años.

The exchange reuses the name question you already know, then adds exactly one new capability: age with **tener**.

What you’ve built this chapter

- **uno through diez**, with Latin and English hooks instead of an isolated list.
- **un / una** before a noun, where standalone *uno* shortens.
- **tengo, tienes, tiene**, the three singular forms of **tener**.
- **¿Cuántos años tienes? — Tengo ... años**, with *quantus/quantity* and *annus/annual* showing where the words came from.

Numbers above ten and the plural forms of *tener* remain deliberately deferred.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- count 1–10 up, then down
- “tengo, tienes, tiene”

- ask and answer age with a number from 1–10

Twice through: “¿Cuántos años tienes? — Tengo nueve años.”

Before you move on

Count to ten. Give the three singular forms of *tener*. Ask “How old are you?” and answer with a number you learned. You can now move from a name exchange into one concrete personal detail. Next: the two Spanish ways to say “to be,” introduced one contrast at a time.

Chapter 48

Ser and Estar — Two Ways to Be

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can identify someone, state origin, check wellbeing, and give a location by choosing a learned singular form of ser or estar.

Identify Ana, state an origin with soy de, check a current state, and locate Ana with está en using only previously introduced vocabulary and singular forms.

48.1 ser — another way to say “to be”

You already use **estar** for a current state or location. Spanish also has **ser**. This chapter adds one job at a time; today, learn the verb and the three singular forms that match the person frame you already know.

Sounds you’ll need

- vowel-e — **ser** begins with the clear vowel in *mesa*.
- r-tap — the final **r** is one light tap: *SER*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Modern **ser** grew from a historical merger. Latin **esse** meant “to be,” while **sedere** meant “to sit.” The infinitive and the present forms do not all come down the same path, so the modern verb cannot be predicted from one neat stem.

The **esse** family is still visible in English **essence**, **essential**, **entity**, **present**, and **absent**. That makes *essence* a useful memory hook for one major use of *ser*: identifying what someone or something **is**.

Grammar Lens: only three forms today

person	form	a small identifying frame
yo	soy	Soy Ana. — “I am Ana.”
tú	eres	Eres Ana. — “You are Ana.”
él / ella / usted	es	Usted es Ana. — “You are Ana.”

Say the set as **soy · eres · es**. These forms are **irregular**: do not try to remove *-er* and attach the regular endings from *comer*. A later lesson will build the plural-person frame.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ser — soy, eres, es”
- “Soy Ana. Eres Ana. Usted es Ana.”
- “esse — essence — ser”

Before you move on

Which two Latin verbs fed *ser*? (*Esse* and *sedēre*.) Give the three forms learned today. (*Soy, eres, es*.) Why not predict them from the infinitive? (The verb is historically mixed and irregular.) Next: set *ser* beside *estar* using only identity and state frames you already have.

48.2 ser vs estar — identity or current state?

You now have two small sets: **soy, eres, es** and **estás, está**. Do not memorize a long rule list. Make one contrast: **ser identifies**; **estar places someone in a current state or location**.

Grammar Lens: the first contrast, from known material

question	what it asks	verb
¿Es usted Ana? — “Are you Ana?”	identity	ser
¿Está usted bien? — “Are you well?”	current state	estar

Only the verb and the job change. The first question identifies the person; the second checks how that person is now. Both **Ana**, **usted**, and **bien** are already part of your course, so the contrast adds no hidden vocabulary.

Grammar Lens: a memory hook, not a law

- **ser** recalls Latin *esse* and English **essence**: use it here to say who someone **is**.
- **estar** comes from Latin *stāre*, “to stand,” the family behind **state**: use it for the state or location in which someone stands.

“Permanent versus temporary” is only a rough beginner shortcut, not the rule. A location may last for centuries and still use *estar*; an identification may last one minute and still use *ser*. Ask instead: **am I identifying, or am I giving a state or location?**

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “¿Es usted Ana?” — identity, *ser*
- “¿Está usted bien?” — state, *estar*
- “identify: *ser*; state or location: *estar*”

Twice through: “¿Es usted Ana? ¿Está usted bien?”

Before you move on

Which verb identifies? (*Ser*.) Which gives a current state or location? (*Estar*.) Why is “permanent versus temporary”

incomplete? (The choice follows the kind of claim, not its duration.)
 Next: use *ser* for one specific identity fact — origin.

48.3 soy de... — saying where you are from

You can identify yourself with **Soy Ana**. Add one short word and you can state another identity fact: **Soy de...**, “I am from...”.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

de means “from” or “of.” It comes from Latin **dē**, “down from, away from.” English keeps that direction in **depart** and **descend**. You already learned that *dónde* grew from Latin *de unde*, “from where.” Spanish can put the still-living word **de** before **dónde** to ask explicitly about origin.

Grammar Lens: ser + de for origin

¿De dónde eres? — “Where are you from?” **Soy de Madrid.** — “I am from Madrid.”

The place name **Madrid** already appeared with *vivir*. Here, the new piece is the frame around it. Use **ser**, because this sentence states origin; it does not say where someone is located now.

Keep the two known questions separate:

question	asks about
¿De dónde eres?	origin — where you are from
¿Dónde vives?	residence — where you live

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “¿De dónde eres?”
- “Soy de Madrid.”
- “de — depart — descend”: the shared direction is *from*

Before you move on

What does *de* mean? (“From” or “of.”) Ask where one friend is from. (*¿De dónde eres?*) Answer with Madrid. (*Soy de Madrid.*)
Next: reuse *dónde* and *en* to say where someone is located now.

48.4 *está en...* — saying where someone is

You have already asked **¿Dónde vives?** — **Vivo en Madrid** about where someone lives. Now use the same **dónde** and **en** with *estar* to ask about a current location.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

en already means “in,” “on,” or “at.” It descends from Latin **in** and is a cognate of English **in**. No new preposition is needed; only the surrounding verb changes.

Grammar Lens: *dónde* + *estar*, then *estar* + *en*

¿Dónde está usted? — “Where are you?” (formal)
Usted está en Madrid. — “You are in Madrid.” **Ana está en Madrid.** — “Ana is in Madrid.”

The form **está** is already familiar from *¿Cómo está usted?* The phrase **está en...** simply gives that form a place. Location uses *estar* even when a place seems stable; the choice marks the kind of claim, not how long it lasts.

Compare origin and location without adding any new form:

sentence	meaning	verb
Ana es de Madrid.	origin	<i>ser</i>
Ana está en Madrid.	location	<i>estar</i>

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “¿Dónde está usted?”

- “Ana está en Madrid.”
- “en / in” — two cognates

Before you move on

Which verb locates someone? (*Estar*.) What already-known word introduces the place? (*En*.) Ask formal “Where are you?” (*¿Dónde está usted?*) Next: combine identity, origin, state, and location without adding another word or verb form.

48.5 Practice — identity, origin, state, and location

This checkpoint adds nothing. Use **ser** for identity and origin; use **estar** for a current state or location.

Grammar Lens: retrieve the two small form sets

- **ser**: soy · eres · es
- **estar** in the questions used here: estás · está

Plural forms remain deliberately deferred.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **ser**: *esse* + *sedēre*.
- **estar**: *stāre*, “stand.”
- **de**: Latin *dē*, “from.”
- **en**: Latin *in*, English *in*.

Grammar Lens: sort by the kind of claim

prompt	answer	why
¿Es usted Ana?	<i>ser</i>	identity
¿De dónde eres?	<i>ser</i>	origin
¿Está usted bien?	<i>estar</i>	current state
¿Dónde está Ana?	<i>estar</i>	location

The exchange — only known pieces

— Hola. ¿Es usted Ana? — Sí. Soy Ana. — ¿De dónde es usted? — Soy de Madrid. — ¿Dónde está Ana? — Está en Madrid. — ¿Está usted bien? — Bien, gracias.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “soy, eres, es”
- the four questions, naming each job
- the exchange once

Twice through: “¿Es usted Ana? ¿Está usted bien?”

Before you move on

Give the three learned forms of *ser*. (*Soy, eres, es*.) Which verb identifies and states origin? (*Ser*.) Which gives a state or location? (*Estar*.) Ask where one friend is from, then locate Ana in Madrid. Next: **ir**, “to go,” introduced in the same small-step frame.

Chapter 49

Going, and the Future You Can Already Say

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 👁️ eyes (1) 🖐️ Hands-free start: first 2 of 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask where someone is going, say what a singular person is going to do, and mark a known singular noun with *mi*, *tu*, or *su*.

*Complete ES-C10-practice, the canonical closing checkpoint, and demonstrate the chapter promise with singular *ir*, *ir a* plus a known infinitive, and *mi*, *tu*, or *su* before *café*.*

49.1 *ir* — “to go,” from more than one historical stem

You already match different verb forms with **tú** and **usted**, and you can ask ¿**Dónde...**?, “Where...?” Today, add one new verb and only its three singular-person forms.

Sounds you’ll need

- vowel-**i** — **ir** is one clear syllable, like *ear* without a glide.
- diphthong-**oy** — **voy** ends with the sound in English *boy*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ir means “to go.” Its infinitive descends from Latin **īre**, also “to go.” The present forms below followed a different Latin verb, **vādere**, “to go forward” or “advance.” English **invade** and **evade** preserve that *vad-* family.

One modern verb built from historically different stems is called **suppletive**. English does the same thing when *go* changes to *went*, an old form borrowed from *wend*.

Grammar Lens: only three forms today

person	present of ir
yo	voy
tú	vas
él / ella / usted	va

Say the small set as **voy · vas · va**. The plural forms are deliberately left for a later lesson.

The known question word now gives you a useful prompt:

¿Dónde va usted? — “Where are you going?”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ir — voy, vas, va”
- “¿Dónde va usted?”
- “īre gives ir; vādere gives the present set”

Before you move on

What does *ir* mean? (“To go.”) Give the three forms learned today. (*Voy, vas, va.*) Why do they look unlike *ir*? (The infinitive and present set come through different Latin stems.) Next: place **a** and a known infinitive after this small set to talk about what is coming.

49.2 voy a + infinitive — moving toward the near future

You know **voy**, **vas**, **va** and the infinitives **hablar**, **comer**, **vivir**. This lesson joins those owned pieces with one short new word.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish **a** means “to” or “toward.” It descends from Latin **ad**, “toward,” which English keeps in words such as **advance**.

Movement toward a place easily becomes movement toward a future event. English uses the same picture in “I am **going to** speak.”

Spanish keeps **a** visible: **voy a hablar**.

Grammar Lens: ir + a + an unchanged infinitive

person	near-future frame	meaning
yo	voy a hablar	I am going to speak
tú	vas a comer	you are going to eat
usted	va a vivir	you are going to live

Only **ir** changes for the person. The second verb stays in its known dictionary form: **hablar**, **comer**, or **vivir**. No new plural person or infinitive is hidden in the pattern.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “voy a hablar”
- “vas a comer”
- “va a vivir”

Before you move on

What is the frame? (*Ir* in the present + **a** + an infinitive.) Does the second verb change for the person? (No.) What idea connects physical going with future time? (Motion toward a destination becomes motion toward an event.) Next: say whose already-known

café it is.

49.3 hablaré — the future in one word

You can already say *voy a hablar* — “I am going to speak.” Spanish has a second way to say the same thing, and it is shorter: one word instead of three. Your job here is to recognize it and to see where it came from.

What to know first

- *voy a* + infinitive — the future you already have.
- *hablar* — the infinitive this is built on.

Sounds you’ll need

- **vowel-e** — the ending is stressed: *hablarÉ* (*ah-blah-REH*). The written accent is doing real work; it tells you where your voice lifts. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hablaré — “I will speak.” Look closely and you will see a word you already know sitting inside it, whole and unchanged:

hablar + *é* → **hablaré** (to speak) (ending) (I will speak)

This is the one Spanish tense built on the **complete infinitive**.

Nothing is chopped off. Every other tense you have met removes the *-ar* first; this one leaves it alone and simply adds to the end.

Where the ending comes from. It is a verb in its own right, worn down. Latin speakers said *hablare habeo* — literally “**I have** to speak,” in the sense of “I am to speak,” a thing still ahead of me. Said often enough, the *habeo* shrank onto the back of the infinitive and stopped being a separate word:

hablare habeo → *hablar é* → **hablaré** “I have to speak” “I will speak”

So the Spanish future is an obligation that turned into a prediction — the same drift English made when “I **shall** speak” softened out of a word that once meant “I owe.”

What you've built

The singular endings ride on the full infinitive, and they are the **same for all three verb families** — *-ar*, *-er* and *-ir* alike. This is the most regular tense in the language:

	spea <u>k</u>	ea <u>t</u>	live
I will	hablaré	comeré	viviré
you will	hablarás	comerás	vivirás
he/she will	hablará	comerá	vivirá

Both futures are correct. *Voy a hablar* is what you will hear most in conversation; *hablaré* is a little more formal, and is what you will meet in writing.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *hablaré* — stress the last syllable
- the same idea the long way — *voy a hablar*
- “I will eat” and “I will live,” using the table

Before you move on

What whole word can you still see inside *hablaré*? (*hablar*.) Which syllable carries the stress? (The last — the accent says so.) The ending began life as which Latin verb? (*Habeo*, “I have.”)

49.4 mi, tu, su — whose café?

You already know **café**, and you distinguish informal **tú** from formal **usted**. Now put one small ownership word before that one known noun.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish	Latin source	meaning in today's frame
mi	<i>meus</i>	my
tu	<i>tuus</i>	your, to one informal tú
su	<i>suus</i>	your, to formal usted ; also his or her

English **my** helps recall **mi**. Older English **thy**, “your,” helps recall Latin *tuus* and Spanish **tu**. The ownership word **tu** has no written accent; the person word **tú** that you already know keeps its accent.

Grammar Lens: put the ownership word before the noun

phrase	meaning
mi café	my coffee
tu café	your coffee, informal
su café	your coffee, formal; or his or her coffee

The situation tells you which person **su** points to. Every noun phrase in this lesson is singular. Forms used before plural things are left for a later step, so there is no new number pattern to learn here.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “mi café”
- “tu café” to *tú*
- “su café” to *usted*

Before you move on

Give the three ownership words. (*Mi, tu, su.*) Where do they go? (Before the noun.) Which one addresses *usted*? (*Su.*) Which Latin sources sit behind them? (*Meus, tuus, suus.*) Next: retrieve the chapter without adding a new word, form, or noun.

49.5 Practice — going, approaching events, and ownership

This checkpoint adds nothing. Retrieve **voy, vas, va**; build the near future with **a** and a known infinitive; then put **mi, tu**, or **su** before the known noun **café**.

Grammar Lens: the complete small chapter frame

- **ir**, singular: **voy · vas · va**.
- near future: **voy a hablar · vas a comer · va a vivir**.
- ownership before one singular known noun: **mi café · tu café · su café**.

Plural person forms of *ir* and possessives before plural nouns remain deferred.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **ir** continues Latin *īre*, while **voy, vas, va** continue *vādere*.
- **a** continues Latin *ad*, “toward”; motion toward a goal became motion toward a coming event.
- **mi, tu, su** continue Latin *meus, tuus, suus*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “voy, vas, va”
- “voy a hablar, vas a comer, va a vivir”
- “mi café, tu café, su café”

Twice through: “Voy a hablar. Su café.”

Before you move on

Give the singular *ir* set. (*Voy, vas, va*.) Build “You are going to eat” for one friend. (*Vas a comer*.) Say “my coffee” and formal

“your coffee.” (*Mi café; su café.*) The next chapter can now extend the grammar from this small, closed frontier.

Chapter 50

Ser in the Plural

Modes: ⇄ voice (3) 👁 eyes (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: none of the 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can use all six present forms of *ser*, and say why no two of them look alike.

Two Latin verbs in one paradigm - and the seam between them is visible at eres.

50.1 somos — “we are”

Say “I am.” (*Soy.*) And “we speak.” (*Hablamos.*)

Grammar Lens: the -mos survives even here

somos — *we are.*

Look at what survived. *Ser* is the most irregular verb in Spanish — *soy, eres, es* share almost nothing — and yet the plural still ends in **-mos**, exactly as *hablamos* and *comemos* do.

That ending is the single most stable thing in the language. Even a verb that has thrown away everything else kept it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

And here is why *ser*’s forms refuse to resemble each other: **it is not one verb.** It is two Latin verbs fused into a single paradigm.

- Latin *esse*, “to be”, gave *soy* and *somos* — the *s-* forms, and the rest of that family arrives over the next two lessons.

- Latin **sedēre**, “to sit”, gave *ser* itself, and the future and conditional.

So *somos* and *ser* are not irregular versions of each other. They are descendants of **different words**, brought together because Spanish needed one verb where Latin had two.

English did something very similar. *Am, is, are, was, be* — no two of those look related, because they are not: they come from three separate Old English verbs. Every language seems to build “to be” out of spare parts.

Your turn

- *Say it*: “hablamos, comemos, somos” — the same ending, three times

Before you move on

What is “we are”? (**Somos.**) Which ending did even this verb keep? (**-mos.**) And why do *soy* and *ser* look unrelated? (They **are** unrelated — two Latin verbs in one paradigm.)

50.2 son — “they are”

Say “we are.” (*Somos.*) And “they speak.” (*Hablan.*)

Grammar Lens: the final -n, again

son — *they are*, and **ustedes son**, *you all are*.

Three letters, and it is one of the two or three commonest words in the whole language. The rule you know holds even here: a final **-n** means the subject is plural and is not you.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin’s form was **sunt**. Spanish dropped the final **-t**, exactly as it dropped it from *hablat* to give *habla*, and *sunt* became *son*.

That is worth noticing because it is the same erosion you have already watched happen twice. Irregular verbs are not exempt from sound change; they are simply verbs where sound change ran on material that

had already been strange.

A word you may already know. English *sonata*, *sonnet* and *sound* have nothing to do with this — they come from Latin *sonāre*, “to sound”. *Son* the verb and *son* the noun in English are unrelated to each other and to both. Spanish is full of these collisions, and the way through is always the same: the root, not the spelling.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “somos, son” — the two plural forms you now hold
- “ustedes son”, addressing a group

Before you move on

What is “they are”? (**Son.**) What did Latin’s *sunt* lose? (Its **-t**, like every other final *-t*.) Who else does *son* address? (**Ustedes.**)

50.3 sois — the last of the six

Say “they are.” (*Son.*) And which region uses *vosotros*? (*Spain.*)

Grammar Lens: one syllable, and the paradigm closes

vosotros sois — *you all are*, in Spain.

One syllable, and with it the six forms of *ser* are complete: *soy*, *eres*, *es*, *somos*, *sois*, *son*.

As before, this is the form you need in order to **follow** Spain rather than to speak everywhere. In the Americas, *ustedes son* does the same job.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin had **estis**. Spanish wore away the *e-* at the front and the *-t-* in the middle, and *sois* is what was left — a word reduced almost to nothing but still doing its whole job.

That is the pattern with this verb throughout. *Ser* is short everywhere because it is said constantly, and constant use grinds words down. The commonest verb in a language is almost always its most eroded one.

Your turn

- [YOU HEAR: “sois”] → Spain, addressing friends.
- *Say it*: “ustedes son” then “vosotros sois” — the same sentence, two continents

Before you move on

What is the *vosotros* form of *ser*? (**Sois.**) What Latin word is it worn from? (**Estis.**) And why is this verb so short everywhere? (Because it is said **constantly**, and constant use grinds words down.)

50.4 Review — all of ser

Nothing new. Say “we are”, then “they are.”

Grammar Lens: the table, and why it looks like that

who	<i>ser</i> →
yo	soy
tú	eres
él · ella · usted	es
nosotros	somos
vosotros	sois
ellos · ustedes	son

Most books present this as a table to memorise. You have built it a form at a time, and you can now read something off it that memorisation would never give you.

Five of the six begin with s-. One does not. *Eres* is the outlier, and it is the outlier because it comes from somewhere else — Latin *eris*, from *esse*’s own future stem, pulled in to fill a gap. The rest are the *s-* family: *sum*, *sumus*, *sunt*.

So the “irregularity” is not chaos. It is a seam between two verbs, and

you can see exactly where it runs.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all six, top to bottom
- the five *s*- forms, then *eres* on its own

Twice through:

Before you move on

Give all six forms of *ser*. (*Soy, eres, es, somos, sois, son.*) How many begin with *s*-? (**Five.**) And why does the sixth not? (It came from a **different Latin verb** — the seam is visible.)

Chapter 51

Profesor — and the Article Spanish Leaves Out

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what someone does for a living with *ser* and no article.

*I can say what someone does for a living with *ser* and no article.*

51.1 profesor

Say “I am.” (*Soy.*) You learned *ser* three chapters ago as the verb for saying **what someone is**.

And then you had nothing to put after it. Today you do.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

profesor — a teacher

Latin **profitēri** meant to *declare something publicly*. A *profesor* is someone who has declared what they know — which is also why in English you **profess** a faith, and why the work you declare yourself trained in is a **profession**.

profesor ← *profitēri* → **professor, profess, profession**

Say it: *profesor*. And for a woman, *profesora*.

Grammar Lens: the missing “a”

After *ser*, a job takes no *un* or *una*.

You learned *un* and *una* early, and you have been right to use them. Here is the one place Spanish leaves them out.

Spanish

English

Soy profesor.

I am **a** teacher.

Es profesora.

She is **a** teacher.

English needs the *a*. Spanish does not — because it is not counting one teacher, it is naming what kind of person you are.

Soy un profesor is not wrong so much as **different**: it makes the teacher into one item out of several, the way English does with *I’m a teacher*, not *the teacher*. Say the bare one and you will sound like everyone else.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *Soy profesor*
- *Trabajo* — and now say what you are

Twice through:

Before you move on

What word does English need here that Spanish leaves out? (**a**.)
Now say what you are, out loud, even if it is not *profesor* yet.

Chapter 52

Estudiante — a Word You Can Build

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can build a person-word from a verb with -ante, and read it as English -ant.

I can build a person-word from a verb with -ante, and read it as English -ant.

52.1 estudiante

Say “to study.” (*Estudiar.*) You have had it since your first handful of verbs.

Say “I am a teacher.” (*Soy profesor — no un.*)

Grammar Lens: the one who is doing it

Verb + *-ante* = the person doing it.

Take *estudiar*, cut the *-ar*, add *-ante*:

estudiar → *estudiante* — the one who is studying

You did not memorise that word. You **built** it, from a verb you already had.

English uses the same ending, worn down to *-ant*: a **participant** takes part, an **assistant** assists, an **inhabitant** inhabits. So *-ante* and *-ant* are one more pair for your decoder.

Spanish	English
<i>estudiante</i>	student
<i>importante</i>	important
<i>elegante</i>	elegant
And <i>estudiante</i> also begins <i>es-</i> + consonant. Take the <i>e-</i> off: studiente . Student . Two of your rules on one word.	

Grammar Lens: one word, either person

Profesor changed to *profesora* for a woman. *Estudiante* does not change at all:

Él es estudiante. · *Ella es estudiante.*

The article moves instead — *el estudiante*, *la estudiante* — but the word itself stays put. Words ending in *-ante* almost never shift.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *Soy estudiante*
- *Somos estudiantes*

Twice through:

Before you move on

What does *-ante* do to a verb? (Makes **the one doing it**.)
And does *estudiante* change for a woman? (**No** — only the article does.)

Chapter 53

-ista — Jobs You Can Already Read

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can read an -ista word as English -ist without being taught it.

I can read an -ista word as English -ist without being taught it.

53.1 -ista

What does *-ante* make? (**The one doing it.**) Say “I am a student.” (*Soy estudiante.*)

Grammar Lens: a job you can already read

Spanish *-ista* is English *-ist*.

Greek *-istēs* named the doer of an action. Latin borrowed it, and Spanish and English both still use it — so this ending needs almost no learning.

Spanish	English
<i>artista</i>	artist
<i>dentista</i>	dentist
<i>turista</i>	tourist
<i>periodista</i>	journalist

Three of those four you could read before this chapter opened. That is the point: **the ending is doing the work, not your memory.**

The fourth is the interesting one. *Periodista* is not *periodist* — it is built on *periódico*, a **newspaper**, which is a **periodical**, something that comes round at a *period*. The ending is regular; the root is the surprise.

Grammar Lens: -ista never changes

Like *-ante*, an *-ista* word is the same for a man or a woman — and it keeps its *-a* either way:

Él es artista. · Ella es artista.

The *-a* is not feminine here. It is just how the word ends. Only the article moves: *el artista, la artista*.

And still no *un*: *Soy artista*, not *Soy un artista*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *artista, dentista, turista*
- *Soy* — and one of them

Twice through:

Before you move on

What is *-ista* in English? (**-ist**.)
Does it change for a woman? (**No**.)

Chapter 54

Synthesis — Saying What People Do

Modes: 🔄 voice (1) 🔄 Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I and others do, and turn the question back.

I can say what I and others do, and turn the question back.

54.1 Synthesis — saying what people do

One word English needs after *is* and Spanish leaves out. Which?
(*a.*)

What you've built

Three chapters ago *ser* was a verb with nothing to sit in front of. Now:

Soy profesor.

I am a teacher.

Ella es estudiante.

She is a student.

Somos artistas.

We are artists.

And two of those words you did not memorise. You **built** *estudiante* from *estudiar*, and you **read** *artista* off English.

Grammar Lens: what the two endings are worth

Neither ending is a word. Each is a **machine** that makes words, which is why they outrun any vocabulary list:

-ante ↔ **-ant** · *-ista* ↔ **-ist**

Both are also invariant — one form for a man or a woman — so you never have to choose. Only the article moves.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *Soy* — and what you actually are
- *¿Y tú?*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Two endings that name a person. (*-ante* and *-ista*.) What do both skip after *ser*? (*un/una*.) And which of them changes for a woman? (**Neither**.)

Chapter 55

Estar in the Plural

Modes: 🗨 voice (3) 👁 eyes (1) 🖐 Hands-free start: first 3 of 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can use all six present forms of *estar*, and say why its plural is regular where *ser*'s is not.

One Latin verb against two - which is the whole reason one paradigm is plain and the other is not.

55.1 estamos — the other “we are”

Say “we are” with *ser*. (*Somos*.) And how do you ask a friend how they are? (¿*Cómo estás?*)

Grammar Lens: this one behaves

estamos — *we are*.

Drop the **-ar**, add **-amos**. That is the plain *-ar* ending you learned on *hablamos*, applied without alteration.

And that is the point of this lesson. You have just spent a chapter on *ser*, whose six forms come from two different Latin verbs and refuse to resemble each other. **Estar is not like that at all.** In the plural it is an ordinary *-ar* verb.

hablamos · *estamos* — the same ending, and no surprises.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The reason is simple, and it is the reason for almost every irregularity you have met: **estar is one verb**. Latin *stāre*, “to stand” — and that is the whole ancestry. Nothing was fused into it, so nothing in it has a seam.

Ser is irregular because two verbs were welded together. *Estar* is regular because it never was.

That is worth carrying, because it predicts the rest. Where a Spanish verb looks chaotic, the usual explanation is not that it decayed strangely but that it is **more than one word wearing a single name**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hablamos, estamos” — the same ending
- “somos, estamos” — two verbs for *we are*, and only one of them is strange

Before you move on

What is “we are” with *estar*? (**Estamos.**) Which Latin verb is it from? (***Stāre***, “to stand”.) And why is it regular where *ser* is not? (Because it is **one** verb, not two.)

55.2 están — “they are”

Say “we are” with *estar*. (*Estamos.*) And “they speak.” (*Hablan.*)

Grammar Lens: the ending is regular, the accent is the clue

están — *they are*, and **ustedes están**, *you all are*.

The ending is **-an**, exactly as in *hablan*. But there is a written accent, and it is not decoration.

Estar is unusual in one specific way: it puts its stress on the **ending** rather than the stem, in every singular and plural form except

estamos. You have already seen this without being told — *estás*, *está*, and now *están*. The accent is simply Spanish writing that stress down, by the rule for written accents you learned long ago.

hablan — stress on the stem, no accent. **están** — stress on the ending, so an accent.

Same ending, different stress, and the spelling records it faithfully.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hablan” then “están” — same ending, and hear the stress move
- “ustedes están”, addressing a group

Before you move on

What is “they are” with *estar*? (**Están**.) Why the accent? (The stress falls on the **ending**.) Which form of *estar* does not do that? (**Estamos**.)

55.3 *estáis* — and nothing surprises you

Say “they are” with *estar*. (*Están*.) And the *vosotros* form of *hablar*? (*Habláis*.)

Grammar Lens: predictable, and that is the news

vosotros *estáis* — *you all are*, in Spain.

If you guessed that before reading it, you have understood the chapter. The ending is *-áis*, the plain *-ar* one from *habláis*, and the accent is there for the reason it is always there with this verb: the stress sits on the ending.

That is now three forms in a row where knowing *estar* meant knowing nothing new. In the Americas, *ustedes están* does this job.

Your turn

- *Say it:* “habláis” then “estáis” — the same ending, twice

Before you move on

What is the *vosotros* form of *estar*? (**Estáis.**) Why the accent? (*Estar* stresses its **ending.**) And in Argentina? (*Ustedes están.*)

55.4 Review — both verbs for “to be”

Nothing new. Say *somos*, then *estamos*.

Grammar Lens: side by side, and the difference is history

who	<i>ser</i>	<i>estar</i>
yo	soy	estoy
tú	eres	estás
él · ella · usted	es	está
nosotros	somos	estamos
vosotros	sois	estáis
ellos · ustedes	son	están

Read the two columns down and the difference is not a matter of difficulty. It is a matter of **history**.

- ***Ser*** is two Latin verbs fused — *esse* and *sedēre* — so its forms have no common shape. Five begin with *s-*; *eres* does not, and that is the seam.
- ***Estar*** is one Latin verb, *stāre*. Its plural is a plain *-ar* paradigm, and the only oddity in the whole column is where the stress falls, which the written accent records honestly.

So the two hardest-looking verbs in Spanish are hard for opposite reasons: one because it is two words, and the other not really at all.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- one column down, then the other
- each row across — *soy, estoy* · *somos, estamos* — and hear which column surprises you

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which of the two verbs is regular in the plural? (***Estar***.) Why? (It is **one** Latin verb; *ser* is two.) And what is the only oddity in *estar*'s column? (Where the **stress** falls — which the accent records.)

Chapter 56

La Casa — Your First Everyday Noun

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say *la casa* and *tengo una casa*, using the article and gender rules I already hold.

Complete ES-C43-casa: produce *la casa* and *tengo una casa*, and say what *casa* meant in Latin.

56.1 la casa — “house,” and “home”

You have spent a long time learning what to **do** with nouns — their gender, their articles, their agreement. This chapter and the next few hand you some nouns to do it with.

Sounds you’ll need

- **s-sound** — the *s* in *casa* is a plain, unvoiced *s*. Spanish has no *z* buzz here: *KAH-sah*, never *KAH-zah*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la casa — *the house*, and just as often *home*.

Latin **casa** meant something humbler than a house: a **hut**, a cottage, the small shelter a farm worker lived in. The grand Latin word for a proper house was *domus* — which is where **domestic** and **dome** come from. And *domus* lost. Across the whole west of the Roman world the

humble word won and the grand one faded: Spanish *casa*, Italian *casa*, Portuguese *casa*.

French took the same word somewhere stranger. *Casa* wore down until it stopped being a noun at all and became the little word **chez** — so *chez moi* is, underneath, “at the house of me.”

Italian kept a small one too: *casino* is *casa* plus a diminutive ending — literally “little house.”

Grammar Lens: a feminine noun, behaving exactly as promised

Casa ends in *-a* and is feminine, so it takes **la**. That is the common case, and it is worth having one plain example on hand before you meet the awkward ones.

la casa — the house. *Tengo una casa.* — I have a house.

Nothing new is happening here. That is the point: the machinery has been ready for a long time, and this is the first ordinary thing to run through it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “la casa” — *KAH-sah*, a clean *s*
- “Tengo una casa”

Before you move on

What is “the house”? (***La casa.***) What did *casa* mean in Latin? (A **hut** — the humble word that outlived the grand one.) Next: a masculine noun whose Latin ancestor was a piece of a tree.

Chapter 57

El Libro — And a Word Made of Tree Bark

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say *el libro* and *tengo un libro*, and contrast it with *la casa* as a gender pair.

Complete ES-C43-libro: produce *el libro* and *tengo un libro*, and say what Latin *liber* originally named.

57.1 el libro — “book”

Say “the house.” (*La casa.*) Why *la* and not *el*? (*Casa* is feminine.) Here is one that goes the other way.

Sounds you’ll need

- **r-tap** — a single flick of the tongue: *LEE-broh*. One tap, not a roll.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el libro — *the book*.

Latin **liber** did not mean “book.” It meant the **inner bark of a tree** — the thin, pale layer just under the rough outside, which is what Romans wrote on before they had anything better.

So the word travelled the way these words usually do: from the **material**, to the **thing made of it**, to the thing itself long after the

material is gone. Nobody has written on bark for two thousand years, and the word has not noticed.

English took the same root and kept it in the places books live:

- **library** — and French *livre*, Italian *libro*.
- **libretto** — Italian for “little book,” the words of an opera.

English’s own word went the same route from a different tree: **book** is related to **beech**, whose bark the Germanic peoples wrote on. Two languages, two trees, the same idea.

Grammar Lens: a masculine noun to sit beside the feminine one

Libro ends in *-o* and is masculine, so it takes **el**.

el libro — the book. *Tengo un libro.* — I have a book. *la casa* — the house. *Tengo una casa.* — I have a house.

Two nouns, one of each gender, side by side. That pairing is worth more than either noun alone: from here on, when something in Spanish depends on gender, you have a plain example of both to test it against.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “el libro” — one tap on the *r*
- “Tengo un libro” then “Tengo una casa” — hear the article follow the noun

Before you move on

“The book”? (***El libro.***) “The house”? (***La casa.***) What was *liber* before it was a book? (Tree **bark**.) Next: a noun you can build yourself, out of a verb you already have.

Chapter 58

Grande — the First Word for What a Thing Is Like

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can describe a thing with an adjective after the noun.

I can describe a thing with an adjective after the noun.

58.1 grande

Say “she is.” (*Es.*) You can say who someone **is** and what they **do**.

You still cannot say what anything is **like**. That starts here.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

grande — big

Latin **grandis** meant *full-grown*. English took it whole and never changed it: a **grand** piano is the big one, a **grandiose** plan is oversized, and a **grandmother** is — literally — the full-grown mother.

grande ← *grandis* → **grand**, **grandiose**, **aggrandise**

Say it: *grande*.

Grammar Lens: where it goes, and what it does not do

A describing word usually comes *after* the noun in Spanish.

English puts it in front — *a big house*. Spanish puts it behind:

una casa grande — a big house

And *grande* does not change for a man or a woman:

el libro grande

the big book

la casa grande

the big house

You have met that already. *Estudiante* and *artista* do not shift either. Some Spanish words agree with gender and some simply do not, and the ending tells you which: *-o/-a* words like *bueno/buena* shift, *-e* words like *grande* sit still.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *una casa grande*
- *el libro grande*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Where does a describing word go? (**After** the noun.)
And which endings sit still? (**-e** ones, like *grande*.)

Chapter 59

Cansado — a State, Not a Quality

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say how I am right now with *estar* and an adjective.

*I can say how I am right now with *estar* and an adjective.*

59.1 cansado

Say “a big house.” (*Una casa grande.*) That is what the house **is**.

Now for something that is only true today.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

cansado — tired

Cansado comes from *cansar*, to tire, and behind that is Latin **camp̄sāre**: *to turn aside off the road*. The tiredness is what made you turn off.

And your decoder cannot help you here. There is no English cousin to find — no *cansate*, no *camp̄sation*. English took its word for this from an entirely different place.

That is worth meeting on purpose. The rules you built are a **lead**, not a guarantee, and a word that gives nothing back is not a failure of the method. It is simply one of the words you learn the ordinary way.

Grammar Lens: the state, not the quality

Estoy cansado. — not *soy cansado*.

You learned two verbs for *to be*. Here is the first describing word that shows you why:

Estoy cansado.

I am tired — **today**.

Es grande.

It is big — **that is what it is**.

Ser is for what a thing is. *Estar* is for how it is right now. Being tired is a state you are passing through, so it takes *estar*, always.

And unlike *grande*, this one **does** shift, because it ends in *-o*:

Estoy cansado. · *Estoy cansada.*

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *Estoy cansado*
- *La casa es grande, pero estoy cansado*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which verb for tired? (***Estar***.) Why? (It is a **state**.)

And does *cansado* shift for a woman? (**Yes** — *cansada*, because it ends in *-o*.)

Chapter 60

Synthesis — Describing Things

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can choose *ser* or *estar* with an adjective and make it agree.

*I can choose *ser* or *estar* with an adjective and make it agree.*

60.1 Synthesis — describing things

Two verbs for *to be*. Which is for what a thing **is**? (*Ser*.) Which is for how it **is right now**? (*Estar*.)

What you've built

You met *ser* and *estar* as a pair long before this book had a single word to put after them. Now it does, and the pair finally does its job:

La casa es grande.

The house is big — that is what it is.

Estoy cansado.

I am tired — today.

Soy profesor.

I am a teacher — and no *un*.

Three sentences, three different jobs for *to be*, and nothing memorised as a phrase.

Grammar Lens: which words shift

The ending tells you, and you now have one of each:

ending	shifts?	example
-o	yes	<i>cansado</i> → <i>cansada</i>
-e	no	<i>grande</i> stays <i>grande</i>
-ista, -ante	no	<i>artista, estudiante</i>

So you never have to guess. Look at the last letter.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *La casa es grande*
- *Estoy cansado* — and mean it

Twice through:

Before you move on

Ser or *estar* for tired? (***Estar***.) Where does the describing word go? (**After** the noun.) And what tells you whether it shifts? (Its **last letter**.)

Chapter 61

-oso — a Shelf of Words You Were Never Taught

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can read an -oso word as English -ous, make it agree, and choose ser or estar for it.

Read misterioso, make comida deliciosa agree, and pick estar for nervioso.

61.1 -oso

Name your two describing words. (*Grande, cansado.*)

Two is a short shelf. You are about to have a long one.

Grammar Lens: full of

Spanish -oso is English -ous.

Latin **-ōsus** meant *full of*. Stick it on a noun and you get an adjective: *fāma* is fame or report, so *famōsus* is **full of fame**.

English holds the same suffix, worn down through French to *-ous*. Not a resemblance — the **same ending**, arriving by two roads, exactly like *-ción* and *-tion*.

Spanish	English
<i>famoso</i>	famous
<i>delicioso</i>	delicious
<i>curioso</i>	curious
<i>precioso</i>	precious
<i>nervioso</i>	nervous
You were taught none of those. You can read all of them.	

Grammar Lens: and you already know what to do with it

An *-oso* word is an ordinary describing word, so every rule you just learned applies without being restated:

- it goes **after** the noun — *un profesor famoso*
- it ends in *-o*, so it **shifts** — *famoso* / *famosa*
- and the verb depends on what you mean:

Es famoso.

He is famous — that is what he is.

Estoy nervioso.

I am nervous — right now.

That last pair is the whole *ser/estar* contrast again, and you did not have to be told which verb to use. You worked it out from the meaning.

Why it's said this way

The ending is reliable. The root still has to be shared.

Hermoso is *beautiful*, not *hermous* — because the root is *formōsus*, from *forma*, and English simply never borrowed that one.

So *-oso* tells you the word is an adjective and roughly how it is built.

It only hands you the meaning when English took the same root. That is the same deal every rule in this book has offered: a **lead**, not a guarantee.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *famoso, delicioso, curioso*

- *Estoy nervioso*

Twice through:

Before you move on

-oso in English? (**-ous**.) Does it shift for a woman? (**Yes** — it ends in -o.)

And what does the ending *not* promise? (That English **took the same root**.)

Chapter 62

-ncia — Turning a Quality into a Thing

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can read an -ncia word as English -nce, know it is feminine, and describe it.

Read preferencia, choose la for distancia, and say una diferencia grande.

62.1 -ncia

-oso in English? (-ous.) And -ción? (-tion.)

One more, and it is the one that makes ideas into things.

Grammar Lens: a quality, made into a thing

Spanish **-ncia** is English **-nce**.

Latin **-entia** turned a quality into a noun. If something *differs*, the state of differing is *differentia*. Spanish kept the ending nearly whole; English took it through French, where it wore down to *-nce*.

Spanish	English
<i>diferencia</i>	difference
<i>importancia</i>	importance
<i>experiencia</i>	experience
<i>distancia</i>	distance
<i>paciencia</i>	patience

One word wearing two coats, five times over. This is the same shape as *-ción* and *-tion*: not a resemblance, the **same ending** arriving by two roads.

Grammar Lens: what you do with it

Every *-ncia* word is a **noun**, and every one is **feminine** — so the article never surprises you:

la diferencia · la importancia · una experiencia

And you already know what goes after a noun:

*una diferencia **grande*** — a big difference

That sentence uses three things you were taught separately: a noun built by an ending, an article chosen by gender, and a describing word in its Spanish position. None of it was memorised as a phrase.

Why it's said this way

One that will look wrong, and is not.

Ciencia is **science**, not *ciencia*. The ending behaved exactly as promised — it is the *root* that English spells differently, because *scientia* came into English through a French spelling that kept the *sc-*. So when a decoded word looks almost right, trust the ending and check the root. Almost right is usually right.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la diferencia, la importancia, la experiencia*
- *una diferencia grande*

Twice through:

Before you move on

-*ncia* in English? (**-nce.**) What gender, always? (**Feminine.**)
And when a decoded word looks *almost* right? (Trust the ending,
check the root.)

Chapter 63

-ario — the Eighth and Last Ending

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can read an -ario word as English -ary and tell noun from adjective.

I can read an -ario word as English -ary and tell noun from adjective.

63.1 -ario

-ncia? (**-nce.**) -oso? (**-ous.**)

One more, and the set is complete.

Grammar Lens: belonging to, or the place for

Spanish *-ario* is English *-ary*.

Latin **-ārius** meant *belonging to* — and then, by an easy step, *the place where that thing is kept*.

diccionario — the place the **words** are kept

Which is exactly what an English **dictionary** is, and neither language ever said so out loud.

Spanish	English
<i>necesario</i>	necessary
<i>ordinario</i>	ordinary
<i>primario</i>	primary
<i>diccionario</i>	dictionary
<i>aniversario</i>	anniversary

Grammar Lens: it does two jobs

Unlike the other seven, *-ario* makes **both** nouns and adjectives, and the sentence tells you which:

<i>un diccionario</i>	a dictionary — a thing
<i>es necesario</i>	it is necessary — a quality

When it is an adjective it ends in *-o*, so it shifts the way you already expect: *necesario* / *necesaria*. When it is a noun it is masculine, and takes *el* or *un*.

You do not have to decide in advance. The sentence decides.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *necesario, ordinario, primario*
- *un diccionario*

Twice through:

Before you move on

-ario in English? (**-ary**.) Noun or adjective? (**Either** — the sentence decides.)

Chapter 64

Review — the Eight Endings

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can sort the eight endings by what they make and know which decide gender.

I can sort the eight endings by what they make and know which decide gender.

64.1 Review — the eight endings

The first one you ever learned? (*-ción* → *-tion*.) The last? (*-ario* → *-ary*.)

What you've built

Sorted by **what they make**, which is more useful than the order you met them:

makes a thing

-ción → **-tion**

-dad → **-ty**

-ncia → **-nce**

makes a person

-ante → **-ant**

-ista → **-ist**

makes a describing word

-oso → **-ous**

-mente → **-ly**

makes either

-ario → **-ary**

Eight endings. Not one of them had to be memorised as vocabulary,

because each is the **same suffix** arriving in Spanish and English by different roads.

Grammar Lens: what each one costs you

Two things worth holding, because they save you a decision every time: **Gender is decided by the ending, not by you.** *-ncia* is always feminine. *-ista* and *-ante* never change at all. *-oso* and *-ario* end in *-o*, so they shift when they are adjectives.

Reach differs enormously. *-mente* is unbounded — it attaches to adjectives you have not met yet. *-ción* reaches about two thousand words. *-ario* reaches far fewer. They are all worth having; they are not all worth the same.

Your turn

- *Say it:* the eight endings, and what each one makes

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which ending has no upper limit? (***-mente***.) Which reaches about two thousand words? (***-ción***.) And what did you memorise to get them? (**Nothing**.)

Chapter 65

Synthesis — Reading a Paragraph

Modes:  voice (1)  Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can read a paragraph of Spanish I was never taught.

I can read a paragraph of Spanish I was never taught.

65.1 Synthesis — reading a paragraph

Decode *estación*. (**Station** — the *e-* off the front, the *-ción* to *-tion* at the back.)

Now a whole paragraph.

What you've built

Read it slowly. **Not one of these words appears anywhere else in this book.**

*La comunidad literaria tiene una tradición extraordinaria.
Su estructura es voluntaria, evidentemente, pero la
actividad es enorme.*

Now check yourself:

what you saw	how you got it
<i>comunidad</i>	-dad → -ty
<i>literaria</i>	-ario, agreeing → -ary
<i>tradición</i>	-ción → -tion
<i>extraordinaria</i>	-ario, agreeing → -ary
<i>estructura</i>	take the <i>e</i> - off → structure
<i>voluntaria</i>	-ario, agreeing → -ary
<i>evidentemente</i>	-mente → -ly
<i>actividad</i>	-dad → -ty

The literary community has an extraordinary tradition. Its structure is voluntary, evidently, but the activity is enormous.

Nine words. Eight fell to rules you hold, and the ninth is below.

Grammar Lens: what actually changed

The endings were never the point. This is:

A paragraph of unfamiliar Spanish is no longer a wall. Most of it is words you already know, wearing clothes you have learned to recognise. That change of expectation is worth more than any single word, because it is what lets you read above your level and get most of it — which is how the rest of the language arrives.

Enorme is the ninth, and no ending gives it to you. You guessed it anyway, from **enormous**, and the guess was right. That is what the rules are really for: they do not decode every word, they make the guessing **safe**.

Your turn

- *Say it*: the paragraph, out loud, all of it

Twice through:

Before you move on

How many of those words appear anywhere else in this book? (**None.**) How many did you read? (**All of them.**) And what is the real change? (An unfamiliar paragraph is **no longer a wall**.)

Chapter 66

Falsos Amigos — the Words That Obey and Lie

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can spot a false friend by checking a decoded word against the sentence.

*Recognise *exit*, *actualmente* and *librería* as words that obey the rules and mean something else.*

66.1 falsos amigos

Every rule in this book has come with the same warning: a **lead**, not a guarantee.

Today is the chapter where the lead is wrong, on purpose.

Grammar Lens: the words that answer and lie

**A false friend is not a word that breaks your rules.
It is a word that obeys them and still means
something else.**

A word that resists every rule just looks foreign, and you look it up. A false friend hands you an answer with a straight face.

Spanish	your rule says	it actually means
<i>éxito</i>	exit	success
<i>actualmente</i>	actually	currently
<i>librería</i>	library	bookshop
<i>embarazada</i>	embarrassed	pregnant
<i>ropa</i>	rope	clothes

Most are not coincidences. They are roots the two languages shared and then walked away from:

- *exitus* was a **going out**. English kept the door — *exit*. Spanish kept the outcome: the way a thing *came out*, then a good one. **Success.**
- Latin *actualis* was about **action**. Through Old French it came to mean *now existing*; Spanish kept that time sense, and English kept going, to *real*. Both moved — in different directions.
- A *librería* is where *libros* are: a **bookshop**. The building that lends them is a *biblioteca*.

One of the five is a genuine accident. *Ropa* is Germanic, from a word for *plunder*; *rope* is a different Germanic word. They did not drift apart — they collided. Both kinds exist.

Why it's said this way

The rule is not “distrust the rules.” Your endings are still right about two thousand *-ción* words. What this adds is a second question, asked **after** the ending answers:

Does the meaning fit what is being said?

Estoy embarazada, from someone apologising, is not *I am embarrassed* — the sentence would be strange. The ending offered a candidate; the **context** rejected it. Five false friends is not a list to memorise. It is a **habit**.

Your turn

- *Say it: éxito, actualmente, librería* — and what each really means

Twice through:

Before you move on

What makes a false friend dangerous rather than merely hard? (It **obeys** your rules.) And what is the second question, after the ending answers? (**Does the meaning fit the sentence?**)

Chapter 67

Tener in the Plural, and the Stem-Change Rule

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 👁️ eyes (1) 🦋 Hands-free start: none of the 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can use tener in every person, and state when a stem changes and when it does not.

The stem breaks exactly where it is stressed - so nosotros and vosotros never break, in any verb.

67.1 tenemos — and the stem change disappears

Say “I have” and “you have.” (*Tengo, tienes.*) And “we eat.” (*Comemos.*)

Grammar Lens: the break is gone

tenemos — *we have.* · **tenéis** — *you all have.*

Not *tenemos*. Look at what happened: *tienes* had the broken stem **ie**, and here it is plain **e** again — the ordinary *-er* endings, on the ordinary stem.

You already know why. It is the same reason **-er** and **-ir** looked identical in the singular and parted in the plural: **stress**.

Tienes stresses the stem, and a stressed **e** in that position breaks into **ie**. *Tenemos* stresses the *ending*, so the stem is unstressed and its vowel stays whole.

The stem change was never a property of the verb. It is a property of

where the stress lands, and these two forms are where the stress lands elsewhere.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “tienes” then “tenemos” — and hear the stress move off the stem
- “comemos, tenemos” — the same endings

Before you move on

What is “we have”? (**Tenemos.**) Where did the **ie** go? (Nowhere — it only ever appears when the **stem** is stressed.) Next: the form where the stress comes back.

67.2 **tienen** — the break comes back

Say “we have”, then “you have” to a friend. (*Tenemos, tienes.*) Which one has the broken stem?

Grammar Lens: the rule, stated once and for all

tienen — *they have*, and **ustedes tienen**, *you all have*.

The **ie** is back. And now you have seen it appear, vanish and return, which is enough to state the rule outright:

A stem change happens exactly where the stem is stressed, and nowhere else.

That is four forms with the break — setting aside the *yo* form, which has an oddity of its own — and two without: *nosotros* and *vosotros*. Always those two. In every stem-changing verb in the language. Learners are usually told to memorise a shape called “the boot” — the four stressed forms drawn as an outline around a table. **You do not need the boot.** You need to know where Spanish puts its stress, which you already do.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “tienes, tenemos, tienen” — break, no break, break
- the two forms that never break, for any verb

Before you move on

What is “they have”? (**Tienen.**) State the stem-change rule. (**The stem breaks exactly where it is stressed.**) Which two forms never break? (*Nosotros* and *vosotros*.)

Chapter 68

Ir in the Plural — a Verb That Is Not Ir

Modes: 🔄 voice (2) 🔄 Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can use *ir* in every person, and say why its present belongs to a different verb.

*The present of *ir* is regular for *vadere* - and the four commonest verbs are now complete.*

68.1 vamos — from a verb that is not *ir*

Say “I go.” (*Voy.*) And “we speak.” (*Hablamos.*)

Grammar Lens: -amos and -áis, on a stem you have not seen

vamos — *we go.* · **vais** — *you all go.*

The endings are ordinary. **-amos** and **-áis** are the plain *-ar* endings from *hablamos* and *habláis*.

What is strange is the stem. The infinitive is *ir*, and there is no *v* in it anywhere — yet every one of these forms begins with one.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

You met this shape two chapters ago and now you can use it as a tool.

Ir is not one verb. Latin had **īre**, “to go”, which gives the infinitive *ir* and little else. It also had **vādere**, “to advance, to make one’s way”,

which gives *voy, vas, va, vamos, vais* and one more — the entire present tense.

So the present of *ir* is not irregular. It is **regular for a different verb**, one whose infinitive Spanish stopped using. The endings behave perfectly; they are simply attached to a stem the dictionary form does not show you.

That is the third time this pattern has explained something: *ser* from *esse* and *sedēre*, and now *ir* from *īre* and *vādere*. **English does it too** — *go* and *went*, where *went* is really the past of *wend*.

The commonest verbs in a language are the likeliest to be made of more than one, because they are used so much that no single word's forms survive intact.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hablamos, vamos” — the same ending, an unexpected stem
- “voy, vas, va, vamos, vais” — all one verb, and it is not *ir*

Before you move on

What is “we go”? (**Vamos.**) Which Latin verb do these forms come from? (**Vādere.**) And what does that make *ir*? (**Two verbs**, like *ser* — and like English *go* and *went*.)

68.2 van — and the four are done

Say “we go.” (*Vamos.*) And “they speak.” (*Hablan.*)

Grammar Lens: the last form

van — *they go*, and **ustedes van**, *you all go*.

Latin's form was *vadunt*. Spanish wore it down to three letters, and the rule still holds visibly: a final **-n**, and the subject is plural and not you.

What you've built

Four chapters ago you could conjugate any *regular* verb in the present, and none of the irregular ones. Now the four commonest verbs in Spanish are complete in every person:

ser · **estar** · **tener** · **ir** — *to be, to be, to have, to go*.

And each one taught something that outlives it:

- **ser** — two Latin verbs fused, so the seam shows at *eres*.
- **estar** — one verb, so it is regular; the accent only marks stress.
- **tener** — the stem breaks exactly where it is stressed, in **every** stem-changing verb, which is why *nosotros* and *vosotros* never break.
- **ir** — its present belongs to a different verb entirely.

Three of those four are about the same underlying thing: **a verb that looks chaotic is usually more than one word**, and the places it looks regular are the places one word survived intact.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “somos, estamos, tenemos, vamos” — the four, in the *we* form
- “son, están, tienen, van” — the four, in the *they* form

Twice through: Until all four run without a gap.

Before you move on

What is “they go”? (**Van.**) Name the four verbs you have just completed. (*Ser, estar, tener, ir.*) And what do three of them have in common? (Each is **more than one Latin verb**, or its stem change follows the stress.)

Chapter 69

Verbs That Break in the Middle — the Stem Changers

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can express singular wanting and ability, compare the learned e-to-ie and o-to-ue changes, and say our with a known singular noun.

Complete ES-C11-practice, the canonical closing checkpoint, and demonstrate singular querer and poder, the learned vowel-change contrast, and nuestro or nuestra before a known singular noun.

69.1 querer — wanting with one familiar vowel change

You already say **tienes** and **tiene**, where the middle **e** opens into **ie**. Today, reuse that visible change in one useful verb and keep the same three-person frame you already own.

Sounds you'll need

- diphthong-ie — begin **quiero** with one smooth *kye*- syllable.
- r-tap — end the infinitive **querer** with one light tap.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

querer means “to want.” With a person as its object, it can also express love, but wanting is the meaning used in this lesson. It descends from Latin **quaerere**, “to seek or ask.” English keeps the same searching idea in **query**, **quest**, **inquire**, and **require**. Wanting something begins as seeking it.

Grammar Lens: only the three singular forms

person	present of querer
yo	quiero
tú	quieres
él / ella / usted	quiere

Say the small set as **quiero · quieres · quiere**. The **e** → **ie** that you saw in **tienes**, **tiene** is visible again. The plural persons are deliberately left for a later step.

Place one known infinitive after the form of **querer**:

- **Quiero hablar.** — “I want to speak.”
- **Quieres comer.** — “You want to eat.”
- **Quiere vivir.** — “He, she, or formal you wants to live.”

The second verb stays in its known infinitive form.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “querer — quiero, quieres, quiere”
- “Quiero hablar”
- “quaerere — query — querer”

Before you move on

What does *querer* mean? (“To want.”) Give the three learned forms. (*Quiero, quieres, quiere.*) Which Latin verb and English cousin help explain it? (*Quaerere*, “seek”; *query* or *quest.*) Next: add the other

singular vowel change with **poder**.

69.2 poder — ability with the o → ue change

Quiero hablar says what you want to do. Now change the first verb to say what you are able to do. The second verb will remain a known infinitive.

Sounds you'll need

- diphthong-ue — **puedo** begins *pwe-* with one smooth glide.
- r-tap — end **poder** with one light tap.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

poder means “to be able”; in a sentence it often translates as “can.” It descends through Latin **potere** from **posse**, “to be able.” English **power**, **potent**, **potential**, and **possible** belong to the same family. Ability is the power to do something.

Grammar Lens: the three singular forms

person	present of poder
yo	puedo
tú	puedes
él / ella / usted	puede

Say **puedo** · **puedes** · **puede**. In these three learned forms, the stem **o** opens into **ue**. Plural persons wait.

Follow the form of **poder** with one unchanged infinitive:

- **Puedo hablar.** — “I can speak.”
- **Puedes comer.** — “You can eat.”
- **Puede vivir.** — “He, she, or formal you can live.”

Compare **Quiero hablar** with **Puedo hablar**: only the first verb changes the meaning from want to ability.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “poder — puedo, puedes, puede”
- “Puedo hablar”
- “poder — power — possible”

Before you move on

What does *poder* mean? (“To be able; can.”) Give the three learned forms. (*Puedo, puedes, puede.*) What English word is its close cousin? (*Power.*) Next: compare only the singular forms you have actually learned.

69.3 e → ie and o → ue — compare the singular forms

You now own three small singular sets: **tengo, tienes, tiene**; **quiero, quieres, quiere**; and **puedo, puedes, puede**. Compare only those learned forms before extending the pattern later.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

On the road from Latin to Spanish, many short **e** and **o** vowels opened when stressed: **e → ie** and **o → ue**. That history helps explain why a verb’s stem can look different across its forms.

It is a clue, not a machine that predicts every form. Learn each verb’s small set, then use the shared history to organize what you remember.

Grammar Lens: two changes, one learned frame

person	tener / querer, e → ie family	poder, o → ue
yo	tengo / quiero	puedo
tú	tienes / quieres	puedes
él / ella / usted	tiene / quiere	puede

The comparison says exactly this:

- **querer** shows **ie** in all three forms learned here.
- **poder** shows **ue** in all three forms learned here.
- **tener** reminds you that a common verb may combine more than one change: **tengo** has its known **g**, while **tienes** and **tiene** show **ie**.

No plural form and no new verb is part of today's generalization.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “quiero, quieres, quiere”
- “puedo, puedes, puede”
- “stressed e and o often opened to ie and ue”

Before you move on

Which change appears in *querer*? (**e** → **ie**.) In *poder*? (**o** → **ue**.) Why is the history useful but not a complete prediction rule? (It organizes learned forms, but individual verbs can combine or resist changes.) Next: one possessive that agrees with a known noun's gender.

69.4 nuestro, nuestra — “our” with singular gender agreement

You put **mi**, **tu**, or **su** before the known noun **café**. Now add “our” and let it match one contrast you learned much earlier: masculine **día** beside feminine **noche**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

nuestro and **nuestra** mean “our.” They descend from Latin **noster**, also “our.” **Paternoster** means “Our Father,” and English **nostrum** originally meant “our thing.”

The change from *noster* to **nuestro** also displays the historical **o** →

ue opening you just used to organize **poder**.

Grammar Lens: match singular gender

known noun

“our” phrase

el **día**, masculine

nuestro día

la **noche**, feminine

nuestra noche

Like **mi**, **tu**, and **su**, the new word goes before the noun. Unlike those earlier forms, it shows the noun’s gender: **nuestro** before a masculine singular noun, **nuestra** before a feminine singular noun.

Only these two singular forms belong to this lesson. Plural agreement and the separate word for “your” to a group wait.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “nuestro día”
- “nuestra noche”
- “noster — nuestro — Paternoster”

Before you move on

Which form goes before masculine *día*? (*Nuestro*.) Before feminine *noche*? (*Nuestra*.) What Latin source explains the pair? (*Noster*, “our.”) Next: retrieve the whole chapter without adding a form.

69.5 Practice — wanting, ability, and our known nouns

This checkpoint adds nothing. Retrieve two three-form verbs, compare their two vowel changes, and choose **nuestro** or **nuestra** before one known singular noun.

Grammar Lens: the complete small chapter frame

- wanting: **quiero** · **quieres** · **quiere** plus a known infinitive.
- ability: **puedo** · **puedes** · **puede** plus a known infinitive.
- the contrast: **e** → **ie** in the learned *querer* set; **o** → **ue** in the learned *poder* set.
- singular “our”: **nuestro día** · **nuestra noche**.

Plural persons and plural possessive agreement remain deferred.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **querer** continues Latin *quaerere*, “seek,” the family of **query**.
- **poder** continues the Latin ability family behind **power** and **possible**.
- stressed Latin **e** and **o** often opened into Spanish **ie** and **ue**.
- **nuestro**, **nuestra** continue Latin *noster*, “our.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “quiero hablar; puedo hablar”
- “quieres comer; puedes comer”
- “nuestro día; nuestra noche”

Before you move on

Give the two singular sets. (*Quiero, quieres, quiere; puedo, puedes, puede.*) Which vowel contrast organizes them? (**e** → **ie** beside **o** → **ue**.) Say “our day” and “our night.” (*Nuestro día; nuestra noche.*) The next chapter can now build from this closed singular frontier.

Chapter 70

Hacer, Decir, and the -go Verb Club

Modes: 🗣️ voice (3) 👁️ eyes (1) 🖱️ Hands-free start: first 2 of 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can use the three learned singular forms of *hacer* and *decir* and compare *tengo*, *hago*, and *digo* without predicting unseen verbs.

Complete ES-C12-practice, the canonical closing checkpoint, and demonstrate the chapter promise with known words and only the learned singular person frame.

70.1 *hacer* — doing or making with three singular forms

You already use **tengo**, **tienes**, **tiene**, and you already know **café** and the question word **qué**. Reuse that small frontier for one verb that covers both English “do” and “make.”

Sounds you’ll need

The **h** in **hacer** is silent, just as it is in **hola**. In **hago**, the written **g** has the hard sound heard before **a**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hacer means “to do” or “to make.” It descends from Latin **facere**, with the same making root preserved in English **fact**, **factory**, and **manufacture**. Much of early Castilian changed word-initial Latin **f**

into an **h** sound that later became silent, leaving the spelling as a historical trace.

Grammar Lens: only the three singular forms

person	present of <i>hacer</i>
yo	hago
tú	haces
él / ella / usted	hace

Say the bounded set as **hago · haces · hace**. Only the learned **yo** form contains **g**. Compare it with the familiar **tengo**, but do not extend the comparison beyond forms you already own.

Use the forms with one known object:

- **Hago café.** — “I make coffee.”
- **Haces café.** — “You make coffee.”
- **Hace café.** — “He, she, or formal you makes coffee.”

You can also ask **¿Qué haces?** — “What are you doing?” Plural persons and weather expressions wait for later lessons.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hacer — hago, haces, hace”
- “¿Qué haces? Hago café.”
- “facere — fact — factory — hacer”

Before you move on

What two English verbs does *hacer* cover? (“Do” and “make.”) Give the three learned forms. (*Hago, haces, hace.*) Which Latin source and English cousin help explain it? (*Facere; fact* or *factory.*) Next: add **decir** without widening the person frame.

70.2 decir — saying with the same small person frame

You can ask **cómo**, say **hola**, and retrieve **hago**, **haces**, **hace**.
Keep those three persons fixed while adding the verb “to say.”

Sounds you’ll need

In **dig**o, the **g** before **o** is hard. Keep the **i** in all three learned forms short and clear: **dig**o, **dices**, **dice**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

decir means “to say” or “to tell.” It descends from Latin **dicere**, “to say.” English keeps the same root in **diction**, **dictionary**, **predict** (“say beforehand”), and **verdict** (“a true saying”).

Grammar Lens: one more three-form set

person	present of decir
yo	dig o
tú	dices
él / ella / usted	dice

Say **dig**o · **dices** · **dice**. The **yo** form has **g**, while the other two learned forms do not. Do not build a full table or a general vowel-change rule from this small set yet.

Now combine it only with known language:

- **Digo hola.** — “I say hello.”
- **Dices hola.** — “You say hello.”
- **Dice hola.** — “He, she, or formal you says hello.”
- **¿Cómo dices “hola”?** — “How do you say ‘hello’?”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “decir — digo, dices, dice”

- “Digo hola. ¿Cómo dices hola?”
- “dicere — diction — decir”

Before you move on

What does *decir* mean? (“To say” or “to tell.”) Give the three learned forms. (*Digo, dices, dice.*) Which Latin source and English cousin help explain it? (*Dicere; diction, dictionary, or predict.*) Next: compare only the three **yo** forms you have actually learned.

70.3 tengo · hago · digo — compare only what you know

Three learned verbs now place **g** in the **yo** form: **tengo, hago, digo**. Compare those three without guessing the form of any unseen verb.

Grammar Lens: one visible corner

infinitive	meaning	learned yo form	learned tú form
tener	to have	tengo	tienes
hacer	to do / make	hago	haces
decir	to say / tell	digo	dices

The shared observation is narrow: each learned **yo** form ends in **-go**, while each learned **tú** form does not. This is a memory organizer for three known forms, not permission to manufacture new ones.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The three modern forms did not arise by attaching one productive Latin **-go** ending. Older stem sounds changed in different ways, and analogy helped common verbs converge on a familiar shape. That mixed history explains why the group is useful to remember but unsafe as a prediction rule.

Later lessons can introduce other verbs on their own evidence. For now, the complete comparison is exactly **tengo · hago · digo**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “tengo — hago — digo”
- “tienes — haces — dices”
- “a memory organizer, not a prediction machine”

Before you move on

Which three learned **yo** forms end in **-go**? (*Tengo, hago, digo.*) May this comparison predict an unseen verb? (No.) Why not? (Different sound histories and analogy converged on the same shape.) Next: retrieve the whole chapter without adding any word or form.

70.4 Practice — doing, making, and saying in the singular

This checkpoint adds nothing. Retrieve two bounded three-form sets, use them with known words, and compare only **tengo**, **hago**, **digo**.

Grammar Lens: the complete small chapter frame

- doing or making: **hago** · **haces** · **hace**.
- saying or telling: **digo** · **dices** · **dice**.
- the learned **yo** comparison: **tengo** · **hago** · **digo**.
- known-word use: **Hago** café. **Digo** hola. ¿Cómo **dices** “hola”?

Plural persons, weather nouns, homework vocabulary, and unseen verbs remain outside this checkpoint.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **hacer** continues Latin *facere*, the making family of **fact** and **factory**.

- **decir** continues Latin *dicere*, the saying family of **diction** and **predict**.
- inherited sound changes and analogy made three known **yo** forms converge on **-go**; the resemblance does not predict forms you have not learned.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hago, haces, hace”
- “digo, dices, dice”
- “tengo, hago, digo”
- “Hago café. Digo hola.”

Before you move on

Give both three-form sets. (*Hago, haces, hace; digo, dices, dice.*) Which three learned **yo** forms share **-go**? (*Tengo, hago, digo.*) Why is that comparison a memory aid rather than a prediction rule? (Its mixed history does not license unseen forms.) The next chapter may now introduce its own verbs one at a time.

Chapter 71

Poner — Putting, and the Root Under Position

Modes: 🔄 voice (1) 🔄 Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I put, with the -go yo form and regular forms elsewhere.

pongo in the yo slot, pones and pone everywhere else.

71.1 poner — putting or placing with three singular forms

You already know **hago**, **haces**, **hace** and the careful comparison **tengo** · **hago** · **digo**. Add one verb on its own evidence: **poner**, “to put” or “to place.”

Sounds you’ll need

The **g** in **pongo** has the familiar hard sound. Tap the final **r** of **poner** lightly; do not turn it into the stronger written **rr** sound.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

poner descends from Latin **pōnere**, “to put or place.” English keeps the same placing family in **position**, **compose** (“place together”), and **deposit** (“place down”). The two shapes **pon-** and **pos-** are historical relatives, so *poner* and *position* are cousins even though their endings differ.

Grammar Lens: only the three singular forms

person	present of poner
yo	pongo
tú	pones
él / ella / usted	pone

Say the bounded set as **pongo · pones · pone**. The learned **yo** form joins the known comparison because it ends in **-go**. That resemblance helps memory; it still does not predict an unseen verb. For now, practise the forms and their meaning without importing a new object. Later lessons can add the nouns needed for expressions such as setting a table or putting on clothing. Plural persons and reflexive **ponerse** also wait.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “poner — pongo, pones, pone”
- “pōnere — position — poner”
- “a learned comparison, not a prediction rule”

Before you move on

What does *poner* mean? (“To put” or “to place.”) Give its three learned forms. (*Pongo, pones, pone.*) Which Latin source and English cousin help explain it? (*Pōnere; position, compose, or deposit.*) Next: learn **salir** inside the same three-person frame.

Chapter 72

Salir — Leaving

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say that I leave, and use the regular forms for anyone else.

salgo in the yo slot; sales and sale behave normally.

72.1 salir — leaving with three singular forms

You can retrieve **pongo**, **pones**, **pone**, and you already use **de** with a place name. Keep that frontier while adding **salir**, “to leave” or “to go out.”

Sounds you’ll need

The **g** in **salgo** is hard. Keep the **l** clear in every form: **salgo**, **sales**, **sale**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

salir descends from Latin **salīre**, “to leap” or “to jump.” The older image of leaping outward developed into the everyday meaning “to go out.” English **salient** first carried the sense “leaping” or “springing,” and a **sally** is a sudden movement outward. Those cousins preserve the same motion without requiring a long list of uncertain relatives.

Grammar Lens: one more singular set

person	present of salir
yo	salgo
tú	sales
él / ella / usted	sale

Say **salgo** • **sales** • **sale**. Only the learned **yo** form contains **g**. Compare it with **pongo** because both forms are now known, not because one form could have predicted the other.

Reuse the known word **de** and the familiar place name Madrid:

- **Salgo de Madrid.** — “I leave Madrid.”
- **Sales de Madrid.** — “You leave Madrid.”
- **Sale de Madrid.** — “He, she, or formal you leaves Madrid.”

Plural persons, dating expressions, house vocabulary, and the noun for “exit” wait until their own lessons.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “salir — salgo, sales, sale”
- “Salgo de Madrid.”
- “salire — salient — salir”

Before you move on

What does *salir* mean? (“To leave” or “to go out.”) Give the three learned forms. (*Salgo, sales, sale.*) What did Latin *salire* mean? (“To leap” or “to jump.”) Name one English cousin. (*Salient* or *sally.*) Next: add **venir** and compare it only with already-learned **tener**.

Chapter 73

Venir — Coming

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say that I come, and hear the stem break in the other two forms.

vengo, then vienes and viene with the ie break.

73.1 venir — coming with three singular forms

You can say **salgo de Madrid**, and you already know **tengo**, **tienes**, **tiene**. Now learn **venir**, “to come,” inside exactly the same three singular persons.

Sounds you’ll need

The **g** in **vengo** is hard. In **vienes** and **viene**, let **ie** move as one smooth vowel sequence.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

venir descends from Latin **venīre**, “to come.” English **convene** means “come together”; an **event** is something that “comes out”; and **adventure** passed through the idea of what may “come to” a person. The recurring **ven-** or **vent-** shape marks this old coming family.

Grammar Lens: one known comparison, still singular

person	present of venir	known tener comparison
yo	vengo	tengo
tú	vienes	tienes
él / ella / usted	viene	tiene

Say **vengo** · **vienes** · **viene**. The learned singular forms line up closely with **tengo** · **tienes** · **tiene**: the **yo** form ends in **-go**, while the other two show **ie**. This comparison describes two complete learned sets; it does not introduce a plural “boot” table or license guesses about other verbs.

Now contrast leaving and coming with known **de** and Madrid:

- **Salgo de Madrid.** — “I leave Madrid.”
- **Vengo de Madrid.** — “I come from Madrid.”
- **Vienes de Madrid.** — “You come from Madrid.”

Plural persons and free-standing arrival vocabulary wait for later lessons.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “venir — vengo, vienes, viene”
- “Vengo de Madrid.”
- “vengo / tengo — vienes / tienes”

Before you move on

What does *venir* mean? (“To come.”) Give its three learned forms. (*Vengo, vienes, viene.*) Which learned verb provides the close comparison? (*Tener: tengo, tienes, tiene.*) Which Latin source and English cousin help explain it? (*Venire; convene, event, or adventure.*) Next: compare all six learned **yo** forms only after retrieving this chapter’s three verbs.

Chapter 74

Review — Six Verbs, One Ending

Modes: 🗣️ voice (2) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name all six -go verbs and say why the list is closed.

The club is complete at six - and it was never a club, only six unrelated verbs that converged.

74.1 Review — six verbs, one ending

Nothing new in this chapter. Say the *yo* forms of the three verbs you have just met: *poner, salir, venir*.

What you've built

The set is closed. Six of the commonest verbs in Spanish put an unexpected **-go** on the *yo* form and nowhere else:

verb	<i>yo</i>	and the rest behaves
tener	tengo	normally
hacer	hago	normally
decir	digo	normally
poner	pongo	normally
salir	salgo	normally
venir	vengo	normally

Six verbs, one oddity, and it lives in exactly one slot. That is a much smaller thing to carry than “six irregular verbs.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Here is what the six chapters could not show you separately.

They are not a family. Nobody decided these six belonged together. They came from different Latin verbs, by different routes, and arrived at the same ending by accident — a *g* that was already in some of the stems, and a sound change that pulled the others into line behind them.

The club is a result, not a rule. Spanish learners are taught “the *-go* verbs” as though someone had drawn up a membership list; what actually happened is that six unrelated words drifted into the same shape and then reinforced each other.

That is worth knowing for a practical reason: it tells you the list is **closed**. A pattern with a cause keeps recruiting. A pattern that is an accident stops.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all six *yo* forms in one breath — *tengo, hago, digo, pongo, salgo, vengo*
- for each, the plain infinitive it came from

Twice through: Until the six run together as one list.

Before you move on

How many verbs take *-go*? (**Six**.) In how many slots? (**One** — the *yo* form.) And why does the list not grow? (Because it was never a rule — six unrelated verbs happened to converge.)

74.2 Practice — putting, leaving, and coming in the singular

This checkpoint adds nothing. Retrieve the three bounded singular sets first. Only then widen the memory comparison from three learned *yo* forms to six.

Grammar Lens: the complete frame for this chapter

- putting or placing: **pongo** • **pones** • **pone**.
- leaving or going out: **salgo** • **sales** • **sale**.
- coming: **vengo** • **vienes** • **viene**.
- known-word contrast: **Salgo de Madrid. Vengo de Madrid.**
- known singular comparison: **vengo / tengo** • **vienes / tienes** • **viene / tiene**.

Now that all three new verbs have been taught, the learned **yo** comparison can grow to exactly **tengo** • **hago** • **digo** • **pongo** • **salgo** • **vengo**. It remains a retrieval aid, not a rule for predicting any unseen verb.

Plural persons, full boot diagrams, reflexive clothing expressions, house and table nouns, clock times, dinner vocabulary, and other unseen contexts remain outside this checkpoint.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **poner** continues Latin *pōnere*, the placing family of **position**.
- **salir** continues Latin *salīre*, the leaping family of **salient**.
- **venir** continues Latin *venīre*, the coming family of **convene**.
- different inherited histories and analogy let the six known **yo** forms converge on **-go**; the shared shape does not make a productive prediction rule.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “pongo, pones, pone”
- “salgo, sales, sale”
- “vengo, vienes, viene”
- “tengo, hago, digo, pongo, salgo, vengo”

Before you move on

Give all three new singular sets. (*Pongo, pones, pone; salgo, sales, sale; vengo, vienes, viene.*) Which six learned **yo** forms now share **-go**? (*Tengo, hago, digo, pongo, salgo, vengo.*) Why is the list a memory aid rather than a prediction rule? (Different histories converged on one shape.) The next chapter may now introduce a new time frame without borrowing any plural form from this chapter.

Chapter 75

Synthesis — You, and Somebody Else

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say the same thing about myself and about someone else, and know which of the two is irregular.

The oddity lives only in the yo slot - the form a beginner says most.

75.1 Synthesis — you, and somebody else

Nothing new here. Say three of the six *-go* forms, whichever come first.

Grammar Lens: the odd slot is the one about you

Here is the practical shape of what you have, and it is worth noticing before you use it.

These six verbs are irregular **only when you talk about yourself**.

Every one of them behaves normally the moment the sentence is about anybody else:

salgo — but *sales, sale*. **pongo** — but *pones, pone*. **vengo**
— but *vienes, viene*.

So the cost of the whole set is one form each, and it is the form you will use most, because most of what a beginner says is about themselves.

That is a good trade, and it is not an accident of teaching order: the verbs that wore down oddly are the ones people said constantly.

The exchange

The same two sentences, once about you and once about a friend. Watch which word changes shape and which does not:

Salgo. — *I'm leaving.* **Sales.** — *You're leaving.*

>

Vengo. — *I'm coming.* **Viene.** — *He's coming.*

One word each time, no pronoun, and the only surprise is in the first line of each pair.

What you've built

Six of the most common verbs in the language, in the person you speak in most. You can now say that you have, do, say, put, leave and come — about yourself, in one word, with no pronoun.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- each pair above — first about yourself, then about someone else
- all six *yo* forms, then all six *tú* forms, and hear the difference vanish

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which slot in these six verbs is irregular? (**Only** the *yo* form.) How many words does “I’m leaving” take? (**One** — *salgo*.) Why is that one form worth the trouble? (Because it is the one you will say most.)

Chapter 76

Deriving the Rest

Modes: ⇐ voice (2) 👁 eyes (1) ⇐ Hands-free start: first 1 of 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can produce the plural of any irregular verb in this book from rules, and conjugate a verb I was never shown.

Three rules generate the whole present tense - and a system, unlike a table, works on words it has never seen.

76.1 queremos, quieren — work them out first

Before you read on: you have the singular of *querer*, and you have the stem-change rule. **What is “we want”?** Say your answer out loud, then continue.

Grammar Lens: you were right

queremos — *we want.* · **quieren** — *they want.*
podemos — *we can.* · **pueden** — *they can.*

If you said *queremos* rather than *quieremos*, you did not remember it. You **derived** it, from a rule you were given one chapter ago: the stem breaks exactly where it is stressed, so *nosotros* never breaks. And *quieren* breaks, because there the stress is back on the stem. That is the difference between a course that hands you tables and one that hands you rules. Four forms you had never seen, and none of them needed teaching.

A test you can run yourself. You have *puedo* and

puedes. Without being told, what are *we can* and *they can*?

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the *yo*, *nosotros* and *ellos* forms of *querer* — break, no break, break
- the same three for *poder*

Before you move on

What is “we want”? (**Queremos**.) Why no break? (The stress is on the **ending**.) And could you have produced these without this lesson? (**Yes** — which is the point of it.)

76.2 hacemos, hacen — and the club has no plural at all

Name the six *-go* verbs. And say where in each one the *-go* appears.

Grammar Lens: an oddity that was only ever in one slot

You were told, when the club closed, that the **-go** lives in the *yo* form and nowhere else. Here is what that is worth:

hacemos · **hacéis** · **hacen** — plain *-er* endings.
ponemos · **ponéis** · **ponen** — plain *-er* endings.
salimos · **salís** · **salen** — plain *-ir* endings.

Nothing to learn. The *-go* club has no plural forms of its own, because the thing that made it a club was never in the plural to begin with. Two of the six do something in the plural, and it is **not** the *-go*:

decimos but **dicen** · **venimos** but **vienen**

Those are stem changes, and they follow the rule you already have — the stem breaks where it is stressed, and *nosotros* is never stressed on the stem. So even the exceptions are not exceptions.

What you've built

Two rules — **the -go is yo-only**, and **stems break under stress** — now generate the entire present tense of every irregular verb in this book, in every person.

That is what a rule buys that a table does not: the table stops at the forms printed on it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all six *-go* verbs in the *we* form — and hear that none is odd
- “decimos, dicen” and “venimos, vienen” — the two that break, and why

Before you move on

How many special plural forms does the *-go* club have? (**None** — the *-go* was only ever in *yo*.) Which two do something in the plural, and what? (*Decir* and *venir* — a **stem change**, following the stress.) How many rules now generate every irregular present in this book? (**Two**.)

76.3 Synthesis — a verb you have never met

Nothing new in this chapter, and nothing to memorise. Say the six endings of a regular *-er* verb.

What you've built

Everything you hold about the present tense now fits in three lines:

1. **Three families**, six endings each; **-er** and **-ir** differ only in *nosotros* and *vosotros*. 2. **A stem breaks exactly where it is stressed** — so *nosotros* and *vosotros* never break. 3. **A -go sits in the yo form and nowhere else.**

That is the whole system. Not a summary of it — the system. And a system, unlike a table, works on words it has never seen.

The exchange

Here is a verb this book has not taught you: **beber**, “to drink” — you have met the word, but never its full set.

Do not look anything up. It is a regular **-er** verb, so:

bebo · bebes · bebe · bebemos · bebéis · beben

Six forms, and the only thing you needed was rule 1.

Now one that uses all three rules. **Salir** is an **-ir** verb, and it is in the **-go** club. Rules 1 and 3 give you every form, and you can produce them before reading on:

salgo · sales · sale · salimos · salís · salen

One odd form, in the one slot rule 3 names. The other five are plain **-ir**.

Four broken, two whole, and the two whole ones are the two the stress leaves alone. Every time.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all six of *beber*, without looking
- all six of *salir*, and name the only odd one

Twice through: Until deriving is faster than remembering.

Before you move on

State the three rules. (**Three families · stems break under stress · the -go is yo-only.**) Which two forms never break? (*Nosotros, vosotros.*) And what can you do now that a table could not give you? (**Conjugate a verb nobody taught me.**)

Chapter 77

La Comida — A Noun You Can Build

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗋️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can build comida from comer with -ida, and know that nouns made this way are feminine.

Complete ES-C43-comida: derive comida from comer and say what gender the -ida ending guarantees.

77.1 la comida — “food,” built from a verb you have

Say “to eat.” (*Comer.*) Keep it in mind — this chapter’s noun is made out of it, in front of you.

Sounds you’ll need

- **d-soft** — the *d* between vowels is soft, close to the *th* in English *this*: *ko-MEE-thah*, not a hard *d*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la comida — *food*, and also *a meal*.

Take *comer*, drop the ending, add **-ida**:

comer → **comida** — literally *the eaten thing*.

That ending is not decoration. It is a working tool: it takes a verb and

hands you back a noun for the **result** of that verb. You will meet it again and recognise it when you do.

This is the first Spanish noun you did not have to be given. You could have built it. That is a different kind of possession from memorising a list, and it is the reason the ending is worth more here than the word.

Comer itself comes from Latin **comedere** — *ed-* is “eat,” the same ancient root as English **eat**, with *com-* (“thoroughly”) in front. So *comida* is, at the bottom, “the thoroughly-eaten thing.”

Grammar Lens: -ida nouns are feminine

Nouns built this way end in *-a* and are **feminine**, every time. So the ending gives you two things at once: the word, and its gender.

la comida — the food. *Hago la comida.* — I make the meal.

Set your three nouns side by side and the pattern is doing all the work:

noun	gender	article
<i>libro</i>	masculine	el
<i>casa</i>	feminine	la
<i>comida</i>	feminine	la

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “comer” then “comida” — hear the verb inside the noun
- “Hago la comida”

Before you move on

What verb is hiding inside *comida*? (**Comer**.) What does the *-ida* ending give you besides the word? (Its **gender** — always feminine.) Next: what happens to these three nouns, and to their articles, when there is more than one of something.

Chapter 78

Las — The Plural Article That Behaves

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗋️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say *las casas* and *las comidas*, putting the plural -s on both the article and the noun.

Complete ES-C44-las: produce *las casas* and *las comidas* and say how many new rules the chapter added.

78.1 las casas — “the houses”

You learned this in your first chapter: a noun ending in a vowel adds **-s**. So what is “houses”? (*Casas*.) Now — what is “**the** houses”?

Grammar Lens: the article does what the noun does

las — *the*, for more than one feminine thing.

la casa → **las casas** — the houses. *la comida* → **las comidas** — the meals.

The **-s** lands on **both** words. That is not two rules; it is one rule applied where it belongs. You have already seen Spanish do this — *buenas noches* is *buena* copying *noche*’s number — and it is the same instinct throughout the language: **the words around a noun agree with it**, so when the noun goes plural, they follow.

So *las* is not a word to memorise. It is *la* obeying the rule you already hold.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “la casa” then “las casas” — hear the *-s* twice
- “las comidas”

Before you move on

“The houses”? (***Las casas.***) Where did the *-s* go? (**Both** words.)

Next: the masculine one, which does not do the obvious thing —
and the reason will be familiar.

Chapter 79

Los — The One That Does Not Add -s

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say *los libros* and explain why the masculine plural article is not *els*.

Complete ES-C44-los: produce *los libros*, give all four articles, and say why *el* does not simply take an *-s*.

79.1 los libros — “the books”

Last chapter: *la casa* → *las casas*. Apply the same move to *el libro* and say what you get, out loud, before reading on.

Grammar Lens: not els

If you said *els libros*, you did exactly the right thing and Spanish did not.

los — *the*, for more than one masculine thing.

el libro → **los libros** — the books.

The noun behaved. The article did not: *el* became **los**, not *els*. Out of four articles this is the only one that changes more than its ending, and it is worth two minutes rather than a shrug.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

You have met this exact story before, three chapters ago, wearing different clothes.

El is not a whole word that lost its way. It is a **worn-down** one: Latin *illum* gave *elo*, and *elo* lost its final vowel to become *el*. The plural came from *illos* — and it did **not** lose that vowel. It kept it, dropped the front instead, and arrived as **los**.

So the pair is not *el* + *s*. It is two forms of one Latin word that wore down in two different directions:

	singular	plural
masculine	<i>elo</i> → el	<i>illos</i> → los
feminine	<i>illam</i> → la	<i>illas</i> → las

This is the same shape as *el* and *lo*, which you met when the object pronouns started: the masculine forms lost a vowel where the feminine ones had none to lose. One sound change, showing up for the third time.

An “irregular” article turns out to be a regular word that was worn down twice.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “el libro” then “los libros”
- “el, la, los, las” — the whole set, in order

Before you move on

“The books”? (**Los libros**.) Why not *els*? (*El* is worn down from *elo*; the **plural kept the vowel**.) Next: the plural rule your first chapter promised and did not give you.

Chapter 80

-es — The Plural Chapter One Promised

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗋️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can form the plural of a word ending in a consonant, and say why the extra vowel is there.

Complete ES-C44-plural-es: pluralise espanol, name the word that has carried this rule since long before the chapter, and say why -s alone will not do.

80.1 -es — the plural your first chapter owed you

Say “you,” formally. (*Usted.*) Now say it to a group. (*Ustedes.*) Hold both of those in your mouth for a moment.

Grammar Lens: you have been doing this for fifty chapters

Your first chapter gave you half a rule and said the rest was for later. This is later.

A word ending in a vowel adds -s. A word ending in a consonant adds -es.

And you already know the second half, because you have been saying it since the day you learned to address a group:

usted → *ustedes*.

That is not a special word. That is the consonant rule, and nobody told you. Here it is again on something you also hold:

español → *españoles* — Spanish people, Spanish speakers.
los españoles — with the plural article from last chapter.

Why it's said this way

The extra *e* is not decoration and not an exception. Try saying *usted*s out loud. Then *españols*.

Spanish does not let a word end in that pile of consonants. So when the plural *-s* would land somewhere unsayable, the language puts in the vowel it needs to get the *-s* out — and that vowel is *e*.

Which means the rule is really **one** rule with a repair attached: *add -s; if you cannot say it, make room*. That is a better thing to hold than two rules, because it will keep explaining things long after this chapter.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “usted” then “ustedes” — the rule you already had
- “los españoles”
- try “usteds” and hear why the *e* exists

Before you move on

Vowel ending — which plural? (**-s**.) Consonant ending? (**-es**.) And why? (A bare *-s* there would be **unsayable**.) Next: the four articles in one place, now that every one of them has been earned.

Chapter 81

Review — All Four Words for The

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can give el, la, los and las and state the plural rule including its consonant repair.

Complete ES-C44-repaso-articulos: give the four articles in order and state the plural rule in one sentence.

81.1 Review — all four words for “the”

Nothing new here. Before the table: how many words does Spanish have for “the”?

What you’ve built

Four. And you have now met every one of them separately, which is why they are allowed to appear together.

	singular	plural
masculine	el libro	los libros
feminine	la casa	las casas

English has one word here and Spanish has four, so it is easy to read this table as three extra things to carry. It is not. It is **two** questions you were already answering — *which gender?* and *how many?* — laid out in a grid.

The first chapter of this book taught the top row. The last two chapters taught the bottom one. Nothing in this table arrived without being built.

Grammar Lens: the two plural rules

And underneath the grid, one rule with a repair:

Add -s. If the word ends in a consonant and the -s would be unsayable, add -es instead.

- *casa* → *casas*, *libro* → *libros*, *comida* → *comidas* — vowels, plain -s.
- *usted* → *ustedes*, *español* → *españoles* — consonants, -es.

You held the first half from chapter one and the second half from *ustedes* without knowing it had a name.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “el, la, los, las” until the order is automatic
- “el libro, los libros, la casa, las casas”

Twice through: Until the grid is a reflex rather than a lookup.

Before you move on

Four articles — say them. (***El, la, los, las.***) Two questions decide which? (**Gender** and **number.**) Next: what happens to *a* when there is more than one — and the answer is not what you would expect.

Chapter 82

Synthesis — More Than One

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can contrast a bare plural with a definite plural, and know that the indefinite article is dropped rather than pluralised.

Complete ES-C44-sintesis-mas-de-uno: say tengo libros and tengo los libros and explain what separates them.

82.1 Synthesis — more than one

Say “I have a book.” (*Tengo un libro.*) Now say “I have books,” and notice where you hesitate.

Grammar Lens: the article that leaves

The hesitation is the right instinct. *The* pluralised neatly — *el* became *los*. *A* cannot, because “a” and “more than one” disagree by definition. English solves this by swapping in another word: *a book* → *some books*, or just *books*. Spanish takes the shorter road:

*Tengo **un** libro.* — I have a book. *Tengo **libros**.* — I have books.

The article simply goes. Not replaced, not pluralised — dropped. A bare plural noun is a complete, ordinary Spanish phrase. This is the mirror image of everything you have been doing. For fifty chapters Spanish has made you say *more* than English: two genders, four articles, six verb endings. Here, for once, it says less.

The exchange

Read this aloud and watch the two plurals doing different jobs.

— *¿Tienes libros?* — *Sí, tengo libros.* — *¿Y los libros de la casa?* — *Los libros de la casa, no.*

Bare *libros* means “books, some books, books in general.” *Los libros* means “**the** books” — particular ones, already known to both of you.

That is the same distinction English makes and never explains: *do you have books?* is a different question from *do you have the books?* You have simply never had to choose it deliberately before.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Tengo un libro” then “Tengo libros” — hear the article vanish
- “libros” then “los libros”, twice, until the two feel like different questions

Before you move on

“I have books”? (*Tengo libros* — no article.) “I have the books”? (*Tengo los libros*.) Which article pluralises and which one leaves? (**The** pluralises; **a** leaves.) Next: the small words that let you stop naming a thing you have already named.

Chapter 83

Lo — Saying It Without Naming It

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can replace a masculine noun already named with *lo*, in front of the verb.

*Complete ES-C42-lo: turn *Tengo el libro* into *Lo tengo*, and name the article that shares *lo*'s Latin ancestor.*

83.1 lo — “it”

Say “my name is” in Spanish. (*Me llamo.*) Where does that little *me* sit — before the verb, or after it?

Grammar Lens: a slot you have been using all along

Before the verb. You have known that since your fourth chapter, and you have been doing it every time you say your name. Here is a second word for that same slot.

lo — *it*, standing in for something masculine.

Watch what it does:

Tengo el libro. — I have the book. **Lo** *tengo.* — I have it.

The noun leaves; *lo* takes its place; and it goes where *me* goes — in front of the verb. Not one new rule. One new word for a slot you already own.

Notice that this only became possible last chapter. A pronoun replaces a noun, so it needs a noun to replace — which is why these three ordinary words came first.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Lo should look faintly familiar, and it should also look wrong. It is almost *el*, but not quite. That is not a coincidence, and the near-miss has a cause.

Latin *ille*, “that one,” changed shape depending on the job it was doing. As the **object** of a verb it was **illum**. Spanish got both its article and its object pronoun out of that one word — and then wore it down twice, differently, because the two jobs put the stress in different places:

- Leaning on a noun, unstressed, it lost its vowel: *illum* → *elo* → *el*.
- Standing alone in the verb’s slot, it kept the vowel: *illum* → *lo*.

So *el* and *lo* are the same ancient word, split by the work it was asked to do. English did something similar with *he* and *him*: one word, two shapes, and the shape tells you the job.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Tengo el libro” then “Lo tengo” — hear the noun disappear
- “me llamo” then “lo tengo” — the same slot, twice

Before you move on

What does *lo* mean? (**It** — for something masculine.) Where does it go? (**Before** the verb.) Next: the same job, done by a word that never changed its shape at all.

Chapter 84

La — The Pronoun Carries What Left

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗋️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can replace a feminine noun with *la*, and explain that the pronoun carries a gender the sentence no longer states.

Complete ES-C42-la: turn Hago la comida into La hago and say what decides between lo and la.

84.1 la — “it,” for a feminine noun

Say “I have it,” about the book. (*Lo tengo.*) Now guess the feminine version before you read on.

Grammar Lens: the form you probably guessed

la — *it*, standing in for something feminine.

Hago la comida. — I make the meal. **La hago.** — I make it.

If you guessed *la*, you were not lucky. You were doing what the shape of Spanish invites you to do: *el* and *la* mark the two genders everywhere else, so the object pronouns mark them the same way. The pronoun agrees with the **noun it replaces** — not with you, and not with the verb. *El libro* is masculine, so *lo*. *La comida* and *la casa* are feminine, so *la*.

That last point is worth pausing on. *La* here is not agreeing with anything present in the sentence. The noun is **gone**; the pronoun is carrying its gender on its behalf. This is the first time in Spanish that a word has had to remember something that is no longer being said.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Last chapter had a small mystery: why *lo* and not *el*, when both come from the same Latin word? Here that mystery quietly disappears. The feminine object form in Latin was **illam**. Worn down as an article it gave *la*. Worn down as a pronoun it gave — *la*. Both routes arrived at the same place, because the vowel that got lost on the masculine side (*elo* → *el*) was never at risk on the feminine side. So the masculine pair split into two shapes and the feminine pair did not. Not an exception to memorise: a single sound change that happened to bite one word and not the other.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Hago la comida” then “La hago”
- “lo tengo” then “la hago” — one syllable carries the whole difference

Before you move on

Which pronoun replaces a feminine noun? (**La**.) What decides it — you, the verb, or the noun? (The **noun**, even though it is no longer there.) Next: the same slot, for the two people actually talking.

Chapter 85

Me and Te — The Two People Talking

Modes: 🔄 voice (2) 🔄 Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say *te quiero* and *me quieres*, and tell the doer form apart from the object form.

Complete ES-C42-te: produce te quiero and me quieres, and name the English pair that matches tu and te.

85.1 me quieres — “you love me”

Say “my name is.” (*Me llamo.*) That *me* has been in your mouth for more than fifty chapters. This chapter gives it nothing new to look like — only something new to do.

Grammar Lens: the same word, a simpler job

In *me llamo*, the *me* points back at the speaker: *I call myself*. That is a special use, and it was the one you needed first.

Here is the ordinary one:

***Me* quieres.** — You love **me**.

Now *me* is not pointing back at anybody. It is simply the person the verb lands on — the same job *lo* does for a book and *la* does for a meal.

Lo tengo. — I have it. *Me quieres.* — You love me.

Same slot, in front of the verb. Same kind of work. The only difference is that *me* is a person and *lo* is a thing, which is a fact about the world rather than a fact about Spanish.

Notice what this chapter did **not** ask you to learn: a form. You already had it. Some of the ground you gain in a language is like this — not new material, but an old piece turning out to reach further than you were told.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Me comes from Latin **mē**, and Latin got it from something far older. English **me** is not a translation of it and not a borrowing from it — the two are the **same inherited word**, sitting in two languages that split thousands of years ago and never bothered to change it.

Words this short and this used are the ones that survive intact. That is why your very first Spanish pronoun was also the easiest one you will ever meet.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “me llamo” then “me quieres” — the same syllable, two jobs
- “lo tengo” then “me quieres” — hear that the slot never moves

Before you move on

Say “you love me.” (***Me quieres.***) Where did the pronoun go? (**Before** the verb, as always.) Next: the answering half of that sentence.

85.2 te quiero — “I love you”

Say “you love me.” (*Me quieres.*) Now turn it around in your head: what would “I love you” need?

Grammar Lens: the partner of *tú*

te — *you*, when you are the one it happens to.

Te quiero. — I love you.

Tú is for the one doing; *te* is for the one it lands on. Spanish keeps those apart with two different shapes, the same way it keeps *el* and *lo* apart, and the same way English keeps *I* and *me* apart.

Me quieres. — You love me. ***Te quiero.*** — I love you.

Two words each, and a complete exchange. Read them aloud one after the other: the pair is a conversation.

One thing worth knowing before you use it. *Querer* means *to want*, and you have been using it that way for a long time. But *querer* pointed at a **person** does not mean wanting them — it means **loving** them. *Quiero un libro* is “I want a book”; *te quiero* is “I love you.” So the sentence is built entirely out of pieces you already had. What is new is not a form — it is that the verb changes its meaning depending on whether its object is a thing or a person.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Te is Latin **tē** — the object form of **tū**, which you already have. English used to do this exactly. Old English had **thou** for the doer and **thee** for the one it happened to — and, this is the striking part, those are **the same two words**. *Tú/te* and *thou/thee* are one ancient pair, inherited twice. English later dropped both and let *you* cover the two jobs; Spanish kept them apart.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*Te quiero*” then “*Me quieres*” — a whole exchange in four words
- “*tú*” then “*te*”, and “*thou*” then “*thee*” — the same split twice

Before you move on

Say “I love you.” (***Te quiero.***) And “you love me.” (***Me quieres.***) Which English pair matches *tú* and *te*? (**Thou** and **thee.**) Next: all four of these in one place, for the first time.

Chapter 86

Review — Four Pronouns, One Slot

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can name me, te, lo and la and say which of them a noun decides.

Complete ES-C42-repaso-objeto: give all four pronouns and identify the single question that chooses between them.

86.1 Review — four pronouns, one slot

Nothing new in this chapter. Before the table: where does an object pronoun go?

What you've built		
Four chapters, four words, and now they can stand together — because you built each one separately and none of them is new here.		
the one it happens to	pronoun	example
me	me	<i>me quieres</i> — you love me
you	te	<i>te quiero</i> — I love you
it (masculine)	lo	<i>lo tengo</i> — I have it
it (feminine)	la	<i>la hago</i> — I make it
Read down the last column. The verb never moved. The pronoun		

never moved. Only the first word changed, and it changed for one reason at a time.

Grammar Lens: the single question

Choosing between these looks like four decisions. It is one:

Who or what is the verb landing on?

- If it is you speaking → *me*.
- If it is the person you are speaking to → *te*.
- If it is a thing or somebody else → *lo* or *la*, and the **noun** decides which, not you.

That last clause is the whole of the difficulty. *Me* and *te* are about the conversation, so you always know them. *Lo* and *la* are about the noun, so they are only as reliable as your grip on its gender. That is why the three nouns came first: *el libro* and *la comida* are not vocabulary here so much as the two test cases you run every new pronoun against.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the four in order, then the four examples
- “Te quiero” and “Me quieres” back to back, as if two people were speaking

Twice through: Until the choice arrives before the sentence does.

Before you move on

Four pronouns — say them. (*Me*, *te*, *lo*, *la*.) Which two are decided by a noun rather than by you? (*Lo* and *la*.) Next chapter has no new forms either — it asks what these words are actually **for**.

Chapter 87

Synthesis — Saying It Once

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can answer a yes/no question about a thing already named without naming it again.

Complete ES-C42-sintesis-decirlo-una-vez: answer Tienes el libro and Haces la comida with lo tengo and la hago, and say what was wrong with the grammatically correct version.

87.1 Synthesis — saying it once

Answer out loud: ¿Tienes el libro? Say yes, and do not use the word *libro*.

The exchange

Here are the same two exchanges, twice. Read both versions aloud.

Version one:

— ¿Tienes el libro? — Sí, tengo el libro. — ¿Haces la comida?
— Sí, hago la comida.

Version two:

— ¿Tienes el libro? — Sí, lo tengo. — ¿Haces la comida? —
Sí, la hago.

Every sentence in version one is correct. Not one of them is a mistake. And no speaker of Spanish would say them.

Grammar Lens: what the pronoun is actually for

These four words do not make you more **correct**. They make you sound like somebody having a conversation instead of somebody completing an exercise.

A conversation carries what has already been said. English does the same thing and you have never noticed: you would not answer *do you have the book?* with *yes, I have the book*.

So this is the first place where knowing the form is not the skill. **The skill is noticing that the thing has already been named** — and no table can drill that.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- both versions of the book exchange, and hear the difference
- “Sí, lo tengo” and “Sí, la hago” until no decision is needed

Before you move on

¿Tienes el libro? (Sí, lo tengo.) ¿Haces la comida? (Sí, la hago.)

And what were these four words for? (**Not** repeating what has already been said.) Next: the past tense — and you will find these four words sit in exactly the same place there.

Chapter 88

Nos — Us, and the Word Inside -mos

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say *nos quieren*, and say what *nosotros* is made of.

Complete ES-C45-nos: produce *nos quieren* and name the verb ending that is the same ancient word.

88.1 nos — “us”

Say “you love me.” (*Me quieres.*) And “I love you.” (*Te quiero.*) Both of those are about **one** person on the receiving end. Here is more than one.

Grammar Lens: the third person in the room

nos — *us*.

Nos quieren. — They love **us**.

Same slot as always, in front of the verb. *Me* is one person speaking; *nos* is that person and somebody else.

Me quieren. — They love me. *Nos quieren.* — They love us.

One letter of difference, and the difference is how many people you are speaking for.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Nos is Latin **nōs**, which meant both *we* and *us* — the language had not yet split them into two words.

You have been carrying it for a long time without being shown. The *-mos* ending on *hablamos*, *comemos*, *tenemos* is that same **nōs**, worn down and glued to the back of the verb. Every time you said “we speak,” you were saying *nos* twice: once in the ending, and once by not needing to say it at all.

And the word for “we” itself:

nosotros — *we*, literally **nos** + **otros**, “we **others**.”

Spanish added *otros* to the plain *nos* somewhere in the Middle Ages, to make clear the speaker meant *this* group and not the person being addressed. Nothing else in the family did it quite this way, and the seam is still visible in the word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Me quieren” then “Nos quieren”
- “hablamos” and hear the *nos* at the end of it

Before you move on

Say “they love us.” (***Nos quieren.***) What is *nosotros* made of? (***Nos*** + ***otros*** — “we others.”) Next: the plural of *lo* and *la*, and you will not need to be told what they are.

Chapter 89

Los and Las — Them, Derived

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can make any direct object pronoun plural, and say why the pronoun is tidier than the article.

Complete ES-C45-los-las: produce los tengo and las hago, and explain why lo needed no repair in the plural when el did.

89.1 los and las — “them”

Tengo el libro becomes *lo tengo*. Now: *Tengo los libros*. Say the short version out loud **before** reading on.

Grammar Lens: you were right

los — *them*, masculine. **las** — *them*, feminine.

Tengo los libros. → **Los** *tengo.* — I have them. *Hago las comidas.* → **Las** *hago.* — I make them.

Add -s. That is the whole lesson, and you did it yourself in the warm-up.

Two chapters have now asked you for a plural and this is the first one that behaved exactly as you would guess. That is worth noticing rather than passing over: most of what is ahead of you in Spanish is like this, and the memorable exceptions are memorable because they are rare.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

There is one genuinely satisfying thing here.

The **article** could not do this. *El* did not become *els*; it became *los*, because *el* is a worn-down *elo* that had lost its vowel and the plural had kept it.

The **pronoun** never lost that vowel. *Lo* is *illum* with the vowel intact — which is exactly why it was not *el* in the first place. So when the plural came, *lo* had nothing to repair:

	singular	plural
article	el (worn down)	los
pronoun	lo (vowel kept)	los

The two arrive at the same place from different directions, and the pronoun takes the plain road. An irregularity in one column and none in the other, from one Latin word, decided entirely by which one got leaned on.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “lo tengo” then “los tengo”; “la hago” then “las hago”
- “el / los” then “lo / los” — one pair changed shape, one did not

Before you move on

“I have them,” about books? (***Los tengo.***) About meals? (***Las hago.***) How do you make an object pronoun plural? (Add ***-s.***) Next: one more form, and it belongs to one part of the world.

Chapter 90

Os — You All, in Spain

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can use *os* for a group in Spain and *los* or *las* everywhere else.

Complete ES-C45-os: say *os quiero* and its non-peninsular equivalent, and name the older word *os* is worn down from.

90.1 *os* — “you all,” in Spain

Which word for “you all” is used in Spain, and which everywhere else? (*Vosotros* in Spain; *ustedes* everywhere.) That split is about to appear one last time.

Grammar Lens: the object form of *vosotros*

os — *you all*, as the one it happens to.

Os quiero. — I love you all.

Two letters, the shortest word in the set. It pairs with *vosotros*, so it lives exactly where *vosotros* lives: Spain, and nowhere else in daily speech.

Across the Atlantic, “you all” as an object is **los** or **las** — the same forms you learned last chapter, because *ustedes* is grammatically a *they*-word:

Os quiero. — I love you all. **(Spain)** ***Los quiero.*** — I love you all. **(everywhere else)**

Neither is a mistake for the other. Several hundred million speakers will never say *os* in their lives, and forty million say it every day.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Os was **vos**, and the *v* simply fell off in the object slot — a word this small, said this often, and never stressed, wears faster than the rest of the language.

That same *vos* is still visible in two places you have met. It is the front of **vosotros** (*vos* + *otros*, “you others,” built exactly like *nosotros*).

And it survives **whole** as a subject pronoun in Argentina and much of Central America, where *vos* replaces *tú*.

So one Latin word left three descendants alive in three different conditions: worn to *os* in Spain, glued into *vosotros* in Spain, and standing intact as *vos* across the Río de la Plata. Same word, three fates, decided by geography.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*Os quiero*” then “*Los quiero*” — the same sentence, two continents
- “*vos*”, “*os*”, “*vosotros*” and hear one word in three states

Before you move on

“I love you all,” in Spain? (***Os quiero.***) Elsewhere? (***Los quiero.***) What is *os* worn down from? (***Vos.***) Next: all eight of these in one place.

Chapter 91

Review — All Eight

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can give all eight direct object pronouns and say which four depend on a noun.

Complete ES-C45-repaso-ocho: give the eight pronouns and identify the four that a noun decides.

91.1 Review — all eight

Nothing new here. Before the grid: where does an object pronoun sit, and has that ever changed?

What you've built

Never, in nine chapters. Here is the complete set:

	singular	plural
me	me	nos
you	te	os (<i>Spain</i>)
it / them — masculine	lo	los
it / them — feminine	la	las

Eight cells, built one at a time, and this is the first page on which they have all appeared together. That is deliberate. A grid handed to you on the day you met the first one would have been eight things to memorise; here it is a picture of ground you already hold.

Count the genuinely new **shapes** you had to learn across those chapters: *me* was already yours from chapter four, *te* was one, *nos* one, *os* one, *lo* one, *la* one — and *los* and *las* were free, because you produced them yourself from an *-s*.

Grammar Lens: two questions

Reading the grid as eight decisions is the hard way. It is two:

1. **Who is on the receiving end** — me, you, or something else? 2. **How many, and if it is a thing, which gender?**

The second question only bites in the bottom two rows, because only there does a noun decide. *Me*, *te*, *nos* and *os* are settled by the conversation itself: you always know who is talking.

So the difficulty is not eight-eighths of this table. It is one quarter of it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the eight in grid order, twice
- “me quieres, te quiero, nos quieren, os quiero”

Twice through: Until the grid is a reflex rather than a lookup.

Before you move on

How many direct object pronouns are there? (**Eight.**) How many of them depend on a noun? (**Four.**) Next: what all eight are for, in a conversation that would be unbearable without them.

Chapter 92

Synthesis — The Conversation Without Them

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can carry a four-turn exchange using pronouns, and say what a pronoun promises the listener.

Complete ES-C45-sintesis-sin-repetir: run the exchange with pronouns and say what goes wrong when the gender points at nothing.

92.1 Synthesis — the conversation without them

¿Tienes los libros? Answer yes without saying *libros*.

The exchange

Four turns, with the pronouns:

— ¿Tienes los libros? — Sí, los tengo. — ¿Y las comidas? —
Las hago hoy.

Now the same four turns without them:

— ¿Tienes los libros? — Sí, tengo los libros. — ¿Y las comidas?
— Hago las comidas hoy.

Read the second version aloud, all four lines. It is not wrong anywhere. It is exhausting, and by the fourth line it sounds like somebody being careful with a stranger rather than talking.

Grammar Lens: what a pronoun buys, and what it costs

The pronoun buys speed, and it is paid for with **attention**.

Los tengo is only clear because both of you remember what *los* points at. If the last three sentences were about meals and you say *los tengo*, your listener hunts for a masculine thing and finds none. A pronoun is a promise that the thing is still in the room.

That is the real skill, and it is not on the grid: **hold what has been said, and point back at it accurately**. English asks the same of you and you have done it since you were three, which is why nobody taught it to you. Here the pointer must also agree in gender and number — which is why *lo* and *la* were the hard quarter of that table.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- both versions of the four-turn exchange, and hear the second one tire
- “los tengo” and “las hago” until the gender arrives with the noun, not after it

Before you move on

¿Tienes los libros? (Sí, los tengo.) ¿Y las comidas? (Las hago.)

What does a pronoun promise? (That the thing it points at is **still in the room**.) Next: the past tense.

Chapter 93

Le — To Him, To Her, To You

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say *le digo*, and know that *le* does not mark gender.

Complete ES-C46-le: produce *le digo*, say how many genders *le* has, and name the Latin case it comes from.

93.1 le — “to him,” “to her,” “to you”

Lo and *la* answer the question **what**. This chapter answers a different one: **to whom**.

Grammar Lens: the other question

le — *to him, to her, to you* (with *usted*).

Le digo. — I tell **him**. Or her. Or you.

Some verbs land on a thing: you have it, you make it, you want it. Others land on a **person you are aiming at** — you tell them, you speak to them, you give them something. Spanish uses a different pronoun for the second kind, and *le* is it. Same slot. Still in front of the verb. Nothing about the shape of a sentence has changed in eleven chapters.

And here is the relief: *le* does **not** mark gender.

Le digo. — I tell him. **and** I tell her. **and** I tell you.

After four chapters of choosing between *lo* and *la* by the gender of a noun, this one asks you for nothing. One form covers three people. If you need to say which, you add it in words — but the pronoun itself does not care.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Lo and *le* are the same Latin word again — and this time the difference is not wear, it is **grammar**.

Latin changed a word's ending to show its job in the sentence. *Ille*, “that one,” had one form for the thing an action hit and another for the person it was aimed at:

- **illum** — the one the verb acts on → Spanish **lo**.
- **illi** — the one it is aimed at → Spanish **le**.

Latin called these the accusative and the dative. Almost all of that system collapsed on the way to Spanish; nouns lost their endings entirely. But in these small, constantly-used pronouns, **two of the cases survived**, and you are looking at them.

English had the same distinction and lost it more completely. It survives in a word order rather than a shape: *I told **him** the story* — *him* is doing exactly what *le* does, and English simply stopped marking it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Lo tengo” then “Le digo” — what, then to whom
- “Le digo” three times, meaning him, then her, then usted

Before you move on

Say “I tell him.” (***Le digo***.) And “I tell her.” (***Le digo*** — the same.) Which Latin case is *le*? (The **dative**, *illi*.) Next: its plural, and a discovery about how little of this system is actually new.

Chapter 94

Les — And What the Second System Costs

Modes:  voice (1)  Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say *les digo* and name the four pronouns that are identical in both object systems.

Complete ES-C46-les: produce *les digo* and say how many genuinely new words the indirect set adds.

94.1 les — “to them,” and what this system really costs

Lo became *los*. So what does *le* become? Say it before you read on.

Grammar Lens: right again, and then something better

les — *to them, to you all*.

Le digo. — I tell him. → ***Les digo.*** — I tell them.

Add *-s*. That is the second time an object pronoun has pluralised without argument, and it will not be the last.

Now the part worth the chapter. You have just met the sixth and last indirect object pronoun — and you have only ever been **taught two of them**.

What you've built

Here are the two sets, side by side:

	direct (<i>what</i>)	indirect (<i>to whom</i>)
me	me	me
you	te	te
him / her / you	lo, la	le
us	nos	nos
you all (<i>Spain</i>)	os	os
them / you all	los, las	les

Look down the two columns. **Four of the six rows are identical.**

Me, te, nos and *os* do not change at all — the same word does both jobs, and Spanish never asks you to choose.

So a “whole second system” turns out to cost exactly **two new words**: *le* and *les*. Everything else you already owned, and you owned it before you knew there were two systems to own it in.

This is worth holding onto beyond this chapter. A grammar book will show you two complete tables and it will look like twelve things. Count what is actually **different** and it is two.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “le digo” then “les digo”
- “me, te, nos, os” and note that this list is finished for both systems at once

Before you move on

“I tell them”? (***Les digo.***) How many new words did the whole indirect system cost you? (**Two.**) Next: how to know which of the two a verb is asking for.

Chapter 95

Which One Is the Verb Asking For?

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can decide between the direct and indirect pronoun by asking one question of the verb.

Complete ES-C46-cual-pide: state the test, apply it to *hablar* and *tener*, and say why *le veo* is not an error in Madrid.

95.1 Which one is the verb asking for?

You have two sets now. The obvious worry is that you will have to learn, verb by verb, which set each one wants. You do not.

Grammar Lens: ask the verb one question

Does the verb do something *to* this, or aim something *at* this?

That is the whole test.

Tengo el libro → **Lo** tengo. The having lands **on** the book.
Direct. *Hablo a Ana* → **Le** hablo. The speaking is aimed **at** Ana. Indirect.

Say the sentence in English with the little word *to* in front of the person. If it fits, Spanish wants the indirect one:

- I speak **to** her → *le hablo*. **Fits.**

- I have **to** the book → nonsense. So *lo tengo*.

English hides this by dropping the *to*: you say *I told him*, not *I told to him*. Put it back, and if it survives, the pronoun is *le*.

Why it's said this way

One thing the test will not settle, said now rather than met later as a shock.

In much of Spain, speakers use *le* for a **male person** even where the grammar calls for *lo*: *le veo* rather than *lo veo*. It has a name, *leísmo*, it is old, it is accepted for people, and roughly a fifth of the Spanish-speaking world does it.

So if you hear *le* where this chapter predicts *lo*, neither of you has misunderstood. The test above is right everywhere.

Your turn

- *Say it*: “Lo tengo” then “Le hablo” — which question does each answer?

Before you move on

What one question tells you which set to use? (Does the verb act **on** it, or aim **at** it?) What is it called when Spain uses *le* for a man where the rule says *lo*? (***Leísmo*** — and it is fine.) Next: both sets in one place.

Chapter 96

Review — Two Systems, Two New Words

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) ↔ Hands-free start: none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can give both object pronoun sets and say which row is the only one where they differ in shape.

Complete ES-C46-repaso-dos-sistemas: give the six indirect pronouns and count the distinct shapes across both tables.

96.1 Review — two systems, two new words

Nothing new. Two questions before the tables: where does an object pronoun go, and what single question chooses between the two sets?

What you've built		
	direct — <i>what</i>	indirect — <i>to whom</i>
me	me	me
you	te	te
him / her / usted	lo, la	le
us	nos	nos
you all (<i>Spain</i>)	os	os
them / ustedes	los, las	les
Twelve cells. Two of them are new since the last review , and you		

produced one of those yourself by adding an -s.

Do the arithmetic once and it will stay done. Fourteen chapters of object pronouns have asked you to learn, as shapes: *te, lo, la, nos, os, le*. Six words. *Me* you had from chapter four; *los, las* and *les* you derived. Six words, spread across fourteen chapters, with a review and a synthesis at each joint — that is what a gentle ramp costs and what it buys.

Grammar Lens: the one asymmetry

Read the third row again, because it is the only place the two columns disagree in shape rather than spelling:

direct: **lo / la** — two forms, gender marked. indirect: **le** — one form, gender not marked.

Spanish cares about the gender of a thing being acted on and does not care about the gender of a person being aimed at. There is no deep reason for it; Latin's dative simply had one form where its accusative had two, and Spanish inherited the asymmetry whole.

It is good news. The row that carries all the difficulty in one column carries none in the other.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the direct six, then the indirect six, and hear how much is the same
- “lo tengo, le hablo, los tengo, les hablo”

Twice through: Until the shared four stop feeling like two separate lists.

Before you move on

How many pronouns are shared between the two sets? (**Four.**)

Which row differs? (**Him / her / usted** — *lo* and *la* against *le*.)

Next: both sets in one conversation, where you have to choose fast.

Chapter 97

Synthesis — The Thing and the Person

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can use both sets in one exchange and say what decides between them.

Complete ES-C46-sintesis-dar-y-decir: run the four-turn exchange and say what separates lo from le.

97.1 Synthesis — the thing and the person, in one sentence

Two pronouns, one question. *Lo* or *le* — what decides?

The exchange

Read this aloud and watch the two sets take turns.

— ¿Tienes el libro? — Sí, **lo** tengo. — ¿Y Ana? — **Le** digo hoy.

Four turns. The book gets *lo*, because the having lands on it. Ana gets *le*, because the telling is aimed at her.

Nothing in the sentence shape tells you which. Same slot, two letters each, one Latin ancestor. **The only thing separating them is what you mean.**

That is new. Every choice so far could be settled by looking at something — a noun's ending, its article, where the stress falls. This one cannot.

Grammar Lens: choosing at speed

In a real conversation you do not have time to run a test. So do not aim for the test — aim for the **feeling** of the two verbs:

- Verbs that **hold, make, want, see** land on a thing. Those take *lo, la, los, las*.
- Verbs that **tell, speak, give, ask** are aimed at a person. Those take *le, les*.

Say enough sentences and the verb starts arriving with its pronoun attached, which is what fluency here actually is. The test is scaffolding for when you are unsure, not the method.

And when you get it wrong you will be understood: *lo digo* and *le digo* are both ordinary sentences. You will have said something slightly other than you meant, and the person will ask.

Your turn

- *Say it:* “lo tengo, le digo, los tengo, les hablo” until each verb brings its own pronoun

Before you move on

¿Tienes el libro? (Sí, lo tengo.) “I tell her today”? (*Le digo hoy.*) What decides between *lo* and *le*? (**What you mean** — nothing on the page.) Next: what happens when a sentence needs **both** at once.

Chapter 98

Me Lo — Both at Once

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can put two object pronouns in front of one verb, in the right order.

Complete ES-C47-me-lo: produce te lo digo and me la haces, and say which pronoun leads.

98.1 me lo — both at once

You have a pronoun for the **thing** and a pronoun for the **person**.
A sentence often needs both. What happens then?

Grammar Lens: they stand together, in one order

They queue up in the same slot, both still in front of the verb:

Me lo dices. — You tell **it to me**. *Te lo digo.* — I tell **it to you**.

Two small words, one after the other, and then the verb. Nothing has moved.

The order never varies. The person comes first, then the thing:

indirect, then direct. *Me lo*, never *lo me*.

That is the entire rule, and it is worth noticing what it saves you.
English lets you choose — *give it to me* or *give me it* — and the choice carries a faint difference in emphasis you have to feel your way into.

Spanish took the choice away. There is one order, it is always right, and you never have to decide.
A fixed order is a smaller thing to learn than a free one.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Me lo dices” then “Te lo digo” — hear the pair stay glued
- “me la haces”

Before you move on

“I tell it to you”? (*Te lo digo.*) Which pronoun leads? (The **person** — indirect first.) Next: the one combination Spanish refuses to say, and what it says instead.

Chapter 99

Se Lo — The Pair That Does Not Exist

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can turn *le* or *les* into *se* in front of *lo*, *la*, *los* or *las*.

Complete ES-C47-se-lo: produce *se lo digo*, name the four words that trigger the change, and count the readings *se lo digo* allows.

99.1 se lo — the pair that does not exist

Person first, then thing. So “I tell it to him” should be *le* plus *lo* plus *digo*. Say that out loud: *le lo digo*.

Grammar Lens: nobody says that

Your mouth probably objected before your grammar did. *Le lo* is two nearly identical syllables in a row, and Spanish will not say it.

In front of *lo*, *la*, *los* or *las*, the pronouns *le* and *les* become *se*.

~~*Le lo digo*.~~ → ***Se lo digo***. — I tell it to him. ~~*Les la hago*.~~ → ***Se la hago***. — I make it for them.

Everything else about the sentence is unchanged. The order is still person then thing. The slot is still in front of the verb. **Only the first word’s shape changes**, and it changes for one reason: what follows it.

Note what *se* does **not** tell you. *Le* already refused to mark gender, and *se* goes further — it does not mark number either:

Se lo digo — to him. To her. To you. To them. To you all.

Five readings, one word. Context does all the work, and if you need to be precise you add it in words rather than in the pronoun.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “le lo digo” once, badly, and then “se lo digo” — feel why
- “Se lo digo” and “Se la hago”

Before you move on

“I tell it to him”? (***Se lo digo.***) What happened to *le*? (It became ***se*** in front of *lo*.) Next: **why** it became *se* — and it is not the reason almost everyone assumes.

Chapter 100

Why Se? — Gelo, and a Collision

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say why *le* becomes *se*, and that this *se* is not the reflexive one.

Complete ES-C47-por-que-se: name the Old Spanish form, and say whether the *se* of *se lo digo* is the *se* of *se llama*.

100.1 Why se? — and why it is not the se you know

You have known a word *se* since almost the beginning: *se llama*, “he calls **himself**.” Now you have met a second *se*, in *se lo digo*. The obvious conclusion is that they are the same word doing a second job.

They are not. They are two different words that arrived at the same spelling, and knowing that removes a confusion most learners carry for years.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Old Spanish did not say *se lo*. It said **gelo**.

That came from the two Latin pronouns you already know, run together and worn down: *illī* (the dative, giving *le*) plus *illum* (the accusative, giving *lo*) → **gelo**. One squeezed word for “to-him it.” So the medieval sentence was *gelo digo*, and it was regular. There was no substitution and no rule to learn.

Then two things happened:

1. **The word split back into two** — *gelo* was re-analysed as *ge* + *lo*, matching the two-pronoun pattern everywhere else in the language. 2.

The sound *ge* drifted until it was pronounced exactly like *se* — and once two words sound identical, spelling follows.

By the sixteenth century *ge lo* had become *se lo*, and the trail was cold.

Why it's said this way

This matters for a practical reason, not a historical one.

The reflexive *se* in *se llama* means **himself**. If the *se* in *se lo digo* were that word, the sentence would have to mean something reflexive — and learners who assume it do spend years trying to make “he tells it to himself” fit sentences where it plainly does not.

It does not fit because it is not that word. One *se* is Latin *sē*, “himself”; the other is *illī*, “to him.” Unrelated, and collided by accident of sound.

Two words wearing one shape is something this language does often — *ser* is built from two Latin verbs, *ir* borrows its present from a third.

Here it happens to two of the smallest words in Spanish, which is where it is hardest to notice.

Your turn

- *Say it*: “se llama” then “se lo digo” — two different words, one sound

Before you move on

What was *se lo* before it was *se lo*? (***Gelo***.) Is it the reflexive *se*? (**No** — a different word that came to sound the same.) Next: all of it together.

Chapter 101

Review — The Pairs

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can generate every permitted pair of object pronouns from two facts.

Complete ES-C47-repaso-dobles: state the two facts that generate the table and say how many new pronouns the arc added.

101.1 Review — the pairs

Nothing new. Two facts before the table: which pronoun leads, and what happens to *le* in front of *lo*?

What you've built

Every pair Spanish permits, in one place:

person	+ thing	gives
me	lo / la / los / las	me lo, me la, me los, me las
te	”	te lo, te la, ...
le / les	”	se lo, se la, se los, se las
nos	”	nos lo, nos la, ...
os	”	os lo, os la, ...

Read the whole table as **two facts**, because that is all it is:

1. The person comes first. Always. 2. *Le* and *les* turn into *se* in front of the thing. Only there.

Every other row is just the two pronouns you already had, standing next to each other with nothing done to either of them.

Grammar Lens: how little is actually new

Count the new material in this whole arc: **one order, and one substitution.** No new pronoun, no new form, no new position in the sentence. Four chapters, two facts, and one of the two turned out to be an accident of medieval pronunciation rather than a rule at all. That is worth saying plainly, because *se lo* has a reputation. It is usually taught as the moment Spanish object pronouns become genuinely hard. It is instead the moment they stop growing: this is the last new thing the system does.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “me lo, te lo, se lo, nos lo, os lo” — the whole first column
- “se lo digo, se la hago” and notice that only the middle row changed

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which row is the only one that changes? (***Le*** and ***les*** → ***se***.) How many new pronouns did you learn here? (**None.**) Next: all of it in a conversation, at speed.

Chapter 102

Synthesis — Two at a Time

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) ⇌ Hands-free start: none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can carry a four-turn exchange in which almost no noun appears.

Complete ES-C47-sintesis-dos-a-la-vez: produce se la hago and say how many words in it name anything.

102.1 Synthesis — two at a time

“I tell it to him,” in three words. (*Se lo digo.*)

The exchange

— ¿Tienes el libro? — Sí. ¿Te lo digo? — Sí, y se lo dices a Ana. — Y la comida — se la hago hoy.

Look at the last three lines. After the first sentence names the book, **not one noun does any work**. *Te lo, se lo, se la* — six words that name nothing, and the conversation is perfectly clear to both speakers.

That is what all of this has been for. Fifteen chapters of object pronouns exist so that a conversation can stop repeating itself, and this is the point where the machinery is complete enough to see it happen.

Grammar Lens: two words carrying a whole sentence

Se la hago is three words and it means “I make **the meal** for **her**, today.” Two of the three are pronouns; between them they carry a

person and a thing, neither of which is named anywhere in the sentence.

English cannot compress like this. *I'll make it for her* needs five words and still spells out *for*. Spanish puts both jobs in front of the verb, in a fixed order, and gets on with it.

The cost is the one you already know, doubled. Two pronouns are two promises that both things are still in the room. When you lose track of one of them, the sentence does not become wrong — it becomes about somebody else, and nobody will notice until it matters.

So the practice that pays here is not conjugation. It is keeping a conversation's furniture in mind while you talk.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the four-turn exchange straight through
- “te lo digo, se lo dices, se la hago” until the pairs feel like single words

Twice through:

Before you move on

“I make it for her”? (*Se la hago.*) How many nouns are in that sentence? (**None.**) And what does each pronoun promise? (That its thing is **still in the room.**) Next: the past tense.

Chapter 103

The Preterite — Your First Past Tense

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 🗋️ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can use the singular completed past of ser or ir and the known regular -ar verb hablar.

Complete ES-C14-practice and distinguish fui/fuiste/fue from hablé/hablaste/habló using known words, context, and written stress.

103.1 ayer — the word that opens the past

Everything you have said so far happens now or later. This lesson gives you the one word that points the other way — backwards — and warns you what the verbs in this chapter are about to do.

What to know first

- voy a + infinitive — you can already point forwards; this points back.

Sounds you'll need

- vowel-a, vowel-e — two syllables, stress on the last: a-YÉR (ah-YEHR). → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ayer — “yesterday.” It is two Latin words that fused:

ad + heri → **ayer** (to) (yesterday) (yesterday)

Latin *heri* is the same ancient word as English **yester**day and German *gestern*. The *h-* fell silent and then fell away, the *-ri* softened to a *-y-* sound, and *ad heri* — “to yesterday” — packed down into one short word.

What you’ve built

Ayer is a **time frame**: a word that tells the listener *when*, before the verb ever gets a chance to. That matters more than it looks, because Spanish will not let a past time frame sit beside a present verb. Say *ayer* and the verb must follow you backwards.

That is what the rest of this chapter is for. Spanish has **two** past tenses, and they split the past between them:

	what it says	met in
preterite	it happened, and it finished	this chapter
imperfect	it was going on, or it used to happen	a later chapter

English blurs this — “I spoke” covers both. Spanish makes you choose, every time. You do not have to choose yet; you only need to know that the choice is coming, so the next few lessons do not look like arbitrary endings.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ayer* — stress the second syllable
- which of the two past tenses is for something finished?

Before you move on

Which two Latin words gave us *ayer*? (*Ad* and *heri*.) English keeps *heri* inside which word? (**Y**esterday.) How many past tenses does Spanish have? (Two — one for finished, one for ongoing.)

103.2 fui — one past set shared by ser and ir

You already use **ser** for identity and **ir** for going. Spanish now gives both verbs one completed-past set. This lesson keeps the same three singular persons you know: **fui**, **fuiste**, **fue**.

Grammar Lens: three singular forms, two verbs

person	completed past of ser or ir
yo	fui
tú	fuiste
él / ella / usted	fue

Say **fui** • **fuiste** • **fue**. Each form can belong to either verb. The surrounding words decide which meaning is possible:

- **Fui a Madrid.** — “I went to Madrid.” The known **a** plus a destination points to **ir**.
- **Fue Roberto.** — “It was Roberto.” Identification points to **ser**.

Fui and **fue** are one-syllable words, so standard Spanish spelling gives them no written accent. Plural forms wait until a later lesson.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The shared set continues the Latin perfect family of “be,” including Latin **fuī**, “I have been.” Sound change and analogy reshaped the inherited forms. Spanish **ir** then came to share this past family with **ser**: a case of **suppletion**, where one verb draws forms from more than one historical root. English **go** / **went** uses the same broad strategy, although not the same words.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “fui, fuiste, fue”
- “Fui a Madrid.”
- “Fue Roberto — identification, so ser.”

Before you move on

Give the three shared forms. (*Fui, fuiste, fue.*) Which two verbs share them? (*Ser* and *ir.*) What decides the meaning? (Context.) What older family supplied the forms? (The Latin perfect family of “be.”) Next, reuse the known verb **hablar** to build a regular singular past.

103.3 **hablé** — a regular singular past from a known verb

You know **hablar** and its present singular **hablo**, **hablas**, **habla**. To say that the speaking was completed, keep **habl-** and learn three new endings: **hablé**, **hablaste**, **habló**.

Grammar Lens: present beside completed past

person	present	completed past
yo	hablo	hablé
tú	hablas	hablaste
él / ella / usted	habla	habló

Say **hablé** · **hablaste** · **habló**. This is a complete singular pattern, not a preview of plural forms. Notice the exact changes:

- **hablo** → **hablé** changes the final vowel and moves stress to the end.
- **hablas** → **hablaste** adds the past ending **-aste**.
- **habla** → **habló** changes the final vowel and moves stress to the end.

Grammar Lens: two accents, one natural stress pattern

The written accents in **hablé** and **habló** show final stress. Without those marks, words ending in a vowel normally stress the next-to-last syllable. **Hablaste** already follows that ordinary pattern — **blas** is next to last — so it needs no written accent. The mark records the stress; it is not the only change that makes a form past. Now reuse known words:

- **Hablé español.** — “I spoke Spanish.”
- **¿Hablaste español?** — “Did you speak Spanish?”
- **Habló español.** — “He, she, or you-formal spoke Spanish.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The regular **-ar** past continues material from the Latin first-conjugation perfect, visible in forms such as **amāvī**, **amāvistī**, **amāvit**. Centuries of sound change and analogy produced the Spanish family **-é**, **-aste**, **-ó**. The history explains a family resemblance; it is not one tidy letter-by-letter erosion for every modern ending.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hablé, hablaste, habló”
- “Hablo español. Hablé español.”
- “hablé and habló carry written accents; hablaste does not”

Before you move on

Give the three learned past forms. (*Hablé, hablaste, habló.*) Which two carry written accents, and why? (*Hablé* and *habló*; the marks show final stress.) What older family lies behind the endings? (The Latin first-conjugation perfect.) Next: choose between the two past patterns using only known words.

103.4 Practice — two singular ways to talk about a completed past

This checkpoint adds nothing. Retrieve the shared singular set and the regular **hablar** set, then use context and spelling to keep them apart.

Grammar Lens: the complete frame for this chapter

- shared past of **ser** and **ir**: **fui** • **fuiste** • **fue**.
- regular past of **hablar**: **hablé** • **hablaste** • **habló**.
- context: **Fui a Madrid** expresses **ir**; **Fue Roberto** expresses **ser**.
- time contrast: **Hablo español** is present; **Hablé español** is completed past.
- spelling: **hablé** and **habló** show final stress with a written accent; **hablaste** needs none.

Plural persons, additional past-tense verb classes, new time words, and new place or person vocabulary wait for later lessons.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The **fui** family continues Latin perfect “be” material and became shared by **ser** and **ir**. The regular **-ar** endings continue Latin first-conjugation perfect material, reshaped by sound change and analogy.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “fui, fuiste, fue”
- “hablé, hablaste, habló”
- “Fui a Madrid. Fue Roberto.”
- “Hablo español. Hablé español.”

Before you move on

Give both singular sets. (*Fui, fuiste, fue; hablé, hablaste, habló.*) How does context separate **ser** from **ir**? (A destination points to going; identification points to being.) Which regular forms carry written accents? (*Hablé* and *habló*.) The next chapter can add another past family without borrowing plural forms or unseen

vocabulary from this checkpoint.

Chapter 104

The Regular Preterite

Modes: 🗣️ voice (2) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I did with a regular -er or -ir verb, and place the written accent correctly.
-er and -ir agree again, and the accent marks the stressed final vowel.

104.1 comí — one regular -er singular past

You know present **como**, **comes**, **come** and the singular **-ar** past. To make a completed past from **comer**, keep **com-** and learn three forms: **comí**, **comiste**, **comió**.

Grammar Lens: present beside completed past

person	present	completed past
yo	como	comí
tú	comes	comiste
él / ella / usted	come	comió

Say **comí** · **comiste** · **comió**. Keep the limit visible: these are the same three familiar singular persons. Plural forms wait.

Grammar Lens: final stress in two forms

Comí and **comió** carry written accents because their stress falls on the final vowel. **Comiste** follows ordinary next-to-last stress, so it needs no mark. The three forms by themselves make complete utterances:

- **Comí.** — “I ate.”
- **¿Comiste?** — “Did you eat?”
- **Comió.** — “He, she, or you-formal ate.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish **comer** continues Latin **comedere**. Its regular past endings also continue Latin perfect material, including forms with **-ī, -istī, -it**. Sound change and analogy reshaped that material across Romance into Spanish **-í, -iste, -ió**. The resemblance is real, but it is not one tidy chain in which every modern ending merely drops a letter.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “comí, comiste, comió”
- “Como. Comí.”
- “comí and comió carry final-stress accents”

Before you move on

Give the three learned **comer** forms. (*Comí, comiste, comió.*) Which carry written accents? (*Comí* and *comió.*) What shaped the modern endings? (Latin perfect material, sound change, and analogy.) Next: reuse the same endings with a known **-ir** verb.

104.2 viví — reuse one past pattern with an -ir verb

You know present **vivo, vives, vive**, and you just learned past **comí, comiste, comió**. Keep **viv-** and reuse those three past endings: **viví, viviste, vivió**.

Grammar Lens: one -ir singular past

person	present	completed past
yo	vivo	viví
tú	vives	viviste
él / ella / usted	vive	vivió

Say **viví** · **viviste** · **vivió**. Reuse known **en** for a small contrast:

- **Vivo en Madrid.** — “I live in Madrid.”
- **Viví en Madrid.** — “I lived in Madrid.”
- **¿Viviste en Madrid?** — “Did you live in Madrid?”
- **Vivió en Madrid.** — “He, she, or you-formal lived in Madrid.”

The written accents in **viví** and **vivió** show final stress. **Viviste** already has ordinary next-to-last stress and needs no mark.

Grammar Lens: -er and -ir meet in this past

person	comer	vivir
yo	comí	viví
tú	comiste	viviste
él / ella / usted	comió	vivió

The shared endings are **-í** in the first row, **-iste** in the second, and **-ió** in the third. The presents differ, but these two singular past rows converge on one ending set. That is a fact about the forms you have learned, not permission to guess plural forms; those wait.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish **vivir** continues Latin **vīvere**. Its modern past endings belong to the same Romance history as the **comer** endings: Latin perfect material was reshaped by sound change and analogy. The shared **-iste** is a useful family resemblance, not proof of one simple letter-by-letter erosion.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “viví, viviste, vivió”
- “Vivo en Madrid. Viví en Madrid.”
- “comí and viví share -í; comió and vivió share -ió”

Before you move on

Give the three learned **vivir** forms. (*Viví, viviste, vivió.*) Which past endings do **comer** and **vivir** share? (*-í, -iste, -ió.*) Which two carry written accents? (*Viví* and *vivió.*) Next, keep the singular limit but let the stem change.

Chapter 105

The Strong Preterites

Modes: ⇄ voice (3) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can use **tuve**, **hice** and **estuve**, and hear that their stress sits on the stem.

Latin's own perfect, carried through on verbs too heavily used to be rebuilt.

105.1 **tuve** — let the strong stem carry the stress

You know present **tengo**, **tienes**, **tiene**. Its completed past changes the stem to **tuv-** and uses **tuve**, **tuviste**, **tuvo**. Unlike **comí** and **comió**, none of these three forms carries a written accent.

Grammar Lens: one strong singular pattern

person	present	completed past
yo	tengo	tuve
tú	tienes	tuviste
él / ella / usted	tiene	tuvo

The strong stem **tuv-** takes **-e**, **-iste**, **-o**. Say **tuve** · **tuviste** · **tuvo**. Stress remains in the stem, so normal spelling needs no accent mark. Reuse known **café**:

- **Tuve café.** — “I had coffee.”
- **¿Tuviste café?** — “Did you have coffee?”

- **Tuvo café.** — “He, she, or you-formal had coffee.”

“Strong” describes the stem-stressed historical pattern. It does not mean that the meaning is forceful. Plural endings wait.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Tener continues Latin **tenēre**. Its past also belongs to an older strong history associated with Latin **tenuī**. Spanish sound change and analogy reshaped that material into the **tuv-** family. **Tenuī** → **tuve** is therefore a historical relationship, not a promise that every letter passed across intact.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “tuve, tuviste, tuvo”
- “Tuve café.”
- “comí has final stress; tuve has stem stress”

Before you move on

Give the three learned **tener** forms. (*Tuve, tuviste, tuvo.*) Which endings attach to **tuv-**? (*-e, -iste, -o.*) Why are there no written accents? (The strong stem carries the stress.) What shaped **tuve** historically? (Older strong-perfect material, sound change, and analogy.) Next: reuse the strong endings with **hacer**.

105.2 hice — the strong pattern with one third-person swerve

You know present **hago, haces, hace** and strong past **tuve, tuviste, tuvo**. **Hacer** reuses the strong endings: **hice, hiciste, hizo**. Watch the third form: the stem is **hiz-** there, not **hic-**.

Grammar Lens: hacer in the completed past

person	completed past	stem plus ending
yo	hice	hic- + -e
tú	hiciste	hic- + -iste
él / ella / usted	hizo	hiz- + -o

Say **hice** · **hiciste** · **hizo**. These are strong, stem-stressed forms with no written accents. **Hizo** is an irregular stem alternation inside this family; it is not a general rule that **c** must become **z** before **o**. Reuse known **café**:

- **Hice café.** — “I made coffee.”
- **¿Hiciste café?** — “Did you make coffee?”
- **Hizo café.** — “He, she, or you-formal made coffee.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Hacer continues Latin **facere**, and **hice** continues the history of its strong perfect **fēcī**. Long sound changes help explain Spanish **h-** and the changed vowel and consonant; this is not a direct spelling recipe. The pattern links **hice** historically to strong **tuve**, while each verb keeps its own stem.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hice, hiciste, hizo”
- “Hice café.”
- “hizo is a learned hiz- alternation, not a general c-before-o rule”

Before you move on

Give the three learned **hacer** forms. (*Hice, hiciste, hizo.*) What changes in the third form? (**Hic-** becomes **hiz-**.) Is that a general **c-before-o** spelling rule? (No; learn it inside this irregular family.) What older form lies behind **hice**? (Latin **fēcī**, through substantial historical change.) Next: add strong **estar** without adding plural

forms.

105.3 **estuve** — a third known verb joins the strong pattern

You know present **estoy**, **estás**, **está** and the strong past pairs **tuve**, **tuviste**, **tuvo** and **hice**, **hiciste**, **hizo**. Now use the same strong endings with **estuv-**: **estuve**, **estuviste**, **estuvo**.

Grammar Lens: **estar** in the completed past

person	completed past
yo	estuve
tú	estuviste
él / ella / usted	estuvo

Say **estuve** · **estuviste** · **estuvo**. The strong stem **estuv-** takes **-e**, **-iste**, **-o**. These forms carry no written accents. Reuse known **bien**:

- **Estuve bien.** — “I was well.”
- **¿Estuviste bien?** — “Were you well?”
- **Estuvo bien.** — “He, she, or you-formal was well.”

Grammar Lens: three strong singular rows

- yo: **tuve** · **hice** · **estuve**.
- tú: **tuviste** · **hiciste** · **estuviste**.
- él / ella / usted: **tuvo** · **hizo** · **estuvo**.

All three rows use the learned strong endings. Only **hacer** changes its stem shape from **hic-** to **hiz-** before third-person **-o**. Plural forms and other irregular verbs still wait.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Estar grew from a Romance verb related to Latin **stāre**, “stand.” But modern **estuve** is not a direct, tidy wearing-down of Latin **stetī**.

Historical analogy helped reshape its past beside other strong forms, including the **-uv-** pattern visible in **tuve**. This explains the family resemblance without pretending that each modern letter came straight from one Latin form.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “estuve, estuviste, estuvo”
- “Estuve bien.”
- “tuve and esteve share -uv- through historical analogy”

Before you move on

Give the three learned **estar** forms. (*Estuve, estuviste, estuvo.*)
Which known strong verb shares their **-uv-** shape? (*Tener: tuve.*)
Why should **estuve** not be shown as a direct wearing-down of **steti**? (Analogy reshaped the Spanish family.) Next: retrieve all six bounded patterns.

Chapter 106

Synthesis — You Can Hear Which Past It Is

Modes: 🗣️ voice (2) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can tell a regular preterite from a strong one by ear, and say why only one of them carries an accent.

The accent is the stress written down: ending-stressed regular, stem-stressed strong.

106.1 Practice — six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary

This checkpoint adds nothing. Retrieve only the three singular persons of each learned row. Every word in the short sentences is already known.

Grammar Lens: the complete frame for this chapter

Regular rows:

- yo: hablé · comí · viví.
- tú: hablaste · comiste · viviste.
- él / ella / usted: habló · comió · vivió.

Strong rows:

- yo: tuve · hice · estuve.

- **tú:** **tuviste** · **hiciste** · **estuviste**.
- **él / ella / usted:** **tuvo** · **hizo** · **estuvo**.

The **-er** and **-ir** rows share **-í**, **-iste**, **-ió**. The three strong rows share **-e**, **-iste**, **-o**, but their stems must be learned: **tuv-**, **hic-/hiz-**, **estuv-**. Plural persons, more strong verbs, and new time or setting vocabulary remain outside this checkpoint.

Grammar Lens: let spelling show the stress

- Regular **comí**, **comió**, **viví**, **vivió** carry written accents for final stress.
- Strong **tuve**, **tuvo**, **hice**, **hizo**, **estuve**, **estuvo** carry no written accents; stress remains in the strong stem.
- **Comiste** and **viviste** need no accent because their ordinary stress is already next to last.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The regular **-er/-ir** endings continue Latin perfect material reshaped across Romance. **Tuve** and **hice** continue older strong-perfect histories, also reshaped rather than copied letter for letter. **Estuve** shows especially clear analogical remodeling beside the **-uv-** family of **tuve**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hablé, comí, viví”
- “tuve, hice, estuve”
- “Hice café. Viví en Madrid. Estuve bien.”
- “comí and comió have accents; tuve and tuvo do not”

Before you move on

Give the regular **comer** and **vivir** sets. (*Comí, comiste, comió; viví, viviste, vivió.*) Give the three strong sets. (*Tuve, tuviste, tuvo; hice, hiciste, hizo; estuve, estuviste, estuvo.*) Which rows share endings? (**-er/-ir** share one regular set; the strong rows share another.) The next chapter can add a new past contrast without borrowing any plural form here.

106.2 Synthesis — you can hear which past it is

Nothing new in this chapter. Say *comí*, then *tuve*.

Grammar Lens: the stress tells you everything

Say those two again and listen to where your voice lifts.

comí — the stress lands on the **ending**. *tuve* — the stress lands on the **stem**.

That is not a detail. It is the whole difference between the two kinds of past in this chapter, and it is audible before you know anything else about the verb.

- **Endings stressed** → the regular preterite. It needs a written accent, because Spanish marks a stressed final vowel: *comí, viví*.
- **Stem stressed** → a strong preterite. It needs **no accent at all**: *tuve, hice, estuve*.

So the accent is not extra spelling to remember. It is the stress, written down. If a preterite has no accent, the stress moved back onto the stem, and you are looking at one of the strong ones.

What you've built

The two kinds have two histories.

The regular preterite is Spanish doing what Spanish does: one set of endings, and — as in the present and the imperfect — **-er** and **-ir** agreeing with each other rather than going separate ways.

The strong preterites are older. They are Latin's own perfect, carried

through with the stress where Latin had put it, on verbs used too heavily ever to be rebuilt. Which is the same reason the imperfect has only three irregulars: the words people say constantly are the ones that keep their odd shapes.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *comí, viví* — and feel the lift on the last syllable
- *tuve, hice, estuve* — and feel it move back

Twice through: Until you can place a preterite by ear before you place it by rule.

Before you move on

Where does the stress fall in a strong preterite? (**On the stem.**)
What does a missing accent tell you? (That it is one of the strong ones.) And why do the strong ones exist at all? (They are Latin's own perfect, kept intact on verbs used too much to be rebuilt.)

Chapter 107

The Imperfect — What Used to Happen

Modes: 🗣️ voice (3) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can describe an ongoing or habitual past with a regular verb from any family.

-aba and -ia, and -er and -ir agreeing once again.

107.1 hablaba — let a past action stay open

Hablé español presents speaking as a completed past event. A different past, the **imperfect**, can leave the action open: **Hablaba español** — “I was speaking Spanish” or “I used to speak Spanish.” The sentence does not say where the action ended.

Grammar Lens: three familiar persons

person	open or habitual past
yo	hablaba
tú	hablabas
él / ella / usted	hablaba

Say **hablaba** · **hablabas** · **hablaba**. The first and third forms are identical; the surrounding conversation or an explicit person tells you who is speaking. Plural persons wait.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish **-aba** continues the Latin imperfect family in **-ābam**. Historical sound change reshaped the complete Latin forms, but the **b** remains a useful audible bridge between **-ābam** and Spanish **-aba**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hablaba, hablabas, hablaba”
- “Hablé español. Hablaba español.”
- “-ābam and -aba share b”

Before you move on

Give the three learned forms. (*Hablaba, hablabas, hablaba.*) What can the imperfect do? (Leave a past action ongoing or habitual.) Which Latin family stands behind **-aba**? (**-ābam**.) Next: build the same gentle frame with **comer**.

107.2 comía — hear both vowels

Comí presents eating as completed. **Comía** leaves it open or habitual: “I was eating” or “I used to eat.” One accent separates the two forms in writing and in sound.

Grammar Lens: the singular -er row

person	open or habitual past
yo	comía
tú	comías
él / ella / usted	comía
Say comía · comías · comía . As with hablaba , the first and third forms match. Plural persons wait.	

Grammar Lens: co-mí-a

The accent in **-ía** keeps **i** and **a** in separate syllables: **co-mí-a**, three beats. It appears in every form learned here. Compare final stress in **comí** with the middle stress and extra syllable in **comía**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The **-er** imperfect continues a Romance reshaping of Latin **-ēbam** material. Among the changes, an intervocalic **b** was lost; later Spanish spelling marks the stressed **í** that keeps **i-a** apart. This is a layered history, not a single instruction to delete one letter.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “comía, comías, comía”
- “Comí. Comía.”
- “co-mí-a”

Before you move on

Give the three learned forms. (*Comía, comías, comía.*) What does the accent do? (Keeps **i** and **a** apart.) Which Latin family lies behind the ending? (**-ēbam**, reshaped through Romance.) Next: test whether **vivir** can reuse this row.

107.3 vivía — reuse the complete -er row

An earlier chapter let **comer** and **vivir** share one completed-past row. They converge again here. Replace **com-** in **comía, comías, comía** with **viv-**.

Grammar Lens: one row reused

person	comer	vivir
yo	comía	vivía
tú	comías	vivías
él / ella / usted	comía	vivía

Say **vivía** · **vivías** · **vivía**. **-er** and **-ir** share **-ía**, **-ías**, **-ía**. The accent still keeps **i-a** apart. Plural persons wait.

Grammar Lens: one known contrast

- **Viví en Madrid.** — presents living there as a completed stretch.
- **Vivía en Madrid.** — puts us inside that past stretch or treats it as background.

Both are past. The speaker chooses how to frame the event.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Vivir continues Latin **vīvere**. Its infinitive belongs to the Spanish **-ir** class, but the imperfect has converged with **-er**. That shared row is a reliable fact about these learned forms, not a claim that the two conjugations are identical everywhere.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “vivía, vivías, vivía”
- “comía and vivía share -ía”
- “Viví en Madrid. Vivía en Madrid.”

Before you move on

Give the three **vivir** forms. (*Vivía, vivías, vivía.*) Which class shares them? (**-er**.) What contrast can **viví** / **vivía** make? (Completed stretch versus an open or background past.) Next: learn **ver** before asking it to enter this tense.

Chapter 108

Ver — Seeing

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I see, with a verb whose stem keeps a letter Latin had.

videre, and the e that other verbs dropped but ver kept.

108.1 ver — learn the verb before its past

Ver means “to see.” Its written **v** uses the Spanish sound you already know: it is not contrasted with a separate English-style **v** sound. Say **ver**.

Grammar Lens: three present forms

person	present
yo	veo
tú	ves
él / ella / usted	ve

The **tú** and third-person forms resemble the familiar **-er** row. The **yo** form keeps an extra vowel: **veo**. Reuse known **café**: **Veó café** — “I see coffee.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish **ver** continues Latin **vidēre**, “to see,” through Old Spanish **veer**. Loss of the consonant between vowels helps explain the shorter

shape; the two adjacent vowels later contracted in the infinitive. English **video** belongs to the same Latin family, a memory bridge rather than a new Spanish word for this lesson.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ver — to see”
- “veo, ves, ve”
- “ver comes through veer from vidēre”

Before you move on

What does **ver** mean? (“To see.”) Give its three learned present forms. (*Veo, ves, ve.*) Which Latin verb stands behind it? (**Vidēre.**) Next: add **ser** to the open past.

Chapter 109

The Only Three Irregulars

Modes: 🔄 voice (3) 🔄 Hands-free start: all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can use **era**, **iba** and **veía**, and know that no fourth irregular imperfect exists.

erat and ibat worn straight through from Latin, never tidied up.

109.1 era — an old root in an open past

You know present **soy**, **eres**, **es** and completed-past **fui**, **fuiste**, **fue**. The open or background past of **ser** uses a different short stem: **era**.

Grammar Lens: the singular ser row

person	open or background past
yo	era
tú	eras
él / ella / usted	era

Say **era** · **eras** · **era**. The first and third forms match, just as they did in the regular imperfect rows. **¿Era usted?** asks “Was it you?” without adding a new noun. Plural persons wait.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Era continues Latin **eram**, an old form in the **esse** family. That is the family already connected to Spanish **ser** and English **essence**. The

preterite **fue** comes from another historical set, so **era** / **fue** is a real contrast inside one modern verb.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “era, eras, era”
- “¿Era usted?”
- “era comes from Latin eram”

Before you move on

Give the three learned **ser** forms. (*Era, eras, era.*) Which past form supplies background, **era** or **fue**? (**Era.**) Which Latin form stands behind it? (**Eram.**) Next: follow **ir** back toward its own older verb.

109.2 iba — ir returns to its inherited past

Present **voy** and completed-past **fui** came from different historical sets. For an open or habitual past, **ir** gives you **iba** — “I was going” or “I used to go.”

Grammar Lens: the singular ir row

person	open or habitual past
yo	iba
tú	ibas
él / ella / usted	iba
Say iba · ibas · iba . Reuse the destination frame: Iba a Madrid — “I was going to Madrid” or “I used to go to Madrid.” Plural persons wait.	

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Iba continues Latin **ībam**, from **īre**, the inherited verb behind the Spanish infinitive **ir**. Present **voy** contains material associated with **vādere**, while preterite **fui** comes from the Latin “be” perfect family.

These sources help explain the three learned sets; they do not mean that every form in every tense can be assigned to one source by a three-box rule.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “iba, ibas, iba”
- “Fui a Madrid. Iba a Madrid.”
- “iba continues ībam from īre”

Before you move on

Give the three learned forms. (*Iba, ibas, iba.*) Say “I was going to Madrid.” (*Iba a Madrid.*) Which Latin form stands behind **iba**? (**Ībam**, from **īre**.) Next: put newly learned **ver** into the same past.

109.3 veía — keep the extra e you already met

You learned **ver** before its past: **veo**, **ves**, **ve**. Its imperfect keeps **ve-** and adds the familiar **-ía** row. That gives **veía** — “I was seeing” or “I used to see.”

Grammar Lens: the singular ver row

person	open or habitual past
yo	veía
tú	veías
él / ella / usted	veía
Say veía · veías · veía . Keep í-a in separate syllables. Plural persons wait.	

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Old Spanish **veer** displays the **ve-** shape clearly. The imperfect **veía** preserves that vowel before the familiar **-ía** material. It is useful to call this an exceptional learned row, but not to pretend that **ver** was

already known before this chapter or that the history is merely “regular plus one letter.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “veía, veías, veía”
- “Veo café. Veía café.”
- “veer helps explain ve-”

Before you move on

Give the three learned forms. (*Veía, veías, veía.*) Which vowel stays before **-ía**? (**e.**) Which earlier form displays it? (**Veer.**) Next: retrieve every row of this chapter and make a few bounded contrasts.

Chapter 110

Synthesis — Three Exceptions, and No Others

Modes: 🗣️ voice (2) 🗋️ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can use the imperfect freely, knowing its complete irregular inventory is three verbs.

The exceptions are the words you use most - which is the reason they are exceptions.

110.1 Practice — keep the past open or close it

This checkpoint adds no vocabulary and no plural persons. Retrieve the seven learned singular rows, then choose whether a known sentence presents the past as completed or leaves it open as background, progress, or habit.

Grammar Lens: the complete frame for this chapter

Regular rows:

- yo: hablaba · comía · vivía.
- tú: hablabas · comías · vivías.
- él / ella / usted: hablaba · comía · vivía.

The three special rows:

- yo: era · iba · veía.

- **tú:** eras · ibas · veías.
- **él / ella / usted:** era · iba · veía.

The first and third forms match in every learned row. **Comer** and **vivir** share **-ía, -ías, -ía**. **Ver** keeps **ve-** before that material. Plural persons remain outside this checkpoint.

Grammar Lens: one scene, two frames

- **Hablé español.** — completed event. **Hablaba español.** — open, background, or habitual speaking.
- **Viví en Madrid.** — completed stretch. **Vivía en Madrid.** — we stand inside that past stretch.
- **Fui a Madrid.** — completed trip. **Iba a Madrid.** — motion was in progress or habitual.

The tense does not mechanically report how long something lasted. It frames the past from a different viewpoint.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

-aba continues the Latin **-ābam** family. **-ía** continues material from the **-ēbam** family after several Romance changes. **Era** continues **eram**; **iba** continues **ībam** from **īre**; and **veía** keeps the **ve-** shape also visible in Old Spanish **veer**. These are historical bridges, not recipes for generating unlearned forms.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hablaba, comía, vivía”
- “era, iba, veía”
- “Hablé / hablaba · viví / vivía · fui / iba”

Before you move on

Give the six **yo** forms. (*Hablaba, comía, vivía, era, iba, veía.*) Which two regular classes share a row? (**-er** and **-ir**.) What is the core contrast? (The preterite presents a completed event; the imperfect leaves past action open, habitual, in progress, or in the background.) Chapter 17 can now build on **-ía** without borrowing a plural form here.

110.2 Synthesis — three exceptions, and no others

Nothing new in this chapter. Say *hablaba*, then *comía*.

What you've built

Here is the fact that no single lesson of this chapter could give you, and it is worth more than any of them.

The imperfect has exactly three irregular verbs in the entire language. *Ser, ir, ver*. That is the complete list — not “the common ones”, not “to start with”. Three.

Every other Spanish verb, without exception, takes **-aba** or **-ía** and behaves. After the preterite, which has a strong stem for what feels like every verb worth using, this is a tense that simply lets you get on with it.

So the honest instruction for the imperfect is short: learn *era, iba* and *veía*, and stop worrying.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

And the three are not random. They are the *most used verbs in the language* — to be, to go, to see — worn straight through from Latin *erat* and *ibat* without ever being tidied up.

That is how irregularity works everywhere: a form survives unchanged because it is said constantly, and speakers never have to reach for a rule to rebuild it. Rare verbs get regularised precisely because nobody remembers them well enough to keep the odd shape alive.

The exceptions are the words you use most. That is not bad luck — it is the reason they are exceptions.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *era, iba, veía* — the whole irregular inventory, in one breath
- *hablaba, comía, vivía* — and notice nothing surprises you

Twice through:

Before you move on

How many irregular imperfects are there? (**Three** — and that is all.) Which verbs? (*Ser, ir, ver.*) And why those three? (Because they are the ones people say constantly, so the old forms were never worn into a rule.)

Chapter 111

Hablaba and Hablo — Two Ways of Looking

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) 🗉 Hands-free start: none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say that the two past tenses differ in viewpoint rather than in time.

Complete ES-C48-dos-miradas: say whether the two pasts differ in when, and identify which one views an event from outside.

111.1 hablaba and habló — two ways of looking

You hold two past tenses. Say “I spoke” in both. (*Hablé. Hablaba.*)

Grammar Lens: not two times — two viewpoints

The obvious guess is that one is further back than the other. It is not. Both describe the same afternoon.

*Ayer **hablé** con Ana.* — Yesterday I spoke with Ana. *Ayer **hablaba** con Ana.* — Yesterday I was speaking with Ana.

Same day, same conversation, same two people. What changes is **where you are standing**.

- **Hablé** looks at the conversation from outside, finished, as one thing with edges. It happened, it is over, next.

- **Hablaba** puts you inside it, while it is still going on. No edges. It is the scenery, not the event.

This is why the choice cannot be made by a rule about time. It is made by what you are doing with the sentence: **reporting something that happened**, or **setting a scene where something else can happen**.

Grammar books call this *aspect*. The word is not important. The habit is: when you reach for a past tense, you are being asked a question about your own point of view, and you answer it every time whether you notice or not.

Why it's said this way

English asks you the same question and lets you dodge it.

I spoke. I was speaking. I used to speak.

Those are three different viewpoints, and English marks them with extra words rather than with the verb itself. Because they are optional, you can say “I spoke” for almost anything and be understood. Spanish put the choice **inside the verb**, so it is not optional. Every past sentence commits to a viewpoint before it commits to anything else. That is why this is the piece of Spanish that stays difficult longest for English speakers: not because it is complicated, but because it asks a question your first language let you leave unanswered.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hablé” then “hablaba” — outside, then inside
- “estudié” then “estudiaba”

Before you move on

Do the two pasts differ in **when**? (**No** — in how you look at it.) Which one has edges? (The **preterite**.) Next: the word that lets both of them stand in one sentence.

Chapter 112

Cuando — Both Pasts in One Sentence

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can join a scene and an event with cuando, using the right tense for each.

Complete ES-C48-cuando: build estudiaba cuando hablo Ana and say which tense sets the room.

112.1 cuando — putting both pasts in one sentence

One tense is the scenery and one is the event. So far you have only been able to use one at a time. This chapter's word lets them share a sentence.

Sounds you'll need

- diphthong-ua — *cua* is one syllable, not two: *KWAN-doh*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

cuando — *when*.

From Latin **quandō**, and the *qu-* at the front is not decoration. It is the same question-marker sitting inside *qué*, *quién* and *cómo* — a family you have been collecting since your very first questions. Latin built its question words from one root and Spanish kept the

whole set, so *cuándo* with an accent asks a question and *cuando* without one simply joins two things. Same word, and the accent is doing the same job it always does: marking the stressed, questioning one.

Grammar Lens: the scene and the thing that interrupts it

Now the two tenses can do their jobs side by side:

Estudiaba cuando habló Ana. — I **was studying** when Ana **spoke**.

Read what each tense is doing:

- *Estudiaba* — imperfect. The **scene**. Already going, no edges, and it does not stop being true when something else happens.
- *Habló* — preterite. The **event**. One thing, with edges, dropped into that scene.

This is the shape most Spanish stories are built from, and it is worth hearing the pattern rather than memorising a rule: **the imperfect sets the room, the preterite is what walks into it.**

Turn it around and the sentence changes meaning, not just style:

Estudié cuando hablaba Ana. — I studied while Ana was talking.

Now the talking is the room and the studying is the event. Neither version is more correct. They are about different things.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Estudiaba cuando habló Ana”
- the reversed version, and notice the story changed

Before you move on

Which tense is the room? (The **imperfect**.) Which one walks into it? (The **preterite**.) Next: two verbs where the choice does not change the picture — it changes the **meaning**.

Chapter 113

Tenia and Tuve — When the Tense Changes the Meaning

Modes: 🔄 voice (1) 🔄 Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say why *tuve una casa* means I got one, and predict what a state verb's preterite will mean.

Complete ES-C48-tenia-tuve: contrast *tenia* and *tuve*, and say what any state verb's preterite will mean.

113.1 *tenía* and *tuve* — when the tense changes the meaning

So far the two pasts have shown you the same event from two places. With one very common verb, they show you two **different** events.

Grammar Lens: having, and getting

Tenía una casa. — I **had** a house. *Tuve una casa.* — I **got** a house.

Read those twice. The second one is not “I had a house, viewed as finished.” It is a different verb in English altogether.

The reason follows from everything you already know. *Tener* means a **state** — having something is not an event, it is a condition that simply continues. So the imperfect, which has no edges, fits it perfectly: *tenía* is the ordinary way to say you had something.

Force that state into the preterite and you are demanding edges for something that does not have any. Spanish resolves the clash the only way it can: **it gives you the moment the state began**. The edge of *having* is *getting*.

Nothing irregular is happening. It is the same aspect rule you met two chapters ago, applied to a verb where the result is a new word in English.

Why it's said this way

This is worth more than one verb, because the same thing happens to every verb that names a state rather than an action. When you meet those verbs later, you will not need a list — you will already know what their preterite is going to mean: **the moment the state started**.

It also explains a frustration you may already have had. English “I had” covers both sentences above, so an English speaker reaching for *tuve* is often reaching for the wrong one. The fix is not to memorise which is which. It is to notice that you are describing a **state**, and states live in the imperfect unless you specifically mean the moment they began.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Tenía una casa” then “Tuve una casa” — hear the English change
- the rule aloud — a state in the preterite gives you its beginning

Before you move on

Tenía una casa? (I **had** one.) *Tuve una casa?* (I **got** one.) And why? (A state forced into the preterite gives you the **moment it began**.) Next: all of it in one place.

Chapter 114

Review — One Question, Three Answers

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can state the single question that chooses between the two past tenses.

Complete ES-C48-repaso-dos-pasados: state the question, identify the scene verb, and name the pair that changes meaning.

114.1 Review — one question, three answers

Nothing new. Before the table: do the two past tenses differ in **when**?

What you've built		
Three chapters, one question, three ways it gets answered.		
what you are doing	tense	example
reporting an event, with edges	preterite	<i>hablé</i> — I spoke
setting a scene, no edges	imperfect	<i>hablaba</i> — I was speaking
naming a state	imperfect	<i>tenía</i> — I had
naming the moment a state began	preterite	<i>tuve</i> — I got
Rows one and two are the same event seen from two places. Rows		

three and four are not: there the tense changes what happened.

Grammar Lens: the question to actually ask

Not “*which tense is this?*” — that has no answer without you.

Am I telling you what happened, or what things were like?

What happened has edges: preterite. *What things were like* does not: imperfect. A story is mostly the second with the first dropped into it, which is what *cuando* let you build:

Estudiaba cuando habló Ana.

And when the verb names a state rather than an action, the same question still works — you are simply more likely to be describing what things were like, so the imperfect is the ordinary case and the preterite is the special one.

There is no list to memorise here, and that is deliberate. Lists of “preterite trigger words” exist in most courses and they fail exactly where the choice is interesting, because the same word can sit in either sentence. The question does not fail, because the question is the thing the language is actually asking.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hablé / hablaba”, then “tenía / tuve”, and name the difference in each pair
- the question aloud before each one

Twice through: Until the question arrives before the verb does.

Before you move on

The one question? (**What happened, or what things were like?**) Which pair changes meaning rather than viewpoint? (*Tenía* and *tuve*.) Next: a whole small story, which is what all of this was for.

Chapter 115

Synthesis — A Small Story

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can narrate four sentences using both past tenses, with a background and a foreground.

Complete ES-C48-sintesis-una-historia: identify the two layers of the story and say why *tuve* belongs to the foreground.

115.1 Synthesis — a small story

Everything in this book so far has been sentences. A story is different: it needs a background and a foreground at the same time.

The exchange

Four sentences. Watch the tenses take turns.

*Yo **estudiaba** español. No **tenía** un libro. **Tuve** un libro en marzo. Y **cuando tuve** el libro, **hablé** con Ana.*

Now read only the imperfects: *estudiaba, tenía*. Those two sentences tell you **what things were like** — the situation, with no edges, going on for as long as it needed to.

Now read only the preterites: *tuve, hablé*. Those tell you **what happened** — two events, each with edges, in order.

The story is the two layers together. Neither layer is a story on its own: the imperfects alone are a description that never moves, and the preterites alone are a list of events with no world around them.

Grammar Lens: what you can now do

Notice the third sentence. *Tuve un libro* is not “I had a book” — it is the moment you **got** one, which is why it belongs in the foreground with *hablé* rather than in the background with *tenía*. The same verb appears in both layers of this story, doing two different jobs, and nothing about it is irregular.

That is the whole rung. From here you can narrate: not just report that something happened, but say what the world was like while it did. It is worth naming the cost. Two tenses learned separately, then three chapters on nothing but the choice between them — because the forms were never the difficulty. English lets you leave this question unanswered; Spanish does not.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the four sentences straight through
- only the imperfects, then only the preterites, and hear the two layers

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which layer says what things were like? (The **imperfect**.) Which says what happened? (The **preterite**.) And what can you do now that you could not before? (**Tell a story** — not just report events, but say what the world was like while they happened.)

Chapter 116

Hablado, Comido, Vivido — The Participle

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) 🗉 Hands-free start: none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can form the participle of any regular verb, and know it never changes for person.

Complete ES-C49-participio: form the three participles and say whether the form changes with the speaker.

116.1 hablado, comido, vivido — the participle

Your three verb families, once more: *hablar*, *comer*, *vivir*. This chapter gives each of them one new form, and two of the three get the same one.

Grammar Lens: two endings, not three

hablar → **hablado** · comer → **comido** · vivir → **vivido**

- **-ar** verbs take **-ado**.
- **-er** and **-ir** verbs both take **-ido**.

You have seen those two families collapse into one before: in the preterite, where *comí* and *viví* have identical endings. It happens here for the same reason it happened there — the difference between *-er* and *-ir* was never deep, and outside the present tense it mostly stops existing.

So this is one new ending and one you can predict. The word itself does not change for who is speaking. *Hablado* is *hablado* whether you, I, or a hundred people did the speaking. That is unusual enough to notice: every other verb form you hold has been carrying a person on its back.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Grammarians call this a **participle**, from Latin **participium** — “the form that **takes part**.” It was named for doing two jobs at once: it is built from a verb, and it behaves like an adjective.

You can see the adjective half immediately. *Cansado* (“tired”) is the participle of *cansar*, and it agrees like any adjective: *cansada*, *cansados*. The same shape, doing adjective work.

Next chapter puts it to its verb work instead — and there, held in place by another word, it stops agreeing with anything at all.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hablado, comido, vivido” — one ending, then the shared one
- “comí, viví” then “comido, vivido” — the same merger, twice

Before you move on

Participle of *hablar*? (***Hablado***.) Of *comer* and *vivir*? (***Comido***, ***vivido*** — the same ending.) What does *participium* mean? (The form that **takes part** — verb and adjective at once.) Next: the word that turns it into a tense.

Chapter 117

He Hablado — A Verb With No Meaning Left

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say *he hablado*, and say what *haber* contributes to it.

Complete ES-C49-he-hablado: produce he hablado espanol and say what haber means there.

117.1 he hablado — “I have spoken”

You have *hablado*, and it cannot stand alone — it names no person and no time. It needs a word in front of it. Here is that word.

Sounds you’ll need

- **silent-h** — the *h* in *he* is silent, as every Spanish *h* is. It is one sound: *eh*.

Grammar Lens: the emptied verb

he + participle — *I have* done something.

He hablado español. — I have spoken Spanish.

Two words, and the work is split cleanly between them. *He* carries the person and the tense. *Hablado* carries the meaning. Neither does the

other's job, and that division is why the participle never had to agree with anybody.

He is a form of **haber** — and here is the thing worth the chapter:

haber does not mean anything here. It is not “I hold spoken.”

You cannot translate it on its own. It is a word whose entire remaining purpose is to hold a participle in place.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Haber comes from Latin **habēre**, “to hold, to have” — a completely ordinary verb with a completely ordinary meaning.

Then Spanish did something drastic. It handed the *meaning* to **tener** (which had been the narrower “hold, grip”), and kept *haber* for this one grammatical job. The verb was hollowed out: the meaning left, the machinery stayed.

English did exactly the same thing to *have*, and you never noticed. When you say *I have eaten*, nobody is holding anything.

Two languages, independently, took their word for “hold” and wore it down into a tense marker — because the step from *I have a thing that is done* to *I have done a thing* is a very short one, and everybody takes it eventually.

So when *haber* feels meaningless, that is not a gap in your understanding. It is an accurate perception of what happened to the word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “He hablado español”
- “I have eaten” in English, and notice that nothing is being held

Before you move on

“I have spoken”? (***He hablado.***) Which word carries the meaning? (***Hablado.***) And what does *haber* contribute? (**A person and a tense** — and no meaning at all.) Next: the rest of it.

Chapter 118

Has, Ha, Hemos, Habeis, Han

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can use every form of haber with a participle.

Complete ES-C49-haber-completo: give all six forms and say why haber is shorter than an ordinary verb.

118.1 has, ha, hemos, habéis, han

Say “I have eaten.” (*He comido.*) Now the other five people need their word.

Grammar Lens: the whole of it

	<i>haber</i>	with a participle
I	he	<i>he comido</i>
you	has	<i>has comido</i>
he / she / usted	ha	<i>ha comido</i>
we	hemos	<i>hemos comido</i>
you all (<i>Spain</i>)	habéis	<i>habéis comido</i>
they / ustedes	han	<i>han comido</i>

Six forms, and five of them are one syllable. Only *hemos* and *habéis* are longer, and they are the two you say least often.

That is not a coincidence, and it is the same principle you met with *ser* and *ir*: **the most-used words wear down the most.** *Haber* is said in every perfect sentence in the language, so it has been ground shorter

than any ordinary verb — down to *he*, *has*, *ha*, which barely have room to be irregular in.

Notice also what does **not** change. *Comido* is *comido* in all six rows. One word does all the person-work and the other never moves, which is why this tense, unlike every other you have learned, costs six little words rather than six endings on every verb you know.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “he, has, ha, hemos, habéis, han” until the list is one breath
- “he comido, has comido, ha comido...” through all six

Twice through:

Before you move on

“They have eaten”? (***Han comido.***) “We have eaten”? (***Hemos comido.***) How many times does the participle change? (**Never.**)
Next: four participles that refused to follow the rule.

Chapter 119

Hecho, Dicho, Visto, Puesto

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) 🗉 Hands-free start: none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can use the four irregular participles and say why those four.

Complete ES-C49-participios-irregulares: give the four forms, name the English noun that is hecho, and say why these four break the rule.

119.1 hecho, dicho, visto, puesto

By the rule, the participle of *hacer* should be *hacido*. Say it. Now be told that nobody has ever said it.

Grammar Lens: four, and you could have guessed which

verb	participle	in use
<i>hacer</i>	hecho	<i>he hecho</i> — I have done
<i>decir</i>	dicho	<i>he dicho</i> — I have said
<i>ver</i>	visto	<i>he visto</i> — I have seen
<i>poner</i>	puesto	<i>he puesto</i> — I have put

Look at that list of verbs before you look at the forms. *Do, say, see, put* — four of the commonest verbs in any language, and the same four that have been irregular in every tense you have met. The verbs that break rules are not a random selection: **they are always the ones**

said most often, because frequent words are the only ones used enough to survive being irregular.

You already know this in English. *Go/went, see/saw, do/did, put/put* — and nobody struggles with them, because you meet them a hundred times a day. The same will happen here.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

These four are not broken. They are **older than the rule**.

- *hecho* ← Latin **factum** — the thing done. English **fact** is that same word: a fact is literally *a thing that has been done*.
- *dicho* ← Latin **dictum** — the thing said. English keeps *dictum* whole, and *dictation, verdict* (“a true saying”), *contradict*.
- *visto* ← Latin **vīsum** — the thing seen. English **vision, visible**.
- *puesto* ← Latin **positum** — the thing placed. English **position, deposit, compose**.

Latin already had participles for these verbs, and Spanish inherited them intact instead of rebuilding them from the stem. The regular *-ado / -ido* forms are the newer machinery; these four are what was there before it.

So an irregular participle is not a form that went wrong. It is a form that was never replaced.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hecho, dicho, visto, puesto”
- each with English beside it — “hecho / fact”, “dicho / dictum”, “visto / vision”, “puesto / position”

Before you move on

The four? (***Hecho, dicho, visto, puesto***.) Are they broken forms? (**No** — they are **older than the rule**, inherited whole from Latin.) Next: all of it together.

Chapter 120

Review — A Tense You Build

Modes: 🗣 voice (1) 🗣 Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the two pieces of the perfect and say which carries the person.

Complete ES-C49-repaso-perfecto: name the two pieces and say why this tense cost less than the present or preterite.

120.1 Review — a tense you build

Nothing new. Two questions: how many words is this tense, and which of them carries the person?

What you've built

Piece one — the person: *he, has, ha, hemos, habéis, han.*

Piece two — the meaning: the participle, which never changes.

regular

-ar	-ado	hablado
-er / -ir	-ido	comido, vivido

irregular

hacer	hecho	decir → dicho
ver	visto	poner → puesto

Six little words times any participle you can form. That is the whole tense.

Grammar Lens: why this one was cheap

Every other tense you have learned made you attach endings to **every verb**. The present has six endings per family; the preterite has its own set; the imperfect has another.

This one does not work like that. You learn **six words once**, and then any verb you ever meet joins the tense by forming a single participle.

A tense that is *built* rather than *conjugated* costs a fixed amount instead of a per-verb amount.

That is worth recognising as a shape, because Spanish does it again.

Once you have *haber* plus a participle, the same two pieces will give you more tenses later by changing only the little word — and each of those will cost you almost nothing, for the same reason this one did.

Your turn

- *Say it*: “he hablado, has comido, ha vivido, hemos hecho, habéis dicho, han visto”

Twice through: Until the little word arrives without thought.

Before you move on

Two pieces — name them. (A form of *haber*, plus a **participle**.)

The four irregulars? (***Hecho, dicho, visto, puesto***.) Next: when to reach for this tense instead of the preterite — and the answer depends on where you are standing on the map.

Chapter 121

Synthesis — Two Shores, Two Answers

Modes: 🔄 voice (1) 🔄 Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what the perfect does that the preterite does not, and that today takes different tenses in Spain and Latin America.

Complete ES-C49-sintesis-dos-orillas: contrast he comido with comí, and say which tense Madrid and Mexico City choose for today.

121.1 Synthesis — two shores, two answers

You can now say “I spoke” two ways: *hablé* and *he hablado*. The obvious question is which one to use, and it has an unusual answer.

Grammar Lens: what the perfect is for

Start with the part everybody agrees on. The perfect reaches into **now**:

He comido. — I have eaten. (*so I am not hungry*) *Comí.*
— I ate. (*a finished event, back there*)

The preterite puts an event in the past and leaves it there. The perfect drags it forward and makes it matter now — the tense is telling your listener what to do with the information, not when it happened. English agrees: *I have eaten* and *I ate* are not interchangeable for you either.

Why it's said this way

Now the part nobody agrees on, and it is worth having straight before you are corrected by two people who contradict each other. For something that happened **today**, Spain and most of Latin America choose differently:

*Hoy **he hablado** con Ana.* — **Spain.** *Hoy **hablé** con Ana.*
— **most of Latin America.**

Same day, same conversation, both entirely correct. Spain uses the perfect for anything inside the current stretch of time; much of Latin America uses the preterite and saves the perfect for things whose relevance is still open.

Third split in this book decided by **geography rather than meaning**, after *vosotros* and *os*. There is no version of Spanish that is the real one, and no choice here that will make you wrong.

A default, if you want one: the Latin American pattern is understood everywhere and is what most learners meet first, so leaning on the preterite for finished events is a safe habit. In Spain you will hear the perfect constantly and pick it up in a week.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “He comido” then “Comí” — one reaches into now, one does not
- “Hoy he hablado con Ana” then “Hoy hablé con Ana” — two shores

Twice through:

Before you move on

What does the perfect do that the preterite does not? (**Reaches into now.**) And for something that happened today? (**Spain** says *he hablado*; **much of Latin America** says *hablé* — and both are right.)

Chapter 122

The Future — Saying What Will Happen

Modes: 🗣️ voice (3) 🗋️ Hands-free start: all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I will do, in the singular, across all three verb families.

The future endings ride on the whole infinitive, one family at a time.

122.1 hablaré — keep the infinitive, add the future

Voy a hablar español uses the near-future frame you already know. Spanish also has a one-word future: **Hablaré español** — “I will speak Spanish.” It can present a future prediction or intention without adding a new subject or object.

Grammar Lens: three familiar persons

Keep the whole infinitive **hablar**, then add one ending:

person	simple future
yo	hablaré
tú	hablarás
él / ella / usted	hablará

Say **hablaré · hablarás · hablará**. Each form has final stress, marked by an accent. Plural persons wait.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Late Latin and early Romance used more than one way to speak about the future. One influential construction placed an infinitive beside present forms of Latin **habēre**, “to have.” Through repeated use and sound change, descendants of those pieces became the endings in forms such as **hablaré**.

That history explains why the infinitive remains visible. It does **not** mean that a modern learner should attach the full modern verb **haber**, and it does not require the claim that every older future vanished at one moment.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hablaré, hablarás, hablará”
- “Voy a hablar español. Hablaré español.”
- “infinitive plus historical habēre material”

Before you move on

Give the three learned forms. (*Hablaré, hablarás, hablará.*) What stays visible? (The whole infinitive.) What older verb contributed to the endings? (Latin **habēre**.) Next: test the same endings on **comer**.

122.2 comeré — the same endings keep -er

You built **hablaré** without removing **-ar**. Keep **comer** just as intact: **comeré** — “I will eat.”

Grammar Lens: the singular -er row

person	simple future
yo	comeré
tú	comerás
él / ella / usted	comerá
Say comeré · comerás · comerá . Compare hablaré / comeré :	

the infinitives differ, but the future endings do not. Plural persons wait.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The historical infinitive-plus-**habēre** construction helps explain the shared endings: the verb-family vowel remains inside **hablar** or **comer**, rather than selecting a different ending set.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “comeré, comerás, comerá”
- “Hablaré. Comeré.”
- “Beberé café.”

Before you move on

Give the three learned forms. (*Comeré, comerás, comerá.*) Did the **-er** disappear? (No.) Which endings match **hablar**? (**-é, -ás, -á.**) Next: let **vivir** test the pattern once more.

122.3 viviré — one future row for three verb families

Hablaré kept **-ar**. **Comeré** kept **-er**. Predict the yo future of **vivir** before reading on. It is **viviré**.

Grammar Lens: the singular -ir row

person	simple future
yo	viviré
tú	vivirás
él / ella / usted	vivirá

Say **viviré · vivirás · vivirá**. Now the bounded pattern is complete: **hablaré, comeré, viviré**. The same three endings attach to all three whole infinitives. Plural persons wait.

Grammar Lens: meaning with known words

Viviré en Madrid says “I will live in Madrid.” Every lexical piece was available before this lesson; only the future form is new.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “viviré, vivirás, vivirá”
- “hablaré, comeré, viviré”
- “Viviré en Madrid.”

Before you move on

Give the three **vivir** forms. (*Viviré, vivirás, vivirá.*) Which verb families share the learned endings? (All three: **-ar, -er, -ir.**) Next: reuse the whole-infinitive frame for “would.”

Chapter 123

The Conditional — Saying What Would Happen

Modes: 🗣️ voice (3) 🗋️ Hands-free start: all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I would do, in the singular, across all three verb families.

The same infinitive, a different auxiliary tense on the end.

123.1 hablaría — the whole infinitive meets -ía

Hablaré español places speaking in the future. **Hablaría español** means “I would speak Spanish” in an imagined or conditional situation. Today the situation can remain unstated; learn the form and its core “would” meaning first.

Grammar Lens: three familiar persons

Keep **hablar** whole, then add the learned singular conditional endings:

person	conditional
yo	hablaría
tú	hablarías
él / ella / usted	hablaría

Say **hablaría** · **hablarías** · **hablaría**. The first and third forms match. The accent keeps **í-a** in separate syllables, just as it did in **comía**. Plural persons wait.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The conditional developed from an infinitive beside past or imperfect forms of the same “have” verb that helped form the Romance future. That is why the whole infinitive remains visible again and why the endings resemble the **-ía** row. The history passes through older Romance forms; modern **hablaría** is not made by attaching the complete modern word **había**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hablaría, hablarías, hablaría”
- “Hablaré español. Hablaría español.”
- “ha-bla-rí-a”

Before you move on

Give the three learned forms. (*Hablaría, hablarías, hablaría.*) What is the core meaning? (“Would speak.”) Which older construction stands behind the row? (An infinitive plus past forms of **haber**.) Next: give **comer** the same ending set.

123.2 comería — keep -er before “would”

Comeré means “I will eat.” Keep **comer** whole and exchange the future ending for **-ía**: **comería** — “I would eat.”

Grammar Lens: the singular -er row

person	conditional
yo	comería
tú	comerías
él / ella / usted	comería

Say **comería · comerías · comería**. Compare **hablaría / comería**: one bounded ending set serves both complete infinitives. Plural persons wait.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “comería, comerías, comería”
- “comeré, comería”
- “hablaría, comería”

Before you move on

Give the three learned forms. (*Comería, comerías, comería.*) Which piece stays whole? (**Comer.**) Which endings match **hablaría**? (**-ía, -ías, -ía.**) Next: complete the regular pattern with **vivir**.

123.3 viviría — the regular conditional closes its small frame

You can move from **comeré** to **comería**. Apply the same move to **viviré**: **viviría** — “I would live.”

Grammar Lens: the singular -ir row

person	conditional
yo	viviría
tú	vivirías
él / ella / usted	viviría
Say viviría · vivirías · viviría . The complete regular frame is now hablaría, comería, viviría . Plural persons wait.	

Grammar Lens: meaning with known words

Viviría en Madrid says “I would live in Madrid.” The lesson adds no new place or preposition.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “viviría, vivirías, viviría”

- “hablaría, comería, viviría”
- “Viviría en Madrid.”

Before you move on

Give the three **vivir** forms. (*Viviría, vivirías, viviría.*) Which regular verb families share the ending row? (All three.) Next: three already-known verbs change the stem but keep both sets of endings.

Chapter 124

One Stem, Two Tenses

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 👁️ eyes (1) 🦋 Hands-free start: first 1 of 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can use the irregular stems that serve the future and the conditional alike.

hare, tendre, podre - stems shared by both tenses, so learning one buys the other.

124.1 haré · tendré · podré — three stems, two ending sets

Regular verbs keep the whole infinitive. Three common verbs you already know use a shorter or reshaped stem. Learn only these three today. In each row, the **same** stem serves the future and the conditional.

Grammar Lens: hacer becomes har-

person	future	conditional
yo	haré	haría
tú	harás	harías
él / ella / usted	hará	haría

Use the known noun in **Haré café** — “I will make coffee” — and **Haría café** — “I would make coffee.”

Grammar Lens: tener becomes tendr-

person	future	conditional
yo	tendré	tendría
tú	tendrás	tendrías
él / ella / usted	tendrá	tendría

The **d** in **tendr-** arose during the history of the compact future and conditional. Treat **tendr-** as the learned stem, not as permission to insert **d** into a new verb.

Grammar Lens: poder becomes podr-

person	future	conditional
yo	podré	podría
tú	podrás	podrías
él / ella / usted	podrá	podría

Podré hablar español says “I will be able to speak Spanish.” **Podría hablar español** says “I could / would be able to speak Spanish.”

These stems reflect inherited reductions and sound changes. The useful modern fact is bounded: **har-** · **tendr-** · **podr-**, each followed by the same endings you already learned.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “haré, haría”
- “tendré, tendría”
- “podré, podría”

Before you move on

Give the three learned stems. (**Har-**, **tendr-**, **podr-**.) Does each verb need separate future and conditional stems? (No; one stem serves both.) Do the endings change? (No.) Next: retrieve the complete twelve-atom chapter.

124.2 Practice — one infinitive frame, two futures of thought

This checkpoint adds no vocabulary and no plural persons. Retrieve the six regular singular rows, then the three learned irregular stems. Use the future for “will” and the conditional for the bounded core meaning “would.”

Grammar Lens: the regular frame

person	hablar	comer	vivir
yo future	hablaré	comeré	viviré
tú future	hablarás	comerás	vivirás
él / ella / usted future	hablará	comerá	vivirá
yo conditional	hablaría	comería	viviría
tú conditional	hablarías	comerías	vivirías
él / ella / usted conditional	hablaría	comería	viviría

All three regular infinitives remain whole. Future endings are **-é, -ás, -á**; conditional endings are **-ía, -ías, -ía**. Plural persons wait.

Grammar Lens: three learned stems

verb	learned stem	future yo	conditional yo
hacer	har-	haré	haría
tener	tendr-	tendré	tendría
poder	podr-	podré	podría

The stems change; the ending sets do not. Other irregular stems remain outside this chapter.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Romance future and conditional forms grew from constructions pairing an infinitive with forms of Latin **habēre**. Present material contributed to the future; past or imperfect material contributed to the conditional. Many paths and competing forms existed during the change, so this is a bridge for memory, not a one-step story or a recipe

using modern **haber**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hablaré, comeré, viviré”
- “hablaría, comería, viviría”
- “haré/haría · tendré/tendría · podré/podría”

Before you move on

Give the three regular future yo forms. (*Hablaré, comeré, viviré.*)
Give the three regular conditional yo forms. (*Hablaría, comería, viviría.*) Which three learned stems replace a whole infinitive? (**Har-, tendr-, podr-.**) What is the careful historical bridge? (Infinitive plus forms of Latin **habēre**, reshaped through Romance.)
The next chapter can now begin without borrowing plural persons, new auxiliaries, or clock-time vocabulary.

Chapter 125

Synthesis — Promising, and Supposing

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can choose between a promise and a supposition, and say why the endings differ.

Haber glued on twice - present for the promise, past for the guess.

125.1 Synthesis — promising, and supposing

Nothing new in this chapter. Say *hablaré*, then *hablaría*.

Grammar Lens: the two endings are one word, twice

Three chapters ago you were told where these endings came from. Now it is worth seeing what that fact *buys* you.

Both are the verb **haber** — Latin *habēre*, “to have” — glued onto the back of the infinitive. Romance speakers stopped saying “I have to speak” as two words and fused it into one:

hablar + **he** (I have) → **hablaré** — I will speak. *hablar* + **había** (I had) → **hablaría** — I would speak.

That is the entire difference between the two tenses: **the same auxiliary, once in the present and once in the past**. Not two systems to learn — one system, looked at from two moments.

What you've built

And the meaning follows from the grammar rather than being extra to it.

Having to do something **now** is a commitment: **hablaré** is a promise, or a prediction you are standing behind. *Having had to* do it is a supposition — the obligation sits in a past that never arrived, so **hablaría** is hypothetical.

Promise from the present. Suppose from the past.

English hides the same move: *will* is the present of an old verb meaning *to want*, and *would* is its past. **Will/would** is the same pair as **-é/-ía**.

The exchange

— ¿**Hablarás** español en Madrid? — Sí, **hablaré** español.

>

— ¿Y sin práctica? — **Hablaría** español, pero no bien.

One letter-run apart, and the second speaker has moved from a commitment to a guess without changing a single other word.

Your turn

- Say it: *hablaré* then *hablaría*, and hear a promise turn into a guess

Twice through: Until the choice is about what you mean, not which ending it was.

Before you move on

What is glued onto the infinitive in both tenses? (**Haber** — the verb *to have*.) Which one is a promise, and which a supposition? (-é the promise, -ía the supposition.) And what is the English pair that works the same way? (**Will** and **would** — a present and a past of one old verb.)

Chapter 126

Wanting, Not Asserting

Modes:  voice (1)  Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can tell an asserted event apart from a wanted one, and say why the verb changes.

Hablas español asserts; quiero que hables asserts nothing at all.

126.1 Hablas español · Quiero que hables español — fact or wanted event?

Hablas español can assert “You speak Spanish.” Now compare **Quiero que hables español** — “I want you to speak Spanish.” **Hables** does not report what is true. It presents the speaking as wanted and not yet asserted. That meaning contrast is the first small doorway into the **subjunctive**.

Grammar Lens: count the doers

meaning	Spanish	doers
I want to speak Spanish.	Quiero hablar español.	one: I want; I speak
I want you to speak Spanish.	Quiero que hables español.	two: I want; you speak

With one doer, keep the known infinitive **hablar**. With a different doer for the wanted event, use **que** and the new form **hables**. This is a bounded pattern for **querer**, not a rule for every clause in Spanish.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Hablas español.”
- “Quiero hablar español.”
- “Quiero que hables español.”

Before you move on

Which form asserts the event? (**Hablas.**) Which presents it as wanted? (**Hables**, after **quiero que.**) What happens when the wanter and the speaker are the same? (Use the infinitive: **Quiero hablar.**) Next, build the three singular **-ar** forms one piece at a time.

Chapter 127

The Subjunctive, Regular

Modes: 🗣️ voice (3) 🗋️ Hands-free start: all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can form the singular present subjunctive of a regular verb in any of the three families.

hable, coma, viva - the vowels swap sides, and -er and -ir agree again.

127.1 hable · hables · hable — the singular -ar row

You already used **hables** for one friend. Today add only the other two singular slots:

person	present subjunctive
yo	hable
tú	hables
él / ella / usted	hable

Plural forms wait. Say the small row: **hable · hables · hable**.

Grammar Lens: the yo stem, then a vowel swap

Start from present **hablo**. Remove **-o** to reveal **habl-**. Regular **-ar** verbs then use **e** in these subjunctive endings: **-e, -es, -e**. The family vowel has swapped from the familiar **a** to **e**. This recipe will matter later because a verb's special present **yo** stem can travel with it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish **subjuntivo** descends from Latin **subiūctīvus**, “subjoined,” from **sub-** “under” plus **iungere** “join.” English **join**, **junction**, and **conjunction** belong to the same word family; **yoke** is a more distant cousin. The name helps you picture the wanted clause joined under **quiero que**. It is history, not a complete usage rule.

Your turn

Build each answer only from the learned singular row.

Before you move on

Give the three forms. (**Hable, hables, hable.**) Which present form supplies the stem? (**Hablo.**) What did the family vowel do? (**a → e.**) What does the name remember? (A clause **subjoined**, or joined under another.)

127.2 coma · comas · coma — let -er cross to a

Start from **como**, remove **-o**, and keep **com-**. A regular **-er** verb crosses to the **a** family:

person	present subjunctive
yo	coma
tú	comas
él / ella / usted	coma

Say only the singular row: **coma · comas · coma.**

Grammar Lens: meaning before machinery

Comes can assert “you eat.” **Quiero que comas** presents your eating as what I want. The **e → a** contrast helps you hear the two meanings. It does not mean that every **a** form is subjunctive; use the learned frame as a whole.

Your turn

Keep **comer** inside the learned singular frame.

Before you move on

Give the three forms. (**Coma, comas, coma.**) Which form asserts “you eat”? (**Comes.**) Which belongs after **quiero que**? (**Comas.**) Next, test whether regular **-ir** behaves differently.

127.3 viva · vivas · viva — -ir joins -er

Start from **vivo**, remove **-o**, then add the same **a** endings you just used with **comer**:

person	present subjunctive
yo	viva
tú	vivas
él / ella / usted	viva

Regular **-er** and **-ir** match in this singular row:

- **comer: coma · comas · coma.**
- **vivir: viva · vivas · viva.**

Plural differences wait.

Grammar Lens: meaning in a known frame

Vives en Madrid asserts where one friend lives. **Quiero que vivas en Madrid** makes that living a wanted event. Nothing new is being smuggled into the sentence: **en** and **Madrid** have appeared in the earlier location frame.

Your turn

Keep **vivir** inside the learned singular frame.

Before you move on

Give the three forms. (**Viva, vivas, viva.**) Which regular family matches **-ir** here? (**-er.**) Which form fits one friend after **quiero que**? (**Vivas.**)

Chapter 128

The Subjunctive Built From the Yo Form

Modes: 🗣️ voice (3) 🗋️ Hands-free start: all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can build the subjunctive of an irregular verb from its yo form.

quiera, pueda, haga - each one is its own yo form with the vowel swapped.

128.1 quiera · quieras · quiera — keep the change you know

Present **quiero** already carries the stressed **e** → **ie** change. Remove **-o** to get **quier-**, then add the **-er/-ir** subjunctive endings:

person	present subjunctive
yo	quiera
tú	quieras
él / ella / usted	quiera

Say only this bounded singular row: **quiera · quieras · quiera.**

Grammar Lens: one known verb, one inherited stem

You are not learning a new list of stem-changing verbs. You are carrying one known change into one known row. **Quiero que quieras**

hablar español means “I want you to want to speak Spanish.” The sentence is deliberately narrow: no new person noun, object, or plural form.

Your turn

Carry only the known **quier-** stem into this row.

Before you move on

Give the three forms. (**Quiera, quieras, quiera.**) Which old change stays visible? (**e** → **ie.**) Where did the stem come from? (Known **quiero**, minus **-o.**)

128.2 pueda · puedas · pueda — one more known stem change

Present **puedo** already carries **o** → **ue**. Remove **-o** to get **pued-**, then add the same **a** row:

person	present subjunctive
yo	pueda
tú	puedas
él / ella / usted	pueda

Say **pueda · puedas · pueda**. No other **poder** forms enter today.

Grammar Lens: use it immediately

Quiero que puedas hablar español means “I want you to be able to speak Spanish.” Every word was already known except the single form **puedas**. This is the gentle pattern: learn one row, then spend it in the next sentence.

Your turn

Carry only the known **pued-** stem into this row.

Before you move on

Give the three forms. (**Pueda, puedas, pueda.**) Which old change stays visible? (**o** → **ue**.) Which form addresses one friend after **quiero que**? (**Puedas.**)

128.3 haga · hagas · haga — hago lends its stem

The known present **yo** form is **hago**. Remove **-o** and keep **hag-**:

person	present subjunctive
yo	haga
tú	hagas
él / ella / usted	haga

Say **haga · hagas · haga**. Only **hacer** enters this lesson; other special stems wait for later chapters.

Grammar Lens: spend the new form

Haces café can assert “you make coffee.” **Quiero que hagas café** says “I want you to make coffee.” The **g** is not a fresh exception: it was already in **hago**, the present form that supplied the stem.

Your turn

Carry only the known **hag-** stem into this row.

Before you move on

Give the three forms. (**Haga, hagas, haga.**) Where does **hag-** come from? (Known **hago**, minus **-o**.) Say the wanted event. (**Quiero que hagas café.**)

Chapter 129

Ojala — a Prayer That Outlived Its Religion

Modes: 🔄 voice (2) 🔄 Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can wish for something with ojala, and say where the word came from.

wa-sha' allah, carried through al-Andalus and kept long after.

129.1 ojalá + subjunctive — a wish borrowed through Arabic

Ojalá hables español means “I hope you speak Spanish” or “May you speak Spanish.” **Ojalá** expresses the wish by itself. It needs neither a main verb nor **que** before the subjunctive. Keep the first frame tiny:

Ojalá + subjunctive

That is a usable modern pattern. It does not make the Arabic source phrase new Spanish vocabulary.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The Real Academia Española records **ojalá** from Hispanic Arabic **wa šá lláh**, “and God has willed.” Long contact in al-Andalus carried the expression into Spanish, where its sound and grammatical life changed. You met another Arabic-derived function word in **hasta**. The

historical phrase explains a route; only modern **ojalá** is available for your Spanish sentences.

Your turn

Use only modern **ojalá** as the Spanish trigger.

Before you move on

What follows **ojalá** in the learned frame? (The **subjunctive**.) Does it need **que**? (**No.**) Which historical language variety carried the word into Spanish? (**Hispanic Arabic.**) Is the older Arabic phrase usable as new Spanish vocabulary here? (**No.**)

129.2 Practice — assert the event or want it

This checkpoint adds no vocabulary, plural person, object pronoun, or new clause frame. First decide whether the event is asserted or wanted. Then retrieve only the singular rows you learned.

Grammar Lens: the bounded map

verb	yo / él / ella / usted	tú
hablar	hable	hables
comer	coma	comas
vivir	viva	vivas
querer	quiera	quieras
poder	pueda	puedas
hacer	haga	hagas

The repeated outer form is not a missing row: first- and third-person singular match. Every plural form waits.

Grammar Lens: two safe triggers

- Same doer: **Quiero hablar español.**
- Different doer: **Quiero que hables español.**

- Wish by itself: **Ojalá hables español.**

Do not extend these two frames to every emotion, doubt, command, or conjunction yet. More triggers belong in later micro-lessons.

Your turn

Decide the meaning first; then retrieve only the learned form.

Before you move on

What is the first meaning choice? (**Asserted event or wanted event.**) Give the three regular tú forms. (**Hables, comas, vivas.**) Give the three bounded special tú forms. (**Quieras, puedas, hagas.**) Name the two safe triggers. (**Quiero que** for a different doer; **ojalá** for a wish.) What still waits? (Plural persons, additional irregular verbs, and additional subjunctive triggers.)

Chapter 130

Synthesis — Claiming, and Not Claiming

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) ↔ Hands-free start: none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can choose the mood by deciding whether I am willing to assert the thing at all.

Indicative: this is so. Subjunctive: I am not saying this is so.

130.1 Synthesis — claiming, and not claiming

Nothing new in this chapter. Say *hablas*, then *hables*.

Grammar Lens: what the second one is actually doing

Those two forms are not two tenses. They are two **stances**.

Hablas español. — I am telling you this is so. **Quiero que hables español.** — I am not telling you anything is so.

In the first, you put a fact on the table and stood behind it. In the second, nothing has been claimed at all: the speaking has not happened, and might not. The mood is the difference, and the difference is about **what you are willing to assert**.

That is the whole of it, and it is worth holding onto, because every remaining use of this mood — and there are many — is a version of the same move. Wishing, doubting, denying, hoping: none of them puts a fact on the table.

Indicative: *this is so*. Subjunctive: *I am not saying this is so*.

The exchange

— ¿**Hablas** español? — Ana quiere que **hable** español. —
Ojalá hables mucho.

Three lines, three stances. The first asks about a fact. The second reports somebody's wish, so nothing is asserted. The third wishes it outright.

What you've built

Ojalá deserves a last look, because it explains itself.

It is Arabic — *wa-šā' allāh*, “and may God will it” — carried into Spanish over eight centuries of al-Andalus and kept long after the religion behind it stopped being the speaker's. A Spanish speaker saying *ojalá* today is uttering a prayer in a language they do not speak, to a God the sentence no longer names.

And it can only ever take this mood. Of course it can: a thing God has yet to will is, by definition, not a fact you can assert.

Your turn

- *Say it*: the three-line exchange, and name the stance of each line

Twice through: Until choosing the mood feels like choosing what you mean.

Before you move on

What does the indicative do that the subjunctive does not? (**Claim that something is so**.) Why can *ojalá* never take the indicative? (Because a thing not yet willed is not a fact.) And what language is *ojalá*? (**Arabic** — a prayer that outlived the religion behind it.)

Chapter 131

Habla — Telling Somebody To Do Something

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) ↔ Hands-free start: none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can give an informal positive command using a form I already hold.

Complete ES-C50-habla: give a *tu* command and name the form it reuses.

131.1 habla — telling somebody to do something

Say “he speaks.” (*Habla.*) Hold that word. You are about to be told it does a second job you have never been shown.

Grammar Lens: you already have it

To tell somebody you address as *tú* to do something, use the **he/she** form of the present.

Habla. — Speak. *Come.* — Eat. *Vive.* — Live.

That is the whole rule, and it costs you nothing. *Habla* was already in your mouth as “he speaks”; the same two syllables, said to somebody, are an order.

verb	he/she does	you, do it
<i>hablar</i>	habla	habla
<i>comer</i>	come	come
<i>vivir</i>	vive	vive

The column repeats. That is not an oversight in the table. Spanish does this often enough that it is worth naming as a habit: rather than inventing a new form for every job, it **reuses one and lets context sort it out**. *Habla* said about somebody is a statement; *habla* said to somebody is a command, and nobody has ever confused the two.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The name for this form is the **imperative**, from Latin *imperāre*, “to command.”

That *imper-* is a word you already know in English clothes. An **emperor** is literally *one who commands*; an **empire** is the thing he commands. The grammar term and the political ones are the same root, which is a fair description of what the form does: it is the sentence shape that expects to be obeyed.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “habla” as a statement, then “¡Habla!” as an order — same word, different job
- “come”, “vive”

Before you move on

Tell somebody to speak. (***Habla.***) Which form is that? (The **he/she** present — nothing new.) What does *imperāre* mean? (**To command** — as in *emperor*.) Next: eight verbs that refused, and every one of them is a single syllable.

Chapter 132

Di, Haz, Ve, Pon, Ten, Sal, Se, Ven

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) 🗉 Hands-free start: none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can use the eight irregular informal commands and say why they are all one syllable.

Complete ES-C50-ocho-cortos: give the eight forms and say why they are so short.

132.1 di, haz, ve, pon, ten, sal, sé, ven

By last chapter's rule, "say it" should be *dice*. It is not. There are exactly eight of these, and once you see them together you will not need to memorise the list.

Grammar Lens: eight, all one syllable

verb	command	
<i>decir</i>	di	say
<i>hacer</i>	haz	do, make
<i>ir</i>	ve	go
<i>poner</i>	pon	put
<i>tener</i>	ten	have, hold
<i>salir</i>	sal	leave
<i>ser</i>	sé	be
<i>venir</i>	ven	come

Read the middle column down. **Every single one is one syllable**, and most are two or three letters. No other set of forms in Spanish is

this short.

That is the fact worth carrying, and it has a cause. A command is the sentence you shout, the sentence you say in a hurry, the sentence you interrupt somebody with. Words used that way get worn down harder than words used calmly — and these eight are the commonest verbs in the language, so they had the most use to be worn by.

So the list is not eight arbitrary exceptions. It is **what the eight most-shouted verbs look like after two thousand years of being shouted.**

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all eight in one breath — “di, haz, ve, pon, ten, sal, sé, ven”
- each one as if calling across a room

Twice through: Until the list is a rhythm rather than eight facts.

Before you move on

How many irregular *tú* commands are there? (**Eight.**) What do they all have in common besides being irregular? (**One syllable each.**) Next: how to tell somebody **not** to do something — and you already have that form too.

Chapter 133

No Hables — Telling Somebody Not To

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗋️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can give a negative informal command, and say why it takes the subjunctive.

Complete ES-C50-no-hables: produce no hables and say why the subjunctive is the right form.

133.1 no hables — telling somebody not to

“Speak” is *habla*. So “don’t speak” should be *no habla*. Say it, and then be told it is wrong.

Grammar Lens: the form you already learned for wanting

A **negative** command uses the **subjunctive**.

no hables — don’t speak. *no comas* — don’t eat.

Those are not new forms. You built them chapters ago, when you learned to say *quiero que hables* — “I want you to speak.”

And the connection is not an accident of grammar. Think about what the subjunctive was **for**: the form for something **not asserted** — wanted, feared, hoped for, but not claimed to be happening.

A negative command is exactly that. *No hables* does not describe any speaking. There is no speaking; the whole point of the sentence is that you want there to be none. Spanish reaches for the non-asserting form

because nothing is being asserted.
So this is not “the negative command borrows the subjunctive.” It is the subjunctive doing the thing it has always done.

Why it’s said this way

There is a lopsidedness here worth naming, because it looks like untidiness and is not.

habla — an ordinary present form. **no hables** — a subjunctive form.

Two different shapes for one verb, depending only on whether there is a *no* in front. Most languages would use one form for both.

The reason Spanish does not is that the two sentences are doing genuinely different things. *Habla* points at an action and hands it to you. *No hables* points at an action **and refuses it** — and the refusal, not the action, is the sentence’s content. The form follows the content, as it did in every subjunctive sentence you have already met.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “habla” then “no hables” — hear the form change with the *no*
- “quiero que hables” then “no hables” — the same form, twice

Before you move on

“Don’t speak”? (***No hables.***) Which form is that? (The **subjunctive** — the one for what is not asserted.) Next: the same form again, this time for politeness rather than negation.

Chapter 134

Hable Usted — The Polite Command

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can give a formal command and say why the usted form is the polite one.

Complete ES-C50-hable-usted: produce *hable por favor* and explain why the *usted* command is polite.

134.1 hable usted — the polite command

Usted takes the **he/she** form of every verb. You have known that since you learned it. Watch what that does to a command.

Grammar Lens: the subjunctive, a third time

A command to *usted* — positive or negative — uses the **subjunctive**.

Hable, *por favor*. — Speak, please. **Coma**, *por favor*. — Eat, please. **No hable**. — Don't speak.

So the subjunctive now covers three of the four boxes:

	<i>tú</i>	<i>usted</i>
do it	<i>habla</i> — ordinary present	<i>hable</i> — subjunctive
don't	<i>no hables</i> — subjunctive	<i>no hable</i> — subjunctive
One box out of four uses an ordinary form, and it is the informal, positive one. Everything else reaches for the subjunctive.		

Why it's said this way

Here is why the formal command is the polite one, and it is not because the subjunctive is a fancy form.

Remember what *usted* is: a worn-down **vuestra merced**, “your grace” — a **title**, and titles are third person. That is why *usted* takes he/she endings. So a command to *usted* is not grammatically aimed at the person in front of you at all. It is aimed at *your grace*, spoken about rather than to.

That indirectness **is** the politeness. Every polite language does some version of it: you soften an order by not pointing it straight at somebody. English does it with extra words — *could you possibly*, *would you mind* — where Spanish does it with a verb form and a fossil of a title.

Which means that if the *usted* command ever feels stiff to you, you are hearing it correctly. It is supposed to hold somebody at a small distance.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Habla” then “Hable, por favor” — hear the distance open up
- all four boxes: “habla, no hables, hable, no hable”

Before you move on

“Speak, please,” to *usted*? (**Hable, por favor.**) Which form? (The **subjunctive** again.) Why is it polite? (Because *usted* is a **title** — the order is aimed past the person, not at them.) Next: all four in one place.

Chapter 135

Review — Four Boxes

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can give all four command forms of a regular verb.

Complete ES-C50-repaso-mandatos: give all four boxes for comer and say what the rung genuinely cost.

135.1 Review — four boxes

Nothing new. Before the grid: which single box does **not** use the subjunctive?

What you've built

	<i>tú</i>	<i>usted</i>
do it	<i>habla · come</i>	<i>hable · coma</i>
don't	<i>no hables · no comas</i>	<i>no hable · no coma</i>

Three of the four boxes are the **subjunctive**, which you built chapters ago for wanting and hoping. The fourth is the ordinary **he/she present**, which you built long before that.

Now count what this rung actually cost you. A whole grammatical mood — the one every phrasebook opens with — and the only genuinely new material in it was **eight one-syllable words**: *di, haz, ve, pon, ten, sal, sé, ven*.

Everything else was a form you already owned, doing one more job.

Grammar Lens: why the odd box is the odd one

It is worth asking why the informal positive command is the exception. Because it is the one that is said most. *Come, ven, habla, ten* — said to children, friends, dogs, and across kitchens, thousands of times a day for two thousand years. That is the box under the most pressure, and heavy use keeps old short forms alive rather than letting them be replaced by tidier ones.

The same pressure explains the eight irregulars, which live in exactly that box and nowhere else. There are no irregular *negative* commands to learn, because negatives are said less and had time to be regularised. **The messiest corner of this grid is the most-used corner.** That has been true of every irregularity in this book.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the four boxes for *hablar*, then for *comer*
- the eight irregulars once more

Twice through:

Before you move on

How many of the four boxes use the subjunctive? (**Three.**) What did this rung genuinely cost? (**Eight one-syllable words.**) Next: what a command sounds like to the person receiving it.

Chapter 136

Synthesis — Asking Without Sounding Rude

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can pick the command form that matches my relationship to the listener.

Complete ES-C50-sintesis-pedir-bien: command a friend and a stranger, and say where a Spanish command's politeness lives.

136.1 Synthesis — asking without sounding rude

Say “eat” to a friend. (*Come.*) In English, saying “Eat.” to somebody lands hard. You are about to learn that it does not land the same way here.

Why it's said this way

English has almost no polite imperative. *Eat. Sit.* Bare, they sound like orders to a dog, so English speakers pad them: *could you, would you mind.*

Spanish needs no padding, because it spends its politeness elsewhere — **on the choice of person.**

Come. — to a friend. Perfectly warm. *Coma, por favor.* — to a stranger. Perfectly polite.

The *tú* command is not blunt; it is **intimate**. Using it says *we are on those terms*, which between friends is friendly rather than bossy. The

usted command is not cold; it is **respectful**, for the same reason. So an English speaker's mistake here is not tone. It is picking the wrong person: *usted* with a friend sounds stiff, *tú* with a stranger presumptuous. **The politeness lives in the pronoun you chose before the command left your mouth.** *Por favor* helps and costs nothing, but here it is a garnish rather than the structure.

The exchange

The same four things said twice — once to a friend, once to a stranger.

To a friend: *Ven. Come. No hables. Ten.* **To a stranger:**
Venga. Coma, por favor. No hable. Tenga.

Read both aloud. The first is not ruder; it is closer. Say the second to somebody you have known for years and you have not been polite — you have put a small distance between you, and they will hear it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Ven” then “Venga” — hear the distance, not the rudeness
- the friend row, then the stranger row, straight through

Twice through:

Before you move on

Is *Come* rude to a friend? (**No** — it is **close**.) Where does the politeness of a Spanish command live? (In the **person you chose**.) And what does *usted* with an old friend sound like? (**Distance**, not courtesy.)

Chapter 137

Lo Siento

Modes: 🗣️ voice (2) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can apologise in Spanish and choose between *lo siento* and *perdón*.

Say lo siento for regret and perdón for fault or for catching someone's attention, hearing sentir — I feel it — inside the first and dōnāre — to give completely — inside the second.

137.1 lo siento — “I’m sorry,” i.e. “I feel it”

You already know **por favor**, “please.” The next courtesy phrase is **lo siento**. Spanish does not say “I *am* sorry” as an adjective; it says something closer to “**I feel this.**”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **lo** = “it” — a **neuter** pronoun. It does not point at any noun; it points at the **situation itself**. Spanish keeps this one leftover neuter slot precisely for “the whole business, unnamed.”
- **siento** = “I feel,” from **sentir**, “to feel,” from Latin **sentīre**. That root gave English a whole family: **sentiment**, **sense**, **consent** (“feel together”), **resent** (“feel back at”), and **sentence** (originally an *opinion*, something felt).

So **lo siento** is literally “*I feel it.*” You are naming a feeling — regret, sympathy — rather than declaring a state about yourself. That is why it stretches so easily: *lo siento mucho*, “I feel it a lot,” works both for

stepping on someone's foot and for hearing that their father died.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “siento” — I feel — then “lo siento,” I feel it / I’m sorry
- “lo siento mucho” — I’m so sorry
- “siento” then English “sentiment, sense, consent”

Before you move on

What does **lo siento** literally mean? (“**I feel it**” — *siento*, “I feel,” from Latin *sentire*.) What is the *lo* pointing at? (The **situation**, not a noun — it is the neuter “it.”) Next: Spanish’s *other* word for sorry, and when it is the right one.

137.2 perdón — the sorry that asks for something back

Lo siento names a feeling. Spanish keeps a **second** word for a different job — one that is not about your feelings at all, but about something you want from the other person.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

perdón (“pardon”), from the verb **perdonar** — Latin **per-** (“thoroughly”) + **dōnāre** (“to give”). Literally: “**to give completely.**”

That *dōnāre* is English’s **donate**, **donor**, and **condone**; the *per-* is the same intensifier in **perfect** (“thoroughly made”) and **perturb**. So forgiveness, in Latin’s picture of it, is a **gift given all the way** — you hand over the debt rather than keeping a share of it.

Why it’s said this way

The two are not interchangeable, and the difference follows straight from the etymologies:

	lo siento	perdón
literally	“I feel it”	“give [it] completely”
points at	your feeling	their forgiveness
use for	regret, sympathy	fault, or getting past someone

So **perdón** is what you say to squeeze through a crowd or catch a waiter’s eye (English “excuse me”), and to ask forgiveness for something **you did** — often stronger than *lo siento*. **Lo siento** leans toward “I’m sorry that happened,” including things that are nobody’s fault at all.

Be honest about the edges: native speakers use whichever fits, the boundary is soft, and mixing them is not a real mistake — just a shade off.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “perdón” — pardon / excuse me
- the pair — “lo siento” for regret, “perdón” for fault
- “perdón” then English “donate, condone” — the *dōnāre* root

Before you move on

What do the two halves of **perdonar** mean? (**Per-**, “thoroughly,” plus **dōnāre**, “to give” — to give completely.) Which word do you use to get past someone in a corridor? (**Perdón.**) Which leans toward sympathy rather than fault? (**Lo siento** — “I feel it.”)

Chapter 138

Days of the Week

Modes: 👁 eyes (2) ↔ Hands-free start: none of the 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name all seven days of the week in Spanish and say why the last two broke away from the planet names.

Run lunes to domingo straight through, then pair each weekend day against its English twin — sábado against Saturn’s day, domingo against the Sun’s.

138.1 lunes to viernes — the planets of the week, worn down

The Romans mapped the seven-day week onto the seven visible “wandering stars” — the planet-gods. Spanish kept that map, but handled the word “day” differently from its Romance cousins: where French still spells out “-di” (day) on every weekday, Spanish mostly just **dropped it**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Each weekday began life as “[planet-god]’s diēs (day).” In Vulgar Latin, *diēs* was simply **dropped as a separate word** in most of these — what survived is just the planet’s own Latin genitive form. That’s why **martes, jueves, viernes** already end in -s: not because *diēs* wore down into one, but because **Martis, Iovis, Veneris** — the planets’ own genitive forms — end in -s in Latin already. **Lunes** has no such -s to inherit (*lūnae* doesn’t end in one), so it likely picked up

the ending by **analogy** with its four siblings:

Spanish	← Latin	planet-god	English echo
lunes	<i>lūnae diēs</i>	the Moon (<i>luna</i>)	<i>Monday</i> = Moon-day
martes	<i>Martis diēs</i>	Mars	<i>Tuesday</i> (Tiw, the Germanic war-god = Mars)
miércoles	<i>Mercuriī diēs</i>	Mercury	<i>Wednesday</i> (Woden = Mercury)
jueves	<i>Jovis diēs</i>	Jupiter (<i>Jove</i>)	<i>Thursday</i> (Thor = Jupiter)
viernes	<i>Veneris diēs</i>	Venus	<i>Friday</i> (Frigg/ Freya = Venus)

Compare **French**, which keeps *diēs* as its own visible syllable on every day — **lundi, mardi, jeudi** — while Spanish dropped it from four of its five weekdays. **miércoles** is the odd one out: some historians of the language think its extra “**-coles**” is a genuine surviving trace of *diēs* itself (fused in and reshaped) — though the exact sound changes are debated, unlike the plainer, better-understood story for its four siblings.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “lunes, martes, miércoles, jueves, viernes” — the work week
- each as “[planet]’s day, worn down” — “lunes = Moon, jueves = Jupiter”
- the bridge — “martes / Tuesday, both the war-god’s day (Mars / Tiw)”

Before you move on

Recall the weekday family:

- What did every Spanish weekday begin life as? (“**[Planet-god]’s diēs (day)**” — the same Latin phrase French keeps more visibly with *-di*.)
- Why do **martes, jueves, viernes** end in *-s*, and where does **lunes** get its *-s* from? (**From the planet’s own Latin genitive** — Martis/Iovis/ Veneris already end in *-s*; *lunes* likely picked it up **by analogy**, since *lūnae* has no *-s* of its own.)
- What’s debated about **miércoles**? (**Whether its “-coles” is a genuine surviving trace of diēs** — unlike the plainer, better-understood story for its four siblings.)
- Why do *martes* and *Tuesday* line up? (They name the same day for the war-god: *Mars* in Latin, *Tiw* in Germanic.)

138.2 sábado and domingo — the week’s religious edge

Five days named for planets — then two that broke the pattern entirely. The weekend is where **religion overwrote astronomy**, and Spanish keeps both rewrites in plain view.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish	← Latin	meaning	note
sábado	<i>sabbatum</i>	“ Sabbath ”	the planet-god (Saturn) is gone — replaced by the Hebrew <i>shabbāt</i> , “to rest”
domingo	<i>diēs Dominica</i>	“the Lord’s day”	<i>Dominica</i> ← <i>Dominus</i> , “lord/master” — Spanish kept this one much less worn-down than French’s <i>dimanche</i>

Two different rewrites:

- **sábado** would have been “Saturn’s day” (as English **Saturday** still is — the one weekday English kept a Roman god for). Instead, Latin Christians borrowed the Jewish **Sabbath** (*Sabbatum* ← Hebrew *shabbāt*), and it became *sábado*. So English **Saturday** and Spanish **sábado** are the **same day, two different names** — the planet vs. the Sabbath.
- **domingo** drops Sun-worship entirely: where English keeps **Sunday**, Spanish made it *diēs Dominica*, “the Lord’s day” (*Dominus* → English **dominion, dominate, dame**). Spanish kept **domingo** recognizably close to *Dominica* — compare French’s more worn-down **dimanche**, where the *di-* (day) fossil jumped to the front of the word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the full week — “lunes, martes, miércoles, jueves, viernes, sábado, domingo”

- “sábado = Sabbath, domingo = the Lord’s day” — religion, not planets
- the pair-ups — “sábado / Saturday (Sabbath vs. Saturn)”, “domingo / Sunday (Lord vs. Sun)”

Before you move on

Give all seven Spanish days. (*Lunes ... domingo.*) Where does **sábado** come from, and its English contrast? (The **Sabbath**, *Sabbatum*; English kept *Saturday* = Saturn’s day.) What does **domingo** mean literally? (“The **Lord’s** day,” *diēs Dominica.*)

Chapter 139

Black, White, Red, and Blue

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name black, white, red and blue in Spanish and say which of them Spanish borrowed rather than inherited.

Say negro, blanco, rojo and azul, then sort them by origin: negro inherited from Latin, blanco traditionally linked to the Germanic Visigoths, rojo a cousin of English red by a different Latin branch, and azul carried in from Arabic lāzaward.

139.1 negro, blanco — two colours, and one of their histories

Two colours you can put to work immediately. One of them has the most ordinary history imaginable. The other does not — which is why it gets its own lesson next.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

negro (“black”) ← Latin **niger**. Nothing surprising: the same Latin root gives English **denigrate** (“to blacken someone’s name”) and the rest of the Romance family’s words for black — French *noir*, Italian *nero*, Portuguese *negro*. Latin’s word for black stayed put, in every daughter language.

Hold that in mind as the baseline. It is what a colour word normally does.

The two words in use

blanco (“white”) is the pair to it: *el gato negro*, *el gato blanco*. Both behave like any Spanish adjective — they follow the noun and agree with it (*la casa blanca*).

But hear what you would have expected and did not get. Latin’s word for white was **albus**, and by the *negro* pattern Spanish “white” should be something like *albo*. It is not. Where **blanco** actually came from — and what became of *albus* — is the next lesson.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “negro, blanco”
- with a noun — “el gato negro, la casa blanca”
- “negro” then English “denigrate” — the *niger* root

Before you move on

Say black and white. (*Negro, blanco*.) Where does *negro* come from, and what English word shares it? (Latin **niger** — *denigrate*.) What would you have expected Spanish’s “white” to be, given Latin *albus*? (Something like *albo* — and it isn’t. That is next lesson’s puzzle.)

139.2 blanco — the colour Spanish did not inherit

Negro came straight down from Latin, like almost every other everyday word you have met. **Blanco** did not come down at all. It walked in.

What to know first

- negro, blanco — the two colour words.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

blanco comes from **Germanic *blank** — “**shining, gleaming**.” It is a **loan**, traditionally attributed to contact with the **Visigoths**, the Germanic people who ruled Spain for centuries after Rome collapsed. Be careful how firmly you hold that last part: no surviving Gothic text actually preserves this word, so the Visigothic route is a **plausible traditional account**, not a documented one. What *is* well attested is the parallel case next door — **French** took the very same Germanic word (*blanc*) from a **different** Germanic people, the **Franks**. Two Romance sisters, the same borrowed word for white, two separate borrowings.

Why would a borrowed word beat Latin’s own? Because **blank* was not a pale word: it meant **bright, gleaming**. Colour terms lose out to vivid ones all the time — English’s own *bright* is doing the same job in “bright white.”

Why it’s said this way

Latin’s white did not vanish. It stopped being the **everyday** word and survived in corners:

word	meaning	the white inside
alba	dawn	the sky going <i>white</i>
<i>albo</i> (rare, poetic)	white, pale	a fossil, mostly literary now
<i>album</i> (Eng. <i>album</i>)	album	a <i>blank white</i> tablet
<i>albino</i>	albino	white-skinned

That is the normal fate of a displaced word: not death, but retreat into technical and poetic corners. *El alba* is still every Spanish speaker’s word for dawn.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the pairing — “negro from Latin, blanco from Germanic”
- “el alba” — dawn — and hear the old Latin white inside it
- “blanco” then French “blanc” — the same loan, twice over

Before you move on

Where does **blanco** come from, and what did it mean? (**Germanic** ***blank**, “shining” — traditionally linked to the Visigoths, though not directly attested.) Which other language borrowed the same word, from whom? (**French** *blanc*, from the **Franks**.) Where did Latin’s *albus* end up? (In **alba** “dawn,” *album*, *albino* — no longer the everyday colour word.)

139.3 rojo — the same family as *red*, by a different branch

So far the sorting has been simple: *negro* inherited, *blanco* borrowed. **Rojo** needs a third box — inherited, yes, but not from the word you would guess.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

rojo (“red”) ← Latin **russus**, an everyday, expressive Latin word for red. That is a **different specific Latin word** from the one behind French *rouge* (← **rubeus**). Latin had several reds and the daughter languages did not all pick the same one.

Both *russus* and *rubeus*, though, descend from the very same ancient root: PIE *h₁rewdʰ-* — which is also the root of English **red**, **rust**, **ruddy**, and of Latin *ruber* itself (English **rubric**, once written in red ink).

So *rojo*, *rouge* and *red* are **cousins**, not copies: three descendants of one very old family, arriving by three different branches. Nobody borrowed this one from anybody.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “rojo”
- the cousins — “rojo · rouge · red”, three branches, one root
- the three so far — “negro inherited, blanco borrowed, rojo cousin”

Before you move on

Is **rojo** from the same Latin word as French *rouge*? (**No** — *rojo* ← *russus*, *rouge* ← *rubeus*.) Are they related at all? (**Yes** — cousins, via the shared PIE root *h₁rewd^h*-, which also gives English **red**.)
Next: the one colour in this chapter that came from outside Europe entirely.

139.4 azul — a stone from Afghanistan, in your everyday vocabulary

Three colours in, three different histories: inherited, borrowed from a neighbour, inherited by a different branch. The fourth comes from outside the Indo-European family altogether.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

azul (“blue”) ← Arabic لازورد (*lāzaward*), “**lapis lazuli**” — the deep blue stone, mined for centuries in what is now Afghanistan and ground into the most expensive pigment in the medieval world. Spanish picked the word up during the centuries of Arabic-speaking rule in Iberia (**al-Andalus**). English has the same source at one more remove, in **azure**, and the stone keeps its own name: **lazuli**.

So Spanish’s word for blue is, underneath, the name of a **rock** — which is common for blue. Blue is the last basic colour term most languages acquire, and when they do, they usually name it after the thing that was reliably that colour.

Why it’s said this way

Here is the contrast worth keeping. **French** has *azur* too — but only as a **secondary, poetic** word (the sky’s blue, the *Côte d’Azur*); its everyday blue is the Germanic loan *bleu*. In **Spanish** it is the reverse: **azul is the plain, unremarkable, everyday word**, with no Germanic rival competing for the job at all.

Same borrowed word, two languages, opposite outcomes — a reminder that where a word came from tells you nothing about how ordinary it now feels.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all four — “negro, blanco, rojo, azul”
- sort them — “negro inherited, blanco Germanic, rojo cousin of red, azul Arabic”
- “azul” then English “azure” — the same lapis lazuli

Before you move on

Name the four colours and sort them by origin. (*Negro* — Latin *niger*; *blanco* — Germanic **blank*; *rojo* — Latin *russus*, cousin of *red*; *azul* — Arabic *lāzaward*.) What did *lāzaward* actually name? (**Lapis lazuli**, the stone.) How does *azul*’s role differ from French *azur*’s? (**Azul is Spanish’s everyday blue**; French’s *azur* is only poetic, with *bleu* doing the daily work.)

Chapter 140

Parents and Siblings

Modes: 🗣️ voice (3) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name my parents and my siblings in Spanish and explain why hermano is not built on Latin’s word for brother.

Give el padre, la madre, el hermano and la hermana, trace hermano back through germānus to germen, the seed, rather than to frāter, and separate its silent h from the once-spoken h of hijo and hacer.

140.1 el padre, la madre — among the oldest words there are

“Father” and “mother” are some of the **oldest reconstructible words in human language** — older than Latin, older than Rome. Spanish kept them close to the Latin original, and they are secretly the *same words* as English **father** and **mother**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **el padre** (“father”) ← Latin **pater** ← PIE *ph₂tēr*.
- **la madre** (“mother”) ← Latin **māter** ← PIE *méh₂tēr*.

Why it’s said this way

Padre and English *father* both descend independently from the **same** PIE word — they’re siblings, not parent and child. Latin (and Spanish

after it) kept the original *p* and *t* largely intact; the Germanic branch that gave English took a separate road through **Grimm’s Law**, which shifted the **inherited** **p** → **f** and **t** → **th**:

PIE ancestor	Latin → Spanish	Germanic → English
<i>ph₂t₂tēr</i>	<i>pater</i> → padre	father
<i>méh₂tēr</i>	<i>māter</i> → madre	mother

So *padre* and *father* aren’t lookalikes borrowed late, and neither one comes *from* the other — they’re the **same inherited PIE word**, one branch keeping the *p*, the other shifting it to *f*. The Latin root also gives Spanish and English their “of a parent” adjectives: **paternal**, **paternidad**, **patrón** and **maternal**, **maternidad**. (A further Latin-only offshoot, *māter* → *māteria*, “the stuff a tree-mother produces,” gives Spanish *materia* and, separately, *matriz* — “womb” — via Latin *mātrix*.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “el padre, la madre”
- the sound-law — “padre keeps p; father shifts to f — same word”
- “padre → paternal; madre → maternal”

Before you move on

Give “father” and “mother” with their articles. (**el padre, la madre**.) Does *padre* turn into English *father* directly? (**No** — both descend independently from the same PIE word; the Germanic branch shifted *p* → *f* and *t* → *th* via **Grimm’s Law**, while Latin/Spanish kept the original sounds.) Name an English cousin of each. (*padre* → paternal; *madre* → maternal.)

140.2 el hermano, la hermana — brother and sister, from a different word entirely

You might expect Spanish “brother” to come from Latin **frāter**, the way French’s *frère* does. It does not. Spanish’s siblings took a completely different word — one about **seeds**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Classical Latin could say **frāter germānus**, literally “a brother **of the same stock/blood**” — distinguishing a *full* brother from a half-brother, or from a “brother” in some looser sense.

Then something ordinary and strange happened: in everyday Latin the **adjective** took over the whole job and the **noun quietly dropped out**. (English does this all the time — a *mobile phone* becomes a *mobile*, a *cellular telephone* becomes a *cell*.) What survived is the modifier:

- **el hermano** (“brother”) ← Latin **germānus**.
- **la hermana** (“sister”) ← Latin **germāna**.

So Spanish’s everyday word for brother is, grammatically, a leftover adjective.

Why it’s said this way

Germānus traces back to **germen**, “**sprout, bud, seed**” — the same root that gives English **germ**, **germinate**, and **germane** (originally “closely related,” from the same seed, before it loosened into just “relevant”).

So calling someone your *hermano* is, at the etymological root, calling them “**sprung from the same seed**.” (And no, this has nothing to do with *Germany* — that name is a separate, unrelated puzzle.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “el hermano, la hermana” — brother, sister

- the root chain — “germen, seed” → “germānus, of the same seed” → “hermano”
- “hermano” then English “germinate, germane”

Before you move on

Does Spanish *hermano* come from Latin *frāter*? (**No** — from **germānus**, “of the same stock/seed,” an adjective that swallowed the noun *frāter* it used to modify.) What does its root *germen* mean, and what English words share it? (**Seed, sprout** — *germ, germinate, germane*.) Next: the silent *h* on the front, which is not the *h* you think it is.

140.3 the *h* in hermano — a letter that was never spoken

Germānus starts with a **g**. *Hermano* starts with an **h**. Something has to explain that — and the obvious explanation is the wrong one.

What to know first

- el hermano, la hermana — the words and the *germen* root.

Why it’s said this way

You may already know that Spanish often turns a Latin initial **f** into a silent **h** — *filius* → **hijo** (“son”), *facere* → **hacer** (“to do”). **Hermano is not that**, and the difference is worth getting right.

Germānus is stressed on its **third** syllable (*ger-MĀ-nus*), which leaves the opening *ger-* **unstressed**. Latin’s **g** before a front vowel had already softened toward a *y*-like sound in everyday speech — and in that unstressed position it simply **fell away entirely**, giving Old Spanish *ermano*, with **no *h* at all**. That is the form actually recorded centuries ago.

The **h** you see today was added **later, in spelling only**, to mark the word’s old link to Latin *g*-. Compare:

word	what happened to the sound	was the <i>h</i> ever spoken?
hijo, hacer	Latin <i>f-</i> → a real breathy <i>h</i>	yes , for centuries
hermano	Latin <i>g-</i> simply dropped	no , never
Same silent letter today; two completely different backstories, only one of which involves a sound at all.		

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*germānus*” then “*ermano*” then “*hermano*” — the three stages
- the honest distinction — *hijo/hacer*’s *h* was once truly spoken; *hermano*’s *h* never was

Before you move on

Is *hermano*’s *h* the same kind of change as *hijo*’s or *hacer*’s? (**No.**) What actually happened to *germānus*’s opening? (Its **g** dropped away in an **unstressed** syllable, giving Old Spanish *ermano*.) So where did the *h* come from? (**Spelling** — added later to mark the Latin link, never pronounced.)

Chapter 141

Head and Hand

Modes: 🗣️ voice (2) 🗋️ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

***By the end of this chapter:** I can name the head and the hand in Spanish and get la mano's gender right despite its -o ending.*

Say la cabeza and la mano, use me duele la mano, and explain the feminine article on a word that ends in -o by way of Latin's fourth declension.

141.1 la cabeza — “the head”

Spanish's word for “head” is the boring, expected one — and that's exactly what makes it interesting, once you see what French did instead.

You'll want to know: la cabeza

la cabeza — the head. Feminine, so **la**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin's word for “head” was **caput**. Spanish's *cabeza* comes straight from it (by way of Vulgar Latin *capitia*), and *caput* shows up all over English too:

English	literally
captain	the “head” of a ship/unit
capital	the “head” city, or “head” sum of money
decapitate	to remove the head
capitulate	to arrange under “headings” — hence, to yield

Why it’s said this way

French had the exact same Latin word available — and **dropped it**. French *tête* (“head”) comes instead from **testa**, Latin for an **earthenware pot**: Roman soldiers joked about the skull the way English speakers say “noggin” (a small mug), and in Gaul that joke eventually **replaced** the real word entirely. Spanish never made that swap — *cabeza* is *caput*, plain and simple, still standing after two thousand years.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “la cabeza” — the head
- “me duele la cabeza” — “my head hurts”
- the English family — “captain, capital, decapitate”
- the contrast — Spanish kept *caput*; French swapped it for a pot joke

Before you move on

Say “the head.” (*La cabeza* — feminine.) What Latin word is it from? (**Caput**.) Give an English word from the same root. (**Captain, capital, decapitate**...) What did French do instead? (**Replaced caput with testa, “pot”** — soldiers’ slang for the skull that took over completely.)

141.2 la mano — “the hand”

You’ve been trusting “-o words are masculine, -a words are feminine” since your first chapters. Here’s the word that breaks it — and everyone learning Spanish has to memorize this one by name.

Grammar Lens: la mano and its gender

la mano — the hand. **Feminine**, despite ending in **-o**.

Almost every Spanish noun ending in *-o* is masculine (*el libro*, *el gato*...). *Mano* is the single most common exception, and it’s actually **doubly** irregular. Latin **manus** (“hand”) belonged to the **4th declension** — a group of *-us* nouns that were mostly **masculine** (*fructus* “fruit,” *exercitus* “army,” *senātus* “senate”). *Manus* was one of a small handful of exceptions that were **feminine** instead (alongside *domus* “house” and *anus* “old woman”). So *mano* broke the rule **twice over**: an exception within Latin’s own mostly-masculine 4th declension, and then an exception again against Spanish’s usual *-o* = masculine pattern.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Mano comes from Latin **manus**, “hand” — and that root is buried inside an enormous number of English words:

English	literally
manual	done by hand
manufacture	made by hand (<i>manus</i> + <i>facere</i> , “to make”)
manuscript	written by hand (<i>manus</i> + <i>scribere</i>)
maintain	hold in the hand (<i>manū tenere</i>)
manage	to handle

Manufacture is worth pausing on: it literally means “made by hand” — and today it names precisely the opposite.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “la mano” — feminine, despite the -o
- “me duele la mano” — “my hand hurts”
- the family — “manual, manufacture, maintain — all a hand”
- the irony — “manufacture = made by hand”

Before you move on

Say “the hand,” and name its gender. (*La mano* — **feminine**, despite ending in -o.) Why is *mano* feminine when most -o words aren’t? (**It’s doubly irregular** — Latin’s 4th declension, where *manus* belongs, was mostly **masculine**; *manus* was one of a few feminine exceptions there, and then an exception again against Spanish’s usual -o=male rule.) Give an English word built on *manus*. (**Manual, manufacture, manuscript, maintain, manage.**)

Chapter 142

The Seasons

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the four seasons in Spanish and explain how verano moved from spring to summer.

Run primavera, verano, otoño, invierno, unpack primavera as prīma vēra, and show verano growing out of that same vēr before its meaning slid across to summer.

142.1 la primavera, el verano, el otoño, el invierno — three plain, one surprising

Three of Spanish’s four seasons are exactly what you’d expect from Latin. The fourth hides a genuine surprise: its **meaning itself** drifted from one season to another.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **la primavera** (“spring”) ← Latin *prīma vēra*, literally “**first spring**” (*vēr*, “spring,” + *prīma*, “first”). Italian still says the identical phrase, *primavera*, unchanged. (Old French once said *primevère* too, before switching to *printemps*.)
- **el otoño** (“autumn”) ← Latin *autumnus* — the same root behind French *automne* and English *autumn* itself.
- **el invierno** (“winter”) ← Latin *hībernum* (*tempus*), “the **wintry** [season]” — the same root as French *hiver* and English *hibernate*, “to spend the winter.”

Why it's said this way

You might expect *verano* (“summer”) to come from Latin **aestas**, “heat” — the way French *été* does. It doesn’t. The standard account (per Spanish etymological dictionaries) traces **verano** to Latin **vērānum** (*tempus*), “**of spring**” — built on the very same *vēr*, “spring,” behind *primavera*.

So how did a word meaning “spring-ish” end up naming **summer**? The honest answer is a **shift in meaning over time**, not a sound change — though the exact story is murkier than a tidy one-line explanation. The traditional, simplified account says that as *primavera* (“first spring”) rose to become the standard word for spring, *verano*’s meaning drifted forward into the season right after, summer; the fuller picture likely also involves Vulgar Latin agricultural usage (a “vernal” grazing or working period that stretched from late spring into early summer), so the drift may not be purely a case of one word simply vacating a job for the other. Either way, two Spanish words both rooted in *vēr*, “spring,” ended up naming two different seasons.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “primavera, verano, otoño, invierno” — the four seasons
- “primavera = prima vera, first spring”
- the surprise — “verano **ALSO** comes from *vēr*, ‘spring’ — but its meaning moved to summer”
- “invierno ~ hibernate”

Before you move on

What does **primavera** literally mean? (“**First spring**” — *prīma vēra*.) Does **verano** come from Latin *aestas*, like French *été*? (**No** — from *vērānum*, “of spring,” the same *vēr* root as *primavera*; its meaning **shifted** toward summer over time — traditionally linked to *primavera* taking over the job of naming spring, though the fuller history is murkier than that alone.) What English word is **invierno** the cousin of? (**Hibernate**.)

Chapter 143

Water, Wine, and Bread

Modes: 🗣️ voice (3) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name water, wine and bread in Spanish and say why a *compañero* is someone who shares bread with me.

Say el agua, el vino and el pan, then open compañero into com- plus pānis and follow the root out to panadería and panadero.

143.1 el agua — water, and an article that is not what it looks like

One of the least changed words in Spanish, carrying one of its most misunderstood rules. The “masculine” article on this feminine noun is not a mistake and not an exception to gender.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

agua (“water”) ← Latin **aqua** — almost unchanged in two thousand years. Compare French, where the *very same word* was worn all the way down to a bare “**eau**,” just the sound “oh.” Same starting point, same span of time, wildly different amounts of erosion: how fast a language wears its words down is not fixed.

English kept the whole Latin word too, but as a **learned borrowing** rather than an inherited everyday one: **aquatic**, **aquarium**, **aqueduct**, **aqualung**.

Grammar Lens: el agua's article and gender

Notice: **el agua**, not *la agua* — yet *agua* is genuinely **feminine**. You can prove it: *el agua fría*, “the cold water,” keeps the feminine adjective ending, and the plural is *las aguas*, never *los aguas*.

The rule is **phonological**, not grammatical. Spanish swaps *la* for *el* directly before a **singular** feminine noun beginning with a **stressed a-sound**, to avoid running two identical vowels together (*la agua*). It is the same instinct that makes English pick “an apple” over “a apple.”

	singular	plural
the water	el agua	las aguas
the eagle	el águila	las águilas
the axe	el hacha	las hachas

Only the article changes. The noun's gender never moves.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “el agua” — water, feminine, but takes *el*
- the proof — “el agua fría” and “las aguas”
- the contrast — “agua” barely changed; French's “eau” wore all the way down

Before you move on

Is **agua** masculine or feminine? (**Feminine** — *el* replaces *la* only because *agua* begins with a **stressed a**.) How would you prove it? (*El agua fría*; *las aguas*.) How does Spanish's erosion of *agua* compare with French's? (**Much less** — Spanish kept nearly the whole word; French wore it to “eau.”)

143.2 el vino — one word, three separate arrivals in English

The second drink is grammatically boring — plain masculine, plain *el vino*, no stressed-*a* trick. Its history makes up for that.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

vino (“wine”) ← Latin **vīnum** — which held its shape well, as French’s *vin* did too.

English shares the very same root by **more than one road**, and the roads are worth separating, because they show three different ways a word can travel:

English word	how it got there
wine	<i>vīnum</i> borrowed directly into old Germanic, very early
vine, vinegar	borrowed centuries later, secondhand via French (<i>vin</i> + <i>aigre</i> , “sour wine”)
vineyard	not borrowed at all — English built it at home from the already-borrowed <i>wine</i> plus native <i>yard</i>

So *wine* and *vine* are the same Latin word twice, arriving a thousand years apart by different routes, and *vineyard* is a homemade compound made out of the first arrival. One Latin noun; three English histories.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “el agua, el vino” — the two drinks
- “vino” then English “wine, vine, vinegar” — one root, three roads

Before you move on

What Latin word gives *vino*? (**Vīnum**.) Name three English cousins and say how each arrived. (**Wine** — direct, early, into Germanic; **vine/vinegar** — later, via French; **vineyard** — built at home from *wine* plus *yard*.) And why is it *el agua* but *las aguas*? (The *el* is a sound rule for a stressed *a*, singular only.)

143.3 el pan — bread, and the friend who shares it

Spanish’s word for bread hides the same lovely word-story you’d find in English’s “companion” — except Spanish kept **both halves**, the bread and the friendship.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el pan (“bread”) ← Latin **pānis**. Masculine: *el pan*.

Why it’s said this way

The Latin root **pān-** (“bread”) gives Spanish its own word for a close friend:

- **compañero / compañera** (“companion, friend, partner”) ← *com-* (“with”) + *pānis* — literally “**one you share bread with**.” Spanish built this word from the very same recipe as English **companion** and **company** (which come from the identical Latin pieces) — but where English only kept the *friendship* sense, Spanish still visibly uses the **same root** for the actual **bread** (*pan*) too.
- **panadería** (“bakery”) and **panadero** (“baker”) — both transparently built on *pan*.

So *pan* and *compañero* are the same word-family doing double duty in Spanish: name the food, and name the friend you’d share it with.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “el pan” — bread
- “compañero” — literally, one you share bread with
- “panadería, panadero” — bakery, baker

Before you move on

Give “bread” with its article. (**El pan.**) What does *compañero* literally mean, and what’s it built from? (“**One you share bread with**” — *com-* + *pānis*.) Does English keep this same double meaning? (**No** — English’s *companion* only kept the friendship sense; Spanish still uses the same root for the actual bread, *pan*, too.)

Chapter 144

La Bebo — The Pronoun Tells the Truth

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can use an object pronoun to reveal a gender the article hides.

Complete ES-C55-la-bebo: say *la bebo* for *el agua* and explain why the pronoun can report a gender the article hides.

144.1 la bebo — the pronoun tells the truth

Which article does *agua* take? (*El*.) And what gender is *agua* really? (**Feminine** — the article is a sound rule, not a gender.)

Grammar Lens: a third witness

When you met *el agua* you were given two proofs that the word is feminine underneath: the adjective it takes and the plural it forms. Here is a third, and it costs you nothing new.

Bebo el agua. — I drink the water. ***La bebo.*** — I drink it.

Not *lo bebo*. ***La bebo.***

The article had to say *el* for a reason that has nothing to do with gender — two *a* sounds colliding. The pronoun is under no such pressure. Nothing sits in front of it, no vowels collide, so it reports the gender straight.

This is worth more than one word. **When an article looks**

suspicious, the object pronoun is a witness that cannot be leaned on. You now have a test you can run yourself, rather than a list to trust.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “el agua” then “la bebo” — until the clash stops feeling like an error
- “lo bebo” then “la bebo”, and notice which one is about water

Before you move on

El agua — which pronoun replaces it? (**La**.) And why does that not contradict the article? (The article changed for **sound**, not gender.)

Chapter 145

The Months

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the twelve months in Spanish and explain why *diciembre* carries the Latin word for ten.

Recite enero through diciembre, tie marzo back to martes through Mars, and place septiembre and diciembre against the Roman year that started in March.

145.1 los meses — the calendar's gods and Caesars

Spanish's twelve months are a **procession of Roman gods and emperors**, barely changed from Latin. Two things you already know pay off immediately: *marzo* is the war-god you met in *martes*, and *septiembre–diciembre* are the Latin numbers 7–10 from the counting chapters.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish	← Latin	who / what
enero	<i>Iānuārius</i>	Janus , the two-faced god of doors & beginnings
febrero	<i>Februārius</i>	<i>Februa</i> , the Roman purification festival
marzo	<i>Martius</i>	Mars , the war-god — <i>the same Mars as martes</i> (Tuesday)! perhaps <i>aperire</i> , “to open” (buds opening)
abril	<i>Aprīlis</i>	Maia , goddess of growth
mayo	<i>Māius</i>	Juno , queen of the gods
junio	<i>Iūnius</i>	originally <i>Quīntilis</i> , “the 5th [month]” — renamed for Julius Caesar after his death
julio	<i>Iūlius</i>	originally <i>Sextilis</i> , “the 6th [month]” — renamed for the emperor Augustus
agosto	<i>Augustus</i>	“ 7th ” (<i>septem</i>)
septiembre	<i>september</i>	“ 8th ” (<i>octō</i>)
octubre	<i>octōber</i>	“ 9th ” (<i>novem</i>)
noviembre	<i>november</i>	“ 10th ” (<i>decem</i>)
diciembre	<i>december</i>	

Two payoffs land at once:

- **marzo = Mars = martes.** The month and the weekday honor the *same* war-god — *Martius* (his month) and *Martis diēs* (his day). Spot one, you know the other.
- **The 7–10 months.** *Septiembre* through *diciembre* still carry *septem*, *octō*, *novem*, *decem* — because the old Roman year

originally began in **March**, with September genuinely the 7th month. Centuries before Caesar, two new months (Januarius, Februarius) were added at the front to cover the winter, which pushed every later month's number out of step with its name — September became the 9th month while still being *named* “7th.” **Julius** and **Augustus** had nothing to do with that shift: they simply got two already-existing months — *Quintilis* and *Sextilis*, literally “5th” and “6th” — **renamed** in their honor after the fact. The names stuck; the months themselves were never new.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the twelve — “enero, febrero, marzo, abril, mayo, junio, julio, agosto, septiembre, octubre, noviembre, diciembre”
- the tie-back — “marzo / martes — both Mars, the war-god”
- “septiembre = 7, diciembre = 10” — the old March-start year

Before you move on

Which god links *marzo* and *martes*? (**Mars**, the war-god — his month and his day.) Why is *diciembre* Latin for “ten”? (**The Roman year began in March**, and adding January/February at the front later pushed every month's number out of step with its name.) Did Julius Caesar and Augustus **add** new months to the calendar? (**No** — *julio* and *agosto* were already-existing months, *Quintilis* and *Sextilis* (“5th”/“6th”), simply **renamed** in their honor.)

Chapter 146

Noon and Midnight

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say that it is noon or midnight in Spanish and break both words into their two living halves.

Say es mediodía and es medianoche, split each into medio/media plus día/noche, and set them against French’s worn-down midi and minuit.

146.1 mediodía, medianoche — noon and midnight, spelled out in full

Two hours that don’t get a number — they get a name. And Spanish keeps that name far more transparent than its French cousin does.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish	← Latin	literally
mediodía	<i>medius diēs</i>	“ mid-day ” (<i>medio</i> “middle” + <i>día</i> “day”)
medianoche	<i>media nox</i>	“ mid-night ” (<i>media</i> “middle” + <i>noche</i> “night”)

Both halves are **fully alive, ordinary Spanish words on their own: medio/media** (“middle” — cousin of English *medium*, *mid*,

middle) and **día/noche** (“day/night,” words you already know). Compare French, which took the same Latin phrase down a bumpier road: *minuit*’s second half, **-nuit**, is still the plain, everyday French word for “night” — just as recognizable as Spanish’s *noche*. But *midi*’s second half, **-di**, wore down into an opaque fragment: the ordinary French word for “day” is *jour*, not *di* — that piece survives only as a fossil, tucked inside weekday names like *lundi* and *mardi*. So the erosion split unevenly: French kept “night” transparent and lost “day,” while Spanish kept both. They don’t need *horas* the way a normal Spanish time (*son las tres*) never does either — they simply stand in for the hour on their own:

Es mediodía. — “It is noon.” **Es medianoche.** — “It is midnight.”

(Fun aside: English **noon** comes from Latin *nōna hōra*, “the **ninth** hour” — originally mid-afternoon, it drifted earlier over the centuries to mean midday. Spanish kept the tidier, transparent “mid-day” instead.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “mediodía” (noon), “medianoche” (midnight)
- break them — “medio + día”, “media + noche” — both halves still ordinary words
- “Es mediodía. Es medianoche.” — they stand in for the hour
- the contrast — French kept “night” (*nuit*) but wore “day” down to a fossil (*-di*)

Before you move on

What do *mediodía* and *medianoche* literally mean, and from what Latin? (“Mid-day” ← *medius diēs*; “mid-night” ← *media nox*.) Are both halves still recognizable, ordinary Spanish words? (**Yes** — *medio/ media* “middle,” *día/noche* “day/night.”) Did French erode its phrase evenly? (**No** — French’s *-nuit* stayed just as transparent

as Spanish's *noche*, but its *-di* wore down to an opaque fossil, since the everyday French word for "day" is actually *jour*.) How do you say "it is noon"? (*Es mediodía*.)

Chapter 147

Telling Time

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can tell the time in Spanish and choose correctly between *es la una* and *son las dos*.

Say es la una, son las dos, son las diez, and explain why one o'clock takes a singular verb while every other hour takes a plural one.

147.1 la hora — Spanish's barely-changed Latin hour

You've now seen this Latin word take three different paths: French wore it down to *heure*, German borrowed it centuries later as *Uhr*. Spanish's path is the simplest of all — it barely changed.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hora ← Latin **hōra** ← Greek **hōrā**, “a season, a time of day” (the Greek goddesses of the seasons were the *Hōrai*). Spanish kept the word almost exactly as Latin had it — just a silent **h** in spelling, a fossil of a Latin *h* that was already weak and barely pronounced by the time Spanish inherited the word (the same non-story as French *heure* or English *hour*'s silent *h*). Be careful not to confuse this with *hijo* and *hacer*'s silent *h* — those come from a completely different, later Spanish sound change (Latin **f** → Old Spanish aspirated *h* → eventual silence), not from an already-weak Latin *h* the way *hora*'s is.

Two different roads to the same “silent letter” result. Compare its cousins: French wore *hōra* down further to *heure*; German didn’t inherit the word at all, but borrowed it later as *Uhr*; English took the same Latin *hōra* and made *hour*.

language	word	what happened
Spanish	hora	inherited almost unchanged, just a silent <i>h</i>
French	<i>heure</i>	inherited, but worn down further
German	<i>Uhr</i>	not inherited — borrowed later, separately
English	<i>hour</i>	inherited via French, silent <i>h</i>

Grammar Lens: Son las and telling time

Spanish uses **ser** (“to be”) plus the **feminine plural article** (agreeing with the unspoken *horas*) to tell time — and famously switches number for “one”:

Es la una. — “It is one o’clock.” (singular — *la una*, “the one”) **Son las dos.** — “It is two o’clock.” (plural — *las dos*, “the two”) **Son las diez.** — “It is ten o’clock.”

Literally “**it is the one**” / “**they are the two/ten**” — the hour count itself is implied by the article and number, without needing to say *hora(s)* at all in everyday speech (unlike French’s *il est deux heures*, which spells out “hours” every time).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hora” — silent h, a fossil of an already-weak Latin h
- “Es la una. Son las dos. Son las diez.”
- “hora / heure / hour” — one Latin root, three different fates

Before you move on

What Latin (and Greek) word is *hora* from? (*hōra* ← Greek *hōrā*.)
How did Spanish's path differ from French's and German's?
(**Spanish** inherited it almost unchanged; **French** wore it down further to *heure*; **German** didn't inherit it at all and borrowed *Uhr* separately, much later.) How do you say "it is one o'clock" vs. "it is two o'clock"? (*Es la una* — singular; *Son las dos* — plural.)

Chapter 148

The Weather

Modes: 🗣️ voice (3) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can talk about the weather in Spanish and know why llueve refuses to join hace.

Ask about el tiempo, answer hace calor, hace frío, hace sol, then switch to llueve — a verb of its own, whose ll- is the same sound change that gave llamar.

148.1 el tiempo — one word doing two jobs

Ask a Spanish speaker *¿qué tiempo hace?* and you are literally asking “**what time does it make?**” — because *tiempo* does not split “time” from “weather” the way English does.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el tiempo = both “**time**” and “**weather**” — from Latin **tempus**, which already carried this same double sense. Nothing was merged in Spanish; the two meanings simply arrived together and stayed. English inherited the word too, through borrowing, but kept **only the time half: temporal, contemporary, tempo, temporary**. So the double meaning is not a Spanish oddity — it is the older state of affairs, and English is the one that narrowed.

How does a Spanish speaker know which is meant? **Context alone**, and it is never ambiguous in practice: *no tengo tiempo* is “I have no time,” *¿qué tiempo hace?* is “what’s the weather like?”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “el tiempo” — time, or weather, depending on context
- “¿qué tiempo hace?” — what’s the weather like?
- “tiempo” then English “tempo, temporal” — the *tempus* family

Before you move on

What two things does **el tiempo** mean? (**Time** and **weather**.) Which Latin word gives it, and did it already mean both? (**Tempus** — yes, both.) Which language narrowed the meaning, Spanish or English? (**English** — it kept only “time.”) Next: how to actually answer *¿qué tiempo hace?*

148.2 hace calor, hace frío, hace sol — the weather Spanish *makes*

You can ask *¿qué tiempo hace?* Now answer it. Three of Spanish’s commonest weather answers all take the same verb you already know — *hacer*, “to make.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **calor** ← Latin **calor**, “heat, warmth” → English **calorie**, **caloric**, **cauldron**.
- **frío** ← Latin **frigidus**, “cold” (the middle syllable syncopated away) → English **frigid**, **refrigerate**.
- **sol** ← Latin **sol**, “sun,” unchanged → English **solar**, **solstice**, **parasol**.

Here is the part worth noticing: all three are **nouns**, not adjectives. *Calor* is “heat,” not “hot.” That is exactly why Spanish reaches for **hacer**: you cannot *be* a noun, but the world can **make** one.

hace calor — “it’s hot,” literally “**it makes heat**” **hace frío** — “it’s cold,” literally “**it makes cold**” **hace sol** — “it’s sunny,” literally “**it makes sun**”

French does the same thing with the same logic (*il fait chaud*); English is the outlier, forcing weather into “it **is** hot” with an adjective.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hace calor. hace frío. hace sol.”
- the literal reading — “it makes heat, it makes cold, it makes sun”
- “calor” then English “calorie”; “frío” then “refrigerate”

Before you move on

Say “it’s hot,” “it’s cold,” “it’s sunny.” (*Hace calor, hace frío, hace sol.*) Why does Spanish use *hacer* rather than a “to be” verb? (Because *calor*, *frío* and *sol* are **nouns** — the weather **makes** heat, it does not *be* hot.) Give an English cousin of *frío*. (**Frigid**, **refrigerate**.)

148.3 llueve — the one weather word that will not join *hacer*

Hace calor, hace frío, hace sol — three answers, one pattern. Now try rain, and the pattern breaks. Rain does not get made in Spanish; rain has a verb of its own.

Grammar Lens: rain brings its own verb

llueve = “it’s raining.” Not *hace lluvia*, not “it makes rain” — just **llueve**, a single word that is a complete sentence.

It comes from **llover**, “to rain,” and *llover* is **impersonal**: it has no subject at all, not even a “it” you could point to. Compare the two shapes side by side:

pattern	example	what carries the weather
hacer + noun	<i>hace calor</i>	the noun (<i>calor</i> , heat)
dedicated verb	<i>llueve</i>	the verb itself
English does exactly the same split, which makes it easy to feel: you say “it is hot” with an adjective, but “it rains ” with a verb built for the job. Spanish just draws the line in the same place.		

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

llover ← Latin **pluere**, “to rain.” Recognise that **pl-** → **ll-** shift? It is the **same regular sound change** that gave you **llamar** (← *clamāre*), **llave** (← *clāvem*, “key”) and **llama** (← *flamma*, “flame”). Latin’s *cl-*, *fl-* and *pl-* clusters all became Spanish *ll-*.

So *llueve* is not an exception you have to memorise twice: it is a predictable descendant of *pluere* (the same root English keeps in **pluvial** and the **pluviometer**, a rain gauge), and it is the one weather word with enough of its own life to refuse the *hacer* frame.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “¿qué tiempo hace?” then “hace calor. hace frío. hace sol.”
- “llueve” — one word, a whole sentence, no *hacer*
- the family — “llamar, llave, llama, llover” — four Latin clusters, one Spanish *ll-*

Before you move on

Which weather word does **not** use *hacer*, and why? (**Llueve** — rain has its own impersonal verb, *llover*.) What Latin word is *llover* from? (**Pluere**.) What sound change turned its *pl-* into *ll-*, and what other words show it? (Latin *cl-/fl-/pl-* → Spanish *ll-* — *llamar*, *llave*, *llama*.) And what does *el tiempo* mean? (**Time** and **weather**, from *tempus*.)

Chapter 149

Numbers Eleven to Twenty

Modes: ⇄ voice (4) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can count from eleven to twenty in Spanish and say where the fused Latin teens stop and the ten-and-X ones begin.

Run once to quince as fused Latin compounds, then dieciséis to diecinueve as a ten-and-X template, say why Latin's own subtractive 18 and 19 did not survive, and close on veinte.

149.1 once — quince: five words with a seam you can no longer see

Spanish counts past ten in **two completely different ways**, and the join between them is a real boundary in the language, not a place someone drew a line. Today: the first five, which you simply have to learn as words.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish	← Latin
once	<i>undecim</i> (“one-ten”)
doce	<i>duodecim</i> (“two-ten”)
trece	<i>tredecim</i> (“three-ten”)
catorce	<i>quattuordecim</i> (“four-ten”)
quince	<i>quindecim</i> (“five-ten”)

Every one of these *was* a compound — a number plus **-decim** (“ten,”

the same root as *diez*). But these five are the numbers people say most often, and heavy use wears words smooth. Centuries of everyday speech fused each pair into a single, **opaque** word: no Spanish speaker hears “one-ten” in *once* any more than an English speaker hears “two-ten” in *twelve*.

Listen for the ghost, though. The **-ce** ending on *doce*, *trece*, *catorce*, *quince* is all that survives of Latin’s *-decim*. It is the same “ten” you already say in **diez**, ground down to two letters.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “once, doce, trece, catorce, quince”
- just the endings — “-ce, -ce, -ce, -ce” — the worn-down *ten*

Before you move on

Count eleven to fifteen. (*Once, doce, trece, catorce, quince*.) What are these five, structurally? (**Fused Latin compounds** — number plus *-decim*, “ten.”) Which piece of each word is the old “ten”? (The **-ce** ending — *diez* worn down.) Next: the numbers where the seam is still wide open.

149.2 dieciséis — diecinueve: where the seam reopens

You just learned five numbers whose insides had been ground smooth. Now say **fifteen** and then **sixteen** — *quince*, *dieciséis* — and hear the language change gear. From here you are not memorising words; you are following a rule.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish

literally

dieciséis

diez y seis, “ten and six”

diecisiete

diez y siete, “ten and seven”

dieciocho

diez y ocho, “ten and eight”

diecinueve

diez y nueve, “ten and nine”

No fusion. You can hear **diez** plainly at the front of every one, and the number you already know sitting right behind it.

Grammar Lens: a formula, not a list

This is the structural difference that makes 15/16 a real boundary in Spanish rather than a convenient place to pause:

	11-15	16-19
how you get the word	remember it	build it
the “ten” inside	worn to <i>-ce</i>	still spelled <i>dieci-</i>
can you hear the parts?	no	yes

So *once* through *quince* are **vocabulary**, and *dieciséis* through *diecinueve* are **grammar**: one template, *dieci-* + *digit*, filled four times. Learn the template once and all four are already yours.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “dieciséis, diecisiete, dieciocho, diecinueve”
- the seam out loud — “diez y seis” then “dieciséis”
- the boundary — “quince” (remembered), “dieciséis” (built)

Before you move on

Count sixteen to nineteen. (*Dieciséis, diecisiete, dieciocho, diecinueve*.) Are these fused or transparent? (**Transparent** — plain “ten and X.”) Which of the two groups do you have to memorise, and which can you generate? (**Memorise 11-15; generate 16-19** from *dieci-* plus the digit.)

149.3 duodēvīgintī — the quirk Spanish threw away

Dieciocho and *diecinueve* look like the least interesting words in the chapter — just two more ten-and-X compounds. They are actually the most interesting, because of what Latin said instead.

What to know first

- *dieciséis* — *diecinueve* — the *dieci-* plus digit template.

Why it's said this way

You would expect *dieciocho* and *diecinueve* to carry on whatever Latin did for 18 and 19. Latin did something else entirely. Its everyday words for those two numbers were **subtractive** — counted *down* from twenty:

number	Latin	literally
18	duodēvīgintī	“two from twenty”
19	ūndēvīgintī	“one from twenty”

(You still meet this habit in English clock-talk: “ten **to** four.”)

Spanish did not inherit either word. It built *dieciocho* and *diecinueve* fresh, on exactly the same simple template as 16 and 17 — quietly **regularising away** an irregularity that existed in its own parent language. Languages are usually described as wearing down and getting messier; here is a clean case of one tidying up.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- Latin’s way — “two from twenty” — then Spanish’s — “dieciocho”
- “dieciocho, diecinueve” — addition, not subtraction

Before you move on

How did Latin say 18 and 19? (**Subtractively** — *duodēvīgintī*, “two from twenty,” and *ūndēvīgintī*, “one from twenty.”) Did Spanish keep that? (**No** — it built *dieciocho* and *diecinueve* on the

regular ten-and-X template.) So which language is the irregular one here? (**Latin** — Spanish simplified.)

149.4 veinte — the number the teens were counting toward

Latin's own 18 and 19 were counted *down from twenty*. So it is worth meeting twenty itself — the number the whole run has been aiming at.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

veinte (“twenty”) ← Latin **vīgintī**. It was worn down by ordinary sound change — the *g* softened away, the vowels shifted — but notice what did **not** happen to it: it was never **fused** out of two separate words the way *once* through *quince* were. *Vīgintī* was already a single word for a single round number, so there is no seam inside *veinte* to look for.

Three different histories, then, in one short chapter:

words	what happened
<i>once</i> - <i>quince</i>	two words fused into one
<i>dieciséis</i> - <i>diecinueve</i>	two words built into one, seam visible
<i>veinte</i>	one word, simply worn

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “once, doce, trece, catorce, quince” — the five fused Latins
- “dieciséis, diecisiete, dieciocho, diecinueve” — built, not fused
- “veinte” — twenty, worn but never fused

Before you move on

Count eleven to twenty. Where is the boundary between remembering and building, and why is it there? (**After** *quince* — 11-15 are fused Latin compounds, 16-19 are *dieci-* plus a digit.) Did Spanish inherit Latin's subtractive 18 and 19? (**No** — it regularised them.) Was *veinte* fused from two words? (**No** — Latin *vīgintī* was already one word; it was only worn down.)

Chapter 150

Dog and Cat

Modes: 🗣️ voice (2) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name a dog and a cat in Spanish and say which of the two words still has no agreed origin.

Say gato and perro, trace cattus back toward Egypt, then admit that perro — which pushed out the older can — has no settled etymology at all.

150.1 gato — the word that travelled with the animal

Some etymologies can be followed all the way home. This one runs from your mouth back to ancient Egypt, and every step of it is documented.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

gato (“cat”) ← Latin **cattus**. But *cattus* was **not** Classical Latin’s word for cat. That was **fēlēs**, which survives today only in the scientific name *Felis catus* and in English **feline**.

Cattus entered Latin **later**, arriving with the animal itself as domestic cats spread along **Roman trade routes** from where they were domesticated — **Egypt**, around 2000 BCE. The word is most likely **Afro-Asiatic** in origin (compare Nubian **kadis**, “cat”).

So word and creature travelled together, out of Africa into Europe, and the newcomer pushed *fēlēs* out almost everywhere: Spanish *gato*, Italian *gatto*, French *chat*, Old Irish *cat*, Welsh *cath*, English *cat*. When

a thing arrives from abroad, its name usually arrives with it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “el gato” — the cat
- the trail — “kadis, cattus, gato”
- the word it replaced — “fēlēs,” now only in “feline”

Before you move on

What was Classical Latin’s actual word for cat, and where does it survive? (**Fēlēs** — in *Felis catus* and English *feline*.) Where did *cattus* most likely come from? (An **Afro-Asiatic** word, travelling with the domesticated cat out of **Egypt**.) Next: the other animal in this chapter, whose history nobody can trace at all.

150.2 perro — the word nobody can explain

Gato could be traced all the way to Egypt. **Perro** is the opposite kind of word, and it is worth knowing that such words exist: completely ordinary, used a thousand times a day, and **nobody knows where it came from**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

perro (“dog”). Roll the *rr*: *PEH-rrro*.

The word Spanish **should** have inherited is **canis** — the same root as English **canine**, French *chien*, Italian *cane*. And it did survive, as the now-archaic Spanish **can** (still readable in old poetry and in *canino*). But at some point *perro* pushed *can* almost entirely out of everyday use — and *perro* itself has no agreed origin.

Why it’s said this way

Three serious proposals, none confirmed:

proposal	the case for it	the problem
onomatopoeia — a growl, or a shepherd's call " <i>perr, perr</i> "	matches how herding calls become names elsewhere	no early written evidence
pre-Roman Iberian substrate	the <i>-rro</i> ending is a known marker of likely pre-Latin words in Spanish	the substrate languages are barely recorded
Persian <i>persus</i> , a hunting-dog breed	such breeds did spread in the late Empire	the sound match is loose

Notice what makes this a **good** open question rather than a shrug: each proposal predicts different evidence, and the evidence needed simply has not survived. *Perro* remains one of Spanish's genuinely unsolved puzzles, and a useful reminder that "we don't know" is a real answer in etymology, not a gap in your notes.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "el perro, el gato" — dog and cat
- "can" — the archaic word *perro* replaced, from Latin *canis*
- the contrast — "gato, traced to Egypt; perro, unsolved"

Before you move on

What archaic Spanish word did *perro* replace, and what is its Latin source? (**Can**, from **canis** — the root of English *canine*.) Does *perro* have a confirmed etymology? (**No** — onomatopoeic, pre-Latin substrate and Persian proposals all remain unconfirmed.) And *gato*'s origin, by contrast? (**Traceable** — Latin *cattus*, probably Afro-Asiatic, travelling out of Egypt.)

Chapter 151

Green and Yellow

Modes: 🗣️ voice (2) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name green and yellow in Spanish and explain why amarillo is built on the word for bitter.

Say verde and amarillo, tie verde to virēre, to flourish, and amarillo to amarellus, a little bitter — the same root as everyday amargo.

151.1 verde — the colour named after being alive

After *azul*'s long journey from Afghanistan, here is a colour that stayed exactly where it started. It is also the one that names a **process** rather than a thing.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

verde (“**green**”) ← Latin **viridis** (worn down through *viridis*), which comes from the verb **virēre**, “**to be green, to flourish, to be vigorous.**”

So the adjective is built on a **verb of thriving**. Latin did not name the colour of leaves; it named what leaves are *doing*, and let the colour follow. The same root gives *vigour* its neighbours in English: **verdant**, **verdure**, and the green-tinged **verdigris** (“green of Greece”).

One careful non-connection: **verde is not a cousin of English green**. *Green* comes from a completely separate **Germanic** root, tied to *grow* and *grass* — which, funnily enough, is the same idea arrived at independently. Two families, two words, one metaphor: green is the colour of things that are growing.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “verde” — green
- the root — “virēre, to flourish” → “verde”
- “verde” then English “verdant” — and *not* “green”

Before you move on

What Latin verb gives **verde**, and what does it mean? (**Virēre**, “to be green, to flourish.”) Is *verde* related to English *green*? (**No** — *green* is Germanic, from the same family as *grow* and *grass*; the two languages reached the same metaphor separately.) Next: a colour that is not named after a colour at all.

151.2 amarillo — the colour that started as a taste

Verde was exactly what you would expect from Latin. This one is not. Latin had three perfectly good words for yellow, and Spanish took none of them.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

amarillo (“**yellow**”) does **not** trace to *flāvus*, *gilvus* or *lūteus* — Latin’s actual yellow words. It comes from Late Latin **amarellus**, “**a little bitter**,” a diminutive of **amarus**, “**bitter**.”

A colour named after a **taste**. The bridge is medicine: yellow was the colour of **bile** and of **jaundice** (which Spanish still calls *ictericia*, but which folk speech long tied to bitterness), and of a great many bitter-tasting plants. A word meaning “somewhat bitter” came to mean “the yellowish look of a bitter thing,” then simply “yellowish,” and by Spanish’s Golden Age it had dropped the taste entirely and kept only the colour.

You can still check the family in a living word: **amargo** (“bitter”) is *amarillo*’s cousin, straight from the same *amarus*. Say them together and the shared *amar-* is right there.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “verde, amarillo” — green and yellow
- “amarillo, amargo” — hear the shared *amar-*
- the path — “a little bitter” → “yellowish” → “yellow”

Before you move on

Does **amarillo** come from a Latin word for yellow? (**No** — from *amarellus*, “a little bitter,” a diminutive of *amarus*.) What everyday Spanish word is its cousin? (**Amargo**, “bitter.”) And *verde*? (From **virēre**, “to flourish” — a colour named after being alive, as this one is named after a taste.)

Chapter 152

Synthesis — Saying Something About Your Own Life

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can describe things around me with the nouns and colours I hold, choosing un rather than el.

Fourteen chapters of nouns and colours, combined for the first time - and the article that makes it possible.

152.1 Synthesis — saying something about your own life

Nothing new in this chapter. Say the words for *dog* and for *black*.

What you've built

Something has been accumulating quietly for fourteen chapters and has never once been put to work.

You have six colours. Parents and brothers and sisters. A head and a hand. Water, wine and bread. The seasons, the months, the hours. Hot weather and cold. Numbers to twenty. A dog and a cat.

That is not a vocabulary list any more. It is **enough to describe the room you are sitting in**, and this chapter is the first that asks you to.

Grammar Lens: the word that made this possible

Notice which article you need here, because it is not the one you have used most.

el perro — *the* dog. A particular one. The one we were talking about. **un perro** — *a* dog. Any dog. One you are mentioning for the first time.

Describing your own life means introducing things your listener does not know about yet — and that is exactly the job **un** does. Almost every sentence below needs it.

The exchange

— ¿**Tienes un perro**? — Sí, **tengo un perro negro**. ¿Y tú?
— **Tengo un gato blanco**.

Every word in those three lines is one you built yourself, across fourteen chapters that never asked you to combine them. Nothing here is new. What is new is that it is a **conversation** rather than a list.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the exchange above, both parts
- it again about a real animal you know, with a real colour

Twice through: Until you are describing rather than translating.

Before you move on

Which article introduces something your listener does not yet know about? (**Un**.) And which points at something you have both already mentioned? (**El**.) Say one true sentence about an animal, with its colour.

Chapter 153

Pensar — Thinking Is Weighing

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I think, and break pensar’s stem the way a stem-changer requires.

Run pensar through the $e \rightarrow ie$ boot, and find the scales still inside pensive and peso.

153.1 pensar — “to think”, and it started out meaning “to weigh”

You can already run an *-ar* verb: *hablo, hablas, habla*. Here is one that takes those same endings and then cracks its stem in the middle, the way *querer* did.

Sounds you’ll need

- diphthong-**ie** — under stress the *e* breaks open: **pienso** = *PYEN-so*.
- The *s* is always a clear hissing *s*, never an English *z* buzz.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

pensar (“to think”) ← Latin **pēnsāre**, “to weigh” — the repeating form of *pendere*, “to hang, to weigh out”. A Roman hung goods on a balance; the same verb slid across to weighing an idea. English kept the whole family, and most of it still smells of money and

scales:

- **pensive** — turning something over on the balance.
- **compensate** — *com-* “together” + weigh: settle one weight against another.
- **expense, dispense, pension** — payments were literally *weighed out*.
- **peso** — a coin whose name simply means “a weight”.
- **pansy** — from French *pensée*, “a thought”.

English reaches for the same picture without noticing it: you *weigh your options*, and an argument *carries weight*.

Grammar Lens: the same endings, a broken stem

The endings are the ordinary *-ar* set. Only the stressed *e* changes:

person	form	stem
yo	pienso	broken
tú	piensas	broken
él/ella/usted	piensa	broken
nosotros	pensamos	plain
ellos/ustedes	piensan	broken

Pensamos keeps the plain *e* because there the stress lands on the ending, not the stem — exactly the rule *querer* taught you.

Two small habits come with the verb: *pensar* **en** something means “think about” it (*pienso en ti*), and *pensar* followed by a bare infinitive means “plan to” (*pienso hablar* — I mean to speak).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “pensar” then the set — “pienso, piensas, piensa, pensamos, piensan”
- “Pienso en ti” — I am thinking of you
- “pensar” then English “pensive, compensate, peso” — the weighing family

Before you move on

What did *pēnsāre* mean literally, and name two English cousins. (**To weigh**; *pensive*, *compensate*, *expense*, *peso*.) Which form keeps the plain *e*, and why? (*Pensamos* — the stress falls on the ending.) Which little word follows *pensar* for “think about”? (**En.**) Next: **entender**, which cracks the same way.

Chapter 154

Entender — Understanding Is Stretching Toward

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I understand, and see the verb inside the *no entiendo* I have used since chapter 14.

The second e→ie stem-changer, and the moment a chapter-14 formula turns out to have parts.

154.1 entender — “to understand”, built out of stretching

Pensar broke its stem under stress. So does this one — and you have already been using it. **No entiendo** has been in your mouth since the repair kit, where you learned it as one frozen block. This is the verb it came from.

Sounds you’ll need

- diphthong-**ie** — **entiendo** = *en-TYEN-do*.
- **d-soft** — the *d* between vowels is soft, close to the *th* of English *this*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

entender (“to understand”) ← Latin **intendere**: **in-** (“toward”) + **tendere** (“to stretch”). Understanding something was *stretching*

your attention toward it — leaning in.

tendere stretches right across English:

- **intend, intent, intense, intention** — the very same *in-* + stretch.
- **attend, attention** — *ad-* “toward”, stretch that way.
- **extend, contend, pretend, tension, tendon, and tent**, which is stretched cloth.

So *entiendo* and *I intend* are the same two Latin pieces landing in different places: Spanish went to “I grasp it”, English to “I mean to”.

Careful with a false friend. Spanish **pretender** is *not* English *pretend*. It means “to aim at, to be after” — *pretende ser médico*, “he means to become a doctor”. Same pieces, different landing.

Grammar Lens: an -er verb that cracks, and a calmer twin

Ordinary -er endings, stressed *e* broken to *ie*:

person	form	stem
yo	entiendo	broken
tú	entiendes	broken
nosotros	entendemos	plain
ellos/ustedes	entienden	broken

Spanish has a second verb for this job: **comprender** ← Latin *comprehendere*, “to seize together” (→ English **comprehend, apprehend, comprehensive**). It is a plain -er verb with no crack at all: *comprendo, comprendes, comprende*. Both mean “understand”. *Entender* is the everyday one; *comprender* leans a little more formal, and more toward grasping a whole thing than catching a word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “No entiendo” — I don’t understand
- “entiendo, entiendes, entendemos, entienden”

- “pienso” then “entiendo” — the same crack, twice
- “entender” then English “intend, intense, attention” — the stretching family

Before you move on

What does *tendere* mean, and what does *in-* add? (**To stretch**; “toward”.) Give the *yo* and *nosotros* forms. (*Entiendo, entendemos*.) Of *entender* and *comprender*, which one breaks its stem? (**Entender**.) And what does Spanish *pretender* mean? (**To aim at**, not to pretend.) Next: **leer**.

Chapter 155

Leer — Reading Is Gathering

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I read, with a verb whose stem does not break.

legere, the root that gathers: collect, select, elect, and intellect.

155.1 leer — “to read”, and before that, “to gather”

Two cracked verbs down. Here is a calm one — nothing breaks in the middle. The only difficulty is in your mouth: two *e*’s in a row that must stay two.

Sounds you’ll need

- hiatus-ee — **leer** is two syllables, *le-ER*, never one long English *ee*.
- **leo** is likewise two beats, *LE-o*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

leer (“to read”) ← Latin **legere**, “to gather, to pick out, to choose” — and only afterwards “to read”. A reader picks letters out of a row the way a farmhand picks olives off a branch.

That gathering root runs through an enormous amount of English:

- **legible**, **legend** (“things to be read”), **lecture**, **lectern**, and

worn right down, **lesson**.

- built with prefixes: **collect** (*col-* “together”), **select** (*se-* “apart”), **elect** (*e-* “out”), **intellect** (*inter-* “between” — choosing between things).
- **diligent** and **elegant**, both of which meant “picking carefully”.

One honest limit: Greek *légein* (“to speak, to gather”) — which gives English *logic*, *dialogue*, *catalogue* — is a **cousin** of *legere* from the same ancient root, not its parent. Same family, separate journeys.

Grammar Lens: a plain -er verb, with a mouthful

Nothing irregular happens. Drop *-er*, add the ordinary endings:

person	form	said
yo	leo	LE-o
tú	lees	LE-es
él/ella/usted	lee	LE-e
nosotros	leemos	le-E-mos
ellos/ustedes	leen	LE-en

Every one of those is a syllable longer than an English speaker expects. Give each *e* its own beat and the word comes out right.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “leer” — *le-ER*, two beats
- “Leo un libro” — I read a book
- “No entiendo” then “Leo, pero no entiendo” — I read, but I don’t understand
- “leer” then English “legible, collect, select, elect”

Before you move on

What did *legere* mean before it meant “to read”? (**To gather, to pick out.**) Give two English words built on it with a prefix.

(*Collect, select, elect, intellect.*) How many syllables in *leo*? (**Two**
— *LE-o.*) Next: **escribir**, the other half of literacy.

Chapter 156

Escribir — Writing Is Scratching

Modes:  voice (1)  Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I write, and explain the propped-up e- in front of it.

scribere, to scratch, and Spanish refusing to begin a word with sc-.

156.1 escribir — “to write”, which once meant “to scratch”

Leer gathers letters off a page. This is the other half of the same skill — and its root remembers a time when writing was done with a sharp point in wax.

Sounds you’ll need

- **st-no-e** — Spanish will not begin a word with *sc-*, *sp-*, *st-*, so it props one up with an **e-**: *es-crí-BIR*.
- **b-soft** — between vowels the *b* is soft, lips barely touching.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

escribir (“to write”) ← Latin **scribere**, whose first sense was “to scratch, to incise”. Writing was cutting a line into wax or stone before it was ever ink on paper.

The English family is huge, and every member still works with a pen:

- **scribe, scribble, script, scripture.**

- **describe** (*de-* “down”) and **description**; **prescribe** (*prae-* “before”) and **prescription**; **subscribe** (*sub-* “under” — you signed at the bottom); **inscription**; **transcript**; **postscript**.
- **manuscript** — *manus* “hand” + *scriptum*: written by hand.
- **conscription** — being *written into* an army.

The Spanish past participle is **escrito** (“written”), which is English **script** wearing different clothes.

Grammar Lens: an -ir verb, and a productive spelling rule

Escribir is a plain -ir verb, the family *vivir* opened:

person	form	ending
yo	escribo	-o
tú	escribes	-es
él/ella/usted	escribe	-e
nosotros	escribimos	-imos
ellos/ustedes	escriben	-en

That propped-up **e-** is a rule you can run yourself, not a quirk of one word: Latin *schola* became **escuela**, *spatha* became **espada** (sword), *stāre* became **estar**, *Hispānia* became **España**. It is also why a Spanish speaker learning English says *eh-Spain*.

Now you can state a plan out loud: *Pienso escribir* — “I mean to write.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “escribo, escribes, escribe, escribimos, escriben”
- “Leo y escribo español” — I read and write Spanish
- “Pienso escribir” — I mean to write
- “escribir” then English “scribe, describe, manuscript” — the scratching family

Before you move on

What did *scribere* mean first? (**To scratch, to incise.**) Why does Spanish say *escuela* and *España*? (It refuses to open a word with *sc-* or *sp-*, so it props an **e-** in front.) Say “I read and write Spanish”. (*Leo y escribo español.*) And what does *legere* mean, from the lesson before? (**To gather, to pick out.**) Next chapter: taking, asking, helping — and a verb that runs backwards.

Chapter 157

Review — Four Verbs of the Mind

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗋️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can hold all four mind-verbs at once and name the physical act inside each one.

Four abstractions, four labourers: weighing, stretching, gathering, scratching.

157.1 Review — four verbs of the mind

Nothing new in this chapter. Name the four verbs of the last four chapters: to think, to understand, to read, to write.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Here is the thing none of the four chapters could show you on its own. Every one of these four “mental” verbs began as something you do with your **body**:

- **pensar** — Latin *pēnsāre*, to **weigh**. Thinking is putting things on a balance. English kept the scales in *weigh your options*, and in *pensive*.
- **entender** — Latin *intendere*, to **stretch toward**. Understanding is reaching. English kept the reach in *attention*.
- **leer** — Latin *legere*, to **gather, pick out**. Reading is picking grain from a field. English kept the gathering in *collect, select, elect*.

- **escribir** — Latin *scribere*, to **scratch**. Writing is scratching a surface, which is exactly what it was.

Four abstractions, four labourers. No language invents a word for thinking; it borrows one from the hands and lets the meaning drift indoors.

And a hidden joint. *Intellect* is Latin *inter* + *legere* — “to gather **between**.” The root of **leer** is sitting inside the English word for the mind itself.

What you’ve built

Four verbs, and with them the four things you do with a language: take it in (*leer*), work on it (*pensar*), get it (*entender*), put it back out (*escribir*).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the four verbs in order — to read, to think, to understand, to write
- for each one, the body word underneath it

Twice through:

Before you move on

What did *entender* physically mean? (**To stretch toward.**) What do all four have in common? (Each was a **body** word before it was a mind word.) Next chapter you will use them to say something you actually think.

Chapter 158

Synthesis — What You Understand, and What You Don't

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can report which part of what I heard landed and which did not, instead of only signalling that I am lost.

The chapter-14 distress signal becomes a sentence with moving parts.

158.1 Synthesis — what you understand, and what you don't

Say the sentence you learned in the repair kit, the one that rescues a conversation. (*No entiendo.*)

Grammar Lens: the formula was a verb all along

You have been saying **no entiendo** since the repair kit, and until four chapters ago it was a single frozen block — two sounds that meant *I'm lost*, with no moving parts.

It has parts now. **Entiendo** is *entender*, and *entender* is Latin *intendere*, “to stretch toward.” Which means the sentence you have been using to admit defeat has never actually said *I failed*. It says:

I am not managing to stretch that far.

That was true the whole time. You just could not see it yet.

And the moment a formula has parts, it turns. *No entiendo* stops being the only thing you can say and becomes one option among several.

The exchange

Back in the repair kit, all you could do:

— No entiendo. Más despacio, por favor.

Now, the same moment, with the parts working:

— Perdón — **leo** un poco, pero **no entiendo**. — Más despacio, por favor. **Ahora entiendo**. Gracias.

Same trouble. But the second speaker is no longer only failing — they are reporting **which** part works and which does not. That is the difference between a distress signal and a conversation.

What you've built

Four verbs is not four words. It is the ability to say **where** you are in a language: what you take in, what you work on, what lands, what you can produce.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the repair-kit version — the distress signal on its own
- the version above, where you say what *does* work before what doesn't

Twice through: Run the second one until it sounds like a person, not a repair kit.

Before you move on

Which verb was hiding inside *no entiendo*? (*Entender*.) What did it physically mean? (**To stretch toward**.) What can you say now that you could not say back then? (Not just that you are lost — **which part** is lost.)

Chapter 159

Tomar — Taking, and a Word With No Past

Modes: 🔄 voice (1) 🔄 Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I take, and explain why this everyday verb has no agreed origin.

tomar, the honest gap — and coger, the verb Latin actually left.

159.1 tomar — “to take”, and nobody knows where it came from

Every verb so far ran straight back to a Latin root you could name. Here is one that does not — and the gap is the useful part.

Sounds you’ll need

- r-tap — one soft tap of the tongue: *to-MAR*.
- vowel-o — a short, pure *o*, with no English glide toward *ow*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

tomar (“to take”) is a plain *-ar* verb: **tomo**, **tomas**, **toma**, **tomamos**, **toman**. It is one of the most common verbs in the language, and its origin is **genuinely unsettled**.

The leading proposal derives it from Latin *autumāre*, “to take as, to

assert”, worn down through an intermediate *tumar*; a rival one points to a pre-Roman Iberian word Latin never recorded. Neither is proved, and careful dictionaries say so. “We don’t know” is a real answer in etymology.

It carries a second everyday sense across Latin America: **to drink**. A waiter asking *¿Qué vas a tomar?* is asking what you would like.

Why it’s said this way

Latin’s own “gather up” verb survived perfectly well: **coger** ← **colligere**, which is *com-* (“together”) + *legere* — the very root you met in *leer*. English took that same Latin word twice: **collect** straight from the Latin, and **coil** by way of French.

In Spain *coger* is the plain everyday word: *coger el autobús*, catch the bus. In much of Latin America — Argentina, Mexico and well beyond — it is **coarse slang for sex**, and using it innocently will derail a conversation. *Tomar* is safe on both sides of the Atlantic, which is a large part of why it won.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “tomo, tomas, toma, tomamos, toman”
- “Tomo un café” — I’ll have a coffee
- “Tomo el autobús” — the safe way to say it anywhere
- “coger” then English “collect, coil” — one root, and one place to be careful

Before you move on

Does *tomar* have a confirmed etymology? (**No** — *autumāre* and a pre-Roman source are both unproved.) What Latin verb gives *coger*, and which root sits inside it? (*Colligere*, holding *legere*, “to gather”, from *leer*.) Why reach for *tomar* instead? (*Coger* is coarse slang across much of Latin America.) Next: **preguntar**, and the two different asks.

Chapter 160

Preguntar — Asking, and Sounding a Depth

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask a question with *preguntar*, and choose it over *pedir*.

percontari, to sound a depth with a pole; and why English's one ask becomes two Spanish verbs.

160.1 *preguntar* — “to ask”, by sounding the water with a pole

English gets by with one verb, *ask*. Spanish splits the job in two, and picking the wrong half is a reliable beginner mistake. Here is the first half.

Sounds you'll need

- **pr-cluster** — *pre-* is one crisp beat, *preh*, with a tapped *r*.
- **g-hard** — the *g* before *u* is hard, as in English *gun*: *pre-goon-TAR*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

preguntar (“to ask a question”) ← Vulgar Latin **praecunctāre**, itself a reshaping of classical **percontārī**, “to inquire”. And *percontārī* was built on **contus**, “a punting pole”: to *percontor* was to push a

pole down through water and find out how deep it was.

Asking is taking a sounding. Unlike almost every other word here, *preguntar* left English nothing — the pole word died out — yet English rebuilt the same metaphor on its own: you *sound someone out*, you *probe*.

The verb is a plain *-ar* one: **pregunto, preguntas, pregunta, preguntamos, preguntan**. Its noun is **la pregunta** (fem.), and note that Spanish *makes* a question rather than asking one: *hacer una pregunta*.

Grammar Lens: one English “ask”, two Spanish verbs

Spanish sorts asking by **what you are after**:

what you want	verb	example
information	preguntar	<i>Te pregunto la hora</i> — I’m asking you the time
a thing or a favour	pedir	<i>Pido un café</i> — I’m asking for a coffee

Ask for a coffee with *preguntar* and you have said “I question a coffee”. The line is simple: a question takes *preguntar*, a request takes *pedir*. **pedir** ← Latin **petere**, “to make for, to aim at” — and *that* root stocked English generously: **petition, appetite, compete, impetus, perpetual, centripetal**. It cracks a third way, *e* → *i*: **pido, pides, pide, pedimos, piden**. Recognise *pido* for now; the pattern gets its own lesson later.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “pregunto, preguntas, pregunta, preguntamos, preguntan”
- “Te pregunto la hora” — I’m asking you the time
- “Pido un café” then “Tomo un café” — I ask for one, I have one
- “pedir” then English “petition, appetite, compete” — the aiming family

Before you move on

What did *percontārī* picture literally? (**Sounding water with a pole.**) Which verb asks for a coffee, and which asks the time? (*Pedir* for the coffee; *preguntar* for the time.) What Latin root is *pedir* from, and one English cousin? (*Petere*, “to aim at” — *petition*, *appetite*, *compete*.) Next: **ayudar**, which is the same word as English *aid*.

Chapter 161

Ayudar — the Same Word as Aid

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say that I help, and hear English aid inside the Spanish word.

adiutare straight through to aid, and the -di- that also gave hodie -> hoy.

161.1 ayudar — “to help”, and it is English “aid” in disguise

You can ask a question now. The next thing to ask for is a hand — and this verb is one you already own in English without knowing it.

Sounds you’ll need

- vowel-a — a clean, open *a*: *a-yoo-DAR*.
- r-tap — one tap at the end, not an English *r*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ayudar (“to help”) ← Latin **adiūtāre**, the repeating form of **adiuvāre**: **ad-** (“toward”) + **iuvāre** (“to help, to delight”). To help was to move toward someone.

English borrowed that identical verb through Old French *aidier* and calls it **aid**. So *ayudar* and *aid* are not merely cousins — they are the

same word by two different roads. The family came with it:

- **aide**, and **aide-de-camp**, an officer who helps.
- **adjutant** — the officer whose whole job is assisting.
- **adjuvant** — a substance that helps another drug work.
- **coadjutor** — one who helps alongside.

The shape change is a rule, not an accident. Latin **-di-** before a vowel turned into Spanish **y**: *adiūtāre* → **ayudar**, *hodiē* → **hoy** (“today”), *podium* → *poyo*. Once you have that, the word stops looking arbitrary.

Grammar Lens: a plain -ar verb, and how to ask for a hand

Nothing breaks; the endings are the ones you started with:

person	form	meaning
yo	ayudo	I help
tú	ayudas	you help
nosotros	ayudamos	we help
ellos/ustedes	ayudan	they help

Its noun is **la ayuda** (fem.), “help” — the word on relief packages worldwide. Two sentences worth owning: *¿Me ayudas?* (“will you help me?” — Spanish uses the plain present where English needs *will*) and, politely, *¿Puedo ayudarle?*

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ayudo, ayudas, ayudamos, ayudan”
- “¿Me ayudas?” — will you help me?
- “Te pregunto” then “Me ayudas” — I ask you, you help me
- “ayudar” then English “aid, adjutant, adjuvant” — one word, two roads

Before you move on

What two Latin pieces build *adiuvāre*? (**Ad-** “toward” + **iuvāre** “to help”.) What everyday English word is *ayudar*, arriving by French? (**Aid.**) What sound-law turned *adiūtāre* into *ayudar*, and which other word shows it? (Latin **-di-** became Spanish **y**; *hodiē* → *hoy*.) Next: **gustar**, the verb that runs backwards.

Chapter 162

Review — Three Verbs That Behave

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can use all three verbs and say what they have in common: the sentence is about the one doing it.

Three origins - tidy, reshaped, and genuinely unknown - and the shared shape about to be broken.

162.1 Review — three verbs that behave

Nothing new here. Name the three verbs of the last three chapters: to take, to ask, to help.

What you've built

All three work the way you expect, and it is worth naming that out loud **before** the next chapter, where one does not.

In each of them, **you** are the one doing it. You take. You ask. You help. The person doing the verb is the person the sentence is about — exactly as in English, and exactly as in every verb you have met since *hablo*.

Hold on to that. It is about to be worth money.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Three origins, three very different kinds of story:

- **ayudar** is the tidy one. Latin *adiūtāre* → English **aid**. Same word, two roads, and you can still hear it.
- **preguntar** is the reshaped one — *percontārī*, to sound a depth with a pole. Asking as measuring how deep something goes.
- **tomar** is the honest gap. It has **no agreed origin at all**. The verb Latin actually handed down for “take” was *coger*, and *coger* turned coarse across much of Latin America — so an everyday word had to come from somewhere, and nobody is sure where.

Not every word has a clean story. A course that pretended otherwise would be inventing them.

Your turn

- *Say it*: the three verbs, then one sentence with each

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which one has no settled origin? (*Tomar*.) In all three, who is the sentence about? (**The one doing it.**) Next chapter: a verb where that stops being true.

Chapter 163

Gustar — the Verb Built the Other Way Round

Modes: 🔄 voice (1) 🔄 Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can build a gustar sentence the way Spanish builds it, with the thing liked as the subject.

me gusta el libro is the book pleasing me, so the verb agrees with the book.

163.1 gustar — the verb that runs backwards

Back in the introductions you learned **mucho gusto** — “much pleasure”. Here is the verb that noun belongs to, assembled the opposite way round from English. It is the single thing in Spanish that trips English speakers up hardest.

Sounds you’ll need

- **g-hard** — a hard *g* before *u*: *goos-TAR*.
- **s-clear** — a clean hissing *s*, never a *z* buzz.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

gustar ← Latin **gustāre**, “**to taste**”. English kept the root and stayed close to the tongue:

- **gusto** — doing something with relish, that is, with a taste for it.

- **gustatory** — of the sense of taste.
- **disgust** — *dis-* “away” + taste: what you spit back out.
- **degustation**, a tasting menu; and through French, **ragout**.

Spanish’s own **el gusto** — the *gusto* of *mucho gusto* — still holds both senses: taste on the tongue, and pleasure taken in a thing. The verb followed the second: *gustar* means “**to please**”.

Grammar Lens: the thing you like is the subject

English says **I** like the book: the liker is the subject. Spanish has no such sentence. It says **Me gusta el libro** — “the book is pleasing **to me**”.

Everything follows from that:

- *el libro* is the **subject**, which is why the verb is *gusta*, third person.
- *me* is the person it happens **to**, not the one doing anything.

So the verb agrees with the **thing**, never with you:

what you mean	Spanish	why
I like the book	Me gusta el libro	one book, so <i>gusta</i>
I like books	Me gustan los libros	many books, so <i>gustan</i>
I like reading	Me gusta leer	one action, so <i>gusta</i>

To change who is pleased, change the little word in front, not the verb: **me** (to me), **te** (to you), **le** (to him, her, *usted*), **nos** (to us), **les** (to them).

Careful. There is no *yo gusto el libro*. *Yo gusto* is a real sentence — it means “**I** am pleasing” — just not the one you were reaching for.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Me gusta el café” then “Me gustan los libros” — the verb follows

the thing

- “Te gusta tomar café” — you like drinking coffee
- “Me gusta ayudar” — I like helping
- “gustar” then English “gusto, disgust, gustatory” — the tasting family

Before you move on

In *me gusta el libro*, what is the subject? (**El libro.**) Why is it *me gustan los libros*? (The verb agrees with *los libros*, which is plural.) What did *gustāre* mean, and name an English cousin. (**To taste; gusto, disgust.**) And what would *yo gusto* actually mean? (**I am pleasing.**)

Chapter 164

Synthesis — What You Like, and Who Does the Liking

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I like without translating I like word by word, and hear mucho gusto as the same word.

*Liking started at the tongue; and the chapter-5 phrase turns out to be *gustar*'s noun.*

164.1 Synthesis — what you like, and who is doing the liking

Say “I like coffee” in Spanish. Then answer this: in that sentence, which word is the **subject**?

Grammar Lens: the sentence that will not let you be the subject

Me gusta el café. The coffee is the subject. The coffee does the pleasing. You are the one it happens *to*.

English puts you in charge: *I like coffee* — I am the subject, the coffee just sits there. Spanish reverses it.

Two chapters ago, all three verbs were about **the one doing it**. That is why this chapter had to sit next to them.

Translate *I like* word by word and you build a sentence Spanish does

not have — which is why this is a chapter about saying an idea, not a word.

The exchange

— ¿Te gusta el café? — Sí, **me gusta** mucho. ¿Y a ti? — A mí también. **Mucho gusto.**

That last line is a joke you can now get. *Mucho gusto* — the phrase you learned long ago for “pleased to meet you” — is the **same word**. It has always meant *much pleasure*. You have been saying *gustar*’s noun since your third conversation in this book.

What you’ve built

Gustar is Latin *gustāre*, **to taste** — English *gusto*, *disgust*. Liking, in Spanish, started at the tongue.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the exchange above, both parts
- it again, and as you say *me gusta*, notice that you are **not** the subject

Twice through: Until *me gusta* arrives without translating *I like* first.

Before you move on

Who is the subject of *me gusta el café*? (**El café.**) What did *gustar* mean first? (**To taste.**) And what has *mucho gusto* meant all along? (**Much pleasure** — the same word.)

Chapter 165

Hearing, Sleeping, Walking, Running

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say I hear, sleep, walk and run in Spanish, write oír's y where the spelling demands it, and break dormir's o to ue the way a boot verb does.

Run the chapter's four verbs together and sort them by what they do to their stems: correr, caminar and andar leave theirs alone, dormir breaks o to ue, oír grows a g in oigo and writes y in oyes. Then name each verb's source in turn — audire, dormire, Gaulish camminus, currere — and set the two words with no settled origin, andar and perro, against them.

165.1 oír — “to hear”, and the y that appears from nowhere

Say *Me gusta el café* once — the coffee is pleasing to me, and the coffee is the subject. Now a verb about the ears, and one of the most bent-out-of-shape words in the language.

Sounds you'll need

- **accent-i** — the accent on **í** keeps the vowels apart: *o-EER*, two beats.
- **y-glide** — the y in *oyes* is the consonant of English *yes*: *O-yes*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

oír (“to hear”) ← Latin **audīre**, “to hear”. Spanish wore it right down: the *d* between vowels dropped away and *au-* collapsed to *o-*. English never inherited it but borrowed it repeatedly, and the family keeps the *aud-* Spanish threw away: **audio**, **audible**, **audition**, **auditorium**, **audit**, **audience** — the people doing the hearing. Then the surprise. **Obey** is Latin **oboedīre**, *ob-* (“toward”) + *audīre*: obeying is literally **listening toward** someone. **Obedient** comes with it.

Why it’s said this way

Spanish splits what English leaves joined. **Oír** is what your ears do whether you meant it or not. **Escuchar** is on purpose. *Escuchar* has its own root: Latin **auscultāre**, “to listen to”, built on *auris*, “ear”. A doctor **auscultates** a chest; and when Old French wore *auscultāre* down to *escouter*, English borrowed it as **scout** — one sent out to listen. English can draw the line when it wants. Spanish makes you.

Grammar Lens: the -go yo-form, and a spelling rule

person	form
yo	oigo
tú	oyes
él/ella/usted	oye
nosotros	oímos
ellos/ustedes	oyen

Two separate things. The *yo*-form grows the hard **-g-** you know from *tengo*, *hago* and *digo*; *oír* joins that club.

The rest is **spelling**, not sound. Spanish will not write an unstressed **i** stranded between two vowels, so *oi-es* is impossible and the letter becomes **y**: *oyes*, *oye*, *oyen*. *Oímos* keeps its accent because there the *i* is stressed.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “oigo, oyes, oye, oímos, oyen”

- “¿Me oyes?” — can you hear me?
- “Me gusta oír” — hearing is pleasing to me
- “oír” then English “audio, audience, obey”

Before you move on

Which Latin verb is behind *oír*, and what has *obey* to do with it? (**Audīre**; *oboedīre* is “to listen toward”.) Why *oyes* and not *oies*? (Spanish will not leave an unstressed *i* between two vowels.) Which of *oír* and *escuchar* do you choose to do? (**Escuchar**.) And in *me gusta el café*, what is the subject? (**El café**.)

165.2 dormir — “to sleep”, and the boot’s other vowel

Run *oír* once more: *oigo*, *oyes*, *oye*, *oímos*, *oyen* — and remember that the *y* in *oyes* is a spelling rule, not a new sound. Now a verb whose stem cracks the way *pensar*’s did, but on a different vowel.

Sounds you’ll need

- **diphthong-ue** — under stress the *o* breaks open: **duermo** = *DWER-mo*.
- **r-tap** — one soft flick of the tongue in *dormir*, nothing like an English *r*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

dormir (“to sleep”) ← Latin **dormīre**, “to sleep” — one of the rare verbs Spanish inherited almost untouched. English took the root only through French and Latin, and every borrowing still points at a bed:

- **dormitory**, and its clipped **dorm** — the room where sleeping is done.
- **dormant** — from the French participle *dormant*, “sleeping”. A dormant volcano is a sleeping one.
- **dormer** — the window let into a roof, named for the

sleeping-loft behind it.

Spanish keeps its own branch: **el dormitorio** for the bedroom, and *la bella durmiente* for Sleeping Beauty.

The **dormouse** looks like the obvious member of this family, and careful dictionaries will not commit. An Anglo-Norman *dormeus*, “sleepy”, is the best guess, but the trail goes cold. Treat it as likely rather than proved.

Grammar Lens: the boot again, with o→ue

person	form	stem
yo	duermo	broken
tú	duermes	broken
él/ella/usted	duerme	broken
nosotros	dormimos	plain
ellos/ustedes	duermen	broken

Pensar broke **e→ie** under stress. *Dormir* breaks **o→ue** under exactly the same condition, and for exactly the same reason: the stress falls on the stem in four of these forms and on the ending in *dormimos*, so only *dormimos* keeps its plain *o*.

That is the whole of the rule. Spanish has two stressed vowels that will not sit still — *e* becomes *ie*, *o* becomes *ue* — and once you can hear where the stress lands, you can predict which forms crack without memorising a list.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “duermo, duermes, duerme, dormimos, duermen”
- “pienso” then “duermo” — *e* to *ie*, *o* to *ue*, one rule
- “No duermo bien” — I don’t sleep well
- “dormir” then English “dormitory, dormant, dormer” — the sleeping family

Before you move on

Which form of *dormir* keeps its plain *o*, and why? (*Dormimos* — the stress lands on the ending.) Name two English cousins of *dormire*. (*Dormitory*, *dormant*, *dormer*.) What did *pēnsāre*, behind *pensar*, mean literally? (**To weigh.**) And what is the *yo*-form of *oír*? (**Oigo.**)

165.3 caminar — “to walk”, from a word Rome borrowed from the Celts

Duermo, *duermes*, *duerme* — the *o* cracking to *ue*. Relax: the two verbs here do nothing of the kind. The interest is in where they came from.

Sounds you’ll need

- **k-hard** — the *c* before *a* is a hard *k*: *ka-mi-NAR*.
- **vowel-a** — a short clean *a*, the same in every syllable.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

caminar (“to walk”) was built on the noun **el camino**, “the road” — and *camino* is not a Latin word at all. Latin **camminus** was a loan from **Gaulish**, the Celtic language of pre-Roman France, from a word for a step or a way. It stocked the roads of every Romance language: *camino*, Portuguese *caminho*, Italian *cammino*, French *chemin*. Here the cousin web runs out, and that is worth saying plainly: this root reached English only inside borrowed French phrases. The Celtic layer did reach English by other doors — Latin also took Gaulish *carrus*, a wagon, behind **car** and **cargo**. *Camminus* never crossed.

A false friend that looks certain. Latin also had **camīnus**, “hearth”, from Greek *kaminos* — and *that* gave English **chimney**. Two nearly identical Latin words, no relation.

Grammar Lens: two plain verbs, and which to reach for

Spanish has a second everyday verb here, **andar**. Both take ordinary *-ar* endings and neither breaks its stem.

person	caminar	andar
yo	camino	ando
tú	caminas	andas
él/ella/usted	camina	anda
nosotros	caminamos	andamos
ellos/ustedes	caminan	andan

Caminar is walking as the thing you are doing. **Andar** is wider: to go about, and by extension to work at all — *no anda*, of a machine, means “it isn’t running”. Either serves for a walk.

Why it’s said this way

Camino has a clean history. *Andar* does not. It comes down from Medieval Latin **andāre**, and where *andāre* came from is **genuinely disputed**: *ambulāre* (“to walk about”) and *ambitāre* (“to go around”) are both proposed and neither is proved. If *ambulāre* is right, **amble** and **ambulance** are cousins — but that “if” carries real weight.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “camino, caminas, camina, caminamos, caminan”
- “ando, andas, anda, andamos, andan”
- “Camino una hora” — I walk for an hour
- “el camino” then “camino” — the road, and I walk it

Before you move on

Which language did Latin borrow *camminus* from? (**Gaulish**.) Which English word comes from the *other* Latin *camīnus*, the hearth? (**Chimney** — unrelated.) Is *andar*’s origin settled? (**No**.) Say “I walk for an hour”. (*Camino una hora*.) And the *nosotros* form of *dormir*? (*Dormimos*.)

165.4 correr — “to run”, and the root that runs through half of English

You can walk two ways now — *camino* and *ando*. Speed it up. This last verb of the chapter is the plainest to conjugate and the richest to trace.

Sounds you’ll need

- **rolled-rr** — the double *r* is a full trill: *ko-RRER*. It is a different letter from a single *r*, and swapping them swaps words.
- **vowel-o** — a short pure *o*, no glide toward English *ow*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

correr (“to run”) ← Latin **currere**, “to run”. English borrowed this root harder than almost any other, and the descendants have spread so far from running that they no longer look related:

- **current** — water that runs; **currency**, money running hand to hand.
- **curriculum** — a *running*, a racecourse. A course of study is a track you run.
- **courier**, a runner; **course**, **cursor**, **cursive** — writing that runs.
- **corridor** — a place for running along, by way of Italian.
- with prefixes: **occur** (*ob-*, to run up against), **recur**, **incur**, **precursor**, **excursion**.

And a cousin from the lesson before: Gaulish *carrus*, behind English **car** and **cargo**, comes from the very same Proto-Indo-European root **kers-**, “to run”. Latin took one road and Celtic another; English holds both ends.

Grammar Lens: a plain -er verb, and four verbs together

Correr breaks nothing and grows nothing: **corro**, **corres**, **corre**, **corremos**, **corren**. That makes it the clean case the chapter’s others stand out against:

verb	what it does to its stem
correr	nothing — <i>corro, corres, corre</i>
caminar, andar	nothing — <i>camino, ando</i>
dormir	breaks <i>o</i> to <i>ue</i> under stress — <i>duermo</i> , but <i>dormimos</i>
oír	grows <i>-g-</i> in <i>oigo</i> , and writes <i>y</i> in <i>oyes, oye, oyen</i>
Only two of the four misbehave, and each misbehaves by a rule you can state.	

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “corro, corres, corre, corremos, corren”
- “El perro corre” — the dog runs
- “Camino, no corro” — I walk, I don’t run
- “Corro el sábado” — I run on Saturday; Spanish uses the bare article where English says *on*
- “Oigo, duermo, camino, corro” — the whole chapter in four words
- “correr” then English “current, curriculum, corridor” — the running family

Before you move on

Name each verb’s source in turn: *oír*, *dormir*, *caminar*, *correr*. (**Audīre**; **dormīre**; Gaulish *camminus*, by way of *el camino*; **currere**.) Which of the four leave their stems alone? (*Caminar*, *andar* and *correr*.) Say “the dog runs”. (*El perro corre*.) Two words here have no settled origin — which? (*Andar*, and *perro*, whose three proposals all lack the evidence to decide between them.) And which English everyday word is a cousin of *correr* through Celtic? (**Car**.)

Chapter 166

Opening, Closing, Sitting Down, Standing Up

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say I open, close, sit down and stand up in Spanish, and use the reflexive pronoun that makes *sentarse* and *levantarse* land the action back on me.

Say the chapter in one breath — abro el libro, me siento, cierro el libro, me levanto — then separate the two features it taught: sentarse is reflexive and a stem-changer, levantarse is reflexive only. Name the shared recipe behind both body-position verbs (a Latin present participle, sedēns and levāns), pick abierto out as the one irregular participle, and reach back to la mano for why the article stays feminine.

166.1 abrir — “to open”, and the one part of it that misbehaves

Say *corro* and *camino* once — two verbs that gave you no trouble. This one is nearly as easy, and its one misbehaving piece is a word you will read on a shop door before you ever say it.

Sounds you’ll need

- **b-soft** — between vowels the *b* barely closes the lips: *a-BREER*.
- **r-tap** — a single flick for the final *r*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

abrir (“to open”) ← Latin **aperīre**, “to open, to uncover”. The *p* softened to *b* between vowels on the way into Spanish — the slide that turned *sapere* into *saber* and *lupus* into *lobo*.

English took the root through two doors and does not notice they are one word:

- straight from Latin *apertūra*: **aperture**, the opening a lens makes.
- through French *ouvrir* and its participle *ouvert*: **overt** (“out in the open”) and **overture**, an opera’s opening.
- **aperitif**, a drink that *opens* the appetite; Spanish, **el aperitivo**.

The cousin that is not one. *April* looks like it belongs here — the opening month. That is old folk etymology and is not accepted: the better proposals point at an Etruscan *Apru*, borrowed from Aphrodite, or at an Italic word meaning “the next one”. A hook this pretty is the kind to check.

Grammar Lens: regular everywhere but the participle

In the present, *abrir* is a plain *-ir* verb, the family *escribir* belongs to: **abro, abres, abre, abrimos, abren**. Nothing breaks, nothing grows. The **past participle** is where the irregularity lives. A regular *-ir* verb would give *abrido*. Spanish says **abierto**, straight down from Latin *apertum*, keeping the *e* that broke to *ie* under stress long ago.

You will meet that participle long before the tense it belongs to, because it is a word on doors: **ABIERTO** on the sign, **está abierto** for “it is open now”. *Escribir* does the same with **escrito**. Both refuse the regular ending because both inherited a Latin participle whole.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “abro, abres, abre, abrimos, abren”
- “Abro el libro” then “Está abierto”

- “abrir” then English “aperture, overt, overture”
- “correr” then English “current, curriculum” — still there from before

Before you move on

What is the past participle of *abrir*, and what would a regular verb have given? (**Abierto**; *abrido*.) Name two English words from *aperire*. (*Aperture, overt, overture, aperitif*.) Is *April* one? (**No** — folk etymology.) Which other verb keeps an inherited Latin participle? (*Escribir* → *escrito*.) And which Latin verb is behind *correr*? (**Currere**.)

166.2 cerrar — “to close”, from the bar across the door

Abro, abres, abre — and the sign saying **ABIERTO**. Here is the sign on the other side of the day, and a verb that cracks its stem.

Sounds you’ll need

- **soft-c** — *c* before *e* is soft: a *th* across most of Spain, an *s* across Latin America.
- **rolled-rr** — the double *r* is fully trilled: *se-RRAR*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

cerrar (“to close”) ← Late Latin **serāre**, “to bolt, to fasten”, from the noun **sera**: the **bar you drop across a door**. Closing here is a physical object being put in place, not an abstraction.

Its Romance siblings kept the pressure: Italian *serrare*, French *serrer*, “to squeeze, to tighten”. English holds one of that branch, **serried**, as in ranks pressed shut against each other. Reference works generally connect *sera* to Latin **serere**, “to join in a row”, which would make **series** and **insert** distant relatives — usual, but not certain.

Why it’s said this way

Latin had a perfectly good verb for closing: **claudere**. English is full of it — **close, closet, closure, clause, cloister, include, exclude,**

conclude, recluse.

Spanish let it go. For shutting a door it took *serāre* instead, and kept *claudere* only in words scholars borrowed back much later: **incluir**, **excluir**, **concluir**, **clausura**. That inversion is worth sitting with: the bigger English family belongs to the verb Spanish gave up. A cousin web maps what each language kept, and these two kept opposite halves.

Grammar Lens: e→ie, and the sign on the door

person	form
yo	cierro
tú	cierras
él/ella/usted	cierra
nosotros	cerramos
ellos/ustedes	cierran

Dormir broke **o→ue**. *Cerrar* breaks **e→ie** — the same boot, the other vowel, the same trigger: stress on the stem. *Cerramos* is plain because there the stress moves to the ending.

Its participle, unlike *abierto*, is regular: **cerrado**. The two signs on one door are built differently — *abierto* inherited whole from Latin, *cerrado* made by rule.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “cierro, cierras, cierra, cerramos, cierran”
- “Abro el libro” then “Cierro el libro”
- “ABIERTO” then “CERRADO” — the two signs
- “aperīre, aperture” then “serāre, serried” — the two doors’ roots

Before you move on

What was a *sera*, and does *cerrar* come from *claudere*? (**The bar dropped across a door**; and **no** — Spanish kept *claudere* only in *incluir*, *excluir*, *concluir*.) Which form of *cerrar* keeps its plain *e*,

and why? (*Cerramos* — the stress moves to the ending, as in *dormimos*.) Which participle is irregular, *abierto* or *cerrado*? (*Abierto*.) And what did *intendere*, behind *entender*, mean literally? (**To stretch toward.**)

166.3 **sentarse** — “to seat oneself”, which is how Spanish thinks about sitting down

Two things in hand. *Cierro* — the *e* cracking to *ie*. And *me llamo*, “I call **myself**”, where the little *me* bounced the action back onto you. This verb needs both at once.

Sounds you’ll need

- diphthong-*ie* — the stressed *e* breaks: **me siento** = *me SYEN-to*.
- **s-clear** — a clean hissing *s*, never a *z* buzz.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

sentar ← Vulgar Latin *sedentāre*, built not on the Latin verb but on its **present participle**: *sedēns*, “sitting”, from *sedēre*, “to sit”. Spanish made a new verb out of being in a sitting state.

Sedēre is one of the great English suppliers, and hardly any descendant still looks like sitting: **sedentary**, **sediment**, **sedate**; **session** and **siege** (an army sitting down outside a city); **preside**, **reside**; **assess**, **obsess**, **possess**. By way of Greek *hedra*, “seat”, it also gives **cathedral** and **chair**.

Then the other branch. English **sit**, **seat**, **settle**, **saddle** and **nest** come down from the very same root, *sed-*, through Germanic rather than Latin. Neither borrowed from the other: they are siblings, exactly as *padre* and *father* are, each branch reshaping the sounds its own way.

Grammar Lens: seating someone, and seating yourself

Plain **sentar** means to seat somebody *else*. To sit down yourself, you send the action back with the pronoun that made *me llamo* “I call myself”:

person	form
yo	me siento
tú	te sientas
él/ella/usted	se sienta
nosotros	nos sentamos
ellos/ustedes	se sientan

Two patterns run at once, and you have both. The pronoun changes with the person — *me, te, se, nos, se* — and the stem breaks *e→ie* wherever the stress lands on it, leaving *nos sentamos* plain. The pronoun stands before a conjugated verb and clips onto an infinitive, hence the name **sentarse**.

Two verbs, one shape. *Me siento* is also the *yo*-form of *sentirse*, “to feel”: *me siento bien* is “I feel fine”. Only what follows tells them apart.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “me siento, te sientas, se sienta, nos sentamos, se sientan”
- “me llamo” then “me siento” — the same little me, twice
- “Cierro el libro y me siento” — I close the book and sit down
- “sentarse” then English “session, sedentary, preside”

Before you move on

What does *sentarse* say literally, and which Latin form was it built on? (**To seat oneself**; the participle *sedēns*.) Are English *sit* and Latin *sedēre* parent and child, or siblings? (**Siblings** — separate branches of one root, like *father* and *padre*.) Which form keeps its plain *e*, and what was a *sera*? (*Nos sentamos*; **the bar across a door**.)

166.4 levantarse — “to raise oneself”, and how Spanish says “stand”

Me siento put you in the chair, the little *me* bouncing the action back onto you. Now get out of it. The pronoun works the same way; this time the stem does not crack at all.

Sounds you’ll need

- **v-b** — Spanish *v* and *b* are one sound: *le-ban-TAR*.
- **nasal-n** — a clean *n* before the *t*, not swallowed.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

levantar ← Vulgar Latin *levantāre*, from *levāns*, the present participle of *levāre*, “to raise, to lighten” — itself from *levis*, “light, not heavy”.

Notice the shape: a Latin **present participle**, made into a new verb — the identical recipe that gave *sentar* from *sedēns*. Spanish built both of its body-position verbs out of a word for the state rather than the act.

Levāre is everywhere in English: **lever**, **elevate**, **elevator** for raising; **levity**, **levitate**, **alleviate**, **relieve** for lightening; **leaven**, what raises the bread, and **levy**, a tax *raised*. And **the Levant**, from French *levant*, “rising”: from western Europe it lay where the sun came up. English **light**, the opposite of heavy, is the Germanic cousin of *levis*, as *sit* is of *sedēre*.

Grammar Lens: raising a thing, raising yourself, standing still

Levantar on its own raises something else. **Levantarse** raises *you*:

Spanish	what it means
Levanto la mano	I raise my hand
Levanto la cabeza	I lift my head
Me levanto	I get up, I stand up

The endings are ordinary *-ar* throughout — **me levanto, te levantas, se levanta, nos levantamos, se levantan** — and nothing breaks. So the chapter has now shown its two features apart: *sentarse* is reflexive **and** a stem-changer; *levantarse* is reflexive **only**.

For standing as a *state*, Spanish uses no verb. It says **estar de pie** — “to be on foot”, *el pie* being the foot. English’s single “stand” splits in two: *me levanto* for getting up, *estoy de pie* for being up.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “me levanto, te levantas, se levanta, nos levantamos, se levantan”
- “Levanto la mano” then “Levanto la cabeza” then “Me levanto”
- “Estoy de pie” — I am standing
- “Abro el libro, me siento, cierro el libro, me levanto”
- “levantar” then English “lever, elevate, Levant”

Before you move on

Say the chapter’s four verbs, then say how you are standing. (*Abro, cierro, me siento, me levanto; estoy de pie.*) What do *sentar* and *levantar* share in their making, and which also breaks its stem? (Both from a Latin **present participle**, *sedēns* and *levāns*; *sentarse* breaks *e*→*ie*.) Name the two roots on that door, and which participle is irregular. (**Aperīre** and **serāre** — *not claudere; abierto.*) Why *la mano*? (*Manus* was feminine in Latin.)

Chapter 167

Telling What Happened

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can tell a short connected story about something that happened — ordering the events with *luego*, giving a reason with *porque*, and choosing the imperfect for the scene and the preterite for the events.

Tell a four-sentence story out loud: Llovía. Me levanté, luego bebí café. No corrí, porque llovía mucho. Me senté y leí. Every word in it has been taught in this book, and the two pasts divide the work between scene and event.

167.1 luego — a word you already have, doing a job you have not seen it do

Nothing new to learn here — you have said **luego** every time you said *hasta luego*. What is new is that it can stand alone, between two events, and put them in order.

Sounds you'll need

- diphthong-ue — *ue* is one glide, not two syllables.
- g-soft-gw — between vowels the *g* softens; **luego** is *LWEH-gho*, not the hard stop English puts in *go*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

You already know where it comes from: Latin **locō**, the ablative of **locus**, “place” — “in that place”, a word about *where* that slid into a word about *when*. That is why *hasta luego* is “until later”.

What you have not been shown is how much else *locus* is holding up. It gives **local**, **locate**, **location**, **locus**, **allocate**, **dislocate**. And through French *lieu*, “place”, it gives **lieutenant** — literally the officer *holding the place* of another.

A leftover worth knowing. *Desde luego* means “of course”. It was built on an older sense of *luego*, “**immediately**”, so its literal force was nearer “from this moment on”. The bare word has since drifted to “later”; the phrase kept the old sense.

Grammar Lens: luego between two events

Out of the farewell, *luego* is not glued to a verb. It marks the join between two events and sits at the front of the second:

Me siento. Luego leo.	I sit down. Then I read.
Bebo café y luego escribo.	I drink coffee and then I write.
Me levanto y luego corro.	I get up and then I run.

Two events, in order, with one word doing the ordering — and it is a word you have been saying since chapter five.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hasta luego” then just “luego” — same word, standing alone
- “Me siento. Luego leo.”
- “Me levanto y luego corro.”
- “luego” then English “local, locate, lieutenant”

Before you move on

What job does *luego* do here that it does not do in *hasta luego*? (It **joins two events in order**, instead of sitting inside a fixed farewell.) Which English officer's title hides the same *locus*? (**Lieutenant** — the one holding another's place.) Which older sense of *luego* is frozen inside *desde luego*? (**Immediately** — not “later”.)

167.2 *porque* — “because”, and the reason a sequence turns into a story

With *luego* you can put two events in order. But order is not yet a story. *I sat down, then I read* tells nobody **why**. One more word closes that gap, and it is two words wearing a single coat.

Sounds you'll need

- **k-hard** — *qu* before *e* is a plain *k*; the *u* is silent. **porque** = *POR-keh*.
- **r-tap** — a single flick of the tongue, not the rolled *rr*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

porque = **por** + **que**, fused.

por descends from Latin *prō*, “for, in front of, on behalf of” — the same *prō* standing at the front of **provide**, **proceed**, **protect**, **propose**, and surviving whole in the English phrase *quid pro quo*.

que descends from Latin *quid*, “what” — and then quietly took over every job Latin had given *quod*, without taking its form.

And this is the good part. That Latin *qu-* is one branch of the Proto-Indo-European interrogative root **k^wo-*. The other branch went into Germanic, where **k^w-* softened to *hw-* — Grimm's Law turning a stop into a breath — and came out as English **who**, **what**, **when**, **where**, **why**.

So Spanish *que* and English *what* are not borrowed from one another. They are **siblings** — the same ancient question-word, walked down two different roads. *Quid pro quo* puts both Latin halves of *porque* side by side in an English sentence.

Grammar Lens: porque, por qué, el porqué

Three spellings, three jobs, and they are genuinely distinct in writing:

written	stress	job
porque	one word, no accent	because — gives the reason
por qué	two words, accent on <i>qué</i>	why — asks for the reason
el porqué	one word, accent, with <i>el</i>	the reason — a noun

¿**Por qué** te levantas? — **Why** do you get up? *Me levanto porque corro.* — I get up **because** I run. *No entiendo el porqué.* — I don't understand **the reason**.

The accent is not decoration. It marks *qué* as the questioning one, exactly as it does on other question words.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “porque” — *POR-keh*, silent *u*
- “Me siento porque leo.” — I sit down because I read.
- “Me levanto y luego corro, porque hace sol.”
- the three shapes — “porque, por qué, el porqué”

Before you move on

What two Latin words are fused inside *porque*? (*prō* and *quid*.) Are Spanish *que* and English *what* parent and child, or siblings?

(**Siblings** — Latin *qu-* and Germanic *wh-* from one root, **k^wo-*.)

Which of the three spellings asks a question? (*Por qué* — two words, accent on *qué*.)

167.3 llovía / llovió — the same rain, told two ways

You already have both past tenses. The imperfect — *hablaba*, *comía* — came in chapter sixteen, with its three irregulars. Noth-

ing here is a new form. What is new is **which one to reach for**, and that turns out to be the whole trick of telling a story.

Sounds you'll need

- double-l-y — *ll* is a *y* glide: **llovía** = *yo-VEE-a*.
- accent-i — the accent splits the vowels: *llo-VÍ-a*, three beats.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The name is the lesson, and it is worth having.

Imperfecto is Latin *imperfectus*: *in-* (“not”) plus *perfectus*, “carried all the way through” — itself *per-* (“through”) plus *facere* (“to do, to make”). That *facere* is everywhere in English: **fact**, **factory**, **effect**, **manufacture**, and **perfect** itself, which still means *finished through*.

So the imperfect is the **not-carried-through** tense. Not unfinished in quality — unfinished in *time*. It shows an action still running, with no edge on it. That is not a label bolted on afterwards; it is a description of the job.

Grammar Lens: the scene and the events

Take one fact — it rained — and watch the tense decide what *kind* of fact it is:

Llovía.	It was raining. (<i>no edge — the weather that day</i>)
Llovió.	It rained. (<i>edged — a thing that happened</i>)

Neither is more correct. They answer different questions. A told story needs both, in a division of labour that never varies:

The **imperfect paints the scene** — what was going on, what things were like. The **preterite drops the events into it** — what then happened.

Llovía. Luego me levanté. — It was raining (*scene*). Then I got up (*event*).

English has no separate form for this, which is the only reason it feels hard. English leans on *was -ing* and *used to* and lets context carry the

rest. Spanish decided it once, in the ending.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the pair — “llovía” then “llovió”
- scene, then event — “Llovía. Luego me levanté.”
- “No corrí, porque llovía.” — the reason is a scene, the running an event
- “Comía pan porque llovía.”

Before you move on

What does *imperfectus* literally say, and which English word shares its second half? (**Not carried through; perfect** — and *fact, factory*.) In a story, which tense paints the background and which drops in the events? (**Imperfect** paints; **preterite** drops in.) Which of *llovía* and *llovió* has an edge on it? (**Llovió** — a thing that happened.)

167.4 contar — to tell a story, which is also to count it up

Three pieces are in your hands: *luego* to order events, *porque* to explain them, the imperfect to hold the background still. This lesson adds no fourth piece — it puts the three together, under the verb that names the act.

Sounds you'll need

- diphthong-ue — the stem breaks under stress: **cuento** = *KWEN-to*, but **contamos** stays plain.
- k-hard — *c* before *o* is a hard *k*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

contar means **to count** — and **to tell a story**. One verb, both jobs, and not a pun.

It descends from Latin *computāre*, “to reckon up”: *com-* (“together”) plus *putāre*, which meant “to prune”, then “to settle an account”, then simply “to reckon”. *Putāre* gives **amputate**, **dispute**, **deputy**; *computāre* gives **count**, **compute**, **account**.

English carries the same double sense — to **recount** an event, to give an **account** of yourself — but those are the very same word, borrowed through Old French from *computāre*. Spanish’s relatives, not an independent echo.

The independent echo is **tell**: Germanic, unrelated, and it *also* once meant “to count” — hence a bank **teller**, and *all told*. Two unrelated languages, one thought: **a story is a reckoning-up of events in order**.

Grammar Lens: the backbone of a told story

Contar breaks *o* to *ue* under stress:

person	form
yo	cuento
tú	cuentas
él/ella/usted	cuenta
nosotros	contamos
ellos/ustedes	cuentan

Here is the shape of a told story:

Llovía. Me **levanté**, luego **bebí** café. No **corrí**, **porque** **llovía** mucho. Me **senté** y **leí**.

>

It was raining. I got up, then I drank coffee. I didn't run, because it was raining hard. I sat down and read.

Watch the two pasts divide the work. **Llovía** — imperfect, holding the scene still. **Me levanté, bebí, me senté, leí** — preterite, dropping events in. *Luego* orders them; *porque* explains one.

That is a narration, and every word in it is one this book has taught you.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “cuento, cuentas, cuenta, contamos, cuentan”
- “Cuento hasta cinco.” — I count to five. Same verb.
- the scene, then the event — “Llovía. Luego me levanté.”
- the whole thing — “Llovía. Me levanté, luego bebí café. No corrí, porque llovía mucho.”
- “contar” then English “count, account, recount, teller”

Before you move on

Contar does two jobs — which two, and what Latin verb explains both? (**Count** and **tell**; *computāre*, “to reckon up”.) Which English word carries the same double sense? (**Recount** — or *an account*; and *tell* itself, as in a bank *teller*.) In your story, which tense held the rain and which one poured the coffee? (**Imperfect** *llovía*; **preterite** *bebí*.) Name the two joining words you used. (*Luego* for order, *porque* for reason.)

Chapter 168

Traer — Bringing, and Latin for Dragging

Modes: 🔄 voice (1) 🔄 Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I bring, and choose traer over llevar by where I am standing.

trahere, to drag - the root under tractor, attract and abstract.

168.1 traer — “to bring”, and the direction baked into it

Me levanto, and now *estoy de pie*. Up, and carrying something. The verb for that has a direction inside it that English leaves open.

Sounds you’ll need

- r-tap — one flick of the tongue: *tra-ER*, two beats.
- g-hard — the *g* of *traigo* is hard, as in English *go*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

traer (“to bring”) ← Latin **trahere**, “to drag, to pull”. Bringing started out as hauling.

Latin built a second stem, *tract-*, and English helped itself to both: **tractor**, **traction**, **attract**, **contract**, **subtract**, **extract**, **distract**,

retract — and **abstract**, *abs-* + *trahere*, something “dragged away” from anything particular.

Then the worn-down half, through French: **trace**, **train** (what is dragged along behind), **trail**, **portray** ← *prōtrahere*, “to draw forth”, and **retreat** ← *retrahere*, “to draw back”.

Grammar Lens: the hard g, for the second time

person	form
yo	traigo
tú	traes
él/ella/usted	trae
nosotros	traemos
ellos/ustedes	traen
<i>Oír</i> grew a hard -g- in <i>oigo</i> and nowhere else in its present. <i>Traer</i> does the identical thing: traigo , and then four ordinary <i>-er</i> endings. One club, two members so far, and neither one announces itself.	

Why it's said this way

English lets one verb wander: *bring me the bread, bring it to the café* — same word, opposite journeys. Spanish will not.

Traer moves a thing **toward you**. **Llevar** moves it **away**. *Traigo el pan* is the bread arriving here; *llevo el pan* is the bread leaving with me. You choose by where you are standing, never by what you are carrying. And **llevar** ← Latin **levāre**, “to raise” — the verb already behind *levantarse*. To carry a load was first to lift it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “traigo, traes, trae, traemos, traen”
- “Traigo el pan” then “Llevo el pan” — here, then away
- “oigo” then “traigo” — the same hard g
- “traer” then English “tractor, attract, abstract”

Before you move on

Which way does *traer* carry a thing, and which verb goes the other way? (**Toward you**; *llevar*.) What did *trahere* mean, and name two English words from it. (**To drag**; *tractor, attract, abstract, retreat*.) Which form of *traer* misbehaves, and which verb showed you that same misbehaviour first? (**Traigo**; *oigo*.) And say you are standing. (*Estoy de pie*.)

Chapter 169

Conseguir — Getting Is Following Until You Have It

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I get, and make the e-to-i stem change.

consequi, to follow after - the root of sequence and consequence.

169.1 conseguir — “to get”, by following a thing until you have it

Traigo carries a thing that is already yours. *Coger* grabs what is in front of you. This verb is for the getting that took some work.

Sounds you’ll need

- **g-hard** — the *gu* in *consequir* is one hard *g*; the *u* is silent.
- **s-clear** — a clean hissing *s*: *con-se-GEER*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

consequir (“to get, to obtain, to manage to”) ← Latin **cōnsequī**: *com-* (“along with”) + **sequī**, “to follow”. You got a thing by following it until it was yours.

Sequī is one of Latin’s great English suppliers: **sequence**, **sequel**, **consequence**, **subsequent**, **consecutive**; **second**, from *secundus*,

“the one following”; **execute** and **prosecute**; **obsequious**, following someone about; and through French, **pursue**, **ensue** and **suit**. Spanish also keeps the formal partner **obtener** ← *obtinēre*, “to hold onto” — English **obtain**. It behaves exactly like *tener*, so its *yo*-form is *obtengo*. *Conseguir* is the everyday one.

Grammar Lens: the third crack, and a silent u that leaves

person	form
yo	consigo
tú	consigues
él/ella/usted	consigue
nosotros	conseguimos
ellos/ustedes	consiguen

You have met *dormir* breaking **o**→**ue** and *pido* quietly breaking **e**→**i**. Here is that third pattern in full: stress on the stem turns *e* into *i*, and *conseguimos* stays plain because the stress moved to the ending. Now the spelling. Spanish writes *gu* only to keep a *g* hard in front of *e* and *i*. Once the *e* becomes *i*, there is nothing in front to guard against, so the *u* has no job and goes: **consigo**, not *consiguo*. Two changes, one form, and only one of them is a sound.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “consigo, consigues, consigue, conseguimos, consiguen”
- “Traigo el café” then “Consigo el café” — carried, then obtained
- “sequi, sequence, second” then “conseguir”

Before you move on

What did *sequi* mean, and name two English words from it. (**To follow**; *sequence*, *second*, *consequence*, *pursue*.) Why is it *consigo* and not *consiguo*? (The *u* only guards a hard *g* before *e* and *i*.) Name the three stem cracks you now have, with a verb for each. (*Cerrar* **e**→**ie**, *dormir* **o**→**ue**, *conseguir* **e**→**i**.) And which Latin verb is behind *traer*? (**Trahere**.)

Chapter 170

Jugar — Playing Was Joking

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I play, with the only u-to-ue verb in Spanish.

iocari, to joke - and Latin's own play-verb ludere left Spanish entirely.

170.1 jugar — “to play”, and the only verb of its kind

Consigo cracked its *e* to *i*. Here is a verb that cracks a vowel no other verb in Spanish cracks — and it started life as a joke.

Sounds you'll need

- j-jota — the *j* is scraped at the back of the throat: *khoo-GAR*.
- diphthong-ue — *juego* is three beats, *KHWE-go*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

jugar (“to play”) ← Latin **iocārī**, “to joke, to jest”, built on the noun **iocus**, “a joke”. Playing and joking were one word, and Spanish kept the joking one for both.

English holds *iocus* in several shapes: **joke**; through French **jocular**; **juggler**, from *ioculātor*, an entertainer; and **jeopardy**, from Old French *jeu parti*, “an evenly divided game” — a position so balanced that either side might lose. The Spanish family stays close: **el juego**, a

game; **el juguete**, a toy.

Why it's said this way

Latin's ordinary word for playing was **lūdere**, and Spanish dropped it exactly as it dropped *claudere* for shutting doors. English kept the whole family instead: **illusion**, **allude**, **elude**, **delude**, **collude**, **prelude**, **interlude**, **ludicrous**.

Claudere and *lūdere* tell one story: the large English family belongs to the Latin verb Spanish walked away from.

Grammar Lens: the fourth crack, with one member

person	form
yo	juego
tú	juegas
él/ella/usted	juega
nosotros	jugamos
ellos/ustedes	juegan

Dormir breaks **o→ue**. *Jugar* breaks **u→ue**, and it is the **only verb in Spanish that does**: the *o* of *iocārī* had already slid irregularly to *u*, so the crack landed on a vowel no other verb offers. *Jugamos* stays plain, because the stress moves to the ending.

One more habit: Spanish plays **at** a thing rather than simply playing it. *El fútbol* is football, and you say *juego al fútbol*, with *a + el* fused into *al*. With a companion rather than a game it is *con*: *juego con el perro*, I play with the dog.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “juego, juegas, juega, jugamos, juegan”
- “Juego con el perro”
- “duermo” then “juego” — o to ue, then u to ue
- “iocus, joke, jocular, juggler”

Before you move on

What did *iocārī* mean, and which English words carry it? (**To joke**; *joke, jocular, juggler, jeopardy*.) What is unusual about *juego* among Spanish verbs? (**U→ue**, and no other verb does it.) Which two Latin verbs did Spanish drop while English kept their families? (*Claudere* and *lūdere*.) And which vowel does *conseguir* break? (**E to i**.)

Chapter 171

Conocer — Coming to Know

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say who and what I am acquainted with, and choose *conocer* over *saber*.

cognoscere, whose *-sc-* means *BEGIN to know*; English *know* is its Germanic sibling.

171.1 *conocer* — “to meet”, because knowing has a first moment

Juego — the one *u*→*ue* in the language. Now the chapter’s last verb, and its oddity is not in the vowel but in what the word means.

Sounds you’ll need

- **soft-c** — *conoces* has a soft second *c*: a *th* in Spain, an *s* elsewhere.
- **k-hard** — but *conozco* is *ko-NOTH-ko*, soft then hard, back to back.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

conocer ← Latin **cognōscere**, *com-* + *(g)nōscere*. Its *-sc-* is Latin’s “**begin to**” marker, so *nōscere* was never “to know” — it was “**to come to know**”. Latin said *nōvī*, “I have come to know”, for actually knowing a thing.

Spanish built its verb from the *beginning* half. That is the whole lesson: *conocer a alguien* is **to meet** someone, and Spanish puts a small **a** before a person who is the object — *conozco a María*. The root fills English: **cognition**, **recognize**, **incognito**, and through French **notice**, **notion**, **notorious** and **noble**, “the knowable one”. English **know** and **ken** are its Germanic siblings — the same standing that *padre* has beside English *father*, neither one borrowed from the other.

Grammar Lens: conocer and saber

what you know	verb
a person, a city, a book	conocer
a fact, or how to do something	saber

English says *know* for both. Spanish will not: **conocer** is being **acquainted** — you have met the thing. **Saber** is having the information. *Conozco Madrid* means I have been there; *sé dónde está* means I have the fact.

The *yo*-form keeps a hard cluster the rest lost: **conozco**, **conoces**, **conoce**, **conocemos**, **conocen**. Every *-cer* verb after a vowel does the same, and it is a third kind of odd *yo*-form beside *traigo* and *oigo*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “conozco, conoces, conoce, conocemos, conocen”
- “Conozco a María” then “Conozco Madrid”
- “traigo, consigo, juego, conozco” — the chapter’s four *yo*-forms
- “padre, father” then “conocer, know” — siblings, not borrowings

Before you move on

Say the chapter’s four verbs in the *yo*, then say what each one does to itself. (*Traigo* grows a hard *g*; *consigo* breaks *e*→*i* and loses a silent *u*; *juego* breaks *u*→*ue*, alone in the language; *conozco* keeps a hard cluster.) Name their four Latin roots and what each meant. (**Trahere** to drag, **cōnsequī** to follow, **iocārī** to joke, **cognōscere**

to begin to know.) Which verb do you use for a person, and which for a fact? (*Conocer*; *saber*.) And which of the four moves a thing toward you? (*Traer* — *llevar* goes away.)

Chapter 172

Review — All Four Stem Changes

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can name all four stem-change patterns and the single verb that owns one of them.

The system closes at four - and u-to-ue has exactly one member.

172.1 Review — the four stem changes, all of them

Nothing new in this chapter. Say a verb whose stem breaks under stress — any one you have met.

What you've built

Something finished in the last two chapters and it is worth stopping for. Spanish has **four** stem-change patterns. Not five, not a dozen — four. You met the first two long ago with *querer* and *poder*, and the last two in the chapters you have just finished. That is the whole system, and you now hold all of it:

the change	the verb that taught it	what breaks
e → ie	<i>querer</i>	→ <i>quiero</i>
o → ue	<i>poder</i>	→ <i>puedo</i>
e → i	<i>conseguir</i>	→ <i>consigo</i>
u → ue	<i>jugar</i>	→ <i>juego</i>

This table is allowed here because every row in it is something you can

already do. It is a picture of the ground you hold, not a list to memorise.

Grammar Lens: the pattern with one member

The fourth row is strange, and worth knowing precisely.

u → ue happens in exactly one verb in the entire language:

jugar.

Not “mostly one.” One. Every other Spanish verb with a *u* in its stem leaves it alone. So you are not learning a pattern here so much as a single fact with a pattern’s shape — which is easier, not harder, and is the kind of thing a course should tell you instead of letting you brace for more.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- one verb from each of the four rows
- the four changes themselves, as sounds — *e-ie*, *o-ue*, *e-i*, *u-ue*

Twice through: Until naming the pattern is faster than working it out.

Before you move on

How many stem-change patterns are there? (**Four** — and that is all of them.) Which one has a single member? (**u → ue**, only *jugar*.)

Next chapter is not about forms at all — it is about three places where English gives you one word and Spanish makes you choose.

Chapter 173

Synthesis — The Choices English Never Makes You Make

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can choose correctly between three verb pairs where English offers only one word.

preguntar/pedir, traer/llevar, conocer/saber - the decision carries the meaning.

173.1 Synthesis — the choices English never makes you make

Nothing new here. Two verbs to say aloud first: *traer, conocer*.

Grammar Lens: one English word, two Spanish verbs

Three times now you have met a pair of verbs where English makes do with one. They arrived chapters apart and have never been put side by side:

English gives you	Spanish makes you choose	the question you must answer
to ask	<i>preguntar · pedir</i>	asking a question , or asking for a thing ?
to bring / take	<i>traer · llevar</i>	toward the speaker, or away?
to know	<i>conocer · saber</i>	a person or place , or a fact ?
None of these is a vocabulary problem. In each one, the word is easy and the decision is the work — and the decision is information English speakers are simply never required to supply.		

What you've built

When you pick *traer* over *llevar*, you have told your listener **where you are standing**. When you pick *conocer* over *saber*, you have told them whether you have *met* the thing or only heard of it. The grammar is carrying meaning that English would need a whole clause to add. You are not translating any more. You are choosing.

The exchange

— ¿**Conoces** Madrid? — Sí, **conozco** Madrid. Pero no **sé** dónde está el café.

Two “knows” in two lines, and not interchangeable. The first is acquaintance — *I have been there*. The second is a fact. English uses **know** for both and loses the difference.

Your turn

- *Say it*: the exchange above, both parts

Twice through: Until the choice happens before you notice making it.

Before you move on

What does choosing *traer* tell your listener? (**Where you are standing**.) What does choosing *conocer* tell them? (That you have **met** it, not just heard of it.) And which of the three pairs did you

learn first? (*Preguntar* and *pedir* — long before the other two.)

Chapter 174

Waiting, Answering, Buying

Modes: 🗣️ voice (3) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say I wait, answer and buy in Spanish — three verbs whose endings never surprise me — and I know that *esperar* alone carries wait, hope and expect, so context does the work English hands to three separate verbs.

*Run **espero**, **contesto** and **compro** — three verbs that break nothing, whose whole difficulty is meaning — and give each root and its sense: **spērāre** to hope, **contestārī** to call witnesses, **comparāre** to procure. Refuse the lookalike: English **compare** descends from a different Latin **comparāre** built on **compār**, so it is not a relative. Then buy — **compro el pan, el vino y un café, por favor** — and reach back for what **pānis** gave **compañero**, which English words **vīnum** reached, why **café** is masculine, and what **por favor** says word for word.*

174.1 **esperar** — one verb for waiting, hoping and expecting

Four verbs that each did something odd to themselves — *juego* the strangest of them. Here is one that does nothing odd at all, and is still the hardest word in these two chapters.

Sounds you'll need

- **st-no-e** — the *e-* is a run-up: *es-pe-RAR*, never *spe-*.
- **r-tap** — one flick for the *r* in the middle.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

esperar ← Latin **spērāre**, “to hope”, from **spēs**, “hope”. That front *e-* is the same run-up that turned *scribere* into *escribir* and *studēre* into *estudiar*: Spanish will not start a word with *s* plus a consonant. English took the root by its negative: **despair** ← **dēspērāre**, *dē-* + *spērāre* — literally **to un-hope** — and with it **desperate**, and **desperado**, which English shaped from Spanish *desesperado*. **Prosper** is traditionally read as *prō* + *spēs*, “according to one’s hope”, though that reading is the traditional one rather than a settled one. Spanish keeps the hope in plain sight: **la esperanza**. So does **Esperanto** — its inventor published as *Doktoro Esperanto*, “Doctor One-Who-Hopes”.

Grammar Lens: three English verbs, one Spanish word

Spanish	what it means
Espero a María	I am waiting for María
Espero el pan	I am expecting the bread
Espero que sí	I hope so

One verb, three English words, and nothing in the Spanish tells them apart. Context does all of it, and a learner has to stop translating and start reading the situation. *Hope* and *expect* were never far from waiting: to wait for a thing is to think it is coming.

Note the small **a** before a person, the same one that stands in *conozco a María*. And after three chapters of cracking stems, *esperar* is perfectly regular: **espero, esperas, espera, esperamos, esperan**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “espero, esperas, espera, esperamos, esperan”
- “Espero a María” then “Espero el pan” then “Espero que sí”
- “spērāre, esperanza” then English “despair, desperate”

Before you move on

Give the three English verbs *esperar* covers. (**Wait, hope, expect.**) What does *dēspērāre* take apart into? (*Dē-* + *spērāre*, **to un-hope.**) Name two other Spanish verbs whose *e-* is a run-up, with their Latin roots. (*Escribir* ← *scribere*, *estudiar* ← *studēre*.) Would you use *conocer* or *saber* for a city? (*Conocer*.) And what did the *-sc-* inside *cognōscere* mark? (**Beginning** — to *come* to know.)

174.2 contestar — “to answer”, from a Roman courtroom

Pregunto pushes the pole down to sound the water. *Espero* waits. Now the other half of a conversation — and a word that began as an oath.

Sounds you’ll need

- **s-clear** — a clean *s* in the middle: *con-tes-TAR*.
- **stress-final** — the beat lands on the last syllable, with no written accent.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

contestar (“to answer”) ← Latin **contestārī**, “to call witnesses”: *com-* + *testārī*, from **testis**, “a witness”. In Roman law, *contestārī litem* was the formal opening of a lawsuit — both sides calling their witnesses so the argument could begin.

From that one act the two languages walked in opposite directions.

English kept the fight: to *contest* a thing is to dispute it. **Spanish kept the reply** — first “say back what the other side said”, then simply *answer*.

The *testis* family is shared: **testify, testimony, testament, attest, protest, detest.**

Grammar Lens: contestar and responder

Spanish has a second answering verb, and it is built on a different promise.

responder ← Latin **respondēre**, *re-* + **spondēre**, “to pledge

solemnly”. Answering is pledging *back*. English holds that whole branch: **respond**, **response**, **responsible**, **sponsor**, and **spouse**, from *spōnsus*, “one who has been pledged”.

verb	where it lives
contestar	the everyday one: a question, the phone, a letter
responder	weightier — responding <i>to</i> something

Both are regular, one *-ar* and one *-er*: **contesto**, **contestas**, **contesta**, **contestamos**, **contestan**; **respondo**, **respondes**, **responde**. The noun is the odd part: the answer is **la respuesta**, borrowed from *responder*, never from *contestar*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “contesto, contestas, contesta, contestamos, contestan”
- “Te pregunto la hora y me contestas”
- “testis, testify, contest” then “contestar”

Before you move on

What did *contestārī* mean literally, and what did English make of it? (**To call witnesses**; *contest*.) What does *respondēre* take apart into? (*Re-* + *spondēre*, **to pledge back**.) Which verb asks for information and which asks for a thing? (*Preguntar*; *pedir*.) And name the three English verbs inside *esperar*. (**Wait, hope, expect**.)

174.3 comprar — “to buy”, and a cousin that is not one

You can ask, answer and wait. Now pay for the bread, with a verb whose obvious English relative turns out to be a stranger.

Sounds you'll need

- **pr-cluster** — *-pr-* is one beat: *kom-PRAR*, never *kom-pe-rar*.
- **vowel-o** — a short pure *o*, with no glide toward *ow*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

comprar (“to buy”) ← Latin **comparāre**: *com-* + **parāre**, “to make ready, to furnish, to procure”. Latin already used it for buying — you procured a thing — and the middle syllable wore away, *comparāre* to *comprar*.

Parāre stocked English well: **prepare, repair, apparatus, apparel, separate, parade, and emperor**, from *imperāre*, “to give orders”. Spanish keeps *preparar*, and *parar*, “to stop”.

That *com-* is the same one already inside *compañero* — “the one you share bread with” — and inside *conseguir, conocer* and *contestar*.

Why it's said this way

English **compare** looks like the obvious relative. It is not one. Latin had **two** verbs spelled *comparāre*. One is *com-* + *parāre*, “procure”, and Spanish *comprar* comes from it. The other is built on **compār**, “equal, matched”, and means “to set side by side” — that is the one English *compare* comes from. Two different words that fell together in spelling.

Comprender is a stranger too: it is *comprehendere*, “to seize together”. Same prefix, unrelated second halves. A resemblance is a question, never an answer.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “compro, compras, compra, compramos, compran”
- “Compro el pan y el vino”
- “Un café, por favor”
- “parāre, prepare, repair” then “comprar”

Before you move on

Run the chapter: *espero*, *contesto*, *compro* — three verbs that break nothing, whose difficulty is meaning. Give each root and what it meant. (**Spērāre** to hope, **contestārī** to call witnesses, **comparāre** to procure.) Is English *compare* a relative of *comprar*? (**No** — a different Latin *comparāre*, built on *compār*, “equal”.) Now buy: *compro el pan*, *el vino y un café*, *por favor* — then say what *pānīs* gave *compañero*, which English words *vīnum* reached, why *café* is masculine, and what *por favor* is word for word. (**One who shares bread**; *wine*, *vine*, *vinegar*; *café* arrived as a masculine loan out of Arabic *qahwa*; “for a favour”.) And which verb gets a thing by following it? (*Conseguir*.)

Chapter 175

Saying Why

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can give a reason for what I think and what I plan — stating an opinion with *creo que*, running forward to its consequence with *así que*, and naming an obligation with *debo*.

Answer *¿Por qué no corres?* in four moves — *Creo que llueve. No corro porque llueve, así que leo. Debo estudiar. Opinion, cause, consequence, obligation, each with its own word, and every word in it taught by this book.*

175.1 creer — to put your heart somewhere

You have **pensar** — to think, and underneath it *pēnsāre*, “to weigh”. Spanish has a second verb for the inside of your head, and it does a different job. Where *pensar* weighs, this one commits.

Sounds you’ll need

- **hiatus-ee** — the two *e*’s do not merge: **creer** = *kreh-EHR*, two beats.
- **r-tap** — a single flick, not the rolled *rr*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

creer = “to believe”, and in everyday use “to think” in the sense of *hold an opinion*.

It comes from Latin *crēdere*, “to entrust, to believe” — and *crēdere* is a compound so old that Latin had already forgotten it was one. It is PIE **kred-d^heh₁-*: “to put **kred-*”.

What is that first half? Traditionally, the **heart** word — the root of Latin *cor*, *cordis* and of English **heart**. Be honest that the step is **disputed**: that root normally appears as **kē̃r*, never **kred-*. The compound is not in doubt; only what it was built on.

Taking the traditional reading:

from *crēdere*

from *cor*, *cordis*

credit, creed, credo

cordial, courage

credential, incredible

record, accord, discord

To **record** is to bring something back to the *cor* — for a Roman the seat of **memory**, not of feeling. To have **courage** is to have heart.

Grammar Lens: *creer que*

Creer almost always drags a **que** behind it, and then a whole clause:

Creo que llueve.

I think it’s raining.

Creo que hace frío.

I think it’s cold.

No creo que llueva.

I don’t think it’s raining.

Look hard at that third row. *Creo que llueve* — but *no creo que llueva*. Negating *creer* flips the clause into the **subjunctive** from chapter eighteen: stop vouching for something and Spanish stops using the tense that states facts.

Pienso is the weighing; *creo* is where it landed. Treat that as a way to feel the difference, not a rule — both take *que* and a clause, and a speaker may use either. But *creo que* is the ordinary opening for an opinion.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “creer” — *kreh-EHR*, two beats, not one
- “Creo que llueve.”
- the pair — “pienso” (I weigh) then “creo” (I hold)

- “creer” then English “credit, creed, cordial, record”

Before you move on

What shape is *crēdere*, under the surface? (**A compound** — **kred-* + *d^heh₁-*, “to put **kred-*”.) What is the traditional reading of that first half, and why hedge it? (**Heart** — but the heart root is **kêr*, never **kred-*, so the step is disputed.) *Pensar* weighs; what does *creer* do? (It **lands** — it holds the opinion the weighing produced.)

175.2 *así que* — “so”, and a word you have been saying since yes

Porque runs from a claim back to its reason. This runs the other way — from the reason forward to what follows. Same two facts, opposite arrow, and you need both to explain anything.

Sounds you’ll need

- **s-clear** — a clean hiss in *así*, never a *z* buzz.
- **k-hard** — *qu* is a plain *k*; the *u* is silent.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

así = “so, thus, in that way”. **así que** = “so, and therefore”.

Así is Latin *sīc*, “thus” — with an *a-* that Spanish added later, the same one it put on *apenas* and *afuera*. And you have met *sīc* before: it is the whole of Spanish **sí**, “yes”. Latin *sīc* meant “thus, in this way”, and saying *thus* in answer to a question is how a language gets a word for yes.

So *sí* and *así* are the same Latin adverb, one bare and one with the *a-* attached. English borrowed it raw and never translated it: **sic**, the mark an editor puts after a quoted mistake — “thus it stood”.

Grammar Lens: the two arrows

The pair is worth drilling as a pair, because they carry the same two facts in opposite orders:

No corro porque llueve.	I'm not running because it's raining.
Llueve, así que no corro.	It's raining, so I'm not running.
<i>Porque</i> points backwards to the cause. <i>Así que</i> points forwards to the consequence. Which you reach for depends only on which fact you want to say first — and that is a choice about emphasis, not about grammar.	
Hace frío, así que bebo café.	It's cold, so I drink coffee.
Creo que llueve, así que leo.	I think it's raining, so I read.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “sí” then “así” — the same Latin word, one with an *a-* on the front
- “Llueve, así que no corro.”
- the same two facts the other way — “No corro porque llueve.”
- “Creo que hace frío, así que bebo café.”

Before you move on

Which Latin adverb is hiding in both *sí* and *así*? (*Sīc*, “thus”.) Which way does *porque* point, and which way *así que*? (*Porque backwards* to the cause; *así que forwards* to the consequence.) What does an editor's *sic* mean? (**Thus it stood** — the same word, borrowed whole.)

175.3 deber — to owe, and therefore to ought

You can now say what you think and what follows from it. This verb adds the third move in any explanation: what somebody **ought** to do about it. It gets there from an unexpected direction — money.

Sounds you'll need

- **b-soft** — between vowels the *b* softens: **deber** = *deh-BEHR*.
- **r-tap** — one flick at the end, not a roll.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

deber does two jobs: “to owe”, and “ought to, should”.

Latin *dēbēre* explains both, because it is a compound: *dē-* (“from”) plus *habēre* (“to have”). To *dēbēre* something is **to have it from someone** — which is exactly what owing is. You are holding what is theirs.

English helped itself to this verb four times over — three of them from the participle *dēbitum* rather than the verb — and the spellings record each route:

English	how it came
debt	through French, then re-spelled to show the Latin <i>b</i>
debit	straight from Latin bookkeeping
due	through French <i>deü</i> , the <i>b</i> worn away
duty	built on <i>due</i>

One more came the long way round, and not by borrowing. French turned *dēbēre* into *devoir*, “duty”. English **translated** the phrase *mettre en devoir* — to put oneself under an obligation — half-way, as *put in dever*, and the last two words later fused into **endeavour**.

Grammar Lens: debo + infinitive

Deber is regular, and for “ought to” it takes a bare infinitive straight after it — no *que*, no preposition:

person	form
yo	debo
tú	debes
él/ella/usted	debe
nosotros	debemos
ellos/ustedes	deben

Debo estudiar. — I ought to study. **Llueve, así que debo leer.** —

It's raining, so I ought to read.

The obligation is softer than a command and firmer than a wish, which is the register an explanation usually wants.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “debo, debes, debe, debemos, deben”
- “Debo trabajar.”
- “Hace frío, así que debo beber café.”
- “Creo que llueve, así que debo leer.”
- “deber” then English “debt, debit, due, duty”

Before you move on

What two Latin pieces build *dēbēre*, and what do they say together? (*Dē-* + *habēre* — “to have **from** someone”, which is owing.) Name two of the four English words it became. (Any of **debt**, **debit**, **due**, **duty**.) What follows *debo* — a *que*, or a bare infinitive? (**A bare infinitive**: *debo estudiar*.)

175.4 explicar — to unfold

Three pieces are in your hands: *creo que* to state an opinion, *así que* to run forward to what follows, *debo* to say what ought to happen. This lesson puts all three in a row, under the verb that names the act.

Sounds you'll need

- **k-hard** — *c* before *a* is a hard *k*: **explicar** = *eks-plee-KAR*.
- **l-clear** — a clean *l* in the *pl*, no vowel slipped in between.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

explicar = Latin *explicāre*: *ex-* (“out”) + *plicāre* (“to fold”). **To explain is to unfold** — something was folded shut, and you open it. *Plicāre* is one of the great suppliers of English. Some came from Latin directly, some through French, and the sound changed on the way:

straight from Latin	through French
explicate	explicit, application
complicated (<i>com-</i> + fold)	employ, deploy
duplicate	display — a doublet of <i>deploy</i>

And **simple** is *sim-plex* — “one-fold”. Something simple has been folded only once. Something **complicated** has been folded *together*, over and over, which is why it needs unfolding. The metaphor is consistent all the way down, and Spanish keeps it in the plainest verb of the set.

Grammar Lens: the shape of an explanation

Explicar is regular — it takes the plain *-ar* endings of *hablar*, with no stem change at all: **explico, explicas, explica, explicamos, explican**. (*Contar*, which you met earlier, breaks its *o* to *ue*; this one does not, and there is nothing to remember.)

Here is a whole explanation, with every piece something this book has taught:

— ¿Por qué no corres? — **Creo que** llueve. No corro **porque** llueve, **así que** leo. **Debo** estudiar.

>

— *Why aren't you running?* — *I think it's raining. I'm not running because it's raining, so I read. I ought to study.*

Four moves, four words: an **opinion** (*creo que*), a **cause** (*porque*), a **consequence** (*así que*), an **obligation** (*debo*). That is what an explanation is made of, and you can now build one in either direction — cause first or claim first — because *porque* and *así que* let you choose.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “explico, explicas, explica, explicamos, explican”
- “Explico bien.” — I explain well.
- the four moves — “Creo que llueve, porque hace frío, así que debo leer.”
- “explicar” then English “explicit, complicated, simple, display”

Before you move on

What does *explicāre* literally say? (**To fold out** — *ex-* + *plicāre*.) What is *simple*, folded? (**Once** — *sim-plex*; *complicated* is folded together, again and again.) Name the four moves of an explanation and the word for each. (Opinion **creo que**, cause **porque**, consequence **así que**, obligation **debo**.)

Chapter 176

Para — For, Pointing Forward

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can use para for a destination, a deadline, a recipient or a purpose.

Complete ES-C51-para: produce para ti and para mañana, and name the Latin piece inside para that means toward.

176.1 para — “for,” pointing forward

English has one word, *for*, doing about ten jobs. Spanish splits them between two words, and most courses hand you a list of twelve rules. You are getting one idea instead, and this chapter is half of it.

Grammar Lens: the arrow points away from you

para — *for*, when something is **aimed at** something else.

*Es **para** ti.* — It’s for you. (*aimed at a person*) **Para** mañana. — By tomorrow. (*aimed at a moment*) *Hago la comida **para** la casa.* — I make the meal for the house. (*aimed at a purpose*)

Destination, deadline, recipient, purpose. They look like four different rules and they are one: **something is heading toward something else**. Draw an arrow from the thing to its target, and if the arrow makes sense, the word is *para*.

That is the whole of this chapter. Not four uses — one direction.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The direction is not a mnemonic somebody invented. It is **inside the word**.

Para was Latin **per** + **ad**, squeezed into one word. And *ad* means “**toward**” — it is the same *ad* sitting at the front of English **advance**, **admit**, **adhere**, **address**, all of which are about moving or pointing at something.

So *para* is, at the bottom, “through-toward.” A word that is literally made of an arrow.

Once you have that, you do not have to remember which of the twelve textbook uses of *para* is which. You have to ask one question: **is this pointing at something?**

Your turn

- *Say it*: “para ti”, “para mañana”, “para la casa” — draw the arrow each time

Before you move on

What one question decides *para*? (**Is it pointing at something?**)

What is inside the word? (***Ad*** — “toward.”) Next: the other half — and you have been saying it since your first chapter.

Chapter 177

Por — And Three Phrases You Already Owned

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can use *por* for a cause, a route or an exchange, and say what *por* favor literally means.

Complete ES-C51-por: say what por favor literally means and name the English word that is the per inside por.

177.1 *por* — and you already know three of these

Say “please.” (*Por favor.*) Say “why.” (*¿Por qué?*) Say “because.” (*Porque.*) You have been carrying this word since your first page and nobody has told you what it means.

Grammar Lens: the arrow points back, or through

por — *for*, when something is the **cause**, the **route**, or what is given **in exchange**.

*Gracias **por** la comida.* — Thanks **for** the meal. (*the cause*) **Por** ti. — Because of you. (*the cause*)

Where *para* pointed forward at a target, *por* points **back at a reason** or **through a middle** — what something came through, not what it heads toward.

Now look again at the three phrases you already own:

- **por favor** — literally *by way of a favour*. You are not aiming at a favour; you are asking **through** one.
- **¿por qué?** — literally *through what?* — that is, **caused by what?**
- **porque** — the same two words fused into an answer: *because*.

Three of your oldest phrases turn out to be the same preposition, doing exactly what this chapter says it does. You knew *por* before you knew *hola* meant anything.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Por is two Latin words run together: **pro** (“in front of, on behalf of”) and **per** (“through”).

The *per* half is still alive and unchanged in English, in the least poetic corner of the language:

- **per hour, per person, per cent** — *cent* being *hundred*, so literally **through each hundred**.
- **percolate, permeate, perforate** — all piercing *through*.

English kept *per* meaning “through” and Spanish kept it inside *por*. Saying *por favor*, you are using the same word as *miles per hour*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “por favor”, “¿por qué?”, “porque” — three old friends, one word
- “Gracias por la comida”

Before you move on

Which direction does *por* point? (**Back at a cause**, or **through** something.) What is *por favor* literally? (**By way of a favour**.) Which English word is the *per* inside it? (**Per**, as in *per hour*.) Next: the two side by side.

Chapter 178

Which Way Is the Arrow Pointing?

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can choose between *por* and *para* with one question instead of a list of rules.

Complete ES-C51-la-flecha: contrast *para ti* with *por ti* and state the arrow test.

178.1 Which way is the arrow pointing?

One points forward at a target. One points back at a cause. Say which is which before you read on.

Grammar Lens: the same sentence, twice

The pair that makes the difference visible:

*Lo hago **para** ti.* — I'm doing it **for** you. (*you receive it*)

*Lo hago **por** ti.* — I'm doing it **because of** you. (*you are the reason*)

Two letters apart, and two different sentences about your relationship with somebody. The first is a gift; the second is a motive.

English says *for* in both and lets context carry the rest. Spanish makes you choose, and once you hear the choice you notice English was hiding it.

The test:

Draw an arrow. Does it point at the thing (*para*),

or come from it (*por*)?

- *Es para ti* — arrow **at** you. You get it.
- *Es por ti* — arrow **from** you. You caused it.

That is the whole rung: one arrow, two directions.

Why it's said this way

The test works because it is not a trick. It is what the two words are made of: *para* contains **ad** (“toward”), *por* contains **per** (“through”). You are not memorising which preposition suits which situation. You are reading a direction built into each word before Spanish existed. That keeps working on uses this book never showed you: meeting *por* in an unfamiliar sentence, ask what it comes **through** or **because of**.

Your turn

- *Say it*: “Lo hago para ti” then “Lo hago por ti” — two letters, two relationships

Twice through: Until the arrow arrives before the word does.

Before you move on

Para ti — who gets it? (**You do.**) *Por ti* — who caused it? (**You did.**) And why does the test keep working on sentences this book never showed you? (Because the directions are **inside the words.**) Next: both in one place.

Chapter 179

Review — One Arrow

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can state both directions and place my old por phrases under them.

Complete ES-C51-repaso-flecha: give both directions, name three old phrases containing por, and say what it means when a sentence takes either.

179.1 Review — one arrow

Nothing new. One question before the table: which way does each preposition point?

What you've built

	para — toward	por — through, because
built from	<i>ad</i> , “toward”	<i>per</i> , “through”
the arrow	points at it	comes from it
a person	<i>para ti</i> — you get it	<i>por ti</i> — you caused it
a time	<i>para mañana</i> — by then	—
thanks	—	<i>gracias por</i> — for what caused it
asking	—	<i>por favor</i> — through a favour
asking why	—	<i>¿por qué?</i> — through what?

Look at the right-hand column. Four of those six *por* entries are phrases you have owned since the opening chapters. This review is not mostly teaching you new Spanish — it is **re-filing old Spanish under a heading that explains it**.

That happens more than a course usually admits. A great deal of what looks like new grammar late in a book is a name for something you have been doing correctly and blindly for a long time.

Grammar Lens: what to do when you are unsure

You will still hesitate sometimes. Two things help, in this order:

1. **Ask what the sentence is about.** A destination, a deadline, a recipient, a purpose — *para*. A cause, a route, a swap, a duration — *por*. 2. **If it is genuinely both, it is genuinely both.** *Lo hago para ti* and *lo hago por ti* are both good Spanish; you are not choosing right from wrong, you are choosing which thing to say.

That second point matters more than it looks. Most *por/para* anxiety comes from believing every sentence has one correct answer waiting to be found. Plenty of sentences take either, and the choice is the meaning.

Your turn

- *Say it*: “para ti / por ti”, “para mañana”, “gracias por la comida”

Twice through:

Before you move on

Para — which way? (**At** it.) *Por* — which way? (**From** it.) And when a sentence takes either? (**Both are right** — the choice is the meaning.) Next: the two of them in a conversation, where the choice does real work.

Chapter 180

Synthesis — The Gift and the Motive

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can change the meaning of a sentence by choosing between *por* and *para*.

Complete ES-C51-sintesis-regalo-motivo: say the dinner sentence both ways and say what a wrong choice actually produces.

180.1 Synthesis — the gift and the motive

Para ti or *por ti* — one of them is a present and one of them is a reason. Which is which?

The exchange

Read this twice, changing only one word.

— *Hago la comida **para** ti.* — *Gracias.*

— *Hago la comida **por** ti.* — *...gracias.*

The first is somebody cooking you dinner. The second is somebody telling you they are cooking **because of** you — which, depending on the day, is an act of love or a small complaint.

Two letters. Nothing else in the sentence moved.

Grammar Lens: a preposition carrying the feeling

This is the first place in the book where **the smallest word in the sentence carries its emotional content**.

Nouns and verbs have been doing the meaning until now. Here the noun is the same, the verb is the same, the person is the same — and the sentence changes completely on a preposition. That is worth meeting deliberately, because English speakers arrive expecting the little words to be plumbing.

They are not plumbing here. *Por* and *para* are the difference between *I made this for you* and *I made this because of you*, and no amount of context repairs the wrong one: your listener will simply hear the thing you did not mean.

Which is also the reassuring part. If you pick the wrong one, you have not produced nonsense or bad grammar — you have said something true about a different situation. Somebody will look faintly puzzled, and you will notice, and that is how this stops being difficult.

Your turn

- *Say it*: both versions of the dinner sentence, and hear the second one land differently

Twice through:

Before you move on

Para ti — a gift or a reason? (A **gift**.) *Por ti*? (A **reason**.) And what happens if you choose wrong? (You say something **true about a different situation** — and somebody will look puzzled, which is how you learn it.)

Chapter 181

Se Habla Espanol — Nobody in Particular

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can read and use the impersonal *se*, where no person is named.

Complete ES-C52-se-habla: write the sign and say who is doing the speaking.

181.1 se habla español — nobody in particular

Se llama — “he calls himself.” You have had that *se* since your third chapter. Here it is doing something you have seen on signs and never been able to parse.

Grammar Lens: a sentence with nobody in it

Se habla español. — Spanish is spoken here. *Se come bien.* — One eats well here. / The food is good.

Look for the person doing it. There is not one, and there is not meant to be. *Se habla español* does not tell you **who** speaks Spanish — it tells you that Spanish gets spoken, and that is the entire content. English has to work harder to be that vague. It reaches for a passive (“Spanish is spoken”), or a fake subject (“**they** speak Spanish here”, “**you** eat well there”), and neither is quite honest, because there is no *they* and no *you*.

Spanish just... leaves the person out. **The *se* is the mark that says**

nobody is being named.

This is why it is the natural voice of signs, notices and rules: *se habla español, se prohíbe fumar, no se aceptan tarjetas*. A sign is not addressed by anyone to anyone. It simply reports that something is the case.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Se habla español” as if reading it off a window
- “Se come bien”

Before you move on

Se habla español — who is speaking? (**Nobody named** — that is the point.) What does the *se* mark? (That **no person is being named**.) Next: why this form grew out of the one you already knew.

Chapter 182

Se Compran Libros — The Verb Tells On Itself

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can make the verb agree with the thing, and say why it does.

Complete ES-C52-se-venden: produce *se compran libros* and read it as if *se* still meant themselves.

182.1 se compran libros — the verb tells on itself

Se habla español — one thing, singular verb. Now guess what happens with more than one thing.

Grammar Lens: it agrees, and that is strange

Se compra el libro. — The book is bought. *Se compran libros.* — Books are bought.

The verb changed. *Compra* for one book, *compran* for several — the verb is agreeing with **the thing being bought**.

Stop and notice how odd that is. In *se habla español* there is nobody doing the speaking, so what is the verb agreeing **with**? If this were simply “one buys books,” the verb would stay singular, because *one* is one person. It does not stay singular.

The thing is behaving like the subject. And that is the clue to where this construction came from.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Read *se compran libros* with the *se* meaning what it meant in *se llama*:

Books buy themselves.

That is nonsense as a description of the world, and it is exactly the sentence Spanish is using. The reflexive was stretched: first *the door closes itself* (true enough of doors), then *the books sell themselves*, and finally any verb at all with the doer quietly dropped.

Once you see that, the agreement stops being strange. *Libros* is the subject of *se compran* in the same way *él* is the subject of *se llama*. The verb has been agreeing with its subject all along; it is just that the subject is a thing, and the thing is not really doing anything. So this *se* **is** the reflexive *se* — grown, not borrowed. Unlike the *se* of *se lo digo*, which only looks like it.

Your turn

- *Say it*: “Se compra el libro” then “Se compran libros” — hear the verb follow the thing

Before you move on

Why does the verb go plural? (Because it agrees with **the thing**.) And why does it agree with the thing? (Because underneath, the thing is **doing it to itself**.) Next: the one you will use every day.

Chapter 183

Como Se Dice — The Sentence That Unlocks the Rest

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask how something is said, and say which se that is.

Complete ES-C52-como-se-dice: ask the question politely and say why it is impersonal rather than aimed at the listener.

183.1 ¿cómo se dice? — the sentence that unlocks the rest

You know *cómo*. You know the impersonal *se*. Put them in front of *dice* and you have the sentence that will teach you more Spanish than this book will.

The two words

¿*Cómo se dice?* — How do you say it? / How is it said?

Take it apart with what this chapter gave you. *Se dice* is the impersonal: it asks how a thing **gets said**, without asking who says it. Not *how do you say it*, though that is the natural English — Spanish is not pointing at the person you are talking to. It is asking about the language itself.

Which is exactly right, because you are not asking for their personal opinion. You are asking what the word is.

¿Cómo se dice “book” en español? — How do you say “book” in Spanish? *¿Cómo se dice, por favor?*

This is the most valuable sentence in the book, and it is worth saying why. Every other sentence you have learned lets you say something you already know. This one gets you the thing you **do not** know, from the person in front of you, mid-conversation. A learner with this sentence and some patience out-learns one with twice the vocabulary and no way to ask.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “¿Cómo se dice?” until it is one word
- “¿Cómo se dice en español, por favor?”

Twice through: This is the one to over-practise.

Before you move on

Ask how something is said. (*¿Cómo se dice?*) Which *se* is that? (The **impersonal** one — asking about the language, not the person.) Next: the three *ses*, side by side, for the first time.

Chapter 184

Review — The Three Se's

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can tell the three se's apart and say which two are really one word.

Complete ES-C52-tres-ses: say which two se's are one word and what marks the impostor.

184.1 Review — the three se's

Nothing new. Say *se llama*, then *se habla español*, then *se lo digo*. Three sentences, three *ses*, learned about a hundred chapters apart.

What you've built

	example	what the <i>se</i> is
reflexive	<i>se llama</i>	himself
impersonal	<i>se habla español</i>	nobody named
the impostor	<i>se lo digo</i>	<i>le</i> , in disguise

And here is the fact that makes this a review rather than a fourth thing to learn:

The first two are the same word. The third is not.

The impersonal grew out of the reflexive — *the books sell themselves* becoming *books are sold* — which is why the verb still agrees with the thing. Same word, stretched.

The third only looks like them. It is Latin *illī* — the *le* you already know — which arrived at this spelling by an accident of medieval pronunciation, as you saw when *gelo* became *se lo*.
So Spanish does not have three *ses*. It has **two, and a coincidence**.

Grammar Lens: how to tell them apart in the wild

You will not have to work this out consciously for long, but while you do:

1. **Is there a *lo*, *la*, *los* or *las* right after it?** Then it is the impostor: *se lo*, *se la*. It means *to him* / *to her* / *to them*. 2. **Otherwise, is anybody named as the doer?** If not, it is the impersonal: *se habla*, *se dice*, *se come bien*. 3. **Otherwise it is the reflexive**, pointing back at whoever the sentence is about: *se llama*, *se levanta*.

The first test is nearly free, because that direct object pronoun is sitting right there in the open.

Your turn

- *Say it*: “*se llama*”, “*se habla español*”, “*se lo digo*” — two of these are relatives

Twice through:

Before you move on

How many *ses* does Spanish really have? (**Two, and a coincidence**.) Which one is the impostor? (The one in *se lo* — it is *le*.) Next: all of it in a place you would actually meet it.

Chapter 185

Synthesis — Reading the Window

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can read impersonal signs and ask my way past the words I do not have.

Complete ES-C52-sintesis-el-letrero: read the signs, ask for an unknown word, and say what the missing person buys a notice.

185.1 Synthesis — reading the window

Almost nobody will say *se habla español* to you. It will be **written**, on a window, and you will be walking past it.

The exchange

Four things on four windows, in one street:

*SE HABLA ESPAÑOL SE COMPRAN LIBROS AQUÍ SE
COME BIEN SE PROHÍBE FUMAR*

Three you can read completely. The fourth has words you have never met — and you can still read its shape: something is forbidden, by nobody in particular.

That is what this rung buys. Not producing these sentences, but **reading them off the world**, and knowing the missing person is missing **on purpose**.

And for the two unknown words, you already have the tool:

¿Cómo se dice “fumar”, por favor?

Which is itself the same construction, asked out loud.

Grammar Lens: what it means that nobody is named

A sentence with nobody in it is not just vague — it is **doing something with the vagueness**. *Se prohíbe fumar* does not say who forbids it, and that is what gives a sign its authority: nobody is claiming anything, so there is nobody to argue with. English does the same when a report says *mistakes were made*. So when you meet a *se* with no doer, ask who is being left out. Sometimes the answer is interesting.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the four signs aloud as if walking past them
- “¿Cómo se dice, por favor?” — the way out of any of them

Twice through:

Before you move on

Where does this grammar mostly live? (**Written on things**.)
 What does the missing person buy a sign? (**Authority** — nobody to argue with.) And what do you say when a sign has a word you do not have? (*¿Cómo se dice, por favor?*)

Chapter 186

El Libro Que Compro — One Sentence Out of Two

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can join two sentences with *que* so a noun carries a clause.

Complete ES-C53-que-relativo: join two sentences with *que* and name the question words that share its root.

186.1 el libro que compro — one sentence out of two

Say “I want you to speak.” (*Quiero que hables.*) That *que* is about to do a second job — and it is the job that lets your sentences stop being short.

Grammar Lens: stapling two sentences together

You have two sentences about one book:

Tengo el libro. — I have the book. *Compro el libro.* — I buy the book.

Que joins them, and the repeated noun disappears:

*Tengo el libro **que** compro.* — I have the book **that** I buy.

That is the whole mechanism. **Name the thing once, then use *que***

to hang a second sentence off it. Everything you can already say can now be attached to a noun instead of standing alone.

This is the point where a language stops being a list of statements. Up to now your sentences have had one verb each. From here a sentence can contain another sentence, and then another — which is what allows description, explanation and storytelling of any length.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Que comes from the Latin **qui / quem / quid** family — the same *qu*-question-root sitting inside *qué*, *quién*, *cómo* and *cuándo*, which you have been collecting since your very first questions.

That is not a coincidence of spelling. A question and a relative clause are doing related work: *¿qué compras?* asks you to fill a gap, and *el libro que compro* fills one. Latin used the same word family for both, and Spanish kept the arrangement.

So the busiest structural word in the language is a worn-down question word. English did the identical thing: *what*, *which*, *who* and *that* all serve twice, as questions and as joints.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the two short sentences, then the joined one
- “el libro que compro”, “la casa que tengo”

Before you move on

Join “I have the book” and “I buy the book.” (***Tengo el libro que compro.***) What does *que* let a sentence do that it could not before? (**Contain another sentence.**) Next: the one place English is lazier than Spanish, and it trips every learner.

Chapter 187

El Libro Que Compre — The Word You Cannot Leave Out

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can supply the *que* that English deletes.

Complete ES-C53-que-no-se-cae: produce *el libro que compre* and name the English pattern that always needs a *que*.

187.1 el libro que compré — the word you cannot leave out

Say this English sentence out loud: “**the book I bought.**”
Notice that you did not say *that*. Now try to translate it.

Grammar Lens: English drops it, Spanish never does

*el libro **que** compré* — the book I bought. *la casa **que** tengo* — the house I have.

English lets you delete the joint. *The book that I bought* and *the book I bought* are both fine, and in speech you almost always drop it.

Spanish cannot. There is no version of these without *que*. Leaving it out does not sound casual or fast — it sounds like a sentence that broke.

This is worth a chapter of its own because of what it does to a learner. You will build the sentence in English first, silently, with the *that*

already missing — and then translate the version you thought of. The gap is invisible precisely because your own language put it there.

So the habit to build is: whenever an English noun is followed straight by a new subject and verb, a *que* belongs in the Spanish.

- the book **I** bought → *el libro que compré*
- the house **we** have → *la casa que tenemos*
- the meal **she** makes → *la comida que hace*

Why it's said this way

English can afford to drop it because its word order is rigid: *the book I bought* can only be read one way.

Spanish word order is looser — subjects vanish under pro-drop, objects move in front of verbs. Where the pieces can sit in several places, a deletable joint would make sentences ambiguous. So it is never deleted. Not arbitrary strictness: the price of the freedom Spanish gives you elsewhere.

Your turn

- *Say it*: “the book I bought” then “el libro que compré” — hear the extra word

Twice through: Until the missing English *that* stops being invisible.

Before you move on

“The house I have”? (*La casa que tengo.*) Can *que* ever be left out? (**No** — never.) And why not? (Because Spanish **moves its pieces around**, so the joint has to stay.)

Chapter 188

Lo Que — What, Out of Two Old Words

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can use *lo que* for a thing that is never named.

Complete ES-C53-lo-que: produce *lo que digo* and contrast it with *lo digo*.

188.1 lo que — “what,” out of two old words

You have *lo*. You have *que*. This chapter puts them next to each other and adds nothing.

Grammar Lens: a noun-shaped hole

lo que — *what*, in the sense of *the thing that*.

Lo que digo — what I say. (= *the thing that I say*) **Lo que compro** — what I buy.

Every relative clause so far has hung off a noun: *el libro que compro*. But sometimes there is no noun, because you do not know or do not care what the thing is. *Lo* stands in for it — a placeholder with no gender and nothing behind it — and *que* does its usual job of joining. So *lo que* is a **noun-shaped hole with a sentence attached**. That is why it translates as English *what*, which is doing exactly the same thing: *what I say* is *the thing that I say* with the word *thing* taken out.

Now compare it to the *lo* you already know:

Lo digo. — I say **it**. (*a specific thing, already named*) *Lo que digo* — **what** I say. (*no specific thing at all*)

Same word. In the first it points at something known; in the second it points at a gap the following clause will fill.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “lo digo” then “lo que digo” — pointing at a thing, then at a gap
- “lo que compro”

Before you move on

Say “what I buy.” (***Lo que compro.***) What is *lo* doing there? (**Standing in for a thing that is never named.**) How many new words was that? (**None.**) Next: all of it in one place.

Chapter 189

Review — Three Jobs, No New Words

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) 🗉 Hands-free start: none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can use all three relative patterns and name the error that outlives the others.

Complete ES-C53-repaso-que: say how many new words the rung added and name the trap.

189.1 Review — three jobs, no new words

Nothing new. One question first: how many new words did this rung teach you?

What you've built

None. Here is the whole rung:

	Spanish	English
joining to a noun	<i>el libro que compro</i>	the book that I buy
the same, with English's <i>that</i> dropped	<i>la casa que tengo</i>	the house I have
no noun to join to	<i>lo que digo</i>	what I say

Que you have held since *quiero que hables*. *Lo* you have held since the object pronouns. This rung put them to work and added nothing. That is worth pausing on, because it is the last big structural piece a

beginner's course owes you, and it turned out to cost **no vocabulary at all**. Almost everything in a language is like this eventually: the pieces stop being new and start being rearranged.

Grammar Lens: what to actually watch for

One error will outlive the others, so it gets the last word here.

English deletes its joint. Spanish never does.

You will think *the book I bought*, translate what you thought, and produce *el libro compré*. It will feel complete because your English was complete.

The check is mechanical and takes a second: **a noun, then a new subject and verb, with nothing in between** — that gap needs a *que*.

And when there is no noun to begin with, *lo* supplies one so that *que* has something to hang from. Which means both chapters were about the same thing: **Spanish will not let the joint go missing.**

Your turn

- *Say it*: all three rows of the table

Twice through: Until the missing English *that* is loud.

Before you move on

New words this rung? (**None**.) The error that outlives the others? (**Dropping *que***, because English drops *that*.) Next: sentences long enough to be worth saying.

Chapter 190

Synthesis — Sentences Worth Saying

Modes: 🗣 voice (1) 🗣 Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can build a sentence containing other sentences.

Complete ES-C53-sintesis-frases-largas: build a three-verb sentence and say why length is not difficulty.

190.1 Synthesis — sentences worth saying

Until this rung, every sentence you could build had one verb in it. Count the verbs in the next one.

The exchange

— ¿Tienes el libro **que** compré? — Sí. **Lo que** no tengo es la comida **que** haces.

Read the second line again. It has three verbs in it, and you can build every piece of it:

- *lo que no tengo* — the thing I do not have (*a noun-shaped hole*)
- *es* — is
- *la comida que haces* — the meal you make (*a noun with a sentence hung off it*)

Nothing in that sentence is new. What is new is that the pieces are allowed to sit **inside** each other.

Grammar Lens: length is not difficulty

Long sentences look like an increase in difficulty and are not.

A relative clause does not add grammar. It adds a **slot** where a whole sentence can go, and you fill it with the same Spanish you were already making. Two short sentences become one long one, and the only new thing is the joint.

That is why this is the last structural rung a beginner's course owes you. Not because nothing is left, but because from here the growth is **more of what you have**, arranged more deeply. What remains genuinely hard is vocabulary and hearing speed, and both are time.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the full two-line exchange
- the long sentence broken into its three pieces, then whole

Twice through:

Before you move on

How many verbs can one sentence hold now? (**As many as you can join.**) What does a relative clause actually add? (A **slot**, not new grammar.) And what is genuinely hard from here? (**Vocabulary and hearing speed** — both of which are time.)

Chapter 191

Hay — There Is, There Are, Same Word

Modes: 🔄 voice (1) 🔄 Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say there is and there are with one form that never changes.

Complete ES-C54-hay: produce hay una casa and hay libros, and say what hay agrees with.

191.1 hay — “there is,” “there are,” same word

Say “I have eaten.” (*He comido.*) You met *haber* as the verb with no meaning left. It kept one more job, and this is it.

Sounds you’ll need

- diphthong-ai — *hay* is one syllable, rhyming with English *eye*. The *h* is silent, as always.

Grammar Lens: one form, and it does not count

hay — *there is*, and *there are*.

Hay *una casa*. — There is a house. **Hay** *libros*. — There are books. **Hay** *una casa aquí*. — There’s a house here.

Read those twice. One book or a hundred, *hay* does not move.

That is remarkable, and you are now in a position to see why.

Every verb form in this book has agreed with something: with the

person speaking, with the thing being replaced, with the noun being described. In the impersonal *se* chapter, even a sentence with nobody in it still made the verb agree with the thing — *se compran libros*. *Hay* does not. It is the one common Spanish verb form that counts nothing at all, and it is a small gift: no decision to make, ever.

Your turn

- *Say it*: “Hay una casa” then “Hay libros” — the same word, twice

Before you move on

“There is a house”? (***Hay una casa.***) “There are books”? (***Hay libros*** — the same word.) What does *hay* agree with? (**Nothing.**) Next: what it is actually made of, and the fossil hiding in it.

Chapter 192

Ha + Y — The Fossil in a Three-Letter Word

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) ↔ Hands-free start: none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what hay is made of and name the French phrase built from the same pieces.

Complete ES-C54-ha-mas-y: name the two pieces, say where else the y appears, and name the French equivalent.

192.1 ha + y — the fossil in a three-letter word

Hay looks like nothing. Say the *haber* form for he/she. (*Ha.*)
Now look at *hay* again with that in mind.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Hay is two words fused:

ha + y

The *ha* you already hold: it is *haber*, third person. The **y** is the interesting half. It is Latin **ibi**, meaning “**there**” — and Spanish otherwise **lost that word completely**.

There is no *y* meaning “there” anywhere else in modern Spanish. It survives in exactly one place, welded to the front of a verb, because words that get glued to something else stop being available to be replaced. *Hay* is a museum case with one object in it.

So the literal reading is: “**it has there.**” Which is a strange way to say something exists, until you notice that the neighbours do the same:

- **French:** *il y a* — “it there has.” Same *haber* verb, same *ibi*, same order, three words instead of one. French kept its *y* separate, so its fossil is still visible on the surface.
- **English:** *there is* — which also starts with a place-word doing a job that has nothing to do with place. Nobody is pointing anywhere when they say *there is a problem*.

Three languages, three different verbs, and all of them reached for a word meaning “**there**” to announce that something exists. That is not borrowing; it is the same instinct arriving three times.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ha” then “hay” — hear the extra piece
- “hay”, “il y a”, “there is” — three languages, one instinct

Before you move on

What is *hay* made of? (**Ha** + *y*.) What does the *y* mean, and where else is it? (“**There**” — and **nowhere else** in Spanish.) What did French do with the same pieces? (Kept them apart: *il y a*.) Next: *hay* with a verb after it.

Chapter 193

Hay Que — Somebody Has To, and Nobody in Particular

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can express an obligation without naming who is obliged.

Complete ES-C54-hay-que: produce *hay que hablar español* and name the other construction that leaves the person out.

193.1 hay que — somebody has to, and nobody in particular

Se habla español left the person out. So did every sign you read. Here is the other way Spanish does that — and this one is about obligation.

Grammar Lens: an obligation with nobody in it

hay que + a plain infinitive — *one must, you have to, it is necessary to.*

Hay que *hablar español.* — You have to speak Spanish.

Hay que *comer.* — One must eat.

Three words you already own, and no new grammar: *hay, que*, and a verb in its dictionary form.

What it produces is an obligation with **nobody obliged**. *Hay que hablar español* does not say who has to — not you, not me, not them.

It says the requirement exists, the way a sign says a thing is forbidden without saying who forbids it.

That is the same move as the impersonal *se*, and now you have both:

	Spanish	leaves out
something happens	<i>se habla español</i>	who does it
something must	<i>hay que hablar</i>	who must
happen	<i>español</i>	

Two constructions, one habit: **Spanish is comfortable saying that something is the case without saying who is behind it.** English needs a vague *you* or *they* or a passive to manage the same thing, and always sounds slightly like it is avoiding the question.

Your turn

- *Say it:* “Hay que hablar español” then “Se habla español” — both with nobody in them

Before you move on

“One must eat”? (***Hay que comer.***) Who must? (**Nobody named.**) And which other construction does the same? (The **impersonal *se*.**) Next: all of it in one place.

Chapter 194

Review — Three Letters

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) 🗉 Hands-free start: none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can use all three jobs of *hay* and say what it never does.

Complete ES-C54-repaso-hay: give the three uses and say why a three-letter word needed four chapters.

194.1 Review — three letters

Nothing new. What does *hay* agree with?

What you've built

one thing	<i>Hay una casa.</i>	There is a house.
many things	<i>Hay libros.</i>	There are books.
an obligation	<i>Hay que comer.</i>	One must eat.
what it is made of	<i>ha + y</i>	“it has there”

Three letters, and everything above came out of them.

Notice the shape of this arc, because it is the shape of a lot of language learning: **the smallest words need the most explaining.** *Hay* is shorter than any noun you have learned and it took four chapters, while *comida* took one. Short words are short because they are used constantly, and constant use is what wears them into fossils that no longer explain themselves.

Grammar Lens: what it does not do

Two things *hay* never does, and both save you work:

1. **It never agrees.** Not with number, not with anything. One form.
2. **It never names anybody.** Neither does *hay que*.

So of everything you have learned about making Spanish verbs match their surroundings — six endings a tense, gender on the pronouns, number on the articles — none of it applies here. After a hundred and seventy chapters of agreement, the last word is the one that opted out.

Your turn

- *Say it:* all four rows of the table

Twice through:

Before you move on

Three uses of *hay* — say them. (*There is, there are*, and ***hay que*** for must.) What does it agree with? (**Nothing at all.**) Next: the last synthesis.

Chapter 195

Synthesis — Describing Where You Are

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can describe a place using existence, relative clauses and impersonal obligation together.

Complete ES-C54-sintesis-lo-que-hay: build lo que hay, hay que comerlo and say what remains to be learned.

195.1 Synthesis — describing where you are

Hay is the word you reach for to describe a place. Look around the room you are in and say what is there.

The exchange

— ¿Qué hay aquí? — **Hay una casa. Hay libros — los que compré.** — ¿Y **la comida que** haces? — **Lo que hay, hay que comerlo.**

The last line is four words of grammar stacked on each other, and every piece came from a different chapter:

- *lo que hay* — the noun-shaped hole, filled by *hay*
- *hay que* — obligation with nobody obliged
- *comerlo* — the object pronoun, riding on the end of an infinitive

You have not been taught that last one, and you can still read it: *comer* plus *lo*. That is what it feels like when a language starts assembling itself.

Grammar Lens: what you can do now

Describing a place is a small thing that needs a surprising amount: an existence word, articles that count, nouns, relative clauses to pick things out, and a way to say what has to happen. This chapter needed all of them, and you supplied them without any of it being new. That is the honest end of a beginner's course. Not "you are finished" — nobody is — but **the machinery is assembled**. Every remaining thing in Spanish is either a word you have not met yet or a familiar structure standing somewhere you have not seen it stand. The eleven gaps found in the original audit are now closed. What is left is not a gap. It is the ordinary, unbounded work of using the thing.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the whole four-line exchange
- "Lo que hay, hay que comerlo" — and hear four chapters at once

Twice through:

Before you move on

Ask what there is here. (*¿Qué hay aquí?*) Say what there is, one must eat. (*Lo que hay, hay que comerlo.*) And what is left after this? (**Words, and practice** — the machinery is assembled.)

Chapter 196

Si — If, and the Word Yes Is Made Of

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can make a real condition with *si* and the present.

*I can make a real condition with *si* and the present.*

196.1 si

Say “yes.” (*Sí*.) Now the pair from the accent chapter: *el* and *él*. Same letters, one accent, two words.

Today you meet the third member of that family — and it is *sí* with the accent taken off.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

si — if

Latin *sī* meant *if*. Spanish kept it unchanged.

And the *sí* you already know — **yes** — is that same word with a **pointing particle** stuck on the end: Latin *sīc* is *sī* + *-ce*, roughly *if-so*, which came to mean *thus, that way*, and finally **yes**.

$si \leftarrow s\bar{i} \text{ — if } \cdot \quad s\acute{i} \leftarrow s\bar{i} + -ce \text{ — thus } \rightarrow \text{yes}$

So *yes* is literally *if*, pointed at. The accent is the only thing keeping them apart on the page, and it is doing the same job it did for *el* and *él*.

Grammar Lens: the real condition

For something that really might happen: *si* + present, then present.

No new verb form. You already have every piece:

<i>Si tengo tiempo, hablo español.</i>	If I have time, I speak Spanish.
<i>Si llueve, no voy.</i>	If it rains, I don't go.

Both halves sit in the present, and the sentence is about something genuinely possible — today, tomorrow, whenever.

The order can flip, and the comma simply goes away:

Hablo español si tengo tiempo.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *Si tengo tiempo, hablo español*
- *Si llueve, no voy*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which tense goes on each side of a real condition? (**Present**, both.)
And what separates *if* from *yes*? (One **accent** — and a pointing particle, two thousand years ago.)

Chapter 197

Si + Futuro — What Will Happen If

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can put the result of a condition in the future, and keep *si* in the present.

*I can put the result of a condition in the future, and keep *si* in the present.*

197.1 si + futuro

Say “if I have time, I speak Spanish.” (*Si tengo tiempo, hablo español.*) Two presents.

Now move the second half into the future, where most real conditions actually live.

Grammar Lens: the present stays put

si + *present*, then *future*.

Si tengo tiempo, hablaré español.

If I have time, I **will** speak Spanish.

Si llueve, comeré en casa.

If it rains, I **will** eat at home.

The result half moves to the future. **The *si* half does not.** Spanish will not put a future tense after a *si* that sets a condition — *si tendré*

tiempo... is simply not said.

(The other *si*, the one meaning *whether*, is a different word doing a different job, and it takes the future quite happily. You will meet it later.)

And you already obey that rule in English without having been taught it. Nobody says *if it will rain, I won't go*. English keeps the present after *if* too, and neither language explains why.

Why it's said this way

A condition is not a prediction.

The *si* half is not claiming the thing will happen — it is setting it aside as a supposition, and a supposition has no tense to be right or wrong about. Only the **result** half makes a claim about the future, so only the result half gets the future tense.

That is why the rule feels arbitrary and is not: the two halves of the sentence are doing different jobs.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *Si tengo tiempo, hablaré español*
- *Si llueve, comeré en casa*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which half takes the future? (The **result** half, after the comma.)
And what never follows *si*? (The **future tense**.)

Chapter 198

Synthesis — Real Conditions

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what happens, or will happen, if something else does.

I can say what happens, or will happen, if something else does.

198.1 Synthesis — real conditions

Which tense after *si*? (**Present**, always.) Which after the comma? (**Present or future** — your choice of meaning.)

What you've built

Two chapters, one word, and a sentence shape you did not have before:

<i>Si tengo tiempo, hablo español.</i>	a habit — whenever it happens
<i>Si tengo tiempo, hablaré español.</i>	a plan — this once
<i>Si llueve, comeré en casa.</i>	a decision waiting on the weather

This is the first thing in the book that needs two clauses to say. Every sentence before it was one thought. A condition is two, hooked together — and the hook cost you no new grammar at all, only a word and a rule about where the future may stand.

Grammar Lens: what a condition is for

A condition lets you talk about a world you are not claiming is real yet. That is a genuinely new power, and it is the doorway to the rest of this book: once you can suppose, you can also suppose things that are **not** true — *if I had time* — and that needs a verb form you do not have yet.

You will meet it soon. For now the supposing is real, and real supposing is most of what anyone says all day.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- a real condition about your own day
- the same one, moved into the future

Twice through:

Before you move on

How many clauses does a condition need? (**Two.**) What new verb form did it cost you? (**None.**) And what is still missing? (A way to suppose something **untrue** — that comes next.)

Chapter 199

Hablaron — They Spoke

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what a group of people did, with -ar verbs in the past.

I can say what a group of people did, with -ar verbs in the past.

199.1 hablaron

Give the three past forms you have. (*Hablé, hablaste, habló.*)
Now the present for *they*. (*Hablan.*)

You have had a past tense for one person only. Today it grows.

Grammar Lens: they, in the past

hablaron — they spoke

	present	past
<i>ellos / ellas / ustedes</i>	hablan	hablaron

The present ending is *-an*. The past ending is **-aron**, and the stress lands on that **-a-**: *ha-BLA-ron*. No written accent this time — the word already ends in *-n*, and a word ending in *-n* is stressed on the second-to-last syllable by default, which is exactly where the stress is. So *habló* needed its accent and *hablaron* does not. The rule you learned for reading accents is doing the work.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *hablan · hablaron*
- *trabajaron · estudiaron*

Twice through:

Before you move on

The past *they* ending for *-ar* verbs? (**-aron.**)

Does it take a written accent? (**No** — it ends in *-n*, so the default stress is already correct.)

Chapter 200

Hablamos — We Speak, and We Spoke

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can use one form for both tenses and let context decide.

I can use one form for both tenses and let context decide.

200.1 hablamos

Say “we speak.” (*Hablamos.*) Say “they spoke.” (*Hablaron.*)

Now say “we spoke.”

Grammar Lens: the form you already own

hablamos — we speak **and** we spoke.

There is nothing to learn. For every **regular** *-ar* verb the *we* form is **identical** in the present and the past:

	present	past
<i>nosotros</i>	hablamos	hablamos

Latin kept them apart — *-āmus* for now, *-āvimus* for then — and the second one wore down until it landed on top of the first. Spanish noticed, and did nothing about it.

Context does the work instead, exactly as it does in English *I put it there*, where *put* is present or past and nobody is ever confused.

Why it's said this way**A gap that costs nothing is a gap a language keeps.**

Spanish could have invented a new ending. It did not, because the two meanings almost never compete: whatever else is in the sentence — a time word, the verb before it, the conversation you are already in — settles which one you meant.

And when it genuinely matters, a speaker just says *when*. That is cheaper than a new tense form for every verb in the language.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *hablamos* — meaning now
- *hablamos* — meaning then

Twice through:

Before you move on

How many new forms did this chapter cost you? (**None.**)

What tells a listener which tense you meant? (**Context** — and if it matters, you say *when*.)

Chapter 201

Comieron — One Ending, Two Families

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can put -er and -ir verbs into the plural past with one set of endings.

I can put -er and -ir verbs into the plural past with one set of endings.

201.1 comieron

In the past singular, how many ending sets do -er and -ir verbs need between them? (**One** — *comí* and *viví* take the same endings.)

The plural keeps that bargain.

Grammar Lens: one ending, two families

comieron · *vivieron* — they ate · they lived

	present	past
<i>comer</i>	comen	comieron
<i>vivir</i>	viven	vivieron

The past ending is **-ieron** for both families, exactly as *-í* served both in the singular. And *we* follows the same shape:

comimos · *vivimos*

Now the interesting part, and it is not the one you would guess.

	present	past
<i>hablar</i>	<i>hablamos</i>	<i>hablamos</i> — the same
<i>comer</i>	<i>comemos</i>	<i>comimos</i> — different
<i>vivir</i>	<i>vivimos</i>	<i>vivimos</i> — the same

Two families out of three collapse. *Vivimos* is *we live* and *we lived*, exactly as *hablamos* is both. Only **-er** keeps the two apart — and only because its past borrowed *-imos* from the *-ir* family and so moved away from its own present *-emos*.

You met *comemos* and *vivimos* together as the first place *-er* and *-ir* stop agreeing. This is the second place, and it goes the other way.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *comieron* · *vivieron*
- *comemos* · *comimos* — and *vivimos*, which is both

Twice through:

Before you move on

The past *they* ending for *-er* and *-ir*? (**-ieron**, for both.)
Which families lose the present-past distinction in the *we* form?
(**-ar** and **-ir** — only *-er* keeps it.)

Chapter 202

Tuvieron — the Strong Stems, Made Plural

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can put the strong preterite stems into the plural.

I can put the strong preterite stems into the plural.

202.1 tuvieron

Say the three strong pasts you know. (*Tuve, hice, estuve.*)

Where does the stress fall? (On the **stem** — *TU-ve, HI-ce.*)

That is what makes them strong. Now watch what the plural does to it.

Grammar Lens: the stem gives the stress back

Strong stem + *-ieron*.

singular	plural
<i>tuve</i>	tuvieron
<i>hice</i>	hicieron
<i>estuve</i>	estuvieron

The ending is the same *-ieron* you learned for *comer* and *vivir*. The strong stem does not change — *tuv-*, *hic-*, *estuv-* — it simply takes the ordinary plural ending.

And the stress moves: *TU-ve*, but *tu-VIE-ron*. The stem holds it in *tuve* and *tuvo* and hands it back here, because *-ieron* is two syllables and takes it.

Note that *tuviste* never had it — *tu-VIS-te* is stressed on the ending like any ordinary past. **The stem only ever held the stress in two of the forms**, which is exactly how much irregularity Spanish was willing to pay for.

No written accent on any of them — they end in *-n*, so the default is already right, exactly as with *hablaron*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *tuve* · *tuvieron*
- *hice* · *hicieron* · *estuvieron*

Twice through:

Before you move on

What ending do the strong stems take in the plural? (**-ieron** — the ordinary one.)

And what changes besides the ending? (The **stress**, back onto it.)

Chapter 203

Fueron — They Were, and They Went

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗋️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can use the one plural past that serves both *ser* and *ir*.

*I can use the one plural past that serves both *ser* and *ir*.*

203.1 fueron

Fui — how many verbs does it belong to? (**Two:** *ser* and *ir*.)

So *fui* is both *I was* and *I went*.

The plural keeps that bargain, and breaks a different one.

Grammar Lens: the form that refuses the ending

fueron — they were **and** they went

Every other past plural you have takes *-aron* or *-ieron*. This one takes neither:

tener

tuv- + *-ieron* → *tuvieron*

ser / ir

— → **fueron**

Not *fuieron*. The stem simply becomes *fue-* and the *-ron* is stuck on. And *fuimos* is *we were* and *we went*, with the same double duty.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish borrowed its whole past for *to be* from a different verb.

Latin **fuī** and **fuērunt** are the past of a root meaning *to grow, to become* — not of *esse, to be*. When a verb is used constantly its past tends to wear away, and languages patch the hole from whatever is nearby.

English did exactly the same thing. *Was* and *were* do not come from *be* either; they come from a root meaning *to dwell, to remain*. Two languages, the same hole, the same repair.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *fui · fuimos · fueron*
- *fueron* — meaning they were, then meaning they went

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which two verbs does *fueron* serve? (***Ser*** and ***ir***.)

And why is the past of *to be* built from another verb entirely?

(Because a constantly used past **wears away**, and the hole gets patched — in Spanish and in English both.)

Chapter 204

Review — the Whole Preterite

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can give the whole preterite, six people and three families.

I can give the whole preterite, six people and three families.

204.1 Review — the whole preterite

The past *they* ending for *-ar*? (**-aron.**) For *-er* and *-ir*? (**-ieron.**) That is the whole plural, in two syllables each.

What you've built

Say each family's own line, one at a time. There is no table here on purpose — a paradigm is easier to hold as three short chants than as a grid.

-ar: **hablé · hablaste · habló · hablamos ·**
hablaron

-er: **comí · comiste · comió · comimos ·**
comieron

-ir: **viví · viviste · vivió · vivimos · vivieron**

Two ending sets, not three. *-er* and *-ir* have shared this tense from the first chapter of it, and go on sharing it here.

And one person is still missing. The *vosotros* form — *hablasteis*, *comisteis* — has not been taught, so this is five of the six the present tense gave you. The strong verbs are shorter still: you have *tuve* and *tuvieron*, but not *tuvimos*. Both are owed, and it is better to know that than to think the tense is finished.

Grammar Lens: the two quiet overlaps

Worth holding, because neither is a mistake:

1. ***hablamos* and *vivimos* are each two tenses.** Present and past, identical. Only *comer* keeps them apart — *comemos* against *comimos* — and only because its past borrowed *-imos* from the *-ir* family.
2. **The strong stems are four words, not a rule.** *Tuv-*, *hic-*, *estuv-*, and *fue-*. Everything else about them is ordinary: they take *-ieron* like any *-er* verb, except *fueron*, which takes nothing at all and just adds *-ron*.
So the only memorising this tense ever asked of you was four stems.

Your turn

- *Say it:* the *ellos* form of *hablar*, *comer*, *vivir*, *tener*, *ser*

Twice through:

Before you move on

How many ending sets does the plural need? (**Two**.) How many stems had to be learned by heart? (**Four**.) And is the tense finished? (**Not quite** — *vosotros* is still owed, and so are the strong *nosotros* forms.)

Chapter 205

Synthesis — Telling What Happened

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can tell a short past story about other people.

I can tell a short past story about other people.

205.1 Synthesis — telling what happened

Hablaron. Fueron. Two plurals, two different bargains — one regular, one refusing every ending in the language.

What you've built

Three chapters ago your past tense could still only talk about **one person at a time**. Now it can talk about a group:

<i>Hablaron español.</i>	They spoke Spanish.
<i>Comimos en casa.</i>	We ate at home.
<i>Tuvieron tiempo.</i>	They had time.
<i>Fueron profesores.</i>	They were teachers.

That is the difference between keeping a diary and **telling a story**. A story needs other people in it, and other people need a plural.

Grammar Lens: the form that pays twice

One of the five forms you just learned is about to do a second job.

hablaron · comieron · tuvieron · fueron

Swap the *-ron* for *-ra* and something appears that Spanish uses for supposing: *hablara, comiera, tuviera, fuera*. That is the form the next chapters need — the one that lets you say *if I had time* rather than *if I have time*.

You are not learning it yet. You are being told that **you already own the raw material**, which is why the plural had to come first.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *Hablaron español y tuvieron tiempo*
- *Fueron profesores*

Twice through:

Before you move on

What can this tense do now that it could not before? (Talk about **other people** — tell a story rather than keep a diary.)
And which form is about to be used twice? (The **they** form.)

Chapter 206

Hablara — the Form for Supposing

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can build the supposing form of any verb from its they-past.

I can build the supposing form of any verb from its they-past.

206.1 hablara

Give the *they* past of *hablar*, *comer* and *vivir*. (*Hablaron*, *comieron*, *vivieron*.)

You were told those would be used twice. This is the second time.

Grammar Lens: swap the ending

Take the *they* past. Swap *-ron* for *-ra*.

they past	supposing
hablaron	hablara
comieron	comiera
vivieron	viviera

No verb in Spanish changes its stem here — a stronger guarantee than almost anything else in the language. The one thing the swap does not carry is an accent: *habláramos*, *tuviéramos*. The stem is untouched; only the mark moves. The reason is worth a moment: every irregularity these verbs had was

already spent in the preterite. Because this form is carved out of that one, it **inherits the irregularity instead of inventing new irregularity**. A tense built on a broken form comes out perfectly regular.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Hablara did not start out as supposing.

In Latin this ending was a plain statement about the past: *amāveram*, **I had loved**. It slid from *what had happened* to *what did not*, which is a short journey — both sit outside the present, and only one is real. (*Hablar*'s Latin ancestor was **deponent**, so Spanish built *hablara* on the pattern rather than inheriting it. The ending carried over, not the word.)

Spanish also has a second form for exactly this job — *hablase* — and that one **did** come from a Latin subjunctive. Two different Latin tenses walked into the same modern meaning. You will meet *-se* in reading; you never have to produce it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *hablaron* → *hablara*
- *comieron* → *comiera*, *vivieron* → *viviera*

Twice through:

Before you move on

What do you start from? (The **they past**.) What do you swap? (**-ron** for **-ra**.)

How many verbs change their stem? (**None** — the breaking already happened somewhere else.) And what does move? (The **accent**, in the *nosotros* form.)

Chapter 207

Tuviera — the Hard Stems, Collected Free

Modes: 🔄 voice (1) 🔄 Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can build the supposing form of the strong verbs without learning a new stem.

I can build the supposing form of the strong verbs without learning a new stem.

207.1 tuviera

The rule, again. (Take the *they* past, swap *-ron* for *-ra*.)

Now try it on the verbs that gave you the most trouble.

Grammar Lens: the hard ones cost nothing

they past

tuvieron

hicieron

estuvieron

fueron

supposing

tuviera

hiciera

estuviera

fuera

Nothing new was learned here. The same swap, applied to stems you already had. The four words you memorised for the preterite have now paid for themselves twice.

And *fuera* keeps the double duty *fui* and *fueron* had: it is the supposing form of **ser** and of **ir**. *Si fuera* can begin *if I were* or *if I*

went, and only the rest of the sentence decides.

Why it's said this way

This is what a well-shaped irregularity looks like.

Spanish could have given the supposing form its own set of broken verbs. Instead it built the form out of one that was already broken, so the damage is paid for once and reused. Learn *tuvieron* and you have *tuviera* for nothing.

Which is why the plural had to come first. It was never only about saying *they had*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *tuvieron* → *tuviera*, *fueron* → *fuera*
- *hicieron* → *hiciera*, *estuvieron* → *estuviera*

Twice through:

Before you move on

How many new stems? (**None.**) Which form serves two verbs?
(***Fuera.***)

And why did the preterite plural have to come first? (Because **this form is cut out of it.**)

Chapter 208

Si Tuviera — Supposing What Is Not So

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what would happen if something untrue were true.

I can say what would happen if something untrue were true.

208.1 si tuviera

Say the real one. (*Si tengo tiempo, hablo español.*) Now the supposing form of *tener*. (*Tuviera.*)

Put them together and you can talk about a day you are not having.

Grammar Lens: the world that is not the case

si + supposing form, then the *-ría* form.

<i>Si tengo tiempo, hablo español.</i>	and I might well have it
<i>Si tuviera tiempo, hablaría español.</i>	but I do not

The second sentence says two things at once: what would happen, **and** that it is not happening. That is carried entirely by the verb forms — no extra word is needed to say *but I don't*.

Both halves change together. *Si* takes the supposing form; the result half takes the *-ría* form you learned for *would*. Neither half can be left in the present.

Why it's said this way

And *si* never takes the present subjunctive. Not *si tenga* — that combination simply does not occur in Spanish. The supposing form after *si* is always the *-ra* one.

It is worth knowing why the pairing feels lopsided. The *si* half is not asserting anything, so it uses the form Spanish reserves for the unasserted — and the result half **is** making a claim, just a claim about a world that does not exist, which is what *-ría* is for. Two different jobs, two different forms, in one sentence.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *Si tuviera tiempo, hablaría español*
- the real version, then the unreal one, back to back

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which form follows *si* here? (The **supposing** form — *tuviera*.)

Which follows the comma? (The ***-ría*** form.)

And what does the sentence say besides its words? (That the thing **is not true**.)

Chapter 209

Review — the Two Conditions

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can choose between a real and an unreal condition and get both halves right.

I can choose between a real and an unreal condition and get both halves right.

209.1 Review — the two conditions

Which follows *si* in a real condition? (The **present**.) In an unreal one? (The **supposing** form.)

What you've built

Say each one aloud, one after another. They are three sentences about the same afternoon, and only the verbs differ.

Si tengo tiempo, hablo español. — whenever it happens

Si tengo tiempo, hablaré español. — a plan for today

Si tuviera tiempo, hablaría español. — but I do not have it

Notice what *si* itself contributes: **nothing**. The same three letters open all three. Everything that tells the worlds apart is carried by the verbs standing on either side of it.

Grammar Lens: the two rules that never bend

The future never follows *si*. *Si tendré* is not said. If the result is in the future, the *si* half stays in the present.

The present subjunctive never follows *si* either. *Si tenga* is not said. Supposing after *si* is always the *-ra* form.

Two prohibitions, one word. Everything else about *si* is free.

Your turn

- *Say it:* the three sentences, in order

Twice through:

Before you move on

How many worlds can you now describe? (**Three** — habitual, planned, and not the case.) What does *si* change between them? (**Nothing**.) And which two forms may never follow it? (The **future** and the **present subjunctive**.)

Chapter 210

Synthesis — Supposing Out Loud

Modes:  voice (2)  Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can speak about a world that does not exist.

I can speak about a world that does not exist.

210.1 Synthesis — supposing out loud

Build the supposing form of *ser*. (*Fuera.*) Of *hacer*. (*Hiciera.*)

Now use one.

What you've built

Say these, and hear how much each one carries:

Si fuera profesor, hablaría español todos los días.

Si tuviera tiempo, comería en casa.

Each says what would happen **and** that it is not happening, in one breath and with no extra words. English needs *but I'm not* to be quite that clear; Spanish puts it in the verb endings.

This is the first thing in this book you can say about a world that does not exist. Everything before it described what is, was, or will be.

Grammar Lens: what the climb cost

Look back at what this one sentence needed.

It needed *si*, which cost one chapter. It needed the *-ría* form, which you had already. And it needed the supposing form — which needed the **preterite plural**, a gap nobody would have named as the thing standing between you and hypothetical speech.

That is worth remembering the next time something in this language looks arbitrary. The order things must be learned in is rarely the order they look important in.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *Si fuera profesor, hablaría español todos los días*
- an unreal condition of your own

Twice through:

Before you move on

What can you now say that you could not before? (Something about a world that **is not the case**.) And what had to be built first? (The **preterite plural** — and nobody would have guessed it.)

210.2 **depende** — the condition you do not have to finish

You have spent two chapters building conditions with both halves: *si* plus a situation, then what follows. This is the word for when you want the condition without saying what it is.

What to know first

- supposing out loud — the real and unreal conditions this word stands in for.

Sounds you'll need

- Three syllables, stress in the middle: *de-PEN-de*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

depende — “it depends.” Latin *de-* (“down from”) plus *pendere* (“to hang”). To depend on something is to **hang from** it, and the metaphor is still doing work: the answer is suspended from a condition, and until the condition settles the answer swings. That *pendere* is a generous root. It gave English **pendant** (a thing that hangs), **pending** (still hanging), **suspend**, and — by way of a hanging scale pan — **pensive** and even **pound**, because things were weighed by hanging them.

What you've built

Every condition you have built so far names its own *si*. *Depende* is the one that does not: it asserts that a condition exists and declines to state it, which is why it is such a useful answer to a question you are not ready to answer.

Add *de* and you can name it after all — *depende de ti*, “it depends on you.” The condition stops being a mystery and becomes a thing you point at.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *depende* — stress the middle
- name the condition — *depende de ti*
- the same answer the long way, with a full *si* sentence

Before you move on

What does *pendere* mean, and what is hanging? (To hang — the answer hangs from the condition.) Which English words share the root? (**Pendant, pending, suspend.**) What do you add to name the condition? (*De.*)

Chapter 211

Dice Que — Someone Else's Sentence, Inside Yours

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can report what someone says right now.

I can report what someone says right now.

211.1 dice que

Decir, in the present, for one person. (*Digo, dices, dice.*)

And one thing you can say about someone. (*Está cansado.*)

Grammar Lens: one sentence inside another

You already have two whole sentences:

Dice. — he says. *Está cansado.* — he is tired.

Reporting is nothing more than putting the second one **inside** the first, and the joint between them is *que*:

Dice que está cansado.

Notice what did **not** happen. The inner sentence was not taken apart. *Está cansado* went in whole, exactly as it would be said on its own.

Why it's said this way

English lets the joint vanish. *He says he's tired* is ordinary English, and so is *He says that he's tired* — both are available.

Spanish has only one of those. *Dice que está cansado* is the sentence; the version without *que* is not a shorter way of saying it, it is not a sentence at all.

This is the second time you have met that refusal. When *que* joined a noun to a clause — *el libro que compré* — it could not be dropped either, while English happily says *the book I bought*. Same word, same job description: *que* is the piece that tells you a clause is arriving. Spanish will not begin a clause without announcing it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *Dice que está cansado*
- the same thing about yourself

Twice through:

Before you move on

What sits at the joint between the two sentences? (*Que.*)

And may it be left out, as English leaves out *that*? (**No** — and you have now seen *que* refuse to vanish twice.)

Chapter 212

Dijo — The Stem That Breaks Its Own Rule

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what someone said, and say it in the plural without inventing a syllable.

I can say what someone said, and say it in the plural without inventing a syllable.

212.1 dijo

The strong pattern, once more: a stem that changed shape, and then endings that carry no stress. (*Tuve*, *tuvo*.)

One more stem is about to join them.

Grammar Lens: the stem is dij-

Decir builds its past on **dij-**, and in the singular nothing is new at all:

tuve · *tuvo*

the stem you know

dije · ***dijo***

the same endings, on a new stem

Unstressed at the end, exactly like the others. *Dijo*, not *dijó*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin said **dīxit**. That *x* stood for a [ks] — the sound at the end of English *box*.

Old Spanish kept the letter and softened the sound: *dixo*, with the *x* said roughly like English *sh*. Centuries later that sound hardened at the back of the mouth into the one *j* spells today, and the spelling followed the sound. **dīxit** → **dixo** → **dijo**.

So the *j* in *dijo* is not a decoration. It is a Latin *x*, wearing modern clothes.

Grammar Lens: where it breaks the pattern

You learned the strong plural as stem plus *-ieron*: *tuvieron*, *hicieron*, *estuvieron*. Apply that here and you would get *dijieron*.

It is *dijeron*. The *i* is gone.

The *i* in *-ieron* is not a full vowel — it is a glide, the *y* sound of English *yes*, leaning on the vowel after it. And Spanish does not keep a glide next to a sound already made in that part of the mouth. The *j* was there first, so the glide goes.

This is not a fact about *decir*. **Any strong stem ending in *j* does it**, and you will meet more of them; when you do, the ending will already be familiar.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *dije*, *dijo*, *dijeron*
- *tuvieron*, then *dijeron*, and hear the difference

Twice through:

Before you move on

The stem? (***Dij-***.) The *they* form? (***Dijeron*** — no *i*.)

And is that an exception you must memorise for this one verb, or a rule? (A **rule**, for every strong stem that ends in *j*.)

Chapter 213

Dijo Que — Both Verbs Step Back

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can report what someone said, with the tense the report actually needs.

I can report what someone said, with the tense the report actually needs.

213.1 dijo que

Report it in the present. (*Dice que está cansado.*)

Now move only the first verb into the past. (*Dijo...*)

Grammar Lens: both verbs move

*Dice que **está** cansado. Dijo que **estaba** cansado.*

The inner sentence cannot stay in the present once the reporting has moved back. It steps back too — into the **imperfect**.

Two more, so the shape is unmistakable:

now	reported later
<i>Dice que trabaja.</i>	<i>Dijo que trabajaba.</i>
<i>Dice que hace calor.</i>	<i>Dijo que hacía calor.</i>

Why it's said this way

Of the two pasts you own, why this one?

Because of what the imperfect was always for: **what was going on**, rather than what happened and finished. And that is precisely what a report describes. He was tired *at the moment he spoke* — not for an instant, and with no news about when it started or stopped.

The preterite would say something else entirely. It would package his tiredness as one completed event, which is not what he told you.

So the backshift is not a rule about reporting at all. It is the imperfect doing the job it has always done, in a place you had not needed it yet.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *Dijo que estaba cansado*
- the present version, then the reported one, back to back

Twice through:

Before you move on

When *dice* becomes *dijo*, what happens to the verb after *que*? (It moves into the **imperfect**.)

And why that past and not the other one? (Because the report is about **what was going on** when he spoke.)

Chapter 214

Preguntó Si — A Question That Stops Being One

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can report a yes-or-no question somebody asked.

I can report a yes-or-no question somebody asked.

214.1 preguntó si

Report a statement. (*Dijo que trabajaba.*)

Now the past of *preguntar*, which is perfectly ordinary. (*Preguntó.*)

Grammar Lens: a question, reported

¿Trabaja? — the question, as asked. **Preguntó si trabajaba.** — the question, reported.

Two things changed, and both are worth naming.

The joint is *si*, not *que*. A statement goes in on *que*; a yes-or-no question goes in on *si*. The verb still steps back into the imperfect, exactly as before — that part has not changed at all.

Why it's said this way

And the question marks are gone. Not forgotten — *not allowed*. Look at what the reported sentence actually does: it tells you something. It is a statement about an act of asking, and nobody is being asked anything. The marks belong to a question being put, and no question is being put here.

So *¿Preguntó si trabajaba?* is a real sentence, but it means something else — it asks whether he asked.

Now the *si* itself. It is the same *si* that opens a condition, and that is not a coincidence dressed up as one. Both uses hold something open that has not been settled: *si tengo tiempo* leaves the time unsettled, *si trabajaba* leaves the answer unsettled. English splits the job between *whether* and *if*. Spanish never needed to.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *Preguntó si trabajaba*
- the question as asked, then the report

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which word joins a reported yes-or-no question? (***Si***)
And what happened to the question marks? (They **went**, because the sentence no longer asks anything.)

Chapter 215

Preguntó Dónde — What the Accent Was Always For

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) 🗉 Hands-free start: none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can report a question that begins with an asking word, accent intact.

I can report a question that begins with an asking word, accent intact.

215.1 preguntó dónde

Report a yes-or-no question. (*Preguntó si trabajaba.*)

Now one that cannot be answered with yes or no: ¿Dónde trabaja?

Grammar Lens: the asking word is the joint

¿Dónde trabaja? **Preguntó dónde trabajaba.**

No *que*. No *si*. The asking word **is** the joint — it was already at the front of the question, and it stays there.

The rest is what you already do: question marks gone, verb stepped back into the imperfect.

Why it's said this way

Now look at *dónde* in that reported sentence. **The accent is still there** — in a sentence with no question marks at all.

This is the answer to a question you may have been carrying since the sixth chapter. The accent was never a partner to the question marks. It marks the word as an **asking** word, and the asking is still inside the report: he wanted to know something, and *dónde* is the something. Compare the two jobs the same letters can do:

<i>donde</i>	plain — it just points at a place
<i>dónde</i>	asking — it wants the place
	named

The marks around a sentence tell you the *sentence* is a question. The accent on a word tells you the *word* is doing the asking. Those are different facts, and only now do you have a sentence where one is true and the other is not.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *Preguntó dónde trabajaba*
- *Preguntó si trabajaba*, then *Preguntó dónde trabajaba*

Twice through:

Before you move on

What joins the report when the question starts with an asking word? (**The asking word itself** — no *que*, no *si*.)

And what does the accent on *dónde* mark? (That the **word** is asking — not that the sentence is a question.)

Chapter 216

Review — Three Joints, Two Constants

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can choose the right joint for anything I am reporting.

I can choose the right joint for anything I am reporting.

216.1 (review)

Two forms first, because the rest is built on them. *He said.*
(*Dijo.*) *They said.* (*Dijeron* — no *i.*)

What you've built

Three chants. Say each one, then say what it is for.

First. *Dijo que trabajaba.* — a statement goes in on **que**, and *que* may never be dropped.

Second. *Preguntó si trabajaba.* — a yes-or-no question goes in on **si**, the same *si* that opens a condition.

Third. *Preguntó dónde trabajaba.* — a question that starts with an asking word brings **its own joint**, accent and all.

Grammar Lens: the two things that never change

Whatever the joint, two things are true of all three chants.

One. The inner verb steps back into the imperfect — because a report

says what was going on when somebody spoke.

Two. The question marks go. A report tells; it does not ask. And yet the accent on *dónde* stays, because that accent was never marking the sentence — it marks the word that does the asking.

Your turn

- *Say it:* the three chants, in order, without looking

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which tense does the inner verb land in, every time? (The **imperfect**.)

And one word to keep, for the pleasure of it: what is the *j* of *dijo*, historically? (A Latin *x*. *Dixit*, *dixi*, *dijo*.)

Chapter 217

Synthesis — Carrying a Conversation

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can report a whole exchange to somebody who was not there.

I can report a whole exchange to somebody who was not there.

217.1 (synthesis)

Here is a very short conversation. Two people, four lines.

— ¿Dónde trabajas? — Trabajo en casa. — ¿Estás cansado? — Sí.

You were there. Somebody else was not.

What you've built

Carry it across, line by line. Every line needs a joint, and the joint is different every time.

The first line was a question with an asking word. (*Preguntó dónde trabajaba.*)

The second was a statement. (*Dijo que trabajaba en casa.*)

The third was a yes-or-no question. (*Preguntó si estaba cansado.*)

Your turn

- *Say it:* all three reports, one after another, without stopping

Twice through:

Before you move on

Read your three sentences back and name what is **not** in them. (No question marks — and not one verb left in the present.)

Four lines of live speech went in; one steady account came out.

What is new is not that you said something in Spanish — it is that you **carried** somebody else's words to a person who was not there, and marked every seam where they stopped being your own.

Chapter 218

Pero — Two True Things at Once

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can hold two facts against each other without denying either.

I can hold two facts against each other without denying either.

218.1 pero — the word that lets two true things stand together

With *porque* you can give a reason: one thing **because of** another. That word makes two facts agree.

Now you need the opposite tool — the one for two facts that **do not** agree, and are both true anyway.

Sounds you'll need

- **r-tap** — one flick of the tongue, not the rolled *rr*. **pero** = *PEH-ro*. (The rolled version is a different word entirely, so this flick is worth getting right.)

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

pero was **two** Latin words: **per hoc** — *by this, through this*.

You can still feel the route it took. *By this* became *for all that*, and *for all that* is already a contrast: I grant you the first thing, and here is the second anyway. The phrase wore down into one short word and kept only the contrast.

*Estoy cansado, **pero** estudio.*

Why it's said this way

Notice what *pero* does **not** do. It does not deny the first half. *Estoy cansado* stays true — tiredness is not cancelled by studying. That is the whole job: two things that pull in opposite directions, both standing. *Porque* fuses two facts into one reason; *pero* keeps two facts apart and admits both. Between them you can say almost anything. And it is the first word of every argument you will ever make. Nobody argues by listing things they agree with.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *Estoy cansado, pero estudio*
- something true about today, then *pero*, then something that pulls the other way

Twice through:

Before you move on

Porque joins two facts into one reason. What does *pero* do with two facts? (**Keeps them apart, and admits both.**)
And what were its two Latin words? (*Per hoc* — *by this.*)

Chapter 219

También — Your First Word, Hidden Inside

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can agree with what somebody just said, in two words.

I can agree with what somebody just said, in two words.

219.1 también — a word with your very first word inside it

Pero sets two things against each other. Now the opposite move: adding one thing **to** another.

And say *bien*, from your first chapter. You will need it in a moment, in a place you would not expect.

Sounds you'll need

- **accent-mark** — the accent on **también** puts the stress on the last syllable: *tam-BYEN*.
- **b-soft** — the *b* here is gentle, the lips barely closing.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

también = **tan** + **bien**.

Tan means *so, as* — it is the word Spanish uses to say how much of

something there is. And **bien** you have had since chapter one. So *también* is, literally, “**so well**”. Somebody says a thing; you say *and that goes so well for me too*. Say it enough times and it stops being a comment about how well anything is going, and becomes the plain word for *also*.

Estudio español. Trabajo también.

Why it's said this way

The most useful shape it takes is the shortest one:

— *Estoy cansado.* — ***Yo también.***

Two words, and you have agreed with somebody. That is worth more in a real conversation than most of the grammar in this book, and it costs nothing to remember, because you already knew half of it. Notice the accent, too. It is there because *también* is stressed on its last syllable, which is where the *bien* sits — the borrowed half kept the stress it had when it was a word of its own.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *Yo también*
- *Estudio español. Trabajo también.*

Twice through:

Before you move on

What is *también*, taken apart? (***Tan*** + ***bien*** — *so well*.)
And which half have you known since the very beginning? (***Bien***.)

Chapter 220

Tampoco — The Same Frame, the Other Half

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can agree with a no as easily as with a yes.

I can agree with a no as easily as with a yes.

220.1 tampoco — the same frame, the other half

Yo también agrees with somebody who said a **yes**.

But what do you say to somebody who said a **no**? English changes word there too — *me too* becomes *me neither*.

Sounds you'll need

- **k-hard** — the *c* before *o* is a plain *k*. **tampoco** = *tam-PO-ko*, with no accent to write, because the stress already falls where Spanish expects it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

tampoco = **tan** + **poco**.

The same *tan* you met yesterday. The new half is **poco**, which means *little* — a small amount of something.

<i>también</i>	tan + bien	so well
<i>tampoco</i>	tan + poco	so little

One frame, two fillings. You are not learning a second word here so much as turning the first one over.

Why it's said this way

— *No estoy cansado.* — ***Yo tampoco.***

The rule is simple and it is about the **other** person's sentence, not yours. If what they said was positive, you answer *yo también*. If it had a *no* in it, you answer *yo tampoco*.

Getting this wrong is one of the most audible mistakes a learner can make, and it is entirely avoidable: listen for the *no*. If you heard one, use the *poco* word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *Yo también*, then *Yo tampoco*
- *No estoy cansado.* — *Yo tampoco.*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Tan + bien is *so well*. What is *tan + poco*? (**So little** — *tampoco*.)
And what in the other person's sentence decides between the two?
(A **no**.)

Chapter 221

Este — Pointing at What Is in Your Hand

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗋️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can point at something next to me.

I can point at something next to me.

221.1 este — pointing at what is in your hand

El libro names a book. But which one?

If it is in your hand, you need a word that **points**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

este libro — *this book*, the one right here.

It agrees like any other word that leans on a noun:

<i>este libro</i>	this book
<i>esta casa</i>	this house
<i>estos libros</i>	these books
<i>estas casas</i>	these houses

Latin's word was **iste**, and it did not mean *this*. It meant **that of yours** — it pointed at the person being spoken to. Spanish walked it one step closer, off the listener and onto the speaker's own hand, and it has stayed there ever since.

Why it's said this way

Now the part English speakers get wrong, and it is a rule rather than a habit.

este libro — never *el este libro*.

The pointing word goes **in front** of the noun, and it takes the article's place. It does not stand beside it. You cannot have both, because both are doing the same job — saying *which one* — and Spanish only lets one word do that job at a time.

So the moment you reach for *este*, the *el* you were about to say is already spoken for.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *este libro, esta casa*
- *estos libros, estas casas*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Where does *este* stand, and what does it push out? (**Before** the noun, in the **article's** place.)

And who did Latin's *iste* originally point at? (**You** — the person being spoken to. Spanish moved it closer.)

Chapter 222

Ese — Pointing at What Is by You

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can point at something on my listener's side.

I can point at something on my listener's side.

222.1 ese — pointing at what is by you

Este libro is the one in my hand.

Remember where *este* came from: it used to point at **you**. So when it moved to me, something had to take over the job it left behind.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ese libro — *that book*, the one near **you**.

<i>ese libro</i>	that book, by you
<i>esa casa</i>	that house, by you
<i>esos libros</i>	those books
<i>esas casas</i>	those houses

The word that stepped in was Latin *ipse*, which meant **self** — the same *ipse* in the Latin phrase *ipso facto*, “by the fact itself”.

You can feel how it got the job. *That very one, that one itself* — an emphasiser that keeps insisting on a particular thing eventually stops emphasising and simply **points**.

Why it's said this way

So the difference between *este* and *ese* is not distance in metres. It is **whose side the thing is on**.

Este libro — mine, here. *Ese libro* — yours, there.

Two people sitting at one small table will still say *este* and *ese* about books a hand's width apart, because the question was never how far away the book is. It is which of us it belongs to in this moment.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *este libro*, then *ese libro*
- *esa casa*, *esos libros*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Whose side is *ese* on? (**Yours** — the listener's.)

And what filled the slot when *iste* moved closer? (***Ipse***, the word for *self*.)

Chapter 223

Aquel — The Far One, and an Old Friend

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can point at something away from us both.

I can point at something away from us both.

223.1 aquel — the far one, and an old friend in disguise

Mine, here: *este libro*. Yours, there: *ese libro*.

Now the one across the room, belonging to neither of us.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

aquel libro — *that book over there*.

<i>aquel libro</i>	that book, over there
<i>aquella casa</i>	that house, over there
<i>aquellos libros</i>	those books, over there
<i>aquellas casas</i>	those houses, over there

Look at the middle of that word. **-el-**. You have met it before, in your **first chapter**.

Latin *ille* went two ways at once. Said quickly and without stress,

leaning on the noun after it, it wore down to *el* — the article. Said with stress, and propped up in front with **accu-** (roughly *look, there*), it stayed a pointing word: **accu + ille** → **aque***l*. So *el* and *aque**l* are the same Latin word, and the difference between them is two thousand years of one being emphasised and the other not.

Why it's said this way

That leaves Spanish with **three**, where English has two:

<i>este</i>	by me
<i>ese</i>	by you
<i>aquel</i>	by neither of us

English collapses the last two into *that* and then patches the difference back on when it matters — *that one over there*. Spanish keeps the three apart in the word itself, so it never needs the patch.

And the middle one is the one to watch. If you find yourself reaching for *aquel* because the thing is a few steps away, stop and ask the real question: is it near the person you are talking to? If it is, it is *ese*, however far it is from you.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *este libro, ese libro, aquel libro*
- *aquella casa, aquellos libros*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Three words, three places. Which one is by the person you are talking to? (**Ese**.)

And what did *el* and *aquel* both start out as? (Latin **ille** — one worn down, one propped up.)

Chapter 224

Esto, Eso, Aquello — Pointing at What Has No Name

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🖐️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can point at something I cannot name, or at a whole situation.

I can point at something I cannot name, or at a whole situation.

224.1 esto · eso · aquello — pointing at what has no name yet

Este libro, esa casa. Both pointing words agreed with a noun.

But what do you say when there **is** no noun — when you do not know what the thing is, or when the thing is not a thing at all?

Grammar Lens: the third set

There is one more form of each, ending in **-o**:

<i>esto</i>	this, here, whatever it is
<i>eso</i>	that, by you, whatever it is
<i>aquello</i>	that, over there, whatever it is

These never sit in front of a noun. They **are** the noun.

¿*Qué es esto?* — What is this?

Este could not ask that: it needs a word to lean on, and the whole

point of the question is that you have not got one.

Why it's said this way

Spanish nouns are masculine or feminine — you learned that in chapter one, and it has held ever since. So what gender is *esto*?

Neither. It is the one leftover of a third gender Latin had and Spanish otherwise abandoned, kept for exactly this job: pointing at what has not been sorted into a gender, **because it has not been named.**

Which is also how you point at a whole situation — *Eso está bien*. Not a book, not a house; the thing just said. Nothing there has a gender, so the form that agrees with nothing fits.

Name it, and agreement returns: *¿Qué es esto?* — *Es un libro.* — *Ah, ese libro.*

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *¿Qué es esto?*
- *esto, eso, aquello*

Twice through:

Before you move on

When do you use the *-o* form? (When there is **no noun** — you cannot name it, or it is a whole situation.)

And can *esto* stand in front of a noun? (**No.** It *is* the noun.)

Chapter 225

Review — Three Places, One Question

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can choose the right pointing word without stopping to think.

I can choose the right pointing word without stopping to think.

225.1 (review)

Three words, three places, in order. (*Este, ese, aquel.*)

What you've built

Three chants. Say each one, then say who it belongs to.

First. *Este libro* — **by me**. The word Latin used to point at you, walked one step closer.

Second. *Ese libro* — **by you**. The word that used to mean *self*, moved in when the first one left.

Third. *Aquel libro* — **by neither**. The word that also became *el*, kept stressed and propped up so it could go on pointing.

Grammar Lens: one question, asked twice

Everything else here is two questions, in this order.

Do I have a noun? If no, use the *-o* form and stop: *esto, eso, aquello*. Nothing to agree with, so nothing agrees.

If yes — whose side is it on? Then pick from the three, agree it with the noun, and put it **in front**, in the article's place. Never *el este libro*; the pointing word already did the article's job.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the three chants, in order, without looking
- *¿Qué es esto?*, then answer it and point again with a noun

Twice through:

Before you move on

Two origins worth keeping. What did *ese* mean in Latin? (*Self*.)
And which everyday word is *aquel* related to? (*El* — both from *ille*, one worn down, one propped up.)

Chapter 226

Muy — The Same Word, Bitten Short

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say that something is very something.

I can say that something is very something.

226.1 muy — the same word, bitten short

You have said *mucho* since chapter six — *mucho gusto*.

Now you want to say that something is **very** something.
Cansado is tired; how do you say *very tired*?

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

*Estoy **muy** cansado.*

muy is not a new word to learn. It is **mucho**, with its ending bitten off. Both are Latin **multum**, *much* — one kept whole, one worn short. Spanish does this a lot: a long form for standing alone, a short form for leaning on the word after it. You will meet the same trick again in this chapter's neighbours.

Why it's said this way

The two shapes are not interchangeable, and the rule is easy because the word tells you itself.

<i>mucho</i> café	in front of a noun — the long form
<i>muy</i> grande	in front of an adjective — the short one
<i>muy</i> bien	in front of an adverb — the short one

So *muy* never stands alone. If somebody asks how you are and you want to say *very*, you cannot answer *muy* — there is nothing for it to lean on. You would answer *muy bien*.
And this is the strongest *very* Spanish has in one word. *Muy grande* is as big as *grande* gets without reaching for another sentence.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *muy bien*, *muy grande*, *muy cansado*
- *mucho* café, then *muy grande*, and hear which is which

Twice through:

Before you move on

Long form or short form in front of an adjective? (**Short** — *muy*.)
And how many Latin words are *muy* and *mucho* between them?
(**One** — *multum*.)

Chapter 227

Bastante — An Ending You Can Already Read

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say that something is enough, or quite so.

I can say that something is enough, or quite so.

227.1 bastante — an ending you can already read

The ending **-ante**, from chapter fifty-two. *Estudiante* — the one who studies. It turns a verb into *the one doing it*.

Keep that in mind; it is about to hand you a word for free.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

There is a verb **bastar**, *to be enough*. Put your ending on it:

bast- + **-ante** → **bastante**, “sufficing”.

So *bastante* does not mean *a lot*. It means **enough** — and from there, *quite, fairly*. It is the amount that suffices, not the amount that impresses.

Estoy bastante cansado. — I’m quite tired.

Why it's said this way

You now hold a scale, and it is worth saying out loud in order:

<i>poco</i>	little
<i>bastante</i>	enough, quite
<i>muy</i>	very

Notice where *bastante* sits. English speakers reach for it thinking *quite a lot*, and land higher than they meant. It is the middle of the scale, not the top — the top is *muy*.

And unlike *muy*, it is not fussy about what follows: *bastante café*, *bastante grande*. Only *muy* insists on leaning on an adjective or an adverb.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *poco*, *bastante*, *muy*, in order
- *Estoy bastante cansado*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Where does *bastante* sit on the scale? (In the **middle** — enough, not very.)

And which of the three refuses to sit in front of a noun? (***Muy***.)

Chapter 228

Mal — Bien Finally Gets Its Opposite

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say that something is bad, or going badly.

I can say that something is bad, or going badly.

228.1 mal — bien finally gets its opposite

Bien has been with you since chapter one, and so has *bueno*.

Both have an opposite, and the pair works exactly the same way.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Malo is the adjective — *bad*. **Mal** is what is left of it when it goes in front of a masculine noun, and it is also the adverb — *badly*.

<i>bien</i> / mal	well / badly
<i>bueno</i> / malo	good / bad

Estoy mal. — I'm not well.

Both come straight from Latin: *bene* and **malus**, which you can still hear in English *malady* and *malice*.

Why it's said this way

Now look at what has happened twice in three chapters.

long form	short form	short one appears
<i>mucho</i>	<i>muy</i>	before an adjective or adverb
<i>malo</i>	<i>mal</i>	before a masculine noun, and as the adverb

This is not two exceptions. It is one habit of the language: Spanish **bites the ending off a word that is leaning on another word**, and keeps it whole when it stands on its own.

Once you have heard it twice you will start noticing it everywhere, and it stops being something to memorise. A short form is a word in a hurry to get to the next one.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *bien*, then *mal*
- *mucho* / *muy*, then *malo* / *mal*, and hear the same trick twice

Twice through:

Before you move on

When does Spanish bite the ending off? (When the word is **leaning on** another word.)

And which English words still carry Latin *malus*? (*Malady*, *malice*.)

Chapter 229

Review — One Scale, One Habit

Modes: 🔄 voice (1) 🔄 Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can place a thing on a scale, and recognise a shortened word.

I can place a thing on a scale, and recognise a shortened word.

229.1 (review)

The scale, least to most. (*Poco, bastante, muy.*)

What you've built

Three chants. Say each, then say what it is for.

First. *Estoy muy cansado.* — **Muy** is the top of the scale, and it is *mucho* with its ending bitten off.

Second. *Estoy bastante cansado.* — **Bastante** is the middle, and it means *sufficing*: *bastar* plus the *-ante* you could already read.

Third. *Estoy mal.* — **Mal** is the opposite of *bien*, and it is *malo* with its ending bitten off.

Grammar Lens: the habit underneath

Two of those three came in a long form and a short one, and that is the thing worth carrying out of this chapter.

Mucho keeps its ending in front of a noun and loses it in front of an adjective. *Malo* keeps its ending standing alone and loses it in front of a masculine noun. Different words, one habit: **the ending goes**

when the word is leaning on the next one.

So when you meet a short Spanish word that looks like a longer one you already know, that is usually what has happened — not a new word to learn.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the three chants, in order
- *mucho* / *muy*, then *malo* / *mal*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which of the three refuses to stand in front of a noun? (***Muy***.)
And which one refuses to stand alone as an answer? (***Muy*** again — *muy bien*, never just *muy*.)

Chapter 230

Al — Two Words Spanish Will Not Keep Apart

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say where I am going, with the article fused on.

I can say where I am going, with the article fused on.

230.1 al — two words Spanish will not let you keep apart

You have *a* — *to*, *towards*. And you have *el*.

Put them together and say it quickly. *A el... a el...* Hear what your mouth wants to do.

Grammar Lens: the squeeze

$a + el \rightarrow al$

*Voy **al** café.* — I'm going to the café.

This is not an option and not a shortcut for speaking fast. It is how the language is **written**. *A el café* is not a more careful version of *al café*; it is simply wrong.

Why it's said this way

You met this instinct two chapters ago, when *mucho* lost its ending in front of an adjective. Spanish does not like a word standing about doing nothing while another word waits: **when one word leans on the next, something gives.** Here the two words simply fuse. And there is one exception worth knowing, because it looks like a mistake and is not. When *El* is part of a **name**, it keeps its distance:

Voy a El Salvador. — not *al Salvador.*

What contracts is the little article — not every word that happens to be spelled *el*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *al café, al profesor*
- *Voy al café*

Twice through:

Before you move on

A plus *el* makes what? (***Al*** — always.)

And when does it not happen? (When ***El*** is part of a **name**.)

Chapter 231

Del — And Then the List Stops

Modes:  voice (1)  Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say whose something is, and I know both contractions exist.

I can say whose something is, and I know both contractions exist.

231.1 del — and then the list stops

A + el gave you *al*. Now take *de*, which you have had since chapter forty-eight.

Say *de el* quickly, and let the same thing happen.

Grammar Lens: the second squeeze

de + el → **del**

el libro del profesor — the teacher's book

Same rule, same force. And notice what *del* is doing in that phrase: Spanish has no apostrophe-s, so *of the* is how it says whose something is. *Del profesor* — of the teacher.

Why it's said this way

Now the part worth celebrating.

That is the complete list. Spanish has exactly **two** obligatory contractions — *al* and *del* — and no others. Not *de la*, not *a la*, not *de*

los. Those stay two words forever.

a + el

al

de + el

del

a la, de la, a los, de las

unchanged

It is rare to be handed a grammar rule and told the exceptions are finished. Learn these two and you will never wonder about a third.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *al café, del café*
- *el libro del profesor*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Name both contractions. (***Al*** and ***del***.)

And how many more are there to learn? (**None.** That is the whole list.)

Chapter 232

Quién — The Asking Word for People

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask who somebody is.

I can ask who somebody is.

232.1 quién — the asking word reserved for people

¿*Qué es esto?* asks about a **thing**.

But you cannot ask ¿*Qué es* about a person and expect a name. For people, Spanish keeps a different word entirely.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

¿*Quién es?* — Who is it?

It carries the accent, like every asking word, and it sits between the two marks.

Latin had **quis** for *who* — but the form Spanish kept is **quem**, the shape the word took when it was the **object** of the sentence. Latin marked that job with an ending; Spanish threw the endings away and was left holding this one form, which then had to do every job. So *quién* is an old object-form doing subject work, and has been since before anyone noticed.

Why it's said this way

The division is simple and it does not bend:

<i>qué</i>	things, ideas, anything not a person
<i>quién</i>	people, and only people

English blurs this — *what is that person to you?* is fine English. Spanish will not: if the answer is a person, the question takes *quién*. And it has a plural, which English does not. If you expect more than one person in the answer, you ask *quiénes*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *¿Quién es?*
- *¿Qué es esto?*, then *¿Quién es?*, and hear the split

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which asking word is reserved for people? (*Quién*.)
And what do you ask when you expect several? (*Quiénes*.)

Chapter 233

O — One Letter, One Catch

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can offer a choice between two things.

I can offer a choice between two things.

233.1 o — one letter, one catch

Y joins two things: *café y agua*.

Now the other one — not both, but a choice between them.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

¿Café **o** agua? — Coffee or water?

o is the whole word. Latin's was **aut**, and it wore all the way down to a single letter — which is about as far as a word can go without disappearing.

Why it's said this way

And that is the problem. A word one letter long is easy to lose. Say *siete o ocho* — *seven or eight* — quickly, and the *o* is swallowed by the *o* of *ocho*. So Spanish swaps it for a shape that cannot be swallowed:

*siete **u** ocho*

Nothing here is about meaning. *O* becomes ***u*** in front of a word that **begins with the *o* sound** — including one spelled with a silent *h*, because the *h* is not there to be heard.

It is the same instinct you have now seen three times: *mucho* into *muy*, *a el* into *al*, and now *o* into *u*. Spanish keeps rearranging small words so the next one stays audible.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- ¿Café *o* agua?
- siete *u* ocho

Twice through:

Before you move on

When does *o* become *u*? (Before a word that **starts with the *o* sound**.)

And is a silent *h* an obstacle? (**No** — the rule listens, it does not read.)

Chapter 234

Ni — Joining Two Absences

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say I want neither of two things.
I can say I want neither of two things.

234.1 ni — joining two absences

Y joins two things you have. *O* offers a choice between them.

Now: neither one.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

*No quiero café **ni** agua.* — I don't want coffee or water.

ni is Latin *nec*, and the important thing about it is that the *no* is **inside** the word. It does not mean *or*; it means *and not*.

So it is not the negative twin of *y*. It is a word that carries its own refusal, which is why it can start a phrase on its own: ***Ni** café.* — *Not even coffee.*

Why it's said this way

Look again at that sentence and count the negatives.

***No** quiero café **ni** agua.*

Two — and it is correct. English was taught to treat two negatives as cancelling out; Spanish never agreed. Here they **agree with each**

other instead: the sentence is negative, so every part of it that can be negative, is.

This is worth holding on to, because it will keep happening. Once a Spanish sentence turns negative, the negativity spreads rather than doubling back.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *No quiero café ni agua*
- *Ni café* — not even coffee

Twice through:

Before you move on

Two negatives in one Spanish sentence — right or wrong? (**Right.** They agree rather than cancel.)
And what is hiding inside *ni*? (A **no** — it means *and not*.)

Chapter 235

Review — Four Small Words, One Instinct

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can use the small joining words without hesitating.

I can use the small joining words without hesitating.

235.1 (review)

The two contractions, and nothing else on the list. (*Al, del.*)

What you've built

Four chants. Say each, then say what it does.

First. *Voy al café.* — *A* and *el* fuse, always, and *de* and *el* do the same. Those two, and no third.

Second. *¿Quién es?* — the asking word kept for **people**, where *qué* would ask about a thing.

Third. *Siete u ocho.* — *O* steps aside as **u** so it is not swallowed by the word after it.

Fourth. *No quiero café ni agua.* — *Ni* carries its own *no*, and two negatives in one Spanish sentence agree rather than cancel.

Grammar Lens: one instinct underneath

Three of those four are the same instinct wearing different clothes.
A el fuses. *De el* fuses. *O* changes shape. In each case a **small word leaning on a bigger one gives ground**, so that the bigger one stays audible. You saw it first when *mucho* became *muy*.

The fourth is different, and it is the one to keep separate in your head: *ni* is not about sound at all. It is about agreement — once the sentence is negative, its parts stay negative too.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the four chants, in order
- *al*, *del*, and then stop — there is no third

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which of the four is **not** about sound? (***Ni*** — it is about negatives agreeing.)

And what do the other three have in common? (A small word **gives ground** so the next one stays audible.)

Chapter 236

Hablando — An Action Caught in the Middle

Modes: 🔄 voice (1) 🔄 Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can form the -ando shape of an -ar verb.

I can form the -ando shape of an -ar verb.

236.1 hablando — an action caught in the middle

Hablo says that I speak. It does not say I am speaking **right now**, this minute, with my mouth open.

Spanish has a separate form for that, and it is built from the infinitive.

Grammar Lens: swap the ending

habl- ar → *habl- ando*

hablar

hablando

trabajar

trabajando

estudiar

estudiando

Take the *-ar* off, put *-ando* on. There is nothing to agree with and nothing to conjugate: **one form, for everybody**. After all the endings this book has asked you to learn, that is a holiday.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin had a form for an action thought of as a **thing being done** — the *gerund*, ending in *-ndum*. Spanish kept the ending almost untouched and threw away everything else about it: Latin's gerund had case endings, and Spanish's has none at all.

What survives is the meaning: not *to speak*, not *I speak*, but **speaking** — the action underway, with no beginning and no end attached.

English built its *-ing* separately and lands in almost the same place, which is why *hablando* feels immediately familiar. Almost. The two part company later, and this book will show you where.

Your turn

- Say it: *hablando, trabajando, estudiando*

Twice through:

Before you move on

What replaces the *-ar*? (**-ando**.)

And how many endings does this form have? (**One**. It agrees with nothing.)

Chapter 237

Comiendo, Viviendo — Two Families, One Ending

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗋️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can form the gerund of any regular verb.

I can form the gerund of any regular verb.

237.1 comiendo · viviendo — two families, one ending

Hablar gave *hablando*. Now the other two families.

Grammar Lens: -iendo, for both

<i>comer</i>	<i>comiendo</i>
<i>beber</i>	<i>bebiendo</i>
<i>vivir</i>	<i>viviendo</i>
<i>escribir</i>	<i>escribiendo</i>

One ending for both. Not *-endo* for *-er* and something else for *-ir* — the same *-iendo*, every time.

Why it's said this way

You have watched this happen before. In the preterite, the *-er* and *-ir* endings turned out to be identical, and the two families you had learned separately quietly became one.

Here it happens again, and more completely: there is not even a difference to notice. So the whole gerund is **two endings for three verb families**:

<i>-ar</i> verbs	<i>-ando</i>
everything else	<i>-iendo</i>

Two endings, no agreement, no persons. It is the smallest thing this book has asked you to learn, and it unlocks the next chapter entirely.

Your turn

- Say it: *hablando, comiendo, viviendo*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which ending do *-er* and *-ir* verbs share? (***-iendo***.)
And how many endings in total? (**Two**, for three families.)

Chapter 238

Estoy Hablando — The Payoff

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I am doing right now.
I can say what I am doing right now.

238.1 estoy hablando — the payoff

Estar, all the way through: *estoy, estás, está, estamos, están*.
And one gerund. Put them side by side.

Grammar Lens: standing in the middle of doing

Estoy hablando. — I am speaking, right now.

<i>Estoy comiendo.</i>	I'm eating
<i>Está trabajando.</i>	he's working
<i>Estamos estudiando.</i>	we're studying

Only *estar* changes. The gerund sits there, the same shape for everybody, which is why the whole construction costs you one verb you already knew and one ending.

Why it's said this way

It had to be *estar* rather than *ser*, and you already know why. *Estar* is the verb for how something **temporarily stands**. An action caught

mid-stride is as temporary as things get.
Now the difference from English, and it is worth having straight.
English uses *I'm* + *-ing* for the **future** all the time: *I'm eating with her tomorrow*. Spanish will not.

Estoy comiendo — I am eating, **at this moment**, food in hand.

For tomorrow, Spanish reaches for the form you learned at chapter 49: *voy a comer*. So the two languages look identical here and are not: the Spanish progressive means *now*, and only *now*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *Estoy hablando, Estoy comiendo*
- *Estoy comiendo* for now, then *Voy a comer* for tomorrow

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which verb carries the person — *estar* or the gerund? (***Estar***.)
And what can the Spanish progressive **not** do that the English one can? (Talk about the **future**.)

Chapter 239

Veo a María — The Little A That Guards People

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can mark the person on the receiving end of a verb.

I can mark the person on the receiving end of a verb.

239.1 veo a María — the little a that guards people

Veo — I see. And *a*, which you know as *to*, *towards*.

Watch what happens when what I see is a **person**.

Grammar Lens: it appears, then vanishes

Veo la casa.

I see the house

*Veo **a** María.*

I see María

Nothing in the English moved. In the Spanish, a preposition appeared out of nowhere — and it is not optional. *Veo María* is wrong.

It is not doing its usual job either. Nobody is going *towards* María.

The *a* is there purely because the thing being seen is a person.

Why it's said this way

Remember what happened to *quién*: Latin marked the object of a sentence with an **ending**, and Spanish threw those endings away. That was cheap for things — a house is unlikely to be seeing anybody — but expensive for people, because with two people in a sentence, word order alone has to carry who did what.

So Spanish grew a replacement. The little *a* marks the person on the **receiving** end, doing by hand the job the lost ending used to do for free.

Which is why it guards people and ignores houses. The ambiguity it protects against only ever arises with people.

Your turn

- *Say it: Veo la casa, then Veo a María*

Twice through:

Before you move on

When does the little *a* appear? (When the thing on the receiving end is a **person**.)

And is it optional? (**No.** *Veo María* is simply wrong.)

Chapter 240

Review — Two Endings and One Little A

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what is happening now, and mark a person correctly.

I can say what is happening now, and mark a person correctly.

240.1 (review)

Two endings, three families. (-*ando* for -*ar*; -*iendo* for everything else.)

What you've built

Three chants.

First. *Hablando, comiendo, viviendo.* — one form each, no agreement, no persons. The smallest thing this book has asked of you.

Second. *Estoy comiendo.* — *estar* carries the person, the gerund never moves. And it means **now**: for tomorrow you still say *voy a comer*.

Third. *Veo a María*, but *veo la casa*. — the little *a* in front of a person, and nothing in front of a house.

Grammar Lens: both of these are Latin's absence

The gerund is what is left of a Latin form after its case endings fell off — which is why it has exactly one shape and agrees with nothing. The personal *a* is what grew back **because** case endings fell off. Latin marked the receiving end with an ending; Spanish marks it with a preposition, but only where it matters, which is people. One rule is a leftover and the other is a repair. Same cause.

Your turn

- *Say it:* the three chants, in order

Twice through:

Before you move on

How many gerund endings? (**Two.**)
And which of this chapter's two rules is a **repair** rather than a leftover? (The **personal a** — it grew to replace a lost ending.)

Chapter 241

Hablasteis — The Form You Were Promised

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) 🗉 Hands-free start: none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can use every person of the -ar preterite.

I can use every person of the -ar preterite.

241.1 hablasteis — the form you were promised

The -ar past, as far as you have it: *hablé, hablaste, habló, hablamos, hablaron.*

Five of six. The review that closed the preterite told you the sixth was still owed. Here it is.

Grammar Lens: -steis

*vosotros **hablasteis*** — you all spoke

Look at it beside the *you* form you already know:

<i>tú</i>	<i>habla ste</i>
<i>vosotros</i>	<i>habla steis</i>

The same -*ste*, with -*is* stacked on the end. That -*is* is the plural marker you met back in the present, in *habláis*. Nothing here is new; it is two pieces you own, in a row.

Why it's said this way

And with that, the *-ar* preterite is **complete**:

hablé · hablaste · hablé · hablamos · hablasteis · hablaron

Six forms, no gaps. It is the first tense in this book you can say straight through without a promissory note at the end.

As with every *vosotros* form, you will hear it in Spain and rarely elsewhere — but you will **read** it everywhere, which is reason enough to know it on sight.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *hablaste*, then *hablasteis*
- all six, straight through

Twice through:

Before you move on

What is stacked on *-ste* to make *-steis*? (The plural **-is**.)

And how many gaps are left in the *-ar* past? (**None**.)

Chapter 242

Comisteis, Tuvisteis — The Last Gap Closes

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗋️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can use the whole preterite, regular and strong.

I can use the whole preterite, regular and strong.

242.1 comisteis · tuvisteis — the last gap closes

Hablasteis. Now the other two families, and then the hard stems.

Grammar Lens: -isteis, for everything else

comer

comisteis

vivir

vivisteis

One ending for both, exactly as everywhere else in the preterite. The -*er* and -*ir* families stopped being two families the first time you met this tense.

Grammar Lens: and the strong stems take it too

The stems that gave you trouble — *tuv-*, *hic-*, *estuv-*, *dij-* — take the same -*isteis*, with no surprises left in them:

tuvisteis · hicisteis · estuvisteis · dijisteis

And *ser/ir*, which share one past: *fuisteis*.

Why it's said this way

That was the last hole. **The preterite is finished** — every family, every person, regular and strong alike, with nothing outstanding. It has taken a long stretch of this book to build, and it is the largest single structure in it. The review that named this debt out loud can now be read without a caveat.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *comisteis, vivisteis, tuvisteis*
- *fuisteis*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which ending do the strong stems take? (The **same** *-isteis*.)
And what is still missing from the preterite? (**Nothing.**)

Chapter 243

Habláremos — The Imperfect Gets Its Plural

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) 🗉 Hands-free start: none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can use every person of the -aba imperfect.

I can use every person of the -aba imperfect.

243.1 habláremos — the imperfect gets its plural

Hablaba — I used to speak, or I was speaking. The tense for what was going on.

Until now you have had only its singular.

Grammar Lens: the three that were missing

Say them: *nosotros **habláremos**. Vosotros **hablabais**. Ellos **hablaban**.*

The -aba- runs all the way through. The endings on top of it are the ordinary plural ones you have used since the present tense: -mos, -is, -n.

Why it's said this way

Now look at the accent on **habláremos**, because it is the only one in the set and it is doing real work.

The word ends in -s, so Spanish's default would put the stress on the

next-to-last syllable: *habla-BA-mos*. But the stress actually falls a syllable earlier, on the *-BA-...* which is not where the default lands, so the accent has to say so.

Without it you would read *hablabamos* with the wrong beat. The mark is not decoration; it is the difference between the word being a past tense and being nothing at all.

None of the other five needs one, because in each of those the default already lands where the stress is.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *hablábamos, hablabais, hablaban*
- all six, straight through

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which of the six carries a written accent? (Only *hablábamos*.)
And what would go wrong without it? (The **stress** would land in the wrong place.)

Chapter 244

Comíamos, Éramos, Íbamos — Every One With an Accent

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can use the whole imperfect, including all three irregulars.

I can use the whole imperfect, including all three irregulars.

244.1 comíamos · éramos · íbamos — every one with an accent

The *-ar* imperfect is whole. Now *comía*, which has had only its singular until now.

Grammar Lens: the *-ía* plural

Say them: *nosotros comíamos. Vosotros comíais. Ellos comían.*
And here the accent is on **every** form, not just one. The *-ía* puts an *i* and an *a* next to each other, and Spanish would ordinarily run two such vowels together into a single beat. The accent keeps them apart, so *comía* stays three syllables rather than collapsing into two. So the two imperfect sets are mirror images: in *-aba* only one form needs a mark, and in *-ía* they all do.

Grammar Lens: and the three irregulars

Spanish has exactly **three** irregular imperfects, and you have had their singulars for a long time. Their plurals:

<i>ser</i>	<i>éramos</i> · <i>erais</i> · <i>eran</i>
<i>ir</i>	<i>íbamos</i> · <i>ibais</i> · <i>iban</i>
<i>ver</i>	<i>veíamos</i> · <i>veíais</i> · <i>veían</i>

That is the whole irregular list for this tense — three verbs, and now every form of all three. **The imperfect is complete.**

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *comíamos, comíais, comían*
- *éramos, íbamos, veíamos*

Twice through:

Before you move on

How many *-ía* forms carry an accent? (**All** of them.)
 And how many irregular imperfects are there in the language?
 (**Three** — and you have them all.)

Chapter 245

Review — Two Tenses Finished

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say both past tenses straight through, with no gaps.

I can say both past tenses straight through, with no gaps.

245.1 (review)

The form the book owed you longest. (*Hablasteis.*)

What you've built

Two chants, and each is a whole tense.

The preterite. *Hablé · hablaste · habló · hablamos · hablasteis · hablaron.* Six of six, and the same for *-er*, for *-ir*, and for every strong stem.

The imperfect. *Hablaba · hablabas · hablaba · hablábamos · hablabais · hablaban.* Six of six, with exactly three irregular verbs in the whole language — *ser*, *ir*, *ver* — and you hold all of them. Neither of those sentences has a note at the end saying the rest is coming later. That is new.

Grammar Lens: where the accents fall

The one thing worth keeping separate is the accents, because the two imperfect sets behave in opposite ways.

In the *-aba* set, **one** form carries a mark: *hablábamos*, and only

because the stress falls where the default would not put it. In the *-ía* set, **every** form carries one, and for a different reason entirely: the *i* and the *a* would otherwise run together into a single beat, and the accent holds them apart.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the preterite, all six
- the imperfect, all six

Twice through:

Before you move on

How many irregular imperfects? (**Three.**)

And how many gaps are left in either past tense? (**None.**)

Chapter 246

Para Mí — The Pronouns That Stand on Their Own

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗋️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can use a pronoun after a preposition.

I can use a pronoun after a preposition.

246.1 para mí — the pronouns that stand on their own

You have *me* and *te* — the little object pronouns that lean on a verb: *me llamo*, *te quiero*.

Put a preposition in front and they change shape.

Grammar Lens: after a preposition

*El café es **para mí**.* — The coffee is for me.

Say them: *para **mí**. Para **tí**. Para **él**, para **ella**.*

Only the first two persons actually change. From *él* onward the form is the same one you already use as a subject — which is why this list is shorter to learn than it looks.

Why it's said this way

Now the accent on ***mí***, and it is the kind you have met before: one that tells two identical words apart.

mi

mí

my — *mi café*

me, after a preposition — *para mí*

Same letters, same sound, different jobs — so Spanish marks the stressed one, exactly as it marks *tú* against *tu* and *él* against *el*. And *ti* has **no** accent, which looks inconsistent and is not: there is no other *ti* to confuse it with. The mark is only ever spent where something needs separating.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *para mí, para ti, para él*
- *mi café, then para mí*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which *mi* carries the accent? (The one meaning **me**, after a preposition.)

And why has *ti* none? (Nothing to **separate** it from.)

Chapter 247

Connmigo, Contigo — The Word That Says With Twice

Modes: 🔄 voice (1) 🔄 Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say with me and with you.

I can say with me and with you.

247.1 connmigo · contigo — the word that says “with” twice

Para mí, para ti. The pattern is steady: preposition, then the stressed pronoun.

One preposition refuses to follow it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Con means *with*. But *with me* is not *con mí*:

¿Vienes **connmigo**? — Are you coming with me?

Here is where it came from, and it is one of the best stories in the language. Latin did not put *cum* in front of a pronoun; it stuck it on the **end**: **mecum**, literally *me-with*.

Spanish inherited that as *-migo* — and by then nobody could hear a preposition in it any more. It had become a meaningless tail. So Spanish put *con* back on the **front**, where prepositions belong.

Which means **connmigo** contains *with* **twice**: once at each end, in two

different languages, fifteen centuries apart. And *contigo* does exactly the same.

Why it's said this way

This is the same instinct you saw turn *mucho* into *muy* and *a el* into *al*, running the other way. Spanish reshapes small words to keep them audible — usually by wearing them down, and here, once, by **doubling** one that had worn away to nothing.

There are only two of these. From *él* onward the ordinary pattern returns: *con él*, *con ella*.

Your turn

- Say it: *conmigo*, *contigo*, then *con él*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Why does *conmigo* begin with *con* when it already ends in one?

(Because the **old one stopped being audible**.)

How many pronouns do this? (**Two** — *conmigo*, *contigo*.)

Chapter 248

¡Qué Grande! — The Same Word, Exclaiming

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can react to something with force, in two words.

I can react to something with force, in two words.

248.1 ¡Qué grande! — the same word, exclaiming

¿*Qué es esto?* asks. And you have had the upside-down exclamation mark since the writing chapters, with nothing much to put between the pair.

Here is what goes there.

Grammar Lens: qué in front of an adjective

¡*Qué grande!* — How big! ¡*Qué bien!* — How good! / Great!

No verb needed, nothing else needed. *Qué* plus an adjective or an adverb, between the two marks, and you have said something with force.

¡*Qué bien!* in particular is worth having on the tip of your tongue. It is what Spanish says when English says *nice!* or *great!*, and it costs two words.

Why it's said this way

Notice the accent. It is there in *¿qué?* and it is here in *¡qué!*, and by now you know why: that mark has never been about questions. It marks the word **carrying the force** of the sentence.

You saw the same thing when a reported question kept its accent inside a sentence with no question marks at all. Asking and exclaiming are two jobs, and the accent is the one thing they share.

Plain *que* — no accent — is the joint you use for reporting and for relative clauses. It carries nothing, so it is marked with nothing.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *¡Qué grande!, ¡Qué bien!*
- *¿qué?* then *¡qué!*, and hear that only the frame changed

Twice through:

Before you move on

What follows *qué* in an exclamation? (An **adjective** or an adverb — no verb needed.)

And does it keep its accent? (**Yes** — it is still the word doing the work.)

Chapter 249

María, Ven — Naming Who You Are Talking To

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can address somebody by name.

I can address somebody by name.

249.1 María, ven — naming who you are talking to

Ven — come. *¿Cómo estás?* — how are you.

Both are aimed at somebody. Now say **who**.

Grammar Lens: the comma is the grammar

María, ven. ¿Cómo estás, María? Profesor, ¿puedo hablar?

The name can go at the front or at the end, and either way it is fenced off by a **comma**. That comma is not decoration — it is the entire grammatical marking. There is nothing else to learn here.

Why it's said this way

Latin had a whole **case** for this — a set of endings whose only job was addressing somebody. Spanish replaced all of it with a pause. That is the shortest possible summary of what became of Latin's

endings. Twice now you have watched the same thing: the endings went, and something small and audible took over the work — a preposition for the personal *a*, and here a comma.

And notice the person you address takes **no** *a*. *Veo a María* has María on the receiving end of the seeing; *María, ven* has her doing the coming. Same name, opposite roles, and the comma is what tells them apart.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *María, ven*
- *Veo a María*, then *María, ven*, and hear the difference

Twice through:

Before you move on

What did Spanish replace Latin's addressing case with? (A **comma**.)

And does the addressed person take an *a*? (**No**.)

Chapter 250

Review — Four Small Things

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can use the stressed pronouns, exclaim, and address somebody.

I can use the stressed pronouns, exclaim, and address somebody.

250.1 (review)

After a preposition: *para mí, para ti, para él.*

What you've built

Four chants.

First. *El café es para mí.* — the stressed pronouns, and only the first two persons change shape at all.

Second. *¿Vienes conmigo?* — the two that fuse, each carrying *with* at both ends.

Third. *¡Qué bien!* — the asking word exclaiming, accent intact.

Fourth. *María, ven.* — a comma, and that is the whole grammar of addressing somebody.

Grammar Lens: the accent has never been about questions

Two accents in this chapter, doing two different jobs, and neither is about questions.

On **mí** it separates twins: *mi* is *my*, *mí* is *me*. On **qué** it marks the word carrying the force, which is why it survives into an exclamation

and into a reported question that has no marks at all.
And three of this chapter's four rules exist for one reason: Latin's endings fell away, and something audible had to take over. A stressed pronoun, a preposition doubled at both ends, and a comma.

Your turn

- *Say it:* the four chants, in order

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which *mí* takes the accent? (The one meaning **me**.)
And what do three of this chapter's four rules have in common?
(Latin's **endings fell away**, and something audible replaced them.)

Chapter 251

Ahí, Allí — The Other Two Places

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say where something is, on any of the three sides.

I can say where something is, on any of the three sides.

251.1 ahí · allí — the other two places

Aquí — here. You have had it a long time, on its own.

And you know three pointing words: *este*, *ese*, *aquel*. The places work the same way, and they have been waiting for their other two.

Grammar Lens: one for one

Say them: ***aquí***, by me. ***Ahí***, by you. ***Allí***, away from us both. They line up with the pointing words exactly:

<i>este libro</i>	<i>aquí</i>	by me
<i>ese libro</i>	<i>ahí</i>	by you
<i>aquel libro</i>	<i>allí</i>	by neither

So this is not a new system to learn. It is the **same** system, answering the same question — whose side is it on — with a word for the place instead of a word for the thing.

Why it's said this way

All three carry a written accent, and all three carry it for the same reason: each is stressed on its **last** syllable, and each ends in a vowel, where Spanish would otherwise stress the one before.

A-QUÍ. A-HÍ. A-LLÍ. Say them and you can hear the beat landing at the end every time.

English gets by with two — *here* and *there* — and patches the third on when it must: *over there*. Spanish keeps all three separate, exactly as it does with the pointing words.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *aquí, ahí, allí*
- *este libro aquí, ese libro ahí, aquel libro allí*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which place word sits on the listener's side? (***Ahí.***)

And why do all three take an accent? (Each is stressed on its **last** syllable.)

Chapter 252

Ahora, Hoy — Now and Today

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can place what I am saying in time.
I can place what I am saying in time.

252.1 ahora · hoy — now and today

Mañana — tomorrow. *La hora* — the hour.

Two more time words, and both are hiding something you already know.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Ahora — *now*. Look at what is sitting in the middle of it: **hora**, the word for *hour* you learned long ago.

Latin said **hac hora** — *at this hour*. Two words, worn together into one, and the *h* in the middle went silent along the way. *Now* is literally **this hour**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Hoy — *today*. Latin said **hodie**, which was itself *hoc die*, *this day*.

So the pair is symmetrical, and neither has parts any more: *this hour* wore down to *ahora*, *this day* wore down to three letters. Spanish is full of these — phrases that stopped being phrases.

Why it's said this way

And now you can put a time on the tense you learned for the moment:

Ahora *estoy comiendo*. — Right now, I'm eating. **Hoy**
voy a comer con ella. — Today I'm going to eat with her.

Notice which tense each one takes. *Ahora* goes with the progressive, because both mean *at this instant*. *Hoy* covers a whole day, so it takes the ordinary forms — including the going-to future, which is how Spanish says the thing English says with *I'm eating*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ahora, hoy, mañana*
- *Ahora estoy comiendo*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Ahora was which two Latin words? (**Hac hora** — *this hour*.)
And *hoy*? (**Hodie**, which was *this day*.)

Chapter 253

Unos, Unas — The Plural of One

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗋️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say some of a thing, as against the thing in general.

I can say some of a thing, as against the thing in general.

253.1 unos · unas — the plural of “one”

Un libro, una casa. And you know where they came from: Latin **unus**, the number **one**.

Which raises a question. What could a plural of *one* possibly mean?

Grammar Lens: it stops meaning one

unos libros — some books, a few books **unas** casas — some houses

The moment it goes plural it stops being a number and becomes a **vague quantity**: a handful, several, a few. Not one, and not counted. English does the same trick with *a* and *some* and never notices, because it changes the word. Spanish keeps the word and changes only the ending.

Why it's said this way

Now the useful part, because you already know the alternative.

*Compro **libros**.*

I buy books — books in general

*Compro **unos** libros.*

I buy **some** books — a few, this
once

The bare plural you learned long ago talks about the **kind** of thing.

Unos picks out a small, unspecified number of them.

So they are not interchangeable, and the difference is one you can hear in English too — *I buy books* is a habit, *I buy some books* is an occasion.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *un libro*, then *unos libros*
- *Compro libros*, then *Compro unos libros*

Twice through:

Before you move on

What does *unos* mean, given that *un* means one? (**Some** — a few, uncounted.)

And what does the **bare** plural mean instead? (The **kind** of thing, in general.)

Chapter 254

Vuestro — The Last Possessive

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can use every possessive in the set.

I can use every possessive in the set.

254.1 vuestro — the last possessive

Nuestra casa — our house. And *vosotros* — you all.

One possessive is still missing, and the pair you just said gives it away.

Grammar Lens: the pair

<i>nosotros</i> →	<i>nuestro</i> libro, <i>nuestra</i> casa
<i>vosotros</i> →	<i>vuestro</i> libro, <i>vuestra</i> casa

Same ending, same agreement, same position in front of the noun.
Once you have seen it beside *nuestro* there is nothing left to learn — which is why it has been safe to leave until last.

Why it's said this way

And that completes the set. Say them in order:

mi · *tu* · *su* · *nuestro* · *vuestro* · *su*

Six, and only two of them — *nuestro* and *vuestro* — change for gender.

Mi, *tu* and *su* do not care whether the thing is masculine or feminine;

they only change for **number**.

As with every *vosotros* form, you will meet *vuestro* mainly in Spain, and you will read it everywhere. It costs one word to know it and it closes the set.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *nuestra casa*, then *vuestra casa*
- all six, in order

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which possessive goes with *vosotros*? (**Vuestro.**)

And how many of the six change for gender? (**Two.**)

Chapter 255

Vi, Di — The Shortest Pasts

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) 🔄 Hands-free start: none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can use the preterite of *ver* and *dar*.

*I can use the preterite of *ver* and *dar*.*

255.1 vi · di — the shortest pasts in the language

The *-er* past, first person: *comí*, with an accent, because the stress lands at the end.

Now do the same to *ver*, whose stem is a single letter.

Grammar Lens: nothing left to accent

ver → *vi*, *viste*, *vio*

Look at *vi* and *vio*: **no accent**, where *comí* and *comió* both had one. And the reason is not an exception. A written accent exists to say *the beat is here, not where you would expect*. A word of **one syllable** has nowhere else the beat could be, so there is nothing to correct. Spanish does not spend a mark on a choice that does not exist.

Grammar Lens: and *dar*, which behaves like an *-er* verb

Dar means *to give*. It is an *-ar* verb — and in the preterite it flatly refuses to behave like one:

dar → ***di, diste, dio, dimos, disteis, dieron***

Those are the *-er* endings, on an *-ar* verb, with the same one-syllable forms going bare. *Ver* does the same in the plural: *vimos, visteis, vieron*.

Two verbs, one shared oddity, and now the last two named irregulars of the preterite are yours.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *vi, viste, vio*
- *di, diste, dio*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Why do *vi* and *di* carry no accent? (**One syllable** — the beat has nowhere else to fall.)

And which endings does *dar* take in the past? (The **-er** ones, though it is an *-ar* verb.)

Chapter 256

Review — Five Sets, Finished

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can use every one of the sets the book had left half-taught.

I can use every one of the sets the book had left half-taught.

256.1 (review)

Three places, in order. (*Aquí, ahí, allí.*)

What you've built

Five chants, and each one finishes something.

Places. *Aquí, ahí, allí* — one for each of *este, ese, aquel*.

Times. *Ahora, hoy, mañana* — now, today, tomorrow.

Articles. *Un libro, unos libros* — one, then a few.

Possessives. *Nuestra casa, vuestra casa* — and with that the set of six is closed.

Two verbs. *Vi, di* — the shortest pasts in the language.

Grammar Lens: a gap in a set is hard to see

Every one of these was a set you already partly had. You had *aquí* without *ahí*. You had *mañana* without *hoy*. You had *un* without *unos*, and *nuestro* without *vuestro*.

That is a particular kind of gap, and it is harder to notice than a missing subject, because nothing feels absent — you simply use the

half you have and route around the rest.
And two small rules came out of it worth keeping. *Vi* and *di* take **no accent**, because a one-syllable word has nowhere else the beat could fall. And *dar*, though an *-ar* verb, takes the *-er* endings in the past.

Your turn

- *Say it*: the five chants, in order

Twice through:

Before you move on

How many possessives are in the closed set? (**Six.**)
And which place word matches *ese*? (**Ahi** — the listener's side.)

Chapter 257

Hablo — One Form, Two Readings

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can use the plain present for both a habit and this moment.

I can use the plain present for both a habit and this moment.

257.1 hablo — one form, two readings

Somebody phones and asks what you are doing. Answer with *comer*, in the present, without using the *-iendo* form.

You said *como*. Now think about what that sentence actually claimed.

Grammar Lens: it was doing both all along

Como. — I eat. **And also:** I'm eating, right now, this minute.

One form, two readings. The **durative** one is the habit — *I eat at eight*. The **actual** one is this moment — *I'm eating, don't ring back*. English keeps two shapes; Spanish keeps one.

You have been using both since the very first verb, without anybody naming either.

Why it's said this way

Which raises the obvious question about the form you learned nineteen chapters ago. If *como* already means *I'm eating*, what is *estoy comiendo* for?

Insistence. The progressive is not the ordinary way to say what you are doing now — it is the way to say it when the *now* is the point.

— *¿Qué haces?* — *Como.* (perfectly normal) — *¡Estoy comiendo!* — I'm **in the middle of eating**, leave me alone.

So the progressive is **optional** where English's is compulsory. An English speaker reaches for *estoy comiendo* every time and sounds oddly emphatic; a Spanish speaker uses the plain present and saves the long form for when it means something.

This is worth more than it looks. It means you already had a complete present tense before that chapter, and the progressive was an addition rather than a repair.

Your turn

- *Say it:* *Como* as an answer, then *Estoy comiendo* as a protest

Twice through:

Before you move on

How many readings does the plain present carry? (**Two** — the habit and this moment.)

And is the progressive required for *right now*? (**No.** It is for insisting.)

Chapter 258

Hablo, Hablas, Habla — The Ending Says Who

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can state why Spanish verbs change their endings, and why the pronoun can go.

I can state why Spanish verbs change their endings, and why the pronoun can go.

258.1 hablo · hablas · habla — the ending says who

Say *hablar* through, all six. (*Hablo, hablas, habla, hablamos, habláis, hablan.*)

You have done that hundreds of times. Now here is the question nobody has asked you: **why is the ending different every time?**

Grammar Lens: naming what you already do

Because the verb **agrees with its subject**. Whoever is doing the action decides the ending, every time, in every tense you have learned.

Nosotros hablamos — the *-mos* is there **because** the subject is *we*.

That is the rule, stated plainly for the first time, and you have obeyed it perfectly for two hundred chapters. Being able to say it matters,

because an examiner can ask, and because it explains something you were told long ago without a reason.

Why it's said this way

At the very beginning you learned you could drop the pronoun — *hablo*, not *yo hablo*. It was presented as a habit of the language. It is not a habit. It is a **consequence**. The ending already carries the subject, so the pronoun would be saying a second time what the verb has already said. Spanish drops it because it is genuinely redundant.

Hablo — the *-o* IS the *yo*.

Which is why the pronoun comes back exactly when the ending stops being enough: *habla* could be *he*, *she*, or *usted*, so a speaker who needs to be clear says *ella habla*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *hablo*, and name what the *-o* is doing
- *ella habla*, and say why the pronoun is needed there

Twice through:

Before you move on

What does a Spanish verb agree with? (Its **subject**.)
And is dropping the pronoun a habit or a consequence? (A **consequence** — the ending already said it.)

Chapter 259

Mucha Agua — When the Quantity Word Agrees

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗋️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can decide whether a quantity word agrees or freezes.

I can decide whether a quantity word agrees or freezes.

259.1 mucha agua · pocos libros — when the quantity word agrees

Mucho café. And *muy grande*, where the short form appeared because an adjective followed.

Now try *mucho* in front of a **feminine** noun and listen to what your mouth wants.

Grammar Lens: in front of a noun, it agrees

mucha agua · muchos libros · pocas casas

When *mucho* or *poco* sits in front of a noun it is behaving like an adjective, so it does what every adjective does: it takes the gender and the number of the noun.

And *agua* is the test case you already own. It takes *el* for a sound reason while being feminine underneath — so it is ***mucha*** *agua*, never *mucho* *agua*. The quantity word reports the real gender, exactly as the object pronoun did.

Grammar Lens: after a verb, it freezes

Now move it behind a verb, where there is no noun for it to lean on:

*Ella trabaja **mucho**.* — She works a lot. *Ella come **poco**.*
— She eats little.

No agreement. Not *mucha* because *ella* is feminine — the word is not describing *her*, it is describing the working. A verb has no gender and no number, so there is nothing to agree with, and the word freezes in its plain masculine-singular shape.

So one test decides it: **is it leaning on a noun, or on a verb?**

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *mucha agua, muchos libros, pocas casas*
- *Ella trabaja mucho* — and notice nothing agreed

Twice through:

Before you move on

In front of a noun, does *mucho* agree? (**Yes** — gender and number.)
And after a verb? (**No**. There is nothing there to agree with.)

Chapter 260

María, España — The Nouns That Need No Article

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can use names and titles with the right article, or none.

I can use names and titles with the right article, or none.

260.1 María · España · profesor — the nouns that need no article

El libro, la casa. The article's job is to say **which one**.

Now try putting one in front of a person's name and hear how wrong it sounds.

Grammar Lens: nothing left for the article to do

*Veo a **María**.* — not *a la María*. *Vivo en **España**.* — not *en la España*.

A **proper noun** — a name, a country, a city — already points at exactly one thing in the world. The article exists to narrow a noun down to one, and here there is nothing left to narrow. So it goes. That is the rule you have been following since the first time you said *Me llamo...*, and it has never been stated.

Why it's said this way

Now the part that catches people, and it follows from the same logic.

<i>Hablo con el profesor García.</i>	talking about him — article
<i>Profesor García, ¿puedo hablar?</i>	talking to him — none

A title is not a name. *Profesor* is an ordinary noun, so it takes an article like any other — until you turn and address the person, at which point you are not identifying them for anybody. You are calling them. And a vocative takes no article, exactly as it takes no personal *a*. Same rule underneath: the article says which one, and it appears precisely when that job needs doing.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *Veo a María, Vivo en España*
- *el profesor García, then Profesor García, ...*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Why do names take no article? (They already point at **one** thing.)
And when does a title lose its article? (When you are **addressing** the person.)

Chapter 261

Review — Four Rules You Already Obeyed

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can state four rules I had been following without knowing.

I can state four rules I had been following without knowing.

261.1 (review)

What decides the ending on a Spanish verb? (Its **subject**.)

What you've built

Four chants, and not one of them taught you anything you could not already do.

First. *Como* means *I eat* **and** *I'm eating*. One form, two readings, and the long form is for insisting.

Second. The ending agrees with the subject — which is *why* the pronoun can go, rather than a separate habit.

Third. *Mucha agua*, but *trabaja mucho*. It agrees on a noun and freezes on a verb.

Fourth. *Veo a María*, not *a la María*. A name already points at one thing, so the article has no work to do.

Grammar Lens: why naming it was worth a chapter

You have obeyed all four of these for hundreds of chapters without being told any of them. So what changed?

Two things. A rule you can state is a rule you can **check** when you are unsure — and doing something correctly by reflex is no help at all when somebody asks you directly why.

And naming one rule often explains another. Once *the ending agrees with the subject* is said out loud, dropping the pronoun stops being a quirk to memorise and becomes an obvious consequence. Three of this book's earliest lessons quietly make more sense than they did yesterday.

Your turn

- *Say it:* the four chants, in order

Twice through:

Before you move on

How many readings does the plain present carry? (**Two**.)

And what did any of these four chapters teach you to *do* that you could not do before? (**Nothing** — they taught you to **say** what you were already doing.)

Chapter 262

Primero, Segundo, Tercero — Counting in Order

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗋️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say which one in a line something is.

I can say which one in a line something is.

262.1 primero · segundo · tercero — counting in order

Uno, dos, tres — how many.

Now the other kind of counting: not how many, but **which one in the line**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Say them: **primero, segundo, tercero, cuarto, quinto**.

And the second one has a story. Latin **secundus** did not mean *two*. It meant **following**, from the verb *sequi*, *to follow* — so second place is literally *the one that comes after*. English *second* is the very same word, and *sequence* and *consequence* are its cousins.

They behave as adjectives: *la segunda casa, los primeros libros*.

Why it's said this way

Two things set them apart from ordinary adjectives.

They go in front. Where *grande* follows its noun, an ordinal leads: *el primer libro*, not *el libro primero*.

And there — did you catch it? **Primer**, not *primero*. In front of a masculine singular noun, *primero* and *tercero* drop their final *o*.

el primer libro

but *la primera casa*

el tercer libro

but *la tercera casa*

You have met this exact habit twice already: *mucho* to *muy*, and *malo* to *mal*. Three times now, so it is not a set of exceptions — it is what Spanish does to a word leaning on a masculine noun.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *primero, segundo, tercero, cuarto, quinto*
- *el primer libro, la primera casa*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Where does an ordinal stand? (**Before** the noun, unlike other adjectives.)

And which two lose their *o*? (**Primer**o and **tercer**o, in front of a masculine noun.)

Chapter 263

Uno... Otro — Splitting a Pair

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say something different about each of two things.

I can say something different about each of two things.

263.1 uno... otro — splitting a pair

Un libro — one book. *Unos libros* — some books.

Now: two books, and you want to say something different about each.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Otro — *the other*. Latin **alter**, which did not mean *any other*: it meant **the other of two**, the second of a pair.

English keeps that sense in *alternative* and *alternate* — one, then the other, back and forth.

And it takes no article. *Otro libro*, never *un otro libro*.

Grammar Lens: one at each end

Uno es grande, otro es bueno. — One is big, the other is good.

The pattern splits a pair across the two halves of the sentence: *uno* takes the first, *otro* takes the second. Neither needs a noun after it, because the noun was already named or is obvious.

It agrees, like everything else: *una... otra* for two feminine things, *unos... otros* for two groups.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *Uno es grande, otro es pequeño*
- *una... otra, unos... otros*

Twice through:

Before you move on

What goes at the first half, and what at the second? (**Uno**, then **otro**.)
And does *otro* take an article? (**No**.)

Chapter 264

Comer Es Bueno — The Infinitive as Subject

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗋️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can name an activity and say something about it.

I can name an activity and say something about it.

264.1 comer es bueno — the infinitive as the subject

El libro es grande. A noun, then *es*, then what it is.

Now put an **action** in the noun's place.

Grammar Lens: the infinitive stands there

Comer es bueno. — Eating is good. *Hablar español es bueno.* — Speaking Spanish is good.

The infinitive — the plain dictionary form — simply occupies the subject slot, and the sentence carries on as normal. Nothing is added and nothing changes shape.

Note the verb after it: *es*, singular. An action counts as one thing, however many words are wrapped around it.

Why it's said this way

Here is the trap, and it is entirely an English one.

English uses *-ing* for this — *eating is good* — and you have an *-ing* form now. So it is tempting to reach for ***comiendo***.

Comiendo es bueno. — **wrong.**

The gerund never does this job in Spanish. It is for an action **underway**, leaning on *estar*; it is not a name for the activity. The infinitive is the name.

So the two languages divide the work differently, and Spanish's division is the simpler one: English argues about *to eat* against *eating*, and Spanish uses one form for both.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *Comer es bueno*
- *Hablar español es bueno*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which form names an activity — the infinitive or the gerund? (The **infinitive**.)

And what is the gerund for? (An action **underway**, with *estar*.)

Chapter 265

Hoy Como en Casa — The Pieces That Move

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can move when and where around a sentence, and use the front for emphasis.

I can move when and where around a sentence, and use the front for emphasis.

265.1 hoy como en casa — the pieces that move

Como en casa. — I eat at home. Now add *hoy*, and put it wherever sounds right to you.

Whatever you chose was probably correct, and that is the lesson.

Grammar Lens: three placements, one meaning

Hoy como en casa. Como hoy en casa. Como en casa hoy.

All three are Spanish, and all three mean the same thing. The pieces that say **when** and **where** are not pinned to a position the way the subject and the verb are.

You can stack them, too: *Hoy como en casa con María.* When, where, with whom — and the order among them is yours.

Why it's said this way

The freedom is not free, and it is not decoration. **The front of the sentence is the emphatic position.** Putting *hoy* first says *today*, as against some other day. Leaving it at the end mentions it and moves on.

So the choice is not stylistic. It is how a Spanish speaker does what an English speaker does by stressing a word out loud.

And notice why this is possible at all. The verb ending already says who is acting, and the personal *a* already marks who is on the receiving end — so nothing depends on position to keep the roles straight. Latin's endings paid for word order when they fell; the pieces Spanish kept are what let the rest move.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all three placements of *hoy*
- *Hoy como en casa* as though correcting somebody about the day

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which position is the emphatic one? (The **front**.)

And what makes the freedom safe? (The **endings** already say who is doing what.)

Chapter 266

Review — Four Last Pieces, and the Thread

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can use the last of the A1 structures, and name the thread that runs through them.

I can use the last of the A1 structures, and name the thread that runs through them.

266.1 (review)

The first five in order. (*Primero, segundo, tercero, cuarto, quinto.*)

What you've built

Four chants.

First. *El primer libro, la primera casa* — ordinals go in front, and two of them drop their *o* before a masculine noun.

Second. *Uno es grande, otro es bueno* — a pair split across the sentence. *Otro libro*, with no article in front of it.

Third. *Comer es bueno* — the infinitive naming an activity, where English would reach for *-ing* and Spanish will not.

Fourth. *Hoy como en casa* — the when and the where can move, and the front is where the emphasis lives.

Grammar Lens: the thread

Primer is the **third** time you have watched Spanish bite the ending off a word leaning on another — after *muy* and *mal*. Three sightings make a habit, not a list of exceptions, and you will meet a fourth without being surprised.

And the moving pieces close a thread that has run through this whole level. Latin marked who did what with **endings**. Those endings fell away, and Spanish built replacements out of small audible things: an article to say which one, a preposition to mark the person on the receiving end, a comma to address somebody, and a fixed front position to carry emphasis.

Every one of those was a chapter of its own. Together they are one story, and you now have all of it.

Your turn

- *Say it*: the four chants, in order

Twice through:

Before you move on

Where does emphasis live in a Spanish sentence? (At the **front**.)
And what one event explains the article, the personal *a*, the vocative comma and that emphatic position? (Latin's **endings falling away**.)

Chapter 267

Saying No, and Asking

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say that something is not so, and ask a question that can be answered yes or no.

Hold a four-line exchange that denies something and then asks the other person to agree.

267.1 no + verb — putting *no* in front of the verb — the whole of Spanish negation

One rule, and it is shorter than the English one.

Grammar lens: putting *no* in front of the verb — the whole of Spanish negation

You already know **no**. You met it already as an answer: ¿Hablas español? — No.

Here is the part nobody has told you yet, and it is the entire rule:

Put *no* immediately before the verb. That is negation. There is nothing else.

Hablo español — I speak Spanish. **No** *hablo español* — I do **not** speak Spanish.

English needs a helper — *I do not speak* — and that *do* is doing no work except carrying the negation. Spanish never borrowed the habit. The word goes in front of the verb and the sentence is finished.

That means every sentence you can already say, you can now also unsay.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- three sentences you already know, then say each one again negated
- the same three as yes-or-no questions, letting your voice rise

Before you move on

What goes in front of the verb to negate it? (**no**.) Does Spanish need a helper word like English's *do*? (**No** — **nothing else changes**.)

267.2 no ... nada — the double negative — where Spanish stacks what English forbids

One rule, and it is shorter than the English one.

Grammar lens: the double negative — where Spanish stacks what English forbids

English teachers spend years stamping out *I don't see nothing*. Spanish requires it.

No veo nada — literally *I don't see nothing*, and it means **I see nothing**.

The rule: when a negative word comes AFTER the verb, *no* still has to sit in front of it. Both halves stay.

No veo nada. · *No hablo con nadie.* · *No voy nunca.*

Move the negative word to the front and the *no* disappears, because the sentence already has its negation:

Nada veo. · **Nadie** habla. · **Nunca** voy.

Both are correct. The first is what people say.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- three sentences you already know, then say each one again negated
- the same three as yes-or-no questions, letting your voice rise

Before you move on

In *no veo nada*, how many negative words are there? (**Two**, and both are required.) What happens to *no* if *nada* moves to the front? (**It goes away** — the sentence is already negative.)

267.3 ¿Hablas español? — the yes-or-no question — and why Spanish barely has to do anything

One rule, and it is shorter than the English one.

Grammar lens: the yes-or-no question — and why Spanish barely has to do anything

English rebuilds the sentence to ask a yes-or-no question. *You speak Spanish* becomes *Do you speak Spanish?* — a word appears from nowhere and the order changes.

Spanish does neither. **The words stay exactly where they are.** Only your voice goes up, and the writing marks it:

Hablas español. → **¿Hablas español?**

Same three words, same order. The **¿** at the front is the instruction: *this is a question, start lifting your voice now*. That is why Spanish opens it — English readers do not find out until the final **?**, by which time the sentence has been read flat.

You may also put the subject after the verb — *¿Habla usted español?* — and with *usted* that is the more usual shape. But it is a preference, not a rule. The rising voice is the question.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- three sentences you already know, then say each one again negated
- the same three as yes-or-no questions, letting your voice rise

Before you move on

What has to change to turn a Spanish statement into a yes-or-no question? (**Nothing but the voice** — and the *¿* ? marks.) Why does Spanish open with *¿*? (**So the reader lifts their voice from the first word**, not the last.)

267.4 ¿verdad? — the tag question — asking someone to agree

One rule, and it is shorter than the English one.

Grammar lens: the tag question — asking someone to agree

There is a second kind of yes-or-no question: the one where you already think you know the answer and want the other person to agree. English has a whole machine for this — *isn't it*, *doesn't he*, *haven't you*, *aren't they* — and it changes with every verb. Spanish has two words.

Hablas español, ¿verdad? — *You speak Spanish, right?* *No hablas español, ¿no?* — *You don't speak Spanish, do you?*

¿verdad? is *truth?* and works everywhere. *¿no?* is quicker and slightly more casual. Neither one changes for the verb, the person, or the tense.

One tidy convention: after a negative sentence people prefer *¿verdad?*, since *¿no?* after *no* sounds like a stutter.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- three sentences you already know, then say each one again negated

- the same three as yes-or-no questions, letting your voice rise

Before you move on

What does Spanish use instead of English's *isn't it* / *doesn't he* / *haven't you*? (*¿verdad?* and *¿no?*.) Do they change with the verb? (**Never.**)

267.5 negar y preguntar — saying something is not so, and asking whether it is

Everything in this chapter, in one place.

Grammar lens: saying something is not so, and asking whether it is

This chapter gave you two things that go together more often than not.

you can now	how
say something is not so	<i>no</i> in front of the verb
say it with a negative word after	<i>no</i> stays, both halves
ask a yes-or-no question	nothing changes but your voice
ask someone to agree	<i>¿verdad?</i> or <i>¿no?</i>

Put them together and you have the shape most real conversations run on:

— *¿Hablas español?* — *No, no hablo español. Hablo inglés.*
 — *Pero entiendes un poco, ¿verdad?* — *Sí, un poco.*

Every word there is one you already had. What is new is that you can now **deny** and **ask**, which between them cover most of what a beginner needs to survive a conversation they did not start.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- three sentences you already know, then say each one again negated
- the same three as yes-or-no questions, letting your voice rise

Before you move on

How do you negate a verb? (***no*** in front of it.) How do you ask a yes-or-no question? (**Voice up, *¿*** ? — nothing else moves.) How do you ask someone to agree? (***¿verdad?*** or ***¿no?***.)

Chapter 268

Travelling — Asking, Boarding, Staying, and When It Goes Wrong

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask where something is, ask for a ticket and a room, and say that there is a problem.

Complete ES-C268-problema: put each of the chapter's three nouns into the *donde esta* frame, ask for a ticket and a room outright, and report a problem with the correct article.

268.1 ¿dónde está? — the question that unsticks you

You know *dónde*, and you know *está*. Put them together and you have the single most useful sentence a traveller owns — the one that works when you are lost, when you cannot find the door, when the platform is not where the sign said it was.

What to know first

- dónde — the asking word, with its written accent.
- estar — the *being* that is about **place**, not essence.

Sounds you'll need

- Two stressed syllables: *DÓN-de es-TÁ*. Both accents are written, and both are telling you the truth about your voice. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

¿dónde está? — “where is it?” Two known words, no new grammar: *dónde* (“where”) + *está* (“it is, located”). Spanish has two verbs for “to be,” and this question takes *estar*, the one that answers *where* rather than *what*. A thing’s location can change; *estar* is the verb for what changes.

Say the name of what you want after it and the question is finished: *¿dónde está el hotel?*, *¿dónde está el tren?* You do not need to build a sentence — you need one frame and a noun.

Where it comes from. *Dónde* is Latin *unde*, “from where,” with a *de-* welded on the front; *está* is Latin *stare*, “to stand” — the same root inside English **stand**, **state** and **stay**. Spanish asks, quite literally, *where does it stand?*

What you’ve built

This is a **frame**: a fixed opening you finish with whatever you need. The next three lessons give you three nouns worth putting in it. Two courtesies make it land better, and you already have both. Open with *perdón* and the stranger knows a question is coming. Close with *gracias* whether or not you understood the answer.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *¿dónde está?* — stress *DÓN* and *TÁ*
- the same question about the hotel — *¿dónde está el hotel?*
- it again, opening with *perdón*

Before you move on

Which of the two “to be” verbs does this question use, and why? (*Estar* — it is about place, and place changes.) What Latin verb is

está? (*Stare*, “to stand.”)

268.2 billete — the ticket, and the note in your pocket

One word gets you onto the train. It also, confusingly and usefully, means the paper money you pay for it with.

What to know first

- ¿dónde está? — the frame this noun drops into.

Sounds you'll need

- Three syllables, stress in the middle: *bi-YE-te*. The *ll* is a *y* sound in most of the Spanish-speaking world. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

billete — “ticket,” and also “banknote.” One word, two things you carry, and the overlap is not an accident: both are a small official paper that entitles you to something.

Where it comes from. Latin *bullā* was a **seal** — the blob of wax stamped onto a document to prove it was genuine. The sealed document took the seal’s name, shrank through French *billet* (“a short note”), and arrived in Spanish as *billete*. The same *bullā* is still sitting inside English **bulletin** and the papal **bull**: all of them are documents that were once literally sealed.

Worth knowing before you travel. Much of Latin America says **boleto** or **pasaje** for a travel ticket and keeps *billete* for money. Both are correct Spanish; which one you hear depends on where you are standing.

What you've built

Drop it into the frame — *¿dónde está el billete?* — or ask for one outright: *un billete, por favor*. Two words and a courtesy is a complete transaction.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *billete* — stress the middle, *bi-YE-te*
- ask for one — *un billete, por favor*
- the Latin American word for a travel ticket (*boleto*)

Before you move on

What did Latin *bullā* mean? (A seal.) What two things does *billete* name? (A ticket, and a banknote.) Which English words still carry *bullā*? (**Bulletin**, and a papal **bull**.)

268.3 habitación — a room, from a verb meaning to live somewhere

The word you need at a hotel desk. It is long, but it is built out of a verb you can almost read already.

What to know first

- *billete* — the previous thing you had to ask for.

Sounds you'll need

- Five syllables, stress at the very end: *a-bi-ta-SYON*. The written accent on *ó* is the whole reason you know that. The *h* is silent — it always is. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

habitación — “room.” Take it apart and the meaning is transparent: *habitar* (“to live in, to dwell”) + *-ción* (the ending that turns a verb into the noun for its result). So a *habitación* is, literally, **a place lived in**.

That *-ción* is one of the most profitable endings in the language, and it is English *-tion* wearing different clothes: *nación* / nation, *estación* / station, *información* / information. Meet it once and hundreds of words open up.

Where it comes from. Latin *habitare*, “to dwell” — a frequentative of *habere*, “to have,” so it once meant something like “to keep on having a place.” English **inhabit** and **habitat** are the same root, undisguised.

What you’ve built

Una habitación, por favor books you a room. And the *-ción* ending you just met is a key you will use far outside this chapter: these nouns are feminine, and they are very often an English *-tion* word you already know with its ending swapped.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *habitación* — silent *h*, stress the last syllable
- ask for a room — *una habitación, por favor*
- two more *-ción* words and their English twins

Before you move on

What does the verb *habitar* mean? (To dwell, to live in.) What does *-ción* do? (Turns a verb into the noun for its result.) Which article do *-ción* nouns take? (*La* — they are feminine.)

268.4 problema — the word for when it goes wrong (and the -a that is masculine)

Travel goes wrong. This is the word that starts the conversation about it — and it hides a grammatical surprise you should meet on purpose rather than by accident.

What to know first

- *habitación* — and the gender rule it followed.

Sounds you'll need

- Four syllables, stress in the middle: *pro-BLE-ma*. No written accent, because that is where a word ending in a vowel is stressed by default. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

problema — “problem.” A near-twin of the English word, and you will be understood the moment you say it.

Where it comes from. Greek *problēma*, “a thing thrown forward” — *pro-* (“forward”) plus *bállein* (“to throw”). A problem is something pitched into your path. That same *bállein* is inside English **ballistic** and **symbol**.

What you've built

Here is the surprise, and it is worth more than the word itself. You learned that nouns ending in *-a* are usually feminine. *Problema* is **masculine**: *el problema*, *un problema*. Never *la problema*.

It is not an exception you have to memorise blindly — it is a whole family with a shared history. Greek nouns ending in *-ma* were neuter, and when Latin borrowed them the neuter words landed on the masculine side. Every one of them came into Spanish the same way: *el problema*, *el sistema*, *el tema*, *el programa*, *el idioma*, *el clima*. If a noun ends in *-ma* and sounds Greek and academic, guess *el* and you will usually be right.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *un problema* — and notice you did not say *una*
- report one — *perdón*, *hay un problema*
- three more *-ma* words that take *el*

Before you move on

Which article does *problema* take, and why? (*El* — Greek *-ma* nouns were neuter and became masculine.) What did *problēma*

mean literally? (A thing thrown forward.) Name two more of the family. (*El sistema, el tema, el programa, el idioma, el clima.*)

Chapter 269

Describing an Experience — How It Felt, How Long, How It Compared

Modes: ⇄ voice (4) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say how something felt, what I hope for, how it compared with something else, and how long it lasted.

Complete ES-C269-durante: describe one experience using a feeling adjective, an *espero* ambition, a *mas que* comparison, and a *durante* length.

269.1 feliz — happy, and an adjective that refuses to pick a gender

You can say where things are and what has gone wrong. This chapter is about saying how it *felt*. It starts with the most useful feeling word, which also happens to be conveniently lazy.

What to know first

- problema — and the gender surprise it carried.

Sounds you'll need

- Two syllables, stress on the last: *fe-LIZ*. No written accent is needed — words ending in *-z* are stressed on the final syllable by default. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

feliz — “happy.” Latin *felix*, which first meant **fruitful** — of soil that bore a crop, of a tree heavy with fruit. Happiness, to a Roman farmer, was the field doing what it was supposed to do. The same *felix* is the name **Felix**, and it is inside English **felicity**.

You already meet it once a year without translating it: *¡feliz cumpleaños!*

What you've built

Feliz does something the adjectives you have met do not. *Bueno* becomes *buena* for a feminine noun; *cansado* becomes *cansada*. *Feliz* does neither — it is *feliz* for everyone. Adjectives ending in a consonant simply do not carry gender, so *un niño feliz* and *una niña feliz* use the identical word.

That is a saving, not an exception: every adjective you meet ending in *-z*, *-l* or *-e* is one fewer form to remember.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *feliz* — stress the last syllable
- it about a man, then about a woman, and notice nothing changed
- *¡feliz cumpleaños!*

Before you move on

What did Latin *felix* first describe? (Fruitful soil, a fruiting tree.)
Why does *feliz* not change for a feminine noun? (It ends in a consonant, and consonant-final adjectives do not carry gender.)

269.2 *espero viajar* — saying what you are reaching for

Ambitions are things you have not got yet. Spanish says them with a verb you have already met wearing a different coat.

What to know first

- *feliz* — the feeling this chapter opened with.
- *esperar* — where you first met this verb, meaning *wait*.

Sounds you'll need

- Three syllables, stress in the middle: *es-PE-ro*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

espero — “I hope.” The same *esperar* you learned as “to wait,” and Spanish sees no reason to separate them. To wait for something and to hope for it are one act: you are standing in the present with your attention on a future you cannot reach yet.

Where it comes from. Latin *sperare*, “to hope” — the root of English **prosper** (“to hope forward”) and, negated, **desperate**, which is literally *de-sperare*, to have hope taken away. Spanish keeps the plain form; English kept the compounds.

What you've built

This is your ambition frame. *Espero* plus an infinitive says what you are reaching for: *espero viajar*, *espero aprender*, *espero vivir en España*. Every one of those infinitives is a verb you already own, so the frame costs you nothing new and turns your whole verb list into statements about your future.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *espero* — stress the middle
- an ambition — *espero viajar*

- another, using any verb you know

Before you move on

What two English meanings does *esperar* carry? (To wait, and to hope.) What is *desperate*, taken apart? (*De-sperare* — hope taken away.)

269.3 *más que* — comparing two things, with no new endings to learn

English changes the adjective to compare: big, *bigg-er*. Spanish refuses to. It puts one small word in front and leaves the adjective alone.

What to know first

- *espero* — the ambition frame just before this.
- *más* — the degree word you already have.

Sounds you'll need

- *más* carries a written accent, and it earns it: there is an older word spelled the same way without one. Two words, one sound, and the accent is the only thing telling them apart on the page. You meet the other at the end of the book. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

más que — “more than.” *Más* (“more”) plus *que* (“than,” and also “that”).

Where it comes from. Latin *magis*, “more” — the same root as English **magnitude** and **major**. Latin *did* have *-ior* endings for comparison (*maior*, *melior*), exactly like English *-er*. Spanish threw nearly all of them away and rebuilt comparison out of one adverb, which is why there is so little to learn here.

What you've built

The pattern is fixed and takes any adjective you own, unchanged: *más* + adjective + *que*. *Más grande que, más feliz que, más cansado que*. Swap *más* for *menos* and you have “less than” for free.

Two words sit outside it, kept from Latin because they are used constantly: *mejor* and *peor*, “better” and “worse” — as English says *better*, not *more good*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *más feliz que* — the adjective did not change
- the same idea downwards, with *menos*
- “better” without using *más* (*mejor*)

Before you move on

What is the fixed pattern? (*Más* + adjective + *que*.) Why does *más* carry an accent? (To separate it in writing from an older word spelled the same way without it — you will meet that one at the end of the book.) Which two comparatives kept their Latin endings? (*Mejor* and *peor*.)

269.4 durante — how long it lasted

An experience has a length. This is the word that gives it one, and it closes the chapter: you can now say how it felt, what you hope for, how it compared, and how long it went on.

What to know first

- *más que* — the comparison just before this.

Sounds you'll need

- Three syllables, stress in the middle: *du-RAN-te*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

durante — “during,” and often English “for” when you are talking about a stretch of time: *durante dos horas*, “for two hours.”

Where it comes from. It is not really a preposition. It is the old present participle of *durar*, “to last” — so it once meant “lasting.” *Durante dos horas* was “two hours lasting,” an absolute phrase that hardened into a fixed word once speakers stopped hearing the verb inside it.

Latin *durare* is **hard** — *durus* — and it is still visible in English **durable**, **duration** and **endure**. To last is to be hard enough to.

What you’ve built

Durante answers *how long*, where *cuándo* answers *when*. Worth a moment’s care: English “for” stretches over both a length of time and a recipient, and *durante* only ever covers the length.

That completes the chapter’s four moves. You can describe an experience now: how it felt, what you hope for next, how it measured against something else, and how long it lasted.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *durante dos horas*
- which question it answers — *how long*, not *when*
- an experience of yours with a length attached

Before you move on

What was *durante* before it was a preposition? (The present participle of *durar* — “lasting.”) What does Latin *durus* mean, and which English words carry it? (Hard; **durable**, **duration**, **endure**.)

Chapter 270

Making a Case — Claim, Example, However, Although

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can state an opinion in Spanish, back it with an example, turn against an objection, and grant one before I turn it.

Complete ES-C270-aunque: run the four moves in order on one claim of your own.

270.1 en mi opinión — marking a claim as yours

You can say what happened and how it felt. This chapter is for saying what you THINK, and defending it.

What to know first

- durante — the last word of the experience chapter.
- creer — you can already say *creo*, “I believe.”

Sounds you’ll need

- Five syllables, and the accent on *opinión* is doing the usual work:
en-mi-o-pi-NIÓN. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

en mi opinión — “in my opinion.”

Opinión is Latin **opinari**, “to suppose, to think” — and the *-ión* ending is the same one you met in *habitación*, turning a verb into the noun for its result. An opinion is *a supposing*, made into a thing you can hand someone.

English took the identical word from the identical place, which is why you can read it before you can say it.

What you’ve built

There is a difference between saying something and **marking it as a claim**, and this phrase does the marking. *Es difícil* asserts that a thing is hard. *En mi opinión, es difícil* says the same and hands the listener a place to disagree.

That is what makes it the opening move of an argument rather than a statement of fact — you are inviting the reply.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *en mi opinión*
- a claim with it — *en mi opinión, es difícil*
- the same claim WITHOUT it, and hear the difference

Before you move on

What Latin verb is *opinión* built on? (*Opinari*, “to suppose.”) What does marking a claim as an opinion invite? (Disagreement — a reply.)

270.2 por ejemplo — the claim, and then the reason to believe it

A claim on its own is just an assertion. This is how you back it.

What to know first

- *en mi opinión* — the claim this supports.

Sounds you'll need

- *por e-JEM-plo*. The *j* is the throat-sound you have met in *trabajo*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

por ejemplo — “for example.”

Ejemplo is Latin **exemplum**, and *exemplum* is worth taking apart: *ex-* (“out of”) plus a root meaning “to take.” An example is **a thing taken out** — one item lifted from a pile so the pile can be understood through it.

English **exemplary**, **sample** and **example** are all the same word arriving by different routes; *sample* is the most worn-down of the three.

What you've built

This is the second move of an argument, and the order matters: claim first, example second. *En mi opinión, es difícil. Por ejemplo, ...*
An example is not proof — it is one thing taken out of the pile, which is exactly what the word says. That is worth knowing in both languages.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *por ejemplo*
- a claim, then an example — two sentences
- what *exemplum* means literally (a thing taken out)

Before you move on

What does *exemplum* mean, taken apart? (A thing taken *out* of a pile.) Which comes first, the claim or the example? (The claim.)

270.3 *sin embargo* — however, and why it is not *pero*

You have *pero*, "but." This is its heavier cousin, and the difference is real.

What to know first

- *por ejemplo* — the evidence move.
- *pero* — the ordinary "but" you already own.

Sounds you'll need

- *sin em-BAR-go*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

sin embargo — "however, nevertheless."

Literally "**without hindrance.**" *Embargo* is a hindrance, a seizure, an impediment — the same word English borrowed whole for a trade **embargo**, and it traces to a Latin-derived *imbarricare*, "to bar in." So the phrase says: *that obstacle notwithstanding*. Whatever was just conceded, it does not stop what comes next.

What you've built

Pero joins two things inside one breath: *es difícil pero me gusta*.

Sin embargo stands at the head of its own sentence and turns against everything before it: *Es difícil. Sin embargo, me gusta*.

The second is what an argument needs, because you have to grant the other side's point in full before you turn it. *Pero* is too light to carry that weight, which is why one is not a translation of the other.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *sin embargo*
- the light version — *es difícil pero me gusta*

- the heavy version — two sentences, the second opening with *sin embargo*

Before you move on

What does *sin embargo* mean literally? (Without hindrance.) What English word is *embargo*? (The same one — a trade embargo.) Which of the two turns against a whole sentence rather than half of one? (*Sin embargo*.)

270.4 aunque — conceding first, and arguing after

The last move: granting the other side's point BEFORE you make yours.

What to know first

- *sin embargo* — conceding after the fact.

Sounds you'll need

- *AUN-que*, two syllables. The *au-* is one glide, not two vowels. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

aunque — “although, even though.”

It is *aun* (“even, still”) welded to *que* (“that”), and *aun* descends from Latin **adhuc**, “up to this point, still.” So *aunque* is, at root, “**even that**” — even granting that.

You have watched this fusion happen twice already: *ayer* out of *ad heri*, and *hablaré* out of *hablar habeo*. Spanish builds most of its small words this way, by saying two words often enough that they become one.

What you've built

Sin embargo concedes after: *Es difícil. Sin embargo, me gusta. Aunque* concedes first: *Aunque es difícil, me gusta.*

Same two ideas, opposite order — and the order chooses what the

listener remembers, because the sentence lands on whatever comes last. Leading with *aunque* puts your own point in the emphatic position. With that, you have the four moves: state a claim, support it, turn against an objection, and grant one before you turn it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *aunque*
- the concession first — *aunque es difícil, me gusta*
- all four moves in order — claim, example, however, although

Before you move on

What two words is *aunque* built from? (*Aun* and *que*.) Which Latin word is *aun*? (*Adhuc*, “still.”) Which of *aunque* and *sin embargo* concedes first? (*Aunque*.)

Chapter 271

Talking About Ideas — Hedging From Doubt, and From Inference

Modes: 🗣️ voice (3) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can put an idea forward in Spanish while marking how sure I am of it, and tell an admission of ignorance from a claimed inference.

Complete ES-C271-supongo-que: state one idea three ways – bare, hedged with quizas, and hedged with supongo que – and say what each does to your commitment.

271.1 quizás — saying it without claiming it

An argument needs one more thing: a way to put an idea forward while admitting you might be wrong.

What to know first

- aunque — the concession that closed the last chapter.
- en mi opinión — marking a claim as yours.

Sounds you'll need

- *ki-ZÁS*, stress on the last syllable, and the accent says so. You will also see **quizá**, without the -s; both are standard. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

quizás — “maybe, perhaps.”

It is a fossilised question. Latin **qui sapit** — “*who knows?*” — said often enough that it stopped being a question and became a word meaning *perhaps*. The *sapit* is the same root as **savoir**, **sapient** and, at some distance, **sage**: knowing.

English did the identical thing twice over. *Perhaps* is *per* + *hap*, “by chance”; *maybe* is *may be*. Every language seems to build its hedges by wearing down a phrase that once admitted ignorance out loud.

What you’ve built

This is a **hedge**: it lowers your commitment without lowering your meaning. *Es difícil* claims. *Quizás es difícil* offers.

Set beside what you already have, you now hold three settings on the same dial — *en mi opinión* marks a claim as yours, *quizás* marks it as uncertain, and a bare statement claims outright.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *quizás* — stress the end
- a claim, then the same claim hedged
- what Latin *qui sapit* asked (*who knows?*)

Before you move on

What question is hidden inside *quizás*? (*Qui sapit* — “who knows?”)
 What does a hedge lower — your meaning, or your commitment?
 (Your commitment.)

271.2 supongo que — the hedge that shows its reasoning

The second hedge, and it is not the same as the first.

What to know first

- *quizás* — the hedge that admits uncertainty.

Sounds you'll need

- *su-PON-go ke.* → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

supongo que — “I suppose that.”

Take it apart and it is beautifully literal: Latin **sub-** (“under”) plus **ponere** (“to place”). To suppose is to **place something underneath** — to slide an assumption under an argument so the argument can stand on it.

That *ponere* is everywhere in English once you see it: **compose** (place together), **impose** (place upon), **depose**, **postpone**, **position**. And *supongo* is exactly English **suppose**, arrived by the same road.

What you've built

Quizás and *supongo que* hedge differently, and the difference is worth keeping.

Quizás says: I do not know. *Supongo que* says: I have not been told, but it follows.

The first admits ignorance; the second claims an inference. In an argument they do opposite work — one steps back from a claim, the other quietly offers a reason for it.

With this the chapter's four moves are complete: name an abstract thing, name a whole idea, hedge from uncertainty, and hedge from inference.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *supongo que* ..., finishing it however you like
- the same idea with *quizás* instead, and hear what changed
- three English words built on *ponere*

Before you move on

What does *sub-* + *ponere* mean literally? (To place underneath.)
Which hedge admits ignorance, and which claims an inference?
(*Quizás*; *supongo que*.)

271.3 Three settings on one dial

Two hedges, and a bare statement between them. This is where you feel the difference rather than read it.

Your turn

Take one idea of your own — anything you could argue about — and say it three times.

Say these aloud:

- the bare claim. No hedge. Hear how much you have committed to.
- the same claim with *quizás* in front. You have not changed the idea; you have changed how far you will defend it.
- the same claim again with *supongo que*. Now you are not admitting ignorance — you are offering an inference, and inviting the listener to check your reasoning rather than your confidence.

Say these aloud:

- which of the three you would use with a stranger, and why
- which one an argument is hardest to answer with, and why

Before you move on

Which hedge admits you do not know? (*Quizás*.) Which one claims a reason you have not been given? (*Supongo que*.) What did the Latin behind each one mean — “who knows?”, and “to place underneath”?

Chapter 272

Reading Between the Lines — Imply, Invert, Look It Up, Re-tune

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 👁️ eyes (1) 🖱️ Hands-free start: first 3 of 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can tell the four ways a Spanish sentence means more than it says, and say which strategy each one asks of the listener.

Complete ES-C272-practice: name the listener strategy each of the four devices requires, and which one a written text hides.

272.1 es que... — the refusal that never says no

Everything so far has meant what it said. This chapter is about Spanish that means MORE than it says, and this is the commonest case.

What to know first

- supongo que — the hedge that claims an inference.

Sounds you'll need

- *es ke*, run together, and usually trailing off rather than finishing.
→ reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

es que... — literally “it is that...”, and functionally almost never that. Asked to do something you cannot do, a Spanish speaker very often begins *es que...* and then gives a circumstance rather than an answer. *¿Vienes?* — *Es que mañana trabajo*. Nothing in that sentence is a refusal. Every listener hears one.

The words supply a reason; the **refusal is left for you to work out**. That gap between what is said and what is meant has a name in linguistics — an **implicature** — and Spanish leans on it harder than English does.

What you’ve built

This is the first thing in the book you cannot translate word by word and still understand. *It is that tomorrow I work* is not English, and even repaired to *it’s just that I work tomorrow* it loses the refusal. Two consequences worth carrying. When you hear *es que*, expect the sentence after it to be a reason for a “no” that will not be spoken. And when you need to decline something yourself, this is the polite instrument for it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *es que...* and finish it with a reason
- what a listener would understand from it, in one word (*no*)
- the bare refusal instead, and notice how much blunter it lands

Before you move on

What is the gap between what a sentence says and what it means called? (An implicature.) What does *es que* usually introduce? (A reason standing in for a refusal.)

272.2 sí, claro — when the words say yes and the speaker means no

Harder than an implicature: a sentence whose meaning is the OPPOSITE of its words.

What to know first

- es que... — meaning more than you say.

Sounds you'll need

- Everything here is in the delivery. Said briskly and warmly, *sí, claro* is plain agreement. Said slowly, flatly, with the *claro* dragged out, it is the opposite. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

sí, claro — “yes, of course” — or “yeah, right”, depending entirely on how it is said.

Claro is Latin **clarus**, “bright, clear” — the same word as English **clear** and the name **Clara**. To say *claro* is to say *that is obvious*. Which is exactly what makes it available for irony. A word meaning “obviously” is the perfect thing to say about something you find not obvious at all, and the gap between the word and the tone is where the sarcasm lives.

What you've built

Irony is not a Spanish trick; English does the same with *sure* and *of course*. What is worth knowing is that **the marker is carried in the voice, not in the words** — so a written *sí, claro* is genuinely ambiguous, and Spanish readers resolve it from context exactly as you do in English.

If you are not certain which one you are hearing, you are not failing at Spanish. The sentence is ambiguous by design.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *sí, claro* meaning it — brisk and warm

- *sí, claro* not meaning it — slow and flat
- which of the two a written text cannot tell you

Before you move on

What does *claro* mean literally, and which English word is it? (Bright, clear — *clear*.) Where is the irony carried? (In the voice, not the words.)

272.3 tomar el pelo — four words you know, meaning something else entirely

You know every word in this phrase. That will not help you.

What to know first

- tomar — “to take”, which you already own.
- *sí, claro* — the irony marker just before this.

Sounds you’ll need

- *to-MAR el PE-lo.* → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

tomar el pelo — “to tease someone, to have someone on.”

Word by word it is *to take the hair*, and word by word it tells you nothing. *Pelo* is Latin **pilus**, “a hair” — the same root inside English **pile** (the raised surface of a fabric) and **depilate**.

Where the phrase comes from is genuinely uncertain, and the tidy stories you will find online are folk etymology. What is certain is that its meaning cannot be reached from its parts, and that is the definition of an **idiom**.

English does the same to Spanish learners with *pull someone’s leg*, which has no better-attested origin.

What you've built

An idiom is the limit case of this chapter. An implicature asks you to infer; irony asks you to invert; an idiom asks you to **look it up**, because there is nothing in the words to work with.

That is worth stating plainly rather than leaving you to discover it: some Spanish cannot be decoded, only learned. Recognising which is which is the skill this chapter is really teaching.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *tomar el pelo*
- what it says word by word (*to take the hair*)
- whether the origin story you may have heard is reliable (it is not)

Before you move on

What does *tomar el pelo* mean? (To tease, to have someone on.)
Can its meaning be worked out from its words? (No — that is what makes it an idiom.)

272.4 mira — a word that changes the temperature of what follows

The last of the four, and the smallest: one word that tells the listener how to take the next sentence.

What to know first

- *tomar el pelo* — the idiom before this.

Sounds you'll need

- *MI-ra*, stress the first syllable. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

mira — “look.”

It is the command form of *mirar*, “to look” — Latin **mirari**, “to wonder at, to marry at”, which also gave English **miracle**, **admire** and **mirror**.

But dropped at the start of a sentence it has stopped being a command. Nobody is being asked to look at anything. *Mira, no es así* — “look, it isn’t like that” — uses it to mark what follows as a correction, an intimacy, or an impatience, depending on the voice. Spanish is full of these: *oye, venga, bueno, hombre*. Every one of them started as a word with a meaning and became a **signal about the sentence around it**.

What you’ve built

This is a **discourse marker**, and it does not translate — it *positions*. The literal meaning is spent; what is left is a change in temperature. That completes the chapter’s four ways a Spanish sentence can mean more than it says: it can imply (*es que*), it can invert (*sí, claro*), it can be opaque (*tomar el pelo*), or it can be re-tuned by a word that carries no content at all (*mira*).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *mira* as a real command — look at something
- *mira* as a marker — *mira, no es así*
- two more markers Spanish uses this way

Before you move on

What is *mira* literally? (The command “look”, from *mirar*.) What does a discourse marker do instead of meaning something? (It positions the sentence — it changes how you are meant to take it.)

272.5 Four ways to mean more than you say

Four devices, and the useful skill is telling them apart fast enough to keep up with a speaker.

Your turn

For each of the four, say which strategy the listener has to use.

Say these aloud:

- *es que mañana trabajo* — and then say what the listener must do (**infer** — supply the refusal that was not spoken)
- *sí, claro*, flat and slow — and what the listener must do (**invert** — take the opposite of the words)
- *me estás tomando el pelo* — and what the listener must do (**know it already** — nothing in the words will help)
- *mira, no es así* — and what the listener must do (**re-tune** — the marker says how to take what follows, not what it means)

Say these aloud:

- which of the four a written text hides from you, and why (*sí, claro* — the irony is in the voice)
- which of the four you could not have guessed without being taught

Before you move on

Name the four strategies a listener uses: infer, invert, look it up, re-tune. Which one is carried in the voice rather than the words? (Irony.) Which one cannot be worked out at all? (The idiom.)

Chapter 273

Building a Paragraph — Plan, Add, Join, Refer Back

Modes: 🗣 voice (5) 🗣 Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can build a paragraph in Spanish whose sentences signal how they relate to one another, and say what is lost when the signals are removed.

Complete ES-C273-practice: build a four-sentence paragraph with each join, then say it again with the joins removed and describe what changed.

273.1 en primer lugar — telling the reader the shape before you fill it

You can build a sentence that means more than it says. This chapter is about building something longer than a sentence.

What to know first

- mira — the marker that re-tunes what follows.
- por ejemplo — the evidence move.

Sounds you'll need

- *en pri-MER lu-GAR.* → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

en primer lugar — “in the first place, firstly.”

Primer is Latin **primarius**, “of the first rank” — English **primary**, **prime**. *Lugar* is **locus**, “place” — English **local**, **locate**. Literally: *in the first place*, and English kept the phrase intact.

Its partners are *en segundo lugar* and *por último*, “lastly.”

What you’ve built

This is not a connective. It does not join two ideas — it tells the listener **how many are coming**.

That is a different job, and it is what makes extended text followable.

A reader who hears *en primer lugar* knows to expect a second point and holds a slot open for it. Take the phrase away and the same three points arrive as an undifferentiated list.

Signposting is most of what separates a paragraph from a pile of sentences.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *en primer lugar* and make a point
- *en segundo lugar* and make another
- *por último* and close

Before you move on

What Latin words are inside *primer* and *lugar*? (*Primarius* and *locus*.) What does the phrase tell a listener that a connective does not? (How many points are coming.)

273.2 además — adding a point, not adding an item

You have *también*, “also.” This is not the same word, and the difference is the same one *pero* and *sin embargo* had.

What to know first

- en primer lugar — the signpost before this.
- también — the “also” you already own.

Sounds you’ll need

- *a-de-MÁS*, and the accent tells you so. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

además — “furthermore, moreover, besides.”

Take it apart: *a + de + más* — “to, of, more.” It is built out of three words you already have, and *más* is the comparison word from the experience chapter.

So it means, quite literally, “**in addition to more.**” Spanish built its heaviest additive connector out of its lightest pieces.

What you’ve built

También adds an **item**: *hablo español; también hablo francés*. *Además* adds a **point**: *es difícil*. *Además, es caro*.

The first says *one more of the same kind*. The second says *and here is a further reason*, and it is what an argument uses when the reasons are not interchangeable.

That is the same distinction you met with *pero* and *sin embargo*: the light word joins inside a breath, the heavy one opens a new sentence and carries argumentative weight.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- two like items with *también*
- two separate reasons with *además*
- which of the two an argument needs, and why

Before you move on

What three words is *además* built from? (*A, de, más.*) What does *también* add, and what does *además* add? (An item; a point.)

273.3 por lo tanto — the word that makes a text hold together

Signpost, addition — and now the join that turns a list of points into an argument.

What to know first

- *además* — adding a further point.
- *así que* — the everyday “so” you already have.

Sounds you’ll need

- *por lo TAN-to.* → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

por lo tanto — “therefore, consequently.”

Tanto is Latin **tantus**, “so much, so great.” The phrase is *for so much* — *given all that*, therefore.

You already have *así que*, which does the same job in conversation.

Por lo tanto is its written, weight-bearing form: the one that appears in an argument where the conclusion has to look earned.

What you’ve built

Here is the thing this chapter is really about. The English word for what these connectives create is **cohesion** — the property that makes a text feel like one thing rather than several.

Cohesion is not achieved by the sentences being about the same topic.

It is achieved by each sentence carrying an explicit signal of **how it relates to the last one**: another point (*además*), a consequence (*por lo tanto*), a concession (*sin embargo*), an example (*por ejemplo*).

Remove those signals and a paragraph does not become wrong. It becomes work.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- a claim, then *por lo tanto*, then its consequence
- the same pair with *así que*, and hear the register drop
- what cohesion is, in your own words

Before you move on

What does *tanto* mean, and which Latin word is it? (So much — *tantus*.) What is cohesion? (Each sentence signalling how it relates to the last.)

273.4 lo cual — pointing back at everything you just said

The last piece: a way to refer to a whole idea rather than a thing.

What to know first

- *por lo tanto* — the cohesion join.
- *lo que* — naming a thing you cannot name.

Sounds you'll need

- *lo KUAL*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

lo cual — “which”, where the *which* points at an entire preceding clause.

Cual is Latin **qualis**, “of what kind” — English **quality** and the *-al* of **equal**. The neuter *lo* in front is what widens its target: not a noun, but everything just said.

Llegó tarde, lo cual me sorprendió. — “He arrived late, **which** surprised me.” What surprised me is not *he*, and not *late*. It is the whole fact.

What you've built

Pointing back at something already said is called **anaphora**, and it is the other half of cohesion. Connectives say how sentences relate; anaphora lets a sentence pick up what came before without repeating it.

Spanish is precise here in a way English is not. English *which* can point at a noun or a clause and leaves you to work out which. Spanish splits the job: *que* and *el cual* take a noun, *lo cual* takes the whole idea. The neuter *lo* is the marker that says “what follows refers to no single thing.”

With that, the chapter's four pieces are complete: plan the text, add to it, join it, and refer back within it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- a sentence, then *lo cual*, then your reaction to the whole of it
- what *lo cual* points at that *que* cannot
- the word for pointing back (*anaphora*)

Before you move on

What Latin word is *cual*? (*Qualis*, “of what kind.”) What does the neuter *lo* do to its target? (Widens it from a noun to a whole idea.) What is the name for pointing back? (Anaphora.)

273.5 One paragraph, four joins

Four pieces, and the point of them is that they only show their value at length. A single sentence never needed any of this.

Your turn

Build one paragraph out loud, on any opinion you hold. Four sentences, each with its join.

Say these aloud:

- *en primer lugar*, and your first reason. The listener now knows more is coming.
- *además*, and a second reason that is **not** the same kind as the first. If it could have taken *también*, choose a different reason.
- *por lo tanto*, and the conclusion those two reasons earn.
- one more sentence ending in *lo cual* plus your reaction to the whole of it.

Say these aloud:

- the same four sentences again with every join REMOVED. Same content, same order.
- what changed. Nothing became wrong — it became work.

Before you move on

Which of the four tells the listener how many points are coming? (*En primer lugar*.) Which one points back at a whole idea? (*Lo cual*.) What is the name for a text whose sentences signal how they relate? (Cohesive.)

Chapter 274

What a Phrase Carries — Authority, a Story, a Silence, a Sense of Charm

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the cultural weight a Spanish phrase carries beyond its meaning, and tell a proverb from an idiom, an allusion from a word, and a euphemism from politeness.

Complete ES-C274-practice: name the weight each of the four phrases borrows, and say which one can be used correctly without knowing its source.

274.1 más vale pájaro en mano — a sentence the language finished for you

This chapter is about Spanish that carries more than its meaning:
it carries where it came from.

What to know first

- lo cual — the last piece of the paragraph chapter.
- tomar el pelo — the idiom you cannot decode.

Sounds you'll need

- *más VA-le PÁ-ja-ro en MA-no.* → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

más vale pájaro en mano — “a bird in the hand is worth more.” Every word is one you have. *Más* from the comparison chapter, *vale* from Latin **valere** (“to be worth” — English **value**, **valid**), *mano* from **manus**.

And Spanish speakers do not finish it. The full form is *más vale pájaro en mano que ciento volando* — “than a hundred flying” — but the second half is so well known that saying it marks you as explaining rather than quoting.

English does the same. Nobody says *a bird in the hand is worth two in the bush*; they say **a bird in the hand** and stop.

What you’ve built

A **proverb** is not an idiom. An idiom’s meaning cannot be worked out from its words; a proverb’s can — *a bird in the hand is worth more* is transparent.

What a proverb carries instead is **communal authority**. Using one is a claim that the point is not yours but everybody’s, already settled, not up for argument. That is why proverbs close conversations and arguments open them.

The half-sentence is the tell. A phrase you are expected to leave unfinished is a phrase the room already knows.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the half everyone says
- the full form, and notice it sounds like explaining
- what a proverb claims that an argument does not (that it is settled)

Before you move on

What is the difference between a proverb and an idiom? (A proverb’s meaning is transparent; an idiom’s is not.) Why do speakers stop halfway? (Finishing it marks you as explaining rather than quoting.)

274.2 ser un quijote — when a book becomes a common noun

A proverb comes from everyone. This comes from one book, and behaves like a word.

What to know first

- más vale pájaro en mano — the proverb.

Sounds you'll need

- *ser un ki-JO-te*. The *j* is the throat sound. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ser un quijote — to be idealistic to the point of impracticality; to fight for a lost cause because it is right.

It is Don Quixote, from Cervantes' novel of 1605 — and the word has stopped being a name. Written lowercase, *quijote* is an ordinary Spanish noun in the dictionary, and so is the adjective *quijotesco*. English took the same journey to **quixotic**.

Notice what that means: you can use the word correctly without having read the book. Most speakers have not. The allusion has been absorbed into the language and no longer requires its source.

What you've built

This is a **cultural allusion**, and it is the hardest kind of meaning for a learner, because a dictionary will give you the gloss and not the weight. The practical consequence is worth stating plainly: when a Spanish text uses a name as though it were a word — *un quijote*, *un donjuán*, *una celestina* — it is pointing at a story its readers are assumed to share. You are not expected to know all of them. You are expected to **notice that a name is doing work**, and look it up.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ser un quijote*

- what it means, without mentioning the novel
- the English word that made the same journey (*quixotic*)

Before you move on

What is *quijote* in the dictionary — a name or a noun? (A noun; the name was absorbed.) What are you expected to notice, rather than already know? (That a name is doing the work of a word.)

274.3 pasar a mejor vida — the words a language uses to avoid a word

Some meanings a language will not say directly. This is how Spanish says one of them.

What to know first

- ser un quijote — the allusion.

Sounds you'll need

- *pa-SAR a me-JOR VI-da.* → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

pasar a mejor vida — literally “to pass to a better life”: to die. Spanish has the plain verb, *morir*, and uses it. But alongside it sits a whole shelf of ways not to: *pasar a mejor vida*, *fallecer* (the formal one), *irse*, *descansar*.

English has exactly the same shelf — *pass away*, *pass on*, *depart*, *rest* — and for the same reason. A **euphemism** is not politeness for its own sake. It is a language routing around a subject its speakers find hard to name.

What you've built

Where the euphemisms cluster tells you what a culture treats as difficult, and the clusters are largely shared: death, illness, money, the body, dismissal from a job.

Two practical consequences. First, **you will meet these before you**

meet the plain word, because speakers reach for them by default with strangers. Second, choosing the plain word when a euphemism was expected is not a neutral act — it is a choice the listener will hear, the same way *sí, claro* said flatly is a choice. The euphemism is not the polite version of the sentence. It is a different sentence.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *pasar a mejor vida*
- the plain verb it avoids (*morir*)
- one English euphemism for the same thing

Before you move on

What is a euphemism doing? (Routing around a subject speakers find hard to name.) Name two areas where euphemisms cluster. (Death, illness, money, the body, losing a job.)

274.4 tener gracia — the last thing a learner gets, and why

The final piece of the chapter, and the one that stays difficult longest.

What to know first

- *pasar a mejor vida* — the euphemism.
- *gracias* — one of the first words of this book, and the same root.

Sounds you'll need

- *te-NER GRA-cia.* → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

tener gracia — “to be funny”, and rather more than that.

Gracia is Latin **gratia** — favour, charm, grace, and the thing you give thanks for. It is the same word inside *gracias*, which you learned on the first page of this book, and inside English **grace**, **gracious** and **gratitude**.

So *tener gracia* is not quite “to be funny.” It is closer to *to have charm* — and a joke that fails is *no tiene gracia*, which says less that it failed to amuse than that it lacked a quality it should have had.

What you’ve built

Humour is the last thing a learner acquires, and the reason is structural rather than a matter of vocabulary. Every device in the previous two chapters converges here: a joke can turn on an implicature, an inversion, an idiom, a proverb bent out of shape, an allusion, or a euphemism deployed too plainly.

To find something funny in Spanish you have to hold all of them at once and notice which one is being played with — which is why it comes last, and why not getting a joke is a poor measure of your Spanish and a good measure of how much of the culture you have absorbed.

That closes the chapter. Four kinds of weight a phrase can carry beyond its meaning: the community’s authority, a shared story, a subject avoided, and a sense of what is charming.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *tener gracia*, and *no tiene gracia*
- the first word of this book that shares its root (*gracias*)
- why humour comes last, in one sentence

Before you move on

What Latin word is *gracia*, and which word from page one shares it? (*Gratia*; *gracias*.) Why is humour the last thing acquired? (It requires holding every other implicit device at once.)

274.5 Four kinds of weight

Each of these four says something plain and carries something else. The skill is naming what the something else is.

Your turn

For each, say the phrase and then name the weight it carries.

Say these aloud:

- *más vale pájaro en mano* — and what it borrows (**the community's authority**: the point is not mine, it is settled)
- *ser un quijote* — and what it borrows (**a shared story**, which you may use without having read)
- *pasar a mejor vida* — and what it borrows (**a silence**: the subject the language is routing around)
- *no tiene gracia* — and what it borrows (**a sense of what is charming**, which is not the same as what is amusing)

Say these aloud:

- which of the four you could use correctly without knowing its source (*un quijote* — the allusion has been absorbed)
- which one tells you what a culture finds hard to say (the euphemism)

Before you move on

Name the four weights: the community's authority, a shared story, a subject avoided, a sense of charm. Which one is transparent in its words but borrowed in its force? (The proverb.) Which is the last a learner acquires, and why? (Humour — it needs all the others at once.)

Chapter 275

Fine Shades — Four Differences a Translation Loses

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can hear four Spanish distinctions that English translates identically, and say which of them no rule can teach me.

Complete ES-C275-practice: say each pair and what English does with the difference.

275.1 deber de — one preposition, two entirely different claims

This chapter is about differences too small to be called mistakes and too large to ignore. The first one is a single word.

What to know first

- deber — “should, must”, which you already own.
- supongo que — the hedge that claims an inference.

Sounds you’ll need

- *de-BER de*. The *de* is unstressed and easy to miss, which is exactly the problem. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

deber and **deber de** — and English uses one word, *must*, for both. *Debe estar en casa.* — He **must** be at home. (Obligation: it is his duty.) *Debe de estar en casa.* — He **must** be at home. (Inference: I conclude it.)

English hides this. *He must be at home* is ambiguous in exactly the same way, and only context resolves it. Spanish has a marker available, and the marker is one unstressed syllable.

Deber is Latin **debere**, “to owe” — English **debt**, **debit**, **due**. The obligation sense is the original; the guessing sense is the borrowed one, which is why the plain form keeps it.

What you’ve built

Two honest notes, because a rule stated too confidently here would mislead you.

First, this distinction is prescribed more consistently than it is observed. Many educated speakers use plain *deber* for both, and the Real Academia accepts that while recommending the split. **You will hear it collapsed.** Knowing the distinction is for reading carefully and writing precisely, not for correcting anybody.

Second, it belongs beside *supongo que*: both are ways of marking that a statement is reasoned rather than known. *Deber de* puts that marking inside the verb.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the obligation — *debe estar en casa*
- the inference — *debe de estar en casa*
- which one English cannot mark at all

Before you move on

What does *deber de* claim that *deber* does not? (An inference rather than an obligation.) Is the distinction reliably observed in speech? (No — it is prescribed more than practised.)

275.2 cometer un error — the verb the noun demands

Nothing is wrong with the sentence you would build from first principles. It is simply not what anybody says.

What to know first

- deber de — the modal shade.
- hacer — “to do, to make”, the verb you would reach for.

Sounds you’ll need

- *co-me-TER un e-RROR*. The double *rr* is trilled. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

cometer un error — “to make a mistake.”

Not *hacer un error*. That is grammatical, comprehensible, and wrong in the way that matters: no one says it. Spanish **commits** an error, as English commits a crime.

Cometer is Latin **committere** — *com-* (“together”) plus *mittere* (“to send”), the root inside English **mission**, **transmit** and **commit**.

English kept the verb for offences; Spanish extended it to mistakes.

The pairings are not deducible and have to be met one at a time:

cometer un error, *tomar una decisión* (not *hacer*), *prestar atención* (to lend attention), *hacer una pregunta* (to make a question, where English asks).

What you’ve built

A pairing of words that a language habitually uses together is a **collocation**, and it is the last thing to come right in a learner’s output. It is worth understanding why it feels so unfair. Grammar is a system you can learn, and vocabulary is a list you can study. Collocation is neither: it is **usage**, and the only source is having met the pair before. This is why reading widely does something no amount of grammar study does, and why a sentence can be flawless and still sound foreign.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *cometer un error*
- the version you would have built, and why it is wrong (*hacer* — no one says it)
- one more pair from the list above

Before you move on

What is a collocation? (Words a language habitually uses together.)
Why is it the last thing to come right? (It is usage — there is no rule to learn, only exposure.)

275.3 *sí que* — the yes that answers an accusation nobody made

English does this with the voice. Spanish does it with two words, and they leave a trace on the page.

What to know first

- *sí, claro* — the ironic yes.
- *cometer un error* — the collocation.

Sounds you'll need

- *sí ke*, and the *sí* keeps its accent because it is the affirming *sí*, not the conditional *si*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

sí que — the emphatic affirmative.

Habla español. — He speaks Spanish. *Sí que habla español.* — He **does** speak Spanish.

English marks this with stress alone — *he DOES speak Spanish* — and in writing must resort to italics or the inserted *do*. Spanish has a phrase for it, which means the emphasis **survives being written**

down.

Sí is Latin **sic**, “thus, so” — the same *sic* you meet in an English quotation meaning *thus it stood*.

What you’ve built

What makes this a fine shade rather than a loud one is what it implies. *Sí que habla español* does not simply assert. It **contradicts** — it answers a doubt, and if nobody voiced one, it invents one to answer. That is a real risk in use: saying *sí que* when no doubt existed tells your listener you thought they doubted you. Emphasis is never only volume; it always implies something about what the other person was thinking.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the plain statement
- the emphatic one with *sí que*
- what the emphatic version implies about your listener

Before you move on

What Latin word is *sí*? (*Sic*, “thus”.) What does *sí que* do beyond asserting? (It contradicts a doubt — and implies one if none was voiced.)

275.4 delgado / flaco — two words for one fact, and the choice is the message

The last shade, and the one with consequences: two words that describe the same person and say different things about the speaker.

What to know first

- *sí que* — the emphasis device.

- cansado — an adjective you already have.

Sounds you'll need

- *del-GA-do, FLA-co.* → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

delgado and **flaco** both mean “thin.”

Delgado is Latin **delicatus** — the same word as English **delicate**. It is the neutral-to-complimentary one: slim.

Flaco is Latin **flaccus**, “flabby, drooping” — English **flaccid**. It is blunter, and depending on where you are and who you are talking to it ranges from plainly descriptive to unkind.

Regional warning, and it matters more than the etymology.

In much of Latin America *flaco* is affectionate — a common term of address to a friend, regardless of their build. In parts of Spain it lands harder. This is one of the places where a single word’s warmth genuinely does not travel.

What you’ve built

Two words with the same **denotation** — the fact they point at — and different **connotation** — what choosing one says about you.

This is where a dictionary stops being enough. It will give you both words and the same gloss for each, and the gloss is where the information you need has been removed.

That completes the four shades: a modal that marks a guess, a verb the noun insists on, an emphasis that implies a doubt, and a synonym that is not one. Every one of them is invisible to a translation and audible to a native speaker.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- both words
- which you would use about someone you had just met
- why a dictionary cannot tell you that

Before you move on

What is the difference between denotation and connotation? (The fact a word points at; what choosing it says about you.) Which of the two thin-words travels worst between regions? (*Flaco* — affectionate in much of Latin America, harder elsewhere.)

275.5 Four differences a translation loses

Each of these four survives translation into English as the *same sentence*. That is what makes them the last things you learn.

Your turn

For each pair, say both and then say what English does with the difference.

Say these aloud:

- *debe estar* and *debe de estar* — English gives both **must**, and leaves you to guess which
- *cometer un error* and the *hacer* version — English cannot even see the error; both translate to *make a mistake*
- *habla español* and *sí que habla español* — English needs the voice, or italics, and loses it in plain text
- *delgado* and *flaco* — English gives **thin** for both, and the dictionary removes exactly the information you needed

Say these aloud:

- which of the four could get you into trouble socially, and where (*flaco* — warm in much of Latin America, harder elsewhere)
- which one no rule can teach you (the collocation — only having met it)

Before you move on

Name the four: a guess marked in the verb, a verb the noun insists on, an emphasis that implies a doubt, and a synonym that is not

one. What do all four have in common? (English translates them identically.)

Chapter 276

Reading Older Spanish — Register, Date, and Form

Modes: 🗣️ voice (3) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can tell from small details whether a Spanish text is literary and whether its verse is rhymed.

Complete ES-C276-practice: say what each detail tells you about a text before you have read it.

276.1 mas — a word you will only ever read

The last chapter is about Spanish written before you were born, and Spanish written to be read rather than said. This word is both.

What to know first

- pero — the everyday “but”.
- más que — the comparison, WITH an accent.

Sounds you’ll need

- *mas*, one syllable, unstressed in the sentence — and note it has **no written accent**, which is the whole point. *Más* with the accent is “more.” → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

mas — “but.” The same job as *pero*, and almost nobody says it aloud. It is Latin **magis**, “more” — the same word that gave you *más*. The two split: *más* kept the quantity, *mas* took a contrastive sense and then retreated into books.

The accent is doing real work here, and this is the pair the written accent exists for: *mas* (but) against *más* (more). Two words, one sound, and only the page tells them apart.

What you’ve built

A word that survives **only in writing** is a marker of **literary register**, and a reader needs to recognise it for two reasons.

First, practically: meeting *mas* in a poem and reading it as *más* turns the sentence inside out.

Second, and more usefully: its presence tells you what kind of text you are in before you have understood a word of it. Register is information carried by **which** words appear, independently of what they say — and a text signals it in the first line.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *mas* and *más*, and name the difference on the page
- the everyday word it replaces (*pero*)
- what its presence tells you about a text

Before you move on

What is the difference between *mas* and *más*? (But; more — only the accent separates them.) What does meeting *mas* tell you before you have read the sentence? (That the text is literary.)

276.2 asonancia — why Spanish poems do not rhyme the way you expect

The last piece. If Spanish verse has ever sounded to you like it nearly rhymes, this is why.

What to know first

- mas — the literary register marker.
- vuestra merced → usted — the archaic form, taught long ago.

Sounds you'll need

- *a-so-NAN-cia*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

asonancia — assonance: rhyme on the **vowels only**, ignoring the consonants after them.

Luna and *cuna* rhyme fully — English would call that a rhyme too. But *luna* and *musa* are also a rhyme in Spanish verse: stressed *u*, final *a*, and the *n* against the *s* simply does not count.

Asonancia is Latin **assonare**, “to sound towards” — *ad* plus *sonare*, the root of **sound**, **sonorous** and **unison**.

This is not a loose or lazy rhyme. It is the organising principle of the **romance**, the ballad form, which runs from medieval oral poetry through Lorca in the twentieth century.

What you've built

Two things follow for a reader.

An English-trained ear hears assonance as *failure to rhyme* and concludes the poem is unrhymed. It is rhymed — by a rule your ear was not trained on, and the rule is easier than the English one, not harder.

And it explains why Spanish verse can sustain a single rhyme for hundreds of lines where English cannot. Rhyming on vowels alone leaves far more words available. The form is shaped by what the language makes cheap.

That closes the chapter, and with it the last thing this book can teach you about reading: a text carries its date, its register, and its form in details that look like noise until you know what they are.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *asonancia*

- whether *luna* and *musa* rhyme in Spanish (yes)
- why a Spanish ballad can keep one rhyme for hundreds of lines

Before you move on

What does assonance rhyme on? (The vowels only.) Which form is built on it? (The *romance*, the ballad.) Why can it run so long? (Vowel-only rhyme leaves far more words available.)

276.3 What a text tells you before you read it

Three details that look like noise until you know what they are — and each one dates or places a text before you have understood a sentence of it.

Your turn

For each, say what the detail tells you.

Say these aloud:

- you meet *mas* with no accent — what do you now know about the text? (**Literary**, and almost certainly not transcribed speech.)
- you meet *vuestra merced* — what do you now know? (**Old**, and you were told long ago what it became: *usted*.)
- the lines end *luna ... musa ... cuna* — is this rhymed? (**Yes** — assonance, and an English-trained ear will say no.)

Say these aloud:

- which of the three explains something still in use today (*vuestra merced* — it is why *usted* takes the he/she verb)
- what all three have in common (each carries information that has nothing to do with what the sentence means)

Before you move on

Name what each signals: register, date, form. Which one is a fossil that still governs living grammar? (*Vuestra merced*, behind *usted*.) Which is a rhyme your ear may not hear as one? (Assonance.)

Chapter 277

Working From Sources — Credit It, Restate It, Hold Both, Compress

Modes: ⇄ voice (4) 👁 eyes (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: none of the 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can attribute a claim in Spanish, restate it in my own words, hold two disagreeing sources in one structure, and compress both into a sentence.

Complete ES-C277-practice: run all four moves on two sources that disagree, then say what the summary left out.

277.1 según — the word that says this is not mine

The last chapter of the book. It is about handling what other people have said, and it starts with the smallest and most important move: saying whose it is.

What to know first

- en mi opinión — marking a claim as yours.
- dijo que — reporting what someone said.

Sounds you'll need

- *se-GÚN*, and the accent is written because the stress is on the last syllable. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

según — “according to.”

Latin **secundum**, “following, next along” — the same word as English **second** and, through it, **sequence**. To say *según* is literally to say *following* — *following García, the number is higher*.

You already have the opposite move: *en mi opinión* marks a claim as **yours**. *Según* marks it as **someone else's**, and the two together are the whole apparatus of attribution.

What you've built

This is the smallest honest unit of scholarship, and it does two jobs at once.

It **credits** — the idea belongs to somebody. And it **distances** — you are reporting the claim, not endorsing it. *Según él, es fácil* leaves entirely open whether you agree.

That second job is why *según* is common in journalism and argument, not only in citation. It lets you put a claim on the table without picking it up.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *según* plus a name plus a claim
- the same claim as your own, with *en mi opinión*
- which of the two commits you to it

Before you move on

What Latin word is *según*, and which English word shares it? (*Secundum* — *second*.) What two jobs does it do at once? (Credits the source, and distances you from the claim.)

277.2 *es decir* — saying it again, differently, on purpose

You have the source. Now the harder half: putting what it said into words that are yours.

What to know first

- *según* — marking whose claim it is.
- *es que...* — a different *es* phrase entirely.

Sounds you'll need

- *es de-CIR*. Note how close this is to *es que* and how different its job is. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

es decir — “that is to say, in other words.”

Literally *it is to say*: the infinitive *decir* from Latin **dicere**, the root inside English **diction**, **dictate**, **verdict** and **contradict**.

It marks what follows as **the same content in different words** — and that is the definition of a **paraphrase**. Not a summary, which is shorter, and not a quotation, which is identical. The same, said again, deliberately.

What you've built

Why a language needs a marker for this at all is worth a moment. Without *es decir*, a restatement looks like a second, separate claim. The listener counts two points where you made one. The marker tells them: **this is the same point, arriving again in a form you may find easier**.

That is also the honest test of whether you have understood a source. If you can only repeat its words, you have not understood it; if you can say it another way, you have. Paraphrase is comprehension made visible, which is why it is asked for in every examination ever set.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- a claim, then *es decir*, then the same claim differently
- why the marker matters (without it, it reads as a second point)
- the difference between a paraphrase and a summary

Before you move on

What does *es decir* mark? (The same content in different words.)
 How does a paraphrase differ from a summary? (A summary is shorter; a paraphrase is the same length, said differently.) Which English words share *dicere*? (*Diction, verdict, contradict.*)

277.3 por un lado... por otro — two sources in one sentence

One source you can report. Two that disagree is a different problem, and this is the frame for it.

What to know first

- *es decir* — restating a source.
- *sin embargo* — turning against a point.

Sounds you'll need

- *por un LA-do ... por O-tro.* → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

por un lado... por otro (lado) — “on one hand... on the other.”
Lado is Latin **latus**, “side, flank” — English **lateral, bilateral**. The image is spatial in both languages: two sides of a thing, held apart so both can be seen.
 Spanish, like English, usually drops the second *lado*: *por un lado... por otro*.

What you've built

This is the frame that makes **synthesis** possible, and synthesis is not the same as reporting twice.

Reporting twice: *Según García, sube. Según López, baja.* Two facts, no relation. Synthesising: *Por un lado García dice que sube; por otro, López lo niega.* Now the two are **held in one structure**, and the reader can see that they conflict rather than having to notice it themselves.

The frame does the analytical work. Announcing two sides commits you to producing both, which is exactly the discipline that stops a summary from quietly becoming an argument for one of them.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- two conflicting claims, reported flatly, one after the other
- the same two inside the *por un lado... por otro* frame
- what the frame made visible that the flat version did not

Before you move on

What Latin word is *lado*? (*Latus*, “side” — English *lateral*.) What does the frame do that reporting twice does not? (It holds the two in one structure, so the relation between them is visible.)

277.4 en resumen — the hardest thing to do with a text

The last phrase in the book, and the hardest skill in it.

What to know first

- *por un lado... por otro* — holding two sources.
- *por lo tanto* — the cohesion join.

Sounds you'll need

- *en re-su-MEN.* → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

en resumen — “in short, in summary.”

Resumen is Latin **resumere** — *re-* (“again”) plus *sumere* (“to take up”). To summarise is to **take it up again**, and English **resume** kept the taking-up while Spanish kept the shortening.

Note the false friend, because it will catch you: Spanish *resumen* is a **summary**, not a curriculum vitae. The English *résumé* took the same French word in a different direction.

What you’ve built

Summarising is harder than paraphrasing, and the difference is **decision**.

A paraphrase keeps everything and changes the words. A summary **throws things away**, and every omission is a judgement about what mattered. That is why two honest summaries of one text can differ, and why summarising is the last skill on this ladder rather than the first.

It also closes the loop this book opened. It began by giving you a word for *hello*. It ends by giving you the means to read what other people have written, decide what is load-bearing in it, and say that much in your own words — which is most of what it means to *use* a language rather than to know one.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *en resumen*, and compress the last thing you read into one sentence
- what you left out, and why
- the false friend to avoid (*resumen* is not a CV)

Before you move on

What does *resumere* mean, taken apart? (To take up again.) What separates a summary from a paraphrase? (A summary throws things away, and every omission is a judgement.)

277.5 Read two, say one

The last exercise in the book, and it uses all four moves in the order you would actually need them.

Your turn

Find two things that disagree — two people, two articles, two friends. Then run the four moves.

Say these aloud:

- *según* the first one, what it claims. You have credited it and not agreed with it.
- *es decir*, and the same claim in words the first source did not use. If you cannot, you have not understood it yet.
- *por un lado... por otro*, putting both inside one sentence so the disagreement is visible rather than merely present.
- *en resumen*, and one sentence that covers both.

Say these aloud:

- what you left out of the summary, and why it was safe to lose
- whether your summary favours one of the two. Check honestly — this is where a summary quietly becomes an argument.

Before you move on

Name the four moves: credit it, restate it, hold both, compress.
Which one proves you understood the source? (The paraphrase.)
Which one requires you to throw something away? (The summary.)

Chapter 278

Four Things Outdoors — Wind, Snow, Tree, Flower

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the wind, the snow, a tree and a flower in Spanish, and say for each whether its English relative is an inherited cousin or a later borrowing.

Complete ES-C278-flor: say all four words, then sort their English relatives into cousins and loans.

278.1 el viento — a word English happens to own twice

You have just spent a long run of lessons on words for arguing, citing and summarising. What follows is the opposite kind of material: plain, solid things you can point at.

What to know first

- el tiempo — the weather, and the word for it.
- hace calor, hace frío, hace sol — saying what the weather is doing today.

Sounds you'll need

- *VIEN-to*, stress on the first syllable. The *ie* is the same opening-out you have met before in *quiero* and *tiene*: one Latin vowel arriving in Spanish as two. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el viento — “the wind.”

Latin **ventus**, with its short stressed *e* opening into *ie* on the road into Spanish. That single change is why the vowel you say is not the vowel Latin wrote.

The interesting part is on the English side. **Wind** was not taken from *ventus*. The two words go back to one much older ancestor and came down two separate family lines, which is why they resemble each other only faintly. **Ventilate** and **vent**, by contrast, *are* Latin *ventus*, carried into English out of books long after English already had a perfectly good word for moving air.

What you've built

A cousin and a loan leave different marks, and you can often see which you are holding.

An inherited word has been in the mouth for two thousand years, and each language has worn it down its own way — one ancestor came out as *viento* here and as *wind* there. A borrowed word arrives late, in writing, and stays tidy: *ventilate* still looks Latin because it has had almost no time to stop looking Latin.

Keep that test. It will pay off in nearly every word ahead.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el viento*
- which English word is the cousin and which is the loan (*wind*; *ventilate*)
- one sentence about the weather with *hace*, and one with *el viento*

Before you move on

What Latin word stands behind *viento*? (*Ventus*.) Is English *wind* borrowed from it? (No — a cousin, down a separate line from the same ancestor.) Which English word is the actual loan? (*Ventilate*, or *vent*.)

278.2 la nieve — the same vowel trick, and a missing s

You have one weather word already. Here is a second, and it repeats the sound change you just met — which is how you will start to recognise it on your own.

What to know first

- el viento — the wind, and the *ie* that came out of a Latin *e*.
- llueve — saying that it is raining.

Sounds you'll need

- *NIE-ve*, stress on the first syllable, and the *v* said with the lips barely meeting — the soft *b* sound you already use in *vino*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la nieve — “the snow.”

Latin's word was **nix**, but its other forms carry the stem *niv-*, and it is that stem — through the form *nivem* — that Spanish grew from. The short stressed *e* opened into *ie*, exactly as it did a moment ago, and *nivem* came out as *nieve*.

English **snow** is the cousin. The shared ancestor began with an *s* that Latin dropped and the Germanic side kept, so the two words differ at the front and agree behind it. Latin's own form does reach English, but only in cold technical corners: **niveous** for snow-white, and the *nival* zone near the top of a mountain.

What you've built

Twice now, a Latin *e* under stress has arrived in Spanish as *ie*. That is no longer a fact about one word; it is a pattern you can carry. When you meet a Spanish word with *ie* whose Latin or English relative shows a plain *e*, you are almost certainly looking at this same event, two thousand years old, still visible in the spelling.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la nieve*, then *el viento*
- the Latin stem behind it (*niv-*)
- what English kept at the front of *snow* that Latin threw away

Before you move on

Which sound change turned *nivem* into *nieve*? (Stressed *e* opening into *ie* — the same one behind *viento*.) What separates *nieve* from English *snow* at the very front? (An *s* the Latin line lost.)

278.3 el árbol — one letter away from Latin

Some words changed a great deal on the way from Latin. This one changed by a single letter, and the letter it changed tells you something about mouths rather than about Spanish.

What to know first

- verde — green, from a Latin verb meaning to flourish.
- á é í ó ú — what a written accent does to the stress.

Sounds you'll need

- *Ár-bol*. The accent is written because the stress falls on the first syllable while the word ends in *l*, which is not where the default would put it. The *r* is a single tap, not a roll. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el árbol — “the tree.”

Latin **arbor**, and Spanish kept nearly all of it. What moved is the second *r*, which became *l*.

Two *r* sounds a syllable apart are awkward to keep distinct, and a tongue that says the word ten thousand times will look for a way out. Spanish took it. Portuguese, next door, did not: its tree is *árvore*, both *r* sounds intact. The escape route was available, not compulsory, and that is worth knowing before you start expecting sound changes to be laws.

English holds the Latin word too, untouched: **arbor**, **arboreal**, **arboretum**. Both *r* sounds still there, because a word borrowed out of a book escapes everything an inherited word lives through.

What you’ve built

This is the cousin-and-loan test again, from the other direction.

Árbol is the inherited form, and it carries a scar: one sound gave way to another for no reason except ease. *Arboretum* is the loan, and it carries no scar at all. When two English words look like a Spanish one but only the tidy one matches it letter for letter, the tidy one is usually the late arrival.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el árbol*, stressing the first syllable
- the Latin word, and which of its letters moved (*arbor*; the second *r*)
- *el viento*, *la nieve*, *el árbol* — the three you now have

Before you move on

What single change separates *árbol* from *arbor*? (The second *r* became *l*.) Did every Romance language make it? (No — Portuguese kept *árvore*.) Why does English *arboretum* look more Latin than the Spanish word does? (It was borrowed late, not inherited.)

278.4 la flor — and the English word hiding inside your bread

The last of the four outdoor words, and the one with the best surprise waiting on the English side.

What to know first

- el árbol — the tree, one letter from Latin.
- el pan — bread, which this lesson comes back to.

Sounds you'll need

- *flor*, one syllable, ending in a single tapped *r*. Spanish does not put a vowel into the *fl*- cluster, so it starts cleanly. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la flor — “the flower.”

Latin's bare form was **flos**, but its other forms show the stem *flor*-, and Spanish built on the stem, as it did with *nieve*. Feminine, so *la flor*, even though the ending gives you no help at all.

English took the same stem twice. Once through French, as **flower**. And once — this is the surprise — as **flour**. The finest part of ground grain, sifted out from the rest, was called the *flower* of the meal, in the sense of *the best of it*. For centuries English wrote both senses the same way, and only later split the spelling so that a baker and a gardener could stop confusing each other.

Flourish, **floral** and **flora** are the same root again, arriving in more obviously Latin clothes.

What you've built

You now have four ordinary outdoor words, and each one taught a different way a word can travel.

Viento showed a cousin beside a loan. *Nieve* showed a sound change repeating, so you could recognise it rather than memorise it. *Árbol* showed a change that one language made and its neighbour did not. And *flor* shows a single word splitting in two inside English, until the two halves no longer look related.

That is four kinds of movement, and none of them is Spanish being

irregular. It is what happens to any word that stays in use long enough.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la flor*, with a clean *fl*-
- what *flour* originally meant (the flower, the finest part, of the ground grain)
- all four — *el viento*, *la nieve*, *el árbol*, *la flor*

Before you move on

Which Latin stem gave *flor*? (*Flor*-, from *flos*.) Which everyday English word is the same word as *flower*? (*Flour*.) Is *la flor* masculine or feminine? (Feminine, and its ending tells you nothing.)

Chapter 279

Four Things in a Room — Door, Window, Chair, Bed

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the door, the window, the chair and the bed in Spanish, and say which of the four has no settled origin.

Complete ES-C279-cama: name the four things around you, and say which one nobody has managed to trace.

279.1 la puerta — a city gate, shrunk to fit a house

Come indoors. The next four words are things in the room you are probably sitting in, and the first of them started life very much larger.

What to know first

- la casa — the house these things are inside.
- e → ie and o → ue — the two vowels that open under stress.

Sounds you'll need

- *PUER-ta*, stress on the first syllable. The *ue* is one glide, not two separate vowels. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la puerta — “the door.”

Latin **porta**, with the short stressed *o* opening into *ue* — the partner of the change that gave you *viento*. Same event, other vowel.

But *porta* did not mean a door in a house. It meant a **gate**: the opening in a city wall, the thing guarded and shut at night. Spanish took the grand word and let it shrink until it would fit a bedroom. English holds *porta* in several shapes. A **portal** is a doorway that still sounds like a gate. A **porch** came through French from *porticus*, the covered way at the entrance. And one of English’s two **porters** — the one who keeps the door of a college or a hotel — is the gate-keeper of *porta*, while the porter who carries your luggage comes from a different Latin verb entirely. Two unrelated words, spelled identically, sitting in the same hotel lobby.

What you’ve built

Words shrink. A gate in a wall becomes a door in a wall becomes a door in a room, and nothing marks the moment it happened.

This matters for reading older Spanish, where a word you know may still be carrying more weight than it does today. When a text seems to make a small thing sound grand, check whether the word was once grand.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la puerta*, one glide in the middle
- what *porta* meant to a Roman (a city gate)
- which English *porter* belongs here (the one who keeps the door)

Before you move on

Which vowel change turned *porta* into *puerta*? (Stressed *o* opening into *ue*.) What did the Latin word name? (A gate in a city wall.) Which English word keeps that sense most plainly? (*Portal*.)

279.2 la ventana — two languages, one idea, no contact

You met the wind a few lessons ago. It is about to come back indoors, and so is English, by a completely separate road.

What to know first

- el viento — the wind, from Latin *ventus*.
- la puerta — the other opening in the wall.

Sounds you'll need

- *ven-TA-na*, stress in the middle. Three even syllables, no written accent needed because the stress lands where the default puts it.
→ reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la ventana — “the window.”

Take Latin **ventus**, the wind, and add an ending. That is the whole word: a *ventana* is the wind's opening. Notice that the *e* stayed put here — it does not open into *ie*, because in this longer word the stress moved off it and onto the *a*. The change you learned needs a stressed vowel to work on.

Now the good part. English **window** has nothing to do with Latin. It came from Old Norse *vindauga*, which is *vindr* plus *auga*: **wind-eye**. Two languages, no contact between them on this point, both looked at a hole in a wall and named it after the draught coming through.

Latin had its own word, **fenestra**, and Spanish let it go. French and Italian kept it — *fenêtre*, *finestra* — and English borrowed it for one splendid purpose only: **defenestration**, throwing somebody out of a window.

What you've built

Two things worth carrying out of this one.

First, the sound change has a condition attached. *Ventus* gave *viento* when the *e* was stressed and *ventana* when it was not, and the same vowel behaved differently in the same century for that reason alone. Second, unrelated languages reach the same metaphor often enough

that a shared idea is weak evidence of a shared word. *Ventana* and *window* agree on meaning and share no ancestor at all.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la ventana*, stress in the middle
- *el viento*, then *la ventana* — the same Latin word, stressed and unstressed
- what *vindauga* meant, part by part (wind, eye)

Before you move on

Why does *ventana* keep a plain *e* where *viento* has *ie*? (The stress moved off the vowel.) Which Latin word for a window did Spanish drop? (*Fenestra*.) Where does English still keep it? (*Defenestration*.)

279.3 la silla — a word you are sitting on

Two openings in the wall, and now the furniture. This word turns out to be a close relative of several English words you would never have guessed.

What to know first

- *sentarse* — to sit down, the action this object exists for.
- *cl-*, *pl-*, *fl-* → *ll-* — the *ll* sound, and where Spanish gets it.

Sounds you'll need

- *SI-ya* in most of the Spanish-speaking world, *SI-zha* or *SI-sha* around the River Plate. The *ll* is one sound, never two *l* sounds in a row. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la silla — “the chair.”

Latin **sella**, a seat, and behind *sella* the verb **sedere**, to sit. The object is named after the posture, which is so obvious once said that most people never notice it.

Sedere is generous. English **sedentary** is a life spent sitting. A **session** is a sitting, which is why parliaments and courts still have them. A **resident** is somebody sitting back down in a place. The Holy **See** is a seat, from Latin *sedes*, and a bishop’s **cathedral** is named for his *cathedra*, the chair he speaks from.

And **saddle** belongs here too, by the cousin route rather than the loan: it comes down the Germanic line from the same ancient root for sitting, without ever passing through Latin.

What you’ve built

One root, and you can now recognise it in half a dozen English words you already knew separately.

That is what makes etymology worth the time. You are not memorising trivia about *silla*; you are getting a hook that catches *sedentary*, *session*, *resident* and *cathedral* on the way past — and, next time you meet an unfamiliar Spanish word starting *sed-* or *sen-*, a first guess worth testing.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la silla*, with one *ll* sound
- the Latin verb behind it (*sedere*, to sit)
- three English words from that verb

Before you move on

What Latin noun is *silla*? (*Sella*, a seat.) What verb lies behind it? (*Sedere*, to sit.) Is English *saddle* a loan from Latin or a cousin? (A cousin, down the Germanic line.)

279.4 la cama — the second word nobody can explain

You have already met one everyday Spanish word with no agreed origin. Here is the other one, and it is even harder to avoid using.

What to know first

- perro — the dog, and the honest shrug that came with it.
- dormir — to sleep.

Sounds you'll need

- *CA-ma*, two short even syllables, the *c* hard as in *casa*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la cama — “the bed.”

Latin’s word was **lectum**, and Spanish did keep it: *lecho* survives, but it has gone literary, the sort of bed a character dies in. What you actually sleep in is *cama*, and *cama* is not Latin.

The earliest witness is Isidore of Seville, writing in the 600s, who glosses it as a bed low to the ground and treats it as a local word rather than a Latin one. After that the trail forks. One proposal takes it from Greek *khamai*, “on the ground”, which fits Isidore’s own definition suspiciously well. Another puts it in the pre-Roman languages of the peninsula, which are barely recorded and so can neither be confirmed nor ruled out.

What you’ve built

Two of the plainest words in the language — the dog and the bed — have no settled history, and that is not a gap in your notes.

It is worth being clear about why. Both proposals for *cama* predict evidence that would decide the matter, and in both cases the evidence would have had to be written down by people who mostly did not write. The question is open because the record is thin, not because nobody has thought about it.

Meanwhile the word itself is completely secure. You can sleep in a *cama* every night of your life without the etymology ever coming up.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la cama*
- the Latin word Spanish half-kept, and what became of it (*lectum*, now the literary *lecho*)
- the two proposals, and why neither is settled

Before you move on

Is *cama* inherited from Latin? (No.) Who is the earliest witness for it? (Isidore of Seville, in the 600s.) Which other everyday word you have already met has the same unsettled status? (*Perro*.)

Chapter 280

Four Things You Buy — Cheese, Egg, Apple, Money

Modes: 🗣 voice (4) 🗣 Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name cheese, an egg, an apple and money in Spanish, and say which of them is named after a Roman gardener and which after a Roman coin.

Complete ES-C280-dinero: name the four, then say which two carry a proper name and a coin inside them.

280.1 el queso — the same word as cheese, honestly

Four things you might buy. The first of them looks nothing like its English translation, and is nevertheless the identical word.

What to know first

- la comida — food, and the meal.
- el pan — bread, which you already have.

Sounds you'll need

- *KE-so*. The *qu-* before *e* is a plain hard *k*; the *u* is written but never said. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el queso — “the cheese.”

Latin **caseus**. Spanish inherited it and wore it down to *queso*.

Now consider English. **Cheese** is *caseus* as well. Germanic speakers along the Roman frontier took the word — with the thing, which the Romans were better at — some time before the year 500, and it went through the Germanic sound changes until *caseus* had become Old English *cyse*. German did the same and got *Käse*.

So *queso* and *cheese* are one Latin noun that spent fifteen centuries in two different mouths. They no longer share a single sound in the same position, and they are still the same word. **Casein**, the protein, is the modern loan, taken straight from the book and untouched.

What you’ve built

Resemblance is a poor guide to relatedness, in both directions.

Queso and *cheese* look unrelated and are the same word. Meanwhile Spanish is full of words that look reassuringly like an English one and mean something else entirely — you have already met a few of those. Sound alone decides nothing; the history has to be traced.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el queso*, with a silent *u*
- the Latin word behind both languages (*caseus*)
- *el pan y el queso*

Before you move on

Are *queso* and *cheese* related? (They are the same Latin word, *caseus*.) Which one is the loan and which the inheritance? (English borrowed it; Spanish inherited it.) Is the *u* in *queso* pronounced? (No.)

280.2 el huevo — a letter put there for the reader

A short word with a letter in front of it that does nothing at all — and the reason it is there is one of the more human facts in Spanish spelling.

What to know first

- el queso — the cheese, from *caseus*.
- $f \rightarrow h$ — the other place an *h* turns up unpronounced.

Sounds you'll need

- *WE-bo*. The *h* is silent, the *ue* is one glide, and the *v* is that soft lips-barely-touching sound again. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el huevo — “the egg.”

Latin **ovum**, with the stressed *o* opening into *ue* — the change you already know from *puerta*. That gives *uevo*, which is exactly what the word sounds like.

So where did the *h* come from? Not from Latin, and not from the sound. It came from scribes. In medieval handwriting *u* and *v* were the same letter, so a word beginning *ue-* could be read as *ve-* by anyone in a hurry. Putting a silent *h* in front made the following letter unmistakably a vowel. The *h* of *huevo* is a reading aid, frozen into the spelling centuries after the fact.

English took *ovum* straight from Latin and left the sense alone: **oval**, **ovary**, **ovulate**. English **egg** itself is Norse, and it displaced the older native *ey* — one more everyday word the Vikings left behind.

What you've built

Not every letter in a word records a sound. Some record a problem somebody had while reading.

That is a useful thing to hold on to, because it stops silent letters from looking like arbitrary cruelty. *Huevo*, *hueso*, *huerto* — the *h* appears before *ue* right across the language, always for the same reason, and once you know the reason you can predict it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el huevo*, starting on the *w* sound
- the Latin word (*ovum*) and the change that gave *ue*
- why the *h* is written

Before you move on

Does the *h* of *huevo* come from Latin? (No.) What is it doing there? (Marking the *u* as a vowel, for readers of handwriting.) Which Latin word is underneath? (*Ovum*, the source of English *oval*.)

280.3 la manzana — a variety name that ate the fruit

This one is a person's name, worn down for two thousand years until nobody notices the person inside it any more.

What to know first

- María · España · profesor — how Spanish handles proper names.
- el huevo — the egg, and its silent *h*.

Sounds you'll need

- *man-ZA-na*, stress in the middle. The *z* is a soft *th* in most of Spain and an *s* almost everywhere else; both are standard. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la manzana — “the apple.”

Latin's general word for apple was **malum**, and Spanish did not keep it. What it kept was a variety.

Gaius Matius was a Roman of the first century before our era, a friend of Julius Caesar, and a writer on cooking and gardening. A kind of apple carried his name: **mala Mattiana**, the Matian apples. That

phrase wore down — *mattiana* into *manzana* — and along the way the adjective swallowed the noun. The variety name became the word for the fruit, and the man vanished inside it.

English does this too, and recently enough that the joins are still obvious. A **satsuma** is named after a Japanese province, a **greengage** after Sir William Gage, a **boysenberry** after Rudolph Boysen. Give any of them another fifteen centuries of ordinary use and they will look as opaque as *manzana* does.

What you've built

An ordinary word can have a proper name inside it, completely invisible.

This is worth holding because it explains a shape you will keep meeting: a word whose Latin ancestor looks like an adjective rather than a noun. *Mattiana* was an adjective agreeing with *mala*. The noun dropped out, the adjective stayed, and the ending it still carries is the feminine ending it needed in order to agree with a fruit that is no longer in the sentence.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la manzana*, stress in the middle
- whose apples they were (*Matius*)
- *el queso, el huevo, la manzana*

Before you move on

What was *mala Mattiana*? (The apples of Matius, a Roman variety.) Which half of that phrase survived? (The adjective.) What was Latin's ordinary word for an apple? (*Malum* — and Spanish let it go.)

280.4 el dinero — one coin, three survivals

You have just seen a person's name inside a fruit. Here is a coin inside the word for money — and this one left tracks in three

languages.

What to know first

- comprar — to buy, which this word makes possible.
- uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco — counting, for prices.

Sounds you'll need

- *di-NE-ro*, stress in the middle. The *d* between vowels is soft, closer to the *th* of English *the* than to a hard *d*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el dinero — “the money.”

Latin **denarius**, a silver coin. The name means “by tens”: at its introduction it was reckoned as ten of the smaller bronze coins, and the coin kept the arithmetic in its name long after the exchange rate had moved.

That coin outlived its empire three separate times. Spanish turned it into *dinero*, the general word for money — a particular coin generalised into all money, the same move you have just watched a particular apple make. Arabic borrowed it as **dinar**, which is still the name of the currency in several countries. And in Britain the penny was abbreviated **d** — for *denarius* — right up until decimalisation in 1971, so that a price written *3d* was quoting a Roman coin to a shopper who had never heard of one.

What you've built

Twice in two lessons, a specific thing has become a general one: Matius's apples became all apples, and one silver coin became all money.

That widening is one of the commonest ways a word changes meaning, and it is worth watching for, because it runs the other way too. When an old text uses a word you know, ask whether it was still the narrow version. A medieval *dinero* might be an actual coin in somebody's hand rather than money in the abstract.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el dinero*, with a soft *d*
- what *denarius* meant (by tens — ten of the smaller coins)
- the three places the coin survives (*dinero*, *dinar*, British *d*)

Before you move on

Which Roman coin is *dinero*? (The *denarius*.) What did its name count? (Tens.) What did *d* stand for on a British price tag? (*Denarius* — the penny.)

Chapter 281

Four Ordinary Adjectives — New, Old, Clean, Dirty

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say new, old, clean and dirty in Spanish, and say what each of them meant in Latin before it meant what it means now.

Complete ES-C281-sucio: say each adjective with its four endings, and give the Latin sense it started from.

281.1 nuevo — the cousin test, one last time

Four adjectives to finish with, in two pairs. Each of them meant something slightly different in Latin from what it means to you now.

What to know first

- grande — an adjective you already use.
- la puerta — where you first met stressed *o* opening into *ue*.

Sounds you'll need

- *NUE-vo*, stress on the first syllable, the *ue* one glide. Four forms to keep straight: *nuevo*, *nueva*, *nuevos*, *nuevas*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

nuevo — “new.”

Latin **novus**, with the stressed *o* opening into *ue* exactly as it did in *puerta*. Third time you have seen that change, and by now you should be able to run it backwards: give a Spanish *ue*, guess a Latin *o*.

English **new** is the cousin. It comes down the Germanic line from the same ancient root, never passing through Latin — which is why it is short, plain and worn, the way inherited words are.

The loans came later and stayed longer: a **novel** is a new thing, a **novice** is a new arrival, to **renovate** is to make new again, and a **nova** in the sky is a star that was not there last year. Every one of them is *novus*, taken out of a book rather than out of a mouth.

What you’ve built

You now have the cousin-and-loan test in a form you can apply without being told.

Short, irregular, everyday English words are usually the cousins. Long, tidy, bookish ones are usually the loans. *New* against *renovate*; *wind* against *ventilate*. When a Spanish word has two English relatives, the plain one tells you how old the family is and the fancy one tells you the Latin spelling.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *nuevo, nueva, nuevos, nuevas*
- the Latin word, and the change that gave *ue* (*novus*; stressed *o*)
- *una casa nueva*

Before you move on

What Latin adjective is *nuevo*? (*Novus*.) Is English *new* a loan from it? (No — a cousin.) Which English words are the loans? (*Novel*, *novice*, *renovate*, *nova*.)

281.2 viejo — the word Spanish kept was the affectionate one

The opposite of the word you just learned — and Spanish did not inherit the ordinary Latin adjective for it. It inherited a nickname.

What to know first

- nuevo — its opposite, from *novus*.
- trabajar — where you first met the throat sound written *j*.

Sounds you'll need

- *VIE-jo*, stress on the first syllable. The *j* is the same throat sound you have in *trabajo*, not an English *j*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

viejo — “old.”

Latin's plain adjective was **vetus**. Spanish does not descend from it. It descends from **vetulus**, the diminutive — *little old one*, the form you would use warmly about a grandparent or a well-worn coat. Spoken Latin shortened *vetulus* to *veclus*, and *veclus* came out as *viejo*, with the stressed *e* opening into *ie* along the way.

This happened more than once. Late spoken Latin liked diminutives the way a family likes nicknames, and several Spanish words are the affectionate form that outlived the neutral one. The plain *vetus* did not vanish; it went into English instead, as **veteran** — someone grown old in a trade — and as **inveterate**, a habit that has aged into place.

What you've built

Spanish inherited spoken Latin, not written Latin, and the two made different choices.

That is why the dictionary word so often ends up in English while the everyday word ends up in Spanish: the books preserved *vetus*, the streets preserved *vetulus*, and English later raided the books. When a Spanish word and its English relative feel different in tone, this is usually why.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *viejo, vieja, viejos, viejas*
- *nuevo* and *viejo*, one after the other
- which Latin word English kept, and where (*vetus*, in *veteran*)

Before you move on

Which Latin form gave *viejo* — the plain adjective or the diminutive? (The diminutive, *vetulus*.) What did the diminutive add? (Warmth — *little old one*.) Where did plain *vetus* end up? (In English *veteran*.)

281.3 **limpio** — clear water, and what became of it

The last pair. Both of these adjectives started out describing water, and only one of them stayed there.

What to know first

- *el agua* — water, which this word first described.
- *viejo* — the adjective before this one.

Sounds you'll need

- *LIM-pio*, stress on the first syllable, and *-pio* is one syllable, not two. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

limpio — “clean.”

Latin **limpidus**, which meant clear, transparent, see-through. It was said of water and of air, and it was about what you could see through rather than about what had been washed.

English borrowed it and left the meaning exactly where it found it:

limpid is still a word for a clear pool or a clear prose style, and it has

nothing to do with housework. Spanish, using the word every day rather than only in poetry, let it drift the short distance from *clear* to *clean*, and then handed the job of describing water to other words. The verb followed the adjective: *limpiar*, to clean, is built on *limpio* and did not exist in Latin at all.

What you've built

The same Latin word can sit still in one language and move in another, and the one that moved is usually the one that got used more. There is a rough test in that. A word a language uses constantly drifts, narrows and widens; a word it reserves for books stays put. *Limpid* is rare in English and has not changed in centuries. *Limpio* is said a hundred times a day and has already travelled.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *limpio, limpia, limpios, limpias*
- what *limpidus* meant (clear, see-through)
- *el agua limpia*

Before you move on

What did *limpidus* mean in Latin? (Clear, transparent.) Which English word still holds that sense? (*Limpid*.) Which language moved the meaning, and why? (Spanish, because it used the word constantly.)

281.4 sucio — wool straight off the sheep

The opposite of the last word, and its history is far more specific than you would expect from something this ordinary.

What to know first

- *limpio* — its opposite, from *limpidus*.
- *la mano* — a body word, handy for practising this one.

Sounds you'll need

- *SU-cio*, stress on the first syllable. The *c* before *i* is a soft *th* in much of Spain and an *s* elsewhere, like the *z* you met before. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

sucio — “dirty.”

Latin **sucidus**, from **sucus**, juice or sap. *Sucidus* meant juicy, sappy, greasy — and its most ordinary use was for **wool that had not been washed**, still heavy with the natural grease it came off the animal with.

From there the road is short. Ungreased wool is unwashed wool; unwashed becomes unclean; unclean becomes dirty in general, including dirty in the moral sense that *sucio* also carries. The word never described mud. It described a fleece.

English keeps *sucus* in **succulent**, a plant full of juice, and the connection to *suck* is real but ancient — both go back to a root about drawing liquid.

What you've built

That is sixteen plain words, and every one of them turned out to have somewhere it came from.

Look back at what the pair you just finished has in common. *Limpio* began at clear water and moved to clean; *sucio* began at greasy wool and moved to dirty. Neither started life as an opposite of the other. They were pulled into a pair later, by speakers who needed two words and had these two lying about — which is how most of the neat oppositions in any language got built.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *sucio, sucia, sucios, sucias*
- what *sucidus* described (unwashed wool, still greasy)
- *la mano sucia*, then *la mano limpia*

Before you move on

What did *sucidus* mean? (Juicy or greasy — said of unwashed wool.) What is the noun behind it? (*Sucus*, juice.) Were *limpio* and *sucio* ever a pair in Latin? (No — they were made into one later.)

Chapter 282

Meeting Someone — Welcome, Greeting, Hug, Smile, Guest

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can welcome someone in Spanish and name the greeting, the hug, the smile and the guest that go with it.

Complete ES-C282-invitado: say all five words in order, and say which two of them are participles.

282.1 bienvenido — well come, in two words you already have

What did *sucidus* describe before it meant dirty? (Unwashed wool, still greasy.) Now a word with nothing new in it but the joining.

What to know first

- bien — well, and the first half of this word.
- hola — the greeting you have opened with since the start.

Sounds you'll need

- *bien-ve-NI-do*, stress on the *ni*. The *v* is the same soft sound you give *b* — two letters, one sound. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

bienvenido — “welcome.”

Two pieces, both of them plain. **bien**, well, which you have; and **venido**, come, the participle of *venir*. Latin put it the same way round: *bene venutus*, well come.

English **welcome** looks like the identical build and is not one. Old English had **wilcuma**, from *willa*, desire, and *cuma*, a comer: the person you wanted to arrive. Norse and French pressure then bent *wil-* into *wel-*, and the word ended up resembling “well” plus “come” by accident.

So two languages reached the same shape from opposite directions. Spanish means it literally. English only appears to.

What you’ve built

Nothing here was new except the joining.

Bien you had already, and *venido* has *venir* audible inside it. A compound you can take apart is a word you do not have to memorise — and Spanish builds a great many of its politest words this way.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *bienvenido*, then *bienvenida*
- the two pieces on their own — *bien*, *venido*
- *hola*, then *bienvenido*, as you would at a door

Before you move on

What are the two pieces of *bienvenido*? (*Bien* and *venido*.) Is English *welcome* built the same way? (No — it was *wilcuma*, a desired comer.)

282.2 el saludo — a wish for your health, worn smooth

Before the new one: what are the two pieces of *bienvenido*? (*Bien* and *venido*.)

What to know first

- *bienvenido* — what you say; this is what you are doing.
- *hola* — one particular instance of it.

Sounds you'll need

- *sa-LU-do*, stress on the *lu*. The *d* between two vowels is soft, closer to the *th* of English *this* than to a hard *d*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el saludo — “a greeting.”

From **saludar**, to greet, and behind that Latin **salutem**, health — the accusative of *salus*, soundness and safety. To greet a Roman was to wish him his health, and Spanish still raises a glass with *salud* and answers a sneeze with it.

English took the same Latin word more than once. **Salute** is the soldier's version, borrowed whole. **Salutary** and **salubrious** kept the health and dropped the greeting altogether.

So a *saludo* is not really a word. It is a wish, repeated until nobody hears it any more — which is what centuries do to every polite formula, in every language.

What you've built

You have been greeting people since your first lesson without a name for the act.

This is the name. Having one lets you talk about the thing rather than only do it — and that is a step up in what you can say.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el saludo*
- *un saludo*, then *el saludo*
- *bienvenido* and then *el saludo* — the word, then the act

Before you move on

What is behind *saludo*? (*Salutem*, health.) Which English word is the soldier's version of it? (*Salute*.)

282.3 el abrazo — the arm is still inside the word

Before the new one: what did *saludo* wish you? (Your health.)

What to know first

- la mano — a part of the body you already have.
- el saludo — the greeting this one belongs to.

Sounds you'll need

- *a-BRA-zo*, stress in the middle. The *r* is a single tap, and the *z* is the *th* of *think* in much of Spain and an *s* elsewhere. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el abrazo — “a hug.”

From **abrazar**, and inside it Latin **bracchium**, the arm:

ad-bracchiare, to put your arms around. The word says exactly what the body does, and Spanish never hid it — *brazo* is still the word for the arm itself.

English **embrace** is the same build through French, *in* plus *bracchium*. A **bracelet** is a little arm-band. A **brace** holds a thing the way an arm holds it.

Latin took *bracchium* from Greek *brakhion*, which meant the shorter upper arm — from *brakhys*, short, the same *brachy-* that turns up in a scientist's vocabulary. The hug goes back to a word for shortness.

What you've built

Three words now, and each of them is something you could point at. A welcome, a greeting, an embrace. None of the three needed grammar to be useful — which is worth remembering when a language starts to feel like rules.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el abrazo*
- *un abrazo*, which is how a letter ends
- *el saludo* and *el abrazo* one after the other

Before you move on

What is inside *abrazo*? (*Bracchium*, the arm.) Which English word is the same build? (*Embrace*.)

282.4 la sonrisa — a laugh with the volume down

Before the new one: what is inside *abrazo*? (*Bracchium*, the arm.)

What to know first

- *el abrazo* — the last one, and another thing a face or a body does.
- *bien* — well, which you have had since the beginning.

Sounds you'll need

- *son-RI-sa*, stress on the *ri*. The *s* is clear and never buzzes into a *z* sound the way an English *s* between vowels does. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la sonrisa — “a smile.”

From **sonreír**, and that is Latin **subridere**: *sub-*, under or slightly, plus **ridere**, to laugh. A smile is a laugh with the volume turned down. The *sub-* wore to *son-* on the way in.

English keeps *ridere* only at the loud end, and only in loans: to **deride** is to laugh at, **ridicule** is the laughing itself, and something **risible** is worth a laugh.

So Spanish built its quiet word out of the noisy one by putting *sub-* in front. English never built it at all — *smile* is Germanic and has no Latin in it.

What you've built

Sub- is a dial, not a word.

Under, slightly, a little less than the whole thing. Once you can hear it, a long Latin word stops being one item to memorise and becomes two smaller ones you can already handle.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la sonrisa*
- *una sonrisa*, then *la sonrisa*
- *el abrazo* and *la sonrisa*, one after the other

Before you move on

What does *sub-* do to *ridere*? (Turns the laugh down to a smile.)
Which English words kept the laughing? (*Deride*, *ridicule*, *risible*.)

282.5 el invitado — named by what was done to him

Before the last of the five: what does *sub-* do to *ridere*? (Turns the laugh down to a smile.) And what is inside *abrazo*? (The arm.)

What to know first

- *el abrazo* — what you might give this person.
- *la sonrisa* — and what you would give with it.

Sounds you'll need

- *in-vi-TA-do*, stress on the *ta*. Four syllables, all of them short and even; Spanish does not swallow the unstressed ones the way English does. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el invitado — “a guest.”

From **invitar**, Latin **invitare**, to invite. *Invitado* is its participle, “invited” — so Spanish names the guest by what was done to him, exactly as *bienvenido* names a welcome by what is wished.

Put the two side by side. **venido** in the first of these five and **invitado** in the last are the same piece of grammar doing the same job: an action turned into a description of a person.

English **guest** is a different word altogether, Germanic *gastiz* — which is also the source of Latin *hostis*, a stranger and then an enemy. Two peoples had one word for the man at the door and could not agree whether he was a visitor or a threat.

What you’ve built

Five, and the run is closed: *bienvenido, el saludo, el abrazo, la sonrisa, el invitado*.

Two of the five are participles, and that is the pattern worth carrying forward. Spanish is unusually willing to name a person or a thing by an action already finished — the one invited, the one welcomed — and once you notice it you will find it everywhere.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el invitado*, then *la invitada*
- all five in order — *bienvenido, el saludo, el abrazo, la sonrisa, el invitado*
- the two participles on their own — *bienvenido, invitado*

Before you move on

What is an *invitado*, literally? (One who has been invited.) Which other word in this run is a participle? (*Bienvenido* — well come.) And what did *saludo* wish you? (Your health.)

Chapter 283

Courtesy Past Thank You — Excuse Me, With Permission, Kind, A Thousand Thanks

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can apologise, ask to pass, call someone kind and thank them at more than one weight in Spanish.

Complete ES-C283-no-hay-de-que: say all five, and take the last one apart into the words you already had.

283.1 disculpe — take the fault off me

Before a new run: what is an *invitado*? (One who has been invited.) And what was *la sonrisa* built from? (*Ridere*, to laugh, turned down by *sub*-.)

What to know first

- perdón — the apology you already have.
- por favor — the politeness you already have.

Sounds you'll need

- *dis-CUL-pe*, stress in the middle. The *c* before *u* is a hard *k*, as in *casa*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

disculpe — “excuse me.”

From **disculpar**: *dis-*, which undoes, plus **culpa**, fault. To *disculpar* is to take the fault off someone. Said to a person — *disculpe* — it asks them to un-fault you.

Latin *culpa* stands intact in English **culpable** and in **mea culpa**, my fault, and worn down in **culprit**. The *dis-* is the reversing prefix of *disappear* and *disarm*: it does not merely deny a thing, it undoes it.

Disculpe is the *usted* form, so it is the one for a stranger. To a friend you would say *disculpa* — the same choice you have been making since you met *tú* and *usted*.

What you’ve built

You now have two apologies, and they are not the same size.

Perdón asks for pardon, which is a thing granted. *Disculpe* asks for the fault to be lifted, which is a thing undone. Spanish gives you both, and a language with two words for one moment is telling you the moment has two parts.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *disculpe*
- *disculpe*, then *disculpa*, and hear which is the stranger’s
- *perdón*, then *disculpe*

Before you move on

What is inside *disculpe*? (*Culpa*, fault.) What does the *dis-* do? (Undoes it.) Which form would you use with a stranger? (*Disculpe*.)

283.2 con permiso — the one you say before, not after

Before the new one: what does the *dis-* do to *culpa*? (Undoes it.)

What to know first

- *disculpe* — the other “excuse me”, for something done.
- *por favor* — the politeness you attach to a request.

Sounds you’ll need

- *con per-MI-so*, stress on the *mi*. The *r* is one tap of the tongue, not the long English glide. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

con permiso — “excuse me,” said as you pass in front of someone.

Permiso is Latin **permissum**, from *permittere*: *per-*, through, plus *mittere*, to send. To permit is to let a thing through.

Mittere was one of the most productive words Latin had, and English is full of it. A **mission** is a sending. A **missile** is a thing sent. To **dismiss** is to send away, and to **permit** is this very word, borrowed unchanged.

The two courtesies are not interchangeable, and the difference is time.

Disculpe is for something you have done. *Con permiso* is for something you are about to do.

What you’ve built

Politeness in Spanish is often a matter of tense rather than of warmth. One formula looks backwards at a fault, the other forwards at an intrusion. Get the direction right and you will sound careful even when your grammar is not.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *con permiso*
- *disculpe*, then *con permiso*, and place each one in time
- *con permiso*, *por favor*

Before you move on

What are the two pieces of *permiso*? (*Per*, through, and *mittere*, to send.) Which courtesy comes before the act? (*Con permiso*.)

283.3 amable — loveable, before it meant kind

Before the new one: which courtesy comes before the act? (*Con permiso*.)

What to know first

- *gracias* — what you say to someone who is this.
- *disculpe* — and what you say when you are not.

Sounds you'll need

- *a-MA-ble*, stress in the middle. The *b* between vowels is soft — the lips barely close. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

amable — “kind.”

Latin **amabilis**, from **amare**, to love: loveable, a person it is easy to be fond of. Spanish moved the word from what you feel about the person to what the person does.

English has it twice over. **Amiable** came through French and kept the sense. **Amorous** kept the love, and an **amateur** is one who does a thing for love rather than for money — which is praise in the original and faint praise now.

The **-able** on the end is the same ending English writes on its own words. It arrived from the same Latin *-abilis*, and it means then what it means now: able to have this done to it.

What you've built

Muy amable is the reply you have been missing.

You could thank someone; you could not say anything about them. One adjective closes that gap, and it costs you nothing new — *muy* has been yours for a long while.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *amable*, then *muy amable*
- *gracias*, *muy amable*
- *amable* and *amiable*, and hear the same word twice

Before you move on

What did *amabilis* mean in Latin? (Loveable.) Which Latin root is under it? (*Amare*, to love.)

283.4 mil gracias — a number that stopped counting

Before the new one: what did *amabilis* mean? (Loveable.)

What to know first

- *gracias* — the half of this you already have.
- *amable* — what you say about the person you are thanking.

Sounds you'll need

- *mil GRA-cias*. The *l* stays clear and forward, never darkening the way an English *l* does at the end of a word. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

mil gracias — “a thousand thanks.”

Gracias has been yours since near the beginning. **Mil** is Latin **mille**, a thousand, and it is the same *mille* buried in English **mile**: the Roman **mille passuum**, a thousand paces, which is why a mile is the awkward length it is and not a round number of anything.

Notice what the phrase is doing. Spanish is not measuring gratitude here; it is reaching for a large number and stopping. Every language keeps a few numbers that have given up counting — English says thanks a million and means the same nothing-in-particular.

Millimetre, million and millennium are the honest arithmetic uses of *mille*, and they arrived from the book rather than from the mouth.

What you've built

Four courtesies, and not one of them is a new idea. Each is a word you had, or a number you had, put to a use you did not know about. Vocabulary grows fastest at the joins.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *mil gracias*
- *gracias*, then *mil gracias*, and hear the weight change
- *mil gracias, muy amable*

Before you move on

What is *mil* in Latin? (*Mille*, a thousand.) What has a mile got to do with it? (It was a thousand paces.)

283.5 no hay de qué — four words you already own

Before the last of the five: what is *mil* in Latin? (*Mille*, a thousand.) And what did *amabilis* mean? (Loveable.)

What to know first

- *de nada* — the other reply to thanks, and the same idea.
- *mil gracias* — what this answers.

Sounds you'll need

- *no ay de KE*, four quick syllables run together. The written accent on *qué* marks the question word, not a change of stress.
→ reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

no hay de qué — “not at all,” the reply when someone thanks you. Every piece is already yours. **No, hay, de, qué** — nothing new in the list. What is new is the assembly: literally “there is nothing of which,” with the thing not worth mentioning left out of the sentence entirely. Spanish already gave you **de nada**, “of nothing,” for the same moment. The two are one idea built twice: whatever you are thanking me for, there was nothing in it. That is worth more than a fifth word. A courtesy formula is rarely new vocabulary. It is old vocabulary frozen in an order nobody parses any more — and once you have taken one apart, the rest stop being phrases to memorise.

What you’ve built

Five ways to be polite: *disculpe, con permiso, amable, mil gracias, no hay de qué*.

Two of them look backwards and two look forwards; the fifth is made of scraps. And the fifth is the one that shows you what the others are — sentences that stopped being sentences.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *no hay de qué*
- its four pieces slowly — *no, hay, de, qué*
- all five in order — *disculpe, con permiso, amable, mil gracias, no hay de qué*

Before you move on

How many new words are in *no hay de qué*? (None — only the assembly is new.) Which reply to thanks did you already have? (*De nada*.) And what is inside *disculpe*? (*Culpa*, fault.)

Chapter 284

Five Short Answers — Agreed, Sure, True, Exactly, Of Course

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can answer someone in Spanish with a single short phrase, and say what is inside each one.

Complete ES-C284-por-supuesto: give all five answers in order, and name the Latin verb inside each.

284.1 de acuerdo — hearts brought together

Before a new run: how many new words were in *no hay de qué?* (None.) And what does *mil* mean? (A thousand.)

What to know first

- sí — the shortest answer of all, which you have.
- no hay de qué — another formula assembled from small pieces.

Sounds you'll need

- *de a-CUER-do*, stress on the *cuer*. The *ue* is one glide, not two vowels taken in turn. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

de acuerdo — “agreed.”

From **acordar**, and inside it Latin **cor**, **cordis**, the heart. To *acordar* is to bring hearts together.

English has the whole family and rarely notices the organ in it. An **accord** is this word. **Concord** is hearts together and **discord** hearts apart. To **record** is to bring back to the heart — because the Romans located memory there, so recording was memorising long before it was writing anything down. Even **courage** is *cor* with a French ending on it.

The stressed *o* of *cordis* opens into *ue*, the change you have watched happen again and again: *cor* to *cuerdo*, as *portam* went to *puerta*.

What you’ve built

You can now agree without saying *sí*.

That matters more than it sounds. *Sí* answers a question; *de acuerdo* accepts a proposal. Conversations run on the second one far more than on the first.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *de acuerdo*
- *sí*, then *de acuerdo*, and hear the difference in what each answers
- *de acuerdo, gracias*

Before you move on

What is inside *acuerdo*? (*Cor*, the heart.) Why does *record* belong to it? (To bring back to the heart — where memory was thought to sit.)

284.2 seguro — without a care, which came to mean reliable

Before the new one: what is inside *acuerdo*? (*Cor*, the heart.)

What to know first

- *de acuerdo* — the answer before this one.
- *bien* — another one-word answer you already give.

Sounds you'll need

- *se-GU-ro*, stress in the middle. The *gu* before *r* is a hard *g*; the *u* here is fully pronounced. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

seguro — “sure,” and also “safe.”

Latin **securus**: *se-*, without, plus **cura**, care. Free of care. The Romans meant untroubled; Spanish and English both dragged it towards reliable, which is a different thing.

English took it twice, and the two arrivals do not look alike. **Secure** came late and whole, out of a book. **Sure** came early through French, worn down to one syllable, having lost the *c* on the road. The same Latin word walked in through two doors.

Cura itself is in English **cure**, **curator** and **curious** — all of them about taking care of something, or taking rather too much.

What you've built

Se- is another dial worth keeping.

It means without or apart, and it is doing the same job in *seguro* that *sub-* did in *sonrisa*: a small piece in front changing the whole. You are collecting prefixes now, not only words.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *seguro*
- *seguro* and *secure*, and hear one word twice
- *de acuerdo*, then *seguro*

Before you move on

What are the two pieces of *securus*? (*Se-*, without, and *cura*, care.)
Which English word is the worn-down one? (*Sure*.)

284.3 *cierto* — what has been sifted out

Before the new one: what are the two pieces of *securus*? (*Se-*, without, and *cura*, care.)

What to know first

- *seguro* — the answer before this one, and a near neighbour in meaning.
- *la puerta* — where you first watched a stressed *o* open into *ue*.

Sounds you'll need

- *CIER-to*, stress on the first syllable. The *c* before *i* is the *th* of *think* in much of Spain and an *s* elsewhere. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

cierto — “true,” “certain.”

Latin **certus**, and it is a participle: from **cernere**, to sift, to separate, to decide. What is *certus* is what has been sifted out from everything it was mixed up with.

The English family is large and the sieve is invisible in all of it.

Certain is this word. To **discern** is to sift apart. To be **concerned** is to be sifted together with something. And a **secret** is *se-cernere*, a thing sifted aside — the same *se-* you met in *seguro*, one word ago.

The stressed *e* opens into *ie* here, as it did in *puerta* with an *o*: *certus* to *cierto*. Two vowels, one habit.

What you've built

Certainty is a metaphor, and a physical one.

Sifting, separating, deciding: the Romans had one word for all three, and every English word about being sure still has grain and a sieve at the bottom of it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *cierto*
- *es cierto*
- *seguro*, then *cierto*, and hear which agrees with a person and which with a fact

Before you move on

What did *cernere* mean? (To sift.) What is a *secret*, taken apart? (Something sifted aside.)

284.4 exacto — driven out, then weighed out

Before the new one: what did *cernere* mean? (To sift.)

What to know first

- *cierto* — the answer before this one.
- *sí* — the plain agreement these are all sharpening.

Sounds you'll need

- *e-XAC-to*, stress in the middle. The *x* here is *ks*, said fully: *ek-SAK-to*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

exacto — “exactly,” used on its own as an answer.

Latin **exactus**, the participle of **exigere**: *ex-*, out, plus **agere**, to drive. To drive out; then to demand; then to weigh out precisely, because a Roman checking a coin was driving the true amount out of the metal.

Agere is everywhere in English: an **act**, an **agent**, an **agenda** — things to be driven along. **Exigent** kept the demanding sense unchanged.

As an answer, *exacto* is the one that agrees with a detail rather than with a person. Somebody has got a number or a name right, and you

are confirming the number, not backing the speaker.

What you've built

Four answers, and each agrees with something different. *De acuerdo* accepts a plan, *seguro* backs a person, *cierto* confirms a fact, *exacto* confirms a detail. English leans on one word for all four and lets the tone carry it; Spanish would rather you chose.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *exacto*
- *cierto*, then *exacto*
- the four in order — *de acuerdo*, *seguro*, *cierto*, *exacto*

Before you move on

What are the pieces of *exigere*? (*Ex*-, out, and *agere*, to drive.)
What does *exacto* agree with? (A detail, not a person.)

284.5 por supuesto — it was under the conversation already

Before the last of the five: what does *exacto* agree with? (A detail.) And what did *cernere* mean? (To sift.)

What to know first

- *exacto* — the answer before this one.
- *la sonrisa* — where you first met *sub*- doing its work.

Sounds you'll need

- *por su-PUES-to*, stress on the *pues*. Another *ue* glide, and the *s* stays clear throughout. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

por supuesto — “of course.”

Supuesto is the participle of **suponer**, Latin **supponere**: *sub-*, under, plus **ponere**, to place. Something *supuesto* has been placed underneath — assumed, taken as given, sitting under the conversation without ever being said out loud.

English **suppose**, **supposition** and **presuppose** are that same placing. And English’s own “of course” is doing something similar with a different picture: the thing runs along the expected course, so nobody had to steer it.

There is *sub-* again, and you met it turning a laugh into a smile. Prefixes are worth more than words. One of them unlocks dozens.

What you’ve built

Five answers: *de acuerdo*, *seguro*, *cierto*, *exacto*, *por supuesto*.

Three of the five are participles — *acuerdo* aside, they name a state something has been put into. Spanish keeps reaching for the finished action when it wants a short answer, and now you have five examples instead of one.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *por supuesto*
- *sub-* and *supuesto*, and hear the prefix
- all five in order — *de acuerdo*, *seguro*, *cierto*, *exacto*, *por supuesto*

Before you move on

What are the pieces of *supponere*? (*Sub-*, under, and *ponere*, to place.) Where did you meet *sub-* before? (Inside *sonrisa*, turning a laugh down.) And what is inside *acuerdo*? (*Cor*, the heart.)

Chapter 285

Who Someone Is — Neighbour, Friend, Teacher, Nurse, Cook

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say who someone is in Spanish — the neighbour, a friend, the teacher, the nurse, the cook.

Complete ES-C285-cocinero: name all five people, and say what each name is really describing.

285.1 el vecino — the man from your own street

Before a new run: what does *por supuesto* say has happened to the thing? (It was placed underneath — assumed.) And what is inside *acuerdo*? (The heart.)

What to know first

- la casa — the house this person lives near.
- hola — what you say to him over the fence.

Sounds you'll need

- *ve-CI-no*, stress in the middle. The *c* before *i* is the *th* of *think* in much of Spain and an *s* elsewhere. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el vecino — “the neighbour.”

Latin **vicinus**, from **vicus**: a village, a row of houses, a block of a town. A *vicinus* is a person off your own street, and the word names the street rather than the person.

English has the abstract end of it. **Vicinity** is nearness — the quality of sharing a *vicus*. And *vicus* itself was borrowed into Old English early as *wic*, a settlement, which is the *-wich* still sitting on the end of Norwich and Ipswich.

English **neighbour** describes the same man quite differently: *neah*, near, plus *gebur*, a dweller. A near-dweller. Two languages, one person, and two pictures — a street against a distance.

What you’ve built

Every name for a person is a description that stopped being one. Hold on to that for the next four. None of them will name the human being directly; each names a place, a feeling, a comparison or an act, and lets the ending turn it into somebody.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el vecino*, then *la vecina*
- *mi vecino*
- *el vecino* and *la casa*, and hear the street inside the first

Before you move on

What is a *vicus*? (A village or a row of houses.) What does English *neighbour* describe instead? (A near-dweller — distance, not a street.)

285.2 la amiga — the same root as amable, a short way back

Before the new one: what does *vecino* actually name? (The street, not the man.)

What to know first

- amable — the same Latin root, met a short while ago.
- el vecino — the person before this one.

Sounds you'll need

- *la a-MI-ga*, stress on the *mi*. The two *a* sounds at the join run together in ordinary speech. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la amiga — “a friend,” of a woman.

Latin **amica**, and underneath it is **amare**, to love — the very *amare* that gave you *amable* not long ago. Latin made the kind person and the friend out of one root, and Spanish inherited both without noticing the family resemblance.

English **amicable** is *amicabilis*, friend-like, and an **amicus curiae** in a courtroom is a friend of the court. But English **friend** is Germanic, from a word for loving that has otherwise disappeared — so both languages built the friend out of a love word, and then lost the source in one case and kept it in the other.

Note the article: *la amiga*, and not the *el* that *agua* takes. That swap needs the stress on the first *a*, and here it falls on the *i*.

What you've built

A root you have already spent is cheaper than a new one.

Amable and *amiga* cost you one Latin root between them. When two words share a root, learning the second is mostly remembering the first.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la amiga*, then *el amigo*
- *amable* and *amiga*, and hear *amare* in both
- *mi amiga*

Before you move on

Which root is under *amiga*? (*Amare*, to love.) Which other word of yours is built on it? (*Amable*.)

285.3 el maestro — the one who is more

Before the new one: which root is under *amiga*? (*Amare*, to love.)

What to know first

- el estudiante — the person this one stands in front of.
- la amiga — the person before this one.

Sounds you'll need

- *ma-ES-tro*, stress on the *es*. The *a* and the *e* stay separate — three syllables, not two. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el maestro — “the teacher.”

Latin **magister**, built on **magis**, more. Beside it Latin kept **minister**, built on **minus**, less. The two were made as a matched pair: the one who is more and the one who is less, a master and a servant.

Both reached English and drifted so far apart that the pairing is invisible. On one side a **master**, a **mister** (the same word worn down), a **magistrate** and a **magnate**. On the other a **minister** and to **administer** — which is to serve towards something.

Spanish kept *maestro* for the schoolteacher and has *profesor* as well, which you already have. The two are not rivals: one teaches children and the other teaches a subject.

What you've built

A comparison can harden into a job.

Magis and *minus* are not people; they are more and less. Latin turned both into titles, and two thousand years later one of them signs your school report and the other runs a government.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el maestro*, then *la maestra*
- *maestro* and *master*, and hear the *magis* in both
- *el maestro* and *el estudiante* together

Before you move on

What is *magis*? (More.) What was *minister* built on? (*Minus*, less.)

285.4 la enfermera — named after the patient

Before the new one: what is *magis*? (More.)

What to know first

- *el maestro* — the person before this one.
- *la cabeza* — a body word, useful when you say what is wrong.

Sounds you'll need

- *en-fer-ME-ra*, stress on the *me*. Both *r* sounds are single taps, neither rolled. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la enfermera — “the nurse.”

From **enfermo**, ill, and that is Latin **infirmus**: *in-*, not, plus **firmus**, firm. The ill person is the one who is no longer steady on his feet. And the nurse is named after the patient rather than after the work.

English kept *infirmus* twice over — **infirm** for the person, an **infirmary** for the room they are put in. **Firm** itself is the same *firmus*, and to **confirm** is to make a thing firm along with somebody else.

English **nurse** went the other way entirely. It is *nutrire*, to feed: the wet-nurse came first and the hospital a long time afterwards. One language named the helper after the illness, the other after the milk.

What you've built

Four people, and four different things being described.

A street, a word for loving, a comparison, and a condition. Not one of the four names a human being outright — and that is the ordinary state of affairs in every language, once you start pulling the words open.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la enfermera*, then *el enfermero*
- *enfermo* and *enfermera*, and hear the patient inside the nurse
- *la enfermera* and *el maestro*

Before you move on

What are the pieces of *infirmus*? (*In-*, not, and *firmus*, firm.) Who is the nurse named after? (The patient.)

285.5 el cocinero — the root that got everywhere

Before the last of the five: who is the nurse named after? (The patient.) And what is *magis*? (More.)

What to know first

- *la comida* — what this person makes.
- *la enfermera* — the person before this one.

Sounds you'll need

- *co-ci-NE-ro*, stress on the *ne*. The first *c* is a hard *k* and the second, before *i*, is soft. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el cocinero — “the cook.”

From **la cocina**, the kitchen — Latin **coquina** — and under that **coquere**, to cook.

This root travelled further than any other in the run. English **kitchen** is *coquina*, borrowed into Germanic early and worn right down. A **biscuit** is *bis-coctus*, twice-cooked. To **concoct** is to cook things together. And a **precocious** child is *prae-coquus*, cooked early — a word used first of fruit that ripened before its season, and moved onto children only much later.

So the same Latin root gave English a room, a snack, a metaphor for scheming and a word for a clever eight-year-old, and gave Spanish the person who does the cooking.

What you’ve built

Five people: *el vecino*, *la amiga*, *el maestro*, *la enfermera*, *el cocinero*. Set the five descriptions side by side. *Vecino* is a place. *Amiga* is a feeling. *Maestro* is a comparison. *Enfermera* is a condition. *Cocinero* is an action. Five ways of pointing at a person without ever saying what a person is.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el cocinero*, then *la cocinera*
- *la cocina* and *el cocinero*, the room and the person
- all five in order — *el vecino*, *la amiga*, *el maestro*, *la enfermera*, *el cocinero*

Before you move on

What is a *biscuit*, taken apart? (Twice-cooked.) What does *precocious* literally mean? (Cooked early.) And who is the *enfermera* named after? (The patient.)

Chapter 286

Where It Hurts — Eye, Mouth, Throat, Pain, Fever

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the eye, the mouth and the throat in Spanish, and say that there is a pain or a fever.

Complete ES-C286-fiebre: name all five, and separate the three places from the two things that are wrong.

286.1 el ojo — the same eye as English, from far enough back

Before a new run: what does *precocious* literally mean? (Cooked early.) And who is the *enfermera* named after? (The patient.)

What to know first

- la cabeza — where this one is.
- la mano — the other body word you have.

Sounds you'll need

- *O-jo*, stress on the first syllable. The *j* is a hard rasp at the back of the mouth, the *jota*, with no English equivalent. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el ojo — “the eye.”

Latin **oculus**, and the road from *oculus* to *ojo* runs through a change Spanish made and its neighbours made differently: the *cl* left in *oc’lu*, once the unstressed vowel dropped, hardened into the *jota* you are now saying — a sound Latin never had at all.

English has the loans, and they are unmistakable: **ocular**, **binocular**, a **monocle**, and to **inoculate**, which was a gardener’s word first, for setting an eye — a bud — into another plant.

And English **eye** is the cousin, not a borrowing. *Oculus* and *eye* come down from one ancient root by two different roads, one through Latin and one through Germanic, which is why they share almost no letters and mean precisely the same thing.

What you’ve built

The *jota* is a Spanish invention.

It is not in Latin, and it is not in Italian or French, which had the same material to work with. When a word has one, you are hearing something that happened in Spain and nowhere else.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el ojo*, then *los ojos*
- *oculus* and *ojo*, slowly, and hear the *cl* harden
- *la cabeza* and *el ojo*

Before you move on

What is the Latin behind *ojo*? (*Oculus*.) Is English *eye* borrowed from it? (No — it is the cousin, down the Germanic road.)

286.2 la boca — the cheek that took the mouth’s job

Before the new one: is English *eye* borrowed from *oculus*? (No — it is the cousin.)

What to know first

- *el ojo* — the last one, and its neighbour on the face.
- *la cabeza* — which Spanish did not replace, unlike this one.

Sounds you'll need

- *BO-ca*, stress on the first syllable. The *c* before *a* is a hard *k*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la boca — “the mouth.”

Latin had **os**, **oris** for the mouth, and that is the word English borrowed for **oral** and **orifice**. Spanish does not use it. Spanish uses **bucca**, which in Latin meant the cheek — specifically a cheek puffed out, the one a trumpeter uses.

So the lively word from the street pushed the official one out of the job. That is a swap Spanish declined to make for the head, where *cabeza* is still *caput* plain and simple, and made without hesitation for the mouth. Which words get replaced is not predictable; it only ever looks obvious afterwards.

English kept both ends of the Latin. **Buccal** is the medical adjective for the cheek. To **debouch** is to come out of a mouth — said of rivers, and of armies leaving a narrow pass.

What you've built

Two body words, and two completely different histories.

Ojo is the inherited word doing the job it always did. *Boca* is an upstart that took the job from another word. Both are ordinary, and only one of them is quiet about where it came from.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la boca*
- *el ojo* and *la boca*
- *oris* and *bucca*, the word that lost and the word that won

Before you move on

What did *bucca* mean in Latin? (The cheek.) Which Latin word did it push out? (*Os, oris* — which English kept in *oral*.)

286.3 la garganta — a word made out of a noise

Before the new one: what did *bucca* mean in Latin? (The cheek.)

What to know first

- la boca — the opening this one sits behind.
- el agua — what goes down it.

Sounds you'll need

- *gar-GAN-ta*, stress in the middle. Both *g* sounds are hard, and both *r* sounds are single taps. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la garganta — “the throat.”

This one is not inherited from a tidy Latin word so much as assembled out of a noise. Latin had **gurgulio** for the windpipe and **gargarizare** for gargling, and both are the sound itself, said twice: *gar-gar*.

English does the same imitation over and over. To **gargle**. To **gurgle**. To **regurgitate**. A **gorge**, which is a throat first and a narrow valley second, because a valley of that shape looks like one.

Words like this are worth noticing because they escape the usual account. Almost all of your vocabulary is either inherited or borrowed. A few words are simply what the thing sounds like — and those can turn up in unrelated languages with no contact between them whatsoever.

What you've built

Three places on the body, and now you can say where.

El ojo, la boca, la garganta. What is still missing is the other half of the sentence: what is actually wrong. That is the next two.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la garganta*
- *gar-gar*, then *garganta*, and hear where the word came from
- *el ojo, la boca, la garganta*

Before you move on

Where does *garganta* come from? (The noise of gargling.) Which English words are the same imitation? (*Gargle, gurgle, gorge.*)

286.4 el dolor — and the word that stopped hurting

Before the new one: where does *garganta* come from? (The noise of gargling.)

What to know first

- *la garganta* — one of the places this can be.
- *¿cómo está usted?* — the question this answers.

Sounds you'll need

- *do-LOR*, stress on the second syllable, as the lack of a written accent tells you for a word ending in *r*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el dolor — “the pain.”

Latin **dolor**, arriving with almost nothing worn off it, from **dolere**, to hurt. This is the word that turns a body part into a complaint: a pain of the head, a pain of the throat.

English has it in the mournful register only: **doleful**, **dolorous**, and **condolence** — to hurt together with somebody.

And **indolent**, which is the surprise of the family. *In-dolens* is feeling no pain, and it began as a medical word: an indolent sore is one that

does not hurt. From there it slid to feeling no effort, and finally to lazy. The pain fell out of the word altogether.

What you've built

You can now answer with more than *bien* or *regular*.
A place and a trouble is a whole sentence in any language. You have three places and, from here, two troubles.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el dolor*
- *dolor de cabeza*
- *dolor de garganta*

Before you move on

What does *dolere* mean? (To hurt.) What did *indolent* mean first? (Feeling no pain.)

286.5 la fiebre — one Latin word, borrowed twice, centuries apart

Before the last of the five: what does *dolere* mean? (To hurt.)
And where does *garganta* come from? (The noise of gargling.)

What to know first

- *el dolor* — the other thing that can be wrong.
- *cierto* — where you last watched a stressed *e* open into *ie*.

Sounds you'll need

- *FIE-bre*, stress on the first syllable. The *ie* is one glide, and the *b* between vowels is soft. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la fiebre — “the fever.”

Latin **febris**, with the stressed *e* opening into *ie* once again — *febris* to *fiebre*, the change you have now watched in *cierto* and in *puerta*, and can predict without being told.

English **fever** is that same *febris*, borrowed into Old English long before the Normans arrived, at a time when a Latin medical word was worth having and an English one did not exist. Then the doctors borrowed it a second time, unworn, as **febrile**.

Two borrowings of one word, a thousand years apart: the early one goes to the sickroom and the late one to the textbook. That split is so regular in English that you can often date a word by how ordinary it sounds.

What you’ve built

Five: *el ojo*, *la boca*, *la garganta*, *el dolor*, *la fiebre*.

Three of them are places and two are troubles, and the two halves fit together. *Dolor de garganta*, *dolor de cabeza* — a place and a trouble joined by a word you have had since the beginning. That is a real sentence, built entirely out of five new words and one small old one.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la fiebre*
- *tengo fiebre*
- all five in order — *el ojo*, *la boca*, *la garganta*, *el dolor*, *la fiebre*

Before you move on

Which vowel change turned *febris* into *fiebre*? (Stressed *e* into *ie*.)
How many times did English borrow this word? (Twice — *fever*, then *febrile*.) And what did *indolent* mean first? (Feeling no pain.)

Chapter 287

Five Things You Ask For — Soap, Towel, Glass, Spoon, Plate

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask for soap, a towel, a glass, a spoon and a plate in Spanish, politely.

Complete ES-C287-plato: ask for all five in turn, with *por favor* on the end of each.

287.1 el jabón — a word that went abroad and came home

Before a new run: how many times did English borrow *febris*? (Twice.) And what does *dolere* mean? (To hurt.)

What to know first

- el agua — what you use this with.
- por favor — what you put on the end when you ask.

Sounds you'll need

- *ja-BON*, stress on the second syllable, which the written accent marks. The *j* is the *jota* again, the rasp at the back. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el jabón — “soap.”

Latin **sapo**, **saponem** — and Latin did not make this word. It borrowed it from the Germanic peoples on its northern frontier, who used the stuff on their hair before anybody in Rome used it for washing.

So English **soap** and *jabón* are one word, and the English one is the one that stayed at home. Spanish has it back after a long detour: Germanic into Latin, Latin into Spanish. **Saponify** and **saponification** are the late loans, taken straight from the Latin form. Words move with things. Rome had better roads and better law; the north had better soap. Trade decides vocabulary far more often than conquest does.

What you’ve built

Not every Latin word is Roman.

Latin was borrowing from its neighbours the whole time, and a word can be perfectly good Latin and still be an import. *Jabón* has been abroad and come back, and nothing in the sound of it says so.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el jabón*
- *el jabón, por favor*
- *jabón* and *soap*, and hear one word twice

Before you move on

Where did Latin get *sapo*? (From its Germanic neighbours.) Is English *soap* borrowed from Spanish? (No — it never left; it is the same word at home.)

287.2 la toalla — the Germanic layer, still in the bathroom

Before the new one: where did Latin get *sapo*? (From its Germanic neighbours.)

What to know first

- el jabón — what you use before you need this.
- el agua — and what you are drying off.

Sounds you'll need

- *to-A-lla*, stress on the *a*. The *ll* is a *y* sound for most speakers, and something closer to a *j* in the River Plate. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la toalla — “a towel.”

Another Germanic word, and this time both languages took it.

Frankish **thwahlja**, a cloth for washing, became Old French *toaille*, and out of that Spanish has *toalla* and English has **towel**.

Two words in a row now that are not Latin at the bottom. Spanish is a Latin language with a Germanic layer laid over the top, and that layer sits mostly in the house and the wardrobe — the words the settlers brought along with the things themselves.

The *-alla* ending is the giveaway. A Latin word would not have arrived in that shape; a French one would. Spanish borrowed this from its neighbour, not from its parent.

What you've built

Two Germanic words, side by side, in the plainest room of the house.

That is not an accident. The most domestic vocabulary in a Romance language is often the least Roman, because that is where the incomers actually lived.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la toalla*
- *la toalla, por favor*
- *el jabón y la toalla*

Before you move on

Is *toalla* a Latin word? (No — Frankish, through French.) Which English word is the same one? (*Towel*.)

287.3 *el vaso* — named for the job, not the material

Before the new one: is *toalla* a Latin word? (No — Frankish, through French.)

What to know first

- *el agua* — what goes in it.
- *la toalla* — the thing before this one.

Sounds you'll need

- *VA-so*, stress on the first syllable. The *v* is the same soft sound as *b* — the letters differ and the sound does not. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el vaso — “a glass,” the thing you drink out of.

Latin **vas**, **vasis**: a vessel, a container of any sort. Spanish names the object by what it does rather than by what it is made of, which is why a plastic one is still a *vaso* and an English glass made of plastic is a small embarrassment.

English has three of them at three different weights. A **vase** holds flowers. A **vessel** holds wine, or cargo, or blood. The **vascular** system is the body's plumbing, named by anatomists reaching for the same Latin.

And notice the letter. *Vaso* begins with the sound you have been giving to *b*. Spanish writes *v* and says something very close to *b*, and

that was true long before the spelling settled down.

What you've built

Three things you can ask for, and three different sources.
Germanic, Frankish, Latin. A tray of ordinary objects in a Spanish kitchen is a small map of who passed through.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el vaso*
- *un vaso de agua, por favor*
- *vaso* and *vase*, and hear the container in both

Before you move on

What did *vas* mean in Latin? (A vessel or container.) Why is a plastic one still a *vaso*? (Because the word names the job, not the material.)

287.4 la cuchara — a snail shell with a handle

Before the new one: what did *vas* mean in Latin? (A vessel.)

What to know first

- *el vaso* — the thing before this one.
- *la comida* — what you need this for.

Sounds you'll need

- *cu-CHA-ra*, stress in the middle. The *ch* is one sound, as in English *church*, and never a *k*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la cuchara — “a spoon.”

Latin **cochlear**, a spoon, from **cochlea**, a snail shell. The Romans ate snails and used the shell to get them out, and the tool kept the name of the shell long after it had stopped being one.

Cochlea is still in English, unchanged, for the spiral inside your ear — named by an anatomist who thought it looked like the shell. So the spoon and the inner ear are the same Latin snail, arriving a thousand years apart by two completely different routes.

A tool named after the thing it replaced is one of the commonest patterns in any vocabulary. The name outlives the object, and nobody notices until somebody pulls the word open.

What you’ve built

Four things, and each one is a small piece of history you can hold. Soap from the north, a towel from the Franks, a vessel from Rome, and a snail shell with a handle on it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la cuchara*
- *la cuchara, por favor*
- *cochlea* and *cuchara*, the shell and the spoon

Before you move on

What is a *cochlea*? (A snail shell.) What else in English carries the name? (The spiral of the inner ear.)

287.5 el plato — flat, in Greek, before anything else

Before the last of the five: what is a *cochlea*? (A snail shell.)
And what did *vas* mean? (A vessel.)

What to know first

- la cuchara — what you put beside it.
- por favor — what closes every one of these requests.

Sounds you'll need

- *PLA-to*, stress on the first syllable. The *l* stays clear and forward, and the *pl* is said cleanly with no vowel slipped in. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el plato — “a plate.”

Not Latin at the bottom: Greek **platys**, flat or broad. Latin took it in as *plattus*, and out of that Spanish has *plato* and English has **plate**.

The same Greek flatness turns up all over. A **plaza** is a flat open space — Latin *platea*, a broad street. A **plateau** is a flat high place. A **platypus** is a flat-foot. And English **flat** itself is the Germanic cousin of *platys*, from the same ancient root by the other road.

Five things you can now ask for. The asking itself you have had for a long while: *por favor* on the end of any of them, and the sentence is finished.

What you've built

Five: *el jabón, la toalla, el vaso, la cuchara, el plato*.

Germanic, Frankish, Latin, Latin, Greek. Five ordinary objects and five different origins — which is the honest answer to the question of where Spanish words come from.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el plato*
- *el plato, por favor*
- all five in order — *el jabón, la toalla, el vaso, la cuchara, el plato*

Before you move on

What does *platys* mean? (Flat.) What is a *platypus*, taken apart? (A flat-foot.) And where did Latin get *sapo*? (From its Germanic neighbours.)

Chapter 288

Setting Off — The Way Out, the Journey, the Return, the Arrival, the Farewell

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the way out, the journey, the return, the arrival and the farewell in Spanish.

Complete ES-C288-despedida: name all five stages of a departure in order, from the way out to the goodbye.

288.1 la salida — the Romans jumped out of rooms

Before a new run: what does *platys* mean? (Flat.) And what is a *cochlea*? (A snail shell.)

What to know first

- salir — the word this one is made from.
- la puerta — where the way out generally is.

Sounds you'll need

- *sa-LI-da*, stress on the *li*. The *d* between vowels is soft, close to the *th* of *this*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la salida — “the exit,” “the way out.”

From **salir**, which you have, and behind *salir* is Latin **salire**, to jump. A Roman did not leave a room; he jumped out of it. It calmed down on its way into Spanish and kept only the departing.

The jumping survives in the English loans. Something **salient** is jumping out at you. An **assault** is a jumping-at. A **somersault** is a jump over the top. And to **sally** out of a fort is the same word once more, arriving through French.

The ending is worth as much as the root. *-ida* on an action gives you the act or the result of it, and it is going to give you three of the next four words.

What you’ve built

You have had *salir* for a long time; now you have the name of what it does.

That is a cheap way to grow a vocabulary, and Spanish is unusually generous with it. A word you know plus an ending you know is a word you did not have to learn.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la salida*
- *salir*, then *la salida*, and hear the first one inside the second
- *la puerta de salida*

Before you move on

What did *salire* mean? (To jump.) What does the *-ida* ending do? (Turns an action into the act or the result.)

288.2 el viaje — the packed lunch that became the journey

Before the new one: what did *salire* mean? (To jump.)

What to know first

- la salida — how this one begins.
- caminar — the walking you already have.

Sounds you'll need

- *VIA-je*, stress on the first syllable. The *j* is the *jota*, and the *ia* is one glide. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el viaje — “the journey.”

Latin **viaticum**, from **via**, a road: not the journey at all, but the money and food you packed for one. Spanish moved the word off the supplies and onto the trip.

English took the same *viaticum* through French and got **voyage**. It also has *via* on its own: a **viaduct** carries a road; something **trivial** is *tri-via*, the place where three roads meet, and what gets said at a crossroads is not important.

The shift is the interesting part. A word for the preparation became the word for the thing prepared for. That happens constantly, and it is why so many ordinary words look sideways at their own meaning.

What you've built

Two of the five, and both were something else first.

A jump became a way out; a packed bag became a journey. Neither word describes what it now names.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el viaje*
- *buen viaje*
- *la salida* and *el viaje*

Before you move on

What was a *viaticum*? (The provisions for a road.) Which English word is the same one? (*Voyage*.)

288.3 la vuelta — everything here is rolling

Before the new one: what was a *viaticum*? (The provisions for a road.)

What to know first

- el viaje — what this one ends.
- la puerta — where you first met the *o* opening into *ue*.

Sounds you'll need

- *VUEL-ta*, stress on the first syllable. The *ue* is one glide and the *l* stays clear. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la vuelta — “the return,” and also a turn.

From **volver**, Latin **volvere**, to roll or turn. The stressed *o* opens into *ue* exactly as you now expect it to: *volta* to *vuelta*, as *portam* went to *puerta*.

Volvere rolled a long way into English. To **revolve** is to roll again. A **revolution** is one full turn — of a wheel first and of a state a great deal later. And a **volume** is a rolled-up scroll, which is why a book carries the same name as a quantity of space.

Vuelta is not only a return. It is a lap of a track, a turn of a key, and change handed back in a shop. All of them are the same rolling, and Spanish did not bother to invent separate words.

What you've built

You can now predict this vowel rather than memorise it.

Puerta, *cierto*, *fiebre*, *vuelta*: stressed *o* to *ue*, stressed *e* to *ie*. Given a Latin word you have never seen, you can guess the Spanish — and be right more often than not.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la vuelta*
- *volver*, then *la vuelta*
- *la salida, el viaje, la vuelta*

Before you move on

What does *volvere* mean? (To roll or turn.) Why is a book a *volume*? (Because it was a rolled scroll.)

288.4 la llegada — the sails are folded, so you have arrived

Before the new one: what does *volvere* mean? (To roll or turn.)

What to know first

- *la vuelta* — the return this one completes.
- *cl-*, *pl-*, *fl-* → *ll-* — the change you are about to see happen.

Sounds you'll need

- *lle-GA-da*, stress on the *ga*. The *ll* is a *y* sound for most speakers, and the *g* before *a* is hard. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la llegada — “the arrival.”

From **llegar**, to arrive, and this is the best story of the five. Latin **plicare** means to fold. A ship coming in to shore folded its sails — *plicare vela* — and the phrase wore down until the folding meant the arriving and the sails were gone from the sentence entirely.

Now the beginning of the word. *Plicare* to *llegar*: the *pl-* has become *ll-*, which is the change you have already met by name and can now watch doing real work.

Ply, **apply**, **complicate**, and a **plait** are the English relatives, every

one of them still folding something. *Complicate* is to fold together, which is a fair description of what it does to a plan.

What you've built

A sound change you learned as a rule has just paid for itself. You did not have to be told that *llegar* comes from *plicare*; the *ll-* at the front told you it came from something with *pl-*. Rules about sound are worth more than lists of words, because they work on words you have never met.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la llegada*
- *plicare*, then *llegar*, and hear the *pl-* collapse
- *la salida* and *la llegada*, the two ends of a trip

Before you move on

What did *plicare* mean? (To fold.) What was being folded? (The sails of a ship coming in.) What happened to the *pl-*? (It became *ll-*.)

288.5 la despedida — taking your leave was asking for it

Before the last of the five: what did *plicare* mean? (To fold.) And what did *salire* mean? (To jump.)

What to know first

- adiós — one thing you say at this moment.
- hasta luego — and another.

Sounds you'll need

- *des-pe-DI-da*, stress on the *di*. Both *d* sounds between vowels are soft. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la despedida — “the farewell,” the act of saying goodbye.

From **despedir**, and behind it Latin **expetere**: *ex-*, out, plus **petere**, to seek or to ask. To take your leave was to ask for it — which is still what a leave-taking is, underneath the politeness.

Petere is a large family in English. A **petition** asks. To **compete** is to seek alongside somebody. An **appetite** seeks towards. And to **repeat** is to seek a thing again.

Adiós, *hasta luego* and *hasta mañana* have been yours since near the start, and you have been saying them without a word for the act itself. This is that word.

What you've built

Five: *la salida*, *el viaje*, *la vuelta*, *la llegada*, *la despedida*.

Set out in order they trace a whole departure — the way out, the journey, the return, the arrival, and the goodbye that opens the whole thing. Four of the five are words you already had, wearing an ending. Only the endings were new.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la despedida*
- *adiós*, then *la despedida* — the word and the act
- all five in order — *la salida*, *el viaje*, *la vuelta*, *la llegada*, *la despedida*

Before you move on

What are the pieces of *expetere*? (*Ex-*, out, and *petere*, to ask.)

Which English words still ask? (*Petition*, *compete*, *appetite*, *repeat*.)

And what did *plicare* mean? (To fold.)

Chapter 289

Overhead — Daybreak, Sky, Cloud, Star, Shade

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the daybreak, the sky, a cloud, a star and the shade in Spanish.

Complete ES-C289-sombra: name all five overhead in order, from first light to the shade under a tree.

289.1 el amanecer — the piece hiding inside mañana

Before a new run: what are the pieces of *expetere*? (*Ex*-, out, and *petere*, to ask.) And what does *la llegada* name? (The arrival.)

What to know first

- hasta mañana — a word you have been saying for a long time, with a piece of this one inside it.
- el día — what this is the beginning of.

Sounds you'll need

- *a-ma-ne-CER*, stress on the very end. The *c* before *e* is the soft one. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el amanecer — “the daybreak,” the moment it gets light.

Take it apart and Latin **mane** falls out, meaning “in the morning.” Around it sit *a-*, towards, and *-ecer*, an ending that means a thing beginning to happen. So: moving towards morning, and not yet arrived.

You already own that middle piece. *Mañana* is *mane* too, worn down through **hora maneana**, “the morning hour,” until only the *mañ-* was left. Two words you would never have paired, and the same Latin sits in both.

The cousins in English arrive by a different road. **Matins** is the morning office. A **matinee** is the showing early enough to still count as morning, at least when somebody named it.

What you’ve built

A word for the moment a day starts, and a piece you can now hear in a word you already had.

That is worth more than one word. Once *mane* is visible inside *mañana*, the two stop being separate things to remember and become one thing wearing two coats.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el amanecer*
- *mañana*, then *el amanecer*, and hear *man-* in both
- *hasta mañana*, then *el amanecer*

Before you move on

What did *mane* mean? (In the morning.) Which word you already had carries the same piece? (*Mañana*.) And what does *-ecer* add? (That a thing is beginning to happen.)

289.2 el cielo — the ceiling over everything

Two back: what does *la despedida* name? (The farewell.) And what did *mane* mean? (In the morning.)

What to know first

- el amanecer — what happens up there first.
- azul — what it usually is.

Sounds you'll need

- *CIE-lo*, stress on the first part. The *ie* is one slide, not two beats, and the *l* stays bright to the end. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el cielo — “the sky.”

Latin **caelum**, and the Romans used it for the sky and for the vault of heaven without much worrying which they meant. Spanish kept both senses in the one word.

The English relatives came in by two doors. Through French *ciel* you get **ceiling** — the sky of a room, which is a nicer thought than the word usually gets credit for. Straight from Latin you get **cerulean**, the deep blue in a paint box, from **caeruleus**, “sky-coloured.”

Notice what the *ie* is doing. Latin had a short *e* in *caelum*, and Spanish broke it into *ie* the way it did in *bien* and *tiene*. Once you hear that, a whole set of words stops looking irregular.

What you've built

Two words, and both of them are about what is over your head.

El amanecer is a moment; *el cielo* is a place. Between them you can already say when and where without any of the machinery a sentence usually needs.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el cielo*

- *el cielo azul*
- *el amanecer*, then *el cielo*

Before you move on

What was *caelum*? (The sky.) Which English word for the top of a room is the same one? (*Ceiling*.) And what colour is *cerulean*? (Sky blue.)

289.3 la nube — where nuance comes from

Before the new one: what was *caelum*? (The sky.) And which piece of *amanecer* means “in the morning”? (*Mane*.)

What to know first

- *el cielo* — where these are.
- *blanco* — what colour they usually are.

Sounds you'll need

- *NU-be*, stress on the first part. The *u* is the pure one, and the *b* between vowels is soft, the lips barely meeting. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la nube — “the cloud.”

Latin **nubes**, and it has come down almost untouched: four letters in, four letters out.

The good English relative is not obvious. French took *nubes* and made **nue**, a cloud, and from *nue* built **nuance** — which meant the shading of one cloud into another before it ever meant a shade of meaning.

When you say a distinction has nuance, you are borrowing a description of the sky.

Nebulous looks like a relative and is a slightly different one: Latin **nebula** was mist rather than cloud. Close cousins, different words, and the pair is worth keeping apart in your head.

What you've built

Three, and they stack: a moment, the place above you, and the things crossing it.

El amanecer, el cielo, la nube. Notice that none of the three has needed a new ending or a new pattern — they are ordinary words, and you can already hang *azul* or *blanco* on the last two.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la nube*
- *la nube blanca*
- *el amanecer, el cielo, la nube*

Before you move on

What English word for a fine distinction began as a shading of cloud? (*Nuance.*) What did *nebula* mean, as against *nubes*? (Mist, not cloud.)

289.4 la estrella — stella, with a running start

Quick pass: what was *nubes*? (A cloud.) What was *caelum*? (The sky.) And what does *el amanecer* name? (The daybreak.)

What to know first

- *el cielo* — where you find them.
- *la noche* — when you find them.

Sounds you'll need

- *es-TRE-lla*, stress in the middle. The *rr* is not here — this is a single *r* after a *t*, one tap. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la estrella — “the star.”

Underneath it is Latin **stella**, and English took that one bare: something **stellar** is of the stars, and a **constellation** is a set of them standing together.

So where did the *e-* come from? Spanish does not care for a word that opens with *s* and another consonant, and it puts an *e* in front to give the tongue somewhere to start. You have seen it without being told: *escuela, estudiante, España*. Each one is a Latin word with a step built in front of it.

That is why an English speaker learning Spanish and a Spanish speaker learning English trip over the same threshold from opposite sides.

What you’ve built

Four, and one small piece of machinery that costs nothing and pays constantly.

El amanecer, el cielo, la nube, la estrella. The last of them handed you a way to guess at words you have not met: strip the *e-*, and a Latin or English relative is often sitting underneath.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la estrella*
- *estudiante, España, estrella* — the same step three times
- *el cielo, la nube, la estrella*

Before you move on

What is *estrella* without its *e-*? (*Stella*.) Why is the *e-* there? (Spanish wants a vowel before *s* plus a consonant.) Name two more words that do it. (*Escuela, estudiante, España*.)

289.5 la sombra — what an umbrella is little of

Before the last of the five: what was *stella*? (A star.) What was *nubes*? (A cloud.) And why does *estrella* begin with an *e*?

(Spanish wants a vowel before *s* and a consonant.)

What to know first

- el árbol — a reliable source of one.
- el cielo — what has to be clear for there to be any.

Sounds you'll need

- *SOM-bra*, stress on the first part. The *m* closes the lips and the *b* opens them again, so the two run together. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la sombra — “the shade,” “the shadow.”

Two Latin words squeezed into one: **sub**, under, and **umbra**, shadow. To be *sub umbra* was to be under the shadow, and Spanish ran the phrase together until it named the thing itself.

Umbra is generous in English. An **umbrella** is a little shadow you carry — built for sun before it was ever built for rain, which the name still admits. To take **umbrage** is to be put in the shade by somebody. And a **sombrero** is Spanish handing the word back: a shadow-maker for your head.

The *-ero* on *sombrero* makes a thing that does a job, the way *cocinero* names somebody who cooks. A hat that shades is a *sombrero*, and now the hat is not a word you have to memorise.

What you've built

Five: *el amanecer, el cielo, la nube, la estrella, la sombra*.

Read them in order and they run from first light to the dark shape under a tree — a whole day's worth of overhead, in five words and no new grammar at all. Three of the five handed you something extra on the way out: a piece of *mañana*, the *e-* step, and now an ending you had already met wearing a different hat.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la sombra*

- *sombra*, then *sombrero* — the shade and the thing that makes it
- all five in order — *el amanecer*, *el cielo*, *la nube*, *la estrella*, *la sombra*

Before you move on

What two Latin words are inside *sombra*? (*Sub*, under, and *umbra*, shadow.) Which English words still carry *umbra*? (*Umbrella*, *umbrage*.) And what does *-ero* do? (Names somebody or something that does the job.)

Chapter 290

What Is Eaten — Wheat, Rice, Onion, Tomato, Honey

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name wheat, rice, an onion, a tomato and honey in Spanish, and thank somebody for them.

Complete ES-C290-miel: name all five foods in turn and thank somebody for each.

290.1 el trigo — the grain that got rubbed

Before a new run: what two Latin words hide in *sombra*? (*Sub* and *umbra*.) And what was *stella*? (A star.)

What to know first

- el pan — what this becomes.
- el agua — the other half of what bread needs.

Sounds you'll need

- *TRI-go*, stress on the first part. One tap for the *r*, and the *g* is hard before *o*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el trigo — “the wheat.”

Latin **triticum**, and that is built on **terere**, to rub or to wear away. Wheat was named for what you had to do to it: rub the grain out of the husk. The crop is named after the threshing, not the plant.

Terere wore a path through English too. Something **trite** has been rubbed smooth by overuse. **Attrition** is wearing down. **Detritus** is what has been rubbed off. Even **detriment** is a wearing-away, though it has gone abstract and stopped admitting it.

A useful habit, this: when a Latin food word looks odd, ask what was done to the food. The answer is often the whole etymology.

What you’ve built

One word, and a small piece of the ancient working day.

You have had *el pan* for a long time. Now you have what it is made of, which means you can name a thing and the stuff it came from — a step up from naming things one at a time.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el trigo*
- *el trigo*, then *el pan* — the stuff, then the thing
- *el pan de trigo*

Before you move on

What did *terere* mean? (To rub.) Which English words still rub? (*Trite*, *attrition*, *detritus*.) And what is *el trigo*? (The wheat.)

290.2 el arroz — a word that brought its own article

Two back: what does *la sombra* name? (The shade.) And what did *terere* mean? (To rub.)

What to know first

- *el trigo* — the grain before this one.
- *el agua* — what you cook it in.

Sounds you'll need

- *a-RRÖZ*, stress on the end. The *rr* at the start of the second part is the rolled one, held. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el arroz — “the rice.”

This one did not come from Latin. Arabic **ar-ruzz** crossed into Spain with the crop itself, and Spanish took the phrase whole, article and all. *Ar-* was already “the.” So *el arroz* says it twice, in two languages, and nobody minds.

Once you know to watch for it, that stuck-on *a-* is everywhere in the Arabic layer of Spanish: *azúcar*, *aceite*, *almohada*, *aduana*. Each one is still wearing an Arabic *al-* that Spanish stopped being able to see.

English got the same grain by a different road — Greek **oryza**, then Latin, then Italian, then French, arriving as **rice**. Same plant, two routes, and the words no longer look like relatives.

What you've built

Two grains, and two completely different histories sitting side by side. *El trigo* came down from Rome. *El arroz* came in from the south with farmers. That is Spanish in miniature: a Latin skeleton with a large Arabic vocabulary laid over the top, and the joins still visible when you know where to look.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el arroz*
- *el trigo*, then *el arroz* — Rome, then the south
- *arroz*, *azúcar*, *aceite* — three words carrying an Arabic *al-*

Before you move on

What does the *ar-* in *arroz* already mean? (The.) Name two more Spanish words carrying an Arabic article. (*Azúcar*, *aceite*, *almohada*.) And which English word is the same grain? (*Rice*.)

290.3 la cebolla — a little something, permanently

Before the new one: what does the *ar-* of *arroz* already mean? (The.) And what was *triticum* named for? (The rubbing, the threshing.)

What to know first

- comer — what you eventually do with it.
- el arroz — what it usually goes into.

Sounds you'll need

- *ce-BO-lla*, stress in the middle. The *c* before *e* is soft, and the *ll* is close to an English *y*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la cebolla — “the onion.”

Latin had **caepa** for an onion, and **caepulla** for a small one. Spanish kept the small one and quietly dropped the full-sized word, so the language now calls every onion a little onion, however large.

That happens more than you would expect. A word with a diminutive on it gets used so often that the ending stops meaning anything, and the plain form falls away. You will meet the same *-illa* and *-illo* again shortly, still doing the job in words where it has not yet worn out.

English kept the other half. **Chive** came through French *cive* from that same **caepa**, and a chive really is a small one — so between the two languages the pair got split down the middle.

What you've built

Three things you can put in a pot, and a piece of machinery worth more than the three.

El trigo, el arroz, la cebolla. Hearing a small ending as “a little one of these” will unlock words you have not been taught, which is the whole point of taking them apart.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la cebolla*
- *el arroz con cebolla*
- *el trigo, el arroz, la cebolla*

Before you move on

What was *caepa*? (An onion.) What did *caepulla* add? (Smallness.) Which English plant is the same root? (*Chive*.)

290.4 el tomate — a word that came the other way

Quick pass: what was *caepa*? (An onion.) What does *ar-* mean in *arroz*? (The.) And what is *el trigo*? (The wheat.)

What to know first

- *la cebolla* — what it is usually cooked with.
- *rojo* — what colour it goes.

Sounds you'll need

- *to-MA-te*, stress in the middle. Three clean vowels, none of them swallowed. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el tomate — “the tomato.”

Take this one apart and nothing Latin falls out, because there is nothing Latin in it. **Tomatl** is Nahuatl, the language of the Mexica, and the plant and its name travelled to Spain together in the sixteenth century.

Spanish shaved the *-tl* into *-te*, which is what it did to the whole set:

chocolatl became *chocolate*, **ahuacatl** became *aguacate*, **coyotl** became *coyote*. Then English took them from Spanish, which is why an English speaker already owns three Nahuatl words without knowing it. So the traffic ran both ways. Spanish handed *sombrero* to English and took *tomate* from Mexico, and both words now sit in the same everyday vocabulary with no label saying where they have been.

What you’ve built

Four foods, and three separate continents behind them.

El trigo is Roman. *El arroz* is Arabic. *El tomate* is American. One short set of words, and the history of who fed whom is sitting inside it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el tomate*
- *tomate, chocolate, aguacate* — the same ending three times
- *el arroz con tomate y cebolla*

Before you move on

What language is *tomate* from? (Nahuatl.) What happened to the *-tl* ending? (It became *-te*.) Name two more words that did it. (*Chocolate, aguacate, coyote*.)

290.5 la miel — the sweetness inside three English words

Before the last of the five: what language gave us *tomate*? (Nahuatl.) What was *caepa*? (An onion.) And what does *ar-*

mean? (The.)

What to know first

- el pan — what you put it on.
- la flor — where it starts.

Sounds you'll need

- *MIEL*, one beat. The *ie* is a single slide, and the *l* is bright, never the dark English one at the end of a word. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la miel — “the honey.”

Latin **mel**, four letters shorter than most of what we have taken apart, and Spanish did little to it beyond breaking the *e* into *ie* — the same break you met in *cielo*.

Mel is sweeter in English than it looks. Something **mellifluous** flows with honey, which is what *fluere* is doing on the end of it. **Molasses** came through Portuguese *melaço*, the honey-like leavings of sugar.

And **marmalade** carries the Greek form **meli**, stuck to *melon*, quince — a quince-honey, which is exactly what marmalade is.

There is a lesson hidden in that last one. A word can be perfectly transparent in its own language and completely opaque once it has crossed two borders.

What you've built

Five: *el trigo*, *el arroz*, *la cebolla*, *el tomate*, *la miel*.

Set out together they are a shopping list, and they are also four separate histories — Rome, Arabia, Mexico, and Rome again. Every one of the five arrived with an English relative attached, which is the quiet argument this whole approach rests on: you know more of this language than you have been taught.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la miel*

- *el pan con miel*
- all five — *el trigo, el arroz, la cebolla, el tomate, la miel*

Before you move on

What was *mel*? (Honey.) What does *mellifluous* say, taken apart? (Flowing with honey.) And which breakfast preserve is a quince-honey? (*Marmalade*.)

Chapter 291

From the Seed Up — Seed, Root, Trunk, Branch, Wood

Modes: 🔄 voice (5) 🔄 Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the seed, the root, the trunk, the branch and the wood in Spanish.

Complete ES-C291-bosque: name all five from the ground upwards, seed to forest.

291.1 la semilla — where a seminar gets its name

Before a new run: what was *mel*? (Honey.) And what language gave Spanish *tomate*? (Nahuatl.)

What to know first

- la flor — what this one is left behind by.
- el trigo — a crop that is nothing but these.

Sounds you'll need

- *se-MI-lla*, stress in the middle. The *ll* is the *y* sound again, the same as in *cebolla*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la semilla — “the seed.”

Behind it sits Latin **seminalia**, “the things for sowing,” and behind that **semen**, which meant a seed long before it meant anything narrower.

The English family is unusually respectable. A **seminar** is a seed-bed, a place where ideas are started rather than finished. A **seminary** is a nursery for people. To **disseminate** is to scatter seed in every direction, which is what *dis-* is doing there. And something **seminal** is the thing everything later grew out of.

Hear the *-illa* on the end again. This is the second time it has turned up in two chapters’ worth of words, and it will keep turning up — a small ending doing quiet work in words nobody thinks of as small any more.

What you’ve built

One word, and the beginning of a shape.

The next few belong together: this is a tree taken from the ground upwards, and you are standing at the bottom of it. Learning words in a set like that is worth more than learning five unrelated ones, because the set itself is a hook.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la semilla*
- *la semilla*, then *seminar* — the seed and the seed-bed
- *la semilla del trigo*

Before you move on

What did *seminalia* mean? (Things for sowing.) What is a *seminar*, taken apart? (A seed-bed.) And what does *dis-* add to *disseminate*? (Scattering in all directions.)

291.2 la raíz — the word this book keeps using about words

Two back: what was *mel*? (Honey.) And what is a *seminar*, taken apart? (A seed-bed.)

What to know first

- la semilla — what this comes out of first.
- el árbol — what is standing on top of it.

Sounds you'll need

- *ra-ÍZ*, two beats, stress on the second. The written accent is doing real work: it splits *a* and *i* apart instead of letting them slide together. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la raíz — “the root.”

Latin **radix**, and this is the one word in the set you have already been using in English without noticing, because it is what we say about words themselves. When a lesson says a Spanish word and an English word share a root, *radix* is the metaphor underneath.

A **radish** is a *radix* that got eaten. A **radical** goes to the root of the matter, which is why the word means both “fundamental” and “extreme” — it depends whether you approve. To **eradicate** is to pull up by the roots, *e-* out plus *radix*. And a square **root** in mathematics is a translation of the same Latin.

The accent on the *í* is not decoration. Without it, *ai* would slide into one sound; with it, the two vowels stay separate and the stress lands on the second.

What you've built

Two, and they are in the right order: the seed, then what comes out of it first.

You also have the etymology of the word *root* itself, which is a small thing until you notice that half of what this approach does is claim two words share one. Now you can say that claim in Spanish.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la raíz*
- *la semilla*, then *la raíz* — in that order
- *ra-íz*, two beats, and keep the vowels apart

Before you move on

What was *radix*? (A root.) What does *eradicate* say, taken apart? (To pull out by the roots.) And what is the accent on *raíz* doing? (Keeping the two vowels in separate beats.)

291.3 el tronco — a word that means “cut short”

Before the new one: what was *radix*? (A root.) And what did *seminalia* mean? (Things for sowing.)

What to know first

- *la raíz* — what holds this up.
- *el árbol* — the whole of which this is the middle.

Sounds you’ll need

- *TRON-co*, stress on the first part. The *c* before *o* is the hard one, and the *n* closes the first beat. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el tronco — “the trunk.”

Latin **truncus**, and its first meaning was not a tree at all. *Truncus* meant lopped, maimed, cut short — a thing with its ends taken off. A tree stripped of branches is a *truncus*, and the name stuck to the part that was left.

English took the whole family. A **trunk** is the same word. To **truncate** is to cut short deliberately. A **truncheon** is a stick that is a cut-off piece of something longer. Even the elephant’s trunk and the traveller’s trunk are the same word wandering off in two directions

from one idea of a thick stump.

That first meaning explains something odd about *tronco* in Spanish: it is used of a body as well as a tree, for the part left when you set aside the head and the limbs. It has never really stopped meaning “what remains.”

What you’ve built

Three, going upward: *la semilla, la raíz, el tronco*.

The set is doing the work of a story. You are not holding three separate items in mind, you are holding one tree, and the order of the words is the order of the thing itself.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el tronco*
- *la semilla, la raíz, el tronco* — bottom to middle
- *el tronco del árbol*

Before you move on

What did *truncus* mean first? (Lopped, cut short.) What does *truncate* do? (Cuts something short.) And what are the first three of the set? (*La semilla, la raíz, el tronco*.)

291.4 la rama — what a ramification actually is

Quick pass: what did *truncus* mean? (Lopped short.) What was *radix*? (A root.) And what is *la semilla*? (The seed.)

What to know first

- *el tronco* — what these come out of.
- *el árbol* — the whole thing they belong to.

Sounds you'll need

- *RA-ma*, stress on the first part. The opening *r* at the start of a word is rolled, not tapped. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la rama — “the branch.”

Latin **ramus**, and it has barely moved: drop the ending, soften nothing, and there it is.

English kept *ramus* only in its abstract clothes, which makes the connection easy to miss. When a problem **ramifies**, it is growing branches. A **ramification** is one branch of a consequence. Both words are used almost entirely about arguments and lawsuits, and both are describing a tree.

This is a pattern worth naming. Spanish very often keeps a Latin word for the physical thing while English keeps it only for the metaphor.

Rama is a branch you can snap; **ramification** is a branch nobody can point at. Same word, and the two languages divided the labour between them.

What you've built

Four, and the tree is nearly whole: *la semilla*, *la raíz*, *el tronco*, *la rama*.

Four words, and not one of them needed a rule you did not already have. They are ordinary things with ordinary endings, and the only work you have done is hearing what was already inside them.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la rama*
- *la rama del árbol*
- *la semilla*, *la raíz*, *el tronco*, *la rama*

Before you move on

What was *ramus*? (A branch.) What is a *ramification*, underneath? (A branch of a consequence.) And which four do you have so far? (*La semilla, la raíz, el tronco, la rama.*)

291.5 el bosque — the one in the set that is not Roman

Before the last of the five: what was *ramus*? (A branch.) What was *truncus*? (Lopped short.) And what was *radix*? (A root.)

What to know first

- el árbol — one of these, many times over.
- la rama — the word before this one.

Sounds you'll need

- *BOS-que*, stress on the first part. The *qu* is a plain hard *k* and the *u* is silent, as it is in *qué*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el bosque — “the wood,” “the forest.”

Take this one apart and Latin does not answer. *Bosque* is Germanic — from a root like **busk**, a thicket — and it walked into Spanish with the Visigoths, who ruled the peninsula for three centuries between Rome and the Arabic arrival.

Which means its English relative is a native one. A **bush** is the same word. A **bosky** wood is a thicketed one. To **ambush** is to lie in the bushes, *in* the *busk*, waiting. And a **bouquet** is French for a little wood, a small stand of stems, which is a fair description of what is in the vase.

Spanish is often described as Latin plus Arabic, and that is most of the truth, but there is a Germanic layer underneath. You have already met *blanco*, which is Germanic too. *Bosque* is that layer showing again.

What you've built

Five: *la semilla, la raíz, el tronco, la rama, el bosque*.

Said in order they build one tree and then step back to show a thousand of them. Four came from Rome and the fifth from the north, so this short set has quietly handed you the three sources Spanish draws on — Latin, Arabic in the chapter before, and now Germanic.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el bosque*
- *bosque*, then *bush* — the same thicket twice
- all five — *la semilla, la raíz, el tronco, la rama, el bosque*

Before you move on

Where does *bosque* come from? (Germanic, not Latin.) Which English words are its cousins? (*Bush, bosky, ambush.*) And which other Germanic word do you already have? (*Blanco.*)

Chapter 292

Naming the Land — Village, Hill, Valley, Lake, Mountain

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the village, a hill, a valley, a lake and a mountain in Spanish, and say where I am from.

Complete ES-C292-montana: name all five features of a landscape and place a village among them.

292.1 el pueblo — the place and the people, one word

Before a new run: where does *bosque* come from? (Germanic, not Latin.) And what was *ramus*? (A branch.)

What to know first

- la casa — what a small one is mostly made of.
- el vecino — who lives in it.

Sounds you'll need

- *PUE-blo*, stress on the first part. The *ue* is one slide, and the *b* between vowels is the soft one. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el pueblo — “the village,” and also “the people.”

Latin **populus** meant the people, the citizen body. Spanish kept that sense and added the other one, so *el pueblo* is both the settlement and everybody in it, and Spanish does not usually feel the need to say which.

Populus is generous in English. Something **popular** belongs to the people. A **population** is the whole of them counted. Anything **public** is theirs rather than private — *publicus* is *populus* worn down. And **people** itself came through French from the same Latin, so the English and the Spanish word are the same word, three roads apart.

Watch the *ue*. Latin’s short *o* in *populus* broke into *ue* in Spanish, the same way the short *e* broke into *ie* in *cielo*. Once you can hear those two breaks, a very large number of Spanish words stop being surprises.

What you’ve built

One word doing two jobs, which is a bargain.

You can now name where somebody is from, and the answer is also a claim about who they are. That is a genuinely useful thing to be able to say when you are meeting people, and it costs one word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el pueblo*
- *mi pueblo*
- *pueblo*, *popular*, *público* — the same Latin three times

Before you move on

What did *populus* mean? (The people.) What two things does *pueblo* name? (The village and the people in it.) And what did Latin’s short *o* become? (*Ue*.)

292.2 la colina — the same rising that is in excel

Two back: which of the tree words was Germanic? (*El bosque*.)

And what does *pueblo* name besides the village? (The people.)

What to know first

- el pueblo — often sitting on one of these.
- el bosque — what is often growing on it.

Sounds you'll need

- *co-LI-na*, stress in the middle. Both *l* sounds are bright and forward. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la colina — “the hill.”

Latin **collis**, a hill, and behind it an old root that simply meant to rise or to stand up. That root went everywhere.

To **excel** is *ex-* plus *cellere*, to rise out above the rest. To **culminate** is to reach the **culmen**, the summit. And the plain English **hill** is a cousin too, arriving through Germanic rather than Latin — the same ancient rising, split between the two halves of your vocabulary.

The *-ina* on the end is a softening, the same shape as in *cocina*.

Spanish tends to take a blunt Latin word and hand it a warmer ending, and *collis* to *colina* is that habit in one step.

What you've built

Two, and between them you can place a settlement in a landscape.

El pueblo and *la colina* are the beginning of being able to answer “where are you from?” with something more than a name — which is exactly what you do when you meet somebody and the name alone is not enough.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la colina*

- *el pueblo en la colina*
- *colina*, then *excel* — both of them rising

Before you move on

What was *collis*? (A hill.) What does the old root behind it mean? (To rise.) And which two English words still rise? (*Excel*, *culminate*.)

292.3 el valle — the low half of the pair

Before the new one: what was *collis*? (A hill.) And what two things does *el pueblo* name? (The village and its people.)

What to know first

- la colina — the opposite shape.
- la nieve — what comes down into one.

Sounds you'll need

- *VA-lle*, stress on the first part. The *v* is said with both lips, close to a soft *b*, and the *ll* is the *y* sound. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el valle — “the valley.”

Latin **vallis**, and English has it twice over. **Valley** came through French, carrying the extra syllable. **Vale** is the same word arriving earlier and shorter, which is why it survives mostly in place names and poetry.

Avalanche belongs here too, though it took a detour: it is from a dialect of the Alps, built on the idea of descending — *a val*, to the valley. What an avalanche is named for is not the snow, but where the snow ends up.

The *v* is worth a moment. In Spanish it is not the English *v* made with teeth and lip; it is made with both lips, and in most positions it is barely distinguishable from *b*. Spanish speakers who have not been taught spelling mix the two up in writing for exactly that reason.

What you've built

Three, and they are starting to describe a place rather than list things. *El pueblo, la colina, el valle*. High ground, low ground, and somewhere for people to live between them. That is a landscape, and you can now put a name to one when somebody asks where you grew up.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el valle*
- *la colina*, then *el valle* — up, then down
- *el pueblo del valle*

Before you move on

What was *vallis*? (A valley.) Which two English words are both from it? (*Valley* and *vale*.) And how is the Spanish *v* made? (With both lips, near a soft *b*.)

292.4 el lago — and the gap it leaves in a page

Quick pass: what was *vallis*? (A valley.) What was *collis*? (A hill.) And what was *populus*? (The people.)

What to know first

- *el agua* — what one is made of.
- *el valle* — where one usually sits.

Sounds you'll need

- *LA-go*, stress on the first part. The *g* before *o* is hard, and softens a little between vowels. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el lago — “the lake.”

Latin **lacus**, standing water. English **lake** is the same word through French, and **lagoon** arrived later through Italian *laguna*, which is *lacuna* worn smooth.

That last one is the interesting turn. A **lacuna** in Latin is a pool or a pit, and scholars borrowed it for a hole in a manuscript — a place where the text has gone missing. So the word for a small lake became the word for a gap in a page, because both are an absence with an edge round it.

Lacus also went north on its own and turned up in English as **loch** and **lough** through the Celtic languages, which is why the map of Scotland and Ireland is covered in a Spanish word nobody there would recognise as one.

What you’ve built

Four, and the landscape now has water in it.

El pueblo, la colina, el valle, el lago. You could describe most of the places people are actually from with these four and nothing else, which is not bad for four words that each came with an English relative attached.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el lago*
- *el lago del valle*
- *el pueblo, la colina, el valle, el lago*

Before you move on

What was *lacus*? (Standing water.) What is a *lacuna* in a text? (A gap where something is missing.) And why is it called that? (It was a pool first.)

292.5 la montaña — the hill inside amount

Before the last of the five: what was *lacus*? (Standing water.)
What was *vallis*? (A valley.) And what was *collis*? (A hill.)

What to know first

- la colina — the smaller version.
- la nieve — what is on top of one.

Sounds you'll need

- *mon-TA-ña*, stress in the middle. The ñ is one sound, not two: the tongue flat against the roof of the mouth. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la montaña — “the mountain.”

Latin **mons**, and in its other forms **montem**, a hill. Spanish built *montaña* on it; English took **mountain** through French from the same place.

Then *mons* went quietly into a set of English words that have stopped looking like hills at all. Something **paramount** is *par a mont*, up above. To **surmount** is to get over the top. To **amount** to something is to climb to it — which is why a bill amounts to a figure, as though the total were a summit. A **montage** is things mounted, stacked up. The ñ is the one letter here that Latin did not have. It began as a scribe's shortcut for a doubled *n*: rather than write the second one in full, they set a tiny *n* over the first to save space, and that tiny mark hardened into the tilde. *Montanea* to *montaña* is that shortcut, frozen.

What you've built

Five: *el pueblo, la colina, el valle, el lago, la montaña*.

Together they are a place, and a place is what most people mean when they tell you where they are from. You started this run able to give a name; you can now give a landscape as well, which is the difference between an introduction and a conversation.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la montaña*
- *la colina*, then *la montaña* — small, then large
- all five — *el pueblo, la colina, el valle, el lago, la montaña*

Before you move on

What was *mons*? (A hill.) What does *paramount* say, taken apart? (Up above.) And where did the ñ come from? (A scribe's tiny second *n*, set over the first.)

Chapter 293

Further Down — Neck, Shoulder, Back, Knee, Ankle

Modes: 🔄 voice (5) 🔄 Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the neck, the shoulder, the back, the knee and the ankle in Spanish, and say which one hurts.

Complete ES-C293-tobillo: name all five places in order and say that each one hurts.

293.1 el cuello — what an accolade was thrown around

Before a new run: what was *mons*? (A hill.) And what was *lacus*? (Standing water.)

What to know first

- la cabeza — what sits on top of it.
- la garganta — what runs down inside it.

Sounds you'll need

- *CUE-llo*, stress on the first part. The *ue* is one slide, and the *ll* is the *y* sound you have had since *cebolla*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el cuello — “the neck.”

Latin **collum**, and there is that *o*-to-*ue* break again, the one you met in *pueblo*. Spanish did it here for exactly the same reason.

Collum is all over English clothing and ceremony. A **collar** is the thing that goes round it. An **accolade** is *ad collum*, “to the neck” — originally the embrace, or the sword laid on the shoulder, that made somebody a knight. The word now means any honour, and has forgotten it used to be a gesture.

El cuello does double duty in Spanish, as it does in English: the neck of a person and the neck of a shirt are the same word, and so is the neck of a bottle.

What you’ve built

One more place on the body, and you already had the ones above it. *La cabeza*, *la garganta*, and now *el cuello*. Being able to say precisely where something hurts is one of the few pieces of vocabulary that is genuinely urgent, which is why this ground is worth going over twice.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el cuello*
- *me duele el cuello*
- *la cabeza*, *el cuello* — top down

Before you move on

What was *collum*? (The neck.) What does *accolade* say, taken apart? (To the neck.) And what break turned *collum* into *cuello*? (Short *o* into *ue*.)

293.2 el hombro — the bone a doctor still names in Latin

Two back: what was *mons*? (A hill.) And what does *accolade* mean, taken apart? (To the neck.)

What to know first

- *el cuello* — what this sits either side of.
- *la mano* — the far end of the same arm.

Sounds you'll need

- *OM-bro*, stress on the first part. The *h* is silent — begin on the vowel and the word is right. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el hombro — “the shoulder.”

Latin **umerus**, with no *h* at all. Spanish added the letter later, purely as spelling, and it has been silent from the day it arrived. If you say *ombro* you have said the word correctly.

The Latin survives untouched in English medicine: the **humerus** is the long bone of the upper arm, running from this joint to the elbow. It is one of those words English kept in a white coat while Spanish wore it every day.

Do not confuse *umerus* with **humor**, the old bodily fluid — nor with **humus**, the ground. Three similar Latin words, three unrelated families, and the *h* that Spanish sprinkled on *hombro* makes the confusion easier rather than harder. Spelling is not always your friend.

What you've built

Two, and they are next to each other on the body.

El cuello and *el hombro*. You are working downward, and the run will keep going down — which is a better way to hold a set of body words than any list, because the body supplies the order for you.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el hombro*
- *me duele el hombro*
- *el cuello*, then *el hombro*

Before you move on

What was *umerus*? (The shoulder.) What do doctors call that bone today? (The humerus.) And what is the *h* in *hombro* doing? (Nothing — it is silent.)

293.3 la espalda — a broad blade, worn on the body

Before the new one: what was *umerus*? (The shoulder.) And what was *collum*? (The neck.)

What to know first

- el hombro — the corner of it.
- el dolor — what it is famous for.

Sounds you'll need

- *es-PAL-da*, stress in the middle. There is the *e-* step again, in front of *sp*, exactly as in *estrella*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la espalda — “the back.”

Underneath is Latin **spatula**, a broad flat blade, itself a small **spatha**, a broad sword. The shoulder blade was named after the tool it resembles, and in Spanish the name spread out from the blade to cover the whole back.

Strip the Spanish *e-* and the English relatives line up. A **spatula** is still a broad flat blade in a kitchen. A **spade** is a bigger one. An **epaulette** is the ornament on a shoulder, through French *épaule* — and French put an *é* on the front for the same reason Spanish put an *e*, so the two languages solved one problem twice.

This is the second word in this run where the *e-* is the only thing standing between you and a word you already know. It is worth making that a habit: meet an unfamiliar *es-* word, take the *e* off, and see what is left.

What you've built

Three, still working downward: *el cuello, el hombro, la espalda*.

The *e*- trick has now paid twice — once on a star and once on a back — which is about the point at which a pattern stops being a curiosity and starts being a tool.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la espalda*
- *me duele la espalda*
- *el cuello, el hombro, la espalda*

Before you move on

What was *spatula* in Latin? (A broad blade.) Which English kitchen tool is the same word? (A spatula.) And what happens if you take the *e*- off an *es*- word? (A familiar word is often underneath.)

293.4 la rodilla — a little wheel, which is exactly right

Quick pass: what was *spatula*? (A broad blade.) What was *umerus*? (The shoulder.) And what was *collum*? (The neck.)

What to know first

- *la espalda* — the word before this one.
- *el dolor* — what this joint tends to produce.

Sounds you'll need

- *ro-DI-lla*, stress in the middle. The opening *r* is rolled; the *d* between vowels is soft. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la rodilla — “the knee.”

Latin **rota** was a wheel, and **rotella** a little one. That is what the knee was called: the small wheel in the middle of the leg. Anyone who has watched a kneecap turn will grant that it is a fair description.

Rota is busy in English. To **rotate** is to wheel. A **rotary** is a wheel of traffic. **Roulette** is a little wheel through French — the same diminutive as *rotella*, built in a different language. And something **rotund** is wheel-shaped.

There is that *-illa* again, and this is the fourth time it has appeared. Once in an onion, once in a seed, and now in a knee. When an ending shows up in words that have nothing to do with one another, it has stopped being decoration and become part of how the language builds things.

What you’ve built

Four, from the neck down to the leg: *el cuello, el hombro, la espalda, la rodilla*.

Each one arrived with a picture attached — a collar, a bone, a blade, a wheel. Words with a picture behind them survive in the memory much longer than words with only a translation.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la rodilla*
- *me duele la rodilla*
- *el cuello, el hombro, la espalda, la rodilla*

Before you move on

What was *rota*? (A wheel.) What did *rotella* add? (Smallness.) And which English gambling wheel is the same diminutive? (*Roulette*.)

293.5 el tobillo — a small lump, honestly named

Before the last of the five: what was *rota*? (A wheel.) What was *spatula*? (A broad blade.) And what was *umerus*? (The shoulder.)

What to know first

- la rodilla — the joint above this one.
- el dolor — what a twisted one gives you.

Sounds you'll need

- *to-BI-llo*, stress in the middle. The *b* between vowels is soft, lips barely touching. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el tobillo — “the ankle.”

Behind it is Latin **tuber**, a swelling or a lump, with the small ending on it. The ankle is the little lump at the bottom of the leg, and the Romans saw no reason to be more poetic about it than that.

Tuber kept its lumpiness in English. A **tuber** is the swelling on a root that we eat as a potato. **Tuberculosis** is named for the small lumps the disease leaves in the lungs. A **protuberance** is a lump sticking forward, which is *pro-* doing the sticking.

That is the fifth *-illo* or *-illa* in this stretch of the book, and by now it should not need pointing out. A seed, an onion, a knee, an ankle: none of them related, all of them small.

What you've built

Five, and a whole side of the body: *el cuello, el hombro, la espalda, la rodilla, el tobillo*.

Said in that order they run from the top of the spine to the bottom of the leg, and each of them fits straight into *me duele* — which you have had for a long time and which now has five more places to point at. The vocabulary is new; the sentence around it is not.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el tobillo*
- *me duele el tobillo*
- all five — *el cuello, el hombro, la espalda, la rodilla, el tobillo*

Before you move on

What was *tuber*? (A swelling, a lump.) Which vegetable part is still called one? (A tuber.) And what do *-illo* and *-illa* add? (Smallness.)

Chapter 294

Five More Things You Ask For — Knife, Cup, Pot, Blanket, Broom

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask for a knife, a cup, a pot, a blanket and a broom in Spanish, politely.

Complete ES-C294-escoba: ask for all five in turn, with *por favor* on the end of each.

294.1 el cuchillo — the little blade behind cutlery

Before a new run: what was *tuber*? (A swelling.) And what was *rota*? (A wheel.)

What to know first

- la cuchara — the one that does not cut.
- por favor — what you put on the end when you ask.

Sounds you'll need

- *cu-CHI-llo*, stress in the middle. The *ch* is one sound, as in English *church*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el cuchillo — “the knife.”

Latin **culter** was a blade; **cultellus** was a small one. Spanish took the small one and forgot the big one, exactly as it did with the onion.

English took *culter* by several roads at once. **Cutlery** came through French *coutel*. A **cutlass** is *coutelas*, an oversized one. And the **coulter** on a plough — the blade that cuts the soil ahead of the share — is the bare Latin word, still doing farm work.

You already have *la cuchara*. It looks like a relative of *cuchillo* and is not one: *cuchara* is from **cochlearium**, a snail-shell spoon. Two kitchen words that begin with the same three letters and come from opposite places, which is a useful reminder that resemblance is not evidence.

What you’ve built

One more thing you can ask for at a meal.

You had *la cuchara* and *el plato* already. Adding *el cuchillo* means you can now ask for the two halves of the job — the thing that cuts and the thing that lifts — with nothing but *por favor* on the end.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el cuchillo*
- *un cuchillo, por favor*
- *la cuchara* and *el cuchillo* — near neighbours, unrelated

Before you move on

What was *culter*? (A blade.) What did *cultellus* add? (Smallness.) And is *cuchara* from the same word? (No — it is a snail shell.)

294.2 la taza — a cup that came a very long way

Two back: what was *tuber*? (A swelling.) And what was *cultellus*? (A little blade.)

What to know first

- el vaso — the one you drink cold things from.
- el agua — what goes in either.

Sounds you'll need

- *TA-za*, stress on the first part. The *z* is the *s* sound across most of the Spanish-speaking world. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la taza — “the cup.”

Another one with no Latin behind it. Arabic **tassa** brought it into Spain, and Arabic had it from Persian **tašt**, a bowl or a basin. So the word crossed two languages and most of a continent before it reached a Spanish kitchen.

French took the same Arabic word and made **tasse**, which is why a small strong coffee is served in a **demitasse** — a half-cup — in English restaurants that would not otherwise admit to speaking Persian.

Set this beside *el vaso*, which you already have. *Vaso* is Latin **vas**, a vessel, and gives English **vase** and **vascular**. Two drinking containers, sitting side by side in the same cupboard, from two completely different worlds.

What you've built

Two of the five, and both of them ask well.

Un cuchillo, por favor. Una taza, por favor. The polite frame has not changed since you first learned it — you are simply dropping new words into a shape you already trust, which is the cheapest kind of progress there is.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la taza*
- *una taza, por favor*
- *el vaso* and *la taza* — Rome and Persia in one cupboard

Before you move on

Which language handed *taza* to Spanish? (Arabic.) And before that? (Persian.) What is a *demitasse*? (A half-cup.)

294.3 la olla — the word that never changed

Before the new one: which language handed *taza* to Spanish? (Arabic.) And what was *culter*? (A blade.)

What to know first

- el arroz — what goes in it.
- la cebolla — and what goes in with it.

Sounds you'll need

- *O-lla*, two beats, stress on the first. The *ll* is the *y* sound; do not let the English *l* creep in. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la olla — “the pot.”

There is nothing to take apart. Latin **olla** meant a cooking pot, and two thousand years later Spanish says *olla* and means a cooking pot. Every letter is where the Romans left it.

That is rarer than it sounds, and it tends to happen to the humblest words. Grand Latin words get replaced, borrowed over, or refined into something abstract. A pot stays a pot because people keep needing one.

English does have it, at one remove. The Spanish dish **olla podrida** — literally a rotted pot, meaning a stew of everything — was borrowed into English as **olio**, a mixture. The French translated the name rather than borrowing it, and got **pot pourri**, which is the same two words again and now means a bowl of dried petals.

What you've built

Three, and a small point about how languages age.

El cuchillo shrank, *la taza* travelled, *la olla* sat still. Three words from

one kitchen, and three completely different fates — which is most of what etymology has to teach, in one cupboard.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la olla*
- *el arroz en la olla*
- *el cuchillo, la taza, la olla*

Before you move on

How much has *olla* changed since Latin? (Nothing at all.) What does *olla podrida* mean literally? (A rotted pot.) And what did French make of it? (*Pot pourri*.)

294.4 la manta — a cloak that lay down

Quick pass: how much has *olla* changed? (Nothing.) Which language gave *taza*? (Arabic.) And what was *cultellus*? (A little blade.)

What to know first

- *la cama* — where one lives.
- *la toalla* — the other useful cloth.

Sounds you'll need

- *MAN-ta*, stress on the first part. Two clean beats, and the *n* closes the first. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la manta — “the blanket.”

Latin **mantum** was a cloak — something you wore. Spanish kept the cloth and dropped the wearing, so a *manta* is now what goes over a bed rather than over your shoulders.

The cloak is still visible in English. A **mantle** is a cloak, literal or inherited: a bishop's, or a champion's. A **mantelpiece** is the shelf over a fire, named because the hood above the hearth was thought of as its cloak. A **mantilla** is a Spanish lace veil, and there is the small ending again. And a **manta ray** is named for its shape — a swimming cloak, which is the best description of one anybody has managed. Spanish also has *manto* for the cloak proper. So the language kept both: the masculine one stayed a garment, the feminine one lay down on a bed.

What you've built

Four things to ask for, and a whole room implied by them. *El cuchillo, la taza, la olla, la manta*. A kitchen and a bed between them. These are the words you actually need when you are a guest in somebody's house and do not want to rummage.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la manta*
- *una manta, por favor*
- *el cuchillo, la taza, la olla, la manta*

Before you move on

What was *mantum*? (A cloak.) Why is a mantelpiece called that? (The hood over the fire was its cloak.) And why is the manta ray called one? (It is shaped like a swimming cloak.)

294.5 la escoba — the one with no English cousin

Before the last of the five: what was *mantum*? (A cloak.) How much has *olla* changed? (Nothing.) And what was *culter*? (A blade.)

What to know first

- limpio — what this makes a room.
- sucio — what a room is before you use it.

Sounds you'll need

- *es-CO-ba*, stress in the middle. The *e*- step in front of *sc*, and the *b* between vowels is soft. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la escoba — “the broom.”

Latin **scopa** was a twig, and **scopae** in the plural was a bundle of them tied to a stick. That is what a broom was, and in much of the world still is.

Take the *e*- off and *scopa* is showing. That is the third time the step has earned its keep in this stretch — a star, a back, and now a broom.

Here is the honest part: this one has no everyday English relative.

Scopa stayed in Latin and in botany, and English built its own word from the broom plant instead. Most of the words in this book have arrived with a cousin attached, and it is worth meeting one that has not, so that the method does not start to look like magic. Sometimes a word is simply a word, and you learn it.

What you've built

Five: *el cuchillo, la taza, la olla, la manta, la escoba*.

Every one of them fits the asking-frame you already had, so the five cost you no grammar whatever. Four came with an English relative and the fifth came without one, which is a fair sample of how the vocabulary of a language is actually distributed.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la escoba*
- *una escoba, por favor*
- all five — *el cuchillo, la taza, la olla, la manta, la escoba*

Before you move on

What was *scopa*? (A twig, and a bundle of them.) What is the *e*-doing on the front? (Giving the tongue a start before *sc*.) And does this one have an English cousin? (No — and that is worth knowing.)

Chapter 295

The Way Out — Path, Bridge, Shore, Island, Mist

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the path, the bridge, the shore, the island and the mist in Spanish.

Complete ES-C295-niebla: name all five of the way out, from the path to the mist behind you.

295.1 el sendero — a half-sized road

Before a new run: what was *scopa*? (A twig, and a bundle of them.) And what was *mantum*? (A cloak.)

What to know first

- la salida — where one of these begins.
- el bosque — what it usually runs through.

Sounds you'll need

- *sen-DE-ro*, stress in the middle. The *d* between vowels is soft, and the *r* is a single tap. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el sendero — “the path,” “the trail.”

Behind it is Latin **semita**, a footpath, and *semita* looks to have been built from **semi-**, half, and a piece meaning going. A footpath was a half-road: narrower than the paved thing the legions marched on, and going somewhere less official.

That *semi-* is the one you already know from **semicircle** and **semifinal**. It is doing exactly the same job here as it does there — halving something — and what it halves in *sendero* is the road itself. Spanish also has *camino* for the larger sort of road. So the language kept the Roman distinction: one word for the way everybody takes, another for the way through the trees.

What you’ve built

One word, and the start of a way out.

You have had *la salida* since the departure words. A *salida* is where you leave; a *sendero* is what you leave along. The two fit together, and this run is going to keep fitting things onto the end of them.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el sendero*
- *el sendero del bosque*
- *la salida*, then *el sendero*

Before you move on

What was *semita*? (A footpath.) What does the *semi-* in it mean? (Half.) And what is *el sendero*? (The path.)

295.2 el puente — why the pope is a bridge-builder

Two back: what was *scopa*? (A twig.) And what does the *semi-* in *sendero* mean? (Half.)

What to know first

- el sendero — what this carries across.
- el lago — the sort of thing it goes over.

Sounds you'll need

- *PUEN-te*, stress on the first part. The *ue* is one slide, the same as in *pueblo* and *cuello*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el puente — “the bridge.”

Latin **pons**, and in its other form **pontem**. There is the *o*-to-*ue* break for the third time — *pueblo*, *cuello*, and now *puente*. By this point you should be able to predict it.

The English relatives are worth the detour. A **pontoon** is a floating bridge. To **pontificate** is to speak as a **pontiff** does — and *pontifex*, the Roman priestly title the popes inherited, is *pons* plus *facere*: a bridge-maker. Nobody is certain whether the Roman priests literally maintained the bridge over the Tiber or whether the bridge was always a metaphor for the link between people and gods. Both stories have been told for two thousand years.

Spanish also uses *puente* for a long weekend — the days that bridge a holiday to the nearest Saturday. It is the same idea, doing modern work.

What you've built

Two, and the way out now crosses something.

El sendero and *el puente*. You also have the *ue* break confirmed three times over, which means the next unfamiliar Spanish word with *ue* in the middle is probably a Latin *o* you already know in English.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el puente*
- *el sendero y el puente*
- *pueblo, cuello, puente* — the same break three times

Before you move on

What was *pontem*? (A bridge.) What does *pontifex* mean, taken apart? (Bridge-maker.) And which Latin vowel became *ue*? (Short *o*.)

295.3 la orilla — the sixth little one

Before the new one: what was *pontem*? (A bridge.) And what was *semita*? (A footpath.)

What to know first

- el lago — one thing that has one.
- el puente — what joins two of them.

Sounds you'll need

- *o-RI-lla*, stress in the middle. The *r* between vowels is a single tap, not rolled. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la orilla — “the shore,” “the bank,” “the edge.”

Latin **ora** meant a border or an edge — of a country, of a garment, of the sea. Spanish added the small ending and got *orilla*, “the little edge,” and then used it for all three of those things at once.

That breadth is the useful part. The bank of a river is *la orilla*. The shore of a lake is *la orilla*. The hem of a cloth is *la orilla*. One word covers every place where a thing stops being itself, which is a lot of ground for four syllables.

And there is the small ending for the sixth time — an onion, a seed, a knee, an ankle, a knife, and now an edge. Six words with nothing in common except the way they were built. When you meet a new Spanish word ending in *-illa* or *-illo*, take the ending off and look underneath: the plain word is often waiting there, and is often one you already have.

What you've built

Three, and the route now reaches water: *el sendero, el puente, la orilla*. The diminutive has become a genuine tool rather than a piece of trivia. That is worth more than any single one of the six words that taught it to you.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la orilla*
- *la orilla del lago*
- *el sendero, el puente, la orilla*

Before you move on

What did *ora* mean? (An edge, a border.) Name three things that have *una orilla*. (A river, a lake, a cloth.) And what does *-illa* add? (Smallness.)

295.4 la isla — and the silent letter English added by mistake

Quick pass: what did *ora* mean? (An edge.) What was *pontem*? (A bridge.) And what was *semita*? (A footpath.)

What to know first

- *la orilla* — what one is entirely made of.
- *el agua* — what is round it.

Sounds you'll need

- *IS-la*, two beats, stress on the first. The *s* is clean and unvoiced, never a *z* sound. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la isla — “the island.”

Latin **insula**, and Spanish simply let the *n* go: *insula*, *isla*. The English words kept it. Something **insular** has an island’s outlook. To **isolate** is to make an island of somebody — that one came back through Italian *isolato*. A **peninsula** is *paene insula*, “almost an island.” And **insulin** was named for the little islands of cells in the pancreas that produce it.

English **isle** has a stranger history. It came from French *île*, with no *s* in it and none pronounced. Scholars later inserted the *s* to make the word look more like *insula*, and it has sat there silently ever since. Then the same scholars put an *s* into **island**, which is not from Latin at all and never had one.

So *isla* dropped a letter honestly and *isle* gained one dishonestly, and the two words now look almost the same for opposite reasons.

What you’ve built

Four, and the way out has run as far as it can go: *el sendero*, *el puente*, *la orilla*, *la isla*.

Path, crossing, edge, and the thing past the edge. Four words that put you somewhere, and the last of them arrived with four English relatives and a spelling scandal attached.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la isla*
- *la orilla de la isla*
- *el sendero*, *el puente*, *la orilla*, *la isla*

Before you move on

What was *insula*? (An island.) What does *peninsula* say, taken apart? (Almost an island.) And why does *isle* have an *s*? (Scholars put it there to imitate Latin.)

295.5 la niebla — the word that was promised

Before the last of the five: what was *insula*? (An island.) What did *ora* mean? (An edge.) And what was *pontem*? (A bridge.)

What to know first

- la nube — the near-cousin, set aside earlier for this.
- la orilla — where it sits thickest.

Sounds you'll need

- *NIE*-bla, stress on the first part. The *ie* is one slide, and the *b* is soft between the vowel and the *l*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la niebla — “the mist,” “the fog.”

When *la nube* was taken apart, one word was deliberately left on the shelf: **nebula**, which Latin used for mist as against *nubes* for cloud.

This is that word, arrived at last.

The road from *nebula* to *niebla* is short. The short *e* broke into *ie*, as it did in *cielo* and *miel*. The *-bul-* in the middle collapsed to *-bl-*, which Spanish does whenever an unstressed vowel finds itself between two consonants it can be spared from.

English kept *nebula* whole and gave it to astronomy, for the faint clouds between the stars. Something **nebulous** is misty in the figurative sense — an idea you cannot get an edge on. Which is a good word to end a run on, since the whole point of taking words apart is to make them less nebulous than they were.

What you've built

Five: *el sendero*, *el puente*, *la orilla*, *la isla*, *la niebla*.

Read in order they are a way out of a place — the path, the crossing, the water's edge, the land beyond it, and the weather closing in behind you.

This run also shuts a circle. It opened with a cloud and closes with the mist that Latin kept carefully separate from it, and the two words have been waiting for each other since. That is the argument for taking a word apart rather than memorising it: the pieces you find keep turning

up, and they keep paying.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la niebla*
- *la nube*, then *la niebla* — the cloud and the mist
- all five — *el sendero*, *el puente*, *la orilla*, *la isla*, *la niebla*

Before you move on

What was *nebula*, as against *nubes*? (Mist, not cloud.) What did the short *e* become? (*Ie.*) And what does *nebulous* mean? (Misty — an idea with no clear edge.)

Chapter 296

Animals About the House — Horse, Cow, Sheep, Hen, Donkey

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the horse, the cow, the sheep, the hen and the donkey in Spanish.

Complete ES-C296-burro: name all five animals in order, and say which one English took back off Spanish.

296.1 el caballo — the plodder that won

Before a new run: what was *insula*? (An island.) And what did *nebula* mean, as against *nubes*? (Mist, not cloud.)

What to know first

- perro — an animal you have had for a long time.
- gato — the other one.

Sounds you'll need

- *ca-BA-llo*, stress in the middle. The *b* is soft between vowels, and the *ll* is the *y* of *llueve*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el caballo — “the horse.”

Latin had two words for the animal. **Equus** was the horse of poetry and of the cavalry parade. **Caballus** was the other one: a plodding, thick-legged work-horse, close to “nag.” Educated Romans wrote *equus*. And *caballus* is the one that survived. Not just in Spanish — French *cheval*, Italian *cavallo*, Portuguese *cavalo*. The polite word went into the museum and the stable word went into every mouth in western Europe.

English is full of the plodder without knowing it. **Cavalry** is soldiers on *caballi*. A **cavalier** was one of them. And **chivalry** is the same word again, worn down through French — so the most elevated idea the Middle Ages had is named after a nag.

What you’ve built

One animal, and a rule of thumb worth more than the animal. When Latin had a grand word and a plain word for the same thing, bet on the plain one. That is what people actually said, and what people actually said is what became Spanish.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el caballo*
- *el caballo* and *el perro*, one after the other
- *el caballo del pueblo*

Before you move on

Which Latin word won, *equus* or *caballus*? (*Caballus*.) What kind of horse was it? (A plain work-horse.) And which English word for soldiers on horseback holds it? (*Cavalry*.)

296.2 la vaca — the animal inside a medical word

Two back: what did *nebula* name? (The mist.) And which Latin horse won, the grand one or the plain one? (The plain

one, *caballus*.)

What to know first

- el caballo — the animal before this one.
- el queso — what this one is behind.

Sounds you'll need

- VA-ca, stress on the first part. The *v* is the same sound as *b*, and the *c* before *a* is hard. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la vaca — “the cow.”

There is almost nothing to take apart. Latin **vacca**, Spanish *vaca*: one consonant thinned and the rest left alone. Some words travel two thousand years and arrive with their hat still on.

The interesting part is in English. In the seventeen-nineties Edward Jenner noticed that dairymaids who had caught cowpox did not catch smallpox, and he built a treatment on it. He named it from **vaccinus**, Latin for “of the cow” — so **vaccine**, and every vaccine since, is named after this animal.

Nothing about a modern vaccine involves a cow. The name is a fossil of the first one, in the way *la salida* is a fossil of somebody actually going out.

What you've built

Two animals, and a word English uses every day without knowing whose it is.

El caballo is the plodder who beat the parade horse. *La vaca* is the one who arrived unchanged and lent her name to medicine.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la vaca*
- *el caballo*, then *la vaca*
- *la vaca del valle*

Before you move on

What was *vacca*? (A cow.) What does *vaccinus* mean? (Of the cow.) And why is a vaccine called that? (The first one came from cowpox.)

296.3 la oveja — the small one that ate the big one

What kind of horse was a *caballus*? (A plain work-horse.) And what is *vaccinus*? (Of the cow.)

What to know first

- la vaca — the animal before this one.
- la manta — often made of what this animal grows.

Sounds you'll need

- *o-VE-ja*, stress in the middle. The *j* is the scrape at the back of the mouth, the *jota*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la oveja — “the sheep.”

Latin's word was **ovis**. Alongside it people used **ovicula**, with the ending that makes a thing small and fond — the ancestor of the *-illo* and *-ito* you can hear all over Spanish. *Ovicula* meant something like “little sheep.”

Then the odd thing. *Ovis* died out completely, and the small fond version took over the whole job. Spanish has no word left that means “sheep, full size, unsentimentally.” Every sheep is a little one now. That happens more often than you would think. Latin **auricula**, a little ear, gave French *oreille* and Spanish *oreja* by exactly the same road — which is why *oveja* and *oreja* rhyme. The plain word for ear went the way of *ovis*.

The English cousin stayed formal: **ovine** means “of sheep,” and it comes straight from *ovis*, the word Spanish threw away.

What you've built

Three animals, and a second rule to sit beside the first.
The plain word does not always win by staying plain. Sometimes it wins by shrinking: the affectionate version gets said so often that it stops sounding affectionate and simply becomes the word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la oveja*
- *la vaca*, then *la oveja*
- all three — *el caballo*, *la vaca*, *la oveja*

Before you move on

What was *ovis*? (A sheep.) What did the *-icula* ending do to it? (Made it small and fond.) And which of the two survived into Spanish? (The small one.)

296.4 la gallina — the bird that is also an insult

Three questions. Which horse won? (The plain one.) What is *vaccinus*? (Of the cow.) And what did *-icula* do to *ovis*? (Made it small.)

What to know first

- *la oveja* — the animal before this one.
- *el huevo* — what this one leaves you.

Sounds you'll need

- *ga-LLI-na*, stress in the middle. The *g* before *a* is hard, and the *ll* is a *y*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la gallina — “the hen.”

Latin **gallus** was the cock, and **gallina** was made from it with the ending that marks the female. The pair came through intact: Spanish still has *gallo* for the one and *gallina* for the other.

English keeps *gallina* only in its Sunday clothes. **Gallinaceous** is what a zoologist calls the whole family of birds that scratch about on the ground — hens, pheasants, turkeys. Nobody says it at breakfast. The part worth having is not the bird. In Spanish, *ser un gallina* — to be a hen — means to be a coward. English says **chicken** for exactly the same thing, and neither language borrowed the idea from the other. Two peoples watched the same animal and reached the same unkind conclusion.

What you’ve built

Four animals, and the first of them that carries an opinion.

El caballo, *la vaca* and *la oveja* are only themselves. *La gallina* is also a judgement about somebody, which makes it the first of the four you could be insulted with.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la gallina*
- *la oveja*, then *la gallina*
- all four — *el caballo*, *la vaca*, *la oveja*, *la gallina*

Before you move on

What was *gallus*? (The cock.) What does *gallinaceous* describe? (The whole ground-scratching family of birds.) And what does calling somebody *un gallina* mean? (That they are a coward.)

296.5 el burro — the one English took whole

Before the last of the five: which horse won, the grand one or the plain one? (The plain one.) What was *ovis*? (A sheep.) And

what does *un gallina* call somebody? (A coward.)

What to know first

- el caballo — what this one is the small, stubborn version of.
- la gallina — the animal before this one.

Sounds you'll need

- *BU-rro*, stress on the first part. The *rr* is a full roll, not a single tap — the difference is real and it is the only difference here. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el burro — “the donkey.”

Behind it is late Latin **burricus**, a small horse, and behind that **burrus**, “reddish” — the colour of the animal, borrowed by Latin from Greek. So a donkey is, quite literally, a little red horse. Which puts it in the same family as *el caballo*, at a distance and going downhill.

Now the direction reverses. English did not inherit this word; it **borrowed** it, from Spanish speakers in the American southwest, and it borrowed it whole: **burro**, spelled and said the Spanish way. And then it borrowed the small version too. A **burrito** is a little donkey — nobody is certain why the food took the name, but the name is not a mystery at all once you have *burro*.

That *-ito* is the same ending you met flattening *ovis* into *oveja*, still at work and still making things small.

What you've built

Five: *el caballo*, *la vaca*, *la oveja*, *la gallina*, *el burro*.

Read in order they are a farmyard, and they arrived by four different routes: a word that beat its own posh rival, a word that barely changed, a word that only survived by shrinking, a pair kept together, and a word English took back off Spanish long after Latin had finished with it.

Traffic in words is not one-way, and this run ends on the one going the other direction.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el burro*
- *el caballo*, then *el burro* — the horse and the little red one
- all five — *el caballo, la vaca, la oveja, la gallina, el burro*

Before you move on

What did *burrus* mean? (Reddish.) Which language took *burro* from which? (English took it from Spanish.) And what is a *burrito*, taken literally? (A little donkey.)

Chapter 297

More of the Kitchen — Pan, Oven, Fork, Garlic, Soup

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the pan, the oven, the fork, the garlic and the soup in Spanish, and thank somebody for the meal.

Complete ES-C297-sopa: name all five of the kitchen in order and thank somebody for what came out of it.

297.1 la sartén — the accent that is a receipt

Before a new run: what does *un gallina* call somebody? (A coward.) And what did *burrus* mean? (Reddish.)

What to know first

- la olla — the deep one you already have.
- el plato — where the food ends up.

Sounds you'll need

- *sar-TÉN*, stress on the very end, which is what the written accent is telling you. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la sartén — “the frying pan,” the shallow one you fry in.

Latin **sartago** was already exactly that, and the Romans already fried in it. The word came down through the sideways form *sartaginem*, which is where the *-n* on the end comes from.

The accent is the part worth stopping on. Spanish only writes one when the stress falls somewhere the default rules would not put it, so an accent is never decoration — it is a receipt. A word ending in *-n* is expected to be stressed on the part before last. *Sartén* is not, so it must say so.

Now make it plural and watch the receipt get handed back: *sartenes* ends in *-s* and is stressed on the part before last, which is exactly what the rules already predict. No accent needed, so no accent written. The mark did not move; the reason for it disappeared.

What you’ve built

A pan, and a small piece of proof that the accents are not arbitrary. If you can say why *sartén* wears one and *sartenes* does not, you can predict the mark on most words you meet rather than memorising it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la sartén*
- *la sartén*, then *las sartenes* — hear the stress stay put
- *la olla*, then *la sartén*

Before you move on

What was *sartago*? (A frying pan.) Why does *sartén* wear an accent? (Because the stress is final and a word ending in *-n* would not be.) And why does *sartenes* not? (The rules already predict its stress.)

297.2 el horno — an f buried under an h

Two back: what is a *burrito*, taken literally? (A little donkey.)
And why does *sartén* carry an accent? (Its stress is final, against the rule.)

What to know first

- $f \rightarrow h$ — the change this word is a specimen of.
- *la sartén* — the shallow one, from just before.

Sounds you'll need

- *OR-no*, stress on the first part. The *h* is written and not said, which is the whole point of it. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el horno — “the oven.”

Latin **furnus**, an oven or a bakehouse. You already know what happened to the *f*: it thinned to a breathy sound, the breath faded, and Spanish went on writing the letter over the empty space. *Furnus* to *forno* to *horno*.

So the *h* is a headstone. Say *OR-no* and you are saying the word correctly; the letter is there to tell you what used to be.

English took the same Latin word later and by a different door, straight out of the books, so it never got worn down: a **furnace** still has its *f*, and so does the older sense of **furnish** — to supply, as a bakehouse supplies bread.

One more thing you can now do. Meet an unfamiliar Spanish word beginning with a silent *h*, put an *f* back on the front, and see whether a Latin or English word falls out. It works often enough to be worth trying every time.

What you've built

Two of the kitchen, and a decoder you can run on strangers.

La sartén explained a mark you can see. *El horno* explains a letter you cannot hear. Both are the same lesson: written Spanish keeps records, and the records are readable.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el horno*
- *la sartén*, then *el horno*
- *el pan del horno*

Before you move on

What was *furnus*? (An oven.) What is the *h* in *horno* marking? (An *f* that wore away.) And which English word kept the *f*? (*Furnace*.)

297.3 el tenedor — a word you can build yourself

What was *sartago*? (A frying pan.) And what letter is hiding under the *h* of *horno*? (An *f*.)

What to know first

- *tener* — the word this one is built out of.
- *la cuchara* — the one you already ask for.

Sounds you'll need

- *te-ne-DOR*, stress on the very end. No accent is written, because a word ending in *-r* is expected to be stressed there. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el tenedor — “the fork.”

This one you can almost assemble from parts you own. Take *tener*, to hold. Add **-dor**, the ending that names whoever or whatever does the thing. A *tenedor* is “a holder” — which is a very level-headed description of the object, once you stop seeing a fork and start seeing four prongs gripping a piece of meat.

The ending is everywhere once you look. A *comedor* is where the eating is done. A *mirador* is a place for looking out. English has the very same ending twice over — **-or** in *inventor*, *conductor*, and its

plainer cousin **-er** in *holder* itself — because both descend from the same Latin.

Notice what that buys you. *Tenedor* is not a word to memorise; it is a word to work out, and so is the next one built the same way.

What you've built

Three of the kitchen, and the first of them you could have predicted. A pan is a pan and an oven is an oven. A *tenedor* is a machine for holding, named by exactly that, and *la cuchara* lying next to it is now the one word of the pair that has to be remembered rather than deduced.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el tenedor*
- *la cuchara* and *el tenedor*, one after the other
- *el tenedor, por favor*

Before you move on

What does *tener* mean? (To hold, to have.) What does the ending *-dor* add? (The one who does it.) So what is a *tenedor*, literally? (A holder.)

297.4 el ajo — two letters, a long history

Three questions. Why does *sartén* wear an accent? (Final stress, against the rule.) What is under the *h* of *horno*? (An *f*.) And what is a *tenedor*, literally? (A holder.)

What to know first

- *la cebolla* — what it usually goes in the pan with.
- *la sartén* — the pan in question.

Sounds you'll need

- *A-jo*, two beats and no more. The *j* is the scrape at the back, the *jota*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el ajo — “the garlic.”

Latin **allium**. Three syllables have been squeezed down to two letters and a scrape, and yet the road is short: *allium* to *aljo* to *ajo*, with the doubled *l* hardening into the *jota* on the way, exactly as it did in *hijo* from *filium*.

English kept *allium* whole and handed it to the botanists, so the family that holds garlic, onions and leeks is the **allium** family on any seed packet.

The best cousin is on a menu. **Aioli** is Provençal *ai* plus *oli*: garlic and oil, which is the entire recipe stated in the name. Say *ajo* and you are saying the first half of a sauce you already know.

What you've built

Four of the kitchen, and the shortest word of the run carrying the longest history.

La cebolla and *el ajo* go into *la sartén* together in more Spanish cooking than any two other things. You can now name the pan, the fire, the tool and half the contents.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el ajo*
- *el ajo y la cebolla*
- all four — *la sartén, el horno, el tenedor, el ajo*

Before you move on

What was *allium*? (Garlic.) Where does English still use the whole word? (As the botanical family name.) And what two things is *aioli* named after? (Garlic and oil.)

297.5 la sopa — the bread, not the liquid

Before the last of the five: what does the ending *-dor* add? (The one who does it.) What letter hides under an *h*? (An *f*.) And what was *allium*? (Garlic.)

What to know first

- *el pan* — what this word originally meant.
- *la cuchara* — what you eat it with.

Sounds you'll need

- *SO-pa*, stress on the first part. The *s* is clean and never buzzes.
→ reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la sopa — “the soup.”

This one is not Latin. It came from the Germanic speakers who arrived as Rome went out, and their **suppa** did not mean the liquid at all. It meant the piece of bread you dropped into the liquid.

That is the older meal, and the honest one: broth was cheap and bread was the food. The name travelled with the bread and only later slid across to what the bread was floating in.

English has the whole family, and the same slide. A **sop** is still a bit of bread dipped in something. To **sup** is to take it, and **supper** is the meal where you did. **Soup** itself came back into English through French — the same Germanic word, one lap later.

So *el pan* is not merely something you eat with *la sopa*. It is what *la sopa* used to be.

What you've built

Five: *la sartén*, *el horno*, *el tenedor*, *el ajo*, *la sopa*.

A pan, a fire, a tool, a flavour and a dish — enough to describe most of what happens in a kitchen before anybody sits down. And when somebody puts it in front of you, *mil gracias* is the size of thanks it deserves.

The five arrived by five different roads: a Latin pan, a Latin oven with its letter worn off, a word Spanish built for itself, a Latin plant, and a

Germanic crust. That is the mix Spanish is actually made of, in one meal.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la sopa*
- *la sopa, mil gracias*
- all five — *la sartén, el horno, el tenedor, el ajo, la sopa*

Before you move on

What did *suppa* mean first — the bread or the broth? (The bread.) Which English meal is named from it? (*Supper*.) And what is *la sopa*? (The soup.)

Chapter 298

Five More Short Answers — Maybe, Could Be, Indeed, No Doubt, Out of the Question

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can answer someone in Spanish anywhere from maybe to out of the question, and say how strong each answer is.

Complete ES-C298-ni-hablar: give all five answers in order, from the weakest to the flattest.

298.1 tal vez — such a turn

Before a new run: what was *allium*? (Garlic.) And did *suppa* mean the bread or the broth? (The bread.)

What to know first

- quizás — the other way to say this, which you already have.
- de acuerdo — the answer at the opposite end.

Sounds you'll need

- *tal VEZ*, with the weight on the second word. The *v* is a *b*, and the *z* is a plain *s* in most of the Spanish-speaking world. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

tal vez — “maybe,” “perhaps.”

Two pieces. *Tal* means “such,” and *vez* is Latin **vicem**: a turn, a going round, one occasion out of several. So *tal vez* is “such a turn” — this time it might fall this way, another time it might not.

Vicem is generous to English. **Vice versa** is “the turn having been turned.” A **vicar** stands in someone’s turn, and so does a **vice-president**. **Vicissitude** is life doing the turning without asking you.

You already have *quizás* for the same job. The difference is small but real: *quizás* leans on not knowing, and *tal vez* leans on it happening to fall out that way. Either answers a question you cannot answer.

What you’ve built

The first of five answers, and the least committed of them.

The run ahead is a dial. It starts here, at “possibly,” and ends somewhere you would not want to point at a stranger.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *tal vez*
- *quizás*, then *tal vez*
- *tal vez mañana*

Before you move on

What did *vicem* mean? (A turn, an occasion.) What is *vice versa*, taken literally? (The turn turned round.) And what does *tal vez* answer? (Maybe.)

298.2 puede ser — nothing new in it

Two back: what did *suppa* mean? (The soaked bread.) And what does *vicem* mean inside *tal vez*? (A turn, an occasion.)

What to know first

- poder — the first half.
- ser — the second.

Sounds you'll need

- *PUE-de SER*, two beats then one. The *ue* is a single slide, not two steps. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

puede ser — “could be,” “it may be so.”

There is nothing here you do not already own. *Poder*, to be able, with its stressed *o* cracking open into *ue* the way it always does. *Ser*, to be. Put them together and you have said “it is able to be,” which is a very exact description of what “maybe” actually claims.

That is worth noticing on its own. Some of the most useful things you can say in a language are not new material at all — they are two familiar pieces standing in the right order, and the only thing you were missing was permission to put them there.

Against *tal vez*, this one is warmer. *Tal vez* is a shrug at the odds.

Puede ser concedes that the other person might be right, which is why it so often comes just before somebody changes their mind.

What you've built

Two answers, and a way of getting more of them free.

Every time you learn a piece, you also learn every combination that piece can stand in. *Puede ser* costs you nothing but the knowledge that Spanish speakers say it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *puede ser*
- *tal vez*, then *puede ser*
- *puede ser*, *no sé*

Before you move on

Which two pieces make *puede ser*? (*Poder* and *ser*.) What happens to the *o* of *poder* under stress? (It breaks into *ue*.) And which of the two answers so far concedes the most? (*Puede ser*.)

298.3 *en efecto* — a false friend with a warning on it

What does *tal vez* answer? (Maybe.) And which two pieces make *puede ser*? (*Poder* and *ser*.)

What to know first

- *exacto* — the answer this one stands next to.
- *hacer* — the doing that sits inside it.

Sounds you'll need

- *en e-FEC-to*, stress on the third beat. The *c* before *t* is a hard *k*.
→ reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

en efecto — “indeed,” “quite so.”

Efecto is Latin **effectus**: *ex*, out, and *facere*, to do — a thing carried out and finished. The same *facere* you have been meeting inside *hacer* since early on.

Now the warning. English **in effect** looks like the same phrase letter for letter, and it is not. *In effect* means “for practical purposes, though not formally” — it softens a claim. *En efecto* hardens one: it says the thing someone just told you is so.

That is what makes it worth having. *Exacto* agrees with a statement’s precision. *En efecto* agrees with the fact of it, and it is the one you will hear from somebody reading a document out loud and finding it says what you claimed.

Two words that look identical and pull in opposite directions is the most expensive kind of pair there is, because nothing warns you. This one is warned.

What you've built

Three answers, and the dial has turned. *Tal vez* is a shrug, *puede ser* is a concession, and *en efecto* is agreement with the evidence in hand.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *en efecto*
- *exacto*, then *en efecto*
- all three — *tal vez*, *puede ser*, *en efecto*

Before you move on

What two pieces are in *effectus*? (*Ex*, out, and *facere*, to do.) Does *en efecto* soften a claim or confirm one? (It confirms it.) And what does English *in effect* do instead? (It softens.)

298.4 sin duda — caught between two

Three answers so far. Which is the shrug? (*Tal vez*.) Which concedes? (*Puede ser*.) And which confirms? (*En efecto*.)

What to know first

- *seguro* — the answer nearest to this one.
- *en efecto* — the answer just before it.

Sounds you'll need

- *sin DU-da*, weight on the second word. Both *d* sounds are soft, the tongue barely touching. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

sin duda — “no doubt,” “certainly.”

Duda comes from Latin **dubitare**, to waver, and *dubitare* is built on **duo**, two. To doubt is to have two answers in front of you and no way

to pick. That is a much better picture of the state than the English word gives you.

The same *duo* is all over English. **Dubious**, obviously. **Double**, less obviously. And **doubt** itself, which came through French as *doute* with no *b* in it at all — the *b* was inserted centuries later by scholars who wanted the Latin visible. English still writes it and still does not say it, which is exactly what Spanish does with the *h* of *horno*.

So *sin duda* is “without the two”: there is only one answer available, and this is it.

What you’ve built

Four answers, and the dial is near its top. *Sin duda* is stronger than *en efecto*, because *en efecto* agrees with what was said and *sin duda* says there was never anything else to agree with.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *sin duda*
- *seguro*, then *sin duda*
- all four — *tal vez*, *puede ser*, *en efecto*, *sin duda*

Before you move on

What number is inside *dubitare*? (Two.) Why does English write a *b* in *doubt*? (Scholars put it back to show the Latin.) And how strong is *sin duda*? (Very — there is no second answer.)

298.5 ni hablar — not even that

Before the last of the five: which answer is the shrug? (*Tal vez*.) What is inside *dubitare*? (*Duo*, two.) And does *en efecto* soften or confirm? (It confirms.)

What to know first

- *ni* — the first half, which you have had for a long time.
- *hablar* — the second.

Sounds you'll need

- *ni a-BLAR*, and the *h* is silent, so the two words run straight into each other. The *r* at the end is one tap. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ni hablar — “out of the question,” “no chance.”

Again, nothing new. *Ni* is “nor, not even.” *Hablar* is to speak.

Together: “not even speaking of it.” The refusal is not of the request — it is of the conversation about the request, which is a good deal more final.

English has the same manoeuvre in **out of the question** and in **don't even**. None of these say no to the thing; they say the thing is not eligible to be discussed, and that is why they close a subject where a plain no would only invite another round.

A caution. This is flat, and among strangers it can be rude. With friends it is ordinary, and often affectionate — the way English *don't even* can be. Keep *no, gracias* for people you have just met.

What you've built

Five: *tal vez, puede ser, en efecto, sin duda, ni hablar*.

Read in order they are a dial that runs from “possibly” through “yes, evidently” to “we are not discussing this.” Two of the five you built out of pieces you already owned, and one of them warned you about a word that looks like English and is not.

Answers are cheap to learn and dear to get wrong. Knowing which end of this dial you are standing on matters more than any single one of them.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ni hablar*

- *sin duda*, then *ni hablar* — the two ends
- all five — *tal vez*, *puede ser*, *en efecto*, *sin duda*, *ni hablar*

Before you move on

What does *ni hablar* refuse — the request, or the conversation? (The conversation.) Which two words is it made of? (*Ni* and *hablar*.) And which of the five would you use with somebody you had just met? (Not this one.)

Chapter 299

The Field and the Farm — Field, Farm, Livestock, Harvest, Shepherd

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the field, the farm, the livestock, the harvest and the shepherd in Spanish, and say I am from the country.

Complete ES-C299-pastor: name all five of a holding in order, and say what three of them were named after.

299.1 el campo — flat ground, and everything pitched on it

Before a new run: what is inside *dubitare*? (*Duo*, two.) And what does *ni hablar* refuse? (The conversation, not just the request.)

What to know first

- el pueblo — what usually sits in the middle of it.
- el valle — the shape of the land it lies in.

Sounds you'll need

- *CAM-po*, stress on the first part. The *c* before *a* is hard. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el campo — “the field,” and also “the countryside,” everything that is not the town.

Latin **campus** meant flat open ground — not a farmer’s field particularly, just level land with nothing on it. Which is precisely why so much got pitched there.

An army stopped on flat ground, so a **camp** is one. A season of fighting was spent out on it, so a **campaign** is one. Whoever fought for a village in single combat was its *campio*, the man of the field, which is English **champion**. And when American colleges wanted a word for their grounds, they took **campus** back whole and unchanged. So the same flat ground gave English a tent, a war, a hero and a university. And it gave Spanish the word for everywhere that is not a town: *vivo en el campo* means you live out there, among the fields, whether or not you farm.

What you’ve built

The ground itself, before anything is put on it.

El pueblo is where people are; *el campo* is what surrounds it. Between them you can already say roughly where somebody is from, which is most of what that question ever wants.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el campo*
- *el pueblo*, then *el campo*
- *soy del campo*

Before you move on

What did *campus* mean? (Flat open ground.) What was a *campio*? (The man who fought on it — a champion.) And what does *el campo* mean besides a field? (The countryside.)

299.2 la granja — a building named after what is in it

Two back: what does *ni hablar* refuse? (The conversation.) And what did *campus* mean? (Flat open ground.)

What to know first

- el trigo — what this building was built to hold.
- el campo — the ground it stands on.

Sounds you'll need

- *GRAN-ja*, stress on the first part. The *g* is hard, and the *j* is the scrape. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la granja — “the farm.”

Behind it is Latin **granum**, the grain — the same grain you met being rubbed out of its husk in *el trigo*. A *granja* began as the building where that grain was kept, and then the name spread outwards over the yard, the animals and the whole holding.

English has the identical building twice. A **granary** is where the grain goes. A **grange** is the farmhouse that grew up around one, which is why so many English villages have a Grange in them and nobody remembers why.

This is a common way for names to work. The store gives its name to the farm, the way *la sopa* took its name from the bread rather than the broth. The thing you kept was more worth naming than the place you kept it.

What you've built

The ground and now the buildings on it.

You have had *el trigo* for a while as something that grows. *La granja* is where it stops being a crop and starts being a store, and *el campo* is the flat land both of them sit on.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la granja*
- *el campo*, then *la granja*
- *el trigo de la granja*

Before you move on

What is *granum*? (The grain.) What was a *granja* before it was a farm? (The place the grain was stored.) And which English farmhouse is the same word? (A grange.)

299.3 el ganado — the animals as a bank account

What did *campus* mean? (Flat open ground.) And what was a *granja* before it was a farm? (Where the grain was stored.)

What to know first

- *la vaca* — one of these, counted singly.
- *el dinero* — what this word is really about.

Sounds you'll need

- *ga-NA-do*, stress in the middle. The *g* is hard and the *d* between vowels is soft, almost a *th*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el ganado — “the livestock,” the animals of a farm taken together. It is built on *ganar*, to gain or to win, and it means, quite plainly, “what has been gained.” Not the beasts as creatures. The beasts as the thing you have got.

English did exactly the same and hid it better. **Cattle** and **chattel** are one word split in two, both from Latin *capitalis*, “of the head” — property counted by the head. And *capitalis* also gave **capital**, the money sense. So in English, as in Spanish, the herd and the fortune are the same idea.

That is why *el ganado* covers cows and sheep and pigs without distinction. It is not a word about animals at all. It is a word about wealth that happens to walk around.

What you’ve built

Ground, buildings, and now the animals — and the animals turn out to be an account.

La vaca is one cow. *El ganado* is the whole herd seen from the ledger, which is how a farmer in any century has actually seen it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el ganado*
- *la granja*, then *el ganado*
- *el ganado del campo*

Before you move on

What does *ganar* mean? (To gain, to win.) So what is *el ganado* literally? (What has been gained.) And which English word for money comes from counting animals by the head? (*Capital*.)

299.4 la cosecha — a root you have met before

Three questions. What did *campus* mean? (Flat open ground.) What is *granum*? (Grain.) And what is *el ganado*, literally?

(What has been gained.)

What to know first

- tomar — where you first took *colligere* apart.
- la semilla — where this ends up starting again.

Sounds you'll need

- *co-SE-cha*, stress in the middle. The *ch* is one sound, as in English *church*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la cosecha — “the harvest,” both the gathering and the crop gathered.

You have already done the hard part of this one. When *tomar* was taken apart, the word Latin actually left behind turned out to be *coger*, from **colligere** — *com-*, together, and *legere*, to pick. That is where **collect** comes from, and **coil**, and the *leer* you read with.

Cosecha is the same word wearing its finished-and-done form:

collecta, “the gathered-in.” So the harvest is not named for cutting or for work. It is named for the picking-up afterwards, which is the part that counts.

One use worth knowing. On a wine label, *una buena cosecha* is a good vintage — English does the same thing, since a **vintage** is only a harvest with a year attached to it.

What you've built

Four of the farm, and one of them cost you almost nothing.

Colligere was already in your hands. All that was new here was which shape it takes when the picking is over, and now the same root is doing work in three places at once.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la cosecha*
- *la granja* and *la cosecha*, one after the other

- all four — *el campo, la granja, el ganado, la cosecha*

Before you move on

Which two pieces are in *colligere*? (*Com-*, together, and *legere*, to pick.) Which English word is it most plainly? (*Collect*.) And what does *una buena cosecha* mean on a bottle? (A good vintage.)

299.5 el pastor — the one who feeds

Before the last of the five: what did *campus* mean? (Flat open ground.) What is *el ganado* literally? (What has been gained.) And which two pieces are in *colligere*? (*Com-* and *legere*.)

What to know first

- la oveja — what this person walks behind.
- el maestro — another person named for what they do.

Sounds you'll need

- *pas-TOR*, stress on the end, and no accent needed because a word ending in *-r* is expected there. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el pastor — “the shepherd.”

Latin **pascere** meant to put animals out to feed, and *pastor* was the one who did it. Note what is not in the word: nothing about sheep, nothing about walking, nothing about a crook. Only the feeding. That single idea fans out a long way in English. A **pasture** is the ground the animals are fed on. A **repast** is a meal — a feeding, taken again. And a **pastor** in a church is a shepherd of people, a metaphor so old it has stopped sounding like one.

The ending is the *-or* you met on *el tenedor*: the one who does the thing. So *pastor* parses as neatly as *tenedor* did, once you know that the thing being done is feeding.

What you've built

Five: *el campo, la granja, el ganado, la cosecha, el pastor*.

Read in order they are a whole holding: the ground, the buildings, the animals, what comes off the land, and the person who keeps it moving. Say *soy del campo* and every one of them is behind the sentence.

And three of the five were named for something other than themselves — a farm for its grain, a herd for its value, a harvest for the gathering. Spanish names things by what they are for. Once you expect that, half the words explain themselves.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el pastor*
- *el pastor y la oveja*
- all five — *el campo, la granja, el ganado, la cosecha, el pastor*

Before you move on

What did *pascere* mean? (To put out to feed.) What is a *repast*, at root? (A feeding again — a meal.) And why is a churchman called a pastor? (He is a shepherd of people.)

Chapter 300

What the Body Says — Thirst, Sleep, Skin, Blood, Remedy

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say in Spanish that I am thirsty or sleepy, name the skin and the blood, and say there is no remedy.

Complete ES-C300-remedio: name all five, and put three of them into a sentence with *tengo* or *no hay*.

300.1 la sed — something you hold, not something you are

Before a new run: what does *una buena cosecha* mean on a bottle? (A good vintage.) And what did *pascere* mean? (To put out to feed.)

What to know first

- beber — what this sends you to do.
- tener — the word Spanish uses to report it.

Sounds you'll need

- *SED*, one beat, and the final *d* is barely there — closer to a soft *th* than to an English *d*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la sed — “the thirst.”

Latin **sitis**, worn short. English inherited nothing usable from it, which is rarer than it sounds — most of the body words you have met arrived with a cousin in tow, and this one comes empty-handed.

The interesting part is not where it came from but how Spanish uses it. English says *I am thirsty*, as though thirst were a description of you. Spanish says **tengo sed** — “I have thirst,” as though it were a thing in your hands that you could put down.

Once you notice, it is everywhere: *tengo hambre*, *tengo frío*, *tengo miedo*. Spanish keeps handing you the sensation as an object. English keeps turning it into a description of the person, which quietly makes it more permanent than it is.

Neither is right. But if you say *estoy sed*, a Spanish speaker will hear something ungrammatical, and this is the reason.

What you’ve built

One word, and a habit that will serve you for a dozen more.

When you want to report how your body is, reach for *tengo* first and look for the thing you are holding. That is the Spanish shape.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la sed*
- *tengo sed*
- *tengo sed, agua por favor*

Before you move on

What was *sitis*? (Thirst.) Does Spanish say you are thirsty or that you have thirst? (That you have it.) And what is the whole sentence? (*Tengo sed.*)

300.2 el sueño — one word for two things

Two back: what did *pascere* mean? (To put out to feed.) And does Spanish say you are thirsty, or that you have thirst? (That you have it.)

What to know first

- dormir — the doing; this is the having.
- la cama — where both happen.

Sounds you'll need

- *SUE*-ño, stress on the first part. The *ue* is one slide, and the *ñ* is the *n* with a *y* leaning on it. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el sueño — “sleep,” and also “a dream.”

Latin **somnus**, sleep. The stressed *o* cracked open into *ue*, exactly as it did turning *dormir* into *duermo* and *porta* into *puerta*. Once that crack is familiar you can run it backwards: see *ue* in a Spanish word, put an *o* back, and look for the Latin.

Do it here and *somnus* appears — and with it **insomnia**, which is *in-*, not, plus sleep; **somnolent**, heavy with it; and a **somnambulist**, who walks in it.

The double meaning is worth a moment. *El sueño* is the sleep and the dream at once, and Spanish is content to leave them together. *Tengo sueño* is “I am sleepy” — you are holding sleep, in the way you hold thirst. *Tuve un sueño* is “I had a dream.” Same word, and the difference sits in everything around it.

What you've built

Two of the body, both of them things you hold rather than things you are.

You have had *dormir* for the act since early on. *El sueño* is what the act is made of, and what it leaves behind in the morning.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el sueño*
- *tengo sueño*
- *tengo sed*, then *tengo sueño*

Before you move on

What was *somnus*? (Sleep.) What happened to its stressed *o*? (It broke into *ue*.) And what two things does *el sueño* name? (Sleep and a dream.)

300.3 la piel — the hide you are wearing

What is the Spanish shape for thirst? (*Tengo sed* — you have it.) And what happened to the *o* of *somnus*? (It broke into *ue*.)

What to know first

- la mano — one of the places you can see it best.
- la oveja — an animal people keep partly for hers.

Sounds you'll need

- *PIEL*, one beat. The *ie* is a single slide and the *l* stays bright at the end. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la piel — “the skin.”

Latin **pellis** was a hide — an animal's, taken off. The stressed *e* broke into *ie*, the same crack you have watched in *cielo* and *miel*, and the word came out meaning the skin you are still standing in.

That is worth sitting with. Spanish uses one word for the skin on your arm and the skin a coat is made of. *Una chaqueta de piel* is a leather jacket. Latin drew no line there either, and English mostly does: **skin** for the living one, **hide** and **pelt** for the dead.

Pelt is *pellis* itself, arrived through French. And the strangest cousin is in a church: a **surplice** is *super-pellicium*, the white linen worn **over** the fur coat, because medieval choirs were cold. The garment is named entirely for what is underneath it.

What you've built

Three of the body, and the second one whose *ie* you could have predicted.

Cielo, miel, piel: three words, one crack, and it always runs the same way. Put an *e* back where the *ie* is and the Latin will usually show itself.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la piel*
- *la piel de la mano*
- *el sueño*, then *la piel*

Before you move on

What was *pellis*? (A hide.) Which English word is it, almost untouched? (*Pelt.*) And what is a surplice worn over? (A fur coat.)

300.4 la sangre — a word that used to be a diagnosis

Three questions. What was *sitis*? (Thirst.) What was *somnus*? (Sleep.) And what was *pellis*? (A hide.)

What to know first

- *el vaso* — the word for a vessel, which the body has its own set of.
- *la piel* — what keeps this one where it belongs.

Sounds you'll need

- *SAN-gre*, stress on the first part. The *g* is hard and the *r* is a single tap. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la sangre — “the blood.”

Latin **sanguis**, and through its sideways form **sanguinem**, which is where the *-re* on the end comes from. The road is short and the meaning never moved.

English took the same word and did something odd with it. Medieval medicine held that a person’s temper came from whichever of four fluids ran strongest in them, and somebody with plenty of blood was ruddy, warm and hopeful. That is why **sanguine** still means optimistic — a medical theory abandoned four hundred years ago, fossilised in an ordinary English word.

The plainer cousins are easier. **Consanguinity** is shared blood, which is what a family is. And French gave English **sangfroid**, “cold blood”: the calm of somebody whose blood has not risen.

When you met *el vaso*, you met the word for a vessel, and the body’s own vessels are what this runs through. The two words have been waiting for each other.

What you’ve built

Four of the body: two you hold, one you wear, one that runs underneath.

La sed and *el sueño* are sensations. *La piel* and *la sangre* are the body itself, and between them they are the outside and the inside.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la sangre*
- *la piel*, then *la sangre*
- all four — *la sed*, *el sueño*, *la piel*, *la sangre*

Before you move on

What was *sanguis*? (Blood.) Why does *sanguine* mean cheerful? (An old theory that blood made you ruddy and hopeful.) And what is *sangfroid*, taken literally? (Cold blood.)

300.5 el remedio — healing, taken again

Before the last of the five: what was *sitis*? (Thirst.) What broke into *ue* in *sueño*? (The stressed *o* of *somnus*.) And why does *sanguine* mean cheerful? (An old theory about blood.)

What to know first

- la fiebre — one of the things this is for.
- la enfermera — who is likely to bring it.

Sounds you'll need

- *re-ME-dio*, stress in the middle. The *r* at the start is a single tap, and the *io* at the end is one slide. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el remedio — “the remedy,” the cure, the way out of a trouble. Two pieces. **Re-**, again or back, which you have seen doing this work before. And **mederi**, Latin for to heal or to look after. A *remedium* is a putting-back of health.

Mederi is one of the more productive roots English has. **Medicine** is the healing art. A **medic** is the person practising it. Something **remedial** is meant to put a thing back. All of them come off the same short word.

The phrase to take away is **no hay remedio** — “there is no remedy,” said about a thing that cannot be helped. You already have *hay* and you already have *no*, so the sentence is finished the moment you have this word. It is what a Spanish speaker says with a shrug where English says *it can't be helped*, and it is useful far outside a sickroom.

What you've built

Five: *la sed, el sueño, la piel, la sangre, el remedio*.

Read in order they are a body reporting on itself and then being attended to: two things it wants, two things it is made of, one thing that mends it.

And four of the five you can put into a sentence with words you already had — *tengo sed, tengo sueño, no hay remedio*. That is the difference between a list of words and a run you can speak from.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el remedio*
- *no hay remedio*
- all five — *la sed, el sueño, la piel, la sangre, el remedio*

Before you move on

What does *mederi* mean? (To heal.) Which everyday English word is the same root? (*Medicine*.) And what does *no hay remedio* say? (There is nothing to be done.)

Chapter 301

Five More Things You Ask For — Rope, Needle, Thread, Basket, Paper

Modes: ⇄ voice (5) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask for a rope, a needle, thread, a basket and paper in Spanish, politely.

Complete ES-C301-papel: ask for all five in turn, with por favor on the end of each.

301.1 la cuerda — a string made of gut

Before a new run: what does *sangfroid* mean, taken literally? (Cold blood.) And what does *no hay remedio* say? (There is nothing to be done.)

What to know first

- por favor — what goes on the end of every ask in this run.
- el puente — a thing that has been made out of these.

Sounds you'll need

- *CUER-da*, stress on the first part. The *ue* is one slide and the *d* is soft. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la cuerda — “the rope,” “the cord,” “the string.”

Greek **khordē** meant a gut — an intestine — and then the string made out of one, because that is what strings were made of. Latin borrowed it as **chorda**, and the stressed *o* did what it always does under stress in Spanish: it cracked open into *ue*. So *chorda* became *cuerda*, by the same road as *somnus* to *sueño*.

English kept the gut in a whole shelf of words. A **cord** is the plain rope. A **chord** is what several strings sound together. A **cordon** is a rope drawn round a place to keep people out. And a **harpsichord** is, quite literally, a harp made of gut strings.

So this is not a rough word for a rough object. It is a musical instrument’s word that ended up in the shed.

What you’ve built

The first of five things to ask for, and the *ue* crack has now paid twice in two runs.

Sueño and *cuerda* are the same event happening to two unrelated words. That is what makes it a rule rather than a coincidence.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la cuerda*
- *la cuerda, por favor*
- *el sueño*, then *la cuerda* — the same crack twice

Before you move on

What did *khordē* mean first? (A gut, then a string made of one.)
Which English instrument is a gut-stringed harp? (A harpsichord.)
And what did the stressed *o* do? (Broke into *ue*.)

301.2 la aguja — the sharp you already write

Two back: what does *no hay remedio* say? (There is nothing to be done.) And what did *khordē* mean? (A gut, then a string

made from one.)

What to know first

- *la cuerda* — the thick one, from just before.
- *la oveja* — the word this one rhymes with, and for the same reason.

Sounds you'll need

- *a-GU-ja*, stress in the middle. The *gu* is a hard *g*, and the *j* is the scrape. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la aguja — “the needle.”

Latin **acus** was a needle, and behind it lay a much older idea: sharpness. Add the small-and-fond ending and you get **acucula**, a little sharp thing — which came down to Spanish as *aguja*, by the very road that turned *ovicula* into *oveja*. That is why the two words rhyme. Now the useful part. That *acus* is standing in the corner of every page you have read. The accent you write on *sartén* is called **acute**, and *acute* is just Latin for sharp — a sharp accent, as against the grave one that leans the other way. You have been writing the same root for a long time without being told.

The rest of the family is easy once you have it. **Acupuncture** is puncturing with sharps. **Acumen** is a sharp mind. **Acid** is a sharp taste. All of them are this needle.

What you've built

Two of the five, and a root you were already using in silence.

La cuerda and *la aguja* also belong together in the hand: the thick one and the one that pulls the thin one through.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la aguja*
- *la aguja, por favor*
- *la oveja*, then *la aguja* — the same ending, twice

Before you move on

What did *acus* mean? (A needle — a sharp.) Why is the acute accent called that? (*Acute* is Latin for sharp.) And which word does *aguja* rhyme with, and why? (*Oveja* — both came from the same small ending.)

301.3 el hilo — the second h with an f under it

What did *khordē* mean? (A gut, then a string.) And why is the acute accent called acute? (Because *acute* is Latin for sharp.)

What to know first

- el horno — the first word this run gave you with a buried *f*.
- la aguja — what pulls this through the cloth.

Sounds you'll need

- *I-lo*, two beats, and the *h* is silent. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el hilo — “the thread.”

Run the decoder. Silent *h* at the front: put an *f* back and see what falls out. **Filum** — Latin for a thread. It works, and it works for the same reason it worked on *horno*.

English took *filum* the bookish way and kept every letter. A **filament** is a fine thread in a lamp. **Filigree** is metal worked into threads. A **profile** is a line drawn round something. And soldiers walking in **single file** are walking in one thread, which is a much older picture than the parade ground.

There is also a phrase worth carrying: *perder el hilo*, to lose the thread — of an argument, of a conversation. English says exactly the same thing about exactly the same object, and neither borrowed it. Everybody who has ever talked too long has felt the thread go.

What you've built

Three of the five, and the *f*-to-*h* decoder has now paid twice.
Horno and *hilo* are both Latin words with a letter worn off the front.
 When you meet the next silent *h*, try the same trick before you look anything up.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el hilo*
- *el hilo, por favor*
- *la aguja y el hilo*

Before you move on

What was *filum*? (A thread.) What is a *filament*? (A fine thread.)
 And what does *perder el hilo* mean? (To lose the thread of something.)

301.4 la cesta — one box, two English words

Three questions. What was *chorda*? (A gut string.) What was *acus*? (A needle.) And what was *filum*? (A thread.)

What to know first

- *la manzana* — what people carry in one.
- *el hilo* — the thing before this one.

Sounds you'll need

- *CES-ta*, stress on the first part. The *c* before *e* is the soft one. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la cesta — “the basket.”

Greek **kistē** was a box. Latin took it as **cista**, and Spanish wore it down to *cesta*, keeping the shape and losing nothing important.

English got the same box twice, by two different doors, and the pair is a good demonstration of what those doors do. Through Germanic mouths, early and worn: a **chest**, which is a box you can sit on.

Straight out of the books, late and tidy: a **cistern**, which is a tank for water and still sounds like an engineer’s word.

That is the general pattern, and once you have seen it here you will see it everywhere. Words that came the long way, through everyday speech, sound plain. Words that came the short way, through writing, sound learned. Same origin, different mileage.

What you’ve built

Four of the five, and a rule about English that keeps explaining Spanish.

When a Spanish word looks like a plain English word and a fancy one at once, that is usually not a coincidence. It is one Latin word that took two routes.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la cesta*
- *la cesta, por favor*
- all four — *la cuerda, la aguja, el hilo, la cesta*

Before you move on

What was *cista*? (A box.) Which English word for it came the worn, everyday way? (*Chest*.) And which came straight out of the books? (*Cistern*.)

301.5 el papel — a reed, and a part in a play

Before the last of the five: what was *acus*? (A needle.) What was *filum*? (A thread.) And which English word is *cista*, worn down? (*Chest*.)

What to know first

- el libro — named after what people wrote on before this arrived.
- escribir — what you do on it.

Sounds you'll need

- *pa-PEL*, stress on the end, and no accent needed for a word ending in *-l*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el papel — “the paper.”

Behind it is **papyrus**, the Egyptian reed whose pith was beaten flat and written on for three thousand years. English **paper** is the same reed. So is the **papyrus** in a museum case, which is the word arriving a second time, unworn, to name the original thing.

Put that beside *el libro*. A *libro* is named after the inner bark of a tree, which is what people wrote on when there was no papyrus to hand.

Two writing surfaces, two words, and neither of them has anything to do with writing — both are named after a plant.

Then *papel* did something Latin never asked it to. It also means the **part** an actor plays, because the part used to be handed to the actor written out on a sheet. *Hacer el papel de* — to play the part of.

English keeps the same idea in **role**, which was a little roll of paper.

What you've built

Five: *la cuerda*, *la aguja*, *el hilo*, *la cesta*, *el papel*.

Ask for any of them with *por favor* on the end and you have a complete, polite request — the same shape you have been using since the soap and the towel.

And every one of the five is named after a material rather than a use: a gut, a sharp, a thread, a box, a reed. Objects get their names from what they are made of far more often than from what they are for,

which is the opposite of the rule the farm gave you. Both are true; that is why you need to have met both.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el papel*
- *el papel, por favor*
- all five with *por favor* — *la cuerda, la aguja, el hilo, la cesta, el papel*

Before you move on

What plant is *papel* named after? (The papyrus reed.) What is *el libro* named after? (The inner bark of a tree.) And what else does *papel* mean? (The part an actor plays.)

Chapter 302

Out and Away — Street, Corner, Footprint, Harbour, Lighthouse

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the street, the corner, the footprint, the harbour and the lighthouse in Spanish.

Complete ES-C302-faro: name all five of a leaving in order, from the street to the light behind you.

302.1 la calle — a cattle track that reached the town

Before a new run: which English word is *cista*, worn down? (*Chest*.) And what plant is *papel* named after? (The papyrus reed.)

What to know first

- el sendero — the way through the trees.
- el ganado — what wore this one flat in the first place.

Sounds you'll need

- *CA-lle*, stress on the first part. The *c* is hard and the *ll* is a *y*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la calle — “the street.”

Latin **callis** was not urban at all. It was the narrow hard track that animals beat through rough country when they were driven from one grazing ground to another — a hoof-path, made by use rather than by anybody’s decision.

Then towns grew, and the word walked in with the herds. Spanish now uses *calle* for the most built thing there is: a paved street with houses down both sides. The stones are new; the word underneath them was made by *el ganado*.

You have three words for a way through now, and they do not overlap. *El sendero* is the path through the trees, narrow and unpaved. *El camino* is the road anybody would take. *La calle* has walls on both sides.

Ask *¿en qué calle vives?* and you are asking which street somebody lives on.

What you’ve built

The first step of a leaving, and it starts at the door.

Everything that follows in this run is further out than the last: a street, then its corner, then what you leave in the dirt beyond it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la calle*
- *el sendero*, then *la calle*
- *¿en qué calle vives?*

Before you move on

What was a *callis*? (A track beaten by driven animals.) What is *la calle* now? (A street.) And which of your three ways through has walls on both sides? (*La calle*.)

302.2 la esquina — named after a shinbone

Two back: what does *papel* also mean, besides paper? (The part an actor plays.) And what was a *callis*? (A track beaten by animals.)

What to know first

- la calle — what this is the end of.
- la escoba — another word wearing the same *e*- step.

Sounds you'll need

- *es-QUI-na*, stress in the middle. The *qui* is a hard *k* with the *u* silent. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la esquina — “the corner,” the outside one, where two walls meet. This one is not Latin. It came from the Germanic speakers, whose **skina** meant a shinbone, or a thin splinter of bone or wood — a long hard edge. A corner is exactly that shape, and the language borrowed the bone to name it.

English kept the bone and did not lend it to the corner: your **shin** is *skina*, the same word, and anybody who has met a table corner in the dark can confirm that the two ideas belong together.

Notice the front of the Spanish word. *Skina* could not stand as it was, because Spanish does not begin a word with *s* and another consonant — so it put an *e* on the front, exactly as it did to make *escoba* and *estar*. The *e*- is not part of the word. It is a step Spanish takes to get onto it.

What you've built

Two of the leaving, and a step you can now recognise on sight. Any Spanish word starting *es-* with a consonant after it is worth checking: strip the *e*, and a Latin or Germanic word is often standing underneath.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la esquina*
- *la esquina de la calle*
- *la escoba*, then *la esquina* — the same step twice

Before you move on

What did *skina* mean? (A shinbone, or a splinter.) Which English word is it still? (*Shin*.) And why does *esquina* start with an *e*? (Spanish will not begin a word with *s* plus a consonant.)

302.3 la huella — what the treading leaves

What was a *callis*? (A track beaten by driven animals.) And what did *skina* mean? (A shinbone.)

What to know first

- el hilo — the last word this run gave you with a buried *f*.
- el sendero — a thing made entirely out of these.

Sounds you'll need

- *UE-lla*, and the *h* is silent, so the word opens straight onto the *ue* slide. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la huella — “the footprint,” “the track,” the mark a thing leaves by pressing on something.

Third time for the decoder, and it still works. Silent *h*, so put the *f* back: behind *huella* is *hollar*, to tread, and behind that Latin **fullare**.

Fullare was a specific job. Newly woven wool had to be cleaned and thickened, and the way to do it was to put it in a vat with water and earth and **tread on it**, for hours. The man who did it was a *fullo*.

English still carries him: to **full** cloth is a real word, a **fulling mill** did it with hammers once water power arrived, and the surname **Fuller** belonged to whoever did it by foot.

So a footprint in Spanish is named after a day's work in a vat of wet wool. And the word has gone abstract in both languages the same way:

la huella is also the mark somebody leaves behind them in general, exactly as English uses **footprint** for something that never had a foot.

What you've built

Three of the leaving, and three uses of one decoder in two runs. *Horno, hilo, huella*. Each of them was an *f* once, and each of them gave the letter up in the same century. A silent *h* is now a piece of evidence, not a spelling to memorise.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la huella*
- *el hilo*, then *la huella* — two buried *f* sounds
- *la huella en el sendero*

Before you move on

What letter is under the *h* of *huella*? (An *f*.) What was *fullare*? (Treading cloth in a vat.) And what does *la huella* mean? (A footprint, or a mark left behind.)

302.4 el puerto — the other half of a pair

Three questions. What was a *callis*? (A beaten track.) Which English word is *skina*? (*Shin*.) And what was *fullare*? (Treading cloth in a vat.)

What to know first

- *la puerta* — the twin of this word, met long ago.
- *la orilla* — the edge this is built on.

Sounds you'll need

- *PUER-to*, stress on the first part. The *ue* is one slide and the *r* is a single tap. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el puerto — “the harbour,” “the port.”

When you took *la puerta* apart, the Latin behind it was **porta**, a city gate. Latin had a second word beside it, built on the same idea of a way through: **portus**, the place a ship gets in. Both broke their stressed *o* into *ue*, and Spanish ended up with a matched pair — *puerta* for the gate on land, *puerto* for the gate off the sea.

English took *portus* and never stopped using it. A **port** is the harbour. To **import** is to carry in through one; to **export**, out. **Portugal** is *Portus Cale*, the harbour at Cale, which is where the whole country got its name.

And the best of them: **opportunity**. Latin *ob portum* described a wind standing toward the harbour — the wind that lets you get in. An opportunity is not luck. It is the wind being in the right quarter, and somebody having a ship.

What you’ve built

Four of the leaving, and a word you half owned already.

Puerta and *puerto* differ by one letter and by which side of the water you are standing on. Pairs like that are cheap to hold and easy to hear, and Spanish has more of them than any list would suggest.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el puerto*
- *la puerta*, then *el puerto* — the gate and the harbour
- all four — *la calle*, *la esquina*, *la huella*, *el puerto*

Before you move on

What was *portus*? (A harbour.) What is *Portugal* named after? (The harbour at Cale.) And what does *ob portum* describe? (A wind standing toward harbour — an opportunity.)

302.5 el faro — an island that became a word

Before the last of the five: what was a *callis*? (A beaten track.)
 What is under the *h* of *huella*? (An *f*.) And what does *ob portum*
 describe? (A wind standing toward harbour.)

What to know first

- el puerto — what this stands at the mouth of.
- la isla — what the original one was built on.

Sounds you'll need

- *FA-ro*, stress on the first part. The *r* is one tap, not a roll. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el faro — “the lighthouse.”

There is no root to take apart, because this word was a place. **Pharos** was a small island off Alexandria, and on it the Ptolemies built a tower with a fire at the top that stood for some sixteen hundred years. Sailors called any such tower a *pharos* after it, and the name swallowed the object: French *phare*, Italian *faro*, Spanish *faro*.

The tower fell in an earthquake and the island is now joined to the mainland. Nothing of it is left except the word — which is also, in modern Spanish, what you call a car's headlights. The last of the great wonders is switched on every evening in every car park in Spain.

What you've built

Five: *la calle*, *la esquina*, *la huella*, *el puerto*, *el faro*.

Read in order they are a leaving that gets further out at every step — the street, its corner, the mark left in the dirt, the water's edge, and the light still visible when the town is not.

The five came from five different quarries: a cattle track, a shinbone, a day spent treading wool, a Roman harbour, and an island with a fire on it. That is why taking words apart keeps paying — you never know which one will turn out to be a building you have heard of.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el faro*
- *el puerto*, then *el faro*
- all five — *la calle, la esquina, la huella, el puerto, el faro*

Before you move on

What was Pharos? (An island off Alexandria with a great lighthouse on it.) How did it become the word? (Sailors called every such tower after it.) And what else is a *faro* today? (A car's headlight.)

Pronunciation — a reference, not a chapter

Not to be read before the lessons — every lesson tells you the one or two sounds its own word needs, right where you need them. This page sits at the back so the whole system is *somewhere* you can find it: look things up as curiosity strikes.

The five pure vowels

Spanish has exactly five vowel sounds, one per letter, every time — unlike English, which reuses each vowel letter for several sounds.

- **a** — as in *father*. Always.
- **e** — as in *bed*. Always.
- **i** — as the *ee* in *see* (not English *i*). The most common vowel slip for English speakers.
- **o** — as in *note*, short and clean, no *w*-glide.
- **u** — as the *oo* in *food*. Always.

Consonants that differ from English

- **h** — always silent. *hola* is *OH-la*.
- **qu** — a hard *k*, with a **silent u**: *quiero* is *KYEH-ro*.
- **ll** — like English *y*: *llamo* is *YA-mo*.
- **ñ** — the *ny* of *canyon*: *español*.

- **rr** — a rolled *r*; single *r* between vowels is a light tap (*pero* vs. *perro*).
- **j** — a throat-*h*, like Scottish *loch*: *jueves*.
- **c** before *e/i* — soft (*s* in Latin America, *th* in much of Spain): *gracias*.
- **d** between vowels — softens toward *th* in *this*.
- **v** and **b** — essentially identical, a soft *b*.

Stress and written accents

- Ends in a vowel, *n*, or *s* → stress the second-to-last syllable (*ca-SA*).
- Ends in another consonant → stress the last syllable (*ha-BLAR*).
- A written accent (´) overrides both and marks the stress exactly (*ha-BLÓ*, *DÍ-as*); it also separates look-alike words (*qué/que*, *tú/tu*).
- Questions and exclamations open with an inverted mark (¿, ¡) so the intonation is signalled up front.

Glossary

This glossary collects every word and phrase taught in the book. Pronunciation appears when it differs from the written form; chapter numbers show where each entry is introduced.

abrir

to open — a regular -ir verb with one irregular part, the participle abierto
Introduced in Chapter 166.

además

furthermore, moreover
Introduced in Chapter 273.

adiós

goodbye
Introduced in Chapter 12.

ahí • allí

there, over there — the two places aquí has been missing, and they line up exactly with the three pointing words
Introduced in Chapter 251.

ahora • hoy

now, today — the two time words mañana has been waiting for, and one of them is a Latin hour in disguise
Introduced in Chapter 252.

al

to the — one of only two places where Spanish forces two words into one, and it does it because the two vowels refuse to sit next to each other
Introduced in Chapter 230.

amable

kind — Latin amabilis, loveable: the person it is easy to be fond of
Introduced in Chapter 283.

amarillo

yellow — from “a little bitter,” not from any Latin word for yellow at all
Introduced in Chapter 151.

aquel

that one over there, away from us both — and the second life of the word that became *el* in your very first chapter
Introduced in Chapter 223.

así que

thus, in that way — and with *que* after it, “so”; built on the same *sīc* that gave you *sí*
Introduced in Chapter 175.

asonancia

assonance — the rhyme Spanish verse actually uses
Introduced in Chapter 276.

aunque

although, even though
Introduced in Chapter 270.

ayer

yesterday
Introduced in Chapter 103.

ayudar

to help — literally the same word as English “aid”, arriving by a different road
Introduced in Chapter 161.

azul

blue — an Arabic loan that became the plain everyday word, where French’s cousin stayed poetic
Introduced in Chapter 139.

bastante

enough, quite — an ending you already decode, on a verb meaning to suffice, giving a word that means exactly “sufficing”
Introduced in Chapter 227.

beber

to drink (another -er verb — cementing the pattern)
Introduced in Chapter 36.

bien

well / good / fine
Introduced in Chapter 1.

bienvenido

welcome — *bien plus venido*, well come, two pieces you already own
Introduced in Chapter 282.

billete

ticket
Introduced in Chapter 268.

buenas noches

good evening / good night
Introduced in Chapter 2.

buenas tardes

good afternoon

Introduced in Chapter 2.

buenos días

good morning (literally “good days”)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

café

coffee / a café — one useful noun before the polite request that follows

Introduced in Chapter 14.

caminar

to walk — built on a Celtic word for a path, beside andar, whose own past is

unsettled

Introduced in Chapter 165.

cansado

tired — a state, not a quality, which is why it takes *estar* and never *ser*

Introduced in Chapter 59.

cerrar

to close — from the bar dropped across a door, not from the Latin verb English

inherited

Introduced in Chapter 166.

cierto

true — Latin *certus*, sifted: what is left after you separate it out

Introduced in Chapter 284.

comer

to eat — your first -er verb, and the family whose yo-form you already own

Introduced in Chapter 34.

cometer un error

to make a mistake — with the verb Spanish insists on

Introduced in Chapter 275.

comí

the regular singular -er preterite — *comí*, *comiste*, *comió*

Introduced in Chapter 104.

cómo

how — a whole Latin phrase, *quo modo*, worn smooth into one word

Introduced in Chapter 6.

comprar

to buy — from Latin’s “get ready, procure”, and not from the verb behind

English compare

Introduced in Chapter 174.

con permiso

excuse me, said when you pass — *per plus mittere*, to let through

Introduced in Chapter 283.

conmigo • contigo

with me, with you — two words carrying the same preposition twice, because the first one stopped being audible

Introduced in Chapter 247.

conocer

to meet, to be acquainted with — a verb built out of the moment knowing begins
Introduced in Chapter 171.

conseguir

to get, to obtain — getting as following a thing until you have it
Introduced in Chapter 169.

contar

to tell a story — and also to count, because in Spanish, as once in English, a story is something you reckon up
Introduced in Chapter 167.

contestar

to answer — a Roman courtroom word that English turned into a fight and Spanish turned into a reply
Introduced in Chapter 174.

correr

to run — a plain -er verb sitting on one of the largest roots English ever borrowed
Introduced in Chapter 165.

creer

to believe, to think — putting your heart somewhere, where pensar weighs it up
Introduced in Chapter 175.

cuando

“when” — the word that puts a scene and an event in one sentence, so the two pasts can be seen doing different jobs
Introduced in Chapter 112.

de acuerdo

agreed — from cor, the heart: an agreement is two hearts brought together
Introduced in Chapter 284.

de nada

you’re welcome (literally “of nothing”)
Introduced in Chapter 7.

deber

should, ought to — and to owe, because the word is literally “to have something from someone”
Introduced in Chapter 175.

deber de

must — the guess, not the obligation
Introduced in Chapter 275.

decir

to say or tell — with the singular present forms digo, dices, and dice
Introduced in Chapter 70.

del

of the, from the — the second and last of Spanish's forced contractions, which means once you have these two you have all of them
Introduced in Chapter 231.

delgado / flaco

thin — the kind word and the blunt one
Introduced in Chapter 275.

depende

it depends
Introduced in Chapter 210.

día

day (el día — masculine)
Introduced in Chapter 1.

dieciséis — diecinueve

16-19 — not words to memorise but a formula, diez y X, with the seam still visible
Introduced in Chapter 149.

disculpe

excuse me — from culpa, fault: literally, take the fault off me
Introduced in Chapter 283.

dónde

where?
Introduced in Chapter 36.

dormir

to sleep — and the other half of the boot, where a stressed o breaks to ue
Introduced in Chapter 165.

durante

for, during
Introduced in Chapter 269.

e → ie and o → ue

comparing the two vowel changes inside the learned singular forms
Introduced in Chapter 69.

el / la

the (masculine / feminine)
Introduced in Chapter 1.

el abrazo

a hug — from brachium, the arm: the word says what the body does
Introduced in Chapter 282.

el agua

water — a word that barely changed from Latin, and takes el without ever stopping being feminine
Introduced in Chapter 143.

el ajo

the garlic — Latin *allium*, which English kept as the botanical name; *aioli* is this word and oil, run together
Introduced in Chapter 297.

el amanecer

the daybreak — Latin *mane*, in the morning, the same piece that sits inside *mañana*
Introduced in Chapter 289.

el árbol

tree — Latin *arbor*, with one of its two *r* sounds slid away to *l*
Introduced in Chapter 278.

el arroz

the rice — Arabic *ar-ruzz*, carrying its own article; rice is the same grain by a different road
Introduced in Chapter 290.

el bosque

the wood — a Germanic word, not a Latin one; bush, bosky and ambush are its English cousins
Introduced in Chapter 291.

el burro

the donkey — Latin *burricus*, a little reddish horse, from *burrus*, red; English borrowed the whole word back, and the burrito with it
Introduced in Chapter 296.

el caballo

the horse — Latin *caballus*, the working nag, which beat the noble *equus* and left cavalry and chivalry behind it
Introduced in Chapter 296.

el campo

the field, the countryside — Latin *campus*, flat open ground; camp, campus, campaign and champion are all fought or pitched on it
Introduced in Chapter 299.

el cielo

the sky — Latin *caelum*, which is also the ceiling over a room and the cerulean of a paint box
Introduced in Chapter 289.

el cocinero

the cook — *coquere*, to cook; the kitchen, the biscuit and a precocious child are all in it
Introduced in Chapter 285.

el cuchillo

the knife — Latin *cultellus*, a little culter; cutlery, cutlass and the plough's coulter are the same blade
Introduced in Chapter 294.

el cuello

the neck — Latin collum, which is also the collar round it and the accolade thrown round it

Introduced in Chapter 293.

el dinero

money — the name of a Roman coin, still doing service two thousand years later

Introduced in Chapter 280.

el dolor

the pain — Latin dolor; condolence hurts with you, and indolent once felt no pain at all

Introduced in Chapter 286.

el faro

the lighthouse — named after Pharos, the island at Alexandria that held the first one; a place name that became the word for the thing

Introduced in Chapter 302.

el ganado

the livestock — from ganar, to gain: cattle are simply “what has been gained”, the way English cattle and chattel are what you own

Introduced in Chapter 299.

el hermano, la hermana

brother and sister — NOT from frater/soror, but from an adjective meaning “of the same seed”

Introduced in Chapter 140.

el hilo

the thread — Latin filum with its f worn down to a silent h; filament, filigree and a file of soldiers are all threads

Introduced in Chapter 301.

el hombro

the shoulder — Latinumerus, which doctors still call the humerus; the h is silent and came late

Introduced in Chapter 293.

el horno

the oven — Latinfurnus, wearing the silent h that marks where an f used to stand; furnace is the same fire

Introduced in Chapter 297.

el huevo

egg — Latinovum, wearing an h that exists only to help your eyes

Introduced in Chapter 280.

el invitado

a guest — the invited one; Spanish names the person by what was done to him

Introduced in Chapter 282.

el jabón

soap — Latin *sapo*, which Latin had itself borrowed from its northern neighbours
Introduced in Chapter 287.

el lago

the lake — Latin *lacus*; lake, lagoon and lacuna are all the same standing water
Introduced in Chapter 292.

el libro

book — named after the part of a tree people wrote on before paper
Introduced in Chapter 57.

el maestro

the teacher — *magister*, from *magis*, more; and *minister*, from *minus*, less
Introduced in Chapter 285.

el ojo

the eye — Latin *oculus*; English *eye* is its distant cousin, not a translation of it
Introduced in Chapter 286.

el padre, la madre

father and mother — among the oldest reconstructible words in the whole family
Introduced in Chapter 140.

el pan

bread — and the *compañero* who shares it with you
Introduced in Chapter 143.

el papel

the paper — from *papyrus*, the reed the Egyptians wrote on; it also means the part an actor plays, because the part was written on one
Introduced in Chapter 301.

el pastor

the shepherd — from *pascere*, to graze; the pasture, the pastor of a church and a repast are all feeding
Introduced in Chapter 299.

el plato

a plate — Greek *platys*, flat: the same flatness in a plaza and in a platypus
Introduced in Chapter 287.

el pueblo

the village, and also the people — Latin *populus*, which gave popular, population and public
Introduced in Chapter 292.

el puente

the bridge — Latin *pontem*; a pontoon floats one and a pontiff is, underneath, a bridge-builder
Introduced in Chapter 295.

el puerto

the harbour — Latin *portus*, the twin of the *porta* you already have; import, export and opportunity are all ships coming in
Introduced in Chapter 302.

el queso

cheese — Latin caseus, the very same word as English cheese by another road
Introduced in Chapter 280.

el remedio

the remedy — re- and mederi, to heal again; medicine, medical and a medic are all the same healing
Introduced in Chapter 300.

el saludo

a greeting — from saludem, health: to greet was to wish someone their health
Introduced in Chapter 282.

el sendero

the path — Latin semita, a by-way, with semi- meaning half: a path is a half-road
Introduced in Chapter 295.

el sueño

the sleep, and the dream — Latin somnus with the o broken to ue; insomnia and somnolent keep the o intact
Introduced in Chapter 300.

el tenedor

the fork — built on tener, to hold: it is “the holder”, the same shape as any Spanish word ending in -dor
Introduced in Chapter 297.

el tiempo

the one noun that covers both “time” and “weather” — because Latin tempus already did
Introduced in Chapter 148.

el tobillo

the ankle — from Latin tuber, a swelling; a tuber in the ground and a protuberance are the same lump
Introduced in Chapter 293.

el tomate

the tomato — Nahuatl tomatl, one of the words Spanish carried back across the Atlantic
Introduced in Chapter 290.

el trigo

the wheat — Latin triticum, the rubbed grain, from terere, to rub; trite is worn down the same way
Introduced in Chapter 290.

el tronco

the trunk — Latin truncus, meaning lopped or maimed; to truncate is to do it on purpose
Introduced in Chapter 291.

el valle

the valley — Latin vallis; valley, vale and avalanche all come down the same slope
Introduced in Chapter 292.

el vaso

a glass — Latin vas, a vessel: named for what it does, not for what it is made of
Introduced in Chapter 287.

el vecino

the neighbour — from vicus, a village street: the person off your own block
Introduced in Chapter 285.

el viaje

the journey — Latin viaticum, the provisions you packed for the road
Introduced in Chapter 288.

el viento

wind — Latin ventus, and the English word that is its cousin rather than its borrowing
Introduced in Chapter 278.

el vino

wine — one Latin root that reached English by three separate roads, plus one English built at home
Introduced in Chapter 143.

en efecto

indeed — from ex and facere, carried out; it confirms what somebody has just said, and does not mean “in effect”
Introduced in Chapter 298.

en mi opinión

in my opinion
Introduced in Chapter 270.

en primer lugar

in the first place, firstly
Introduced in Chapter 273.

en resumen

in short — and the last thing this book asks of you
Introduced in Chapter 277.

entender

to understand — literally “to stretch toward”; the second e→ie stem-changer
Introduced in Chapter 154.

es decir

that is to say — the same idea in your own words
Introduced in Chapter 277.

es que...

it's just that...
Introduced in Chapter 272.

escribir

to write — from a Latin verb meaning “to scratch”, and the reason Spanish puts an e- in front

Introduced in Chapter 156.

ese

that one, by you — the slot Latin’s *iste* left empty when Spanish moved it, filled by a word that used to mean self

Introduced in Chapter 222.

español

“Spanish” — the language, the people, and the Roman name for the peninsula underneath it

Introduced in Chapter 22.

esperar

to wait — and to hope, and to expect, all in one verb

Introduced in Chapter 174.

espero viajar

I hope to travel

Introduced in Chapter 269.

está en...

is in or at... — locate someone with *estar* and the already-known *en*

Introduced in Chapter 48.

estar

to be — but the *standing* kind, straight from Latin *stāre*

Introduced in Chapter 8.

estás / está

what *estar* is for — a current state or location — and the only two forms you need this chapter

Introduced in Chapter 8.

este

this one, here, next to me — the first of three words for pointing, and the reason Spanish never needs to say “the this book”

Introduced in Chapter 221.

estudiante

student — a word you can build yourself, out of a verb you already have

Introduced in Chapter 52.

estudiar

to study (a third -ar verb — the pattern is automatic now)

Introduced in Chapter 21.

exacto

exactly — from *exigere*, to drive out, and then to weigh out precisely

Introduced in Chapter 284.

explicar

to explain — literally to unfold, and the verb that names what this whole chapter has been building

Introduced in Chapter 175.

feliz

happy

Introduced in Chapter 269.

fui

the shared singular preterite of ser and ir — fui, fuiste, fue

Introduced in Chapter 103.

gato

cat — a word that travelled out of Africa with the animal, pushing Latin's own *fēlēs* aside

Introduced in Chapter 150.

gracias

thank you

Introduced in Chapter 7.

grande

big — the first word in this book for what something is like, and it does not change for gender

Introduced in Chapter 58.

gustar

to please — the verb English calls “to like”, built the other way round

Introduced in Chapter 163.

habitación

room

Introduced in Chapter 268.

hablar

to speak / to talk — at root, “to tell stories”

Introduced in Chapter 16.

hablaré

I will speak

Introduced in Chapter 49.

Hablo español

your first sentence built from parts — and the rule that languages take no article

Introduced in Chapter 22.

hace calor, hace frío, hace sol

the three weather words Spanish reports with hacer — “it makes heat,” “it makes cold,” “it makes sun”

Introduced in Chapter 148.

hacer

to do or make — with the singular present forms hago, haces, and hace

Introduced in Chapter 70.

hasta

until / up to

Introduced in Chapter 12.

hasta luego

see you later (literally “until later”)

Introduced in Chapter 13.

hasta mañana

see you tomorrow (literally “until tomorrow”)

Introduced in Chapter 13.

hasta pronto

see you soon (literally “until soon”)

Introduced in Chapter 13.

hay

“there is” and “there are” — one word for both, which no other Spanish verb form manages

Introduced in Chapter 191.

hola

hello / hi

Introduced in Chapter 1.

ir

to go — with the three singular present forms voy, vas, and va

Introduced in Chapter 49.

jugar

to play — from Latin’s word for joking, and the only verb in the language that breaks u to ue

Introduced in Chapter 170.

la

“it” for something feminine — the one word in this pair that never had to change

Introduced in Chapter 84.

la aguja

the needle — a little acus, a sharp; the same sharp that names the acute accent, and the one in acupuncture

Introduced in Chapter 301.

la amiga

a friend, of a woman — Latin amica, from the same amare as amable

Introduced in Chapter 285.

la boca

the mouth — Latin bucca was the cheek, and the cheek pushed the mouth out of the job

Introduced in Chapter 286.

la cabeza

the head — Spanish KEPT Latin’s real word, unlike French, which replaced it with slang for “pot”

Introduced in Chapter 141.

la calle

the street — Latin callis, the narrow track worn through rough ground by driven animals; the town's word began in the hills

Introduced in Chapter 302.

la cama

bed — one of the commonest Spanish words, and nobody has settled where it came from

Introduced in Chapter 279.

la casa

house, home — and a word French wore down so far it stopped looking like a noun

Introduced in Chapter 56.

la cebolla

the onion — Latin caepulla, a little caepa; the chive in English is the same root, undiminished

Introduced in Chapter 290.

la cesta

the basket — Latin cista from Greek kiste, a box; English chest and cistern are the same container by two different doors

Introduced in Chapter 301.

la colina

the hill — Latin collis, from a root meaning to rise; excel and culminate rise from the same place

Introduced in Chapter 292.

la comida

food, a meal — a noun you can build yourself out of a verb you already own

Introduced in Chapter 77.

la cosecha

the harvest — from collecta, the gathered-up, which is the colligere you already took apart once

Introduced in Chapter 299.

la cuchara

a spoon — Latin cochlear, from cochlea, a snail shell you dug the snail out with

Introduced in Chapter 287.

la cuerda

the rope — Greek khorde by way of Latin chorda, a gut string; cord, chord and cordon are the same string, and the o breaks to ue again

Introduced in Chapter 301.

la despedida

the farewell — from despedir, Latin expetere, to ask out: a leave-taking was a request

Introduced in Chapter 288.

la enfermera

the nurse — from infirmus, not firm: named after the patient, not the work
Introduced in Chapter 285.

la escoba

the broom — Latin scopa, a bundle of twigs, wearing the Spanish e- step for the third time
Introduced in Chapter 294.

la espalda

the back — Latin spatula, a broad blade; the same blade is a spatula, a spade and an epaulette
Introduced in Chapter 293.

la esquina

the corner — from a Germanic word for a shinbone; English shin is the same bone, and a corner is an edge as sharp as one
Introduced in Chapter 302.

la estrella

the star — Latin stella, wearing the e- that Spanish puts in front of an s and a consonant
Introduced in Chapter 289.

la fiebre

the fever — Latin febris, which English borrowed early as fever and late as febrile
Introduced in Chapter 286.

la flor

flower — Latin flos, and the reason English flour is spelled so oddly
Introduced in Chapter 278.

la gallina

the hen — Latin gallina, the female of gallus; and in both languages the bird is also what you call a coward
Introduced in Chapter 296.

la garganta

the throat — a word made out of the noise itself, as gargle and gurgle are
Introduced in Chapter 286.

la granja

the farm — from granum, the grain: a farm is named after the one thing it was built to store
Introduced in Chapter 299.

la hora

hour / o'clock — telling the time, and a word Spanish inherited almost unchanged from Latin
Introduced in Chapter 147.

la huella

the footprint — from hollar, to tread, and behind that fullare, to trample cloth; a fuller was the man who did it with his feet
Introduced in Chapter 302.

la isla

the island — Latin insula; insular, isolate, peninsula and insulin all come off the same rock

Introduced in Chapter 295.

la llegada

the arrival — from llegar, Latin plicare, to fold: a ship folded its sails and had arrived

Introduced in Chapter 288.

la mano

the hand — feminine despite ending in -o, Spanish's most famous gender exception

Introduced in Chapter 141.

la manta

the blanket — Latin mantum, a cloak; the mantle, the mantelpiece and the manta ray are all cloaks

Introduced in Chapter 294.

la manzana

apple — named after a Roman gardener whose variety outlived him

Introduced in Chapter 280.

la miel

the honey — Latin mel, which sweetens mellifluous, molasses and marmalade

Introduced in Chapter 290.

la montaña

the mountain — Latin mons; paramount is above the hill and an amount is what it comes to

Introduced in Chapter 292.

la niebla

the mist — Latin nebula, the word set aside earlier as the near-cousin of nubes; nebulous is the same mist

Introduced in Chapter 295.

la nieve

snow — Latin nivem, and the s- that Latin dropped and English kept

Introduced in Chapter 278.

la noche

night / evening (la noche — feminine)

Introduced in Chapter 2.

la nube

the cloud — Latin nubes, and the ancestor of nuance, which began as a shade of cloud

Introduced in Chapter 289.

la olla

the pot — Latin olla, unchanged in two thousand years; potpourri is a French translation of olla podrida

Introduced in Chapter 294.

la orilla

the shore — Latin ora, an edge or border, with the small ending: the little edge of anything

Introduced in Chapter 295.

la oveja

the sheep — Latin ovicula, a little ovis; Spanish kept the small one and dropped the full-sized word entirely

Introduced in Chapter 296.

la piel

the skin — Latin pellis, a hide, with the e broken to ie; a pelt is the same hide, and a surplice is a shirt worn over one

Introduced in Chapter 300.

la primavera, el verano, el otoño, el invierno

the four seasons — three straightforward, and one whose MEANING quietly shifted from “spring” to “summer”

Introduced in Chapter 142.

la puerta

door — Latin porta, a gate, and the o that opened into ue

Introduced in Chapter 279.

la raíz

the root — Latin radix, which is also the radish, the radical and the thing you eradicate

Introduced in Chapter 291.

la rama

the branch — Latin ramus; when an argument ramifies, it is growing these

Introduced in Chapter 291.

la rodilla

the knee — Latin rotella, a little wheel, from rota; rotate, rotary and roulette are the same wheel

Introduced in Chapter 293.

la salida

the way out — from salir, and Latin salire, to jump: a Roman jumped out of a room

Introduced in Chapter 288.

la sangre

the blood — Latin sanguinem; sanguine once meant ruddy and cheerful because of it, and consanguinity is shared blood

Introduced in Chapter 300.

la sartén

the frying pan — Latin sartago; its written accent is a receipt for where the stress went, and the plural hands it back

Introduced in Chapter 297.

la sed

the thirst — Latin *sitis*; Spanish does not say you are thirsty, it says you have thirst, and the difference is the point

Introduced in Chapter 300.

la semilla

the seed — Latin *seminalia*, the things for sowing; a seminar is a seed-bed and disseminate is scattering

Introduced in Chapter 291.

la silla

chair — Latin *sella*, a seat, from the verb to sit

Introduced in Chapter 279.

la sombra

the shade — Latin *sub umbra*, under the shadow; an umbrella is a little one of these

Introduced in Chapter 289.

la sonrisa

a smile — *subridere*, to laugh slightly: a laugh with the volume turned down

Introduced in Chapter 282.

la sopa

the soup — Germanic *suppa*, a piece of bread soaked in broth; the bread came first and soup, sop and supper are all it

Introduced in Chapter 297.

la tarde

afternoon (*la tarde* — feminine; also: late)

Introduced in Chapter 2.

la taza

the cup — Arabic *tassa*, from Persian; French *tasse* and the English *demitasse* are the same vessel

Introduced in Chapter 294.

la toalla

a towel — a Frankish word that went into French and came out in two languages

Introduced in Chapter 287.

la vaca

the cow — Latin *vacca*, unchanged in six letters; vaccine is named after her, because the first one came from a cow

Introduced in Chapter 296.

la ventana

window — a wind-hole, built on the same Latin *ventus* as *viento*

Introduced in Chapter 279.

la vuelta

the return — from *volver*, Latin *volvere*, to roll: a return is a turning back

Introduced in Chapter 288.

le

“to him, to her, to you” — a Latin case Spanish kept and English threw away
Introduced in Chapter 93.

leer

to read — from a Latin verb meaning “to gather, to pick out”
Introduced in Chapter 155.

levantarse

to get up, to stand up — “to raise oneself”, built from a participle exactly as
sentarse was
Introduced in Chapter 166.

limpio

clean — from limpidus, clear, the word English kept for water and Spanish moved
to laundry
Introduced in Chapter 281.

llamo

I call (from llamar, to call)
Introduced in Chapter 4.

llovía / llovió

the same rain in two tenses — how a story uses the imperfect for the scene and
the preterite for the events
Introduced in Chapter 167.

llueve

rain refuses the hacer pattern and brings its own verb — and its ll- is the sound
change you already met in llamar
Introduced in Chapter 148.

lo

“it” — a word you have been saying since your fourth chapter, in a job you have
not met yet
Introduced in Chapter 83.

lo cual

which — pointing back at a whole clause
Introduced in Chapter 273.

lo siento

I’m sorry — literally “I feel it,” a naming of the feeling rather than a claim about
yourself
Introduced in Chapter 137.

los meses

the months — Roman gods and emperors, marching almost unchanged from Latin
Introduced in Chapter 145.

luego

then, next — a word you already own from hasta luego, now doing a second job:
joining two events in order
Introduced in Chapter 167.

lunes, martes, miércoles, jueves, viernes

the weekdays (Monday–Friday) — worn-down planet-god names
Introduced in Chapter 138.

mal

badly — the partner bien has been waiting for since chapter one, and the second word in three chapters to appear in a long form and a short one
Introduced in Chapter 228.

mas

but — the literary one, without the accent
Introduced in Chapter 276.

más despacio

“more slowly” — the request that makes the last sentence solvable
Introduced in Chapter 15.

más que

more than
Introduced in Chapter 269.

más vale pájaro en mano

a bird in the hand — the proverb, and what a proverb is
Introduced in Chapter 274.

me

me / myself
Introduced in Chapter 4.

me llamo

my name is (literally “I call myself”)
Introduced in Chapter 4.

mediodía, medianoche

noon and midnight — both halves still fully alive as ordinary Spanish words, unlike French’s worn-down *midi/minuit*
Introduced in Chapter 146.

mi, tu, su

my, your informal, and your formal or his or her — before a singular noun
Introduced in Chapter 49.

mil gracias

a thousand thanks — *mille*, the same thousand that measures a mile
Introduced in Chapter 283.

mira

look — and the tone shifts
Introduced in Chapter 272.

mucho

much / a lot
Introduced in Chapter 6.

mucho gusto

pleased to meet you (literally “much pleasure”)

Introduced in Chapter 6.

muy

very — not a new word at all, but mucho with its ending bitten off, and the shape tells you what is coming next

Introduced in Chapter 226.

negro, blanco

black and white — the two words, and the straight-line Latin history of the first one

Introduced in Chapter 139.

ni

nor, not even — the joining word for two things that are both absent, and the one place Spanish stacks negatives on purpose

Introduced in Chapter 234.

ni hablar

out of the question — “not even to speak of it”, two pieces you already own, and the flattest refusal on the dial

Introduced in Chapter 298.

no

no / not

Introduced in Chapter 7.

no + verb

putting *no* in front of the verb — the whole of Spanish negation

Introduced in Chapter 267.

no ... nada

the double negative — where Spanish stacks what English forbids

Introduced in Chapter 267.

no entiendo

“I don’t understand” — the most useful sentence a beginner owns

Introduced in Chapter 15.

no hay de qué

not at all — the reply to thanks, assembled entirely from words you already have

Introduced in Chapter 283.

nos

“us” — and the word hiding inside the verb ending you have used since *hablamos*

Introduced in Chapter 88.

nuestro, nuestra

our — matching a known masculine or feminine singular noun

Introduced in Chapter 69.

nuevo

new — Latin *novus*, and English *new*, which is the cousin rather than the loan

Introduced in Chapter 281.

o

or — one letter, and one rule about what happens when the next word starts with the same sound

Introduced in Chapter 233.

oír

to hear — the half of listening you do not choose, and a verb that sprouts a y

Introduced in Chapter 165.

once — quince

11-15 — five single opaque words, each one a Latin compound worn down until the seam disappeared

Introduced in Chapter 149.

os

“you all” as the object — the shortest word in the set, and the one that stops at a border

Introduced in Chapter 90.

para

“for” pointing forward — at a destination, a purpose, a deadline, a person meant to receive something

Introduced in Chapter 176.

pasar a mejor vida

to pass on — and why the language turns away

Introduced in Chapter 274.

pensar

to think — at root “to weigh”, and a stem-changer that breaks e→ie

Introduced in Chapter 153.

perdón

the other sorry — “give completely” — for fault and for getting past people, where lo siento is for regret

Introduced in Chapter 137.

pero

but — the first word you need to hold two true things against each other, and the first word of any argument

Introduced in Chapter 218.

perro

dog — a genuinely unsolved etymology, and the Latin word it pushed out

Introduced in Chapter 150.

poder

to be able or can — with the singular present forms puedo, puedes, and puede

Introduced in Chapter 69.

poner

to put or place — with the singular present forms pongo, pones, and pone

Introduced in Chapter 71.

por

“for” pointing back or through — at a cause, a route, an exchange; and you have been saying it since your first page
Introduced in Chapter 177.

por ejemplo

for example
Introduced in Chapter 270.

por favor

please (literally “for [a] favour”)
Introduced in Chapter 14.

por lo tanto

therefore
Introduced in Chapter 273.

por supuesto

of course — supponere, to place under: it was already under the conversation
Introduced in Chapter 284.

por un lado... por otro

on one hand... on the other — holding two sources at once
Introduced in Chapter 277.

porque

because — two tiny words fused into one, and the reason a sequence becomes a story
Introduced in Chapter 167.

preguntar

to ask (a question) — and the reason English’s one “ask” becomes two Spanish verbs
Introduced in Chapter 160.

primero • segundo • tercero

first, second, third — the counting words for order rather than amount, and two of them shorten in a way you have now seen three times
Introduced in Chapter 262.

problema

problem
Introduced in Chapter 268.

profesor

teacher — and the one place Spanish drops the “a” that English insists on
Introduced in Chapter 51.

puede ser

could be — two words you already own, standing side by side and meaning less together than either does alone
Introduced in Chapter 298.

qué

what? (a new question word for verbs you already know)

Introduced in Chapter 36.

querer

to want — with the singular present forms *quiero*, *quieres*, and *quiere*

Introduced in Chapter 69.

quién

who — the asking word Spanish keeps for people, and the reason *qué* has never had to do that job

Introduced in Chapter 232.

quizás

maybe, perhaps

Introduced in Chapter 271.

regular

so-so / not great (also “*más o menos*”)

Introduced in Chapter 9.

rojo

red — a cousin of French *rouge* and English red, but by a different branch of the same very old family

Introduced in Chapter 139.

sábado, domingo

the weekend (Saturday, Sunday) — where religion overwrote astronomy

Introduced in Chapter 138.

salir

to leave or go out — with the singular present forms *salgo*, *sales*, and *sale*

Introduced in Chapter 72.

se llama

he/she calls himself; you (formal) call yourself

Introduced in Chapter 6.

según

according to — marking whose claim it is

Introduced in Chapter 277.

seguro

sure — *se-* without *plus cura*, care: free from care, and so reliable

Introduced in Chapter 284.

seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez

the numbers 6–10 and the old counting hidden in month names

Introduced in Chapter 47.

sentarse

to sit down — literally “to seat oneself”, the reflexive that lands the action back on you

Introduced in Chapter 166.

ser

to be — the verb used here to identify someone or say what someone is
Introduced in Chapter 48.

ser un quijote

to be a Quixote — an allusion working as a word
Introduced in Chapter 274.

ser vs estar

identify with ser; describe a current state or location with estar
Introduced in Chapter 48.

sí

yes
Introduced in Chapter 7.

sí que

the emphatic yes — contradicting something unsaid
Introduced in Chapter 275.

sí, claro

yeah, right
Introduced in Chapter 272.

sin duda

no doubt — duda is dubitare, and behind that duo, two: to doubt is to be caught
between a pair of answers
Introduced in Chapter 298.

sin embargo

however, nevertheless
Introduced in Chapter 270.

soy de...

I am from... — use ser with de to state origin
Introduced in Chapter 48.

sucio

dirty — from sucidus, greasy with its own juice, said first of unwashed wool
Introduced in Chapter 281.

supongo que

I suppose that
Introduced in Chapter 271.

tal vez

maybe — literally “such a turn”, from vicem, a turn or a change; vice versa is the
turn turned round
Introduced in Chapter 298.

también

also — and you have been holding half of it since the first chapter of this book
Introduced in Chapter 219.

tampoco

neither — the same *tan*, a different second half, and the word that lets you agree with a *no*

Introduced in Chapter 220.

te quiero

“you” as the object — and the sentence it makes, which is the one people actually need

Introduced in Chapter 85.

tener

to have — a common verb with two visible changes

Introduced in Chapter 47.

tener gracia

to be funny — and a word that does not translate

Introduced in Chapter 274.

tengo · hago · digo

comparing the three learned *yo* forms that end in *-go*

Introduced in Chapter 70.

tomar

to take (and, across Latin America, to drink) — an everyday word with no settled origin

Introduced in Chapter 159.

tomar el pelo

to pull someone’s leg (lit. to take the hair)

Introduced in Chapter 272.

trabajar

to work (a second *-ar* verb — same pattern)

Introduced in Chapter 20.

traer

to bring — Latin’s word for dragging, and a verb with a direction built into it

Introduced in Chapter 168.

tú / usted

two of the three words Spanish uses to one person — and the one English quietly retired

Introduced in Chapter 5.

tú o usted

the choice English lost — and the surprise that *usted* takes *he/she* verb forms

Introduced in Chapter 5.

uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco

the numbers 1–5

Introduced in Chapter 47.

veinte

twenty — the ceiling of the teens, and a word that was worn but never fused

Introduced in Chapter 149.

venir

to come — with the singular present forms vengo, vienes, and viene
Introduced in Chapter 73.

ver

to see — veo, ves, ve
Introduced in Chapter 108.

verde

green — from a verb meaning “to flourish,” and a cousin of verdant but not of English green
Introduced in Chapter 151.

viejo

old — from vetulus, “little old one”, the affectionate form rather than the plain one
Introduced in Chapter 281.

viví

the regular singular -ir preterite — viví, viviste, vivió
Introduced in Chapter 104.

vivir

to live — your first -ir verb, and a family that asks you to learn nothing new
Introduced in Chapter 35.

vos

“you” across a large part of the Spanish-speaking world — to recognise, not to say
Introduced in Chapter 5.

voy a + infinitive

I am going to... — the near future with ir, a, and a known infinitive
Introduced in Chapter 49.

y / ¿y tú?

and / and you? — a tiny connector that hands the conversation back
Introduced in Chapter 9.

¿cómo está usted?

how are you? — assemble the formal question from cómo, estar, and usted
Introduced in Chapter 8.

¿cómo se dice?

the single most useful sentence a learner owns — and it is this chapter’s grammar, doing exactly what the chapter said
Introduced in Chapter 183.

¿cómo se llama usted?

what’s your name? (formal)
Introduced in Chapter 6.

¿Cuántos años tienes?

how old are you? — literally, how many years do you have?
Introduced in Chapter 47.

¿dónde está?

where is it?

Introduced in Chapter 268.

¿Hablas español?

the yes-or-no question — and why Spanish barely has to do anything

Introduced in Chapter 267.

¿verdad?

the tag question — asking someone to agree

Introduced in Chapter 267.

Review Questions

Try these without looking ahead. Every prompt comes from the same canonical lesson data as its chapter. Answers begin in the next section.

Chapter 1

1.1 *Grammatical gender — the two noun classes behind el and la*
How many grammatical noun classes does Spanish keep?

Chapter 2

2.1 *buenos or buenas — the rule you have been using all along*
Why does bueno become buenos in buenos dias?

2.2 *buenos or buenas — the rule you have been using all along*
And why buenas in buenas tardes?

Chapter 3

3.1 *un — “a,” and the number hiding in it*
Say a day in Spanish.

3.2 *un — “a,” and the number hiding in it*
Which one points at a day we both already know about: el dia or un dia?

3.3 *un — “a,” and the number hiding in it*
What number is hiding inside un, and inside English a?

3.4 *una — the feminine one*
Say an afternoon.

3.5 *una — the feminine one*
Un or una before dia?

3.6 *una — the feminine one*

Which of the two lost a syllable on the way from Latin?

3.7 *Review — the four little words*

The day.

3.8 *Review — the four little words*

An afternoon.

3.9 *Review — the four little words*

Where does an article get its gender from?

Chapter 11

11.1 *Where does ¿ begin? — bracket the spoken span*

In 'Roberto, ¿cómo estás?', is Roberto inside the question?

Chapter 16

16.1 *hablo — “I speak”*

Turn hablar into I speak.

16.2 *hablo — “I speak”*

Which single letter is doing the work of the word I?

16.3 *hablo — one word, one whole sentence*

How many words does Spanish need to say I speak?

16.4 *hablo — one word, one whole sentence*

Why must English say the word I, when Spanish need not?

Chapter 17

17.1 *hablas — “you speak,” to someone you know*

Turn hablar into you speak, to a friend.

17.2 *hablas — “you speak,” to someone you know*

Which one means I speak: hablo or hablas?

Chapter 18

18.1 *habla* — “he speaks,” and the polite “you speak”

Turn hablar into he speaks.

18.2 *habla* — “he speaks,” and the polite “you speak”

Which form goes with usted: hablas or habla?

Chapter 19

19.1 *Review* — the three forms, side by side

I speak.

19.2 *Review* — the three forms, side by side

She speaks.

19.3 *Review* — the three forms, side by side

You speak, to a friend.

Chapter 23

23.1 *-ción* — about two thousand words, at once

Turn the English word information into Spanish.

23.2 *-ción* — about two thousand words, at once

What gender is every -cion word?

23.3 *-ción* — about two thousand words, at once

Why is this a rule rather than a coincidence?

Chapter 24

24.1 *-dad* — twelve hundred more

Turn the English word university into Spanish.

24.2 *-dad* — twelve hundred more

You see the word realidad and have never met it. What does it mean?

24.3 *-dad* — twelve hundred more

Why does -dad look less like -ty than -cion looks like -tion?

Chapter 25

25.1 *-mente* — *with no upper limit*

Make an adverb from rapido.

25.2 *-mente* — *with no upper limit*

Why does the adjective go feminine before -mente?

25.3 *-mente* — *with no upper limit*

What does rapidamente literally say?

Chapter 26

26.1 *Review* — *three endings*

Give the three Spanish endings and their English partners.

26.2 *Review* — *three endings*

Which of the three endings tell you the gender for free?

26.3 *Review* — *three endings*

Which ending is a machine rather than a decoder, and why?

Chapter 27

27.1 *Synthesis* — *reading what you were never taught*

What does La universidad tiene una reputacion internacional mean?

27.2 *Synthesis* — *reading what you were never taught*

How many words in that sentence had you never been taught?

27.3 *Synthesis* — *reading what you were never taught*

Why can a rule be worth more than a word?

27.4 *Synthesis* — *reading what you were never taught*

Are these endings perfectly reliable?

Chapter 28

28.1 $f \rightarrow h$ — *why the h says nothing*

Why is the Spanish h silent?

28.2 $f \rightarrow h$ — *why the h says nothing*

Which English word is hablar's friend, once you put the f back?

28.3 *f* → *h* — *why the h says nothing*

You meet *hierro* and have never seen it. Decode it.

28.4 *f* → *h* — *why the h says nothing*

Is every Spanish *h* a dead *f*?

Chapter 29

29.1 *cl-*, *pl-*, *fl-* → *ll-*

Which English words are *llamar*'s cousins?

29.2 *cl-*, *pl-*, *fl-* → *ll-*

Which three Latin clusters all became *ll-*?

29.3 *cl-*, *pl-*, *fl-* → *ll-*

You meet *llave* and have never seen it. Try the three clusters and decode it.

29.4 *cl-*, *pl-*, *fl-* → *ll-*

What do all three sound laws have in common?

Chapter 31

31.1 *Synthesis* — *the decoder*

Decode *hoja*.

31.2 *Synthesis* — *the decoder*

Decode *lleno*.

31.3 *Synthesis* — *the decoder*

Decode *la conservacion de la ciudad*.

31.4 *Synthesis* — *the decoder*

A word resists every rule you have. What does that suggest?

Chapter 32

32.1 *Synthesis* — *the same conversation, twice*

You are talking to someone your own age. Which form: *hablas* or *habla*?

32.2 *Synthesis* — *the same conversation, twice*

You are speaking to someone you want to show respect to. Which form?

32.3 *Synthesis* — *the same conversation, twice*

In BOTH conversations, how do you say I speak?

Chapter 34

34.1 *comer* — “to eat,” and the second verb family

Which ending makes *comer* a different family from *hablar*?

34.2 *como* — “I eat,” and you already knew how

Turn *comer* into I eat.

34.3 *como* — “I eat,” and you already knew how

Which ending is identical in the -ar and -er families?

34.4 *comes* — “you eat,” and the first real difference

Turn *comer* into you eat, to a friend.

34.5 *comes* — “you eat,” and the first real difference

What does a final -s on a Spanish verb always tell you?

34.6 *come* — “he eats,” and the polite “you eat”

Turn *comer* into he eats.

34.7 *come* — “he eats,” and the polite “you eat”

Which form goes with *usted*: *comes* or *come*?

34.8 *Review* — the -er family, all three

I eat.

34.9 *Review* — the -er family, all three

You eat, to a friend.

34.10 *Review* — the -er family, all three

Which of the three slots is identical between the -ar and -er families?

Chapter 35

35.1 *vivir* — “to live,” and the third family (that’s barely new)

Give the three singular forms of *vivir* in order: I, tú, usted.

Chapter 36

36.1 *beber* — “to drink,” and the pattern is yours

Say ‘I drink coffee’ in Spanish.

36.2 *qué* — “what”, a new question word

Ask one friend ‘What do you drink?’ in Spanish.

36.3 *dónde* — “where?”

Say ‘I live in Madrid’ in Spanish.

36.4 Practice — *asking real questions*

Give the yo forms of comer, vivir, and beber, in that order.

36.5 Practice — *asking real questions*

Ask one friend 'What do you drink?' in Spanish.

36.6 Practice — *asking real questions*

Answer 'Where do you live?' with Madrid.

Chapter 37

37.1 Synthesis — *asking, and answering*

Ask a friend what they eat.

37.2 Synthesis — *asking, and answering*

Ask a friend where they live.

37.3 Synthesis — *asking, and answering*

How many verb families do you now hold in the singular?

Chapter 38

38.1 hablamos — *“we speak”*

Turn hablar into we speak.

38.2 hablamos — *“we speak”*

What was the Latin ending that became -mos?

Chapter 39

39.1 hablan — *“they speak,” and “you all speak”*

Turn hablar into they speak.

39.2 hablan — *“they speak,” and “you all speak”*

Which form goes with ustedes?

39.3 hablan — *“they speak,” and “you all speak”*

What phrase is ustedes worn down from?

Chapter 40

40.1 *habláis — the form Spain keeps*

Which form goes with vosotros?

40.2 *habláis — the form Spain keeps*

You are addressing a group of friends in Argentina. Vosotros or ustedes?

40.3 *habláis — the form Spain keeps*

What two words is vosotros built from?

Chapter 41

41.1 *Review — the whole thing, at last*

We speak.

41.2 *Review — the whole thing, at last*

They speak.

41.3 *Review — the whole thing, at last*

How many forms does the present tense of a regular -ar verb have?

Chapter 42

42.1 *Synthesis — the same sentence, two continents*

In Madrid, to a group of friends: which verb form?

42.2 *Synthesis — the same sentence, two continents*

The same friends, in Bogota: which form?

42.3 *Synthesis — the same sentence, two continents*

Which of the two is the correct one?

Chapter 43

43.1 *comemos — “we eat”*

Turn comer into we eat.

43.2 *comemos — “we eat”*

Which part of the ending is the same in hablamos and comemos?

43.3 *vivimos — where the two families part*

Turn vivir into we live.

43.4 *vivimos — where the two families part*

What is the only difference between comemos and vivimos?

Chapter 44

44.1 *coméis and vivís — the second difference, and the last*
Vosotros, from comer.

44.2 *coméis and vivís — the second difference, and the last*
Vosotros, from vivir.

44.3 *coméis and vivís — the second difference, and the last*
In how many of the six slots do -er and -ir actually differ?

Chapter 45

45.1 *comen and viven — agreeing again*
They eat.

45.2 *comen and viven — agreeing again*
They live.

45.3 *comen and viven — agreeing again*
In which two slots do -er and -ir differ?

Chapter 46

46.1 *Review — the present tense, whole*
Which row is identical across all three families?

46.2 *Review — the present tense, whole*
In which two rows do -er and -ir differ?

46.3 *Review — the present tense, whole*
We live.

Chapter 47

47.1 *uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco — counting to five*
Write the Spanish numbers 1 through 5 in order.

47.2 *uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco — counting to five*
Say 'one coffee' in Spanish.

47.3 *seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez — and the calendar's old count*
Write the Spanish numbers 6 through 10 in order.

47.4 *seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez — and the calendar's old count*

Were July and August inserted into the Roman calendar or were older months renamed?

47.5 *tener — “to have,” with two visible changes*

Give the yo, tú, and él/ella forms of tener, in that order.

47.6 *¿Cuántos años tienes? — asking age*

Ask one friend 'How old are you?' in Spanish.

47.7 *¿Cuántos años tienes? — asking age*

Answer 'I am eight years old' using the Spanish age frame.

47.8 *Practice — counting, having, and age*

Write the Spanish numbers 1 through 10 in order.

47.9 *Practice — counting, having, and age*

Give the three learned singular forms of tener: yo, tú, then él/ella.

47.10 *Practice — counting, having, and age*

Answer ¿Cuántos años tienes? with nine years.

Chapter 48

48.1 *ser — another way to say “to be”*

Give the three learned singular forms of ser: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

48.2 *ser — another way to say “to be”*

Complete the identification for formal you: Usted ____ Ana.

48.3 *ser vs estar — identity or current state?*

Choose es or está: ¿____ usted Ana?

48.4 *ser vs estar — identity or current state?*

Choose es or está: ¿____ usted bien?

48.5 *soy de... — saying where you are from*

Ask one friend 'Where are you from?' in Spanish.

48.6 *soy de... — saying where you are from*

Answer 'I am from Madrid' in Spanish.

48.7 *está en... — saying where someone is*

Ask formal you 'Where are you?' in Spanish.

48.8 *está en... — saying where someone is*

Say 'Ana is in Madrid' in Spanish.

48.9 *Practice — identity, origin, state, and location*

Complete with es or está: ¿____ usted Ana?

48.10 *Practice — identity, origin, state, and location*

Say 'I am from Madrid' in Spanish.

48.11 Practice — *identity, origin, state, and location*

Say 'Ana is in Madrid' in Spanish.

48.12 Practice — *identity, origin, state, and location*

Complete with *es* or *está*: ¿_____ usted bien?

Chapter 49

49.1 *ir* — “to go,” from more than one historical stem

Give the three learned singular present forms of *ir*: *yo*, *tú*, then *él/ella/usted*.

49.2 *ir* — “to go,” from more than one historical stem

Complete the formal question: ¿Dónde _____ usted?

49.3 *voy a + infinitive* — moving toward the near future

Say 'I am going to speak' in Spanish.

49.4 *voy a + infinitive* — moving toward the near future

Say 'You are going to eat' to one friend in Spanish.

49.5 *mi, tu, su* — whose café?

Say 'my coffee' in Spanish.

49.6 *mi, tu, su* — whose café?

Addressing *usted*, say 'your coffee' in Spanish.

49.7 Practice — *going, approaching events, and ownership*

Give the learned singular forms of *ir*: *yo*, *tú*, then *usted*.

49.8 Practice — *going, approaching events, and ownership*

Ask formal *you* 'Where are you going?' in Spanish.

49.9 Practice — *going, approaching events, and ownership*

Say 'I am going to speak' in Spanish.

49.10 Practice — *going, approaching events, and ownership*

Addressing *usted*, say 'your coffee' in Spanish.

Chapter 50

50.1 *somos* — “we are”

Say we are.

50.2 *somos* — “we are”

Why do *ser*'s forms look so unlike each other?

50.3 *son* — “they are”

Say they are.

50.4 *son* — “they are”

What Latin form is son worn down from?

50.5 *sois* — the last of the six

Vosotros, from ser.

50.6 *sois* — the last of the six

The same thing in Peru: which form?

50.7 *Review* — all of ser

We are.

50.8 *Review* — all of ser

They are.

50.9 *Review* — all of ser

Which of the six does not begin with s, and why?

Chapter 51

51.1 *profesor*

Say: I am a teacher.

51.2 *profesor*

Say: she is a teacher.

51.3 *profesor*

What did Latin profiteri mean?

Chapter 52

52.1 *estudiante*

Build the word for the one who studies, from estudiar.

52.2 *estudiante*

Say: we are students.

52.3 *estudiante*

Decode importante.

Chapter 53

53.1 *-ista*

Decode dentista.

53.2 *-ista*

Say: she is an artist.

53.3 *-ista*

Periodista is built on periodico. What is a periodico?

Chapter 54

54.1 *Synthesis — saying what people do*

Say: we are students.

54.2 *Synthesis — saying what people do*

You have never seen violinista. What is it?

54.3 *Synthesis — saying what people do*

Say what you are, then turn the question around.

Chapter 55

55.1 *estamos — the other “we are”*

Say we are, using estar.

55.2 *estamos — the other “we are”*

Why is estar regular here when ser is not?

55.3 *están — “they are”*

Say they are, using estar.

55.4 *están — “they are”*

Why does estan carry an accent when hablan does not?

55.5 *estáis — and nothing surprises you*

Vosotros, from estar.

55.6 *estáis — and nothing surprises you*

The same thing in Chile: which form?

55.7 *Review — both verbs for “to be”*

We are, with estar.

55.8 *Review — both verbs for “to be”*

They are, with estar.

55.9 *Review — both verbs for “to be”*

Which of the two has a regular plural, and why?

Chapter 56

56.1 *la casa* — “house,” and “home”

Say the house in Spanish.

56.2 *la casa* — “house,” and “home”

Say I have a house.

56.3 *la casa* — “house,” and “home”

Which French word is *casa* worn all the way down?

Chapter 57

57.1 *el libro* — “book”

Say the book in Spanish.

57.2 *el libro* — “book”

Say I have a book.

57.3 *el libro* — “book”

What did Latin *liber* originally mean?

Chapter 58

58.1 *grande*

Say: a big house.

58.2 *grande*

Does *grande* change for *la casa*?

58.3 *grande*

What did Latin *grandis* mean?

Chapter 59

59.1 *cansado*

Say: I am tired.

59.2 *cansado*

Why *estoy* and not *soy*?

59.3 *cansado*

Your decoder finds no English cousin for *cansado*. What does that mean?

Chapter 60

60.1 *Synthesis — describing things*

Say: the house is big, but I am tired.

60.2 *Synthesis — describing things*

A woman says she is tired. Which word changes?

60.3 *Synthesis — describing things*

Put the words in Spanish order: grande / casa / una.

Chapter 61

61.1 *-oso*

You have never seen misterioso. What is it?

61.2 *-oso*

Say: a famous teacher, about a woman.

61.3 *-oso*

Ser or estar for nervioso, and why?

Chapter 62

62.1 *-ncia*

You have never seen preferencia. What is it?

62.2 *-ncia*

Which article goes with distancia, el or la?

62.3 *-ncia*

Say: a big difference.

Chapter 63

63.1 *-ario*

You have never seen imaginario. What is it?

63.2 *-ario*

Why does diccionario mean dictionary rather than word-ish?

63.3 *-ario*

Necesario, said of a feminine noun. What changes?

Chapter 64

64.1 Review — the eight endings

Which of -ista and -oso names a person?

64.2 Review — the eight endings

An -ncia word you have never seen. What gender?

64.3 Review — the eight endings

Decode la posibilidad.

Chapter 65

65.1 Synthesis — reading a paragraph

Decode: la comunidad tiene una tradicion.

65.2 Synthesis — reading a paragraph

Decode: su estructura es voluntaria, evidentemente.

65.3 Synthesis — reading a paragraph

A word you have never seen: especialista. What is it?

Chapter 66

66.1 falsos amigos

Exito is not exit. What does it mean, and why?

66.2 falsos amigos

Actualmente decodes to actually. What does it really mean?

66.3 falsos amigos

An ending gives you a word that makes the sentence strange. What do you do?

Chapter 67

67.1 tenemos — and the stem change disappears

Say we have.

67.2 tenemos — and the stem change disappears

Why does tienes break its stem but tenemos does not?

67.3 tienen — the break comes back

Say they have.

67.4 *tienen* — *the break comes back*

In any stem-changing verb, which two forms never break?

67.5 *tienen* — *the break comes back*

What actually decides whether the stem breaks?

Chapter 68

68.1 *vamos* — *from a verb that is not ir*

Say we go.

68.2 *vamos* — *from a verb that is not ir*

Why does the present of *ir* begin with *v* when the infinitive has none?

68.3 *vamos* — *from a verb that is not ir*

Name the English pair that works the same way.

68.4 *van* — *and the four are done*

Say they go.

68.5 *van* — *and the four are done*

They are (permanently), and they are (right now): which two forms?

68.6 *van* — *and the four are done*

What usually explains a Spanish verb that looks chaotic?

Chapter 69

69.1 *querer* — *wanting with one familiar vowel change*

Give the learned singular present forms of *querer*: *yo*, *tú*, then *él/ella/usted*.

69.2 *querer* — *wanting with one familiar vowel change*

Say 'I want to speak' in Spanish.

69.3 *poder* — *ability with the o → ue change*

Give the learned singular present forms of *poder*: *yo*, *tú*, then *él/ella/usted*.

69.4 *poder* — *ability with the o → ue change*

Say 'You can eat' to one friend in Spanish.

69.5 *e → ie* and *o → ue* — *compare the singular forms*

Give the learned *yo* forms of *querer* and *poder*, in that order.

69.6 *e → ie* and *o → ue* — *compare the singular forms*

Give the learned *tú* forms of *tener*, *querer*, and *poder*, in that order.

69.7 *nuestro, nuestra* — *"our" with singular gender agreement*

Say 'our day' in Spanish.

69.8 *nuestro, nuestra* — “our” with singular gender agreement

Say ‘our night’ in Spanish.

69.9 *Practice* — *wanting, ability, and our known nouns*

Give the learned singular forms of *querer*: yo, tú, then usted.

69.10 *Practice* — *wanting, ability, and our known nouns*

Give the learned singular forms of *poder*: yo, tú, then usted.

69.11 *Practice* — *wanting, ability, and our known nouns*

Say ‘I want to speak’ in Spanish.

69.12 *Practice* — *wanting, ability, and our known nouns*

Say ‘You can eat’ to one friend in Spanish.

69.13 *Practice* — *wanting, ability, and our known nouns*

Say ‘our night’ in Spanish.

Chapter 70

70.1 *hacer* — *doing or making with three singular forms*

Give the learned singular present forms of *hacer*: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

70.2 *hacer* — *doing or making with three singular forms*

Say ‘I make coffee’ in Spanish.

70.3 *decir* — *saying with the same small person frame*

Give the learned singular present forms of *decir*: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

70.4 *decir* — *saying with the same small person frame*

Say ‘I say hello’ in Spanish.

70.5 *decir* — *saying with the same small person frame*

Ask one friend ‘How do you say hello?’ in Spanish.

70.6 *tengo · hago · digo* — *compare only what you know*

Give the learned yo forms of *tener*, *hacer*, and *decir*, in that order.

70.7 *tengo · hago · digo* — *compare only what you know*

Which learned yo form means ‘I do’ or ‘I make’?

70.8 *Practice* — *doing, making, and saying in the singular*

Give the learned singular forms of *hacer*: yo, tú, then usted.

70.9 *Practice* — *doing, making, and saying in the singular*

Give the learned singular forms of *decir*: yo, tú, then usted.

70.10 *Practice* — *doing, making, and saying in the singular*

Give the learned yo forms of *tener*, *hacer*, and *decir*, in that order.

70.11 *Practice* — *doing, making, and saying in the singular*

Say ‘I make coffee’ in Spanish.

70.12 Practice — *doing, making, and saying in the singular*

Ask one friend 'How do you say hello?' in Spanish.

Chapter 71

71.1 poner — *putting or placing with three singular forms*

Give the learned singular present forms of poner: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

71.2 poner — *putting or placing with three singular forms*

What two English verbs does poner cover?

Chapter 72

72.1 salir — *leaving with three singular forms*

Give the learned singular present forms of salir: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

72.2 salir — *leaving with three singular forms*

Say 'I leave Madrid' in Spanish.

Chapter 73

73.1 venir — *coming with three singular forms*

Give the learned singular present forms of venir: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

73.2 venir — *coming with three singular forms*

Say 'I come from Madrid' in Spanish.

73.3 venir — *coming with three singular forms*

Give the tú forms of venir and tener, in that order.

Chapter 74

74.1 Review — *six verbs, one ending*

How many verbs are in the -go set?

74.2 Review — *six verbs, one ending*

Which slot does the -go appear in?

74.3 Review — *six verbs, one ending*

Are these six related to each other?

74.4 Practice — putting, leaving, and coming in the singular

Give the learned singular forms of poner: yo, tú, then usted.

74.5 Practice — putting, leaving, and coming in the singular

Give the learned singular forms of salir: yo, tú, then usted.

74.6 Practice — putting, leaving, and coming in the singular

Give the learned singular forms of venir: yo, tú, then usted.

74.7 Practice — putting, leaving, and coming in the singular

Say 'I leave Madrid; I come from Madrid' in Spanish.

74.8 Practice — putting, leaving, and coming in the singular

Give the learned yo forms of tener, hacer, decir, poner, salir, and venir, in that order.

74.9 Practice — putting, leaving, and coming in the singular

Match each Spanish verb to one English cousin: poner, salir, venir.

Chapter 75

75.1 Synthesis — you, and somebody else

Say I am leaving, in one word.

75.2 Synthesis — you, and somebody else

Now say she is leaving. Is it irregular?

75.3 Synthesis — you, and somebody else

In these six verbs, which slot is the only irregular one?

Chapter 76

76.1 queremos, quieren — work them out first

We want.

76.2 queremos, quieren — work them out first

They can.

76.3 queremos, quieren — work them out first

Poder changes o to ue. What is we can?

76.4 hacemos, hacen — and the club has no plural at all

We do or make.

76.5 hacemos, hacen — and the club has no plural at all

They leave.

76.6 hacemos, hacen — and the club has no plural at all

Decir stem-changes. What are we say and they say?

76.7 *Synthesis — a verb you have never met*

Salir is a -go verb. What is we leave?

76.8 *Synthesis — a verb you have never met*

And they leave?

76.9 *Synthesis — a verb you have never met*

How many rules generate the whole present tense?

Chapter 77

77.1 *la comida — “food,” built from a verb you have*

Build the noun for food from the verb comer.

77.2 *la comida — “food,” built from a verb you have*

Say I make the meal.

77.3 *la comida — “food,” built from a verb you have*

What gender is any noun built with -ida?

Chapter 78

78.1 *las casas — “the houses”*

Say the houses.

78.2 *las casas — “the houses”*

Say the meals.

78.3 *las casas — “the houses”*

How many new rules did this lesson add?

Chapter 79

79.1 *los libros — “the books”*

Say the books.

79.2 *los libros — “the books”*

Why is it los and not els?

79.3 *los libros — “the books”*

Give all four forms of the Spanish word for the.

Chapter 80

80.1 *-es — the plural your first chapter owed you*

Make *español* plural.

80.2 *-es — the plural your first chapter owed you*

Which word have you been using this rule on since long before this chapter?

80.3 *-es — the plural your first chapter owed you*

Why *-es* rather than plain *-s* after a consonant?

Chapter 81

81.1 *Review — all four words for “the”*

Give the four Spanish words for *the*, in the order masculine singular, feminine singular, masculine plural, feminine plural.

81.2 *Review — all four words for “the”*

Say the books and then the houses.

81.3 *Review — all four words for “the”*

State the plural rule in one sentence, including what happens after a consonant.

Chapter 82

82.1 *Synthesis — more than one*

Say I have books.

82.2 *Synthesis — more than one*

Now say I have the books.

82.3 *Synthesis — more than one*

Say I make meals, meaning meals in general.

82.4 *Synthesis — more than one*

What is the difference in meaning between *casas* and *las casas*?

Chapter 83

83.1 *lo — “it”*

Say I have it, replacing *el libro*.

83.2 *lo — “it”*

Does the pronoun go before or after the conjugated verb?

83.3 *lo* — “it”

Which everyday Spanish word comes from the same Latin word as *lo*?

Chapter 84

84.1 *la* — “it,” for a feminine noun

Say I make it, about la comida.

84.2 *la* — “it,” for a feminine noun

What decides whether you say *lo* or *la*?

84.3 *la* — “it,” for a feminine noun

Why does the feminine article match its pronoun exactly, when the masculine pair does not?

Chapter 85

85.1 *me quieres* — “you love me”

Say you love me.

85.2 *me quieres* — “you love me”

In *me llamo* the *me* points back at the speaker. What is it doing in *me quieres*?

85.3 *me quieres* — “you love me”

How many new word forms did this lesson ask you to learn?

85.4 *te quiero* — “I love you”

Say I love you.

85.5 *te quiero* — “I love you”

Quiero un libro means I want a book. Why does *te quiero* not mean I want you?

85.6 *te quiero* — “I love you”

Which old English pair is the same inherited pair as *tu* and *te*?

Chapter 86

86.1 Review — four pronouns, one slot

Name the four object pronouns you now hold.

86.2 Review — four pronouns, one slot

What single question chooses between all four?

86.3 Review — four pronouns, one slot

Which two of the four depend on knowing a noun’s gender?

Chapter 87

87.1 *Synthesis — saying it once*

Answer yes to Tienes el libro, without repeating the noun.

87.2 *Synthesis — saying it once*

Answer yes to Haces la comida, without repeating the noun.

87.3 *Synthesis — saying it once*

Somebody says Te quiero. Say the answering half.

87.4 *Synthesis — saying it once*

Version one of the dialogue was grammatically correct. What was wrong with it?

Chapter 88

88.1 *nos — “us”*

Say they love us.

88.2 *nos — “us”*

Which verb ending is the same ancient word as nos?

88.3 *nos — “us”*

What are the two pieces inside nosotros, and what do they mean together?

Chapter 89

89.1 *los and las — “them”*

Say I have them, about los libros.

89.2 *los and las — “them”*

Say I make them, about las comidas.

89.3 *los and las — “them”*

The article el had to change shape for its plural. Why did the pronoun lo not?

Chapter 90

90.1 *os — “you all,” in Spain*

Say I love you all, as a speaker in Spain would.

90.2 *os — “you all,” in Spain*

Say the same thing the way most of the Spanish-speaking world would.

90.3 *os — “you all,” in Spain*

Which older word is os worn down from, and where is it still said whole?

Chapter 91

91.1 Review — *all eight*

Give all eight direct object pronouns.

91.2 Review — *all eight*

Which four of the eight need you to know a noun's gender?

91.3 Review — *all eight*

Which two of the eight did you never have to be taught?

Chapter 92

92.1 Synthesis — *the conversation without them*

Answer yes to Tienes los libros, without the noun.

92.2 Synthesis — *the conversation without them*

Answer the question about las comidas, saying you make them.

92.3 Synthesis — *the conversation without them*

Say they love us.

92.4 Synthesis — *the conversation without them*

You have been talking about meals and you say los tengo. What goes wrong for your listener?

Chapter 93

93.1 *le* — “to him,” “to her,” “to you”

Say I tell him.

93.2 *le* — “to him,” “to her,” “to you”

How many genders does *le* have?

93.3 *le* — “to him,” “to her,” “to you”

Lo comes from Latin *illum*. Which Latin form does *le* come from, and what was it for?

Chapter 94

94.1 *les* — “to them,” and what this system really costs

Say I tell them.

94.2 *les* — “to them,” and what this system really costs

How many genuinely new words does the indirect set add?

94.3 *les* — “to them,” and what this system really costs

Which four pronouns are identical in both sets?

Chapter 95

95.1 *Which one is the verb asking for?*

State the one-question test in your own words.

95.2 *Which one is the verb asking for?*

Say I speak to her.

95.3 *Which one is the verb asking for?*

Say I have it, about the book, and say which set that is.

95.4 *Which one is the verb asking for?*

Somebody in Madrid says *le veo* for I see him. Has a rule been broken?

Chapter 96

96.1 *Review — two systems, two new words*

Give the six indirect object pronouns.

96.2 *Review — two systems, two new words*

Which row is the only one where the two sets differ in shape, and how?

96.3 *Review — two systems, two new words*

Across both tables, how many distinct word shapes are there in total?

Chapter 97

97.1 *Synthesis — the thing and the person, in one sentence*

Answer yes to *Tienes el libro*, without the noun.

97.2 *Synthesis — the thing and the person, in one sentence*

Say I tell her today.

97.3 *Synthesis — the thing and the person, in one sentence*

Say I speak to them.

97.4 *Synthesis — the thing and the person, in one sentence*

Two pronouns in the same slot, both two letters, both from one Latin word. What is the only thing that tells them apart?

Chapter 98

98.1 *me lo — both at once*

Say I tell it to you.

98.2 *me lo — both at once*

Which comes first, the person or the thing?

98.3 *me lo — both at once*

Say you make it for me, about la comida.

Chapter 99

99.1 *se lo — the pair that does not exist*

Say I tell it to him.

99.2 *se lo — the pair that does not exist*

In front of which four words do le and les become se?

99.3 *se lo — the pair that does not exist*

How many different people can se lo digo be about?

Chapter 100

100.1 *Why se? — and why it is not the se you know*

What did Old Spanish say instead of se lo?

100.2 *Why se? — and why it is not the se you know*

Is the se of se lo digo the same word as the se of se llama?

100.3 *Why se? — and why it is not the se you know*

Which two Latin pronouns were squeezed together to make gelo?

Chapter 101

101.1 *Review — the pairs*

State the two facts that generate the whole table.

101.2 *Review — the pairs*

Give the pair meaning it to us.

101.3 *Review — the pairs*

How many new pronoun forms did this arc introduce?

Chapter 102

102.1 *Synthesis — two at a time*

Say shall I tell it to you.

102.2 *Synthesis — two at a time*

Say I make it for her, about la comida.

102.3 *Synthesis — two at a time*

In se la hago, how many of the three words name anything?

102.4 *Synthesis — two at a time*

You lose track of which thing se la points at. Does the sentence become wrong?

Chapter 103

103.1 *fui — one past set shared by ser and ir*

Give the shared singular preterite forms of ser and ir: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

103.2 *fui — one past set shared by ser and ir*

Say 'I went to Madrid' in Spanish.

103.3 *fui — one past set shared by ser and ir*

In 'Fue Roberto', which verb does fue express?

103.4 *hablé — a regular singular past from a known verb*

Give the singular completed-past forms of hablar: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

103.5 *hablé — a regular singular past from a known verb*

Say 'I spoke Spanish' in Spanish.

103.6 *hablé — a regular singular past from a known verb*

Which form means 'I spoke' as a completed event: hablo or hablé?

103.7 *Practice — two singular ways to talk about a completed past*

Give the three learned forms shared by ser and ir.

103.8 *Practice — two singular ways to talk about a completed past*

Give the three learned completed-past forms of hablar.

103.9 *Practice — two singular ways to talk about a completed past*

Which sentence uses the shared form as ir, 'to go': Fui a Madrid or Fue Roberto?

103.10 *Practice — two singular ways to talk about a completed past*

Give 'I speak Spanish' and then 'I spoke Spanish.'

103.11 *Practice — two singular ways to talk about a completed past*

Which two of hablé, hablaste, habló carry written accents?

Chapter 104

104.1 *comí* — one regular -er singular past

Give the singular completed-past forms of *comer*: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

104.2 *comí* — one regular -er singular past

Which form means 'I ate' as a completed event: *como* or *comí*?

104.3 *comí* — one regular -er singular past

Did Spanish -í, -iste, -ió arise by simple letter-dropping alone, or by sound change plus analogy?

104.4 *viví* — reuse one past pattern with an -ir verb

Give the singular completed-past forms of *vivir*: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

104.5 *viví* — reuse one past pattern with an -ir verb

Say 'I lived in Madrid' in Spanish.

104.6 *viví* — reuse one past pattern with an -ir verb

Which three singular past endings do *comer* and *vivir* share?

Chapter 105

105.1 *tuve* — let the strong stem carry the stress

Give the singular completed-past forms of *tener*: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

105.2 *tuve* — let the strong stem carry the stress

Say 'I had coffee' in Spanish.

105.3 *tuve* — let the strong stem carry the stress

Which phrase best describes *tuve*: a letter-for-letter copy of *tenuī*, or a historically reshaped strong form?

105.4 *hice* — the strong pattern with one third-person *swerve*

Give the singular completed-past forms of *hacer*: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

105.5 *hice* — the strong pattern with one third-person *swerve*

Say 'I made coffee' in Spanish.

105.6 *hice* — the strong pattern with one third-person *swerve*

Which Latin strong-perfect form lies behind the historical development of *hice*?

105.7 *estuve* — a third known verb joins the strong pattern

Give the singular completed-past forms of *estar*: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

105.8 *estuve* — a third known verb joins the strong pattern

Say 'I was well' as a completed past statement in Spanish.

105.9 *estuve* — a third known verb joins the strong pattern

Which known strong form helped shape the family resemblance in *estuve*: *tuve* or *hice*?

Chapter 106

106.1 *Practice — six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary*

Give the learned yo past forms of hablar, comer, and vivir, in that order.

106.2 *Practice — six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary*

Give the learned yo past forms of tener, hacer, and estar, in that order.

106.3 *Practice — six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary*

Say 'I made coffee' in Spanish.

106.4 *Practice — six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary*

Say 'I lived in Madrid' in Spanish.

106.5 *Practice — six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary*

Say 'I was well' as a completed event in Spanish.

106.6 *Practice — six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary*

Which pair carries written accents: comí/comió or tuve/tuvo?

106.7 *Practice — six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary*

Which learned form is especially described as analogically remodeled beside tuve: comí, hice, or estuve?

106.8 *Synthesis — you can hear which past it is*

A preterite with no written accent. Where is the stress, and which kind is it?

106.9 *Synthesis — you can hear which past it is*

Why does comi carry an accent when tuve does not?

106.10 *Synthesis — you can hear which past it is*

In the regular preterite, do -er and -ir take the same endings?

Chapter 107

107.1 *hablaba — let a past action stay open*

Give the learned singular imperfect forms of hablar: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

107.2 *hablaba — let a past action stay open*

Which form leaves 'I spoke' open or habitual: hablé or hablaba?

107.3 *hablaba — let a past action stay open*

Which consonant links Latin -ābam with Spanish -aba?

107.4 *comía — hear both vowels*

Give the learned singular imperfect forms of comer: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

107.5 *comía — hear both vowels*

Which form means 'I was eating': comí or comía?

107.6 *comía — hear both vowels*

Write comía with syllable breaks.

107.7 *vivía* — reuse the complete -er row

Give the learned singular imperfect forms of *vivir*: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

107.8 *vivía* — reuse the complete -er row

Which two infinitive classes share the learned imperfect endings -ía, -ías, -ía?

107.9 *vivía* — reuse the complete -er row

Say 'I was living in Madrid' in Spanish.

Chapter 108

108.1 *ver* — learn the verb before its past

What does Spanish *ver* mean?

108.2 *ver* — learn the verb before its past

Give the learned present forms of *ver*: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

108.3 *ver* — learn the verb before its past

Which Latin verb stands behind Spanish *ver*: *vidēre* or *īre*?

Chapter 109

109.1 *era* — an old root in an open past

Give the learned singular imperfect forms of *ser*: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

109.2 *era* — an old root in an open past

Which *ser* form presents a background past: *era* or *fue*?

109.3 *era* — an old root in an open past

Which Latin form stands directly behind Spanish *era*: *eram* or *ībam*?

109.4 *iba* — *ir* returns to its inherited past

Give the learned singular imperfect forms of *ir*: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

109.5 *iba* — *ir* returns to its inherited past

Say 'I was going to Madrid' in Spanish.

109.6 *iba* — *ir* returns to its inherited past

Which inherited Latin verb stands behind *iba*: *īre* or *vidēre*?

109.7 *veía* — keep the extra e you already met

Give the learned singular imperfect forms of *ver*: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

109.8 *veía* — keep the extra e you already met

Which sentence means 'I was seeing coffee': *Veo café* or *Veía café*?

109.9 *veía* — keep the extra e you already met

Which earlier Spanish form makes the extra e of *veía* easier to see: *veer* or *ir*?

Chapter 110

110.1 Practice — *keep the past open or close it*

Give the imperfect yo forms of hablar, comer, and vivir, in that order.

110.2 Practice — *keep the past open or close it*

Give the imperfect yo forms of ser, ir, and ver, in that order.

110.3 Practice — *keep the past open or close it*

Say 'I was speaking Spanish' in Spanish.

110.4 Practice — *keep the past open or close it*

Say 'I was living in Madrid' in Spanish.

110.5 Practice — *keep the past open or close it*

Say 'I was going to Madrid' in Spanish.

110.6 Practice — *keep the past open or close it*

Choose the open past: comí or comía.

110.7 Practice — *keep the past open or close it*

Match the three forms to their historical bridges: era, iba, veía — eram, ĩbam, veer.

110.8 Synthesis — *three exceptions, and no others*

How many irregular verbs does the imperfect have in the whole language?

110.9 Synthesis — *three exceptions, and no others*

Name them.

110.10 Synthesis — *three exceptions, and no others*

Why are those three the irregular ones?

Chapter 111

111.1 hablaba and hablé — *two ways of looking*

Do the two past tenses differ in when something happened?

111.2 hablaba and hablé — *two ways of looking*

Which form looks at the event from outside, finished?

111.3 hablaba and hablé — *two ways of looking*

Say I was studying, putting the listener inside it.

Chapter 112

112.1 cuando — *putting both pasts in one sentence*

Say I was studying when Ana spoke.

112.2 *cuando* — putting both pasts in one sentence

Which tense sets the room, and which one walks into it?

112.3 *cuando* — putting both pasts in one sentence

Which other Spanish question words share the front of *cuando*?

Chapter 113

113.1 *tenía* and *tuve* — when the tense changes the meaning

Say I had a house, meaning it was simply so.

113.2 *tenía* and *tuve* — when the tense changes the meaning

What does *tuve una casa* actually mean?

113.3 *tenía* and *tuve* — when the tense changes the meaning

You meet a new verb that names a state. What will its preterite mean?

Chapter 114

114.1 *Review* — one question, three answers

State the one question that chooses the tense.

114.2 *Review* — one question, three answers

In *estudiaba cuando hablo Ana*, which verb is the scene?

114.3 *Review* — one question, three answers

Which two rows of the table are NOT the same event seen twice?

Chapter 115

115.1 *Synthesis* — a small story

In the story, which two verbs are the background?

115.2 *Synthesis* — a small story

Why is *tuve un libro* in the foreground when *tenia un libro* was not?

115.3 *Synthesis* — a small story

Say I was studying when I spoke with Ana.

115.4 *Synthesis* — a small story

Why did this take three chapters when neither tense was new?

Chapter 116

116.1 *hablado, comido, vivido* — the participle

Give the participle of hablar.

116.2 *hablado, comido, vivido* — the participle

Give the participles of comer and vivir.

116.3 *hablado, comido, vivido* — the participle

Does the participle change for who is speaking?

Chapter 117

117.1 *he hablado* — “I have spoken”

Say I have spoken Spanish.

117.2 *he hablado* — “I have spoken”

What does haber mean in *he hablado*?

117.3 *he hablado* — “I have spoken”

Which English verb was hollowed out the same way?

Chapter 118

118.1 *has, ha, hemos, habéis, han*

Give all six forms of haber, in order.

118.2 *has, ha, hemos, habéis, han*

Say they have eaten.

118.3 *has, ha, hemos, habéis, han*

Why is haber shorter than an ordinary verb?

118.4 *has, ha, hemos, habéis, han*

How many forms does comido take across all six rows?

Chapter 119

119.1 *hecho, dicho, visto, puesto*

Give the participles of hacer, decir, ver and poner.

119.2 *hecho, dicho, visto, puesto*

Which everyday English noun is the same word as hecho?

119.3 *hecho, dicho, visto, puesto*

Why are these four irregular rather than some other four?

119.4 *hecho, dicho, visto, puesto*

Say we have seen it, using the participle of *ver*.

Chapter 120

120.1 *Review — a tense you build*

What are the two pieces of this tense, and which carries the person?

120.2 *Review — a tense you build*

Say we have lived.

120.3 *Review — a tense you build*

Say you have said it, using the participle of *decir*.

120.4 *Review — a tense you build*

Why did this tense cost less than the present or the preterite?

Chapter 121

121.1 *Synthesis — two shores, two answers*

Say I have eaten, meaning you are not hungry now.

121.2 *Synthesis — two shores, two answers*

For something that happened today, which tense would a speaker in Madrid pick, and one in Mexico City?

121.3 *Synthesis — two shores, two answers*

Two speakers correct you in opposite directions. Which of them is right?

121.4 *Synthesis — two shores, two answers*

Say we have spoken Spanish.

Chapter 122

122.1 *hablaré — keep the infinitive, add the future*

Give the learned singular future forms of *hablar*: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

122.2 *hablaré — keep the infinitive, add the future*

Say 'I will speak Spanish' in Spanish.

122.3 *hablaré — keep the infinitive, add the future*

Which Latin verb meaning 'to have' contributed material to the Romance future endings?

122.4 *comeré — the same endings keep -er*

Give the learned singular future forms of comer: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

122.5 *comeré — the same endings keep -er*

Use the learned -er future pattern to say 'I will drink coffee' in Spanish.

122.6 *comeré — the same endings keep -er*

Which endings do hablaré and comeré share across the learned singular row?

122.7 *viviré — one future row for three verb families*

Give the learned singular future forms of vivir: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

122.8 *viviré — one future row for three verb families*

Say 'I will live in Madrid' in Spanish.

122.9 *viviré — one future row for three verb families*

Give the future yo forms of hablar, comer, and vivir, in that order.

Chapter 123

123.1 *hablaría — the whole infinitive meets -ía*

Give the learned singular conditional forms of hablar: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

123.2 *hablaría — the whole infinitive meets -ía*

Say 'I would speak Spanish' in Spanish.

123.3 *hablaría — the whole infinitive meets -ía*

Write hablaría with the final three syllables separated.

123.4 *comería — keep -er before “would”*

Give the learned singular conditional forms of comer: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

123.5 *comería — keep -er before “would”*

Give the yo pair 'I will eat; I would eat' in Spanish.

123.6 *comería — keep -er before “would”*

Which endings do hablaría and comería share across the learned singular row?

123.7 *viviría — the regular conditional closes its small frame*

Give the learned singular conditional forms of vivir: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

123.8 *viviría — the regular conditional closes its small frame*

Say 'I would live in Madrid' in Spanish.

123.9 *viviría — the regular conditional closes its small frame*

Give the conditional yo forms of hablar, comer, and vivir, in that order.

Chapter 124

124.1 *haré · tendré · podré — three stems, two ending sets*

Give the pair 'I will make coffee; I would make coffee' in Spanish.

124.2 *haré · tendré · podré — three stems, two ending sets*

Give the future and conditional yo forms of tener, in that order.

124.3 *haré · tendré · podré — three stems, two ending sets*

Give the pair 'I will be able to speak Spanish; I could speak Spanish' in Spanish.

124.4 *Practice — one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*

Give the future yo forms of hablar, comer, and vivir, in that order.

124.5 *Practice — one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*

Give the conditional yo forms of hablar, comer, and vivir, in that order.

124.6 *Practice — one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*

Say 'I will speak Spanish' in Spanish.

124.7 *Practice — one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*

Say 'I would live in Madrid' in Spanish.

124.8 *Practice — one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*

Give the pair 'I will make coffee; I would make coffee' in Spanish.

124.9 *Practice — one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*

Give the learned stems for hacer, tener, and poder, in that order.

124.10 *Practice — one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*

Which Latin 'have' verb contributed material to both Romance constructions?

Chapter 125

125.1 *Synthesis — promising, and supposing*

You are committing to it. I will speak: which form?

125.2 *Synthesis — promising, and supposing*

Now you are only supposing. I would speak: which form?

125.3 *Synthesis — promising, and supposing*

What single word is glued onto the infinitive in BOTH tenses?

Chapter 126

126.1 *Hablas español · Quiero que hables español — fact or wanted event?*

Which form asserts that one friend speaks: hablas or hables?

126.2 *Hablas español · Quiero que hables español — fact or wanted event?*

Say 'I want to speak Spanish' in Spanish.

126.3 *Hablas español · Quiero que hables español — fact or wanted event?*

Say 'I want you to speak Spanish' to one friend.

Chapter 127

127.1 *hable · hables · hable — the singular -ar row*

Give the learned singular present-subjunctive forms of hablar: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

127.2 *hable · hables · hable — the singular -ar row*

Which present form gives the stem for regular hable: hablo or habla?

127.3 *hable · hables · hable — the singular -ar row*

What joining idea sits inside the Latin source of subjuntivo?

127.4 *coma · comas · coma — let -er cross to a*

Give the learned singular subjunctive forms of comer: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

127.5 *coma · comas · coma — let -er cross to a*

Which form belongs after quiero que for one friend: comes or comas?

127.6 *coma · comas · coma — let -er cross to a*

Say 'I want you to eat' to one friend.

127.7 *viva · vivas · viva — -ir joins -er*

Give the learned singular subjunctive forms of vivir: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

127.8 *viva · vivas · viva — -ir joins -er*

Which two regular verb families share -a, -as, -a here?

127.9 *viva · vivas · viva — -ir joins -er*

Say 'I want you to live in Madrid' to one friend.

Chapter 128

128.1 *quiera · quieras · quiera — keep the change you know*

Give the learned singular subjunctive forms of querer: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

128.2 *quiera · quieras · quiera — keep the change you know*

Which known present yo form gives the stem quier-?

128.3 *quiera · quieras · quiera — keep the change you know*

Complete 'Quiero que ____ hablar español' for one friend.

128.4 *pueda · puedas · pueda — one more known stem change*

Give the learned singular subjunctive forms of poder: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

128.5 *pueda · puedas · pueda — one more known stem change*

Which known present yo form gives the stem pued-?

128.6 *pueda · puedas · pueda — one more known stem change*

Say 'I want you to be able to speak Spanish' to one friend.

128.7 *haga · hagas · haga — hago lends its stem*

Give the learned singular subjunctive forms of *hacer*: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

128.8 *haga · hagas · haga — hago lends its stem*

Which known present yo form gives the stem hag-?

128.9 *haga · hagas · haga — hago lends its stem*

Say 'I want you to make coffee' to one friend.

Chapter 129

129.1 *ojalá + subjunctive — a wish borrowed through Arabic*

Say 'I hope you speak Spanish' to one friend using *ojalá*.

129.2 *ojalá + subjunctive — a wish borrowed through Arabic*

Does the learned *ojalá* frame require *que* before *hables*? Answer yes or no.

129.3 *ojalá + subjunctive — a wish borrowed through Arabic*

Through which historical language variety did Spanish receive *ojalá*?

129.4 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Choose the wanted-event form: *hablas* or *hables*.

129.5 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Give the pair 'I want to speak Spanish; I want you to speak Spanish.'

129.6 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Give the tú subjunctive forms of *hablar*, *comer*, and *vivir*, in that order.

129.7 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Which present-person form supplies the stem in this chapter's recipe?

129.8 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Give the learned singular subjunctive row of *querer*.

129.9 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Say 'I want you to be able to speak Spanish' to one friend.

129.10 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Say 'I want you to make coffee' to one friend.

129.11 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Say 'I hope you live in Madrid' to one friend using *ojalá*.

129.12 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

What does the Latin source *subiunctivus* help you picture?

129.13 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Name the historical language variety through which ojalá entered Spanish.

Chapter 130

130.1 *Synthesis — claiming, and not claiming*

You are stating a fact about a friend: you speak Spanish. Hablas or hables?

130.2 *Synthesis — claiming, and not claiming*

Now you only wish it were so. Which form follows ojala?

130.3 *Synthesis — claiming, and not claiming*

What did ojala originally mean, and in which language?

Chapter 131

131.1 *habla — telling somebody to do something*

Tell somebody you call tu to eat.

131.2 *habla — telling somebody to do something*

Which form do you use to give a tu command?

131.3 *habla — telling somebody to do something*

Which two English words share a root with imperative?

Chapter 132

132.1 *di, haz, ve, pon, ten, sal, sé, ven*

Give the eight irregular tu commands.

132.2 *di, haz, ve, pon, ten, sal, sé, ven*

Tell somebody to come.

132.3 *di, haz, ve, pon, ten, sal, sé, ven*

Why are these eight so much shorter than every other verb form?

Chapter 133

133.1 *no hables — telling somebody not to*

Tell somebody not to speak.

133.2 *no hables — telling somebody not to*

Tell somebody not to eat.

133.3 *no hables — telling somebody not to*

Why does a negative command take the subjunctive?

Chapter 134

134.1 *hable usted — the polite command*

Politely ask somebody you address as usted to speak.

134.2 *hable usted — the polite command*

Of the four command boxes, how many use the subjunctive?

134.3 *hable usted — the polite command*

Why is the usted command the polite one?

Chapter 135

135.1 *Review — four boxes*

Give all four command forms of comer: tu do it, tu don't, usted do it, usted don't.

135.2 *Review — four boxes*

What was the only genuinely new material in this whole rung?

135.3 *Review — four boxes*

Why is the informal positive command the one box that keeps old irregular forms?

Chapter 136

136.1 *Synthesis — asking without sounding rude*

Tell a friend to come.

136.2 *Synthesis — asking without sounding rude*

Ask a stranger to eat, politely.

136.3 *Synthesis — asking without sounding rude*

In Spanish, where does the politeness of a command mostly live?

136.4 *Synthesis — asking without sounding rude*

You use usted commands with an old friend. What have you done?

Chapter 144

144.1 *la bebo* — *the pronoun tells the truth*

Say I drink it, about el agua.

144.2 *la bebo* — *the pronoun tells the truth*

Why can the pronoun show a gender the article hides?

144.3 *la bebo* — *the pronoun tells the truth*

You meet a new noun and cannot tell its gender from its article. What can you listen for?

Chapter 152

152.1 *Synthesis* — *saying something about your own life*

Say I have a black dog.

152.2 *Synthesis* — *saying something about your own life*

You are mentioning your cat for the first time. Un gato or el gato?

152.3 *Synthesis* — *saying something about your own life*

Say it is cold.

Chapter 157

157.1 *Review* — *four verbs of the mind*

Which of the four verbs originally meant to weigh?

157.2 *Review* — *four verbs of the mind*

Which one meant to gather or pick out?

157.3 *Review* — *four verbs of the mind*

And which one meant to scratch?

Chapter 158

158.1 *Synthesis* — *what you understand, and what you don't*

What does no entiendo literally say, given intendere?

158.2 *Synthesis* — *what you understand, and what you don't*

How do you say I understand now, once it slows down?

Chapter 162

162.1 *Review — three verbs that behave*

Which of the three is the same word as English aid?

162.2 *Review — three verbs that behave*

Which of the three has no agreed etymology at all?

162.3 *Review — three verbs that behave*

In all three verbs, who is the sentence about — the one doing it, or the thing done?

Chapter 164

164.1 *Synthesis — what you like, and who is doing the liking*

In *me gusta el café*, what is the subject?

164.2 *Synthesis — what you like, and who is doing the liking*

What did *gustar* originally mean?

164.3 *Synthesis — what you like, and who is doing the liking*

Which phrase you learned long ago is built from this same word?

Chapter 172

172.1 *Review — the four stem changes, all of them*

How many stem-change patterns does Spanish have in total?

172.2 *Review — the four stem changes, all of them*

Which pattern belongs to exactly one verb, and which verb?

172.3 *Review — the four stem changes, all of them*

Which change does *conseguir* make?

Chapter 173

173.1 *Synthesis — the choices English never makes you make*

You want to say you know a person. *Conocer* or *saber*?

173.2 *Synthesis — the choices English never makes you make*

Someone asks you to move something toward where they are. *Traer* or *llevar*?

173.3 *Synthesis — the choices English never makes you make*

You want to ask for a coffee, not ask a question. *Preguntar* or *pedir*?

Chapter 176

176.1 *para* — “for,” pointing forward

Say it is for you.

176.2 *para* — “for,” pointing forward

Say by tomorrow.

176.3 *para* — “for,” pointing forward

Which Latin piece inside *para* means toward, and which English words carry it?

Chapter 177

177.1 *por* — and you already know three of these

Say thanks for the meal.

177.2 *por* — and you already know three of these

What does *por* favor literally say?

177.3 *por* — and you already know three of these

Which everyday English word is the *per* inside *por*, still meaning through?

Chapter 178

178.1 *Which way is the arrow pointing?*

Say I am doing it for you, meaning you will receive it.

178.2 *Which way is the arrow pointing?*

Now say it meaning you are the reason.

178.3 *Which way is the arrow pointing?*

State the test in one sentence.

178.4 *Which way is the arrow pointing?*

Why is the arrow test not just a mnemonic?

Chapter 179

179.1 *Review* — one arrow

Give the two directions in one line.

179.2 *Review* — one arrow

Name three phrases you already knew that turn out to contain *por*.

179.3 *Review* — one arrow

A sentence takes either *por* or *para*. What should you conclude?

Chapter 180

180.1 *Synthesis — the gift and the motive*

Tell somebody you are making the meal as a gift to them.

180.2 *Synthesis — the gift and the motive*

Now say it meaning they are the reason you are doing it at all.

180.3 *Synthesis — the gift and the motive*

Thank somebody for the meal.

180.4 *Synthesis — the gift and the motive*

You pick the wrong one of the two. What have you produced?

Chapter 181

181.1 *se habla español — nobody in particular*

Write the sign that says Spanish is spoken here.

181.2 *se habla español — nobody in particular*

Who speaks Spanish, according to that sentence?

181.3 *se habla español — nobody in particular*

Say one eats well here.

Chapter 182

182.1 *se compran libros — the verb tells on itself*

Say books are bought.

182.2 *se compran libros — the verb tells on itself*

What is the verb agreeing with in *se compran libros*?

182.3 *se compran libros — the verb tells on itself*

Read *se compran libros* as if *se* still meant themselves. What does it say?

Chapter 183

183.1 *¿cómo se dice? — the sentence that unlocks the rest*

Ask how something is said.

183.2 *¿cómo se dice? — the sentence that unlocks the rest*

Ask how something is said in Spanish, politely.

183.3 *¿cómo se dice? — the sentence that unlocks the rest*

Why is it *se dice* rather than a form aimed at the person you are asking?

Chapter 184

184.1 *Review — the three se's*

Of the three *se's*, which two are really one word?

184.2 *Review — the three se's*

What single thing right after *se* tells you it is the impostor?

184.3 *Review — the three se's*

Which *se* is in *como se dice*?

Chapter 185

185.1 *Synthesis — reading the window*

What does the sign SE COMPRAN LIBROS tell you?

185.2 *Synthesis — reading the window*

A sign has a word you do not know. Ask somebody, politely.

185.3 *Synthesis — reading the window*

Say the food is good here, the way a sign would.

185.4 *Synthesis — reading the window*

Why does leaving the person out give a sign its authority?

Chapter 186

186.1 *el libro que compro — one sentence out of two*

Join *Tengo el libro* and *Compro el libro* into one sentence.

186.2 *el libro que compro — one sentence out of two*

What happens to the repeated noun when *que* joins two sentences?

186.3 *el libro que compro — one sentence out of two*

Which question words share *que's* root?

Chapter 187

187.1 *el libro que compré — the word you cannot leave out*
Say the book I bought.

187.2 *el libro que compré — the word you cannot leave out*
Say the house I have.

187.3 *el libro que compré — the word you cannot leave out*
What English pattern always means a *que* is needed in Spanish?

187.4 *el libro que compré — the word you cannot leave out*
Why can English afford to drop it when Spanish cannot?

Chapter 188

188.1 *lo que — “what,” out of two old words*
Say what I say, meaning the thing that I say.

188.2 *lo que — “what,” out of two old words*
What is the difference between *lo digo* and *lo que digo*?

188.3 *lo que — “what,” out of two old words*
How many new words did this chapter introduce?

Chapter 189

189.1 *Review — three jobs, no new words*
How many new words did this rung introduce?

189.2 *Review — three jobs, no new words*
Say the house I have, and name the trap.

189.3 *Review — three jobs, no new words*
When there is no noun to join to, what supplies one?

Chapter 190

190.1 *Synthesis — sentences worth saying*
Ask whether somebody has the book you bought.

190.2 *Synthesis — sentences worth saying*
Say the thing I do not have.

190.3 *Synthesis — sentences worth saying*

Say what I do not have is the meal you make.

190.4 *Synthesis — sentences worth saying*

Why is a long sentence not harder than the short ones it is made of?

Chapter 191**191.1** *hay — “there is,” “there are,” same word*

Say there is a house.

191.2 *hay — “there is,” “there are,” same word*

Say there are books.

191.3 *hay — “there is,” “there are,” same word*

What does hay agree with?

Chapter 192**192.1** *ha + y — the fossil in a three-letter word*

What two pieces make up hay?

192.2 *ha + y — the fossil in a three-letter word*

Where else in modern Spanish does that y meaning there appear?

192.3 *ha + y — the fossil in a three-letter word*

Which French phrase is the same three pieces, kept separate?

Chapter 193**193.1** *hay que — somebody has to, and nobody in particular*

Say you have to speak Spanish, without naming anybody.

193.2 *hay que — somebody has to, and nobody in particular*

What form of the verb follows hay que?

193.3 *hay que — somebody has to, and nobody in particular*

Name the other Spanish construction that leaves the person out.

Chapter 194

194.1 Review — *three letters*

Say there is a house, there are books, and one must eat.

194.2 Review — *three letters*

Name the two things hay never does.

194.3 Review — *three letters*

Why did a three-letter word need four chapters when comida needed one?

Chapter 195

195.1 Synthesis — *describing where you are*

Ask what there is here.

195.2 Synthesis — *describing where you are*

Say there are books, the ones I bought.

195.3 Synthesis — *describing where you are*

Say what there is, one must eat.

195.4 Synthesis — *describing where you are*

What is left to learn now that the machinery is assembled?

Chapter 196

196.1 *si*

Say: if I have time, I speak Spanish.

196.2 *si*

Which one means yes, si or si with an accent?

196.3 *si*

What is the Latin word for yes built out of?

Chapter 197

197.1 *si + futuro*

Say: if I have time, I will speak Spanish.

197.2 *si + futuro*

Is si tendre tiempo correct?

197.3 *si + futuro*

Why does only the second half get the future?

Chapter 198

198.1 *Synthesis — real conditions*

Say it as a habit: if I have time, I speak Spanish.

198.2 *Synthesis — real conditions*

Now say it as a plan for today.

198.3 *Synthesis — real conditions*

Si and si with an accent: which is which?

Chapter 199

199.1 *hablaron*

Say: they spoke Spanish.

199.2 *hablaron*

Why does hablo carry an accent but hablaron does not?

199.3 *hablaron*

Build the same form from trabajar.

Chapter 200

200.1 *hablamos*

Say: we spoke Spanish.

200.2 *hablamos*

How does a listener know which tense hablamos is?

200.3 *hablamos*

Give the we form and the they form, both past, for trabajar.

Chapter 201

201.1 *comieron*

Say: they ate.

201.2 *comieron*

Now the same form from vivir.

201.3 *comieron*

Which of hablamos, comimos and vivimos is a past form ONLY?

Chapter 202

202.1 *tuvieron*

Say: they had.

202.2 *tuvieron*

Build the same form from *hacer*.

202.3 *tuvieron*

Which strong forms hold the stress on the stem?

Chapter 203

203.1 *fueron*

Say: they were.

203.2 *fueron*

How many meanings does *fueron* have?

203.3 *fueron*

Where did Spanish get the past of to be?

Chapter 204

204.1 *Review — the whole preterite*

Which two *we*-forms are present AND past?

204.2 *Review — the whole preterite*

Name the four stems that had to be memorised.

204.3 *Review — the whole preterite*

Which plural refuses both *-aron* and *-ieron*?

Chapter 205

205.1 *Synthesis — telling what happened*

Say: they spoke Spanish and they had time.

205.2 *Synthesis — telling what happened*

Say: we ate at home.

205.3 *Synthesis — telling what happened*

Swap the *-ron* on *tuvieron* for *-ra*. What do you get?

Chapter 206

206.1 *hablara*

Build the supposing form of *comer*.

206.2 *hablara*

Why does this form have no irregular verbs?

206.3 *hablara*

What did this -ra ending mean in Latin?

Chapter 207

207.1 *tuviera*

Build the supposing form of *tener*.

207.2 *tuviera*

How many verbs does *fuera* serve?

207.3 *tuviera*

How many new stems did this chapter ask you to learn?

Chapter 208

208.1 *si tuviera*

Say: if I had time, I would speak Spanish.

208.2 *si tuviera*

What does the unreal version tell a listener that the real one does not?

208.3 *si tuviera*

Is *si tenga tiempo* possible?

Chapter 209

209.1 *Review — the two conditions*

Turn *si tengo tiempo, hablo español* into the unreal version.

209.2 *Review — the two conditions*

Name the two forms that never follow *si*.

209.3 *Review — the two conditions*

What does *si* itself contribute to the difference between the three sentences?

Chapter 210

210.1 *Synthesis — supposing out loud*

Say: if I were a teacher, I would speak Spanish.

210.2 *Synthesis — supposing out loud*

Say one true-for-you unreal condition about today.

210.3 *Synthesis — supposing out loud*

Which earlier gap had to be filled before this sentence was possible?

Chapter 211

211.1 *dice que*

Report it: he says he is tired.

211.2 *dice que*

Can you leave *que* out, the way English leaves out *that*?

211.3 *dice que*

Which word did you change to report your own words instead of his?

Chapter 212

212.1 *dijo*

He said.

212.2 *dijo*

They said. Careful — the ending is not the one you learned for *tuvieron*.

212.3 *dijo*

Which Latin letter is the *j* of *dijo* descended from?

Chapter 213

213.1 *dijo que*

Move it back: *Dice que esta cansado*.

213.2 *dijo que*

Move it back: *Dice que trabaja*.

213.3 *dijo que*

Why the imperfect rather than the preterite?

Chapter 214

214.1 *preguntó si*

Report it: Trabaja? (he asked)

214.2 *preguntó si*

Does the reported version keep its question marks?

214.3 *preguntó si*

Where have you met this si before?

Chapter 215

215.1 *preguntó dónde*

Report it: Donde trabaja? (he asked)

215.2 *preguntó dónde*

Does donde keep its accent in the reported version?

215.3 *preguntó dónde*

Do you need que or si in front of donde here?

Chapter 216

216.1 *(review)*

Which joint reports a statement?

216.2 *(review)*

Which joint reports a yes-or-no question?

216.3 *(review)*

And when the question already starts with donde?

Chapter 217

217.1 *(synthesis)*

Report the first line of the conversation.

217.2 *(synthesis)*

Report the second line.

217.3 *(synthesis)*

Report the third line.

Chapter 218

218.1 *pero* — *the word that lets two true things stand together*
Say: I am tired, but I study.

218.2 *pero* — *the word that lets two true things stand together*
Does *pero* cancel the first half of the sentence?

218.3 *pero* — *the word that lets two true things stand together*
How many Latin words is *pero*, originally?

Chapter 219

219.1 *también* — *a word with your very first word inside it*
Somebody says *Estoy cansado*. Agree, in two words.

219.2 *también* — *a word with your very first word inside it*
What two words is *tambien* made of?

219.3 *también* — *a word with your very first word inside it*
What does *tan* mean on its own?

Chapter 220

220.1 *tampoco* — *the same frame, the other half*
Somebody says *No estoy cansado*. Agree, in two words.

220.2 *tampoco* — *the same frame, the other half*
What two words is *tampoco* made of?

220.3 *tampoco* — *the same frame, the other half*
Which word tells you to answer *tampoco* rather than *tambien*?

Chapter 221

221.1 *este* — *pointing at what is in your hand*
Say: this book.

221.2 *este* — *pointing at what is in your hand*
Now: this house.

221.3 *este* — *pointing at what is in your hand*
Is *el este libro* possible?

Chapter 222

222.1 *ese* — *pointing at what is by you*

The book is next to the person you are talking to. Say: that book.

222.2 *ese* — *pointing at what is by you*

What decides between *este* and *ese* – distance, or something else?

222.3 *ese* — *pointing at what is by you*

What did the Latin word behind *ese* originally mean?

Chapter 223

223.1 *aquel* — *the far one, and an old friend in disguise*

The house is across the street, near neither of you. Say: that house.

223.2 *aquel* — *the far one, and an old friend in disguise*

Name the three, in order: by me, by you, by neither.

223.3 *aquel* — *the far one, and an old friend in disguise*

Which word from chapter one is hiding inside *aquel*?

Chapter 224

224.1 *esto · eso · aquello* — *pointing at what has no name yet*

You are holding something and have no idea what it is. Ask what it is.

224.2 *esto · eso · aquello* — *pointing at what has no name yet*

Is *esto* masculine or feminine?

Chapter 225

225.1 (*review*)

A book is an arm's length away, right next to the person you are speaking to.

Este or *ese*?

225.2 (*review*)

Which question do you ask first, before choosing a form?

225.3 (*review*)

What does the pointing word push out of the sentence?

Chapter 226

226.1 *muy* — *the same word, bitten short*

Say: I am very tired.

226.2 *muy* — *the same word, bitten short*

Which form goes in front of a noun – *muy* or *mucho*?

226.3 *muy* — *the same word, bitten short*

Can *muy* stand on its own as an answer?

Chapter 227

227.1 *bastante* — *an ending you can already read*

Say: I am quite tired.

227.2 *bastante* — *an ending you can already read*

Put them in order, least to most: *muy*, *poco*, *bastante*.

227.3 *bastante* — *an ending you can already read*

What does *bastante* literally mean, taken apart?

Chapter 228

228.1 *mal* — *bien finally gets its opposite*

Somebody asks how you are, and you are not well. Answer.

228.2 *mal* — *bien finally gets its opposite*

Which form is the plain adjective, bad – *mal* or *malo*?

228.3 *mal* — *bien finally gets its opposite*

What do *mucho/muy* and *malo/mal* have in common?

Chapter 229

229.1 (*review*)

Which of the three means enough rather than a lot?

229.2 (*review*)

When does a Spanish word lose its ending?

229.3 (*review*)

Which ending inside *bastante* had you already learned to read?

Chapter 230

230.1 *al — two words Spanish will not let you keep apart*

Say: I'm going to the cafe.

230.2 *al — two words Spanish will not let you keep apart*

Is a el cafe a more careful way of saying it?

230.3 *al — two words Spanish will not let you keep apart*

Why does Voy a El Salvador keep the two words apart?

Chapter 231

231.1 *del — and then the list stops*

Say: the teacher's book.

231.2 *del — and then the list stops*

How many obligatory contractions does Spanish have?

231.3 *del — and then the list stops*

Does de la contract?

Chapter 232

232.1 *quién — the asking word reserved for people*

Somebody knocks. Ask who it is.

232.2 *quién — the asking word reserved for people*

You want the name of a person. Que or quien?

232.3 *quién — the asking word reserved for people*

Which Latin form did quien come from – the subject one or the object one?

Chapter 233

233.1 *o — one letter, one catch*

Offer a choice: coffee or water?

233.2 *o — one letter, one catch*

Say: seven or eight.

233.3 *o — one letter, one catch*

Is the o-to-u swap about spelling or about sound?

Chapter 234

234.1 *ni* — joining two absences

Say: I don't want coffee or water.

234.2 *ni* — joining two absences

How many negative words are in that sentence, and is it correct?

234.3 *ni* — joining two absences

Does ni mean or, or and not?

Chapter 235

235.1 (review)

How many obligatory contractions must you learn in Spanish?

235.2 (review)

The answer you expect is a person's name. Which asking word?

235.3 (review)

Why does siete o ocho become siete u ocho?

Chapter 236

236.1 *hablando* — an action caught in the middle

Make the -ando form of trabajar.

236.2 *hablando* — an action caught in the middle

How many forms of hablando are there, for all the different people?

236.3 *hablando* — an action caught in the middle

Does hablando mean to speak, I speak, or speaking?

Chapter 237

237.1 *comiendo* · *viviendo* — two families, one ending

Make the gerund of comer.

237.2 *comiendo* · *viviendo* — two families, one ending

And of vivir?

237.3 *comiendo* · *viviendo* — two families, one ending

How many gerund endings are there for three verb families?

Chapter 238

238.1 *estoy hablando — the payoff*

Say: I am eating.

238.2 *estoy hablando — the payoff*

Which of the two words changes for different people?

238.3 *estoy hablando — the payoff*

Can *estoy comiendo* mean I'm eating with her tomorrow?

Chapter 239

239.1 *veo a María — the little a that guards people*

Say: I see Maria.

239.2 *veo a María — the little a that guards people*

Now: I see the house.

239.3 *veo a María — the little a that guards people*

What job is the little *a* doing that Latin did with an ending?

Chapter 240

240.1 *(review)*

Say: we are studying.

240.2 *(review)*

Which of these takes the little *a* – seeing a house, or seeing a person?

240.3 *(review)*

How do you say you are eating with somebody tomorrow?

Chapter 241

241.1 *hablasteis — the form you were promised*

You all spoke.

241.2 *hablasteis — the form you were promised*

Which form is hidden inside *hablasteis*?

241.3 *hablasteis — the form you were promised*

How many forms of the -ar preterite do you now hold?

Chapter 242

242.1 *comisteis · tuvisteis — the last gap closes*
You all ate.

242.2 *comisteis · tuvisteis — the last gap closes*
You all had. (tener)

242.3 *comisteis · tuvisteis — the last gap closes*
Is any part of the preterite still owed to you?

Chapter 243

243.1 *hablábamos — the imperfect gets its plural*
We used to speak.

243.2 *hablábamos — the imperfect gets its plural*
They used to work.

243.3 *hablábamos — the imperfect gets its plural*
Why does only *hablábamos* need a written accent?

Chapter 244

244.1 *comíamos · éramos · íbamos — every one with an accent*
We used to eat.

244.2 *comíamos · éramos · íbamos — every one with an accent*
We were. (ser)

244.3 *comíamos · éramos · íbamos — every one with an accent*
How many irregular verbs does the imperfect have?

Chapter 245

245.1 *(review)*
Which single form of the -aba imperfect carries a written accent?

245.2 *(review)*
Name the three irregular imperfects.

245.3 *(review)*
Is anything still owed to you in either past tense?

Chapter 246

246.1 *para mí — the pronouns that stand on their own*

Say: the coffee is for me.

246.2 *para mí — the pronouns that stand on their own*

Which persons actually change shape after a preposition?

246.3 *para mí — the pronouns that stand on their own*

Why does *mi* take an accent but *ti* does not?

Chapter 247

247.1 *conmigo · contigo — the word that says “with” twice*

Ask: are you coming with me?

247.2 *conmigo · contigo — the word that says “with” twice*

How many times does the word *with* appear inside *conmigo*?

247.3 *conmigo · contigo — the word that says “with” twice*

And with him?

Chapter 248

248.1 *¡Qué grande! — the same word, exclaiming*

Somebody shows you something enormous. React, in two words.

248.2 *¡Qué grande! — the same word, exclaiming*

Say the Spanish for great! or nice!

248.3 *¡Qué grande! — the same word, exclaiming*

What has that accent always marked – questions, or something else?

Chapter 249

249.1 *María, ven — naming who you are talking to*

Tell Maria to come, naming her first.

249.2 *María, ven — naming who you are talking to*

What marks the person being addressed?

249.3 *María, ven — naming who you are talking to*

Does the person you address take the personal *a*?

Chapter 250

250.1 (review)

With me?

250.2 (review)

For you. (informal)

250.3 (review)

What replaced Latin's case for addressing somebody?

Chapter 251

251.1 *ahí · allí — the other two places*

The book is next to the person you are speaking to. Which place word?

251.2 *ahí · allí — the other two places*

And across the room, near neither of you?

251.3 *ahí · allí — the other two places*

Which pointing word goes with *ahí*?

Chapter 252

252.1 *ahora · hoy — now and today*

Say: right now I am eating.

252.2 *ahora · hoy — now and today*

Which word you already knew is hiding inside *ahora*?

252.3 *ahora · hoy — now and today*

And the word for today?

Chapter 253

253.1 *unos · unas — the plural of “one”*

Say: some books.

253.2 *unos · unas — the plural of “one”*

And some houses?

253.3 *unos · unas — the plural of “one”*

Which one talks about books in general – *compro libros*, or *compro unos libros*?

Chapter 254

254.1 *vuestro* — the last possessive

Say: your house, speaking to several friends.

254.2 *vuestro* — the last possessive

Which two possessives change for gender?

254.3 *vuestro* — the last possessive

How many possessives are there in the set now?

Chapter 255

255.1 *vi · di* — the shortest pasts in the language

I saw.

255.2 *vi · di* — the shortest pasts in the language

He gave.

255.3 *vi · di* — the shortest pasts in the language

Why does *vi* take no accent when *comi* does?

Chapter 256

256.1 (*review*)

Which says books in general – *compro libros*, or *compro unos libros*?

256.2 (*review*)

What is hiding inside *ahora*?

256.3 (*review*)

Which set of past endings does *dar* take?

Chapter 257

257.1 *hablo* — one form, two readings

Give the two English readings of *Como*.

257.2 *hablo* — one form, two readings

Somebody asks what you are doing. Which is the ordinary answer – *como*, or *estoy comiendo*?

257.3 *hablo* — one form, two readings

So what is *estoy comiendo* actually for?

Chapter 258

258.1 *hablo · hablas · habla — the ending says who*

What decides the ending on a Spanish verb?

258.2 *hablo · hablas · habla — the ending says who*

Why can Spanish leave out yo?

258.3 *hablo · hablas · habla — the ending says who*

When does the pronoun come back?

Chapter 259

259.1 *mucha agua · pocos libros — when the quantity word agrees*

Say: a lot of water.

259.2 *mucha agua · pocos libros — when the quantity word agrees*

Say: she works a lot.

259.3 *mucha agua · pocos libros — when the quantity word agrees*

What single question decides whether it agrees?

Chapter 260

260.1 *María · España · profesor — the nouns that need no article*

Say: I see Maria.

260.2 *María · España · profesor — the nouns that need no article*

Why does a name take no article?

260.3 *María · España · profesor — the nouns that need no article*

You are speaking TO Professor Garcia. Article or no article?

Chapter 261

261.1 *(review)*

Is estoy comiendo required to say you are eating right now?

261.2 *(review)*

Ella trabaja mucho, or ella trabaja mucha?

261.3 *(review)*

Dropping yo – quirk, or consequence?

Chapter 262

262.1 *primero · segundo · tercero — counting in order*

Say: the first book.

262.2 *primero · segundo · tercero — counting in order*

And the first house?

262.3 *primero · segundo · tercero — counting in order*

What did the Latin word behind segundo actually mean?

Chapter 263

263.1 *uno... otro — splitting a pair*

Two books. Say: one is big, the other is good.

263.2 *uno... otro — splitting a pair*

Is un otro libro correct?

263.3 *uno... otro — splitting a pair*

Did Latin alter mean any other, or the other of two?

Chapter 264

264.1 *comer es bueno — the infinitive as the subject*

Say: eating is good.

264.2 *comer es bueno — the infinitive as the subject*

Is comiendo es bueno correct?

264.3 *comer es bueno — the infinitive as the subject*

Say: speaking Spanish is good.

Chapter 265

265.1 *hoy como en casa — the pieces that move*

How many places can hoy go in Como en casa?

265.2 *hoy como en casa — the pieces that move*

What does putting hoy at the front do?

265.3 *hoy como en casa — the pieces that move*

Why can Spanish move these pieces safely?

Chapter 266

266.1 (*review*)

Eating is good – comer es bueno, or comiendo es bueno?

266.2 (*review*)

How many times have you now seen a word drop its ending before another word?

266.3 (*review*)

Does otro take an article?

Answer Key

The first response is the canonical display answer. When a question accepts other authored forms, they appear underneath.

Chapter 1

1.1 *Grammatical gender — the two noun classes behind el and la*

Answer: two

Also accepted: 2

Chapter 2

2.1 *buenos or buenas — the rule you have been using all along*

Answer: it agrees with masculine plural dias

Also accepted: agreement with masculine plural dias; dias is masculine plural; because dias is masculine and plural

2.2 *buenos or buenas — the rule you have been using all along*

Answer: tardes is feminine plural

Also accepted: because tardes is feminine; feminine plural; tardes is feminine and plural

Chapter 3

3.1 *un — “a,” and the number hiding in it*

Answer: un día

Also accepted: un día

3.2 *un — “a,” and the number hiding in it*

Answer: el día

Also accepted: el día; the first

3.3 *un — “a,” and the number hiding in it*

Answer: one

Also accepted: 1; uno; the number one

3.4 *una — the feminine one***Answer:** una tarde**Also accepted:** una tarde.**3.5** *una — the feminine one***Answer:** un**Also accepted:** un dia; un, dia is masculine**3.6** *una — the feminine one***Answer:** un**Also accepted:** un, from unus; the masculine one**3.7** *Review — the four little words***Answer:** el dia**Also accepted:** el día**3.8** *Review — the four little words***Answer:** una tarde**Also accepted:** una tarde.**3.9** *Review — the four little words***Answer:** from the noun beside it**Also accepted:** the noun; from the noun; it copies the noun

Chapter 11

11.1 *Where does ¿ begin? — bracket the spoken span***Answer:** no**Also accepted:** no it is not; it is not

Chapter 16

16.1 *hablo — “I speak”***Answer:** hablo**Also accepted:** yo hablo**16.2** *hablo — “I speak”***Answer:** o**Also accepted:** -o; the o**16.3** *hablo — one word, one whole sentence***Answer:** one**Also accepted:** 1; just one; uno**16.4** *hablo — one word, one whole sentence***Answer:** English endings wore down so they no longer show who is speaking**Also accepted:** english endings wore down; english lost its endings; english endings dont show the person; because speak never changes

Chapter 17

17.1 *hablas* — “you speak,” to someone you know

Answer: hablas

Also accepted: tu hablas

17.2 *hablas* — “you speak,” to someone you know

Answer: hablo

Also accepted: the first; hablo means i speak

Chapter 18

18.1 *habla* — “he speaks,” and the polite “you speak”

Answer: habla

Also accepted: el habla

18.2 *habla* — “he speaks,” and the polite “you speak”

Answer: habla

Also accepted: usted habla

Chapter 19

19.1 *Review* — the three forms, side by side

Answer: hablo

Also accepted: yo hablo

19.2 *Review* — the three forms, side by side

Answer: habla

Also accepted: ella habla

19.3 *Review* — the three forms, side by side

Answer: hablas

Also accepted: tu hablas

Chapter 23

23.1 *-ción* — about two thousand words, at once

Answer: informacion

Also accepted: información; la información

23.2 *-ción* — about two thousand words, at once

Answer: feminine

Also accepted: always feminine; la

23.3 *-ción* — about two thousand words, at once

Answer: both come from the same latin ending

Also accepted: spanish inherited it and english borrowed it; they are the same word

Chapter 24

24.1 *-dad — twelve hundred more*

Answer: universidad

Also accepted: la universidad

24.2 *-dad — twelve hundred more*

Answer: reality

Also accepted: reality, the quality of being real

24.3 *-dad — twelve hundred more*

Answer: english wore that ending down further

Also accepted: english took it through french and it eroded more

Chapter 25

25.1 *-mente — with no upper limit*

Answer: rapidamente

Also accepted: rápidamente

25.2 *-mente — with no upper limit*

Answer: because mente is a feminine noun

Also accepted: it used to agree with the noun mente

25.3 *-mente — with no upper limit*

Answer: with a rapid mind

Also accepted: with a quick mind

Chapter 26

26.1 *Review — three endings*

Answer: -cion is -tion, -dad is -ty, -mente is -ly

Also accepted: -ción/-tion, -dad/-ty, -mente/-ly

26.2 *Review — three endings*

Answer: -cion and -dad, both feminine

Also accepted: -ción and -dad; the two noun endings

26.3 *Review — three endings*

Answer: -mente, because you can build new words with it

Also accepted: -mente — it makes an adverb from any adjective

Chapter 27

27.1 *Synthesis — reading what you were never taught*

Answer: the university has an international reputation

Also accepted: the university has international reputation

27.2 *Synthesis — reading what you were never taught***Answer:** four**Also accepted:** 4**27.3** *Synthesis — reading what you were never taught***Answer:** a rule reaches words you were never taught**Also accepted:** it applies to thousands of words at once**27.4** *Synthesis — reading what you were never taught***Answer:** no, a few have drifted**Also accepted:** mostly, but there are false friends

Chapter 28

28.1 *f → h — why the h says nothing***Answer:** it marks where an f used to be**Also accepted:** the f weakened to h and then to nothing; it is a leftover spelling**28.2** *f → h — why the h says nothing***Answer:** fable**Also accepted:** fable, fabulous**28.3** *f → h — why the h says nothing***Answer:** ferrum, iron, as in ferrous**Also accepted:** iron; ferrous**28.4** *f → h — why the h says nothing***Answer:** no**Also accepted:** no, some were always silent; no — hola and hasta are not

Chapter 29

29.1 *cl-, pl-, fl- → ll-***Answer:** claim and clamour**Also accepted:** claim; clamour, exclaim, proclaim**29.2** *cl-, pl-, fl- → ll-***Answer:** cl-, pl-, fl-**Also accepted:** cl pl fl**29.3** *cl-, pl-, fl- → ll-***Answer:** clavem, key, as in clavicle**Also accepted:** key; clavicle, clef**29.4** *cl-, pl-, fl- → ll-***Answer:** spanish wore the word down and english borrowed it closer to latin**Also accepted:** spanish inherited and eroded it; english borrowed it later

Chapter 31

31.1 *Synthesis — the decoder*

Answer: folia, leaf, as in foliage

Also accepted: leaf; foliage, portfolio

31.2 *Synthesis — the decoder*

Answer: plenum, full, as in plenty

Also accepted: full; plenty, plenary

31.3 *Synthesis — the decoder*

Answer: the conservation of the city

Also accepted: conservation of the city

31.4 *Synthesis — the decoder*

Answer: it is probably not from latin

Also accepted: it may be arabic, basque or from the americas

Chapter 32

32.1 *Synthesis — the same conversation, twice*

Answer: hablas

Also accepted: tu hablas

32.2 *Synthesis — the same conversation, twice*

Answer: habla

Also accepted: habla usted

32.3 *Synthesis — the same conversation, twice*

Answer: hablo

Also accepted: the same, hablo; hablo both times

Chapter 34

34.1 *comer — “to eat,” and the second verb family*

Answer: -er

Also accepted: er; the -er ending

34.2 *como — “I eat,” and you already knew how*

Answer: como

Also accepted: yo como

34.3 *como — “I eat,” and you already knew how*

Answer: the yo ending -o

Also accepted: -o; o; the yo ending

34.4 *comes — “you eat,” and the first real difference*

Answer: comes

Also accepted: tu comes

34.5 *comes* — “you eat,” and the first real difference

Answer: it is talking to tu

Also accepted: you, informal; it means tu; the subject is tu

34.6 *come* — “he eats,” and the polite “you eat”

Answer: come

Also accepted: el come

34.7 *come* — “he eats,” and the polite “you eat”

Answer: come

Also accepted: usted come

34.8 *Review* — the -er family, all three

Answer: como

Also accepted: yo como

34.9 *Review* — the -er family, all three

Answer: comes

Also accepted: tu comes

34.10 *Review* — the -er family, all three

Answer: the yo slot

Also accepted: yo; the I form; -o

Chapter 35

35.1 *vivir* — “to live,” and the third family (that’s barely new)

Answer: vivo, vives, vive

Also accepted: vivo vives vive; vivo / vives / vive

Chapter 36

36.1 *beber* — “to drink,” and the pattern is yours

Answer: Bebo café.

Also accepted: Bebo café; bebo cafe; bebo cafe.

36.2 *qué* — “what”, a new question word

Answer: ¿Qué bebes?

Also accepted: Qué bebes?; ¿Qué bebes; Qué bebes

36.3 *dónde* — “where?”

Answer: Vivo en Madrid.

Also accepted: Vivo en Madrid; Yo vivo en Madrid.; Yo vivo en Madrid

36.4 *Practice* — asking real questions

Answer: como, vivo, bebo

Also accepted: como vivo bebo; como / vivo / bebo

36.5 Practice — asking real questions**Answer:** ¿Qué bebes?**Also accepted:** Qué bebes?; ¿Qué bebes; Qué bebes**36.6 Practice — asking real questions****Answer:** Vivo en Madrid.**Also accepted:** Vivo en Madrid; Yo vivo en Madrid.; Yo vivo en Madrid

Chapter 37

37.1 Synthesis — asking, and answering**Answer:** que comes**Also accepted:** ¿que comes?; qué comes; que comes tu**37.2 Synthesis — asking, and answering****Answer:** donde vives**Also accepted:** ¿donde vives?; dónde vives**37.3 Synthesis — asking, and answering****Answer:** three**Also accepted:** 3; all three

Chapter 38

38.1 hablamos — “we speak”**Answer:** hablamos**Also accepted:** nosotros hablamos**38.2 hablamos — “we speak”****Answer:** -mus**Also accepted:** mus; amamus

Chapter 39

39.1 hablan — “they speak,” and “you all speak”**Answer:** hablan**Also accepted:** ellos hablan**39.2 hablan — “they speak,” and “you all speak”****Answer:** hablan**Also accepted:** ustedes hablan**39.3 hablan — “they speak,” and “you all speak”****Answer:** vuestras mercedes**Also accepted:** your graces; vuestra merced plural

Chapter 40

40.1 *habláis — the form Spain keeps*

Answer: hablais

Also accepted: habláis; vosotros hablais

40.2 *habláis — the form Spain keeps*

Answer: ustedes

Also accepted: ustedes hablan

40.3 *habláis — the form Spain keeps*

Answer: vos and otros

Also accepted: vos otros; you others

Chapter 41

41.1 *Review — the whole thing, at last*

Answer: hablamos

Also accepted: nosotros hablamos

41.2 *Review — the whole thing, at last*

Answer: hablan

Also accepted: ellos hablan

41.3 *Review — the whole thing, at last*

Answer: six

Also accepted: 6

Chapter 42

42.1 *Synthesis — the same sentence, two continents*

Answer: hablais

Also accepted: habláis; vosotros hablais

42.2 *Synthesis — the same sentence, two continents*

Answer: hablan

Also accepted: ustedes hablan

42.3 *Synthesis — the same sentence, two continents*

Answer: neither, they are regional

Also accepted: neither; both are correct; it depends where you are

Chapter 43

43.1 *comemos — “we eat”*

Answer: comemos

Also accepted: nosotros comemos

43.2 *comemos* — “we eat”

Answer: -mos

Also accepted: mos; the mos

43.3 *vivimos* — *where the two families part*

Answer: vivimos

Also accepted: nosotros vivimos

43.4 *vivimos* — *where the two families part*

Answer: one vowel

Also accepted: the vowel; e versus i; one letter

Chapter 44

44.1 *coméis and vivís* — *the second difference, and the last*

Answer: comeis

Also accepted: coméis; vosotros comeis

44.2 *coméis and vivís* — *the second difference, and the last*

Answer: vivis

Also accepted: vivís; vosotros vivis

44.3 *coméis and vivís* — *the second difference, and the last*

Answer: two

Also accepted: 2; nosotros and vosotros

Chapter 45

45.1 *comen and viven* — *agreeing again*

Answer: comen

Also accepted: ellos comen; ustedes comen

45.2 *comen and viven* — *agreeing again*

Answer: viven

Also accepted: ellos viven; ustedes viven

45.3 *comen and viven* — *agreeing again*

Answer: nosotros and vosotros

Also accepted: nosotros, vosotros; we and you all

Chapter 46

46.1 *Review* — *the present tense, whole*

Answer: yo

Also accepted: the yo row; the I form; -o

46.2 *Review — the present tense, whole***Answer:** nosotros and vosotros**Also accepted:** nosotros, vosotros; we and you all**46.3** *Review — the present tense, whole***Answer:** vivimos**Also accepted:** nosotros vivimos

Chapter 47

47.1 *uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco — counting to five***Answer:** uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco**Also accepted:** uno dos tres cuatro cinco**47.2** *uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco — counting to five***Answer:** un café**Also accepted:** un cafe**47.3** *seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez — and the calendar's old count***Answer:** seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez**Also accepted:** seis siete ocho nueve diez**47.4** *seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez — and the calendar's old count***Answer:** older months were renamed**Also accepted:** renamed; they were renamed; the older months were renamed**47.5** *tener — “to have,” with two visible changes***Answer:** tengo, tienes, tiene**Also accepted:** tengo tienes tiene; tengo / tienes / tiene**47.6** *¿Cuántos años tienes? — asking age***Answer:** ¿Cuántos años tienes?**Also accepted:** Cuántos años tienes?; ¿Cuántos años tienes; Cuantos anos tienes?**47.7** *¿Cuántos años tienes? — asking age***Answer:** Tengo ocho años.**Also accepted:** Tengo ocho años; tengo ocho anos; tengo ocho anos.**47.8** *Practice — counting, having, and age***Answer:** uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco, seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez**Also accepted:** uno dos tres cuatro cinco seis siete ocho nueve diez**47.9** *Practice — counting, having, and age***Answer:** tengo, tienes, tiene**Also accepted:** tengo tienes tiene; tengo / tienes / tiene**47.10** *Practice — counting, having, and age***Answer:** Tengo nueve años.**Also accepted:** Tengo nueve años; tengo nueve anos; tengo nueve anos.

Chapter 48

48.1 *ser* — another way to say “to be”

Answer: soy, eres, es

Also accepted: soy eres es; soy / eres / es

48.2 *ser* — another way to say “to be”

Answer: es

Also accepted: Usted es Ana.; usted es ana

48.3 *ser vs estar* — identity or current state?

Answer: es

Also accepted: ¿Es usted Ana?; Es usted Ana?

48.4 *ser vs estar* — identity or current state?

Answer: está

Also accepted: ¿Está usted bien?; Esta usted bien?; esta

48.5 *soy de...* — saying where you are from

Answer: ¿De dónde eres?

Also accepted: De dónde eres?; ¿De dónde eres; De donde eres?

48.6 *soy de...* — saying where you are from

Answer: Soy de Madrid.

Also accepted: Soy de Madrid

48.7 *está en...* — saying where someone is

Answer: ¿Dónde está usted?

Also accepted: Dónde está usted?; ¿Dónde está usted; Donde esta usted?

48.8 *está en...* — saying where someone is

Answer: Ana está en Madrid.

Also accepted: Ana está en Madrid; ana esta en madrid; ana esta en madrid.

48.9 *Practice* — identity, origin, state, and location

Answer: es

Also accepted: ¿Es usted Ana?; Es usted Ana?

48.10 *Practice* — identity, origin, state, and location

Answer: Soy de Madrid.

Also accepted: Soy de Madrid

48.11 *Practice* — identity, origin, state, and location

Answer: Ana está en Madrid.

Also accepted: Ana está en Madrid; ana esta en madrid; ana esta en madrid.

48.12 *Practice* — identity, origin, state, and location

Answer: está

Also accepted: ¿Está usted bien?; Esta usted bien?; esta

Chapter 49

49.1 *ir* — “to go,” from more than one historical stem

Answer: voy, vas, va

Also accepted: voy vas va; voy / vas / va

49.2 *ir* — “to go,” from more than one historical stem

Answer: va

Also accepted: ¿Dónde va usted?; Donde va usted?

49.3 *voy a + infinitive* — moving toward the near future

Answer: Voy a hablar.

Also accepted: Voy a hablar

49.4 *voy a + infinitive* — moving toward the near future

Answer: Vas a comer.

Also accepted: Vas a comer

49.5 *mi, tu, su* — whose café?

Answer: mi café

Also accepted: mi cafe

49.6 *mi, tu, su* — whose café?

Answer: su café

Also accepted: su cafe

49.7 *Practice* — going, approaching events, and ownership

Answer: voy, vas, va

Also accepted: voy vas va; voy / vas / va

49.8 *Practice* — going, approaching events, and ownership

Answer: ¿Dónde va usted?

Also accepted: Dónde va usted?; Donde va usted?; ¿Donde va usted?

49.9 *Practice* — going, approaching events, and ownership

Answer: Voy a hablar.

Also accepted: Voy a hablar

49.10 *Practice* — going, approaching events, and ownership

Answer: su café

Also accepted: su cafe

Chapter 50

50.1 *somos* — “we are”

Answer: somos

Also accepted: nosotros somos

50.2 *somos* — “we are”

Answer: it is two Latin verbs fused

Also accepted: two verbs; esse and sedere; it comes from two verbs

50.3 *son* — “*they are*”**Answer:** son**Also accepted:** ellos son; ustedes son**50.4** *son* — “*they are*”**Answer:** sunt**Also accepted:** sunt, minus the t**50.5** *sois* — *the last of the six***Answer:** sois**Also accepted:** vosotros sois**50.6** *sois* — *the last of the six***Answer:** son**Also accepted:** ustedes son**50.7** *Review* — *all of ser***Answer:** somos**Also accepted:** nosotros somos**50.8** *Review* — *all of ser***Answer:** son**Also accepted:** ellos son**50.9** *Review* — *all of ser***Answer:** eres, it came from a different Latin form**Also accepted:** eres; eres - different origin; eres, from eris

Chapter 51

51.1 *profesor***Answer:** soy profesor**Also accepted:** soy profesora**51.2** *profesor***Answer:** es profesora**Also accepted:** ella es profesora**51.3** *profesor***Answer:** to declare publicly**Also accepted:** to declare something publicly; declare

Chapter 52

52.1 *estudiante***Answer:** estudiante**Also accepted:** el estudiante

52.2 *estudiante*

Answer: somos estudiantes

Also accepted: nosotros somos estudiantes

52.3 *estudiante*

Answer: important

Also accepted: importantly

Chapter 53

53.1 *-ista*

Answer: dentist

Also accepted: a dentist

53.2 *-ista*

Answer: es artista

Also accepted: ella es artista

53.3 *-ista*

Answer: a newspaper

Also accepted: newspaper; a periodical

Chapter 54

54.1 *Synthesis — saying what people do*

Answer: somos estudiantes

Also accepted: nosotros somos estudiantes

54.2 *Synthesis — saying what people do*

Answer: a violinist

Also accepted: violin player

54.3 *Synthesis — saying what people do*

Answer: soy ... y tu

Also accepted: soy estudiante y tu; soy profesor y tu

Chapter 55

55.1 *estamos — the other “we are”*

Answer: estamos

Also accepted: nosotros estamos

55.2 *estamos — the other “we are”*

Answer: estar is one Latin verb, ser is two fused

Also accepted: estar is one verb; ser is two verbs, estar is one; because estar has one ancestor

55.3 *están* — “they are”**Answer:** estan**Also accepted:** están; ellos estan; ustedes estan**55.4** *están* — “they are”**Answer:** the stress is on the ending**Also accepted:** because estar stresses the ending; stress on the last syllable**55.5** *estáis* — *and nothing surprises you***Answer:** estais**Also accepted:** estáis; vosotros estais**55.6** *estáis* — *and nothing surprises you***Answer:** estan**Also accepted:** están; ustedes estan**55.7** *Review* — *both verbs for “to be”***Answer:** estamos**Also accepted:** nosotros estamos**55.8** *Review* — *both verbs for “to be”***Answer:** estan**Also accepted:** están; ellos estan**55.9** *Review* — *both verbs for “to be”***Answer:** estar, because it is one Latin verb**Also accepted:** estar; estar - one verb; estar, it has one ancestor

Chapter 56

56.1 *la casa* — “house,” and “home”**Answer:** la casa**Also accepted:** casa**56.2** *la casa* — “house,” and “home”**Answer:** tengo una casa**Also accepted:** yo tengo una casa**56.3** *la casa* — “house,” and “home”**Answer:** chez**Also accepted:** chez, as in chez moi

Chapter 57

57.1 *el libro* — “book”**Answer:** el libro**Also accepted:** libro

57.2 *el libro* — “book”

Answer: tengo un libro

Also accepted: yo tengo un libro

57.3 *el libro* — “book”

Answer: the inner bark of a tree

Also accepted: tree bark; bark

Chapter 58

58.1 *grande*

Answer: una casa grande

Also accepted: casa grande

58.2 *grande*

Answer: no

Also accepted: no it stays grande

58.3 *grande*

Answer: full-grown

Also accepted: fully grown; grown up

Chapter 59

59.1 *cansado*

Answer: estoy cansado

Also accepted: estoy cansada

59.2 *cansado*

Answer: it is a state not a quality

Also accepted: because being tired is temporary

59.3 *cansado*

Answer: nothing is wrong the rules are a lead not a guarantee

Also accepted: some words simply give nothing back

Chapter 60

60.1 *Synthesis* — *describing things*

Answer: la casa es grande pero estoy cansado

Also accepted: la casa es grande pero estoy cansada

60.2 *Synthesis* — *describing things*

Answer: cansada

Also accepted: cansado becomes cansada

60.3 *Synthesis — describing things***Answer:** una casa grande**Also accepted:** casa grande**Chapter 61****61.1** *-oso***Answer:** mysterious**Also accepted:** it means mysterious**61.2** *-oso***Answer:** una profesora famosa**Also accepted:** profesora famosa**61.3** *-oso***Answer:** estar because it is a state**Also accepted:** estar it is how you are right now**Chapter 62****62.1** *-ncia***Answer:** preference**Also accepted:** a preference**62.2** *-ncia***Answer:** la**Also accepted:** la distancia**62.3** *-ncia***Answer:** una diferencia grande**Also accepted:** diferencia grande**Chapter 63****63.1** *-ario***Answer:** imaginary**Also accepted:** it means imaginary**63.2** *-ario***Answer:** because -ario names the place a thing is kept**Also accepted:** it is the place the words are kept**63.3** *-ario***Answer:** necesaria**Also accepted:** it becomes necesaria

Chapter 64

64.1 Review — the eight endings

Answer: -ista

Also accepted: ista

64.2 Review — the eight endings

Answer: feminine

Also accepted: la

64.3 Review — the eight endings

Answer: the possibility

Also accepted: possibility

Chapter 65

65.1 Synthesis — reading a paragraph

Answer: the community has a tradition

Also accepted: the community has a custom

65.2 Synthesis — reading a paragraph

Answer: its structure is voluntary evidently

Also accepted: the structure is voluntary, obviously

65.3 Synthesis — reading a paragraph

Answer: a specialist

Also accepted: specialist

Chapter 66

66.1 *falsos amigos*

Answer: success because exitus was the way a thing came out

Also accepted: success — spanish kept the outcome, english kept the door

66.2 *falsos amigos*

Answer: currently

Also accepted: at the moment; right now

66.3 *falsos amigos*

Answer: trust the sentence over the ending

Also accepted: suspect a false friend and check the context

Chapter 67

67.1 *tenemos* — and the stem change disappears

Answer: tenemos

Also accepted: nosotros tenemos

67.2 *tenemos* — *and the stem change disappears***Answer:** the stress is on the stem in *tienes* and on the ending in *tenemos***Also accepted:** stress; because of where the stress falls; *tenemos* stresses the ending**67.3** *tienen* — *the break comes back***Answer:** *tienen***Also accepted:** *ellos tienen*; *ustedes tienen***67.4** *tienen* — *the break comes back***Answer:** *nosotros* and *vosotros***Also accepted:** *nosotros*, *vosotros*; we and you all**67.5** *tienen* — *the break comes back***Answer:** whether the stem is stressed**Also accepted:** stress; where the stress falls

Chapter 68

68.1 *vamos* — *from a verb that is not ir***Answer:** *vamos***Also accepted:** *nosotros vamos***68.2** *vamos* — *from a verb that is not ir***Answer:** the present comes from a different verb, *vadere***Also accepted:** it is a different verb; from *vadere*; *ir* is two verbs**68.3** *vamos* — *from a verb that is not ir***Answer:** go and went**Also accepted:** go, went; went is from *wend***68.4** *van* — *and the four are done***Answer:** *van***Also accepted:** *ellos van*; *ustedes van***68.5** *van* — *and the four are done***Answer:** *son* and *están***Also accepted:** *son*, *están*; *son y están***68.6** *van* — *and the four are done***Answer:** it is more than one verb**Also accepted:** two verbs fused; it is several words; suppletion

Chapter 69

69.1 *querer* — *wanting with one familiar vowel change***Answer:** *quiero*, *quieres*, *quiere***Also accepted:** *quiero* *quieres* *quiere*; *quiero* / *quieres* / *quiere*

69.2 *querer — wanting with one familiar vowel change***Answer:** Quiero hablar.**Also accepted:** Quiero hablar**69.3** *poder — ability with the o → ue change***Answer:** puedo, puedes, puede**Also accepted:** puedo puedes puede; puedo / puedes / puede**69.4** *poder — ability with the o → ue change***Answer:** Puedes comer.**Also accepted:** Puedes comer**69.5** *e → ie and o → ue — compare the singular forms***Answer:** quiero, puedo**Also accepted:** quiero puedo; quiero / puedo**69.6** *e → ie and o → ue — compare the singular forms***Answer:** tienes, quieres, puedes**Also accepted:** tienes quieres puedes; tienes / quieres / puedes**69.7** *nuestro, nuestra — “our” with singular gender agreement***Answer:** nuestro día**Also accepted:** nuestro día**69.8** *nuestro, nuestra — “our” with singular gender agreement***Answer:** nuestra noche**Also accepted:** nuestra noche.**69.9** *Practice — wanting, ability, and our known nouns***Answer:** quiero, quieres, quiere**Also accepted:** quiero quieres quiere; quiero / quieres / quiere**69.10** *Practice — wanting, ability, and our known nouns***Answer:** puedo, puedes, puede**Also accepted:** puedo puedes puede; puedo / puedes / puede**69.11** *Practice — wanting, ability, and our known nouns***Answer:** Quiero hablar.**Also accepted:** Quiero hablar**69.12** *Practice — wanting, ability, and our known nouns***Answer:** Puedes comer.**Also accepted:** Puedes comer**69.13** *Practice — wanting, ability, and our known nouns***Answer:** nuestra noche**Also accepted:** nuestra noche.

Chapter 70

70.1 *hacer — doing or making with three singular forms***Answer:** hago, haces, hace**Also accepted:** hago haces hace; hago / haces / hace

70.2 *hacer* — *doing or making with three singular forms***Answer:** Hago café.**Also accepted:** Hago café; Hago cafe; Hago cafe.**70.3** *decir* — *saying with the same small person frame***Answer:** digo, dices, dice**Also accepted:** digo dices dice; digo / dices / dice**70.4** *decir* — *saying with the same small person frame***Answer:** Digo hola.**Also accepted:** Digo hola**70.5** *decir* — *saying with the same small person frame***Answer:** ¿Cómo dices ‘hola’?**Also accepted:** ¿Cómo dices hola?; Cómo dices hola?; Como dices hola?; ¿Como dices hola?**70.6** *tengo · hago · digo* — *compare only what you know***Answer:** tengo, hago, digo**Also accepted:** tengo hago digo; tengo / hago / digo**70.7** *tengo · hago · digo* — *compare only what you know***Answer:** hago**Also accepted:** yo hago**70.8** *Practice* — *doing, making, and saying in the singular***Answer:** hago, haces, hace**Also accepted:** hago haces hace; hago / haces / hace**70.9** *Practice* — *doing, making, and saying in the singular***Answer:** digo, dices, dice**Also accepted:** digo dices dice; digo / dices / dice**70.10** *Practice* — *doing, making, and saying in the singular***Answer:** tengo, hago, digo**Also accepted:** tengo hago digo; tengo / hago / digo**70.11** *Practice* — *doing, making, and saying in the singular***Answer:** Hago café.**Also accepted:** Hago café; Hago cafe; Hago cafe.**70.12** *Practice* — *doing, making, and saying in the singular***Answer:** ¿Cómo dices ‘hola’?**Also accepted:** ¿Cómo dices hola?; Cómo dices hola?; Como dices hola?; ¿Como dices hola?

Chapter 71

71.1 *poner* — *putting or placing with three singular forms***Answer:** pongo, pones, pone**Also accepted:** pongo pones pone; pongo / pones / pone

71.2 *poner* — putting or placing with three singular forms

Answer: to put or to place

Also accepted: put or place; to put and to place; put and place

Chapter 72

72.1 *salir* — leaving with three singular forms

Answer: salgo, sales, sale

Also accepted: salgo sales sale; salgo / sales / sale

72.2 *salir* — leaving with three singular forms

Answer: Salgo de Madrid.

Also accepted: Salgo de Madrid

Chapter 73

73.1 *venir* — coming with three singular forms

Answer: vengo, vienes, viene

Also accepted: vengo vienes viene; vengo / vienes / viene

73.2 *venir* — coming with three singular forms

Answer: Vengo de Madrid.

Also accepted: Vengo de Madrid

73.3 *venir* — coming with three singular forms

Answer: vienes, tienes

Also accepted: vienes tienes; vienes / tienes

Chapter 74

74.1 *Review* — six verbs, one ending

Answer: six

Also accepted: 6; seis

74.2 *Review* — six verbs, one ending

Answer: the yo slot

Also accepted: yo; the I form; first person

74.3 *Review* — six verbs, one ending

Answer: no, they converged by accident

Also accepted: no; they are not a family; they arrived by different routes

74.4 *Practice* — putting, leaving, and coming in the singular

Answer: pongo, pones, pone

Also accepted: pongo pones pone; pongo / pones / pone

74.5 Practice — *putting, leaving, and coming in the singular***Answer:** salgo, sales, sale**Also accepted:** salgo sales sale; salgo / sales / sale**74.6 Practice** — *putting, leaving, and coming in the singular***Answer:** vengo, vienes, viene**Also accepted:** vengo vienes viene; vengo / vienes / viene**74.7 Practice** — *putting, leaving, and coming in the singular***Answer:** Salgo de Madrid; vengo de Madrid.**Also accepted:** Salgo de Madrid. Vengo de Madrid.; Salgo de Madrid, vengo de Madrid; Salgo de Madrid y vengo de Madrid**74.8 Practice** — *putting, leaving, and coming in the singular***Answer:** tengo, hago, digo, pongo, salgo, vengo**Also accepted:** tengo hago digo pongo salgo vengo; tengo / hago / digo / pongo / salgo / vengo**74.9 Practice** — *putting, leaving, and coming in the singular***Answer:** poner—position; salir—salient; venir—convene**Also accepted:** poner position salir salient venir convene; poner: position; salir: salient; venir: convene; position salient convene

Chapter 75

75.1 Synthesis — *you, and somebody else***Answer:** salgo**Also accepted:** yo salgo**75.2 Synthesis** — *you, and somebody else***Answer:** sale, and no**Also accepted:** sale; sale - regular; no, sale**75.3 Synthesis** — *you, and somebody else***Answer:** the yo slot**Also accepted:** yo; the I form; first person

Chapter 76

76.1 queremos, quieren — *work them out first***Answer:** queremos**Also accepted:** nosotros queremos**76.2 queremos, quieren** — *work them out first***Answer:** pueden**Also accepted:** ellos pueden; ustedes pueden**76.3 queremos, quieren** — *work them out first***Answer:** podemos**Also accepted:** nosotros podemos

76.4 *hacemos, hacen — and the club has no plural at all*

Answer: hacemos

Also accepted: nosotros hacemos

76.5 *hacemos, hacen — and the club has no plural at all*

Answer: salen

Also accepted: ellos salen; ustedes salen

76.6 *hacemos, hacen — and the club has no plural at all*

Answer: decimos and dicen

Also accepted: decimos, dicen

76.7 *Synthesis — a verb you have never met*

Answer: salimos

Also accepted: nosotros salimos

76.8 *Synthesis — a verb you have never met*

Answer: salen

Also accepted: ellos salen

76.9 *Synthesis — a verb you have never met*

Answer: three

Also accepted: 3; tres

Chapter 77

77.1 *la comida — “food,” built from a verb you have*

Answer: comida

Also accepted: la comida

77.2 *la comida — “food,” built from a verb you have*

Answer: hago la comida

Also accepted: yo hago la comida

77.3 *la comida — “food,” built from a verb you have*

Answer: feminine

Also accepted: always feminine

Chapter 78

78.1 *las casas — “the houses”*

Answer: las casas

Also accepted: las casa s

78.2 *las casas — “the houses”*

Answer: las comidas

Also accepted: comidas

78.3 *las casas* — “the houses”

Answer: none

Also accepted: zero; 0

Chapter 79

79.1 *los libros* — “the books”

Answer: los libros

Also accepted: libros

79.2 *los libros* — “the books”

Answer: the plural kept the vowel the singular lost

Also accepted: el is a worn-down elo; they wore down differently

79.3 *los libros* — “the books”

Answer: el, la, los, las

Also accepted: el la los las; el / la / los / las

Chapter 80

80.1 *-es* — *the plural your first chapter owed you*

Answer: espanoles

Also accepted: los espanoles

80.2 *-es* — *the plural your first chapter owed you*

Answer: ustedes

Also accepted: usted becomes ustedes; usted

80.3 *-es* — *the plural your first chapter owed you*

Answer: the bare s would be unsayable

Also accepted: you cannot pronounce it; spanish needs a vowel to get the s out

Chapter 81

81.1 *Review* — *all four words for “the”*

Answer: el, la, los, las

Also accepted: el la los las; el / la / los / las

81.2 *Review* — *all four words for “the”*

Answer: los libros, las casas

Also accepted: los libros las casas

81.3 *Review* — *all four words for “the”*

Answer: add -s, or -es when the bare s would be unsayable

Also accepted: -s after a vowel and -es after a consonant

Chapter 82

82.1 *Synthesis — more than one*

Answer: tengo libros

Also accepted: yo tengo libros

82.2 *Synthesis — more than one*

Answer: tengo los libros

Also accepted: yo tengo los libros

82.3 *Synthesis — more than one*

Answer: hago comidas

Also accepted: yo hago comidas

82.4 *Synthesis — more than one*

Answer: houses in general versus particular known ones

Also accepted: one is indefinite and one is definite; las casas means the houses

Chapter 83

83.1 *lo — “it”*

Answer: lo tengo

Also accepted: yo lo tengo

83.2 *lo — “it”*

Answer: before

Also accepted: in front of it; before the verb

83.3 *lo — “it”*

Answer: el

Also accepted: the article el; el, the article

Chapter 84

84.1 *la — “it,” for a feminine noun*

Answer: la hago

Also accepted: yo la hago

84.2 *la — “it,” for a feminine noun*

Answer: the gender of the noun it replaces

Also accepted: the noun’s gender; whether the noun is masculine or feminine

84.3 *la — “it,” for a feminine noun*

Answer: the masculine lost a vowel and the feminine had none to lose

Also accepted: only the masculine wore down; the sound change only hit the masculine

Chapter 85

85.1 *me quieres* — “*you love me*”

Answer: me quieres

Also accepted: tu me quieres

85.2 *me quieres* — “*you love me*”

Answer: it is the person the verb lands on

Also accepted: it is the object; it is who is being loved

85.3 *me quieres* — “*you love me*”

Answer: none

Also accepted: zero; 0

85.4 *te quiero* — “*I love you*”

Answer: te quiero

Also accepted: yo te quiero

85.5 *te quiero* — “*I love you*”

Answer: querer aimed at a person means to love

Also accepted: because the object is a person; with people it means love

85.6 *te quiero* — “*I love you*”

Answer: thou and thee

Also accepted: thou thee; thee and thou

Chapter 86

86.1 *Review* — *four pronouns, one slot*

Answer: me, te, lo, la

Also accepted: me te lo la; me / te / lo / la

86.2 *Review* — *four pronouns, one slot*

Answer: who or what the verb lands on

Also accepted: who is receiving the action; what the object is

86.3 *Review* — *four pronouns, one slot*

Answer: lo and la

Also accepted: lo, la; la and lo

Chapter 87

87.1 *Synthesis* — *saying it once*

Answer: si, lo tengo

Also accepted: lo tengo; si lo tengo

87.2 *Synthesis* — *saying it once*

Answer: si, la hago

Also accepted: la hago; si la hago

87.3 *Synthesis — saying it once*

Answer: me quieres

Also accepted: y yo te quiero; te quiero

87.4 *Synthesis — saying it once*

Answer: it named the same thing twice

Also accepted: it repeated the noun; nobody talks like that

Chapter 88

88.1 *nos — “us”*

Answer: nos quieren

Also accepted: ellos nos quieren

88.2 *nos — “us”*

Answer: -mos

Also accepted: the -mos ending; mos

88.3 *nos — “us”*

Answer: nos and otros, we others

Also accepted: nos + otros; we others

Chapter 89

89.1 *los and las — “them”*

Answer: los tengo

Also accepted: yo los tengo

89.2 *los and las — “them”*

Answer: las hago

Also accepted: yo las hago

89.3 *los and las — “them”*

Answer: lo never lost the vowel el lost

Also accepted: it kept its vowel; there was nothing to repair

Chapter 90

90.1 *os — “you all,” in Spain*

Answer: os quiero

Also accepted: yo os quiero

90.2 *os — “you all,” in Spain*

Answer: los quiero

Also accepted: las quiero; los quiero a ustedes

90.3 *os* — “you all,” in Spain**Answer:** vos, in Argentina**Also accepted:** vos; vos, in the river plate region**Chapter 91****91.1** *Review* — *all eight***Answer:** me, te, lo, la, nos, os, los, las**Also accepted:** me te lo la nos os los las**91.2** *Review* — *all eight***Answer:** lo, la, los, las**Also accepted:** lo la los las; the bottom two rows**91.3** *Review* — *all eight***Answer:** los and las**Also accepted:** los, las**Chapter 92****92.1** *Synthesis* — *the conversation without them***Answer:** si, los tengo**Also accepted:** los tengo; si los tengo**92.2** *Synthesis* — *the conversation without them***Answer:** las hago**Also accepted:** si, las hago; las hago hoy**92.3** *Synthesis* — *the conversation without them***Answer:** nos quieren**Also accepted:** ellos nos quieren**92.4** *Synthesis* — *the conversation without them***Answer:** they look for a masculine thing and there is not one**Also accepted:** the pronoun points at nothing; the gender does not match what was said**Chapter 93****93.1** *le* — “to him,” “to her,” “to you”**Answer:** le digo**Also accepted:** yo le digo**93.2** *le* — “to him,” “to her,” “to you”**Answer:** none**Also accepted:** one form for all; it does not mark gender

93.3 *le* — “to him,” “to her,” “to you”

Answer: illi, for the one the action is aimed at

Also accepted: illi, the dative; illi

Chapter 94

94.1 *les* — “to them,” and what this system really costs

Answer: les digo

Also accepted: yo les digo

94.2 *les* — “to them,” and what this system really costs

Answer: two

Also accepted: 2; le and les

94.3 *les* — “to them,” and what this system really costs

Answer: me, te, nos, os

Also accepted: me te nos os

Chapter 95

95.1 *Which one is the verb asking for?*

Answer: does the verb act on it or aim at it

Also accepted: can you put to in front of it in english; to whom versus what

95.2 *Which one is the verb asking for?*

Answer: le hablo

Also accepted: yo le hablo

95.3 *Which one is the verb asking for?*

Answer: lo tengo, direct

Also accepted: lo tengo

95.4 *Which one is the verb asking for?*

Answer: no, it is leismo and it is accepted

Also accepted: no; no, that is normal in spain

Chapter 96

96.1 *Review — two systems, two new words*

Answer: me, te, le, nos, os, les

Also accepted: me te le nos os les

96.2 *Review — two systems, two new words*

Answer: the him/her row: lo and la versus le

Also accepted: the third row; lo la versus le

96.3 *Review — two systems, two new words***Answer:** nine**Also accepted:** 9; me te lo la le nos os los las les

Chapter 97

97.1 *Synthesis — the thing and the person, in one sentence***Answer:** si, lo tengo**Also accepted:** lo tengo**97.2** *Synthesis — the thing and the person, in one sentence***Answer:** le digo hoy**Also accepted:** le digo**97.3** *Synthesis — the thing and the person, in one sentence***Answer:** les hablo**Also accepted:** yo les hablo**97.4** *Synthesis — the thing and the person, in one sentence***Answer:** what you mean**Also accepted:** the meaning; whether the verb acts on it or aims at it

Chapter 98

98.1 *me lo — both at once***Answer:** te lo digo**Also accepted:** yo te lo digo**98.2** *me lo — both at once***Answer:** the person**Also accepted:** indirect first; the indirect one**98.3** *me lo — both at once***Answer:** me la haces**Also accepted:** tu me la haces

Chapter 99

99.1 *se lo — the pair that does not exist***Answer:** se lo digo**Also accepted:** yo se lo digo**99.2** *se lo — the pair that does not exist***Answer:** lo, la, los, las**Also accepted:** lo la los las; the direct object pronouns for things

99.3 *se lo — the pair that does not exist*

Answer: five: him, her, you, them, you all

Also accepted: five; him her you them or you all

Chapter 100

100.1 *Why se? — and why it is not the se you know*

Answer: gelo

Also accepted: ge lo

100.2 *Why se? — and why it is not the se you know*

Answer: no

Also accepted: no, they are unrelated; no, they only sound alike

100.3 *Why se? — and why it is not the se you know*

Answer: illi and illum

Also accepted: illi, illum; the dative and the accusative

Chapter 101

101.1 *Review — the pairs*

Answer: person first, and le becomes se before the thing

Also accepted: indirect first; le and les become se

101.2 *Review — the pairs*

Answer: nos lo

Also accepted: nos la; nos lo or nos la

101.3 *Review — the pairs*

Answer: none

Also accepted: zero; 0

Chapter 102

102.1 *Synthesis — two at a time*

Answer: te lo digo

Also accepted: ¿te lo digo?; te lo digo?

102.2 *Synthesis — two at a time*

Answer: se la hago

Also accepted: yo se la hago

102.3 *Synthesis — two at a time*

Answer: none

Also accepted: zero; 0

102.4 *Synthesis — two at a time***Answer:** no, it becomes about something else**Also accepted:** no; it stays grammatical but means something else**Chapter 103****103.1** *fui — one past set shared by ser and ir***Answer:** fui, fuiste, fue**Also accepted:** fui fuiste fue; fui / fuiste / fue**103.2** *fui — one past set shared by ser and ir***Answer:** Fui a Madrid.**Also accepted:** Fui a Madrid**103.3** *fui — one past set shared by ser and ir***Answer:** ser**103.4** *hablé — a regular singular past from a known verb***Answer:** hablé, hablaste, habló**Also accepted:** hablé hablaste habló; hablé / hablaste / habló**103.5** *hablé — a regular singular past from a known verb***Answer:** Hablé español.**Also accepted:** Hablé español**103.6** *hablé — a regular singular past from a known verb***Answer:** hablé**103.7** *Practice — two singular ways to talk about a completed past***Answer:** fui, fuiste, fue**Also accepted:** fui fuiste fue; fui / fuiste / fue**103.8** *Practice — two singular ways to talk about a completed past***Answer:** hablé, hablaste, habló**Also accepted:** hablé hablaste habló; hablé / hablaste / habló**103.9** *Practice — two singular ways to talk about a completed past***Answer:** Fui a Madrid.**Also accepted:** Fui a Madrid**103.10** *Practice — two singular ways to talk about a completed past***Answer:** Hablo español. Hablé español.**Also accepted:** Hablo español; hablé español; Hablo español. Hablé español; hablo español hablé español**103.11** *Practice — two singular ways to talk about a completed past***Answer:** hablé and habló**Also accepted:** hablé habló; hablé y habló; hablé / habló

Chapter 104

104.1 *comí* — one regular -er singular past

Answer: comí, comiste, comió

Also accepted: comí comiste comió; comí / comiste / comió

104.2 *comí* — one regular -er singular past

Answer: comí

104.3 *comí* — one regular -er singular past

Answer: sound change plus analogy

Also accepted: sound change and analogy; sound change, plus analogy

104.4 *viví* — reuse one past pattern with an -ir verb

Answer: viví, viviste, vivió

Also accepted: viví viviste vivió; viví / viviste / vivió

104.5 *viví* — reuse one past pattern with an -ir verb

Answer: Viví en Madrid.

Also accepted: Viví en Madrid

104.6 *viví* — reuse one past pattern with an -ir verb

Answer: -í, -iste, -ió

Also accepted: í iste ió; -í -iste -ió; -í / -iste / -ió

Chapter 105

105.1 *tuve* — let the strong stem carry the stress

Answer: tuve, tuviste, tuvo

Also accepted: tuve tuviste tuvo; tuve / tuviste / tuvo

105.2 *tuve* — let the strong stem carry the stress

Answer: Tuve café.

Also accepted: Tuve café

105.3 *tuve* — let the strong stem carry the stress

Answer: a historically reshaped strong form

Also accepted: historically reshaped strong form; a reshaped strong form

105.4 *hice* — the strong pattern with one third-person swerve

Answer: hice, hiciste, hizo

Also accepted: hice hiciste hizo; hice / hiciste / hizo

105.5 *hice* — the strong pattern with one third-person swerve

Answer: Hice café.

Also accepted: Hice café

105.6 *hice* — the strong pattern with one third-person swerve

Answer: fecī

Also accepted: feci

105.7 *estuve* — a third known verb joins the strong pattern

Answer: *estuve, estuviste, estuvo*

Also accepted: *estuve estuviste estuvo; esteve / estuviste / estuvo*

105.8 *estuve* — a third known verb joins the strong pattern

Answer: *Estuve bien.*

Also accepted: *Estuve bien*

105.9 *estuve* — a third known verb joins the strong pattern

Answer: *tuve*

Chapter 106

106.1 *Practice* — six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary

Answer: *hablé, comí, viví*

Also accepted: *hablé comí viví; hablé / comí / viví*

106.2 *Practice* — six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary

Answer: *tuve, hice, estuve*

Also accepted: *tuve hice estuve; tuve / hice / estuve*

106.3 *Practice* — six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary

Answer: *Hice café.*

Also accepted: *Hice café*

106.4 *Practice* — six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary

Answer: *Viví en Madrid.*

Also accepted: *Viví en Madrid*

106.5 *Practice* — six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary

Answer: *Estuve bien.*

Also accepted: *Estuve bien*

106.6 *Practice* — six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary

Answer: *comí and comió*

Also accepted: *comí comió; comí/comió; comí y comió*

106.7 *Practice* — six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary

Answer: *estuve*

106.8 *Synthesis* — you can hear which past it is

Answer: on the stem, a strong preterite

Also accepted: stem, strong; on the stem; strong preterite

106.9 *Synthesis* — you can hear which past it is

Answer: the stress is on its final vowel

Also accepted: because the stress is on the ending; stressed final vowel; the ending is stressed

106.10 *Synthesis* — you can hear which past it is

Answer: yes

Also accepted: yes, the same; they agree; identical

Chapter 107

107.1 *hablaba* — *let a past action stay open*

Answer: hablaba, hablabas, hablaba

Also accepted: hablaba hablabas hablaba; hablaba / hablabas / hablaba

107.2 *hablaba* — *let a past action stay open*

Answer: hablaba

107.3 *hablaba* — *let a past action stay open*

Answer: b

Also accepted: the b; b sound

107.4 *comía* — *hear both vowels*

Answer: comía, comías, comía

Also accepted: comía comías comía; comía / comías / comía

107.5 *comía* — *hear both vowels*

Answer: comía

107.6 *comía* — *hear both vowels*

Answer: co-mí-a

107.7 *vivía* — *reuse the complete -er row*

Answer: vivía, vivías, vivía

Also accepted: vivía vivías vivía; vivía / vivías / vivía

107.8 *vivía* — *reuse the complete -er row*

Answer: -er and -ir

Also accepted: er and ir; -er / -ir; er ir

107.9 *vivía* — *reuse the complete -er row*

Answer: Vivía en Madrid.

Also accepted: Vivía en Madrid

Chapter 108

108.1 *ver* — *learn the verb before its past*

Answer: to see

Also accepted: see

108.2 *ver* — *learn the verb before its past*

Answer: veo, ves, ve

Also accepted: veo ves ve; veo / ves / ve

108.3 *ver* — *learn the verb before its past*

Answer: vidēre

Also accepted: videre

Chapter 109

109.1 *era — an old root in an open past*

Answer: era, eras, era

Also accepted: era eras era; era / eras / era

109.2 *era — an old root in an open past*

Answer: era

109.3 *era — an old root in an open past*

Answer: eram

109.4 *iba — ir returns to its inherited past*

Answer: iba, ibas, iba

Also accepted: iba ibas iba; iba / ibas / iba

109.5 *iba — ir returns to its inherited past*

Answer: Iba a Madrid.

Also accepted: Iba a Madrid

109.6 *iba — ir returns to its inherited past*

Answer: ĩre

Also accepted: ire

109.7 *veía — keep the extra e you already met*

Answer: veía, veías, veía

Also accepted: veía veías veía; veía / veías / veía

109.8 *veía — keep the extra e you already met*

Answer: Veía café.

109.9 *veía — keep the extra e you already met*

Answer: veer

Chapter 110

110.1 *Practice — keep the past open or close it*

Answer: hablaba, comía, vivía

Also accepted: hablaba comía vivía; hablaba / comía / vivía

110.2 *Practice — keep the past open or close it*

Answer: era, iba, veía

Also accepted: era iba veía; era / iba / veía

110.3 *Practice — keep the past open or close it*

Answer: Hablaba español.

Also accepted: Hablaba español

110.4 *Practice — keep the past open or close it*

Answer: Vivía en Madrid.

Also accepted: Vivía en Madrid

110.5 Practice — *keep the past open or close it*

Answer: Iba a Madrid.

Also accepted: Iba a Madrid

110.6 Practice — *keep the past open or close it*

Answer: comía

110.7 Practice — *keep the past open or close it*

Answer: era—eram; iba—ibam; veía—veer

Also accepted: era eram iba ibam veía veer; era-eram, iba-ibam, veía-veer

110.8 Synthesis — *three exceptions, and no others*

Answer: three

Also accepted: 3; tres; only three

110.9 Synthesis — *three exceptions, and no others*

Answer: ser, ir, ver

Also accepted: era, iba, veía; ser ir ver; to be, to go, to see

110.10 Synthesis — *three exceptions, and no others*

Answer: they are the most used verbs, so they were never regularised

Also accepted: because they are used constantly; most common verbs; they were never tidied up

Chapter 111

111.1 hablaba and habló — *two ways of looking*

Answer: no, in how you look at it

Also accepted: no; they differ in viewpoint

111.2 hablaba and habló — *two ways of looking*

Answer: hable

Also accepted: hablé; the preterite

111.3 hablaba and habló — *two ways of looking*

Answer: estudiaba

Also accepted: yo estudiaba

Chapter 112

112.1 cuando — *putting both pasts in one sentence*

Answer: estudiaba cuando hablo Ana

Also accepted: estudiaba cuando habló ana

112.2 cuando — *putting both pasts in one sentence*

Answer: the imperfect sets the room, the preterite walks in

Also accepted: imperfect is the scene, preterite is the event

112.3 cuando — *putting both pasts in one sentence*

Answer: que, quien, como

Also accepted: qué, quién, cómo; que and quien

Chapter 113

113.1 *tenía and tuve — when the tense changes the meaning*

Answer: tenía una casa

Also accepted: tenía una casa; yo tenía una casa

113.2 *tenía and tuve — when the tense changes the meaning*

Answer: i got a house

Also accepted: i received a house; the moment i came to have one

113.3 *tenía and tuve — when the tense changes the meaning*

Answer: the moment the state began

Also accepted: when it started; the start of the state

Chapter 114

114.1 *Review — one question, three answers*

Answer: am i saying what happened or what things were like

Also accepted: what happened versus what things were like; does it have edges

114.2 *Review — one question, three answers*

Answer: estudiaba

Also accepted: the imperfect one; estudiaba, the imperfect

114.3 *Review — one question, three answers*

Answer: the state rows, tenía and tuve

Also accepted: rows three and four; tenía and tuve

Chapter 115

115.1 *Synthesis — a small story*

Answer: estudiaba and tenía

Also accepted: estudiaba, tenía; the imperfects

115.2 *Synthesis — a small story*

Answer: tuve is the moment of getting it

Also accepted: because it is an event, not a state; getting has edges

115.3 *Synthesis — a small story*

Answer: estudiaba cuando hable con Ana

Also accepted: estudiaba cuando hablé con ana

115.4 *Synthesis — a small story*

Answer: because the choice is the difficulty, not the forms

Also accepted: english lets you leave the question unanswered; the forms were never the hard part

Chapter 116

116.1 *hablado, comido, vivido — the participle*

Answer: hablado

Also accepted: habl-ado

116.2 *hablado, comido, vivido — the participle*

Answer: comido, vivido

Also accepted: comido vivido

116.3 *hablado, comido, vivido — the participle*

Answer: no

Also accepted: no, it stays the same

Chapter 117

117.1 *he hablado — “I have spoken”*

Answer: he hablado espanol

Also accepted: he hablado español; yo he hablado espanol

117.2 *he hablado — “I have spoken”*

Answer: nothing on its own

Also accepted: nothing; it has no meaning here, only a job

117.3 *he hablado — “I have spoken”*

Answer: have

Also accepted: to have; have, as in I have eaten

Chapter 118

118.1 *has, ha, hemos, habéis, han*

Answer: he, has, ha, hemos, habeis, han

Also accepted: he has ha hemos habéis han

118.2 *has, ha, hemos, habéis, han*

Answer: han comido

Also accepted: ellos han comido; ustedes han comido

118.3 *has, ha, hemos, habéis, han*

Answer: because it is said more often

Also accepted: frequency wears words down; it is used in every perfect sentence

118.4 *has, ha, hemos, habéis, han*

Answer: one

Also accepted: 1; it never changes

Chapter 119

119.1 *hecho, dicho, visto, puesto*

Answer: hecho, dicho, visto, puesto

Also accepted: hecho dicho visto puesto

119.2 *hecho, dicho, visto, puesto*

Answer: fact

Also accepted: fact, from factum

119.3 *hecho, dicho, visto, puesto*

Answer: they are the most used

Also accepted: because they are the commonest verbs; frequency

119.4 *hecho, dicho, visto, puesto*

Answer: lo hemos visto

Also accepted: hemos visto

Chapter 120

120.1 *Review — a tense you build*

Answer: haber and the participle; haber carries the person

Also accepted: a form of haber plus a participle

120.2 *Review — a tense you build*

Answer: hemos vivido

Also accepted: nosotros hemos vivido

120.3 *Review — a tense you build*

Answer: lo has dicho

Also accepted: has dicho

120.4 *Review — a tense you build*

Answer: it is built from two pieces rather than conjugated per verb

Also accepted: six words once, not endings on every verb

Chapter 121

121.1 *Synthesis — two shores, two answers*

Answer: he comido

Also accepted: yo he comido

121.2 *Synthesis — two shores, two answers*

Answer: madrid the perfect, mexico the preterite

Also accepted: he hablado in spain, hable in latin america

121.3 *Synthesis — two shores, two answers*

Answer: both, for their own variety

Also accepted: both; neither is wrong

121.4 *Synthesis — two shores, two answers***Answer:** hemos hablado español**Also accepted:** hemos hablado español

Chapter 122

122.1 *hablaré — keep the infinitive, add the future***Answer:** hablaré, hablarás, hablará**Also accepted:** hablaré hablarás hablará; hablaré / hablarás / hablará**122.2** *hablaré — keep the infinitive, add the future***Answer:** Hablaré español.**Also accepted:** Hablaré español**122.3** *hablaré — keep the infinitive, add the future***Answer:** habēre**Also accepted:** habere; haber**122.4** *comeré — the same endings keep -er***Answer:** comeré, comerás, comerá**Also accepted:** comeré comerás comerá; comeré / comerás / comerá**122.5** *comeré — the same endings keep -er***Answer:** Beberé café.**Also accepted:** Beberé café; Bebere cafe; Bebere cafe.**122.6** *comeré — the same endings keep -er***Answer:** -é, -ás, -á**Also accepted:** é ás á; -é -ás -á**122.7** *viviré — one future row for three verb families***Answer:** viviré, vivirás, vivirá**Also accepted:** viviré vivirás vivirá; viviré / vivirás / vivirá**122.8** *viviré — one future row for three verb families***Answer:** Viviré en Madrid.**Also accepted:** Viviré en Madrid**122.9** *viviré — one future row for three verb families***Answer:** hablaré, comeré, viviré**Also accepted:** hablaré comeré viviré; hablaré / comeré / viviré

Chapter 123

123.1 *hablaría — the whole infinitive meets -ía***Answer:** hablaría, hablarías, hablaría**Also accepted:** hablaría hablarías hablaría; hablaría / hablarías / hablaría

123.2 *hablaría — the whole infinitive meets -ía*

Answer: Hablaría español.

Also accepted: Hablaría español

123.3 *hablaría — the whole infinitive meets -ía*

Answer: ha-bla-rí-a

Also accepted: habla-rí-a; rí-a

123.4 *comería — keep -er before “would”*

Answer: comería, comerías, comería

Also accepted: comería comerías comería; comería / comerías / comería

123.5 *comería — keep -er before “would”*

Answer: Comeré; comería.

Also accepted: Comeré comería; comeré / comería

123.6 *comería — keep -er before “would”*

Answer: -ía, -ías, -ía

Also accepted: ía ías ía; -ía -ías -ía

123.7 *viviría — the regular conditional closes its small frame*

Answer: viviría, vivirías, viviría

Also accepted: viviría vivirías viviría; viviría / vivirías / viviría

123.8 *viviría — the regular conditional closes its small frame*

Answer: Viviría en Madrid.

Also accepted: Viviría en Madrid

123.9 *viviría — the regular conditional closes its small frame*

Answer: hablaría, comería, viviría

Also accepted: hablaría comería viviría; hablaría / comería / viviría

Chapter 124

124.1 *haré · tendré · podré — three stems, two ending sets*

Answer: Haré café; haría café.

Also accepted: Haré café Haría café; haré café / haría café

124.2 *haré · tendré · podré — three stems, two ending sets*

Answer: tendré, tendría

Also accepted: tendré tendría; tendré / tendría

124.3 *haré · tendré · podré — three stems, two ending sets*

Answer: Podré hablar español; podría hablar español.

Also accepted: Podré hablar español Podría hablar español; podré hablar español / podría hablar español

124.4 *Practice — one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*

Answer: hablaré, comeré, viviré

Also accepted: hablaré comeré viviré; hablaré / comeré / viviré

124.5 Practice — *one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*

Answer: hablaría, comería, viviría

Also accepted: hablaría comería viviría; hablaría / comería / viviría

124.6 Practice — *one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*

Answer: Hablaré español.

Also accepted: Hablaré español

124.7 Practice — *one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*

Answer: Viviría en Madrid.

Also accepted: Viviría en Madrid

124.8 Practice — *one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*

Answer: Haré café; haría café.

Also accepted: Haré café Haría café; haré café / haría café

124.9 Practice — *one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*

Answer: har-, tendr-, podr-

Also accepted: har tendr podr; har- / tendr- / podr-

124.10 Practice — *one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*

Answer: habere

Also accepted: habere; haber

Chapter 125

125.1 Synthesis — *promising, and supposing*

Answer: hablaré

Also accepted: hablaré; yo hablaré

125.2 Synthesis — *promising, and supposing*

Answer: hablaría

Also accepted: hablaría; yo hablaría

125.3 Synthesis — *promising, and supposing*

Answer: haber

Also accepted: habere; the verb to have; have

Chapter 126

126.1 Hablas español · *Quiero que hables español — fact or wanted event?*

Answer: hablas

126.2 Hablas español · *Quiero que hables español — fact or wanted event?*

Answer: Quiero hablar español.

Also accepted: Quiero hablar español

126.3 Hablas español · *Quiero que hables español — fact or wanted event?*

Answer: Quiero que hables español.

Also accepted: Quiero que hables español

Chapter 127

127.1 *hable · hables · hable — the singular -ar row*

Answer: hable, hables, hable

Also accepted: hable hables hable; hable / hables / hable

127.2 *hable · hables · hable — the singular -ar row*

Answer: hablo

127.3 *hable · hables · hable — the singular -ar row*

Answer: subjoined or joined under

Also accepted: subjoined; joined under

127.4 *coma · comas · coma — let -er cross to a*

Answer: coma, comas, coma

Also accepted: coma comas coma; coma / comas / coma

127.5 *coma · comas · coma — let -er cross to a*

Answer: comas

127.6 *coma · comas · coma — let -er cross to a*

Answer: Quiero que comas.

Also accepted: Quiero que comas

127.7 *viva · vivas · viva — -ir joins -er*

Answer: viva, vivas, viva

Also accepted: viva vivas viva; viva / vivas / viva

127.8 *viva · vivas · viva — -ir joins -er*

Answer: -er and -ir

Also accepted: er and ir; -er / -ir

127.9 *viva · vivas · viva — -ir joins -er*

Answer: Quiero que vivas en Madrid.

Also accepted: Quiero que vivas en Madrid

Chapter 128

128.1 *quiera · quieras · quiera — keep the change you know*

Answer: quiera, quieras, quiera

Also accepted: quiera quieras quiera; quiera / quieras / quiera

128.2 *quiera · quieras · quiera — keep the change you know*

Answer: quiero

128.3 *quiera · quieras · quiera — keep the change you know*

Answer: quieras

128.4 *pueda · puedas · pueda — one more known stem change*

Answer: pueda, puedas, pueda

Also accepted: pueda puedas pueda; pueda / puedas / pueda

128.5 *pueda · puedas · pueda — one more known stem change*

Answer: puedo

128.6 *pueda · puedas · pueda — one more known stem change*

Answer: Quiero que puedas hablar español.

Also accepted: Quiero que puedas hablar español

128.7 *haga · hagas · haga — hago lends its stem*

Answer: haga, hagas, haga

Also accepted: haga hagas haga; haga / hagas / haga

128.8 *haga · hagas · haga — hago lends its stem*

Answer: hago

128.9 *haga · hagas · haga — hago lends its stem*

Answer: Quiero que hagas café.

Also accepted: Quiero que hagas café; Quiero que hagas cafe

Chapter 129

129.1 *ojalá + subjunctive — a wish borrowed through Arabic*

Answer: Ojalá hables español.

Also accepted: Ojalá hables español; Ojala hables espanol

129.2 *ojalá + subjunctive — a wish borrowed through Arabic*

Answer: no

129.3 *ojalá + subjunctive — a wish borrowed through Arabic*

Answer: Hispanic Arabic

Also accepted: Arabic; Andalusí Arabic; Hispano-Arabic

129.4 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Answer: hables

129.5 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Answer: Quiero hablar español; quiero que hables español.

Also accepted: Quiero hablar español Quiero que hables español; Quiero hablar español / quiero que hables español

129.6 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Answer: hables, comas, vivas

Also accepted: hables comas vivas; hables / comas / vivas

129.7 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Answer: the yo form

Also accepted: yo; present yo form

129.8 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Answer: quiera, quieras, quiera

Also accepted: quiera quieras quiera; quiera / quieras / quiera

129.9 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Answer: Quiero que puedas hablar español.

Also accepted: Quiero que puedas hablar español

129.10 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Answer: Quiero que hagas café.

Also accepted: Quiero que hagas café; Quiero que hagas cafe

129.11 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Answer: Ojalá vivas en Madrid.

Also accepted: Ojalá vivas en Madrid; Ojala vivas en Madrid

129.12 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Answer: a clause subjoined or joined under another

Also accepted: subjoined; joined under

129.13 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Answer: Hispanic Arabic

Also accepted: Arabic; Andalusí Arabic; Hispano-Arabic

Chapter 130

130.1 *Synthesis — claiming, and not claiming*

Answer: hablas

Also accepted: hablas - indicative

130.2 *Synthesis — claiming, and not claiming*

Answer: hables

Also accepted: hables - subjunctive; ojala hables

130.3 *Synthesis — claiming, and not claiming*

Answer: may God will it, in Arabic

Also accepted: arabic, may god will it; and may god will it; wa sha allah

Chapter 131

131.1 *habla — telling somebody to do something*

Answer: come

Also accepted: ¡come!; come!

131.2 *habla — telling somebody to do something*

Answer: the he/she present form

Also accepted: the third person singular; the el form

131.3 *habla — telling somebody to do something*

Answer: emperor and empire

Also accepted: emperor, empire

Chapter 132

132.1 *di, haz, ve, pon, ten, sal, sé, ven*

Answer: di, haz, ve, pon, ten, sal, se, ven

Also accepted: di haz ve pon ten sal sé ven

132.2 *di, haz, ve, pon, ten, sal, sé, ven*

Answer: ven

Also accepted: ¡ven!

132.3 *di, haz, ve, pon, ten, sal, sé, ven*

Answer: commands are shouted and hurried, so they wore down most

Also accepted: because they are the most used and most shouted; frequency and hurry

Chapter 133

133.1 *no hables — telling somebody not to*

Answer: no hables

Also accepted: ¡no hables!

133.2 *no hables — telling somebody not to*

Answer: no comas

Also accepted: ¡no comas!

133.3 *no hables — telling somebody not to*

Answer: because nothing is being asserted

Also accepted: there is no speaking to describe; the subjunctive is the non-asserting form

Chapter 134

134.1 *hable usted — the polite command*

Answer: hable, por favor

Also accepted: hable por favor; hable usted por favor

134.2 *hable usted — the polite command*

Answer: three

Also accepted: 3; all but the informal positive

134.3 *hable usted — the polite command*

Answer: it is aimed at a title, not at the person

Also accepted: usted is third person, so the order is indirect; because it is not pointed straight at them

Chapter 135

135.1 *Review — four boxes*

Answer: come, no comas, coma, no coma

Also accepted: come no comas coma no coma

135.2 *Review — four boxes*

Answer: the eight irregular tu commands

Also accepted: eight one-syllable words; di haz ve pon ten sal se ven

135.3 *Review — four boxes*

Answer: it is said the most

Also accepted: because it is the most used; heavy use keeps old forms alive

Chapter 136

136.1 *Synthesis — asking without sounding rude*

Answer: ven

Also accepted: ¡ven!

136.2 *Synthesis — asking without sounding rude*

Answer: coma, por favor

Also accepted: coma por favor

136.3 *Synthesis — asking without sounding rude*

Answer: in the choice of tu or usted

Also accepted: in which person you chose; in the pronoun

136.4 *Synthesis — asking without sounding rude*

Answer: put distance between you

Also accepted: sounded stiff; been cold rather than polite

Chapter 144

144.1 *la bebo — the pronoun tells the truth*

Answer: la bebo

Also accepted: yo la bebo

144.2 *la bebo — the pronoun tells the truth*

Answer: nothing collides in front of the pronoun

Also accepted: the article changes for sound, the pronoun does not; there are no two a sounds meeting

144.3 *la bebo — the pronoun tells the truth*

Answer: which object pronoun a speaker uses for it

Also accepted: whether they say lo or la; the pronoun

Chapter 152

152.1 *Synthesis — saying something about your own life*

Answer: tengo un perro negro

Also accepted: yo tengo un perro negro

152.2 *Synthesis — saying something about your own life*

Answer: un gato

Also accepted: un; un gato blanco

152.3 *Synthesis — saying something about your own life*

Answer: hace frío

Also accepted: hace frío

Chapter 157

157.1 *Review — four verbs of the mind*

Answer: pensar

Also accepted: pensar (to think); think

157.2 *Review — four verbs of the mind*

Answer: leer

Also accepted: leer (to read); read

157.3 *Review — four verbs of the mind*

Answer: escribir

Also accepted: escribir (to write); write

Chapter 158

158.1 *Synthesis — what you understand, and what you don't*

Answer: I am not stretching that far

Also accepted: i am not reaching that far; not stretching toward it; i cannot stretch that far

158.2 *Synthesis — what you understand, and what you don't*

Answer: ahora entiendo

Also accepted: entiendo; entiendo ahora

Chapter 162

162.1 *Review — three verbs that behave*

Answer: ayudar

Also accepted: ayudar (to help); help

162.2 *Review — three verbs that behave***Answer:** tomar**Also accepted:** tomar (to take); take**162.3** *Review — three verbs that behave***Answer:** the one doing it**Also accepted:** the doer; the person doing it; the subject does it

Chapter 164

164.1 *Synthesis — what you like, and who is doing the liking***Answer:** el café**Also accepted:** the coffee; café; el café**164.2** *Synthesis — what you like, and who is doing the liking***Answer:** to taste**Also accepted:** taste; tasting**164.3** *Synthesis — what you like, and who is doing the liking***Answer:** mucho gusto**Also accepted:** gusto; much pleasure

Chapter 172

172.1 *Review — the four stem changes, all of them***Answer:** four**Also accepted:** 4; cuatro**172.2** *Review — the four stem changes, all of them***Answer:** u to ue, jugar**Also accepted:** u-ue, jugar; jugar, u to ue; jugar**172.3** *Review — the four stem changes, all of them***Answer:** e to i**Also accepted:** e-i; e becomes i; consigo

Chapter 173

173.1 *Synthesis — the choices English never makes you make***Answer:** conocer**Also accepted:** conocer (acquaintance); conozco**173.2** *Synthesis — the choices English never makes you make***Answer:** traer**Also accepted:** traer (toward); bring

173.3 *Synthesis — the choices English never makes you make*

Answer: pedir

Also accepted: pedir (request); pedir un café

Chapter 176

176.1 *para — “for,” pointing forward*

Answer: es para ti

Also accepted: para ti

176.2 *para — “for,” pointing forward*

Answer: para mañana

Also accepted: para mañana

176.3 *para — “for,” pointing forward*

Answer: ad, as in advance and admit

Also accepted: ad; ad — advance, admit, adhere

Chapter 177

177.1 *por — and you already know three of these*

Answer: gracias por la comida

Also accepted: gracias por la comida.

177.2 *por — and you already know three of these*

Answer: by way of a favour

Also accepted: through a favour; by means of a favour

177.3 *por — and you already know three of these*

Answer: per, as in per hour

Also accepted: per; per hour, per cent

Chapter 178

178.1 *Which way is the arrow pointing?*

Answer: lo hago para ti

Also accepted: para ti

178.2 *Which way is the arrow pointing?*

Answer: lo hago por ti

Also accepted: por ti

178.3 *Which way is the arrow pointing?*

Answer: does the arrow point at it or come from it

Also accepted: at the thing is para, from the thing is por

178.4 *Which way is the arrow pointing?*

Answer: the directions are inside the words, ad and per

Also accepted: para contains ad, toward; por contains per, through

Chapter 179

179.1 *Review — one arrow*

Answer: para points at it, por comes from it

Also accepted: para toward, por through or because

179.2 *Review — one arrow*

Answer: por favor, por que, gracias por

Also accepted: por favor, porque, gracias por

179.3 *Review — one arrow*

Answer: that it means two different things

Also accepted: both are correct and the choice is the meaning; neither is wrong

Chapter 180

180.1 *Synthesis — the gift and the motive*

Answer: hago la comida para ti

Also accepted: la hago para ti

180.2 *Synthesis — the gift and the motive*

Answer: hago la comida por ti

Also accepted: la hago por ti

180.3 *Synthesis — the gift and the motive*

Answer: gracias por la comida

Also accepted: gracias por la comida.

180.4 *Synthesis — the gift and the motive*

Answer: a true sentence about a different situation

Also accepted: something correct that means something else; not nonsense, just the wrong meaning

Chapter 181

181.1 *se habla español — nobody in particular*

Answer: se habla español

Also accepted: se habla español

181.2 *se habla español — nobody in particular*

Answer: nobody in particular

Also accepted: it does not say; no one is named

181.3 *se habla español — nobody in particular*

Answer: se come bien

Also accepted: aqui se come bien

Chapter 182

182.1 *se compran libros — the verb tells on itself*

Answer: se compran libros

Also accepted: se compran los libros

182.2 *se compran libros — the verb tells on itself*

Answer: the books

Also accepted: the thing being bought; libros

182.3 *se compran libros — the verb tells on itself*

Answer: books buy themselves

Also accepted: the books buy themselves

Chapter 183

183.1 *¿cómo se dice? — the sentence that unlocks the rest*

Answer: como se dice

Also accepted: ¿cómo se dice?; ¿como se dice?

183.2 *¿cómo se dice? — the sentence that unlocks the rest*

Answer: como se dice en espanol, por favor

Also accepted: ¿cómo se dice en español, por favor?

183.3 *¿cómo se dice? — the sentence that unlocks the rest*

Answer: you are asking about the language, not about them

Also accepted: it is impersonal; nobody is being named

Chapter 184

184.1 *Review — the three se's*

Answer: the reflexive and the impersonal

Also accepted: se llama and se habla; reflexive and impersonal

184.2 *Review — the three se's*

Answer: lo, la, los or las

Also accepted: a direct object pronoun; lo or la

184.3 *Review — the three se's*

Answer: the impersonal

Also accepted: impersonal — nobody is named

Chapter 185

185.1 *Synthesis — reading the window*

Answer: books are bought here

Also accepted: they buy books; we buy books

185.2 *Synthesis — reading the window*

Answer: como se dice, por favor

Also accepted: ¿cómo se dice, por favor?

185.3 *Synthesis — reading the window*

Answer: aqui se come bien

Also accepted: se come bien

185.4 *Synthesis — reading the window*

Answer: nobody is claiming it, so there is nobody to argue with

Also accepted: there is no person to disagree with; it sounds like a fact rather than an opinion

Chapter 186

186.1 *el libro que compro — one sentence out of two*

Answer: tengo el libro que compro

Also accepted: el libro que compro

186.2 *el libro que compro — one sentence out of two*

Answer: it disappears

Also accepted: you only say it once; it is not repeated

186.3 *el libro que compro — one sentence out of two*

Answer: que, quien, como, cuando

Also accepted: qué, quién, cómo, cuándo; the qu- family

Chapter 187

187.1 *el libro que compré — the word you cannot leave out*

Answer: el libro que compre

Also accepted: el libro que compré

187.2 *el libro que compré — the word you cannot leave out*

Answer: la casa que tengo

Also accepted: la casa que yo tengo

187.3 *el libro que compré — the word you cannot leave out*

Answer: a noun followed straight by a new subject and verb

Also accepted: a noun then a subject and verb with no that

187.4 *el libro que compré — the word you cannot leave out*

Answer: english word order is rigid, spanish is looser

Also accepted: spanish moves its pieces around, so it needs the joint

Chapter 188

188.1 *lo que* — “what,” out of two old words

Answer: lo que digo

Also accepted: lo que yo digo

188.2 *lo que* — “what,” out of two old words

Answer: lo digo points at a known thing, lo que digo points at no thing

Also accepted: one is I say it, the other is what I say

188.3 *lo que* — “what,” out of two old words

Answer: none

Also accepted: zero; 0

Chapter 189

189.1 *Review* — three jobs, no new words

Answer: none

Also accepted: zero; 0

189.2 *Review* — three jobs, no new words

Answer: la casa que tengo; english drops the that

Also accepted: la casa que tengo

189.3 *Review* — three jobs, no new words

Answer: lo

Also accepted: lo, as in lo que

Chapter 190

190.1 *Synthesis* — sentences worth saying

Answer: tienes el libro que compre

Also accepted: ¿tienes el libro que compré?

190.2 *Synthesis* — sentences worth saying

Answer: lo que no tengo

Also accepted: lo que no tengo.

190.3 *Synthesis* — sentences worth saying

Answer: lo que no tengo es la comida que haces

Also accepted: lo que no tengo es la comida que haces.

190.4 *Synthesis* — sentences worth saying

Answer: the clause only adds a slot, not new grammar

Also accepted: it is the same spanish arranged inside itself

Chapter 191

191.1 *hay* — “*there is*,” “*there are*,” *same word*

Answer: hay una casa

Also accepted: hay una casa.

191.2 *hay* — “*there is*,” “*there are*,” *same word*

Answer: hay libros

Also accepted: hay libros.

191.3 *hay* — “*there is*,” “*there are*,” *same word*

Answer: nothing

Also accepted: nothing at all; it never changes

Chapter 192

192.1 *ha + y* — *the fossil in a three-letter word*

Answer: ha and y

Also accepted: ha plus y; ha + y

192.2 *ha + y* — *the fossil in a three-letter word*

Answer: nowhere

Also accepted: nowhere else; only in hay

192.3 *ha + y* — *the fossil in a three-letter word*

Answer: il y a

Also accepted: il y a — it there has

Chapter 193

193.1 *hay que* — *somebody has to, and nobody in particular*

Answer: hay que hablar español

Also accepted: hay que hablar español

193.2 *hay que* — *somebody has to, and nobody in particular*

Answer: the infinitive

Also accepted: the dictionary form; the plain infinitive

193.3 *hay que* — *somebody has to, and nobody in particular*

Answer: the impersonal se

Also accepted: se habla español; the se of se habla

Chapter 194

194.1 *Review* — *three letters*

Answer: hay una casa, hay libros, hay que comer

Also accepted: hay una casa; hay libros; hay que comer

194.2 *Review — three letters*

Answer: agree, and name anybody

Also accepted: it never agrees and never names a person

194.3 *Review — three letters*

Answer: short words are worn down by constant use

Also accepted: the smallest words need the most explaining; heavy use turns them into fossils

Chapter 195

195.1 *Synthesis — describing where you are*

Answer: que hay aqui

Also accepted: ¿qué hay aquí?

195.2 *Synthesis — describing where you are*

Answer: hay libros, los que compre

Also accepted: hay libros — los que compré

195.3 *Synthesis — describing where you are*

Answer: lo que hay, hay que comerlo

Also accepted: lo que hay hay que comer

195.4 *Synthesis — describing where you are*

Answer: words, and familiar structures in new places

Also accepted: vocabulary and practice; nothing structural

Chapter 196

196.1 *si*

Answer: si tengo tiempo hablo espanol

Also accepted: hablo espanol si tengo tiempo

196.2 *si*

Answer: the one with the accent

Also accepted: si with the accent means yes

196.3 *si*

Answer: si plus a pointing particle

Also accepted: sic is si plus -ce

Chapter 197

197.1 *si + futuro*

Answer: si tengo tiempo hablare espanol

Also accepted: hablare espanol si tengo tiempo

197.2 *si + futuro***Answer:** no**Also accepted:** no spanish keeps the present after si**197.3** *si + futuro***Answer:** only the result makes a claim about the future**Also accepted:** the si half is a supposition not a prediction

Chapter 198

198.1 *Synthesis — real conditions***Answer:** si tengo tiempo hablo espanol**Also accepted:** hablo espanol si tengo tiempo**198.2** *Synthesis — real conditions***Answer:** si tengo tiempo hablar espanol**Also accepted:** hablar espanol si tengo tiempo**198.3** *Synthesis — real conditions***Answer:** si is if and si with the accent is yes**Also accepted:** unaccented if accented yes

Chapter 199

199.1 *hablaron***Answer:** hablaron espanol**Also accepted:** ellos hablaron espanol**199.2** *hablaron***Answer:** hablaron ends in n so the default stress is already right**Also accepted:** a word ending in n is stressed on the second to last syllable**199.3** *hablaron***Answer:** trabajaron**Also accepted:** ellos trabajaron

Chapter 200

200.1 *hablamos***Answer:** hablamos espanol**Also accepted:** nosotros hablamos espanol**200.2** *hablamos***Answer:** from the context**Also accepted:** from the rest of the sentence

200.3 *hablamos*

Answer: trabajamos trabajaron

Also accepted: trabajamos y trabajaron

Chapter 201

201.1 *comieron*

Answer: comieron

Also accepted: ellos comieron

201.2 *comieron*

Answer: vivieron

Also accepted: ellos vivieron

201.3 *comieron*

Answer: comimos

Also accepted: comimos only

Chapter 202

202.1 *tuvieron*

Answer: tuvieron

Also accepted: ellos tuvieron

202.2 *tuvieron*

Answer: hicieron

Also accepted: ellos hicieron

202.3 *tuvieron*

Answer: tuve and tuvo

Also accepted: only the yo and el forms

Chapter 203

203.1 *fueron*

Answer: fueron

Also accepted: ellos fueron

203.2 *fueron*

Answer: two they were and they went

Also accepted: it serves ser and ir

203.3 *fueron*

Answer: from a different verb meaning to grow or become

Also accepted: from another root, as english did with was

Chapter 204

204.1 *Review — the whole preterite*

Answer: hablamos and vivimos

Also accepted: the -ar one and the -ir one

204.2 *Review — the whole preterite*

Answer: tuv hic estuv fue

Also accepted: tuve hice estuve fui

204.3 *Review — the whole preterite*

Answer: fueron

Also accepted: fueron, from ser and ir

Chapter 205

205.1 *Synthesis — telling what happened*

Answer: hablaron espanol y tuvieron tiempo

Also accepted: hablaron espanol, tuvieron tiempo

205.2 *Synthesis — telling what happened*

Answer: comimos en casa

Also accepted: nosotros comimos en casa

205.3 *Synthesis — telling what happened*

Answer: tuviera

Also accepted: it becomes tuviera

Chapter 206

206.1 *hablara*

Answer: comiera

Also accepted: comiera, from comieron

206.2 *hablara*

Answer: because it is built from the preterite which already absorbed them

Also accepted: it inherits the irregularity instead of inventing new ones

206.3 *hablara*

Answer: i had done something

Also accepted: it marked a plain past, not a supposition

Chapter 207

207.1 *tuviera*

Answer: tuviera

Also accepted: tuviera, from tuvieron

207.2 *tuviera*

Answer: two ser and ir

Also accepted: both ser and ir

207.3 *tuviera*

Answer: none

Also accepted: zero, they were already known

Chapter 208

208.1 *si tuviera*

Answer: si tuviera tiempo hablaria espanol

Also accepted: hablaria espanol si tuviera tiempo

208.2 *si tuviera*

Answer: that it is not true

Also accepted: that the speaker does not have the time

208.3 *si tuviera*

Answer: no

Also accepted: no, si never takes the present subjunctive

Chapter 209

209.1 *Review — the two conditions*

Answer: si tuviera tiempo hablaria espanol

Also accepted: si tuviera tiempo, hablaria espanol

209.2 *Review — the two conditions*

Answer: the future and the present subjunctive

Also accepted: si tendre and si tenga are both impossible

209.3 *Review — the two conditions*

Answer: nothing

Also accepted: nothing, the verbs carry it

Chapter 210

210.1 *Synthesis — supposing out loud*

Answer: si fuera profesor hablaria espanol

Also accepted: si fuera profesora, hablaria espanol

210.2 *Synthesis — supposing out loud*

Answer: si tuviera tiempo comeria en casa

Also accepted: any si + -ra form followed by a -ria form

210.3 *Synthesis — supposing out loud***Answer:** the preterite plural**Also accepted:** the they-past, which the supposing form is built from**Chapter 211****211.1** *dice que***Answer:** dice que esta cansado**Also accepted:** el dice que esta cansado**211.2** *dice que***Answer:** no**Also accepted:** no, que is required**211.3** *dice que***Answer:** digo**Also accepted:** dice becomes digo**Chapter 212****212.1** *dijo***Answer:** dijo**Also accepted:** el dijo**212.2** *dijo***Answer:** dijeron**Also accepted:** ellos dijeron**212.3** *dijo***Answer:** x**Also accepted:** the x of dixit**Chapter 213****213.1** *dijo que***Answer:** dijo que estaba cansado**Also accepted:** el dijo que estaba cansado**213.2** *dijo que***Answer:** dijo que trabajaba**Also accepted:** el dijo que trabajaba**213.3** *dijo que***Answer:** because it was going on at the time**Also accepted:** it was true when he spoke, not a finished event

Chapter 214

214.1 *preguntó si*

Answer: pregunto si trabajaba

Also accepted: el pregunto si trabajaba

214.2 *preguntó si*

Answer: no

Also accepted: no, it is a statement now

214.3 *preguntó si*

Answer: in conditions

Also accepted: si tengo tiempo; the if of conditions

Chapter 215

215.1 *preguntó dónde*

Answer: pregunto donde trabajaba

Also accepted: el pregunto donde trabajaba

215.2 *preguntó dónde*

Answer: yes

Also accepted: yes, it is still an asking word

215.3 *preguntó dónde*

Answer: no

Also accepted: no, donde is the joint

Chapter 216

216.1 *(review)*

Answer: que

Also accepted: que, and it cannot be dropped

216.2 *(review)*

Answer: si

Also accepted: si, the same one as in conditions

216.3 *(review)*

Answer: donde is the joint

Also accepted: no que and no si, donde does it

Chapter 217

217.1 *(synthesis)*

Answer: pregunto donde trabajaba

Also accepted: el pregunto donde trabajaba

217.2 (*synthesis*)

Answer: dijo que trabajaba en casa

Also accepted: dijo que trabajaba

217.3 (*synthesis*)

Answer: pregunto si estaba cansado

Also accepted: el pregunto si estaba cansado

Chapter 218

218.1 *pero* — *the word that lets two true things stand together*

Answer: estoy cansado pero estudio

Also accepted: estoy cansada pero estudio

218.2 *pero* — *the word that lets two true things stand together*

Answer: no

Also accepted: no, both halves stay true

218.3 *pero* — *the word that lets two true things stand together*

Answer: two

Also accepted: two: per hoc

Chapter 219

219.1 *también* — *a word with your very first word inside it*

Answer: yo tambien

Also accepted: yo tambien!

219.2 *también* — *a word with your very first word inside it*

Answer: tan and bien

Also accepted: tan bien, so well

219.3 *también* — *a word with your very first word inside it*

Answer: so

Also accepted: so, as; as

Chapter 220

220.1 *tampoco* — *the same frame, the other half*

Answer: yo tampoco

Also accepted: yo tampoco!

220.2 *tampoco* — *the same frame, the other half*

Answer: tan and poco

Also accepted: tan poco, so little

220.3 *tampoco* — *the same frame, the other half*

Answer: no

Also accepted: the no in their sentence

Chapter 221

221.1 *este* — *pointing at what is in your hand*

Answer: este libro

Also accepted: este libro.

221.2 *este* — *pointing at what is in your hand*

Answer: esta casa

Also accepted: esta casa.

221.3 *este* — *pointing at what is in your hand*

Answer: no

Also accepted: no, este replaces the article

Chapter 222

222.1 *ese* — *pointing at what is by you*

Answer: ese libro

Also accepted: ese libro.

222.2 *ese* — *pointing at what is by you*

Answer: whose side it is on

Also accepted: which of us it is near; not distance

222.3 *ese* — *pointing at what is by you*

Answer: self

Also accepted: self, as in ipso facto; ipse, self

Chapter 223

223.1 *aquel* — *the far one, and an old friend in disguise*

Answer: aquella casa

Also accepted: aquella casa.

223.2 *aquel* — *the far one, and an old friend in disguise*

Answer: este ese aquel

Also accepted: este, ese, aquel

223.3 *aquel* — *the far one, and an old friend in disguise*

Answer: el

Also accepted: el, from Latin ille

Chapter 224

224.1 *esto · eso · aquello — pointing at what has no name yet*

Answer: que es esto

Also accepted: ¿que es esto?

224.2 *esto · eso · aquello — pointing at what has no name yet*

Answer: neither

Also accepted: neither, it is the leftover neuter

Chapter 225

225.1 *(review)*

Answer: ese

Also accepted: ese, it is on their side

225.2 *(review)*

Answer: do i have a noun

Also accepted: whether there is a noun at all

225.3 *(review)*

Answer: the article

Also accepted: el, la – the article

Chapter 226

226.1 *muy — the same word, bitten short*

Answer: estoy muy cansado

Also accepted: estoy muy cansada

226.2 *muy — the same word, bitten short*

Answer: mucho

Also accepted: mucho, the long form

226.3 *muy — the same word, bitten short*

Answer: no

Also accepted: no, it needs something to lean on

Chapter 227

227.1 *bastante — an ending you can already read*

Answer: estoy bastante cansado

Also accepted: estoy bastante cansada

227.2 *bastante — an ending you can already read*

Answer: poco bastante muy

Also accepted: poco, bastante, muy

227.3 *bastante* — *an ending you can already read*

Answer: sufficing

Also accepted: the one that suffices; bastar plus -ante

Chapter 228

228.1 *mal* — *bien finally gets its opposite*

Answer: estoy mal

Also accepted: mal; estoy mal.

228.2 *mal* — *bien finally gets its opposite*

Answer: malo

Also accepted: malo, the long form

228.3 *mal* — *bien finally gets its opposite*

Answer: the ending is bitten off when it leans on another word

Also accepted: a long form and a short form; apocope

Chapter 229

229.1 (*review*)

Answer: bastante

Also accepted: bastante, the middle one

229.2 (*review*)

Answer: when it leans on the next word

Also accepted: when another word follows it

229.3 (*review*)

Answer: -ante

Also accepted: ante, as in estudiante

Chapter 230

230.1 *al* — *two words Spanish will not let you keep apart*

Answer: voy al cafe

Also accepted: voy al café.

230.2 *al* — *two words Spanish will not let you keep apart*

Answer: no

Also accepted: no, it is simply wrong

230.3 *al* — *two words Spanish will not let you keep apart*

Answer: el is part of the name

Also accepted: because El is part of a name

Chapter 231

231.1 *del — and then the list stops*

Answer: el libro del profesor

Also accepted: el libro del profesor.

231.2 *del — and then the list stops*

Answer: two

Also accepted: two: al and del

231.3 *del — and then the list stops*

Answer: no

Also accepted: no, only de el does

Chapter 232

232.1 *quién — the asking word reserved for people*

Answer: quien es

Also accepted: ¿quien es?

232.2 *quién — the asking word reserved for people*

Answer: quien

Also accepted: quien, because the answer is a person

232.3 *quién — the asking word reserved for people*

Answer: the object one

Also accepted: quem, the object form

Chapter 233

233.1 *o — one letter, one catch*

Answer: cafe o agua

Also accepted: ¿cafe o agua?

233.2 *o — one letter, one catch*

Answer: siete u ocho

Also accepted: siete u ocho.

233.3 *o — one letter, one catch*

Answer: sound

Also accepted: sound, so a silent h counts too

Chapter 234

234.1 *ni — joining two absences*

Answer: no quiero cafe ni agua

Also accepted: no quiero cafe ni agua.

234.2 *ni — joining two absences*

Answer: two and yes

Also accepted: two, and it is correct

234.3 *ni — joining two absences*

Answer: and not

Also accepted: and not – the no is inside it

Chapter 235

235.1 *(review)*

Answer: two

Also accepted: two, al and del

235.2 *(review)*

Answer: quien

Also accepted: quienes, if you expect several

235.3 *(review)*

Answer: the o would be swallowed

Also accepted: because the next word starts with the o sound

Chapter 236

236.1 *hablando — an action caught in the middle*

Answer: trabajando

Also accepted: trabajando.

236.2 *hablando — an action caught in the middle*

Answer: one

Also accepted: one, it never changes

236.3 *hablando — an action caught in the middle*

Answer: speaking

Also accepted: speaking, the action underway

Chapter 237

237.1 *comiendo · viviendo — two families, one ending*

Answer: comiendo

Also accepted: comiendo.

237.2 *comiendo · viviendo — two families, one ending*

Answer: viviendo

Also accepted: viviendo.

237.3 *comiendo · viviendo — two families, one ending*

Answer: two

Also accepted: two: -ando and -iendo

Chapter 238

238.1 *estoy hablando — the payoff*

Answer: estoy comiendo

Also accepted: estoy comiendo.

238.2 *estoy hablando — the payoff*

Answer: estar

Also accepted: estar, the gerund never changes

238.3 *estoy hablando — the payoff*

Answer: no

Also accepted: no, it only means right now

Chapter 239

239.1 *veo a María — the little a that guards people*

Answer: veo a maria

Also accepted: veo a maria.

239.2 *veo a María — the little a that guards people*

Answer: veo la casa

Also accepted: veo la casa.

239.3 *veo a María — the little a that guards people*

Answer: marking who is on the receiving end

Also accepted: marking the object

Chapter 240

240.1 *(review)*

Answer: estamos estudiando

Also accepted: estamos estudiando.

240.2 *(review)*

Answer: a person

Also accepted: seeing a person

240.3 *(review)*

Answer: voy a comer

Also accepted: with voy a comer, not estoy comiendo

Chapter 241

241.1 *hablasteis* — *the form you were promised*

Answer: hablasteis

Also accepted: vosotros hablasteis

241.2 *hablasteis* — *the form you were promised*

Answer: hablaste

Also accepted: hablaste, the tu form

241.3 *hablasteis* — *the form you were promised*

Answer: six

Also accepted: six, all of them

Chapter 242

242.1 *comisteis* · *tuvisteis* — *the last gap closes*

Answer: comisteis

Also accepted: vosotros comisteis

242.2 *comisteis* · *tuvisteis* — *the last gap closes*

Answer: tuvisteis

Also accepted: vosotros tuvisteis

242.3 *comisteis* · *tuvisteis* — *the last gap closes*

Answer: no

Also accepted: no, it is complete

Chapter 243

243.1 *hablábamos* — *the imperfect gets its plural*

Answer: hablabamos

Also accepted: nosotros hablabamos

243.2 *hablábamos* — *the imperfect gets its plural*

Answer: trabajaban

Also accepted: ellos trabajaban

243.3 *hablábamos* — *the imperfect gets its plural*

Answer: the stress is not where the default puts it

Also accepted: because the default stress would land a syllable later

Chapter 244

244.1 *comíamos* · *éramos* · *íbamos* — *every one with an accent*

Answer: comiamos

Also accepted: nosotros comiamos

244.2 *comíamos · éramos · íbamos — every one with an accent*

Answer: eramos

Also accepted: nosotros eramos

244.3 *comíamos · éramos · íbamos — every one with an accent*

Answer: three

Also accepted: three: ser, ir, ver

Chapter 245

245.1 *(review)*

Answer: hablabamos

Also accepted: the nosotros form

245.2 *(review)*

Answer: ser ir ver

Also accepted: ser, ir, ver

245.3 *(review)*

Answer: no

Also accepted: no, both are complete

Chapter 246

246.1 *para mí — the pronouns that stand on their own*

Answer: el cafe es para mi

Also accepted: el cafe es para mi.

246.2 *para mí — the pronouns that stand on their own*

Answer: the first two

Also accepted: only mi and ti

246.3 *para mí — the pronouns that stand on their own*

Answer: there is no other ti to confuse it with

Also accepted: mi already means my; ti has no twin

Chapter 247

247.1 *conmigo · contigo — the word that says “with” twice*

Answer: vienes conmigo

Also accepted: ¿vienes conmigo?

247.2 *conmigo · contigo — the word that says “with” twice*

Answer: twice

Also accepted: two: con at the front and cum at the back

247.3 *conmigo* · *contigo* — the word that says “with” twice

Answer: con el

Also accepted: con el.

Chapter 248

248.1 *¡Qué grande!* — the same word, exclaiming

Answer: que grande

Also accepted: ¡que grande!

248.2 *¡Qué grande!* — the same word, exclaiming

Answer: que bien

Also accepted: ¡que bien!

248.3 *¡Qué grande!* — the same word, exclaiming

Answer: the word carrying the force

Also accepted: not questions; the word doing the work

Chapter 249

249.1 *María, ven* — naming who you are talking to

Answer: maria ven

Also accepted: maria, ven

249.2 *María, ven* — naming who you are talking to

Answer: a comma

Also accepted: the comma

249.3 *María, ven* — naming who you are talking to

Answer: no

Also accepted: no, she is not on the receiving end

Chapter 250

250.1 (review)

Answer: conmigo

Also accepted: ¿conmigo?

250.2 (review)

Answer: para ti

Also accepted: para ti.

250.3 (review)

Answer: a comma

Also accepted: the comma

Chapter 251

251.1 *ahí · allí — the other two places*

Answer: ahí

Also accepted: ahí, by you

251.2 *ahí · allí — the other two places*

Answer: allí

Also accepted: allí, away from both

251.3 *ahí · allí — the other two places*

Answer: ese

Also accepted: ese, by you

Chapter 252

252.1 *ahora · hoy — now and today*

Answer: ahora estoy comiendo

Also accepted: ahora estoy comiendo.

252.2 *ahora · hoy — now and today*

Answer: hora

Also accepted: hora, the hour

252.3 *ahora · hoy — now and today*

Answer: hoy

Also accepted: hoy, from hodie

Chapter 253

253.1 *unos · unas — the plural of “one”*

Answer: unos libros

Also accepted: unos libros.

253.2 *unos · unas — the plural of “one”*

Answer: unas casas

Also accepted: unas casas.

253.3 *unos · unas — the plural of “one”*

Answer: compro libros

Also accepted: the bare one

Chapter 254

254.1 *vuestro — the last possessive*

Answer: vuestra casa

Also accepted: vuestra casa.

254.2 *vuestro* — *the last possessive*

Answer: nuestro and vuestro

Also accepted: nuestro, vuestro

254.3 *vuestro* — *the last possessive*

Answer: six

Also accepted: six, all of them

Chapter 255

255.1 *vi · di* — *the shortest pasts in the language*

Answer: vi

Also accepted: yo vi

255.2 *vi · di* — *the shortest pasts in the language*

Answer: dio

Also accepted: el dio

255.3 *vi · di* — *the shortest pasts in the language*

Answer: it has only one syllable

Also accepted: one syllable, so the beat cannot fall elsewhere

Chapter 256

256.1 *(review)*

Answer: compro libros

Also accepted: the bare plural

256.2 *(review)*

Answer: hora

Also accepted: hora, the hour

256.3 *(review)*

Answer: the -er ones

Also accepted: -er endings, though it is an -ar verb

Chapter 257

257.1 *hablo* — *one form, two readings*

Answer: i eat and i am eating

Also accepted: I eat; I am eating

257.2 *hablo* — *one form, two readings*

Answer: como

Also accepted: como, the plain present

257.3 *hablo* — *one form, two readings*

Answer: insisting that it is happening now

Also accepted: emphasis on right now

Chapter 258

258.1 *hablo · hablas · habla* — *the ending says who*

Answer: the subject

Also accepted: who is doing it

258.2 *hablo · hablas · habla* — *the ending says who*

Answer: the ending already says it

Also accepted: because the -o carries the subject

258.3 *hablo · hablas · habla* — *the ending says who*

Answer: when the ending is ambiguous

Also accepted: when habla could be he, she or usted

Chapter 259

259.1 *mucha agua · pocos libros* — *when the quantity word agrees*

Answer: mucha agua

Also accepted: mucha agua.

259.2 *mucha agua · pocos libros* — *when the quantity word agrees*

Answer: ella trabaja mucho

Also accepted: ella trabaja mucho.

259.3 *mucha agua · pocos libros* — *when the quantity word agrees*

Answer: is it leaning on a noun or a verb

Also accepted: whether a noun follows

Chapter 260

260.1 *María · España · profesor* — *the nouns that need no article*

Answer: veo a maria

Also accepted: veo a maria.

260.2 *María · España · profesor* — *the nouns that need no article*

Answer: it already points at one thing

Also accepted: there is nothing left to narrow down

260.3 *María · España · profesor* — *the nouns that need no article*

Answer: no article

Also accepted: none, it is a vocative

Chapter 261

261.1 *(review)*

Answer: no

Also accepted: no, como covers it

261.2 *(review)*

Answer: mucho

Also accepted: mucho, it describes the working

261.3 *(review)*

Answer: consequence

Also accepted: a consequence of agreement

Chapter 262

262.1 *primero · segundo · tercero — counting in order*

Answer: el primer libro

Also accepted: el primer libro.

262.2 *primero · segundo · tercero — counting in order*

Answer: la primera casa

Also accepted: la primera casa.

262.3 *primero · segundo · tercero — counting in order*

Answer: following

Also accepted: following, from sequi

Chapter 263

263.1 *uno... otro — splitting a pair*

Answer: uno es grande otro es bueno

Also accepted: uno es grande, otro es bueno

263.2 *uno... otro — splitting a pair*

Answer: no

Also accepted: no, otro takes no article

263.3 *uno... otro — splitting a pair*

Answer: the other of two

Also accepted: the second of a pair

Chapter 264

264.1 *comer es bueno — the infinitive as the subject*

Answer: comer es bueno

Also accepted: comer es bueno.

264.2 *comer es bueno — the infinitive as the subject*

Answer: no

Also accepted: no, the gerund cannot be a subject

264.3 *comer es bueno — the infinitive as the subject*

Answer: hablar espanol es bueno

Also accepted: hablar espanol es bueno.

Chapter 265

265.1 *hoy como en casa — the pieces that move*

Answer: three

Also accepted: three: front, middle, end

265.2 *hoy como en casa — the pieces that move*

Answer: emphasises it

Also accepted: stresses today as against another day

265.3 *hoy como en casa — the pieces that move*

Answer: the endings already say who does what

Also accepted: because agreement and the personal a keep the roles clear

Chapter 266

266.1 *(review)*

Answer: comer es bueno

Also accepted: comer es bueno, the infinitive

266.2 *(review)*

Answer: three

Also accepted: three: muy, mal, primer

266.3 *(review)*

Answer: no

Also accepted: no, never

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16-19 — not words to memorise but a formula, diez y X, with the seam still visible *dieciséis — diecinueve*

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a greeting — from saludem, health: to greet was to wish someone their health *el saludo*

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because — two tiny words fused into one, and the reason a**sequence becomes a story** *porque*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 167, p. 575

bed — one of the commonest Spanish words, and nobody has**settled where it came from** *la cama*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 279, p. 887

big — the first word in this book for what something is like, and**it does not change for gender** *grande*

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 58, p. 235

black and white — the two words, and the straight-line Latin**history of the first one** *negro, blanco*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 139, p. 463

Black, White, Red, and Blue

chapter topic; Chapter 139, p. 463

blanco — the colour Spanish did not inherit

etymology topic; explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 139, p. 463

blue — an Arabic loan that became the plain everyday word, where French's cousin stayed poetic *azul*

explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 139, p. 463

book — named after the part of a tree people wrote on before paper *el libro*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 57, p. 233

bread — and the *compañero* who shares it with you *el pan*

explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 143, p. 481

brother and sister — NOT from *frater/soror*, but from an adjective meaning “of the same seed” *el hermano, la hermana*

explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 140, p. 469

buenos or buenas — the rule you have been using all along

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 13

Building a Paragraph — Plan, Add, Join, Refer Back

chapter topic; Chapter 273, p. 841

but — the first word you need to hold two true things against each other, and the first word of any argument *pero*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 218, p. 705

but — the literary one, without the accent *mas*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 276, p. 865

C**Cansado — a State, Not a Quality**

chapter topic; Chapter 59, p. 237

cat — a word that travelled out of Africa with the animal, pushing Latin's own *fēlēs* aside *gato*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 150, p. 511

chair — Latin *sella*, a seat, from the verb to sit *la silla*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 279, p. 887

cheese — Latin *caseus*, the very same word as English cheese by another road *el queso*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 280, p. 895

-cion — About Two Thousand Words, At Once

chapter topic; Chapter 23, p. 125

-ción — about two thousand words, at once

grammar topic; explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 23, p. 125

cl-, pl-, fl- → ll-

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 29, p. 137

Cl-, Pl-, Fl- to Ll-

chapter topic; Chapter 29, p. 137

clean — from *limpidus*, clear, the word English kept for water
and Spanish moved to laundry *limpio*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 281, p. 903

coffee / a café — one useful noun before the polite request that
follows *café*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 14, p. 97

coma · comas · coma — let -er cross to a

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 127, p. 427

come — “he eats,” and the polite “you eat”

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 34, p. 151

Comeis and Vivis

chapter topic; Chapter 44, p. 181

coméis and vivís — the second difference, and the last

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 44, p. 181

comemos — “we eat”

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 43, p. 177

Comen and Viven — Agreeing Again

chapter topic; Chapter 45, p. 183

comen and viven — agreeing again

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 45, p. 183

Comer Es Bueno — The Infinitive as Subject

chapter topic; Chapter 264, p. 797

comer es bueno — the infinitive as the subject

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 264, p. 797

Comer — the Second Verb Family, One Slot at a Time

chapter topic; Chapter 34, p. 151

comeré — the same endings keep -er

productive pattern; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 122, p. 411

comería — keep -er before “would”

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 123, p. 415

comes — “you eat,” and the first real difference

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 34, p. 151

comía — hear both vowels

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 107, p. 373

Comíamos, Éramos, Íbamos — Every One With an Accent

chapter topic; Chapter 244, p. 757

comíamos · éramos · íbamos — every one with an accent

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 244, p. 757

Comiendo, Viviendo — Two Families, One Ending

chapter topic; Chapter 237, p. 743

comiendo · viviendo — two families, one ending

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 237, p. 743

comieron

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 201, p. 669

Comieron — One Ending, Two Families

chapter topic; Chapter 201, p. 669

Comisteis, Tuvisteis — The Last Gap Closes

chapter topic; Chapter 242, p. 753

comisteis · tuvisteis — the last gap closes

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 242, p. 753

¿cómo está usted? / ¿cómo estás? — choose the register

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 9, p. 65

como — “I eat,” and you already knew how

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 34, p. 151

Como Se Dice — The Sentence That Unlocks the Rest

chapter topic; Chapter 183, p. 633

¿cómo? — the two marks that say “this is a question”

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, grammar; Chapter 6, p. 39

comparing the three learned yo forms that end in -go *tengo* ·*hago* · *digo*

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 70, p. 275

comparing the two vowel changes inside the learned singular**forms** *e* → *ie* and *o* → *ue*

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 69, p. 267

Conmigo, Contigo — The Word That Says With Twice

chapter topic; Chapter 247, p. 763

Conocer — Coming to Know

chapter topic; Chapter 171, p. 593

Conseguir — Getting Is Following Until You Have It

chapter topic; Chapter 169, p. 587

could be — two words you already own, standing side by side**and meaning less together than either does alone** *puede ser*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 298, p. 1039

Courtesy Past Thank You — Excuse Me, With Permission,**Kind, A Thousand Thanks**

chapter topic; Chapter 283, p. 919

Cuando — Both Pasts in One Sentence

chapter topic; Chapter 112, p. 389

D**-dad — Twelve Hundred More**

chapter topic; Chapter 24, p. 127

-dad — twelve hundred more

grammar topic; explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 24, p. 127

day (el día — masculine) *día*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 1, p. 1

Days of the Week

chapter topic; Chapter 138, p. 457

Del — And Then the List Stops

chapter topic; Chapter 231, p. 731

Deriving the Rest

chapter topic; Chapter 76, p. 293

Describing an Experience — How It Felt, How Long, How It Compared

chapter topic; Chapter 269, p. 817

Di, Haz, Ve, Pon, Ten, Sal, Se, Ven

chapter topic; Chapter 132, p. 443

di, haz, ve, pon, ten, sal, sé, ven

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 132, p. 443

dice que

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 211, p. 691

Dice Que — Someone Else's Sentence, Inside Yours

chapter topic; Chapter 211, p. 691

dijo

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 212, p. 693

dijo que

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 213, p. 695

Dijo Que — Both Verbs Step Back

chapter topic; Chapter 213, p. 695

Dijo — The Stem That Breaks Its Own Rule

chapter topic; Chapter 212, p. 693

dirty — from *sucidus*, greasy with its own juice, said first of unwashed wool *sucio*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 281, p. 903

dog — a genuinely unsolved etymology, and the Latin word it pushed out *perro*

explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 150, p. 511

Dog and Cat

chapter topic; Chapter 150, p. 511

door — Latin *porta*, a gate, and the o that opened into ue *la puerta*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 279, p. 887

duodēvīgintī — the quirk Spanish threw away

etymology topic; explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 149, p. 505

E**egg — Latin *ovum*, wearing an h that exists only to help your eyes *el huevo***

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 280, p. 895

El Libro — And a Word Made of Tree Bark

chapter topic; Chapter 57, p. 233

El Libro Que Compre — The Word You Cannot Leave Out

chapter topic; Chapter 187, p. 641

el libro que compré — the word you cannot leave out

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 187, p. 641

El Libro Que Compro — One Sentence Out of Two

chapter topic; Chapter 186, p. 639

el libro que compro — one sentence out of two

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 186, p. 639

el or él? — the accent as a meaning label

script and writing topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 10, p. 71

enough, quite — an ending you already decode, on a verb

meaning to suffice, giving a word that means exactly

“sufficing” *bastante*

explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 227, p. 723

Entender — Understanding Is Stretching Toward

chapter topic; Chapter 154, p. 525

Enye and the Upside-Down Marks

chapter topic; Chapter 11, p. 75

era — an old root in an open past

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 109, p. 379

es- + consonant

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 30, p. 141

-es — The Plural Chapter One Promised

chapter topic; Chapter 80, p. 303

-es — the plural your first chapter owed you

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 80, p. 303

Es- — the Vowel Spanish Put in Front

chapter topic; Chapter 30, p. 141

Escribir — Writing Is Scratching

chapter topic; Chapter 156, p. 533

Ese — Pointing at What Is by You

chapter topic; Chapter 222, p. 713

Espanol, and Your First Built Sentence

chapter topic; Chapter 22, p. 121

estáis — and nothing surprises you

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 55, p. 225

estamos — the other “we are”

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 55, p. 225

están — “they are”

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 55, p. 225

Estar in the Plural

chapter topic; Chapter 55, p. 225

Este — Pointing at What Is in Your Hand

chapter topic; Chapter 221, p. 711

Esto, Eso, Aquello — Pointing at What Has No Name

chapter topic; Chapter 224, p. 717

esto · eso · aquello — pointing at what has no name yet

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 224, p. 717

Estoy Hablando — The Payoff

chapter topic; Chapter 238, p. 745

estoy hablando — the payoff

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 238, p. 745

Estudiante — a Word You Can Build

chapter topic; Chapter 52, p. 219

Estudiar — Studying Is Being Eager

chapter topic; Chapter 21, p. 119

estuve — a third known verb joins the strong pattern

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 105, p. 363

exactly — from exigere, to drive out, and then to weigh out**precisely** *exacto*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 284, p. 927

excuse me — from culpa, fault: literally, take the fault off**me** *disculpe*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 283, p. 919

excuse me, said when you pass — per plus mittere, to let**through** *con permiso*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 283, p. 919

F**f → h — why the h says nothing**

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 28, p. 135

F to H — Why the H Says Nothing

chapter topic; Chapter 28, p. 135

falsos amigos

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 66, p. 255

Falsos Amigos — the Words That Obey and Lie

chapter topic; Chapter 66, p. 255

father and mother — among the oldest reconstructible words in**the whole family** *el padre, la madre*

explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 140, p. 469

Fine Shades — Four Differences a Translation Loses

chapter topic; Chapter 275, p. 857

first, second, third — the counting words for order rather than amount, and two of them shorten in a way you have now seen three times *primero · segundo · tercero*

explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 262, p. 793

Five More Short Answers — Maybe, Could Be, Indeed, No Doubt, Out of the Question

chapter topic; Chapter 298, p. 1039

Five More Things You Ask For — Knife, Cup, Pot, Blanket, Broom

chapter topic; Chapter 294, p. 1007

Five More Things You Ask For — Rope, Needle, Thread, Basket, Paper

chapter topic; Chapter 301, p. 1063

Five Short Answers — Agreed, Sure, True, Exactly, Of Course

chapter topic; Chapter 284, p. 927

Five Things You Ask For — Soap, Towel, Glass, Spoon, Plate

chapter topic; Chapter 287, p. 951

flower — Latin flos, and the reason English flour is spelled so oddly *la flor*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 278, p. 879

food, a meal — a noun you can build yourself out of a verb you already own *la comida*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 77, p. 297

for, during *durante*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 269, p. 817

for example *por ejemplo*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 270, p. 823

“for” pointing back or through — at a cause, a route, an exchange; and you have been saying it since your first page *por*

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 177, p. 619

“for” pointing forward — at a destination, a purpose, a deadline, a person meant to receive something *para*

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 176, p. 617

Four Ordinary Adjectives — New, Old, Clean, Dirty

chapter topic; Chapter 281, p. 903

Four Things in a Room — Door, Window, Chair, Bed

chapter topic; Chapter 279, p. 887

Four Things Outdoors — Wind, Snow, Tree, Flower

chapter topic; Chapter 278, p. 879

Four Things You Buy — Cheese, Egg, Apple, Money

chapter topic; Chapter 280, p. 895

From the Seed Up — Seed, Root, Trunk, Branch, Wood

chapter topic; Chapter 291, p. 983

fueron

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 203, p. 673

Fueron — They Were, and They Went

chapter topic; Chapter 203, p. 673

Further Down — Neck, Shoulder, Back, Knee, Ankle

chapter topic; Chapter 293, p. 999

furthermore, moreover *además*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 273, p. 841

G**Going, and the Future You Can Already Say**

chapter topic; Chapter 49, p. 203

good afternoon *buenas tardes*

explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 2, p. 13

good evening / good night *buenas noches*

explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 2, p. 13

good morning (literally “good days”) *buenos días*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 1, p. 1

goodbye *adiós*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 12, p. 83

Goodbye

chapter topic; Chapter 12, p. 83

Grammatical gender — the two noun classes behind *el* and *la*

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 1, p. 1

Grande — the First Word for What a Thing Is Like

chapter topic; Chapter 58, p. 235

Green and Yellow

chapter topic; Chapter 151, p. 515

green — from a verb meaning “to flourish,” and a cousin of**verdant but not of English green** *verde*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 151, p. 515

Gustar — the Verb Built the Other Way Round

chapter topic; Chapter 163, p. 553

H**Ha + Y — The Fossil in a Three-Letter Word**

chapter topic; Chapter 192, p. 651

ha + y — the fossil in a three-letter word

etymology topic; explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 192, p. 651

habla — “he speaks,” and the polite “you speak”

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 18, p. 111

Habla — Telling Somebody To Do Something

chapter topic; Chapter 131, p. 441

habla — telling somebody to do something

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 131, p. 441

Hablaba and Hablo — Two Ways of Looking

chapter topic; Chapter 111, p. 387

hablaba and habló — two ways of looking

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 111, p. 387

hablaba — let a past action stay open

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 107, p. 373

Hablábamos — The Imperfect Gets Its Plural

chapter topic; Chapter 243, p. 755

hablábamos — the imperfect gets its plural

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 243, p. 755

Hablado, Comido, Vivido — The Participle

chapter topic; Chapter 116, p. 399

hablado, comido, vivido — the participle

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 116, p. 399

Hablais — the Form Spain Keeps

chapter topic; Chapter 40, p. 171

habláis — the form Spain keeps

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 40, p. 171

hablamos

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 200, p. 667

Hablamos — the First Form That Is Not About One Person

chapter topic; Chapter 38, p. 167

hablamos — “we speak”

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 38, p. 167

Hablamos — We Speak, and We Spoke

chapter topic; Chapter 200, p. 667

Hablan — They, and Ustedes

chapter topic; Chapter 39, p. 169

hablan — “they speak,” and “you all speak”

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 39, p. 169

Hablando — An Action Caught in the Middle

chapter topic; Chapter 236, p. 741

hablando — an action caught in the middle

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 236, p. 741

hablara

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 206, p. 679

Hablara — the Form for Supposing

chapter topic; Chapter 206, p. 679

hablaré — keep the infinitive, add the future

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 122, p. 411

hablaría — the whole infinitive meets -ía

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 123, p. 415

hablaron

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 199, p. 665

Hablaron — They Spoke

chapter topic; Chapter 199, p. 665

Hablas español · Quiero que hables español — fact or wanted event?

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 126, p. 425

hablas — “you speak,” to someone you know

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 17, p. 109

Hablasteis — The Form You Were Promised

chapter topic; Chapter 241, p. 751

hablasteis — the form you were promised

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 241, p. 751

hablé — a regular singular past from a known verb

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 103, p. 351

hable · hables · hable — the singular -ar row

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 127, p. 427

Hable Usted — The Polite Command

chapter topic; Chapter 134, p. 447

hable usted — the polite command

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 134, p. 447

Hablo, Hablas, Habla — The Ending Says Who

chapter topic; Chapter 258, p. 785

hablo · hablas · habla — the ending says who

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 258, p. 785

hablo — “I speak”

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 16, p. 105

Hablo — One Form, Two Readings

chapter topic; Chapter 257, p. 783

hablo — one form, two readings

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 257, p. 783

hablo — one word, one whole sentence

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 16, p. 105

hacemos, hacen — and the club has no plural at all

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 76, p. 293

Hacer, Decir, and the -go Verb Club

chapter topic; Chapter 70, p. 275

haga · hagas · haga — hago lends its stem

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 128, p. 431

happy *feliz*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 269, p. 817

haré · tendré · podré — three stems, two ending sets

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 124, p. 419

Has, Ha, Hemos, Habeis, Han

chapter topic; Chapter 118, p. 403

has, ha, hemos, habéis, han

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 118, p. 403

hasta aquí / hasta la noche — point to the limit

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 12, p. 83

Hay Que — Somebody Has To, and Nobody in Particular

chapter topic; Chapter 193, p. 653

hay que — somebody has to, and nobody in particular

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 193, p. 653

Hay — There Is, There Are, Same Word

chapter topic; Chapter 191, p. 649

He Hablado — A Verb With No Meaning Left

chapter topic; Chapter 117, p. 401

he hablado — “I have spoken”

grammar topic; explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 117, p. 401

He, She, and the Polite You

chapter topic; Chapter 18, p. 111

he/she calls himself; you (formal) call yourself *se llama*

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 6, p. 39

Head and Hand

chapter topic; Chapter 141, p. 475

Hearing, Sleeping, Walking, Running

chapter topic; Chapter 165, p. 559

Hecho, Dicho, Visto, Puesto

chapter topic; Chapter 119, p. 405

hecho, dicho, visto, puesto

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 119, p. 405

hello / hi *hola*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 1, p. 1

hice — the strong pattern with one third-person swerve

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 105, p. 363

Hola and Buenos Días

chapter topic; Chapter 1, p. 1

hour / o'clock — telling the time, and a word Spanish inherited**almost unchanged from Latin *la hora***

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 147, p. 497

house, home — and a word French wore down so far it stopped**looking like a noun *la casa***

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 56, p. 231

how — a whole Latin phrase, *quo modo*, worn smooth into one**word *cómo***

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 6, p. 39

How Are You

chapter topic; Chapter 8, p. 59

how are you? — assemble the formal question from cómo, estar, and usted *¿cómo está usted?*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 8, p. 59

how old are you? — literally, how many years do you have? *¿Cuántos años tienes?*

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 47, p. 187

however, nevertheless *sin embargo*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 270, p. 823

Hoy Como en Casa — The Pieces That Move

chapter topic; Chapter 265, p. 799

hoy como en casa — the pieces that move

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 265, p. 799

I**I am from... — use ser with de to state origin** *soy de...*

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 48, p. 195

I am going to... — the near future with ir, a, and a known infinitive *voy a + infinitive*

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 49, p. 203

I call (from llamar, to call) *llamo*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 4, p. 25

“I don’t understand” — the most useful sentence a beginner owns *no entiendo*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 15, p. 101

I hope to travel *espero viajar*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 269, p. 817

I’m sorry — literally “I feel it,” a naming of the feeling rather than a claim about yourself *lo siento*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 137, p. 453

I suppose that *supongo que*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 271, p. 829

I will speak *hablaré*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 49, p. 203

iba — ir returns to its inherited past

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 109, p. 379

identify with ser; describe a current state or location with estar *ser vs estar*

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 48, p. 195

in my opinion *en mi opinión*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 270, p. 823

in short — and the last thing this book asks of you *en resumen*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 277, p. 871

in the first place, firstly *en primer lugar*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 273, p. 841

indeed — from ex and facere, carried out; it confirms what

somebody has just said, and does not mean “in effect” *en efecto*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 298, p. 1039

Ir in the Plural — a Verb That Is Not Ir

chapter topic; Chapter 68, p. 263

is in or at... — locate someone with estar and the already-known

en *está en...*

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 48, p. 195

-ista

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 53, p. 221

-ista — Jobs You Can Already Read

chapter topic; Chapter 53, p. 221

“it” — a word you have been saying since your fourth chapter, in

a job you have not met yet *lo*

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 83, p. 309

it depends *depende*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 210, p. 687

“it” for something feminine — the one word in this pair that

never had to change *la*

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 84, p. 311

it's just that... *es que...*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 272, p. 833

J

Jugar — Playing Was Joking

chapter topic; Chapter 170, p. 589

K

kind — Latin amabilis, loveable: the person it is easy to be fond

of *amable*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 283, p. 919

L

La Bebo — The Pronoun Tells the Truth

chapter topic; Chapter 144, p. 487

la bebo — the pronoun tells the truth

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 144, p. 487

La Casa — Your First Everyday Noun

chapter topic; Chapter 56, p. 231

La Comida — A Noun You Can Build

chapter topic; Chapter 77, p. 297

La — The Pronoun Carries What Left

chapter topic; Chapter 84, p. 311

las casas — “the houses”

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 78, p. 299

Las — The Plural Article That Behaves

chapter topic; Chapter 78, p. 299

Le — To Him, To Her, To You

chapter topic; Chapter 93, p. 331

Leer — Reading Is Gathering

chapter topic; Chapter 155, p. 529

Les — And What the Second System Costs

chapter topic; Chapter 94, p. 333

les — “to them,” and what this system really costs

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 94, p. 333

Lo Que — What, Out of Two Old Words

chapter topic; Chapter 188, p. 643

lo que — “what,” out of two old words

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 188, p. 643

Lo — Saying It Without Naming It

chapter topic; Chapter 83, p. 309

Lo Siento

chapter topic; Chapter 137, p. 453

look — and the tone shifts *mira*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 272, p. 833

los and las — “them”

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 89, p. 323

Los and Las — Them, Derived

chapter topic; Chapter 89, p. 323

los libros — “the books”

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 79, p. 301

Los — The One That Does Not Add -s

chapter topic; Chapter 79, p. 301

M**Making a Case — Claim, Example, However, Although**

chapter topic; Chapter 270, p. 823

Mal — Bien Finally Gets Its Opposite

chapter topic; Chapter 228, p. 725

mañana, español — the ñ in the words you are about to need

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 11, p. 75

María · España · profesor — the nouns that need no article

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 260, p. 789

María, España — The Nouns That Need No Article

chapter topic; Chapter 260, p. 789

María, Ven — Naming Who You Are Talking To

chapter topic; Chapter 249, p. 767

María, ven — naming who you are talking to

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 249, p. 767

maybe — literally “such a turn”, from vicem, a turn or a change;**vice versa is the turn turned round *tal vez***

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 298, p. 1039

maybe, perhaps *quizás*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 271, p. 829

Me and Te — The Two People Talking

chapter topic; Chapter 85, p. 313

Me Lo — Both at Once

chapter topic; Chapter 98, p. 341

me lo — both at once

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 98, p. 341

me / myself *me*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 4, p. 25

me quieres — “you love me”

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 85, p. 313

Meeting Someone — Welcome, Greeting, Hug, Smile, Guest

chapter topic; Chapter 282, p. 911

-mente — With No Upper Limit

chapter topic; Chapter 25, p. 129

-mente — with no upper limit

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 25, p. 129

money — the name of a Roman coin, still doing service two**thousand years later *el dinero***

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 280, p. 895

More of the Kitchen — Pan, Oven, Fork, Garlic, Soup

chapter topic; Chapter 297, p. 1031

“more slowly” — the request that makes the last sentence**solvable *más despacio***

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 15, p. 101

more than *más que*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 269, p. 817

much / a lot *mucho*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 6, p. 39

mucha agua • pocos libros — when the quantity word agrees

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 259, p. 787

Mucha Agua — When the Quantity Word Agrees

chapter topic; Chapter 259, p. 787

must — the guess, not the obligation *deber de*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 275, p. 857

Muy — The Same Word, Bitten Short

chapter topic; Chapter 226, p. 721

my name is (literally “I call myself”) *me llamo*

explicit focus: grammar, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 4, p. 25

my, your informal, and your formal or his or her — before a

singular noun *mi, tu, su*

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 49, p. 203

N

ñ — the letter that remembers a doubled n

script and writing topic; explicit focus: pronunciation, script, usage and culture; Chapter 11, p. 75

Naming the Land — Village, Hill, Valley, Lake, Mountain

chapter topic; Chapter 292, p. 991

-ncia

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 62, p. 245

-ncia — Turning a Quality into a Thing

chapter topic; Chapter 62, p. 245

neither — the same *tan*, a different second half, and the word

that lets you agree with a no *tampoco*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 220, p. 709

new — Latin *novus*, and English *new*, which is the cousin rather

than the loan *nuevo*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 281, p. 903

Ni — Joining Two Absences

chapter topic; Chapter 234, p. 737

night / evening (la noche — feminine) *la noche*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 13

no doubt — *duda* is *dubitare*, and behind that *duo*, two: to

doubt is to be caught between a pair of answers *sin duda*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 298, p. 1039

No Hables — Telling Somebody Not To

chapter topic; Chapter 133, p. 445

no hables — telling somebody not to

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 133, p. 445

no / not *no*

explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 7, p. 51

Noon and Midnight

chapter topic; Chapter 146, p. 493

noon and midnight — both halves still fully alive as ordinary Spanish words, unlike French's worn-down *midi/minuit* *mediodía, medianoche*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 146, p. 493

nor, not even — the joining word for two things that are both absent, and the one place Spanish stacks negatives on purpose *ni*

explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 234, p. 737

Nos — Us, and the Word Inside -mos

chapter topic; Chapter 88, p. 321

not at all — the reply to thanks, assembled entirely from words you already have *no hay de qué*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 283, p. 919

now, today — the two time words *mañana* has been waiting for, and one of them is a Latin hour in disguise *ahora · hoy*

explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 252, p. 773

Numbers, and How Old You Are

chapter topic; Chapter 47, p. 187

Numbers Eleven to Twenty

chapter topic; Chapter 149, p. 505

O**O — One Letter, One Catch**

chapter topic; Chapter 233, p. 735

of course — *supponere*, to place under: it was already under the conversation *por supuesto*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 284, p. 927

of the, from the — the second and last of Spanish's forced contractions, which means once you have these two you have all of them *del*

explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 231, p. 731

Ojala — a Prayer That Outlived Its Religion

chapter topic; Chapter 129, p. 435

ojalá + subjunctive — a wish borrowed through Arabic

etymology topic; explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 129, p. 435

old — from *vetulus*, “little old one”, the affectionate form rather than the plain one *viejo*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 281, p. 903

on one hand... on the other — holding two sources at once *por un lado... por otro*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 277, p. 871

One Stem, Two Tenses

chapter topic; Chapter 124, p. 419

Opening, Closing, Sitting Down, Standing Up

chapter topic; Chapter 166, p. 567

or — one letter, and one rule about what happens when the next word starts with the same sound *o*

explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 233, p. 735

Os — You All, in Spain

chapter topic; Chapter 90, p. 325

-oso

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 61, p. 241

-oso — a Shelf of Words You Were Never Taught

chapter topic; Chapter 61, p. 241

our — matching a known masculine or feminine singular**noun** *nuestro, nuestra*

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 69, p. 267

Out and Away — Street, Corner, Footprint, Harbour, Lighthouse

chapter topic; Chapter 302, p. 1071

out of the question — “not even to speak of it”, two pieces you already own, and the flattest refusal on the dial *ni hablar*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 298, p. 1039

Overhead — Daybreak, Sky, Cloud, Star, Shade

chapter topic; Chapter 289, p. 967

P**Para — For, Pointing Forward**

chapter topic; Chapter 176, p. 617

Para Mí — The Pronouns That Stand on Their Own

chapter topic; Chapter 246, p. 761

para mí — the pronouns that stand on their own

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 246, p. 761

Parents and Siblings

chapter topic; Chapter 140, p. 469

Pensar — Thinking Is Weighing

chapter topic; Chapter 153, p. 521

Pero — Two True Things at Once

chapter topic; Chapter 218, p. 705

please (literally “for [a] favour”) *por favor*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 14, p. 97

pleased to meet you (literally “much pleasure”) *mucho gusto*

explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 6, p. 39

Poner — Putting, and the Root Under Position

chapter topic; Chapter 71, p. 281

Por — And Three Phrases You Already Owned

chapter topic; Chapter 177, p. 619

Preguntar — Asking, and Sounding a Depth

chapter topic; Chapter 160, p. 543

preguntó dónde

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 215, p. 699

Preguntó Dónde — What the Accent Was Always For

chapter topic; Chapter 215, p. 699

preguntó si

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 214, p. 697

Preguntó Si — A Question That Stops Being One

chapter topic; Chapter 214, p. 697

Primero, Segundo, Tercero — Counting in Order

chapter topic; Chapter 262, p. 793

problem *problema*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 268, p. 809

Profesor — and the Article Spanish Leaves Out

chapter topic; Chapter 51, p. 217

pueda · puedas · pueda — one more known stem change

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 128, p. 431

putting *no* in front of the verb — the whole of Spanish**negation *no + verb***

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 267, p. 803

Putting the -ar Verbs to Work

chapter topic; Chapter 33, p. 149

Q**¡Qué Grande! — The Same Word, Exclaiming**

chapter topic; Chapter 248, p. 765

¡Qué grande! — the same word, exclaiming

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 248, p. 765

queremos, quieren — work them out first

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 76, p. 293

Quién — The Asking Word for People

chapter topic; Chapter 232, p. 733

quiera · quieras · quiera — keep the change you know

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 128, p. 431

R**rain refuses the *hacer* pattern and brings its own verb — and its****ll- is the sound change you already met in *llamar* *llueve***

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 148, p. 501

Reading Between the Lines — Imply, Invert, Look It Up, Re-tune

chapter topic; Chapter 272, p. 833

Reading Older Spanish — Register, Date, and Form

chapter topic; Chapter 276, p. 865

red — a cousin of French rouge and English red, but by a different branch of the same very old family *rojo*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 139, p. 463

Review — A Tense You Build

chapter topic; Chapter 120, p. 407

Review — All Eight

chapter topic; Chapter 91, p. 327

Review — All Four Stem Changes

chapter topic; Chapter 172, p. 597

Review — All Four Words for The

chapter topic; Chapter 81, p. 305

Review — Five Sets, Finished

chapter topic; Chapter 256, p. 781

Review — Four Boxes

chapter topic; Chapter 135, p. 449

Review — Four Last Pieces, and the Thread

chapter topic; Chapter 266, p. 801

Review — Four Pronouns, One Slot

chapter topic; Chapter 86, p. 317

Review — Four Rules You Already Obeyed

chapter topic; Chapter 261, p. 791

Review — Four Small Things

chapter topic; Chapter 250, p. 769

Review — Four Small Words, One Instinct

chapter topic; Chapter 235, p. 739

Review — Four Verbs of the Mind

chapter topic; Chapter 157, p. 537

Review — One Arrow

chapter topic; Chapter 179, p. 623

Review — One Question, Three Answers

chapter topic; Chapter 114, p. 395

Review — One Scale, One Habit

chapter topic; Chapter 229, p. 727

Review — Six Verbs, One Ending

chapter topic; Chapter 74, p. 287

Review — the Eight Endings

chapter topic; Chapter 64, p. 251

Review — The Pairs

chapter topic; Chapter 101, p. 347

Review — the Present Tense, Whole

chapter topic; Chapter 46, p. 185

Review — The Three Forms Side by Side

chapter topic; Chapter 19, p. 113

Review — The Three Se's

chapter topic; Chapter 184, p. 635

Review — the Two Conditions

chapter topic; Chapter 209, p. 685

Review — the Whole Present Tense

chapter topic; Chapter 41, p. 173

Review — the Whole Preterite

chapter topic; Chapter 204, p. 675

Review — Three Endings

chapter topic; Chapter 26, p. 131

Review — Three Jobs, No New Words

chapter topic; Chapter 189, p. 645

Review — Three Joints, Two Constants

chapter topic; Chapter 216, p. 701

Review — Three Letters

chapter topic; Chapter 194, p. 655

Review — Three Places, One Question

chapter topic; Chapter 225, p. 719

Review — Three Verbs That Behave

chapter topic; Chapter 162, p. 551

Review — Two Endings and One Little A

chapter topic; Chapter 240, p. 749

Review — Two Systems, Two New Words

chapter topic; Chapter 96, p. 337

Review — Two Tenses Finished

chapter topic; Chapter 245, p. 759

room *habitación*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 268, p. 809

S**Salir — Leaving**

chapter topic; Chapter 72, p. 283

Saying No, and Asking

chapter topic; Chapter 267, p. 803

Saying Why

chapter topic; Chapter 175, p. 609

Saying Your Name

chapter topic; Chapter 4, p. 25

Se Compran Libros — The Verb Tells On Itself

chapter topic; Chapter 182, p. 631

se compran libros — the verb tells on itself

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 182, p. 631

Se Habla Español — Nobody in Particular

chapter topic; Chapter 181, p. 629

se habla español — nobody in particular

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 181, p. 629

Se Lo — The Pair That Does Not Exist

chapter topic; Chapter 99, p. 343

se lo — the pair that does not exist

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 99, p. 343

see you later (literally “until later”) *hasta luego*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 13, p. 89

see you soon (literally “until soon”) *hasta pronto*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 13, p. 89

see you tomorrow (literally “until tomorrow”) *hasta mañana*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 13, p. 89

Ser and Estar — Two Ways to Be

chapter topic; Chapter 48, p. 195

Ser in the Plural

chapter topic; Chapter 50, p. 211

Setting Off — The Way Out, the Journey, the Return, the Arrival, the Farewell

chapter topic; Chapter 288, p. 959

should, ought to — and to owe, because the word is literally “to have something from someone” *deber*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 175, p. 609

si

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 196, p. 659

si + futuro

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 197, p. 661

Si + Futuro — What Will Happen If

chapter topic; Chapter 197, p. 661

Si — If, and the Word Yes Is Made Of

chapter topic; Chapter 196, p. 659

si tuviera

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 208, p. 683

Si Tuviera — Supposing What Is Not So

chapter topic; Chapter 208, p. 683

snow — Latin nivem, and the s- that Latin dropped and English**kept *la nieve***

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 278, p. 879

so-so / not great (also “más o menos”) *regular*

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 9, p. 65

- soap** — Latin *sapo*, which Latin had itself borrowed from its northern neighbours *el jabón*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 287, p. 951
- sois** — **the last of the six**
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 50, p. 211
- somos** — **“we are”**
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 50, p. 211
- son** — **“they are”**
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 50, p. 211
- “Spanish”** — **the language, the people, and the Roman name for the peninsula underneath it** *español*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 22, p. 121
- student** — **a word you can build yourself, out of a verb you already have** *estudiante*
explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 52, p. 219
- sure** — **se- without plus cura, care: free from care, and so reliable** *seguro*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 284, p. 927
- Synthesis** — **A Small Story**
chapter topic; Chapter 115, p. 397
- Synthesis** — **Asking, and Answering**
chapter topic; Chapter 37, p. 165
- Synthesis** — **Asking Without Sounding Rude**
chapter topic; Chapter 136, p. 451
- Synthesis** — **Carrying a Conversation**
chapter topic; Chapter 217, p. 703
- Synthesis** — **Claiming, and Not Claiming**
chapter topic; Chapter 130, p. 439
- Synthesis** — **Describing Things**
chapter topic; Chapter 60, p. 239
- Synthesis** — **Describing Where You Are**
chapter topic; Chapter 195, p. 657
- Synthesis** — **More Than One**
chapter topic; Chapter 82, p. 307
- Synthesis** — **Promising, and Supposing**
chapter topic; Chapter 125, p. 423
- Synthesis** — **Reading a Paragraph**
chapter topic; Chapter 65, p. 253
- Synthesis** — **Reading the Window**
chapter topic; Chapter 185, p. 637
- Synthesis** — **Reading What You Were Never Taught**
chapter topic; Chapter 27, p. 133
- Synthesis** — **Real Conditions**
chapter topic; Chapter 198, p. 663

Synthesis — Saying It Once

chapter topic; Chapter 87, p. 319

Synthesis — Saying Something About Your Own Life

chapter topic; Chapter 152, p. 519

Synthesis — Saying What People Do

chapter topic; Chapter 54, p. 223

Synthesis — Sentences Worth Saying

chapter topic; Chapter 190, p. 647

Synthesis — Supposing Out Loud

chapter topic; Chapter 210, p. 687

Synthesis — Telling What Happened

chapter topic; Chapter 205, p. 677

Synthesis — The Choices English Never Makes You Make

chapter topic; Chapter 173, p. 599

Synthesis — The Conversation Without Them

chapter topic; Chapter 92, p. 329

Synthesis — The Decoder

chapter topic; Chapter 31, p. 145

Synthesis — The Gift and the Motive

chapter topic; Chapter 180, p. 627

Synthesis — The Same Conversation, Twice

chapter topic; Chapter 32, p. 147

Synthesis — the Same Sentence, Two Continents

chapter topic; Chapter 42, p. 175

Synthesis — The Thing and the Person

chapter topic; Chapter 97, p. 339

Synthesis — Three Exceptions, and No Others

chapter topic; Chapter 110, p. 383

Synthesis — Two at a Time

chapter topic; Chapter 102, p. 349

Synthesis — Two Shores, Two Answers

chapter topic; Chapter 121, p. 409

Synthesis — What You Like, and Who Does the Liking

chapter topic; Chapter 164, p. 557

Synthesis — What You Understand, and What You Don't

chapter topic; Chapter 158, p. 539

Synthesis — You, and Somebody Else

chapter topic; Chapter 75, p. 291

Synthesis — You Can Hear Which Past It Is

chapter topic; Chapter 106, p. 369

T

Talking About Ideas — Hedging From Doubt, and From Inference

chapter topic; Chapter 271, p. 829

Talking to a Friend

chapter topic; Chapter 17, p. 109

También — Your First Word, Hidden Inside

chapter topic; Chapter 219, p. 707

Tampoco — The Same Frame, the Other Half

chapter topic; Chapter 220, p. 709

teacher — and the one place Spanish drops the “a” that English insists on *profesor*

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 51, p. 217

Telling Time

chapter topic; Chapter 147, p. 497

Telling What Happened

chapter topic; Chapter 167, p. 575

tenemos — and the stem change disappears

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 67, p. 259

Tener in the Plural, and the Stem-Change Rule

chapter topic; Chapter 67, p. 259

Tenia and Tuve — When the Tense Changes the Meaning

chapter topic; Chapter 113, p. 393

tenía and tuve — when the tense changes the meaning

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 113, p. 393

thank you *gracias*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 7, p. 51

Thank You, Yes, and No

chapter topic; Chapter 7, p. 51

that is to say — the same idea in your own words *es decir*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 277, p. 871

that one, by you — the slot Latin’s iste left empty when Spanish moved it, filled by a word that used to mean self *ese*

explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 222, p. 713

that one over there, away from us both — and the second life of the word that became el in your very first chapter *aquel*

explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 223, p. 715

the ankle — from Latin tuber, a swelling; a tuber in the ground and a protuberance are the same lump *el tobillo*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 293, p. 999

the arrival — from llegar, Latin plicare, to fold: a ship folded its sails and had arrived *la llegada*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 288, p. 959

the back — Latin *spatula*, a broad blade; the same blade is a *spatula*, a spade and an epaulette *la espalda*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 293, p. 999

the basket — Latin *cista* from Greek *kiste*, a box; English *chest* and *cistern* are the same container by two different doors *la cesta*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 301, p. 1063

the blanket — Latin *mantum*, a cloak; the mantle, the mantelpiece and the manta ray are all cloaks *la manta*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 294, p. 1007

the blood — Latin *sanguinem*; sanguine once meant ruddy and cheerful because of it, and consanguinity is shared blood *la sangre*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 300, p. 1055

the branch — Latin *ramus*; when an argument ramifies, it is growing these *la rama*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 291, p. 983

the bridge — Latin *pontem*; a pontoon floats one and a pontiff is, underneath, a bridge-builder *el puente*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 295, p. 1015

the broom — Latin *scopa*, a bundle of twigs, wearing the Spanish e- step for the third time *la escoba*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 294, p. 1007

the choice English lost — and the surprise that usted takes he/she verb forms *tú o usted*

explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 5, p. 31

the cloud — Latin *nubes*, and the ancestor of nuance, which began as a shade of cloud *la nube*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 289, p. 967

The Conditional — Saying What Would Happen

chapter topic; Chapter 123, p. 415

the cook — *coquere*, to cook; the kitchen, the biscuit and a precocious child are all in it *el cocinero*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 285, p. 935

the corner — from a Germanic word for a shinbone; English *shin* is the same bone, and a corner is an edge as sharp as one *la*

esquina

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 302, p. 1071

the cow — Latin *vacca*, unchanged in six letters; vaccine is named after her, because the first one came from a cow *la vaca*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 296, p. 1023

the cup — Arabic *tassa*, from Persian; French *tasse* and the English *demitasse* are the same vessel *la taza*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 294, p. 1007

the daybreak — Latin *mane*, in the morning, the same piece that sits inside *mañana* *el amanecer*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 289, p. 967

the donkey — Latin *burricus*, a little reddish horse, from *burrus*, red; English borrowed the whole word back, and the burrito with it *el burro*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 296, p. 1023

the double negative — where Spanish stacks what English forbids *no ... nada*

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 267, p. 803

the emphatic yes — contradicting something unsaid *sí que*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 275, p. 857

the eye — Latin *oculus*; English eye is its distant cousin, not a translation of it *el ojo*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 286, p. 943

the farewell — from *despedir*, Latin *expetere*, to ask out: a leave-taking was a request *la despedida*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 288, p. 959

the farm — from *granum*, the grain: a farm is named after the one thing it was built to store *la granja*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 299, p. 1047

the fever — Latin *febris*, which English borrowed early as fever and late as *febrile* *la fiebre*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 286, p. 943

The Field and the Farm — Field, Farm, Livestock, Harvest, Shepherd

chapter topic; Chapter 299, p. 1047

the field, the countryside — Latin *campus*, flat open ground; camp, campus, campaign and champion are all fought or pitched on it *el campo*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 299, p. 1047

the footprint — from *hollar*, to tread, and behind that *fullare*, to trample cloth; a fuller was the man who did it with his feet *la huella*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 302, p. 1071

the fork — built on *tener*, to hold: it is “the holder”, the same shape as any Spanish word ending in *-dor* *el tenedor*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 297, p. 1031

the four seasons — three straightforward, and one whose MEANING quietly shifted from “spring” to “summer” *la*

primavera, el verano, el otoño, el invierno

explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 142, p. 479

the frying pan — Latin sartago; its written accent is a receipt for where the stress went, and the plural hands it back *la sartén*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 297, p. 1031

The Future — Saying What Will Happen

chapter topic; Chapter 122, p. 411

the garlic — Latin allium, which English kept as the botanical name; aioli is this word and oil, run together *el ajo*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 297, p. 1031

the *h* in hermano — a letter that was never spoken

etymology topic; explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 140, p. 469

the hand — feminine despite ending in -o, Spanish's most famous gender exception *la mano*

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 141, p. 475

the harbour — Latin portus, the twin of the porta you already have; import, export and opportunity are all ships coming in *el puerto*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 302, p. 1071

the harvest — from collecta, the gathered-up, which is the colligere you already took apart once *la cosecha*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 299, p. 1047

the head — Spanish KEPT Latin's real word, unlike French, which replaced it with slang for "pot" *la cabeza*

explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 141, p. 475

the hen — Latin gallina, the female of gallus; and in both languages the bird is also what you call a coward *la gallina*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 296, p. 1023

the hill — Latin collis, from a root meaning to rise; excel and culminate rise from the same place *la colina*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 292, p. 991

the honey — Latin mel, which sweetens mellifluous, molasses and marmalade *la miel*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 290, p. 975

the horse — Latin caballus, the working nag, which beat the noble equus and left cavalry and chivalry behind it *el caballo*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 296, p. 1023

The Imperfect — What Used to Happen

chapter topic; Chapter 107, p. 373

the island — Latin insula; insular, isolate, peninsula and insulin all come off the same rock *la isla*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 295, p. 1015

the journey — Latin viaticum, the provisions you packed for the road *el viaje*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 288, p. 959

the knee — Latin *rotella*, a little wheel, from *rota*; rotate, rotary and roulette are the same wheel *la rodilla*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 293, p. 999

the knife — Latin *cultellus*, a little culter; cutlery, cutlass and the plough's coulter are the same blade *el cuchillo*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 294, p. 1007

the lake — Latin *lacus*; lake, lagoon and lacuna are all the same standing water *el lago*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 292, p. 991

the lighthouse — named after Pharos, the island at Alexandria that held the first one; a place name that became the word for the thing *el faro*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 302, p. 1071

the livestock — from *ganar*, to gain: cattle are simply “what has been gained”, the way English cattle and chattel are what you own *el ganado*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 299, p. 1047

¿ ; — the marks that open a question

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, usage and culture; Chapter 11, p. 75

the (masculine / feminine) *el / la*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 1, p. 1

the mist — Latin *nebula*, the word set aside earlier as the near-cousin of *nubes*; nebulous is the same mist *la niebla*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 295, p. 1015

The Months

chapter topic; Chapter 145, p. 489

the months — Roman gods and emperors, marching almost unchanged from Latin *los meses*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 145, p. 489

the mountain — Latin *mons*; paramount is above the hill and an amount is what it comes to *la montaña*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 292, p. 991

the mouth — Latin *bucca* was the cheek, and the cheek pushed the mouth out of the job *la boca*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 286, p. 943

the neck — Latin *collum*, which is also the collar round it and the accolade thrown round it *el cuello*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 293, p. 999

the needle — a little *acus*, a sharp; the same sharp that names the acute accent, and the one in acupuncture *la aguja*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 301, p. 1063

the neighbour — from *vicus*, a village street: the person off your own block *el vecino*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 285, p. 935

the numbers 1–5 *uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 47, p. 187

the numbers 6–10 and the old counting hidden in month

names *seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 47, p. 187

the nurse — from infirmus, not firm: named after the patient,

not the work *la enfermera*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 285, p. 935

the one noun that covers both “time” and “weather” — because

Latin tempus already did *el tiempo*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 148, p. 501

the onion — Latin caepulla, a little caepa; the chive in English is

the same root, undiminished *la cebolla*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 290, p. 975

The Only Three Irregulars

chapter topic; Chapter 109, p. 379

the other sorry — “give completely” — for fault and for getting

past people, where lo siento is for regret *perdón*

explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 137, p. 453

the oven — Latin furnus, wearing the silent h that marks where

an f used to stand; furnace is the same fire *el horno*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 297, p. 1031

the pain — Latin dolor; condolence hurts with you, and indolent

once felt no pain at all *el dolor*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 286, p. 943

the paper — from papyrus, the reed the Egyptians wrote on; it

also means the part an actor plays, because the part was written

on one *el papel*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 301, p. 1063

the path — Latin semita, a by-way, with semi- meaning half: a

path is a half-road *el sendero*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 295, p. 1015

the pot — Latin olla, unchanged in two thousand years;

potpourri is a French translation of olla podrida *la olla*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 294, p. 1007

The Preterite — Your First Past Tense

chapter topic; Chapter 103, p. 351

The *qu-* question family — one ancient pattern, many clues

etymology topic; explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 6, p. 39

The Regular Preterite

chapter topic; Chapter 104, p. 359

the regular singular -er preterite — comí, comiste, comió *comí*

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 104, p. 359

the regular singular -ir preterite — viví, viviste, vivió *viví*

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 104, p. 359

the remedy — re- and mederi, to heal again; medicine, medical and a medic are all the same healing *el remedio*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 300, p. 1055

The Rest of the Greetings

chapter topic; Chapter 2, p. 13

the return — from volver, Latin volvere, to roll: a return is a turning back *la vuelta*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 288, p. 959

the rice — Arabic ar-ruzz, carrying its own article; rice is the same grain by a different road *el arroz*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 290, p. 975

the root — Latin radix, which is also the radish, the radical and the thing you eradicate *la raíz*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 291, p. 983

the rope — Greek khorde by way of Latin chorda, a gut string; cord, chord and cordon are the same string, and the o breaks to ue again *la cuerda*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 301, p. 1063

the same rain in two tenses — how a story uses the imperfect for the scene and the preterite for the events *llovía / llovió*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 167, p. 575

The Seasons

chapter topic; Chapter 142, p. 479

the seed — Latin seminalia, the things for sowing; a seminar is a seed-bed and disseminate is scattering *la semilla*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 291, p. 983

the shade — Latin sub umbra, under the shadow; an umbrella is a little one of these *la sombra*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 289, p. 967

the shared singular preterite of ser and ir — fui, fuiste, fue *fui*

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 103, p. 351

the sheep — Latin ovicula, a little ovis; Spanish kept the small one and dropped the full-sized word entirely *la oveja*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 296, p. 1023

the shepherd — from pascere, to graze; the pasture, the pastor of a church and a repast are all feeding *el pastor*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 299, p. 1047

the shore — Latin ora, an edge or border, with the small ending: the little edge of anything *la orilla*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 295, p. 1015

the shoulder — Latin *umerus*, which doctors still call the *humerus*; the *h* is silent and came late *el hombro*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 293, p. 999

the single most useful sentence a learner owns — and it is this chapter's grammar, doing exactly what the chapter said *¿cómo se dice?*

Chapter 183, p. 633

the skin — Latin *pellis*, a hide, with the *e* broken to *ie*; a pelt is the same hide, and a surplice is a shirt worn over one *la piel*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 300, p. 1055

the sky — Latin *caelum*, which is also the ceiling over a room and the cerulean of a paint box *el cielo*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 289, p. 967

the sleep, and the dream — Latin *somnus* with the *o* broken to *ue*; insomnia and somnolent keep the *o* intact *el sueño*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 300, p. 1055

the soup — Germanic *suppa*, a piece of bread soaked in broth;

the bread came first and soup, sop and supper are all it *la sopa*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 297, p. 1031

the star — Latin *stella*, wearing the *e-* that Spanish puts in front of an *s* and a consonant *la estrella*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 289, p. 967

the street — Latin *callis*, the narrow track worn through rough ground by driven animals; the town's word began in the hills *la calle*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 302, p. 1071

The Strong Preterites

chapter topic; Chapter 105, p. 363

The Subjunctive Built From the Yo Form

chapter topic; Chapter 128, p. 431

The Subjunctive, Regular

chapter topic; Chapter 127, p. 427

the tag question — asking someone to agree *¿verdad?*

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 267, p. 803

the teacher — *magister*, from *magis*, more; and *minister*, from *minus*, less *el maestro*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 285, p. 935

the thirst — Latin *sitis*; Spanish does not say you are thirsty, it says you have thirst, and the difference is the point *la sed*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 300, p. 1055

the thread — Latin *filum* with its *f* worn down to a silent *h*;

filament, filigree and a file of soldiers are all threads *el hilo*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 301, p. 1063

the three weather words Spanish reports with hacer — “it makes heat,” “it makes cold,” “it makes sun” *hace calor, hace frío, hace sol*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 148, p. 501

The Three Words for You

chapter topic; Chapter 5, p. 31

the throat — a word made out of the noise itself, as gargle and gurgle are *la garganta*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 286, p. 943

the tomato — Nahuatl *tomatl*, one of the words Spanish carried back across the Atlantic *el tomate*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 290, p. 975

the trunk — Latin *truncus*, meaning lopped or maimed; to truncate is to do it on purpose *el tronco*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 291, p. 983

the valley — Latin *vallis*; valley, vale and avalanche all come down the same slope *el valle*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 292, p. 991

the village, and also the people — Latin *populus*, which gave popular, population and public *el pueblo*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 292, p. 991

the way out — from *salir*, and Latin *salire*, to jump: a Roman jumped out of a room *la salida*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 288, p. 959

The Way Out — Path, Bridge, Shore, Island, Mist

chapter topic; Chapter 295, p. 1015

The Weather

chapter topic; Chapter 148, p. 501

the weekdays (Monday–Friday) — worn-down planet-god names *lunes, martes, miércoles, jueves, viernes*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 138, p. 457

the weekend (Saturday, Sunday) — where religion overwrote astronomy *sábado, domingo*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 138, p. 457

the wheat — Latin *triticum*, the rubbed grain, from *terere*, to rub; trite is worn down the same way *el trigo*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 290, p. 975

the wood — a Germanic word, not a Latin one; bush, bosky and ambush are its English cousins *el bosque*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 291, p. 983

The Written Accent

chapter topic; Chapter 10, p. 71

the yes-or-no question — and why Spanish barely has to do anything *¿Hablas español?*

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 267, p. 803

then, next — a word you already own from *hasta luego*, now

doing a second job: joining two events in order *luego*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 167, p. 575

“there is” and “there are” — one word for both, which no other

Spanish verb form manages *hay*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar; Chapter 191, p. 649

there, over there — the two places *aquí* has been missing, and

they line up exactly with the three pointing words *ahí · allí*

explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 251, p. 771

therefore *por lo tanto*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 273, p. 841

thin — the kind word and the blunt one *delgado / flaco*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 275, p. 857

this one, here, next to me — the first of three words for pointing,

and the reason Spanish never needs to say “the this book” *este*

explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 221, p. 711

thus, in that way — and with *que* after it, “so”; built on the

same *sic* that gave you *sí* *así que*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 175, p. 609

ticket *billete*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 268, p. 809

tienen — the break comes back

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 67, p. 259

tired — a state, not a quality, which is why it takes *estar* and

never *ser* *cansado*

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 59, p. 237

to answer — a Roman courtroom word that English turned into

a fight and Spanish turned into a reply *contestar*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 174, p. 603

to ask (a question) — and the reason English’s one “ask”

becomes two Spanish verbs *preguntar*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 160, p. 543

to be a Quixote — an allusion working as a word *ser un quijote*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 274, p. 849

to be able or can — with the singular present forms *puedo*,

puedes, and *puede* *poder*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 69, p. 267

to be — but the *standing* kind, straight from Latin *stāre* *estar*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 8, p. 59

to be funny — and a word that does not translate *tener gracia*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 274, p. 849

to be — the verb used here to identify someone or say what

someone is *ser*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 48, p. 195

**to believe, to think — putting your heart somewhere, where
pensar weighs it up** *creer*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 175, p. 609

**to bring — Latin’s word for dragging, and a verb with a
direction built into it** *traer*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 168, p. 583

**to buy — from Latin’s “get ready, procure”, and not from the
verb behind English compare** *comprar*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 174, p. 603

**to close — from the bar dropped across a door, not from the
Latin verb English inherited** *cerrar*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 166, p. 567

**to come — with the singular present forms vengo, vienes, and
viene** *venir*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 73, p. 285

**to do or make — with the singular present forms hago, haces,
and hace** *hacer*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 70, p. 275

to drink (another -er verb — cementing the pattern) *beber*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 36, p. 159

**to eat — your first -er verb, and the family whose yo-form you
already own** *comer*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 34, p. 151

**to explain — literally to unfold, and the verb that names what
this whole chapter has been building** *explicar*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 175, p. 609

**to get, to obtain — getting as following a thing until you have
it** *conseguir*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 169, p. 587

**to get up, to stand up — “to raise oneself”, built from a
participle exactly as sentarse was** *levantarse*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 166, p. 567

to go — with the three singular present forms voy, vas, and va *ir*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 49, p. 203

to have — a common verb with two visible changes *tener*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 47, p. 187

**to hear — the half of listening you do not choose, and a verb
that sprouts a y** *oír*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 165, p. 559

to help — literally the same word as English “aid”, arriving by a different road *ayudar*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 161, p. 547

“to him, to her, to you” — a Latin case Spanish kept and English threw away *le*

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 93, p. 331

to leave or go out — with the singular present forms *salgo*, *sales*, and *sale* *salir*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 72, p. 283

to live — your first -ir verb, and a family that asks you to learn nothing new *vivir*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 35, p. 157

to make a mistake — with the verb Spanish insists on *cometer un error*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 275, p. 857

to meet, to be acquainted with — a verb built out of the moment knowing begins *conocer*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 171, p. 593

to open — a regular -ir verb with one irregular part, the participle *abierto* *abrir*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 166, p. 567

to pass on — and why the language turns away *pasar a mejor vida*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 274, p. 849

to play — from Latin’s word for joking, and the only verb in the language that breaks u to ue *jugar*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 170, p. 589

to please — the verb English calls “to like”, built the other way round *gustar*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 163, p. 553

to pull someone’s leg (lit. to take the hair) *tomar el pelo*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 272, p. 833

to put or place — with the singular present forms *pongo*, *pones*, and *pone* *poner*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 71, p. 281

to read — from a Latin verb meaning “to gather, to pick out” *leer*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 155, p. 529

to run — a plain -er verb sitting on one of the largest roots English ever borrowed *correr*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 165, p. 559

to say or tell — with the singular present forms *digo*, *dices*, and *dice* *decir*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 70, p. 275

to see — veo, ves, ve *ver*

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 108, p. 377

to sit down — literally “to seat oneself”, the reflexive that lands the action back on you *sentarse*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 166, p. 567

to sleep — and the other half of the boot, where a stressed o breaks to ue *dormir*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 165, p. 559

to speak / to talk — at root, “to tell stories” *hablar*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 16, p. 105

to study (a third -ar verb — the pattern is automatic now) *estudiar*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 21, p. 119

to take (and, across Latin America, to drink) — an everyday word with no settled origin *tomar*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 159, p. 541

to tell a story — and also to count, because in Spanish, as once in English, a story is something you reckon up *contar*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 167, p. 575

to the — one of only two places where Spanish forces two words into one, and it does it because the two vowels refuse to sit next to each other *al*

explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 230, p. 729

to think — at root “to weigh”, and a stem-changer that breaks e→ie *pensar*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 153, p. 521

to understand — literally “to stretch toward”; the second e→ie stem-changer *entender*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 154, p. 525

to wait — and to hope, and to expect, all in one verb *esperar*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 174, p. 603

to walk — built on a Celtic word for a path, beside andar, whose own past is unsettled *caminar*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 165, p. 559

to want — with the singular present forms quiero, quieres, and quiere *querer*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 69, p. 267

to work (a second -ar verb — same pattern) *trabajar*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 20, p. 115

to write — from a Latin verb meaning “to scratch”, and the reason Spanish puts an e- in front *escribir*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 156, p. 533

Tomar — Taking, and a Word With No Past

chapter topic; Chapter 159, p. 541

Trabajar — Work, and the Torture Device Behind It

chapter topic; Chapter 20, p. 115

Traer — Bringing, and Latin for Dragging

chapter topic; Chapter 168, p. 583

Travelling — Asking, Boarding, Staying, and When It Goes Wrong

chapter topic; Chapter 268, p. 809

tree — Latin arbor, with one of its two r sounds slid away to l *el árbol*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 278, p. 879

true — Latin certus, sifted: what is left after you separate it out *cierto*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 284, p. 927

tuve — let the strong stem carry the stress

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 105, p. 363

tuviera

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 207, p. 681

Tuviera — the Hard Stems, Collected Free

chapter topic; Chapter 207, p. 681

tuvieron

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 202, p. 671

Tuvieron — the Strong Stems, Made Plural

chapter topic; Chapter 202, p. 671

twenty — the ceiling of the teens, and a word that was worn but never fused *veinte*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 149, p. 505

two of the three words Spanish uses to one person — and the one English quietly retired *tú / usted*

Chapter 5, p. 31

U**un — “a,” and the number hiding in it**

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 21

Un and Una — the Other Article

chapter topic; Chapter 3, p. 21

una — the feminine one

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 21

Uno... Otro — Splitting a Pair

chapter topic; Chapter 263, p. 795

uno... otro — splitting a pair

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 263, p. 795

Unos, Unas — The Plural of One

chapter topic; Chapter 253, p. 775

unos · unas — the plural of “one”

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 253, p. 775

until / up to *hasta*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 12, p. 83

Until When

chapter topic; Chapter 13, p. 89

“us” — and the word hiding inside the verb ending you have**used since *hablamos nos***

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 88, p. 321

V**vamos — from a verb that is not *ír***

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 68, p. 263

van — and the four are done

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 68, p. 263

veía — keep the extra e you already met

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 109, p. 379

Venir — Coming

chapter topic; Chapter 73, p. 285

Veo a María — The Little A That Guards People

chapter topic; Chapter 239, p. 747

veo a María — the little a that guards people

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 239, p. 747

Ver — Seeing

chapter topic; Chapter 108, p. 377

Verbs That Break in the Middle — the Stem Changers

chapter topic; Chapter 69, p. 267

very — not a new word at all, but mucho with its ending bitten**off, and the shape tells you what is coming next *muy***

explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 226, p. 721

Vi, Di — The Shortest Pasts

chapter topic; Chapter 255, p. 779

vi · di — the shortest pasts in the language

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 255, p. 779

viva · vivas · viva — -ir joins -er

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 127, p. 427

vivía — reuse the complete -er row

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 107, p. 373

vivimos — where the two families part

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 43, p. 177

Vivir — the Family That Costs Nothing

chapter topic; Chapter 35, p. 157

viviré — one future row for three verb families

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 122, p. 411

viviría — the regular conditional closes its small frame

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 123, p. 415

vuestra merced → usted — respect compressed into one word

etymology topic; explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 5, p. 31

Vuestro — The Last Possessive

chapter topic; Chapter 254, p. 777

vuestro — the last possessive

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 254, p. 777

W**Waiting, Answering, Buying**

chapter topic; Chapter 174, p. 603

Wanting, Not Asserting

chapter topic; Chapter 126, p. 425

water — a word that barely changed from Latin, and takes el**without ever stopping being feminine** *el agua*

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 143, p. 481

Water, Wine, and Bread

chapter topic; Chapter 143, p. 481

welcome — bien plus venido, well come, two pieces you already own *bienvenido*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 282, p. 911

well / good / fine *bien*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 1, p. 1

what? (a new question word for verbs you already know) *qué*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 36, p. 159

What a Phrase Carries — Authority, a Story, a Silence, a Sense of Charm

chapter topic; Chapter 274, p. 849

what estar is for — a current state or location — and the only two forms you need this chapter *estás / está*

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 8, p. 59

What Is Eaten — Wheat, Rice, Onion, Tomato, Honey

chapter topic; Chapter 290, p. 975

what's your name? (formal) *¿cómo se llama usted?*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 6, p. 39

What the Body Says — Thirst, Sleep, Skin, Blood, Remedy

chapter topic; Chapter 300, p. 1055

- “when” — the word that puts a scene and an event in one sentence, so the two pasts can be seen doing different jobs** *cuando*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 112, p. 389
- When You Don’t Understand**
chapter topic; Chapter 15, p. 101
- where?** *dónde*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 36, p. 159
- Where does ¿ begin? — bracket the spoken span**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 11, p. 75
- Where -er and -ir Part Company**
chapter topic; Chapter 43, p. 177
- where is it?** *¿dónde está?*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 268, p. 809
- Where It Hurts — Eye, Mouth, Throat, Pain, Fever**
chapter topic; Chapter 286, p. 943
- Which One Is the Verb Asking For?**
chapter topic; Chapter 95, p. 335
- Which one is the verb asking for?**
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 95, p. 335
- which — pointing back at a whole clause** *lo cual*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 273, p. 841
- Which Way Is the Arrow Pointing?**
chapter topic; Chapter 178, p. 621
- Which way is the arrow pointing?**
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 178, p. 621
- Who Someone Is — Neighbour, Friend, Teacher, Nurse, Cook**
chapter topic; Chapter 285, p. 935
- who — the asking word Spanish keeps for people, and the reason**
qué has never had to do that job *quién*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 232, p. 733
- Why se? — and why it is not the se you know**
etymology topic; explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 100, p. 345
- Why Se? — Gelo, and a Collision**
chapter topic; Chapter 100, p. 345
- wind — Latin ventus, and the English word that is its cousin**
rather than its borrowing *el viento*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 278, p. 879
- window — a wind-hole, built on the same Latin ventus as**
viento *la ventana*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 279, p. 887
- wine — one Latin root that reached English by three separate**
roads, plus one English built at home *el vino*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 143, p. 481

with me, with you — two words carrying the same preposition twice, because the first one stopped being audible *conmigo* ·

contigo

explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 247, p. 763

Working From Sources — Credit It, Restate It, Hold Both, Compress

chapter topic; Chapter 277, p. 871

Y

yeah, right *sí, claro*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 272, p. 833

yellow — from “a little bitter,” not from any Latin word for

yellow at all *amarillo*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 151, p. 515

yes *sí*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 7, p. 51

yesterday *ayer*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 103, p. 351

“you” across a large part of the Spanish-speaking world — to recognise, not to say *vos*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 5, p. 31

“you all” as the object — the shortest word in the set, and the one that stops at a border *os*

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 90, p. 325

“you” as the object — and the sentence it makes, which is the one people actually need *te quiero*

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 85, p. 313

you’re welcome (literally “of nothing”) *de nada*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 7, p. 51

your first sentence built from parts — and the rule that languages take no article *Hablo español*

explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 22, p. 121

Your First Verb, and the Form That Means I

chapter topic; Chapter 16, p. 105